i didnt know i was broken until i wanted a change

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/19331872.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Original Characters, Magicat Queen (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Magicats, Beast Island, catra get sent to beast island and discovers magicast n shit, Character Development, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, bc theres no way that this is gonna happen in s3, world-building, Slow Burn, Slow burn EVERYTHING, Slow Burn Romance, slow burn character development, slow burn family, slow burn acceptance, gracious references to fictional cats, mainly to cats the musical, Because I can, Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Magicats (She-Ra), Embedded Images, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Princess Catra (She-Ra)

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Part 1 of i wanna get better

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by shutupimshakira (Sniperdoodle)

Summary

As a consequence for losing Shadow Weaver, Catra receives her punishment: an exclusive, one-way trip to Beast Island.

Beast Island is as dangerous as the legends say, but there's something hidden underneath the horrors of the island above. Something . . . that may just reveal secrets about herself that Catra didn't know existed.

Who are the Magicats? Why do the Queens trust her so much? And why does Catra feel an intrinsic draw to the caves of Half Moon?

Notes

I love the fics where Catra finds the family she never knew she had and heals, so I figured I'd try my hand at it. The first chapter is pretty short but we'll get into the nitty-gritty soon.

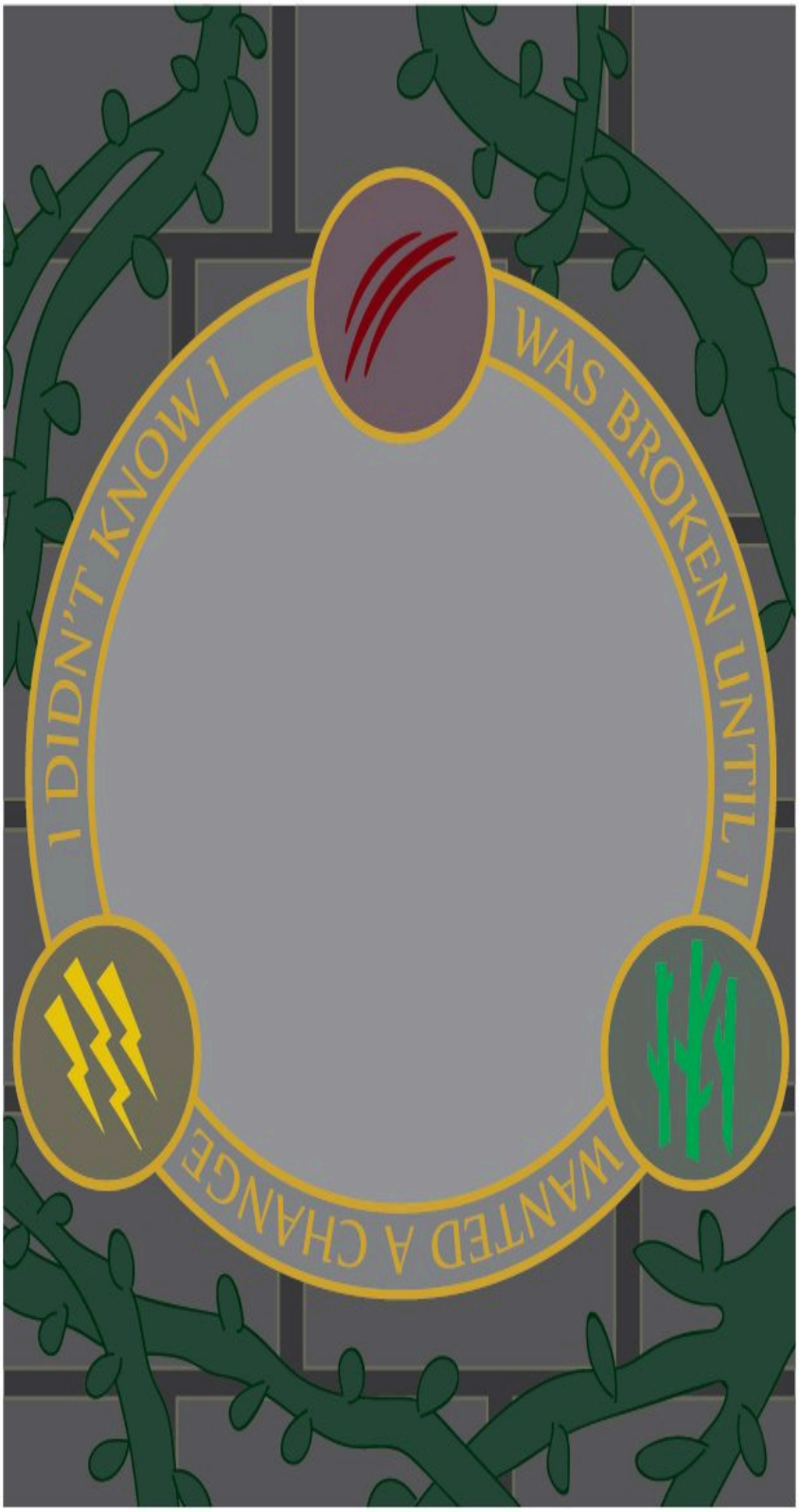
The fic title comes from the Bleacher's I Wanna Get Better, and the chapter title comes from Guns N' Roses Welcome to the Jungle.

Also, warning, I came up with a lot of world-building for Magicats society, based off of the two She-Ra Wikipedia pages I've read. I also read other Wikipedia pages, but lists of fictional cats so beware of . . . intentional Cats the Musical reference and unintentional Warrior Cats reference. I swear this is more serious than I'm currently making this out to be.

Well, my ramblings aside, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

if you want it youre gonna bleed but thats the price to pay


I DIDN'T KNOW I
WAS BROKEN UNTIL I
WANTED A CHANGE

So, this was really happening.

Catra tries to not throw-up as the boat swayed, focusing on the smooth lines of the cell surrounding her. She starts counting titles for the umpteenth times when there's a jolt across the ship that sends her sprawling on the floor of her cell.

"Get up."

Catra looks up at the two, faceless Horde soldiers she once-up until recently-had command over and contemplates spitting on them. Her body protests, but she manages to push herself up onto her knees. The soldiers must've thought she was taking too long, and grab her by her shoulders before dragging her out of the brig. Catra lets her body go limp just to make it harder for them.

The dark grays of the ship pass by quickly as she's brought up to the deck. The sun blinds her after days of being stuck in that little cell, and she barely has time to adjust before she's weightless. The soldiers throw her over the side of the boat and she lands in the sand unceremoniously.

Catra manages to sit up just in time to see the Horde ship push away from the shore, back out into the sea and back to the Fight Zone. She flops back into the sand and stares up at the sky. It's a perfect blue and completely empty of clouds, so perfect it's almost like the universe is mocking her.

So, she wasn't the perfect second-in-command. Sue her. It's a hard fucking job, and even though she did more than Shadow Weaver ever did, Hordak decided to get rid of her for one slip up.

Well, it was a pretty big slip up. She doesn't know where Shadow Weaver is, but she knows that the bitch definitely is *not* on Beast Island.

Because that's where Catra is right now.

The thought manages to shock Catra into the action. She really is on Beast Island. The ultimate punishment for any traitorous Horde soldiers (*like her*). If she doesn't kick her ass into gear, she is as good as dead.

She wills herself to stand up. Her body screams at her, begging for her to lay down in the sand and just give up, but she can't. Whatever Hordak did to her did a number on her body, and she has to be extra careful in her weakened state.

So Catra just starts walking, following the shoreline as she tries to come up with a plan. The sun seems high enough in the sky that she has a good bit of time to find shelter for the night, but she doesn't seem to be going very fast right now. She may as well keep moving forward as she thinks.

To her left, there's the ocean. Not much to do there. Ocean water makes you sick. She could try and make a raft to sail back out, but she was kept in a windowless room for four days in the Horde's fastest ship. She doubts there's much of anything near-by Beast Island.

In front of her is more sand. Lots and lots of sand. Oh, how she hates sand. There's not much she could do there. Maybe figure out how to fish from the shoreline, grab some materials from the near-by forest to build a quick shelter. However, there's no cover out here, and she'd be an easy target for the beasts.

To her right is the jungle. The sand quickly turns into a dense forest, with trees looming overhead and dark undergrowth containing the terrible beasts. But, if she's smart she could hide from the them, maybe stay to the trees but then again, she doesn't know much of anything about the beasts other than that, well . . . they are scary fucking monster. It would have more cover than the beach, though. And the forest could have food in the form of berries or small animals the beasts eat.

Catra's stomach grumbles. The forest it is.

She slowly steps through the tree line, treading carefully so as to not step on a twig or kick a pebble. Staying close to the shore, she carefully surveys the area before every step, probably being way too wary, but she can't afford it. Her life is on the line.

She listens for a scurry of feet, a snap of a twig, or the low growling of a monster a thousand times bigger than her. She watches out for bright spots of color, of fur or of fruit, in the dark greens of the jungle. As the sun gets lower in the sky, Catra hasn't seen much of either, which is equal parts good and equal parts bad. Catra decides to head further into the island for the chance of something to eat.

And of course, that plans goes to shit as quickly as possible.

The sun is setting behind her, the shadows growing long. She's used to the dark, and it doesn't bother her as much, but she makes one mistake and slips. She falls as the ground gives out beneath her and she hits the dirt as she slides down a deep incline.

She hits the bottom, hard, one leg slamming up against a rock jutting out of the ground. It feels like it just shattered into a million little pieces, and she can't help but cry out in pain as it impacts. She hisses and clutches her leg, but that doesn't really help. She manages to look at it and uh, it shouldn't be bending that way.

Catra's dealt with worse pain, pain like her best friend leaving for a bunch of idiots in the rebellion. A broken leg wouldn't be too bad. She tries to stand up, clawing at a tree trunk as she gets herself straight. As soon as she stands her leg bumps the ground and she cries again, slumping on the forest floor.

Catra looks up at the trees, vaguely making out the lines of leaves in the dark of the night sky. Maybe she can just lie here for a while, cover herself with some leaves, survive the night and deal with her leg in the morning.

Crrrrrrrrrrr . . .

She here's a low hum, more like a chittering sound than a growl. The forest shifts as a large mass pushes through the foliage, it's colorful hind sticking out against the dark greens of the forest. It's a mess of bright green fur with yellow stripes, and Catra can't make out a head or tail in the dark, but she knows one thing for certain: it's one of the legendary beasts of Beast Island.

She does her best to lay still, not even breathing, hoping it goes away. But the chittering stops and it spins around on a dime. She can see its ugly mug a few yards away from her.

It has red eyes with stringy green fur draping over from a protruded brow, a squished nose surrounded by wrinkles, a drooling maw with rows of sharp white teeth. It's about seven-feet tall, not as tall as She-Ra but tall enough to be menacing, and it certainly is scaring the shit out of Catra right now.

Adrenaline kicks in and Catra's able to ignore her wounded leg as she tries to scramble away from the beast. She's trapped in a corner, the steep incline she fell down minutes ago to her back and the beast pinning her in. She uses her claws to grab onto the dirt, pulling herself up despite her muscles begging her to give up. She doesn't look back, just forward, she seems so close-

The trees bend over and break with a crack as heavy paws stomp on the forest floor, crushing the brambles. She's slammed against the mountain as the beast knocks into her. She narrowly misses its jaw but gets smashed by its protruding forehead.

She loses her grip and falls to the ground underneath its feet. The adrenaline can't combat the pain she's in, and she slowly starts to succumb to it as the beast stands above her. She starts to black out as it rakes one clawed paw across her body, as if it's playing with its prey.

She almost thinks she hears voices in the distance as everything goes black.

am i dead or am i dreaming am i underneath the ocean or are my eyes just streaming

Chapter Summary

Catra wakes up, despite all signs pointing to her never waking up again the last time she closed her eyes.

Chapter Notes

Chapter title comes from The Weirdest Dream, from the Lightning Thief Musical

I hope you all enjoy reading this chapter! A quick descent into what will be a whole load of world-building!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"There's a Magicat there! Quick, she's-!"

"-I've never seen her before, not around Half-"

"-She kinda looks like the Queen, am I-"

"-Get her to-!"

"She was attacked by a beast-"

"-She's in a bad way, I don't know-"

"-Looks so much like her-"

"-She hasn't woken up-"

"-Can't get our hopes up-"

"-Getting worried-"

"Sleep well, kitten."

Catra wakes up in pain. It shouldn't be a surprise; the last thing can recall clearly is being attack by the beast. Well, at least she now knows for certain why it's called 'Beast Island'. Everything from that point though is . . . a blur. She recalls distant voices, like they were eons away, and only remembers fragments.

She wills her eyes to open and looks around the room she's in. It's a cavern of some kind, with a chiseled-out hole across from her bed letting in moonlight. It's dark, asides from a short candle with a light that's barely holding on. It looks like there's a couple other beds here and cabinets, but she's the only one here. She tries to sit up, but cries out in pain as her muscle protest and bandages strain against her skin.

"Oh scat, you're awake! Don't move!"

Catra's head whips around to the entrance, and a young woman enters. She's shorter than Catra, and could possibly be a bit younger than her. She's wearing a white robe over plain clothes, has a pair of glasses perched on her head, and looks completely average. Well, she's covered with brown fur, has a mane of hair tied back into a messy pony tail, and alert ears. She looks a lot like Catra.

Catra's never seen anyone like herself.

"No really," she walks over to Catra and carefully pushes her back down. Catra's so shocked, she doesn't even protest. "You need to be laying down or else you're going to reopen your wounds. It's a good thing you're awake but you still need more rest and-"

The girl looks Catra in the eyes, and her own eyes widen as she loses her train of thought. Catra manages to get enough

sense about her to hiss, "What are you looking at?"

"I, uh," the girl quickly looks around. "I need to get Ri'ta."

Before Catra can questions anything that's going on, the girl scurries out of the room.

Catra huffs and stares at the ceiling, trying to figure out everything that's happened the last couple seconds.

Somehow, she's not dead. That beast should've killed her, she was utterly defenseless and not in a position to fight. But she's alive, patched up, on the mend, thanks to someone. Someone, who happens to look like her.

A few minutes later, the same girl comes back in, towing behind two older women-who are also both cat people.

One of them is a warrior, Catra can just tell by how she's built. She's lean and strong, and probably could take on Scorpia if she so chooses. Her fur is a dark orange and mane is absent, cut down to keep out of the way, Catra assumes. One eye is a bright blue, but the other is kept shut by a long scar trailing down her face. She's wearing a night robe, but seemed to have found time to grab a sword that's holstered on a belt around her waist.

The second one is a bit shorter than the first, and doesn't seem to be as intimidating. Her fur is blonde with dark brown strips, and her mane is kept long. It's a bit ruffled and bushy, probably by sleep, but she doesn't seem to care about that. She's wearing a blue robe over a night gown, and is keeping one hand tucked inside her robe.

The original girl has stayed behind as the two older woman approach Catra, surprise on both of their faces. Catra doesn't like to be gawked at like she's some sideshow freak, so she hisses, "Okay, what are you looking at? I look like you all, there's no reason to be weird."

"Oh, my apologizes," the blonde-furred woman recovers first. "We weren't . . . expecting you to wake up so soon, especially after the injuries you sustained from getting attacked by the beast."

"Uh . . . yes," the orange-furred woman coughs, but Catra can tells there's something fishy. They don't give her time to point that out, as she continues, "Allow us to introduce ourselves. I'm C'yra, and this is my lovely wife Ri'ta. We're the . . . leaders of Half Moon."

"And the girl who came to get us is Shire, my apprentice," Ri'ta continues. "You are?"

"Catra," Catra's not a big fan of giving out information to people she's just met. She wants some answers first, "What the fuck is going on here? Where am I? Why are you all . . . cat people like me?"

"I supposed you're a cat person because you were born that way, like the rest of us," Ri'ta points out with an amused smile.

"Please dear, I doubt now is the time for sarcasm," C'yra rolls her eyes, but has a soft smile on her face. She sits down on the bed adjacent to Catra's own. "You're in Half Moon, the safe haven for Magicats, like us, underneath the island."

"Wait, we're *under* Beast Island?" Catra checks.

"It's the safest place, ever since the Horde attacked," C'yra reveals. "We lived above ground before the Horde found Purrsia, and their attacks caused me to lead our people underground."

"Uhm . . ." Catra looks around, awkwardly. She probably shouldn't mention that she's with the Horde. Or, was with the Horde. Catra's not quite sure what's going on with that, but after being suffocated by Hordak and condemned to die on Beast Island, she's got a pretty good feeling that she's not in his good graces.

"Yes, we know you're a Horde soldier," C'yra leans over and grabs something off the night stand. She flashes it to Catra, it's her force captain badge. C'yra gets colder as she examines the badge, "A force captain, to be correct. Usually we don't see someone of your rank here. It's even less likely to see a Magicat with the Horde. Would you like to explain what you did to get you sentenced here? And how you ended up with the Horde?"

"Pissed Hordak off, and dunno, I've been with the Horde my whole life," Catra simply says. She doesn't need to get into her multiple failures. She would really rather not think about that right now. "So, do you take in all the Horde soldiers you find getting ripped apart by a beast?"

"No, usually they're left to die," C'yra states. "But, you're a Magicat. You're an exception."

"I'm still a Horde soldier!" Catra spits.

"Can take the girl of the Fright Zone, but not the Fight Zone out of the girl?" Ri'ta guesses, she still has a small smile on her face despite the direction of the conversation. Catra just glares at her.

C'yra grips the badge, "The Horde assumes you're dead, and you're too injured to do anything. However, you are more than welcome to stay here, in Half Moon. I figure the Horde never told you about the Magicats, or true history of this island, once known as Purrsia."

Catra turns her glare to C'yra, crossing her arms despite it hurting to do so.

C'yra sighs and puts the badge down, "Aren't you curious about your origins? Where you came from? Who you are? There are no other Magicat colonies anywhere in Etheria, only here. I assume the Horde took you during the Invasion, there's no other way."

Catra frowns but says, "Well, you know what they say, curiosity killed the cat."

Catra hopes that would shut her up, but Ri'ta had a counter, "Yes, and satisfaction brought it back. The Horde probably didn't tell you that there was a second part."

Catra glares at Ri'ta again.

Ri'ta sighs and stands besides C'yra, placing a hand on her shoulder, "If you insist on being stubborn-" for some reason, Ri'ta shoots C'yra a look, "-Then at least stay until you're fully healed. You won't be able to tackle the beasts if you don't."

Catra looks between the two leaders. This is probably the worse she's ever been hurt, and usually she's good at covering that up but Ri'ta has a point. That beast was worse than She-Ra. She needed to be at peak condition to survive on Beast Island, where other Horde soldiers have failed.

The plan is already forming in her mind. Use the Magicats to fix her back up. Start patrolling the island, around where she was dropped off. The next time the Horde ships someone to Beast Island, she jumps on board and takes it over. She then goes back to the main land, group back up with Scorpia, and finds a way to prove herself to Hordak, or at least overthrow the bastard. Probably something to do with She-Ra.

"Ah, she's scheming," Ri'ta says to C'yra, pulling Catra out of her thoughts, causing C'yra to chuckle.

Catra's ears flatten and she hisses, "I'm just thinking my options over!"

"Alright, and what do you think?" C'yra asks.

Catra pauses, "How long until I'm fine?"

"Shire has been the one over-seeing your recovery," Ri'ta reveals. She turns to her apprentice, who was still in the back

corner. "What do you think?"

"Oh!" Shire's surprised to have been brought up. "Uh . . . let's see, between the broken ribs and leg . . . I'd say seven or so more weeks. That's if she follows instructions to a T and doesn't strain herself."

"Then I'll be the best patient you've ever had," Catra promises. Seven weeks would be a long time, but she could do it, bide her time and fortify her plan.

"Then it's settled," C'yra stands up and places a hand on Catra's shoulder, "Welcome to Half Moon, Catra. I truly do hope you enjoy your stay."

Catra brushes C'yra's hand off, "I won't."

C'yra is ready to leave, but Ri'ta is finalizing a few things with Shire, "If you need to go and get rest yourself, just send Gar in. I know she's not as good as healing magic as you, but she can handle any complications. Alright?"

"Yes ma'am," Shire nods her heads with a smile on her face. "Have a good night."

"You too, get some sleep," Ri'ta pats Shire on the shoulder. She turns to Catra, and with a soft smile adds, "Sleep well, kitten."

Catra doesn't say anything as Ri'ta turns around and joins her wife, the two leaving the room. Catra feels like she's heard that before, and though she usually doesn't like being called kitten, it made her feel . . . warm.

Shire closes the door and turns to Catra, "You need to go to sleep. Your body needs all the rest it can get to aid in your recovery."

"What if I'm not tired?" Catra asks, her smartass ways kicking in not ten minutes after she promised to be a model patient. Well,

ain't that just the way?

"You want something to knock you out?" Shire opens up a cupboard, and in the low light Catra can see various bottles of dark liquid. She picks up one and swirls it around, and it appears to be a dark purple, "This one tastes like scat, and it's only purpose is to knock people out."

"Any that taste good?" Catra checks.

Shire pauses for a moment, "Nope, they all pretty much taste like scat."

"Fine, give it here."

Shire pours a small cup-about the size of a shot glass-and hands it to Catra. Catra downs it in one, and it somehow manages to taste worse than the slop the Horde fed her. She hands the cup back over as she wipes her mouth and lies down in bed.

"So, when's this thing supposed to kick in?"

"Give it a moment."

". . . oh, shit."

"Told you so. Good night."

Catra barely has time to think as her eyes close. The medicine quickly pulls her into a dreamless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! I appreciate all who commented, and leave a comment with your thoughts below!

Next time, Catra learns more about the place she's stuck in for the next seven or so weeks.

i never thought i'd live to see the day when everybody's words got in the way

Chapter Summary

Catra learns just a bit more about Half Moon and meets a few of it's inhabitants.

Chapter Notes

This chapter title is from Everybody Talks, by Neon Trees.

So, I guess just as a warning, I'm going to try to update this once every week for as long as I can. I'm a college student working two jobs, and I've got the first five chapters written so hopefully I can stay ahead of the curve. If not, oh well.

Otherwise, I hope you enjoy this chapter! It's a bit of a long one!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Catra wakes up, sun is streaming thrown the small window in the infirmary. She blinks and tries to move her arm to rub the sleep out of her eyes, but something is weighing down on it. She glances to her side, where a kid is leaning on her arm and staring right at her.

"You're finally awake!" the brown-furred kit exclaims. "By Saz, you were asleep for soooo long!"

Catra's about to shoo the kid away, when Shire enters the room and comes to her rescue. She marches over, grabs the kid by the scruff of her neck, and pulls her away, "N'yan! I told you could come with me only if you followed my instructions! And what did I say?"

N'yan sighs, "Leave Catra alone."

"And what were you doing?"

"Not leaving Catra alone."

"Good," Shire lets go of N'yan. "Go into the other room. You're not allowed back in here until I say so."

"You're no fun," N'yan huffs as she kicks the ground and walks to a doorway that's squeezed into the narrow passageway into the infirmary. Catra didn't notice it last night, but that's probably where Shire has been spending her time.

"I'm so sorry," Shire sighs. "My aunt asked me to watch my cousin today because she doesn't have classes, so we're stuck with her. But how'd you sleep? It sounded like you rested well."

"Best sleep I've gotten in a long time," Catra sighs. It's sadly true. Since Adora left the Horde . . . she really does not need to think about that right now. She decides to move on, "Can I sit up, or am I stuck laying her like a fucking log?"

"Let me help you," Shire insists. She grabs a couple extra pillows and helps Catra get into a sitting position. Catra notices how sore her chest and ribs feel, as well as how stiff her leg is.

"So, what damage did that beast do to me?" Catra tries to evaluate everything, but it all just feels sore.

Shire has moved away to the other side of the room, preparing something with leaves and spices in a wooden bowl, "Five broken ribs, a broken leg, a plethora of cuts and bites, but the worst one was across your stomach. So, overall, you need to be very careful."

Shire crosses the room, carrying a wooden cup and hands it to Catra, "This'll help with the soreness. You have to drink it before eating something, though."

Catra takes it, greedy for anything to dull the pain, even if it knocks her out again. She polishes it off and hands the cup back

to Shire, "So, I heard something about food?"

"Yeah, my aunt promised to bring something her-for all three of us-she's the head cook," Shire reveals. She continues to move around the room, cleaning up messes and creating new ones, "She's really good. Ri'ta also may be stopping by? I don't know, I don't think I'm going to be able to make my lessons today so, who knows. Uh, not me, obviously."

"What does Ri'ta even teach you?" Catra questions as her stomach rumbles. She hopes food gets here soon.

"Uh, magic," Shire says.

Catra freezes up. She wonders if that's what happened last night, that feeling she felt was some type of spell Ri'ta cast on her. If it was magic, though, why did it feel so good? Magic only hurt, like anything Shadow Weaver did to her, ever.

Shire doesn't know that Catra's on the verge of panic, and just keeps talking.

"She's really great, the best magician here and she's from the M'stoff'lls clan so I guess that explains that, but she's a battle mage and not a healing mage so I have to learn a lot of the spells on my own. She helps, at least," Shire rambles.

Catra wants to change the subject, desperately. She tries, "Aren't there any other healers here?"

"Most of them were killed during the Horde Invasion," Shire bluntly says. "Like my parents."

Catra's eyes go wide. This is not the topic change she wanted. She still can't help but wonder, "So why are you helping me?"

"One, because Ri'ta told me too," Shire lists. She walks back over to Catra, carrying a tray of bandages. "Lift up your shirt, I need to change the bandages. And two, my parents always said that a healer does not do harm unto others."

Catra's silent as Shire changes the bandages. The bandages appear to just be protecting the stitches that rake across her skin, but there is some oozing. Catra's never gotten a wound this bad back at the Horde, but has seen plenty of others with wounds like this.

Shire finishes changing the bandages, and stays quiet for once. Catra doesn't say anything either but her stomach growls every once and a while.

The door to the infirmary creaks open, and Catra winces as Ri'ta's voice calls, "Shire, can you give me hand?"

Shire sighs as she walks over, "Not funny."

"No, I actually do need help if you want to eat," Ri'ta says as she steps in. Her one arm is still tucked inside a robe, but this robe is blue with golden trim and looks more formal than the one she had on last night. She's carrying a large basket with a fabric covering the top, "Jen'dots got caught up with a . . . certain someone sneaking into the kitchen, so I offered to bring it by."

"Oh, thank-you!" Shire finishes washing her hands and walks over to the basket. She takes the cover off, and the scent of food hits Catra in the face. She almost considers climbing out of bed, but that would strain her wounds and set back her recovery.

Shire begins to takes out plates and set up the meal, and calls out, "N'yan, you can come out if you want to eat!"

"Fooooooood!" N'yan calls as she runs out of the corner room at a full sprint. She almost runs into Ri'ta, but stops on a dime, "Oh, hi Queen Ri'ta!"

"Queen?" Catra questions, as no one mentioned anything about the leader of Half Moon being queens but she guesses it makes sense, and is ignored by everyone in the room.

"Hello N'yan," Ri'ta puts on the same soft smiles she had last night. "How are you today?"

"Well, Shire's being mean-"

"I told you not to annoy the patient!" Shire argues.

"I wasn't!"

Ri'ta chuckles, "Sounds like everything's going as it usually does. Now N'yan, have you been practicing the spell I taught you?"

"Oh yeah!" N'yan says. She brings her hands together and Catra waits for an explosion or something to lash out, but instead there's just a small orb of light floating above N'yan's palms.

"Good job," Ri'ta says as she ruffles N'yan hair. N'yan makes a face and the light orb goes out.

"Hey, ya made me loose concentration!" N'yan says.

"Then it seems like you better keep practicing," Ri'ta points out. "And once you do that, I'll teach you another one."

"Sweet!" N'yan says as she runs over to Shire. "Did Mom make this?"

"Yeah," Shire hands her cousin a plate. "Would you like to eat with us?"

"No, I gotta practice!" N'yan claims. She grabs the plate and sprints back towards the corner room.

"Be careful!" Shire shouts, but it sounds like it goes unheeded. Shire sighs and grabs a tray from another cabinet, puts a full plate of food on it, and lays it across Catra's lap, "Here you go."

Catra waits a second, smelling the food and making sure it wasn't poisoned. Shire has already started eating her own meal, so Catra assumes that it's safe for her to eat as well.

"So," Ri'ta turns to Catra just as she starts to eat. "How are you feeling today?"

"F'n," Catra says with her mouth full. This food was the best thing she's ever tasted, it was some kind of meat but it had flavor? Flavors she's never tasted before, because all the Horde has is gross rations. She forgoes asking questions and proceeds to shove the rest of her plate into her mouth.

"Hey! Slow down or you'll choke!" Shire warns her, but Catra's too busy eating to care. She sighs and goes back to her own food, "So, are we going to have our lesson today?"

"Of course," Ri'ta says.

"But," Shire glances over to Catra and doesn't say anything. Catra just glares back.

"I was going to ask Gar to come in, but Busto offered to watch her while we go to the library," Ri'ta reveals.

Shire almost spits her food out, and Catra raises an eyebrow, "What? Are we thinking of the same Busto?"

"Well, I'm talking about Captain Bust'fer of Bo'ots," Ri'ta checks, smiling. "Second to General Az'al?"

"Why would he want to watch over Catra?" Shire questions.

"Well, he was on the patrol that found her, I suppose he wants to make sure that she's okay," Ri'ta guesses. "He also may see as an opportunity to tell all his stories to someone who hasn't heard them a thousand times before."

"Not happening," Catra interjects.

Ri'ta laughs, "Oh, Busto will talk your ear off whether you're listening or not. Or . . ." Ri'ta trails off, she turns to Shire, "Gus has called an emergency council meeting."

Shire quirks an eyebrow, but realizations dawns on her face, "He wouldn't."

"You know how he is," Ri'ta says. "Az'al may be trying to gather information on her own."

"Hasn't C'yra talked to her?" Shire asks.

"Planning to, she's been busy this morning," Ri'ta reveals. "But considering all she's been through; I don't blame her."

Catra has a clue on what they're talking about, they're talking about her. Some council is going to convene today to decide whether she can stay or not, because she's a Horde soldier. Catra swallows the last piece of meat and questions, "But, aren't you and your wife the queens, or whatever? Can't you just tell them to fucking deal with it?"

Ri'ta doesn't seem surprised that Catra was able to skim on what's going on, "We could, but the Council is a Magicat tradition. When C'yra's ancestor, the first C'yra of D'riluth, united the tribes of Purrsia, she created the Council so each tribe could have a voice in how the Magicats were ruled. It's changed quite a bit since the tribe structure . . . no longer exists. It's myself, C'yra, and the heads of main the core factions: the soldiers, the hunters, the scholars, the chefs, so on and so forth. C'yra prefers it this way, so everyone can still have a voice."

"And so this Busto person is going to come in and evaluate me to see if I'm evil or not?" Catra guesses.

"Yes, but he'll also talk your ear off," Ri'ta ends it with a smile. "But I'm sure that the meeting will go smoothly. Mine and C'yra's vote both count as two, and I'm sure that C'yra can sway Az'al if you can't win Busto over."

"Honestly, just nod your head and say 'okay' every once and a while and you'll be fine," Shire advises. "Act like you're listening and he'll love you."

Catra has to think about it. She doesn't like this, one bit, sucking up to some stranger so she could stay. But, she's definitely not well enough to survive Beast Island on her own. She sighs, "Fine. Maybe you can tell the Council that I'm planning on leaving once I'm healed up, anyways. Don't need to go too out of your way for me."

Ri'ta smile seems sad now, for some reason, "Alright, thank-you."

Shire looks between the two and picks up on the awkwardness, "So, lesson at the same time?"

"Yes," Ri'ta turns to Shire. "When Busto gets here, you are welcome to come and find me in the library. I must go and talk to Deut'ron, so I will see you later. You too, Catra."

"Sure," Catra just shrugs.

Ri'ta makes her exit, and Catra looks down at her empty plate. That witch must be working more magic, because Catra feels bad, somehow? Like she disappointed Ri'ta when she didn't do anything to disappoint.

"You done eating?" Shire checks with Catra.

"Yeah uh . . ." Catra looks over to the basket. "Is there more?"

Shire smiles, "Yeah, of course. My aunt always makes extra."

Shire gets Catra another plate, and though the proportion is not as big as last time, Catra basically inhales the food. Shire watches with a curious look, "Wow, you were hungrier than I expected. Want me to send N'yan to get some more?"

"Yeah, this is the best shit I've ever had," Catra admits as she polishes off the last of the meat. "Better than anything I've ever had in the Horde. Of course, all we had was ration bars."

"Really?" Shire questions. Catra just nods. She looks down at her own plate, "I can tell my aunt to give you more, or try more stuff out. She loves experimenting with food."

"Yeah, sure," Catra agrees. "As long as it as good as this."

"Oh, it will be," Shire promises. She picks up Catra's empty plate and washes it off in a sink in the corner. She stacks up the plates and put them back in the basket, "I'll be right back. I'm going to see if N'yan's done, or if she's still playing with magic."

Shire moves to the corner room, leaving Catra with her thoughts.

"Hello there!"

Catra was about to take a nap (since the infirmary was so boring, asides from N'yan and Shire yelling at each other every once and a while) when the door to the infirmary bursts open.

A younger male Magicat swaggers into the room, and his general disposition makes Catra scowl. He's an orange tabby, wearing a red uniform with a gold cord across his chest like a sash and a short red cape hanging off his back. A sword is tucked into his belt and he has on thigh-high, black boots. It's an odd choice, and Catra forces herself not to think about it. He has a dazzling grin as he glides into the room he announces, "No need to fear, for Captain Bust'fer of Bo'ots is here!"

Shire sighs as she steps out of the corner room, dragging N'yan by her hand, "Hey Busto."

“Shire! How are you today?” Busto asks, and even though he’s already coming off as full of himself, seems genuine.

“Perfect,” Shire sighs. “Please don’t talk Catra’s ears off, she needs at least one part of her to not be broken.”

“Will do,” Busto dramatically opens the door. “You can trust your patient with me. Now, you two ladies should be on your way, don’t want to leave the Queen waiting.”

N'yan giggles at Busto’s extravagance, but Shire just rolls her eyes. She gives Catra an apologetic look, and leaves her alone with Busto.

“So, your name is Catra?” Busto asks as he walks over to her, boots squeaking on the floor. He leans up against the counter across from the end of her bed, “That’s a bit on the nose, don’t you think?”

Catra glares at him, “And what kind of idiotic name is Busto?”

“Oo, feisty,” Busto comments, but moves on. “It was a nickname given to me by my cousin. Is Catra a nickname?”

“No, it’s the name I’ve always had,” Catra hisses. “And look, let’s get this clear: I know you’re not here to be buddy-buddy. I know you’re here to report back on me to your boss. You can tell her this: I’m not staying in Half Moon. I’m going to get healed up and get out of all of your furs before you know it.”

“Really?” Busto checks.

Catra nods, “So I don’t want to hear any of your stories either.”

“Well, that’s a pity,” Busto sighs. “But are you sure you want to go back out into Beast Island, especially after you went hand-to-hand with a monster?”

“Now that I know what I'm dealing with, I’ll be fine,” Catra insists. “And that’s that.”

“Hhm, it’s a shame, I would’ve loved to trade blows with you, I’ve heard about the might of Force Captains, and being a captain myself, I feel like it could be a fair fight,” Busto mentions.

Catra just rolls her eyes, “Yeah, sure. Now we can stop talking.”

“So what was the Horde like?”

Catra glares at Busto, who has a mischievous smile on his, “‘Didn’t I just say I don’t want to talk.”

“Yet you’re still talking.”

“Fuck, fine you wanna know what the Horde’s like? It fucking sucks.”

“Really, yet you want to go back?”

“Better than on an island overrun by vicious monsters.”

“Are you sure? Because I heard that you already had some of Jen’dots’ food, and I know there’s no one in all of Etheria that’s a better cook than her.”

“I’ve survived on Horde food long enough.”

“But still, you would want to go back to the Horde after they sent you to your death?” Busto circles back. By Lord Hordak, he was annoying.

“Who said I was going to just rejoin them? I’m not that stupid.”

“I feel we’re having some type of disconnect here. What do you think you’re going to do once you leave Half Moon?”

“I don’t have to tell you anything.”

“Fair. So considering that you’ve been unconscious for a week, I doubt you’ve seen much of Half Moon.”

“Nope. Don’t need to. Don’t care.”

"Are you sure? We may be underground but we have a beautiful city. A vast marketplace. Sprawling libraries. State of the art training arenas."

"What, are you a soldier or a travel guide? You don't have to try and sell me shit because I'm not biting."

Busto just grins, like that's a challenge. Catra scowls deeper.

"Have you ever heard of a game called 20 questions?" Busto carefully states like he's handling a bomb.

"No," Catra sighs. She wants to add onto the fact that the only 'games' the Horde played were usually on the combat field, and involved strategy or hitting each other.

"Well, it's a game where someone thinks of an object-an animal, plant, mineral, something animate or inanimate-and the other must guess what it is by asking questions that can be answered with 'yes', 'no' or 'maybe'," Busto explains. "But, you have to guess what it is within twenty questions."

"Sounds *riveting*," Catra snarks.

"Exactly!" Busto beams, knowing very well that that was sarcasm. "So, I'll think of something first . . . and got it. Alright, you ask a question."

Catra sighs, "What is it?"

"Not a valid question, I can only answer with yes, no, maybe or neither," Busto argues. "Try again."

"This is pointless," Catra growls and glares at Busto. "After this, I will never see you again and yet you decide to torture me with inane games that are completely stupid."

"Harsh, and well, after this I am going to report to my boss on how this meeting goes as you deduced earlier," Busto continues. "And, if you don't want to play, I can just tell you about some of my grand adventures. I'm sure you'll find them, oh what's the word you used . . . riveting?"

Catra glares at him. They both know very well that she needs to stay in Half Moon for at least seven more weeks, to recover, or else she'll fucking die. She huffs, "Fine. Does it move?"

Busto thinks, "Maybe."

"Is it an animal?" Catra drones on.

"No."

"A plant?"

"Yes."

"I don't know any fucking plants."

"Just *try*."

"Is it a tree?"

"No."

"Does it have leaves?"

"Yes."

"That's all plants!"

"Continue."

"Is it, uh, poisonous, I fucking guess?"

"No."

"So is it edible?"

"Yes."

"Does it . . . have flowers?"

"No."

"Does it have fruit?"

"No."

"So then it's a stupid piece of shit plant?"

"No, that's an insult to the plant and I'm counting that as one of your twenty questions."

Catra continues to try, but the Horde didn't teach her anything about plants other than to identify which ones are poisonous and which ones are not. Apparently, Busto was thinking of 'catnip' and Catra doesn't even know what the fuck that is.

"I'll show you, one day," Busto says with a devious grin. "So, did you enjoy the game?"

"No. It was terrible."

"We can play a different version then."

"No, please. This is worse than torture."

"No, it'll be fun," Busto insists. "We take turns asking each other twenty questions so we can get to know each other better."

"What if I don't want to know you better?"

"Too bad. So, what's your favorite color?"

"I dunno, blue I guess?" Catra shrugs. She doesn't really know what to ask Busto, but then a devious plot hatches in her mind, "What's the fastest way out of this place?"

"Through the door, obviously," Busto grins. "So, what's your favorite food?"

"Whatever I had for breakfast this morning," Catra rolls her eyes. Busto foiled her devious plan first thing, so she just tries to keep him happy at this point. Maybe he'll be less annoying, "So like, Ri'ta mentioned something about you being on the patrol that found me . . . how fucked up was I?"

A shadow falls over Busto's face as the perpetual smile falters, "You were in . . . a real bad way. You're lucky to be alive right now." Busto doesn't seem to want to dwell on that too long, and won't let Catra dwell on it, "So, did you have any friends in the Horde?"

Catra's a bit shocked, since Busto seemed to have been making small talk. Her first thought is Adora and she almost spits out 'no', but then thoughts of Scorpia and Entrapta roll in. She wants to curl into a ball but mutters, "You don't really have friends in the Horde."

Busto's smile falters again, but then the door to the infirmary opens again. Catra wishes for Shire and her annoying cousin to return. Instead, it's an unfamiliar Magicat.

She seems to be around the same ages as C'yra, has slate gray fur and shoulder-length hair. She has bright blue eyes that seem to have been frozen in a critical glare. She's wearing the same red uniform as Busto but slightly stylized and with more emblems and badges, and Catra knows by the way she walks that she's in charge of something around here.

Busto hopes to attention, "General Az'al."

"At ease," Az'al says, not focusing on Catra at all. "I would like to talk to you."

"Already?" Busto checks. "Shire has not returned yet and I promised to watch over Catra."

Az'al glances over to Catra, face unchanging, but Catra's seen that look before. The General's wondering why Busto's bothering to use her name, she's a Horde soldier and worthless.

"The meeting is in an hour. I'd like a debrief before then," Az'al explains. "We can step outside, if you wish."

Busto nods obediently, and gives Catra one of his dazzling smiles, "Be right back."

The two leave the room and Catra's stuck with her thoughts. Busto was an annoyance and grated her in the wrong way but . . . after meeting his superior she has to realize that he's not as bad as that and could, quite possibly, be a decent person. But, Catra doesn't trust anyone, especially soldiers under people like that. She once was a soldier under a person like that.

Busto does not come right back. Shire and N'yan return from the lesson and Shire explains that she let the two soldiers go. Catra's surprised, Busto doesn't seem like the person who would go without a dramatic goodbye, but at least Catra can finally nap.

So, Catra naps. Sweet, dreamless sleep overtakes her for a couple hours and when she wakes up, C'yra is by her bed.

C'yra is no longer dressed in her night clothes, but she's not dressed like how Catra expected a Queen to dress. She has seen Queen Angela and the Princesses in their flowing robes and tiaras. Ri'ta wore a more practical robe so Catra really didn't question it. C'yra's outfit is closer to a military uniform, like Az'al's but purple and with different emblems. She doesn’t bother with a tiara, her head bare of any royal signifier.

C'yra's sitting on the bed, elbows on her legs as she stares at her clasped hands.

"Fuck, how long have you been there?" Catra yawns as she wakes up. She doesn't bother trying to sit up, just remains laying down.

"Not long," C'yra says, but it sounds forced. She must've been there a while, lost in thought and hopefully not watching her sleep like some creep. "Ri'ta told me you heard about the Council Meeting and figured out it was about you."

"Yeah, so I'm out?" Catra guessed. Why else would the fucking Queen herself be here other than to deliver the bad news?

"No," C'yra reveals. "You are welcome to stay in Half Moon as long as you want. The majority agreed to let you stay here and I wanted to deliver the good news myself."

"Well, I'm only going to be here until I get better, so that's cool, I guess," Catra huffs.

The same sad look Ri'ta had earlier crosses C'yra's face as well. She promptly stands up, "Then you best get your rest, but know that you will always be welcomed here."

Catra knows that's not true. The Queens may welcome her, and somehow the majority of this stupid council thinks that she could belong, but she won't. There will be people like Az'al, seeing her as just a fucking Horde soldier and a failure and nothing else. She's not welcome in Half Moon. She doesn't belong here.

She might not belong anywhere.

"Also, I don't know how you manage to win Busto over, but he thinks highly of you," C'yra adds. "He's well-liked by the public and as loyal as they come. He's a friend you'll want by your side, whether or not you stay in Half Moon."

Catra recalls Busto's final question, about whether or not she had friends. She answers, "I'm not really the person who has friends."

"Maybe you haven't met the right people," C'yra suggests. Catra thought she had met the right person to be her friend, through thick and thin and forever. Then there was Scorpia, who was quickly becoming Catra's friend. C'yra continues, "But, I really should let you go back to bed. Sleep well, kitten."

C'yra turns around leaves and Catra wonders why that makes her feel better, somehow. Those three words can conjure up a warm feeling in her chest, and it freaks her the fuck out. Maybe C'yra can do magic too. Or maybe . . . C'yra and Ri'ta just mean it.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading and if you enjoyed it or just want to guess what fictional cat all the characters are named after, go ahead and leave a comment! Have a good day!

Interlude I: Scorpia

Chapter Summary

Hey, what's Scorpia been up to?

Chapter Notes

Of course as soon as I say I wanted to update this once a week I'm late.

To be fair, I've been busy. I'm trying to go to a university in the winter and I've got to get shit done now. Plus, once again, full-time school and two jobs. Fun times!

Anyway, I guess I have two other points to touch on. One, is the She-Ra trailer. I knew that this was, no way in hell, going to be close to anything that happens in Season Three. But, I'm going to continue my original plan and season three looks pretty cool.

Secondly . . . that Cats trailer . . . what in the WHOLE fuck.

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Scorpia sits in Catra's room, feeling completely lost.

It's been a few days since her Wildcat was sent to Beast Island. She was shipped off, effective immediately, with no time for Scorpia to interfere.

Scorpia's tried everything since to figure out where Beast Island is and how she can get to Catra. Well, everything short of marching up to Hordak himself and demanding he return her now. She's asked just about every cadet and officer what they know about Beast Island, tried to track the ships leaving and returning

to the Fright Zone, and got Entrapta to hack into the Fright Zone systems.

Nothing.

Scorpia's not sure why Beast Island is such a well-hidden secret, considering that it's a prison island and a tale to scare young Horde cadets. There's something more there, something she doesn't understand . . .

But Scorpia's too overwhelmed with regret to try to comprehend the larger picture. She failed to protect her Wildcat, and now she's off suffering on the terrible Beast Island.

Scorpia wishes she knows what she could have done different, and even if she managed to intercept Catra's exiling, she's not sure what she could have done. She would, of course, fight like hell to protect her Wildcat, even if that meant defying the Horde. But then, if they managed to make it out of the Fright Zone alive, where would they go?

Every village would spurn them for being Horde soldiers. The Princess Alliance would pursue them for the grievances they two of them have caused them in the past. There would be nowhere to go.

Scorpia flops back on the bed, falling deeper into her grieving. She already misses Catra, her Wildcat would have a plan and the two of them would pull it off, together. Scorpia already feels so alone, like she did before Shadow Weaver brought her and Catra together.

That's probably the only good thing Shadow Weaver has ever done. She brought her and Catra together.

But, if Scorpia ever sees Shadow Weaver again she is going to kick the shit out of her, for hurting Catra. That's just the way the cookie crumbles.

Scorpia decides to not waste too much of thought on Shadow Weaver, she's not worth the trouble. She goes back to replaying and replaying and replaying every possible scenario on how she could possibly get Catra back but nothing's adding up.

Until she has her epiphany.

Her thoughts wander to Entrapta, as even though she considers Entrapta a friend, right now Entrapta is loyal to her progress in technology. Going against the Horde to get Catra back counteracts that. Scorpia doesn't blame her for that, just wishes that she would come along, as it was nice to be friends with a Princess who doesn't abhor her.

The train of thought jumps to the Princess Alliance. How they all must hate her and Catra for being a part of the Horde. In all truths, the Horde is pretty much the only thing either of them have ever known. The only person who could possibly understand that is . . .

Adora.

Scorpia jolts up, sitting up straight in bed. She's always been jealous of Adora, how close she is to Catra even though the two are on opposite sides of the war. After ever brutal fight, there's something deep down inside of both of them that forces them to still care about the other person.

Adora still cares about Catra, maybe even as much as Scorpia does.

She would help.

She would help her Scorpia save Catra.

Scorpia decides to wait until night, going through the rest of her day absent-mindedly, trying to formulate and hide her plan at the same time. No one apparently notices, as Scorpia was able to sneak out later that night with no interference.

Scorpia steals one of the skiffs, piloting it through the twisting Whispering Woods. Scorpia almost gets lost, once or twice, but eventually she sees Bright Moon, a beacon in the literal darkness.

It's dawn when she finds the castle, the sun creating a halo around the already glowing castle. It's beautiful, with its bright colors and shimmering waterfalls. It also kinda hurts Scorpia's eyes.

She parks the skiff on the edge of the Whispering Woods, jumping down into the dirt and walking towards the tree line. In the distance, she can spot some guards making their rounds on the castle, but none as far out as the Woods.

Scorpia takes a deep breath and steps out into the light.

She finds the path the goes right up to the front gate and follows it. May as well be direct, it'll be more suspicious if she tries to sneak in. Stay calm, keep her claw shut and tail down. Don't be a threat.

She only gets half-way up the path before some of the guards on the parapets see her. Even from so far away, she can hear their echoing cry of, "STOP RIGHT THERE!"

So Scorpia stops, puts her claws up in the air and kneels on the ground. It feels demeaning, but this just might be the fastest way to Adora.

The guards share a confused look before more pile out of the front gates of the castle door. They come out with handcuffs, but with one look at her claws and the small loops of the cuffs, one guard says, "Uh . . . I don't think there are gonna fit."

"No shit," a second ones says. She keeps a spear aimed at Scorpia, "Just . . . don't try any funny business, Horde scum."

"I'm here to see Adora, not fight," Scorpia states. "Tell her it's about Catra."

The two guards share another confused look, and the first one says, "Uh . . . okay?"

"I think we're just gonna put ya in a cell now," the second one insists.

Scorpia hates the thought of that. She knows the cells in the Fright Zone are void of any comfort asides from a cold, hard floor. But she goes along and allow herself to be corraled into the castle like a monster and put inside a cell.

The cell is actually . . . nice? Scorpia's a bit surprised. There's a bed, toilet, sink and desk, and chair, all nailed into the ground but it's already looking better than Horde cells. The mattress on the bed is just like the ones back in the Fright Zone, but the pillow is a bit plushier. There's a small window near the ceiling that lets light stream in from outside.

Scorpia sits down on the bed as the cell door closes. The Rebellion only has iron bars, not a force field like the Horde. If Scorpia really wanted too, she could just bend the bars and leave, and even though she's not a fan of being put into a cell she doesn't want to leave.

The two guards stand outside her cell for a moment, and the first one questions, "Doya think she's too close to tha . . . scary one?"

"I dunno," the second one shrugs. "Queen Angella can make that decision. Rory went to go tell 'er that we got a second Horde soldier in Bright Moon in a week."

"Oh yeah, but this one ain't as scary," the first insists as the two walk away.

Scorpia sits in silence for a while, hoping that someone will listen to her plea and tell Adora she's here. If she's left to rot away in this cell, she can at least say she tried to save her Wildcat.

Scorpia's surprised when she gets a visitor not an hour (at least she thinks it's an hour) later, but it's not Adora or any of the Princesses.

The ethereal form of Queen Angella seems to float between the cells and she rests in front of the door to Scorpia's. Her face is neutral and solid as stone as she looks down and cordially orders, "State your name and business here, Horde Soldier."

"Oh, uh," Scorpia jumps off her bed. "Force Commander Scorpia, though I guess technically not anymore? I uh, kinda left without telling anyone but I don't think I'll be able to go back after this, all things considering-"

"And your business?" Angella cuts her off.

"Oh! Right, well," Scorpia tries to get herself back on track, but she rambles whether or not she's nervous. "I came to see Adora. Catra's in trouble and she's the only one who can help me."

"So you came to Bright Moon . . . for aid?" Angella checks.

"Yes," Scorpia pleads. "Catra's my best friend and . . . and . . . she's been sentenced to a fate worse than death and need to save her, and I know Adora and Catra haven't gotten along in a while but they still care for each other and she can help me!"

Angella doesn't really react during Scorpia's speech. She still stands up, straight as a board and says, "Is that why you surrendered yourself to the Rebellion?"

Scorpia nods, trying to keep herself from going off on another tangent.

"Before we continue, what do you know about the Horde mage, Shadow Weaver?" Angella questions.

"Well, after Catra usurped her she was in prison for a while," Scorpia spills in hope of pleasing Angella. "But Hordak wanted to send her to Beast Island, but Shadow Weaver manipulated Catra

into helping her escape her cell. So, Catra got into trouble instead and received Shadow Weaver's punishment."

Scorpia looks down at her claws, "She only told me all of this in confidence, but Hordak still found out. And now she's on Beast Island, and she could die, and my Wildcat could die and it would be my fault! So please, let me speak to Adora."

"Adora's not in Bright Moon," Angella simply says.

Scorpia's mouth drops, "Uh, what?"

"She has gone on a mission, away from Bright Moon," Angella says, staying tight-lipped about her true whereabouts. "And it may be quite some time before she returns."

Scorpia staggers back to the bed and slumps down onto it. Adora's not here. She's trapped in Bright Moon. Catra will be as dead as dirt by the time she's able to do anything.

"But you gave me valuable insight on a common enemy and I believe your intentions are pure," Angella continues. "You do not have to stay in this cell, but you will be under house arrest in one of the rooms here in Bright Moon, kept with a constant guard. You can remain there until Adora returns, but I will not allow you to return to the Fright Zone."

Scorpia doesn't feel like she has much of a choice, but she does ask, "What do you know about Beast Island?"

Angella pauses, "To be honest, I've never heard of it before."

"It's a prison island, where traitorous Horde soldiers are sent to suffer and die," Scorpia explains. "I thought it was just a story to scare children, but it's real. And that's where Catra is. I can't just wait around. She'll be dead already."

"I'm being more lenient than I should be, especially with a Horde soldier that aided in the attack on my home," Angella says. "Even though your emotions are real, I must be wary that this is a

trap. It is up for Adora to decide whether to pursue this or not, but as I said she is away. I will try and send word to her, but until then you must wait. You can either wait here, or in one of our rooms. What will it be?"

Scorpia looks around the cells. If the cells are this nice, the rooms must be nicer. If she's going to wait, she may as well wait in comfort.

"I'll go to the room," Scorpia mumbles.

"I'll have the guard prepare one for you, and retrieve you when it's ready," Angella states. "And I must warn you, one wrong move and you'll be back in a cell and unable to see Adora. Am I clear?"

"Yes ma'am," Scorpia says, staring Angella in the eyes.

Angella curtly nods and glides away, the entrance to the jail slams shut and echoes once she's gone.

It doesn't take much longer for the guards to come and get Scorpia. She's flanked on either side as she's lead up into the castle, to a room that already has guards stationed outside of it. As she enters, the door locks behind her and she has to take in just how bright this place really is.

There's a large plush bed at the center of the room that she just knows won't mix well with her claws. There's a waterfall in the corner next to a large open balcony overlooking the villages of Bright Moon. There's an en suite bathroom and lots of furniture and . . . man it's so bright. Scorpia really should ask for a pair of sunglasses or something.

Scorpia avoids the bed and sits by the waterfall, listening to the trickle of water to try and relax her. However, her thoughts are a flurry of worries about Catra and Beast Island and when Adora would arrive.

She really hopes that Adora returns so. And Catra can survive long enough for Scorpia to come for her. Because she’d get to Beast Island eventually, so she can see her Wildcat again.

Chapter End Notes

Hey, if you liked this chapter or want to scream about the Cats trailer (or She-Ra too,I guess that's related to this fic), go ahead and leave a comment! That's the equivalent of standing in my room and cheering me on as I write this. Thank-you and see y'all next time!

Next time, load on for the magical mystery tour!

so what the heck you're welcome glad to have you with us even though we may not ever mention it again

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a tour of Half Moon and meets some of it's colorful denizens.

Chapter Notes

Uh . . . sorry this is late? But happy She-Ra season three! Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter!

Also, I'm really tired and can't remember but the chapter title is from the one song from the Music Man about Iowa. I think the title's Iowa Stubborn? Idk.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s not a couple days until Catra sees either of the Queens again.

She’s been getting along with just Shire and N’yan, not really talking with either of them but appreciating not being left alone in the infirmary. Busto stopped by once as well, but Shire chased him out as soon as he started to annoy her.

And then C’yra shows up out of the blue.

Shire had taken N’yan to go and get lunch, and promised to bring some back. She trusted Catra not to do anything stupid at this point, mainly because Catra doesn’t want to compromise her recovery. So, Catra was completely alone.

C’yra looks around the room as she enters, quietly enough to surprise Catra. Catra almost jumps out of bed when she sees the Queen and hisses, “Fuck, don’t you know how to knock?”

“I’m sorry,” C’yra tries to bite back a chuckle. “I was expecting Shire to be here.”

“Getting lunch,” Catra explains. “What are you doing here?”

“I came here to check-up on you,” C’yra says and sits down in the same spot she sat the night Catra woke up (it was basically just her spot at this point). “How are you feeling?”

“Bored,” Catra huffs. N’yan was trying to get her to play a game called ‘Twono', but Catra didn’t want to play stupid board games. Maybe she should have taken her up on it.

“I know, I don’t like spending much time in the infirmary either,” C’yra says. “So, I thought I’d offer you a tour.”

Catra quirks an eyebrow, “I thought I was on bed rest?”

“Yes,” C’yra stands up and walks over to one of the tall cabinets at the end of the room. She pulls out a wheelchair that looks uncomfortable but functional, “But I having a feeling we can get away with it. So, would you like to come with me?”

Catra thinks through her options, and decides that she not only doesn’t have anything better to do, but also doesn’t have a choice because this is the queen. She shrugs, “As long as we stop by the kitchen, I’ll be happy.”

C’yra smiles, “Good. Let’s get you out.”

It takes some maneuvering, especially because Catra’s leg in a cast and it hurting to twists around, but she gets the chair with minimal pain. C’yra writes a note for Shire and they leave.

The hallways of Half Moon are made of rock, with little crevices carved out near the ceiling and floor to squeeze in small lanterns. There's a couple of other doors in this hallway, but it currently seems empty.

"Not many people are out now, because it's lunchtime," C'yra explains. "Lunch is served from noon to two, but Jen'dots is not one to deny anyone food if they're a bit earlier or a bit late. So, would you like to stop by the kitchen first or elsewhere?"

It doesn't take Catra long to deliberate, her stomach grumbles loudly and she decides, "Kitchen."

"Alright," C'yra says.

The halls seem twisting, and Catra wonders if C'yra is deliberately taking the longest path to the kitchen possible with the winding path she's taking. Catra wonders if it just takes forever because she's hungry, or Half Moon is just that confusing.

After a lifetime of strolling through the halls, Catra can hear a cacophony of voice echoing off cave walls and into the tunnels. It sounds like the Fright Zone's mess hall at dinner, with tired recruits at the end of a hard day's training managing to gab as they shove the meager rations in their mouths. Well, actually it doesn't sound the same. These aren't drones of tired subjects, they're lively and . . . joyful sounding.

A steep incline brings C'yra and Catra into the cafeteria. It's a large cavern, with vines and floating lights hanging at the stooped ceiling. There are rows and rows of tables filled with Magicats, all talking and eating and sharing in revelry. Some wearing uniforms that are either red or green, some wear blue robes, and some are the clothes of commoners. Everyone is here, eating together.

"Shit, that's a lot of people," Catra mumbles as C'yra wheels her in.

C'yra chuckles, "This is the majority of the Magicat population. We make sure everyone is fed. The hunters hunt for food on the surface and bring it to the kitchen staff to prepare for everyone. Some families like to prepare food for themselves, and those portions are set aside for those that reserve it. Though, it's quite hard to resist Jen'dots food."

"Yeah," Catra agrees. The cafeteria-style set-up reminded her of the Fright Zone but it was so . . . different. People enjoyed being here and eating together, and the food was, well, to put it mildly, *fucking fantastic*.

C'yra wheels Catra over to a white building built off of the cave walls. There's a window at the front facing the cafeteria, and a large queue waiting for their food. Magicats pass by the open window and servers fill up their trays with a delicious-smelling meal.

"We could wait in line," C'yra points out. There's a hint of mischief to her voice, and sounds like she's smirking, "Or, we could go in the back door."

C'yra takes Catra near the back of the building and through one of the doors into the hot kitchen. Magicats wearing white clothes and poofy hats are running around and finishing making food or serving it to the people at the window. At the center of all the chaos, wearing a purple handkerchief around her neck, is a stout Magicat with brown fur. She reminds Catra a bit of Shire, and a lot like N'yan.

She freezes when she sees Catra and C'yra, "Queen C'yra! You need to stop coming by during the lunch rush, I don't have time to talk!"

Catra smirks that this woman has the balls to talk to a Queen like that. C'yra though, doesn't seem to mind, "Sorry Jen’dots, but we're not here to talk. I'm giving Catra a tour."

"Catra?" Jen’dots looks down to her. Catra's waiting for a disgusted look to cross the chef's face, she is after all a Horde soldier, but instead Jen’dots lights up, "Shire's newest patient! By Saz, it’s wonderful to meet you! Shire's told me you've only ever had rations before, such a shame! I hope I'm feeding you well!"

Catra's a bit shocked by Jen’dots' enthusiasm, "Yeah, uhm, it's really good. Do you have any leftovers right now?"

"Well, I sent Shire away with an extra share, but we always make enough so everyone can have at least two shares, so we definitely have extras!" Jen’dots rushes away, moving around the kitchen in a blur. Less than five minutes later she returns with a delicious-smelling picnic basket, "There you go! Enjoy your meal, and hopefully I'll be able to see more of you once you're able to get around on your own two feet!"

"Yeah . . ." Catra flashes to her plans to leave as soon as she's well, but she can already say for certain she'll miss Jen’dots' food.

"Now you two better get out of here," Jen’dots continues. "It's lunch rush, after all."

"Of course, thank-you," C'yra says and she and Catra retreat from the kitchen. When the door shuts, C'yra lets out a sigh of relief, "For a second, I thought she wasn't going to feed us. She hates it when I disturb her during a rush."

Catra has already opened the picnic basket and is munching on the food inside. With a full mouth she mumbles back, "Yer welc'm th'n."

"Well then, where to next?" C'yra asks and she moves them out of the cafeteria, into a different, winding, hallway.

Between bites Catra snarks, "I dunno, you know this place better than me."

"Well, would you like to see the training arena?" C'yra asks, sounding strangely hopeful.

"Yeah, sure, why not," Catra shrugs. She hopes C'yra isn't asking her just because she's a Horde *soldier*. Okay yeah, maybe Catra is a bit curious about where the Magicats train, but that's just because Busto keeps on talking about it, not because she genuinely wants to know about that type of thing. Of course not.

"The quickest way from here is through the market, so we'll be getting two birds with one stone," C'yra comments, seeming to

pick up pace.

It's not as long as a journey to the marketplace, also shoved into a large cavern. They enter on the second floor, a rim around the market and closer to the floating lights crowded in the ceiling. On the walls of this pathways are more entrances to the caverns, though in some of the large ones there seem to be shops. As they descend the spiral pathway into the market, Catra looks over the rails down into the colorful tents that are so pushed together that she can't see the ground.

The market isn't too crowded-considering that almost everyone is at lunch-but it's still busy. Shopkeepers are pushing their wares, from rugs to clothes to shoes. C'yra doesn't stop to talk, but everyone smiles and waves at her as they pass. They leave the stares of confusion and disgust for Catra.

C'yra seems determined to make it to the arena quickly, until there's a cry of pain followed by heckling laughs. She sighs, "I'm sorry Catra, I must derail for the tour and deal with this."

Catra was finishing of the flavored wings of whatever-type-of-bird-that-lives-on-Beast-Island and was content to just eat. She mutters, "Yeah go ahead."

C'yra parks Catra in an open spot between two empty stalls, both of their owners out of lunch and dives into the mess of the market.

She returns, about ten minutes later, dragging a tall, Magicat with a mess of orange, red, white and black stripes covering his fur. Both of his ears are nicked and pierced and he's scowling as he's being pulled around like a child.

"Ya can set me down now, C'yra," the Magicats drawls, like he's not concerned about his well-being.

"Well Thom, are you going to try and steal from the marketplace again?" C'yra asks with a sigh, like this is a boresome chore. "And attack the stall keeper?"

"No, of course not," Thom rolls his eyes and manages to sound like he's been caught in some odd trap, but the grin on his face says otherwise. "I would never."

"You would, and you still will," C'yra says with a deep frown. "You have one more chance, or you're going to be stuck sleeping in a cell and spending your days doing community service. Am I clear?"

"Of course," Thom rolls his eyes once again.

C'yra lets go of the scruff of his neck and he falls onto the ground face-first. Catra can't help but laugh as he ungracefully stumbles back up onto his feet.

Thom glares at her as he hisses, "Whatcha laughin' at, Horde scum?"

Catra wants to retort, but C'yra places a hand on Thom's shoulder, "Catra is a guest in Half Moon, and you shall treat her with the same respect you'd give any other Magicat here."

Thom sleazily grins, "I'll make sure to do just that. See ya 'round, Queenie!"

Thom stalks back into the marketplace and C'yra glares at him as he leaves. Once he's gone, Catra comments, "Ya know, I don't think he treats anyone decently."

"He doesn't," C'yra growls. She takes a deep breath and stands up a bit straighter, "But, don't worry yourself with Thom of M'cavity, Catra. He's just a ne'er-do-well, and better left for those in charge to deal with. Let's resume the tour."

They promptly leave the market and take another winding path until they get to a formal set of doors. There's a small chamber behind it with racks of weapons, paintings of warriors, and some plush-looking seats. At the other enter is a curtained-off doorway, but when C'yra parts them, Catra can see the bright lights of the arena.

C'yra wheels her out onto a formal viewing platform, definitely meant for herself and other Magicats royals (if there are any). There are two seats at the fore-front, with a scattering of seats behind them. C'yra manipulates the wheelchair around the seats so Catra can have a front-row look at the arena.

There are rows of benches circling the arena, down to the actual fighting area below. It's large and clearly sectioned off for different tasks. In one quarter there's a complex climbing gym, for Magicats to test their dexterity. The next, there's a plethora of training dummies, all worn and beaten up. The other half is dedicated to sparring.

Even from the height, Catra can see Busto facing off against three other Magicats soldiers. Two are bigger than him, and one is about the same size. In one hand, Busto is holding a thin blade, and the other is a small knife. He takes a breath, before blasting forward and trading blows with the biggest bloke in the bunch.

"So, here's the training arena, open to all," C'yra explains, but Catra's paying more attention to Busto's fight. He's managed to knock the biggest one down and has turned to the second one. She continues, "But, you will always find some of the soldiers out here. Sadly, the ones in New Moon was bigger and frankly, more impressive, and I have many good memories training in there. I met Ri'ta there, afterall."

Catra manages to tear her gaze away from the fight to look at C'yra, staring off in the distance with a wistful smile on her face. Catra's not sure if she wants to her to ask about it because . . . Catra's strangely curious, though she's telling herself that she doesn't care about the Queens and doesn't want to learn more about them because she'll be leaving. So Catra doesn't ask.

But she does miss the rest of Busto's fight.

All three soldiers are on the ground, and Busto is standing between the, victorious. She can't make out the words, but he says something encouraging as they pick themselves up.

"Busto is an impressive soldier, one of our best," C'yra comments when she notices Catra watching him. "One of the many reasons the General of our standing army, Az'al, chose him as her majordomo."

"Yeah on Az'al, what's her problem?" Catra decides to ask. "She sent him to spy on me, basically and seems to have a major stick up her ass."

C'yra blanches, "You met Az'al?"

"She came to talk to Busto when he was baby-sitting me that first day," Catra reveals.

C'yra sighs and rubs her temple, "Az'al was hurt greatly by the Horde Invasion, as many of us were. She's cautious, and doesn't want anyone else to get hurt. Don't take it personally, she's a good person, deep down inside. She's just created many," C'yra pauses and takes a deep breath as she looks off into the distance, "Many barriers since the Magicats moved to Half Moon."

Catra quirks an eyebrow. She *will* take it personally, but C'yra's being a bit weird about this, "So, what's up with you two?"

"Best friend since childhood," C'yra automatically says. She's silent for a moment as if she's just now thinking about what she should say before it just flies out, "But you don't need to know about a stranger's problems. It's about time we get moving, not much here for either of us to do."

"Fair," Catra agrees. C'yra's stuck as he baby sitter and she's stuck in a wheelchair, so all they can do is watch the fights.

They leave back through the antechamber back into the hallways. More Magicats are showing up, done with their lunch and getting back to their normal business. They politely nod to the Queen, but still give Catra odd looks.

It's not too far of a walk to a pair of thick doors, made of metal and beautiful forged with a swirling design. As C'yra pushes

one open, inside Catra can see rows and rows of . . . books.

"This is the library," C'yra says, going into a whisper as she pushes Catra inside. "Center of learning for our scholars and mages."

"You have . . . a lot of books," Catra says, looking at the high shelves as they pass by. All the books look really old, and Catra's never seen so many books in her life. The Horde didn't encourage reading that wasn't propaganda or battle strategy. She asks, "Didn't you all have to retreat into the caves? How come you saved all these books?"

"The books were actually here before we moved into the Half Moon caves," C'yra explains. "Hundreds of years ago, a bolt of lightning struck the Great Library of New Moon, causing it to burn down. The Fire of Ilir convinced my ancestor, Queen Cl'eo, to move the surviving books to a place where they would be safe from natural disaster. That answer was the Half Moon Caves, where they would be safe from fires and flooding. In the years since, the scholars have recreated many of the books lost and made copies. That's why our library is so vast."

Catra only half pays attention, the history boring her. C'yra directs them to the center of the library where the floor is raised to a large circular platform. It's covered in tables, filled with research and jars of bright liquids, but a large area at the center is open. And, right now at the center, looking at a book on a lectern, is Ri'ta.

Well, Ri'ta is a mage and C'yra said that mages congregate in the library, so it makes sense that she's here. C'yra doesn't disturb her though, as Ri'ta raises her arms and objects placed on the floor around her start to float. They float straight off the ground, each glowing faintly, until they start to slowly spin around.

The magic makes Catra uncomfortable. She tries to shrink back into the chair, wondering if she could slowly start scooting away for when it eventually goes wrong. C'yra's wrapped up in the

magic and Catra doesn't want to disturb anything, so she tries to find something else to focus on.

Catra finds a welcome distraction when she notices that Ri'ta's missing a hand. It's the arm she often tucks into her robe, and now it makes sense why. There's a stump at the wrist and air where the hand should be, and Catra has to wonder what happened to her.

The objects go faster and faster until they shoot towards the center above Ri'ta head and collide. Instead of exploding, they become one object and floats down onto the lectern. Ri'ta picks up a strange sphere, coated with a rocky-looking substance, and turns around. Her mouth turns into an 'o' as she gasps, "By Saz, I didn't hear you two enter."

"You never do," C'yra says with a soft smile. Ri'ta walks over and C'yra steps up onto the dais to meet her, pressing a quick kiss to her lips, "Anyways, I'm giving Catra the tour of Half Moon."

"Did you ask Shire for permission?" Ri'ta questions, quirking an eyebrow through her smirk makes Catra think she already knows the answer.

"Well . . . " C'yra rubs the back of her head.

"You would've taken Catra on the tour if she said no anyways?"

"You know me so well," C'yra grins dopily, like a teenager in love.

"Yes, and you're as stubborn as they come," Ri'ta comments, but says it fondly. She places the sphere in a basket on one of the tables, "Well Catra, I better make sure you get returned to the infirmary safely, but do you have any questions first?"

"Any?" Catra checks.

"Yes, shoot," Ri'ta insists.

Catra looks at the stump once again and asks, "What happened to your hand?"

Ri'ta looks down at the stump and her eyes go wide as well, "Holy scat, when did that happen?"

Catra quickly glances to C'yra for any confirmation as to whether this was a recent development. C'yra rolls her eyes and sighs, "Dear, that stopped being funny twelve years ago."

"The kits still get a kick out of it," Ri'ta insists.

C'yra gives Catra a tried look as she warns, "She has more than that. Be prepared for a lot of bad jokes."

"They're great!"

"I love you, but they're not."

"They are, and Catra," Ri'ta finally gets serious. "I lost it during the Horde Invasion, during one of the battles."

"You were fighting? I thought you were just a mage," Catra comments.

"A war mage," Ri'ta corrects. "One of the best. After all, the first time I met C'yra I bested her in battle."

"And from that day on I was completely taken by you," C'yra says, looking at Ri'ta like she was the sun. Ri'ta smiles back and gives C'yra the same look.

The two of them are so in love it's actually kinda of disgusting.

Thankfully, there was a distraction.

A bent-over Magicat with slate grey fur hobbles over, his cane made of knotted wood knocking on the ground with every step and a small pair of glasses in danger of falling of his nose. He's looking directly at Catra, pure hatred etched in his grizzled

features. Catra figures that even in her weakened state, she can take him out by blowing on him and knocking him over.

"My Queens," the Magicat basically growls as he shatters the moment. "May I ask, what are you thinking, bringing the Horde soldier into the Great Library?"

The mood shifts instantly, C'yra returning to the serious look of a Queen and Ri'ta giving the Magicat an annoyed look that screams 'seriously? right now?' C'yra steps forward, standing as straight as she can and towering over the Magicat, trying to intimidate him, "Gus, Catra is our guest in Half Moon. I was simply giving her a tour."

"You're risking thousands of pages of knowledge by bringing her here, after all the work your ancestors have done to protect this place!" Gus spits, still keeping a whisper.

"The Council decided that Catra can stay in Half Moon as long as she wishes," C'yra continues. "And the Great Library is included in Half Moon."

"I'm not even that interested in dusty old books," Catra points out, but Gus only shoots her another withered glare. She continues, "And what am I even going to do, huh? Stuck in this wheelchair?"

"Knowledge is dangerous," Gus hisses, his cane makes a slight knocking sound against the floor as he shakes in rage. "The more you know, the worst off the Magicats are."

"Gus, you're over-reacting," Ri'ta steps in. "We all lost something to the Horde, and yet C'yra and I and many others are not filled with anger by just the sight of her. Maybe you need to rethink your stance against her, it will do you better in the long run."

"I know why you two have let your guards down," Gus pouts. "But I don't want her in my library."

"It's not *your* library," C'yra argues. "It's not even my library. This library belongs to Half Moon, to the Magicats. Even Catra has a right to have access to it. But you may go back to your work in peace. We were just leaving."

"Good," Gus spits, sends Catra one glare, and hobbles away.

"Well," Ri'ta sighs. "That's happened. Catra, let's get you back to the infirmary before Shire hunts C'yra down."

"There's still the Shrines and Hunter's Quarters," C'yra says, steering Catra out of the library. "But that can happen at another time."

Catra nods, and waits until they're out of the library and heavy metal doors have closed behind them to ask, "Man, that Gus guy's an ass."

Ri'ta laughs and C'yra comments. "Well, if I wasn't Queen, I'd have to agree with you. But since I am, I have nothing to say to that."

Catra stays mostly silent on the way back to the infirmary, C'yra and Ri'ta talking together and Catra feeling that she's intruding on something. They seem so close and intimate with each other, something Catra once had with Adora though not as . . . romantic or intense. It makes Catra miss Adora, but then Catra shoves that thought into the incinerator of her mind as soon as she processes it.

Shire's waiting for them in the infirmary, and doesn't rat out C'yra until Ri'ta tells her that it's okay to. C'yra is looking at Ri'ta in annoyance during said ratting out, but Ri'ta just laughs at her situation. Eventually, the two leave and Catra's boring day in the infirmary proceeds as normal.

But, Catra keeps on thinking about Half Moon. The joy in the cafeteria, the friendliness of Jen'dots, the expertise of the soldiers, the endlessness of the library and the love between C'yra and

Ri'ta. However, the good starkly contrast with the odd looks she received all day, the scheming of Thom, and the hatred from Gus.

Even so, Catra wants to see more of Half Moon.

And that thought scares her.

She's getting attached.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you or a love one was traumatized by the Cats trailer, you should consider commenting on this fic. Or if you liked the chapter, let me know!

Next time: Dreams, by Fleetwood Mac

like a heartbeat drives you mad in the stillness of remembering what you had and what you lost

Chapter Summary

Catra has a nightmare.

Chapter Notes

Chapter title from Dreams, by Fleetwood Mac

Uhm, sorry I guess for taking a hot second to update? I've been busy. I also haven't seen She-Ra season 3 yet. I'm so bad at actually watching shows I like.

Otherwise, enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It is a moment of respite, between endless training exercises and Shadow Weaver bearing down on her for everything she does. Catra and Adora have snuck away, going up, up and up to the highest points of the Fright Zone.

"C'mon, slowpoke!" Catra teases, jumping from one pipe to a ledge, quick as ever.

"Hey, hold on!" Adora cries back, still a couple floors behind.

This was one of the only thins Catra was better at than Adora: climbing. Catra could climb forever, up higher and faster than Adora ever could, reaching up into the clear air above the perpetual smog of the Fright Zone.

Then Adora falls. Probably loses her grip on one of the bars and goes tumbling back to the floor. Catra tries to call out her name but no sound comes out of her mouth.

Catra scrambles down, desperately trying to get to her best friend as fast as she can. She seems to be moving in slow motion, no matter how fast she wills her body to move.

By the time she reaches the bottom, Shadow Weaver is standing over Adora. Adora is curled up at her feet, clutching her arm, but looking more like a pet than a human.

Shadow Weaver's shadows snake across the floor, grabbing Catra by the ankles, keeping her from running away before she even has the thought. Catra is paralyzed in fear, waiting for the punishment to come.

As the shadows start to crawl up her legs, feeling like a billion tiny ants against her fur, Shadow Weaver howls, "Insolent child! Look at what you've done to Adora!"

Catra tries to protest that it's not her fault, but nothing comes out. The clinging shadows reach her chest, and continue upwards.

"You will pay for being useless, worthless, an annoyance," Shadow Weaver continues the long list as the shadows reach Catra's face. Catra tries to cry out for help, but the shadows just pour into her mouth and spill down her throat. She tries to breath but the shadows are blocking her throat, her noses, even her eyes as darkness surrounds her.

"CATRA!"

Catra jolts awake, heaving as she tries to remember how to breathe. The cold night air fills her lungs and reminds her that she's not in the Fright Zone anymore. She's in the infirmary of Half Moon.

Shire had refused to give her any of the shitty purple liquid that helped Catra sleep. Her exact words were, "this is pretty much pure alcohol, and I don't want you to get addicted, become an alcoholic, destroy your liver, and die a horrible death."

Catra feels like the horrible death is worth it to not have nightmares.

"Catra, are you alright?"

Catra looks to her left and for some fucking reason, Ri'ta is there sitting by Catra's bedside like that's fucking normal.

"What the fuck are you doing here?" Catra hisses, not intentionally but she's pretty much panicking right now.

"Glad to see you still have your wits about you," Ri'ta says. "I'll tell you, but first take a deep breath in and breathe out. It will help calm you down."

Catra almost debates continuing to hyperventilate just to spite Ri'ta, but she's more curious as to why Ri'ta was here, watching her sleep. She breathes in and breathes out, until her heartbeat slows down and things start to feel real again.

"There," Ri'ta sighs. "Feel a bit better?"

"Were you watching me sleep!?" Catra accuses.

"Technically, yes," Ri'ta admits. "This is the last night Shire wanted to keep you under observation, and I offered to stay up so she could get some sleep."

Catra gives Ri'ta an uncertain look, "Still kinda creepy."

"Well, I wasn't even paying that much attention, I was reading until you started to thrash about in your sleep," Ri'ta flashes Catra the cover of the book in her lap. "If that makes it any better."

Catra shrugs.

"So, that was quite the nightmare you were having," Ri'ta points out, though Catra wishes that she wouldn't have dredged it up again. "It took me a bit to get you to wake up. Do you want to talk about it?"

"Not really," Catra mumbles. Like every other nightmare she's had that reveals some repressed feelings, she saves it for future Catra to deal with. Sadly, Future Catra is usually the Catra that has a similar nightmare the next night, who also decides to put off dealing with it.

Such is life.

"Alright," Ri'ta doesn't try to dig in further. "I know everyone deals with nightmares their own way, but if you want to talk, I'll always lend an ear."

"Okay, whatever," Catra's not entirely sure how to respond to that. Catra's used to repressing any sign of weakness-including nightmares-and bottling it up inside so no one ever knew about it. Or until it exploded, either or. It's bad enough that Ri'ta *saw* her have a moment of weakness, but she wants to *talk* about it.

Catra decides to curl up back onto the covers and try to fall asleep, but it's weird that Ri'ta is besides her. She can hear the turning of the pages in the book, so maybe Ri'ta really is just reading instead of being creepy.

Catra glances over her shoulder and Ri'ta is actually fully absorbed in the book.

"What are you even reading?" Catra questions.

Ri'ta seems surprised that Catra's awake, but she answers, "Just some family history, a recording of important figures in the M’stoff’lls Tribe."

"What?" Catra questions.

"Well, remember when we talked about the Council, and I talked about the Tribe structure?" Ri'ta asks. Catra nods, so Ri'ta continues. "Before C'yra the First united the Tribes, they were groups of families who banded together to protect each other or fight other Tribes. After the Great Unification, Tribes became more centralized to families. My tribe, the M’stoff’lls, harks back to before the Great Unification. My ancestors were at the center of many great magical discoveries, so I'm just reading about some of them."

Catra scrunches her nose, "Wait, how far back does that all go?"

"Over one-thousands years, at least," Ri'ta answers. "Maybe getting close to two."

Catra can't even imagine that. Not just how much time that is, but knowing where you came from down to the name of your oldest ancestor. Catra didn't know anything about her past. It sounds like Ri'ta could know everything about her own.

"So, are there other cats in your tribe? Family? Whatever?" Catra asks.

Ri'ta give Catra a sad stare before looking down at the book, "None, unless you include C'yra but she hasn't an ounce of magic in her. My mother died almost twenty years ago, now. My father was a mage but not born into the tribe, and he died shortly before I was born, so I had no other siblings and my mother was an only child. It's just me. That's why I decided to not officially join the D'riluths when C'yra and I married, just to keep the tribe going a bit longer."

"Mh," Catra must be tired, because she finds herself getting sappy for a second, "It kinda sucks being alone like that."

Ri'ta quirks an eyebrow but the realization dawns on her face, "I imagine it must have been harder for you. Were there any other Magicats in the Horde?"

Catra wants to sink back into the bed at just the mention of the Horde, and just shakes her head. There may have been lizard people, scorpion princesses, and weird recording demons, but Catra never saw anyone else like her.

"I can't imagine being isolated like that," Ri'ta admits. "To look around and not see a face like mine. You're much stronger than I."

"Aw sweet," Catra yawns. Yeah, she's fucking tired.

"You should close your eyes, you sound like you're tired enough to go to sleep," Ri'ta says. For once, the idea of spite does not surface, so Catra closes her eyes. She hears Ri'ta settles back into her chair and whisper, "Sleep well, kitten."

It's midday when Catra wakes up the next morning. Shire is studying a book and occasionally scratching down notes on paper, while N'yan is coloring in a book Catra kinda hopes is one of Gus' favorites.

Shire looks up when Catra sits up with a groan, "Did you sleep well?"

The first part, definitely not. The nightmare ruined that part of sleep with her. After she talked with Ri'ta? Catra slept as soundly as she did with the shitty grape drug. She's starting to wonder if that 'sleep kitten' thing Ri'ta and C'yra have been saying is some kinda of spell . . . but Ri'ta said that C'yra can't do magic. She'd either let her curiosity overtake her one day and get to the bottom of that saying, or she'd desperately hold onto her apathy about Half Moon to stop getting further and further into the lives of the Queens.

Though, to answer Shire's question Catra just shrugs and admits, "Eventually."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you like the story, consider leaving a comment!

Next time: Fun fact about academic books that I learned in college is that no one has ever enjoyed writing or reading an academic paper WHYD YA PUT IT IN A FANFICTION

i cant remember if i cried when i read about his widowed bride but something touched me deep inside the day the music died

Chapter Summary

> Catra is forced to read a book when she would much rather be Jared, 19.

Chapter Notes

> yo what's up uhm . . . so its been like a year since i've updated and this chapter has been sitting around like, 90% finished for a year. so since we're in the middle of a pandemic and i don't want to work on my project for a professional development confrence, i've finally decided to finish this chapter. also, she ra s5 tho. so fucking good. no spoilers for now, but i have Thought (TM) on how to adapt that bad boy for this universe. Anyway, this is a world-building chapter and I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra is getting the feeling she might be annoying Shire.

It's the third week into her recovery, and sitting around the infirmary is driving Catra mad. There wasn't much to do, aside from playing card games she frankly didn't understand with N'yan (why does flying defeat fighting? Catra knows she could punch a bird if she tried hard enough) and bugging Shire (or Busto, he has continued to stop by and when he's here, at least Shire can join in on the jeering).

Shire must've snapped, because after her lessons with Ri'ta one day, returns and drops a pile of books on the end of Catra's bed.

"What are those for?" Catra asks like she is being shown a brand new, never tested, torturing device.

"Books, for you," Shire reveals. "The next time you start to whine about being bored I will be throwing one of these at you."

"You're going to throw one of these heavy-ass books at your patient?" Catra questions.

"Don't test me," Shire warns. "So the next time you even dream about complaining, try picking up a book instead."

Catra reaches for the book on the top, and it looks to be a boring history book. Catra drops it back on top, "You really expect me to read this boring shit?"

"It's what Ri'ta gave me," Shire shrugs. "But you may as well start somewhere. You have the entire library to work through in the next four to five weeks."

Catra pouts, but then she recalls her meeting with Gus. Being fueled by spite and boredom (an odd mix, but it certainly works) Catra picks the book back up and begins to read.

THE ARRIVAL OF THE 3 DEITIES AND THEIR LASTING IMPACT ON PURSSIA

In the earliest days, after the island of Purrsia was revealed from the sea, the Magicats were aimless vagabonds vying for territory in its dense jungles. But it was not a lifestyle that would last forever, evident by how we live today.

Around the year XXXX, the D'riluth Tribe had set up camp for the night. The guards had just changed, according to oral traditions, meaning it must have been about midnight when Magicat culture changed forever.

Three stars, blinding and brilliant, descended from the sky. Standing before the D'riluth Tribe were the three deities. The Magicats didn't know that at first, so they reacted to their arrival with fear and attacked.

The First Star stepped forward and pushed the warriors away with a sweep of their arm. The Magicat warriors tumbled backwards from their might.

The Second Star stepped forward and helped the warriors off of the ground, healing any of the wounds that they received.

The Third Star stood in the background, watching with harsh, glowing eyes.

"Let us help you," the First Star said. "We will help make you the greatest warriors your world has seen."

"Let us help you," the Second Star said. "We will teach you how to heal any wound and harness nature to your benefit."

"Let us help you," the Third Star said. "We will make you devastating destroyers, leaving nothing but ash in the paths you walk."

What could the D'riluth Tribe say but yes?

The Three Stars began to teach the D'riluth Tribe their ways.

The First Star, known now as Saz the Great, taught the Magicats how to fight and introduced powerful magic that could ensure them victory over their enemies. The warriors emulated Saz as best as they could, to try and match their might to his.

The Second Star, who is known as Lyses the Kind, showed the Magicats the wonders of nature. They helped them settle down and plant roots, through farming and hunting. They showed the Magicats that there's magic hidden in nature and how to use that magic to heal.

The Third Star, Ilir the Wretched, showed Magicats how to become cruel and capricious. A select band of Magicats followed Ilir, trailing them into the jungle where they became like Beasts, hunting their brethren not for food, but for wicked sport.

As the D'riluth Tribe flourished, the other Magicat tribes struggled against nature and each other. Eventually, Saz and Lyses took pity on them and brought the other tribes into their fold, teaching them like they had taught the D'riluth.

For the first time, the tribes of Purrsia were united.

Together, the Magicats built the city of New Moon and temples to Saz and Lyses, marking a new era. With the aid of the first two Stars, progress was made in every field. Warriors trained harder and crafted better weapons. Mages made daily discoveries in science and magic. Healers learned how to cure the worst diseases. Farmers made their crops healthier. It was an Age of Enlightenment.

But in the shadows of the light of progress, Ilir hid and burned with rage. Their beasts had done all they could to hinder the Magicats' progress, but it wasn't enough. Ilir had to come up with something new.

Using their malicious magic, Ilir took the brightest spark, the loudest noise, and the darkest colors and mixed them all together. They released this beast into the sky, where it could not be reached by arrows or spears, and it attacked.

The Magicats were confused when the sky turned dark, but Saz and Lyses already had their suspicions about who was behind this. A flash of light broke apart the sky, followed by a furious bellow so loud it caused even the greatest of Magicat warriors to crumple to the ground in pain.

Saz and Lyses raced into the jungle, where they found Ilir and their Beasts waiting. The three battled during the storm, and not is known from the fight due to the drowning out from the

thunder. All we know is that when the Three Stars stepped back out of the jungle, they had decided to leave.

Some scholars believe that the Three Stars' departure from Purrsia coincides with the last First Ones contact on Mainland or the Great Star Extinguishing, so the three had to leave. Some religious scholars believe that Saz and Lyses had to leave because they needed to take Ilir far away from their beloved Magicats, and the only way to make sure they left was to go with them. But it would not be the last time the Magicats would see their Stars.

When the Three Stars left, they gave the Magicats these parting words:

"We shall see you all again," Saz said. "The warriors that have I have trained and guided, and who shall die gloriously in battle, shall enter my realm and shall forever celebrate your victories."

"We shall meet again, many times," Lyses continued. "If you lived a good and just life, you will be welcomed to my realm to rest. Then, you will be sent back into this realm, but your life will begin anew. You shall visit me nine times before you can rest in the fields and forests of my realm for eternity."

"Hear me when I swear, we shall meet again," Ilir concluded. "If you are wicked and cruel like my Beasts, you shall enter my realm to endlessly suffer for your crimes."

With that, the Three Stars ascended back up to the night sky, and the Magicats have not seen them in the living realms since.

The Magicats tried to continue on, but without the guiding prescenses of Saz and Lyses, the United tribes fractured apart. The D'riluth Tribe remained in New Moon, creating the Castle Stronghold as the center of their stronghold. The other Tribes went out and built their own cities and forts. They fought

among each other, warring for territory or bragging rights. The Age of Chaos had begun.

One would think that this endless war would be more suitable to Ilir, who would have delighted in seeing the peaceful Magicats becoming frenzied fighters. Now, scholars looking back wonder if the departure of the Three Stars was all a device of Ilir to cause such ruin. At the time, however, each tribe credited their fighting efforts to the Deity of War themselves, Saz.

Saz's final words may have been an incentive to the years of war. After all, how are you supposed to die gloriously in battle without war? The draw of the other side was far greater than the pull of reality.

During the Age of Chaos, the outside world finally made contact with the Magicats. They were shocked to find Purrsia in a state of disarray, but even more frightened to see the mettle of their warriors. The outsiders decided to let the Magicats be, as they were afraid of a war against the fearsome Magicats.

The Age of Chaos lasted close to a thousand years, until the D'riluth Tribe was at the center of the dawning of a new age once again.

The Temples to Saz and Lyses were the only neutral grounds throughout the Age of Chaos, every other piece of land was up for contest. It was in the Temple of Saz, C'yra of D'riluth the First was given her mission to bring peace to Purrsia and the Magicats.

C'yra led the D'riluth Tribe in a conquest of Purrsia. The other tribes bowed to her might, and after the Great Conquest was complete, C'yra was named queen and ruler of this community with Saz's blessing.

And thus began the Age of Peace, which we have been living in since. The D'riluth Matriarch still rules Purrsia, and people

continue to devote themselves to finding joy in Lyses' or Saz's realms after death.

“I have questions,” Catra says as she closes the first book.

“Yes?” Shire aska a bit unsure, busy working on some new medicine. She looks like she doesn’t want to be disturbed. Catra continues.

“First questions, what the fuck are stars?” Catra begins.

“They were bright orbs like the sun that used to light up the night sky,” Shire reveals. “Except that they were all much, much smaller because they were very, very far away and there were a lot of them. But one day, they all disappeared. There’s not much surrounding the Great Star Extinguishing, but Magicats used stars to navigate and tell stories. There are some more books on them and star maps in the library, if you’re curious. I don’t really know a lot.”

Catra almost asks for those books. Almost. Stars sound interesting, though weird. She decides to not prompt Shire to bring her any more books.

“Okay, second one,” Catra glances to the cover. “Does anyone actually believe this shit about these three deities and their afterlifes of whatever it is?”

"Uh, yeah?" Shire says like it's obvious. "Doesn't the mainland have their First Ones, or whatever?

"The First Ones aren't deities, no one worships them," Catra argues. "They're just an ancient civilization with cool tech. If anything, these 'Three Stars' sound like First Ones."

"Well, they're not," Shire insists.

"What proof do you have?" Catra claims. "Some old books?"

"We have very thorough historical records," Shire begins. "The Temples to Lyses and Saz. The Beasts on this island-that were made by Ilir-are found nowhere else. The magic given to us by Saz and Lyses can only be performed by Magicats. Some people can recall past lives, from before passing through Lyses' realm."

Catra figures that the Temples and the records were made by a Magicat very dedicated to this scam. The magic and Beasts are because Purrsia developed on its own far away from the mainland, where people took the First Ones as they were: a dusty old civilization that left a lot of death temples. The last one was the most ridiculous, Catra couldn't help but laugh

"People, people really think they can remember their past life?" Catra cackles."That's some grade a bullshit right there."

"Well, I'm not one of them but you could talk to Deut'ron if you want proof," Shire says. "And some people have dreams about the gods and the afterlifes."

"Do you believe in this shit?" Catra questions.

"It's not scat, and yes I do," Shire says. "My parents were devout followers of Lyses, he taught Magicats how to heal after all."

"So like, what the fuck do you do? Ask for him to come back?" Catra asks. She can't really see anyone devoutly following someone who isn't there, and is mostly likely a myth. Don't you have to be in this realm to either inspire your followers, or strike fear into them?

"Leave offerings for him at the Shrine," Shire explains. "Usually I'll include notes, requesting aid in being a good healer."

Catra wants to laugh, but somehow Shire seems withdrawn and uncertain about sharing this information. She's embarrassed. Catra decides to cut back and instead ask, "Does it work?"

"Well, you're alive, aren't you?" Shire counters. "You were in a very bad way when you arrived. I asked Lyses for aid in your recovery. Maybe it was all me that helped you. Maybe Lyses pushed you along. Who knows?"

Catra's certain that Lyses did not help her heal. That was Shire's medicine and her own unconscious determination. She continues, "What about Saz? You believe in him?"

"I believe that he exists," Shire says. "But I doubt that many people have faith in Saz these days."

Catra considers asking about what Shire means by that, but is also getting a headache talking about all this crap. She decides that the only thing to do is stare at tiny words on a page of a book, and hopes it's the remedy.

C'YRA OF D'RILUTH THE FIRST: THE GREAT UNIFIER OF PURRSIA

The only people who could have possibly influenced Magicat society as it is today more than C'yra of D'riluth the First are the Three Stars themselves. C'yra did what, before her time, only deities could do and she will be remembered by our people for centuries.

C'yra of D'riluth was born into the D'riluth Tribe near the end of the Age of Chaos. The daughter of one of the tribes' great warriors and was trained in all forms of combat. She excelled at everything, but her speciality was strategy. At 17, she became her tribe's youngest warrior.

She saw her first real battle months after being elevated to one of the tribes most honored positions. The D'riluths were

attacking Waning Moon, the home of the Bom'luri Tribe. The Bom'luri were clever, as they built their home so close to the Temple of Saz, one of two neutral territories at the time (the other being the Temple of Lyses). Those who decided to attack Waning Moon had to be careful so that the battle did not spill over into the sacred neutral territory.

But, the Third Battle of Waning Moon did just that. C'yra was unknowingly drawn into sacred neutral territory by the leader of Waning Moon. She bested him in combat, and was going to kill him when a voice told her not to. She raised her head and saw the Temple of Saz on the horizon. Instead, she went to the Temple, feeling drawn there whether to apologize to Saz themselves for violating their holy grounds or a deeper feeling of fate.

The Temple of Saz was empty. Clerics of Saz usually came in the evening to clean up if anyone had stopped by in the end to see its beauty, worship the god, or ask for Saz's aid in combat. She walked to the center and heard Saz talking to her, though it was cut off by the leader of the Waning Moon attacking her.

The Leader has snuck up on her, creeping through the Temple of Saz, with full intent of defiling their sacred ground. He swung his huge club at C'yra's head, but C'yra dodged it just in time. The Leader, instead, shattered a relic dedicated to Saz. With aid of Saz, C'yra moved with unseen speeds and attacked the Leader. In the quick battle, she cut off his arm and skewered his eye but she did not kill. She would not do that on Saz's sacred grounds.

Victorious, she stood over the leader and her mind raced with questions. Saz, however, provided them as she stood in the Temple.The Great Star gave her a mission, and she knew what she must do.

Feeling empowered, C'yra returned to the Tribe. When C'yra returned with the Leader, now missing an eye and an arm,

the Bom'lrui surrendered to the D'riluths. The D'riluths had taken Waning Moon, and C'yra used that to her benefit.

She explained to the D'riluth and Bom'luri the visions Saz had given her. The two tribes were moved by C'yra speech, and rallied behind her for her cause.

Within a few days, the two tribes were able to pull together-under C'yra's newfound leadership-and pushed forward to Full Moon, the home of the Pangur'ban Tribe. Their combined might could not be stopped by the famous archers of Pangur'ban. The day was truly won when C'yra approached the Pangur'ban leader and asked her to join their cause, all in the name of Saz. The leader agreed, and their collective gained another tribe.

The three tribes became the United Purrsia Tribes, and with C'yra's leadership they conquered the rest of Purrsia the same way. They showed their mettle in battle, but C'yra always convinced the leader to join her.

The Tribes were finally united. C'yra was chosen as the country's new leader and elevated to the status of Queen. She was crowned in the Temple of Saz in XXXX.

Until her death, C'yra ruled Purrsia with a just hand and is remembered for her mercy. Her descendants continue to rule Purrsia, doing their best to emulate her rule.

C'yra's (the First) story was pretty clear, Catra was only struggling with her conquest. It was for a purpose much different from the Horde, to unite rather than control. Of course, all that Saz shit could have been a made-up reason to do so, but after she became Queen she only did things that would benefit everyone, not just herself. Her subjects respected her, there was no fear there. Catra still decided to take anything else she heard about the first C'yra with a grain of salt.

The next book on the pile is the Abridged History of the D'riluth Queens. It's an old book with hand-written pages, and each section has a different style. Each page was on a different Queen, and holy fuck there was a lot. Catra skimmed through most of it, as the queens were either scholars or warriors and just kept the peace for Purrsia. A few caught her eye, like Y'fang the Mage who was the only mage in the full line of D'riluth or Obs'dian the City Builder, who expanded Purrsia and built many cities during her reign as Queen.

No Queen was wicked and cruel. They all did their best to protect the Magicats and help them thrive. Catra was surprised that after so many years of ruling a nation, no one became corrupted.

Catra got to the final entry, a single page about Queen Bett'i, C'yra's mother.

QUEEN BETT'I OF D'RILUTH

Bett'i of D'riluth was born on the second day of the fifth cycle in New Moon, in XXXX. During her upbringing in the Castle Stronghold, she tended more towards the scholarly traditions than those of the warrior, even though she had an intense connection to the Stone of Saz.

During her reign, she focused on pushing Magicats more towards education, as Purrsia had not seen a war in thousands of years. Many Magicats started to enter trades and skilled jobs rather than the Army or Guard.

She was crowned on the seventh day of the ninth cycle in XXXX after her mother stepped down from the throne due to illness. Though she was no warrior, the Clerics of Saz gifted her a spear.

In XXXX, she married R'bin of Bom'luri, and she gave birth to C'yra the Third on the twelfth day of the seventh cycle the

following year. Though R'bin died when C'yra was young, the Queen devoted herself to both her country and her daughter.

Tragedy struck when the Horde invaded Purrsia in XXXX. To try and stop the conflict before anyone died, Bett'i made an agreement with Hordak of the Horde: that she would surrender herself and he would leave Purrisa alone. Hordak agreed, but the moment Bett'i stepped into Horde territory she was slain.

Queen Bett'i became a martyr for the Magicats, and C'yra was crowned days after her death.

Catra couldn't help but laugh. This dumb bitch thought that she could just surrender herself to the Horde and everything would be fine and dandy. It was kinda hilarious.

"Uh," Shire looks at Catra, the book cover, then back to Catra. "Are you . . . okay? Because you're pretty much reading an obituary."

"Yeah, yeah, I'm laughing at how stupid this person is," Catra tries to explain. "She just surrendered herself to the Horde? And didn't expect anything bad to happen? Fuckin' idiotic, is what it is."

Shire steps forward, "You're reading about Queen Bett'i."

"Yeah," Catra says. "But, I'm right, right?"

Shire has a solemn look on her face, "It probably makes sense to you, since you're a . . . since you lived with them. But us Magicats? We've always been a bit detached from the rest of the world. Purrsia is far away from the mainland, and after the Tribe Wars we kinda scared everyone away. We didn't know anything about the Horde. We didn't think they'd be our problem."

Catra frowns, "It's still a stupid thing to do! Surrender yourself to the enemy! The enemy known as the *Evil* Horde."

"Queen Bett'i was a scholar, not a warrior," Shire tries to argue. "The Magicats were warriors who hadn't seen a war in thousands of years. She wanted to try and settle it peacefully, and try she did."

"And it was a foolish effort! A death sentence!" Catra points out. "The Horde doesn't give a shit about that, they probably knew that and saw you as an easy target! You all should have just run off into the underground in the first place!"

"Of course we should have!" Shire yells back. "But I was only six at the time so what was I supposed to do about it!?"

"I'm not saying you should have done something!" Catra yells back. "If you're agreeing with me, then why are you yelling at me!"

"Because you don't know what happened during the Invasion! You don't know how much we lost!"

"Then tell me!"

Shire calms down, taking a deep breath before she pulls up a chair next to Catra's bedside.

"After Bett'i died, C'yra was made Queen. She has spent most of her life as a warrior, gone on a few diplomatic missions, but had never actually run a country before," Shire begins. "Pair that with the fact that she was dealing with her own grief and trying to fight a war at the same time. Throw in all the talented, yet inexperienced, warriors who were itching for a chance to prove themselves to Saz. And you know what happened?"

"You lost and finally retreated," Catra guesses.

"We didn't just lose, we lost over half of our population," Shire stresses. "The technology our warriors had were on par with the Horde's, our warriors are some of the best in the world but almost all of them had never known war, and the Horde had an almost unlimited supply of troops. That, and they managed to use

the Beasts to their advantage. They didn't just kill our troops, they killed everyone who had a shred of usefulness: the mages, the healers, the engineers. They didn't play by our honor system, of glorious battle in the name of Saz. Just death and destruction.

"There's a common saying now, there's no one who made it out of the war without losing something. I lost my parents, Busto lost his sister, Az'al lost her husband and son, C'yra and Ri'ta lost their daughter-"

"They had a daughter?" Catra questions in a small voice.

"Princess Fel'cty," Shire nods her head slowly. "They never found her body. It was her death that convinced C'yra to retreat. Some think that she made the decision too late, other things that she did it too early. Either way, the damage was already done. We had lost."

Catra's silent after that. She knows how the Horde operates, and it sounded like the Invasion of Purrsia was just another standard job. She never knew anyone who had made it out of those battles on the other side personally, those who survived but lost everything. She's . . . not sure how to feel about it.

"So, I suggest that you leave the whole Horde Invasion subject alone in the future," Shire says as she stands up. "It's a touchy subject, with everyone. After all, everyone lost something in the Horde Invasion."

Catra doesn't say anything, just nods and tries to think of Shire's words. She doubts that anyone who ever came face to face with the Horde came out of it fully intact, but it wasn't just their victims. It was the soldiers too. Just look at her. She lost her best friend to the other side, was probably taken away during the Horde Invasion so she lost her history, almost lost her life.

A lot of Magicats probably went through something like that, in or out of the Horde. Losing family, friends, body parts,

home, or their life.

Catra shifts through the rest of the stack of books. They’re all history books, but none about recent history. She wonders if it would be suspicious if she asked for books about the Horde Invasion.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, actually, the next chapter is finished but we'll see if I remember to post it. See y'all next time!

and you are the dreamer and we are the dream i could write it better than i ever felt it so hum hallelujah just off the key of reason

Chapter Summary

Catra is off of bed rest and is given a minor existential crisis.

Chapter Notes

So, I was in a weird mood when I posted the chapter Monday so I'm gonna try to be more coherent.

First off, I wanna quickly mention why I gave the Magicats deities it's because . . . I kinda just like mythology and worldbuilding and they developed away from mainland Etheria. I just thought it would be cool. The three deities are based off of Nordic mythology, you see a lot of deities with war & death/thunder/life trinities, like Odin/Thor/Frey. So . . . that's just that.

(Once this fic is done I'm gonna have a complete anthropological study of Magicats done, just you wait)

Uh, a life update, I guess? I'm still going to school and working, plus I have a big presentation for a professional development conference going on, and my friends want me to write a dnd campaign, so we'll see how consistent my updates with this will be (haha jokes on myself, the updates will never be consistent).

But, anyway, here's another chapter! I hope you enjoy!

Also, chapter title is from Hum Hallelujah by Fall Out Boy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The following weeks were boring, to say the least.

Catra was given a steady stream of books from Shire, about Magicat history and folk tales. Catra's favorites were stories that weren't real, but about strange adventures that happened in far-off worlds (the Horde didn't have fiction books, they would rather stomp out any creativity than have it potentially come into conflict with their doctrine), and surprisingly, the books about the stars.

There were once so many stars in the sky that you could make pictures out of them, and those pictures had stories come along with. Some books about stars talked about visiting them one day, potentially. It was unbelievable, but Catra felt like she was being let in on a secret. No one outside of Half Moon has ever mentioned stars before, so it must be unknown.

She also talked with Busto and Shire. Catra's still not Busto's biggest fan, but they easily throw barbs at each other and neither of them seem too offended about it. She talks more with Shire, just about whatever Shire's working on with Ri'ta or in the infirmary because it was better to talk to another living being rather than read words on a page. Sometimes, she'd play one of N'yan's games if she was in the right mood. She'd been playing with her more often, just because N'yan was very happy whenever Catra agreed and it was infectious.

The only people Catra didn't see were C'yra and Ri'ta. Catra doesn't mind, they're both Queens and probably have duties aside from keeping an eye on the Horde soldier (if anything, that was what Busto was doing). If they wanted to keep their distance after taking so much interest in her that first week, it's fine with Catra. It's fine. Really.

Eventually, Catra gets better. The scratches scar over and the wounds seal up. Shire said that her ribs are okay, and Catra's allowed to move around the infirmary so her muscles don't atrophy.

("I don't understand, why would her muscles win a trophy?" N'yan questions one day.)

But now, the cast on her leg is coming off and she's finally free.

"Honestly," Shire grunts as she breaks the cast open. "You really need to go through some physical therapy, you haven't put weight on this foot for almost two cycles."

"And how long will that take?" Catra questions, excited to finally be fully free of everything.

"Longer than my patience will last, but you really need it," Shire finally breaks it open, and the cool air of the infirmary hits Catra's leg. Catra wiggles her toes and leans forward to scratch an itch that had been trapped under there for ages. Shire tosses the halves of the cast on the ground, "There, how does it feel?"

"Nice," Catra grins. She swings herself and puts her feet on the ground. She tries to stand up but her leg protests any weight on it. Catra unceremoniously falls back onto the bed with a yelp.

"Yep, you need physical therapy," Shire announces as she walks over to the corner and grabs a crutch. She hands them to Catra, "Use this while you're recovering, so you don't put all your weight on your leg. Move it when you're moving your bad leg."

Catra takes them reluctantly. She's gotten cabin fever and she's ready to get out, with a crutch jammed up her armpit she's able to stand up straight. She uses them to move around the infirmary just to get used to them.

"Alright, can I leave now?" Catra asks once she's gotten the hang of it.

"Leave like, leave the infirmary to go to Half Moon or leave as in 'im leaving and never seeing any of you again'?" Shire checks.

"Well, what am I gonna do if I meet a beast? Bludgeon it with a crutch?" Catra snarks. "The only place to go is Half Moon, I guess. Let's just get out of here, I'm sick of these walls."

"You're going to be seeing more of them, since I have not released you yet," Shire points. "But, a walk would do you good. Where do you want to go?"

Catra takes a moment to think. For now, she wants to stay away from crowded areas with everyone, like the marketplace, cafeteria and the arena. Maybe the library, but what is she gonna do, read more books?

"Somewhere quiet and where I haven't been before," Catra says.

Shire thinks, "Alright, I think I know where. Follow me."

They leave the infirmary, and now that Catra can walk around on her own she actually pays attention to where they're going. The halls and tunnels of Half Moon are still winding, and frankly, confusing, but Catra's noticed signs that point to the major locations. Shire seems to be following the ones that direct them to the shrines.

Shire leads Catra into a dark, circular cavern. There are dim lights floating on the ceiling, just bright enough that you could see your own two feet but still be atmospherically dark.

On the walls of the cavern are statues, old and broken. Some are missing heads or arms; some have just been so worn it's hard to make out a face. They all seem to be of warriors, Magicats in the middle of a battle with strange swords pointed at their imaginary opponents. At the foot of the statues are a variety of items, some are bowls of food, weapons, or shiny trinkets, but there doesn't seem to be too many of them.

Parallel to the entrance is the largest statue of them all, standing on a pedestal that's about as tall as N'yan. The figure standing on the pedestal isn't a Magicat or any other recognizable

race, but is vaguely humanoid. It has legs and arms and a head, but nothing that stands out. Behind its head is a pointy halo made of gold, and it's holding a golden sword straight up to the ceiling.

There's no one in the shrine except for the oldest person Catra has ever seen, sitting on a small stool next to the largest statue and smoking a pipe. He appears to be almost spherical, with very shaggy grey fur covered by a black robe. A long fluffy beard flops over his knees. His face is squished and mostly covered by thick eyebrows, Catra only knows where his eyes are because he has a small pair of glasses perched on his nose.

He looks up, right at Catra and says, "Catra, I was wondering when you'd visit."

"Uh," Catra wanted to run, what does this old ass cat know her name, but she decides to try to be on her best behavior for once. "How . . . do you know me?"

"Ri'ta and C'yra have told me about you," the old cat stands up, though he doesn't really gain any height. He grabs a smooth cane and barely leans on it when he walks over. He seems older than Gus, but is ten times more agile. He puts his pipe in the corner of his mouth and holds out his hand, "I am Deut'ron of Salem, it's a pleasure to make your acquaintance."

Catra gives Shire a confused glance before shaking his hand, "Uh, yeah, me too, I guess."

Deut'ron nods and takes the pipe out of his mouth, "Also Shire, a pleasure to see you again. And Catra, you are certainly doing better. Of course, the last update I got was that you were still bedridden."

"Wait," Catra decides to throw her best behavior out the window. "Who are you?"

"Deut'ron of Salem," Deut'ron unhelpfully repeats.

“Deut’ron is the Head Cleric of Saz, here in Half Moon,” Shire politely explains. "As the oldest living Magicat, he also provides counsel to the Queens.”

Catra looks Deut’ron over. He certainly appears to be the oldest.

“Yes, it’s quite an interesting story, the one about how I became the Head Cleric,” Deut’ron continues. “Of course, I was a simple servant of Saz. I was just the mortician at the Temple.”

“What?” Catra’s not really sure what’s going on anymore. She figures that they just let Deut’ron blow off some steam and then she and Shire can be on their way.

“Yes, I was a mortician,” Deut’ron continues. “All Three Stars are associated with death, but since Lyses deals with reincarnation he got the ‘life’ aspect and Saz got stuck with, of course, the whole ‘death’ business, even though it’s much harder to get into their realm. So, no matter how someone died they’d be taken to the Temple for me to prepare for entering the next life and of course, burial.”

“I didn’t really need to know all that but cool,” Catra mumbles. Shire elbows her in the side. Catra hisses, she guesses now that she’s up and about Shire can finally unleash all the physical rage she must’ve been storing up over the past seven weeks.

“During the Horde Invasion, I was very busy and was kept in the Temple all night and all day, very sad really,” Deut’ron meanders about the point of this conversation. “But all the other Clerics, of course, being followers of Saz were more capable warriors than I. I pretty much got saddled with the job no one wants but I didn’t mind, it was important work, of course. They all went to battle alongside other warriors and sadly, perished in combat. Of course, as you went down the line eventually all that was left was me. But, I’d like to think that I do a decent job.”

"You certainly do, sir," Shire says kindly.

"Thank-you, Shire," Deut'ron nods. "Now Catra, how is Half Moon treating you?"

Shire glares at her and Catra mumbles, "I haven't seen a lot of it."

"Yes, of course that's understandable," Deut'ron agrees. "So, this being your first time in the shrine I should, of course, show you around."

Catra glances around the room, "I . . . think I've seen it all."

Shire frowns at Catra, but Deut'ron just laughs, "Aye, a fair assessment. You must have questions though."

"I suppose," Catra mutters. "What is the big statue supposed to be of?"

"Why, that is the Great Star, Saz himself," Deut'ron explains. "There's one of Lyses over in his Shrine area, of course, but this is ours."

"Is . . . that what he actually looks like?" Catra checks.

"I don't know," Deut'ron shrugs. "I've never seen himself myself, to be honest. I've been far fonder of Lyses' realm the past few times I've been through."

"Through . . . what?" Catra's not entirely sure that Deut'ron knows what he's talking about. That, or he's not all there.

"Well, through death of course," Deut'ron says like it should be obvious.

Yep, he's not all there. He's missing that one final screw. He's not in the pink. He hasn't got a clue. One card short of a full

deck. Not quite the shilling. One wave short of a shipwreck. He's knitting with only one needle. Driving with only three wheels.

"This is my last life, and it certainly has been an interesting one," Deut'ron continues normally.

"Eight times around is quite the feat," Shire provides.

Catra decides to not say anything, or Shire might shiv her right there and then. Deut'ron seems to notice, "You don't believe, do you? In Lyses or any of the Three Stars?"

"Nope," Catra plainly says.

"That's understandable, of course," Deut'ron says. Catra lets out a sigh, she thought he might push it on her. He continues, "Faith in Saz isn't quite popular these days, I'm afraid. They're not as much of a comforting spirit as they once were."

"What do you mean?" Catra asks. From her understanding, everyone's faith in Saz pretty much got them killed because they promised 'eternal glory' or whatever.

"Well, isn't that why we believe?" Deut'ron counters. "Because our faith comforts us in our times of need. When we have fallen down or need aid, we are able to ask Saz and Lyses for aid. We don't have to fear the inky blackness of what lies beyond death, because we have been told what is there and it is good. It doesn't even have to be in the Three Stars or any other deity, it could be in your friends that will be there for you, faith that the sun will rise and bring a new day, faith in anything. Faith is comfort. Comfort is faith. And to some, faith in Saz no longer provides that comfort."

"But it's comforting to you?" Catra asks.

"I am comfortable with death," Deut'ron explains. "Therefore, I am comfortable with Saz."

Faith is comfort. Who does Catra have faith in these days? She has faith in Scorpia, that when she finally returns to the mainland Scorpia will come to her side. That gives her comfort, the thought of seeing Scorpia again. She has faith in herself, that she'll be able to get back to the mainland to take down the Horde and She-Ra, but right now . . . it isn't comforting her.

What the fuck is wrong with her.

"That's why I believe everyone needs faith in something," Deut'ron picks up. "Faith is comfort, and with comfort we feel safe and secure."

"Uh, yeah," Catra didn't come here to be given an existential crisis. She doesn't even know why she's here.

"Well, I won't keep you two here for long," Deut'ron heads back to his little stool, leaving everything at that. "Stop by if you ever have any questions or want advice."

"Uh, okay," Catra says, starting to move backwards towards the door.

Shire seems to be following suit, "Thank-you for your time, Deut'ron."

"Of course," Deut'ron nods as he sits down on his stool, but Catra and Shire are already out of the Shrine Room.

"Hey," Catra says as they walk down the hall. "What the fuck."

"I didn't think we'd be the only ones there," Shire mutters. "I just wanted to stop in. I didn't think we'd be alone with Deut'ron. That was weird."

"It was really fucking weird," Catra agrees.

"Sorry, I rarely go there. Deut'ron is wise . . . he just talks a lot," Shire says. "A whole lot."

"Yeah, he does."

"I was gonna show you Lyses' Shrine . . . there's a lot of plants and it's very light, so there should be more people there. What do you think?"

"I . . . don't think I want to hear more about the deities . . . or potentially have another existential crisis."

"Oh yeah, Deut'ron is good at that. Then . . . you wanna go to the Watering Hole?"

"What's that?"

"It's where we pipe our water from. There's always a couple guards there because when we first found it, people used to swim in it and . . . relieve themselves in it."

"Aw, that's fucking gross, I don't want to think about that!"

"It's clean now!"

"Let's just go to the library."

"Sounds good to me."

Chapter End Notes

So, apparently I really enjoy validation because I got like four comments and I finished the next three chapters of this fic so . . . if you really like this fic and want me to continue, please leave a comment!

he was born in the summer of his 27th year coming home to place he'd never been before he left yesterday behind him you might say he was born again you might say he found a key for every door

Chapter Summary

Catra leaves Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone! Thank-you for all of the kind comments, I'm going to try and get better at responding to all of them! I'm glad a lot of you like my world-building, and a lot of it is probably influenced by my own love for mythology . . . and the anthropology classes I'm taking even though I'm an engineering student. Like I said, you'll all have a complete anthropological study by the end of it.

(And if you're a student, I'd honestly recommend taking some type of anthropology course as a humanities credit or something because it really makes you think about other cultures, your own views, and how you interact with the world, only if it somehow fits into your college course tho, college is expensive y'all)

Ahem. Anthropology propaganda asides, I'm probably going to stop doing the every other day updates, just so I can spread out the remaining chapters I have in case my life gets way too busy over the next couple weeks. I was mainly doing to updates this week because of the release of She-Ra S5, because i knew there would be more traffic on Ao3.

Speaking of She-Ra S5, the number of chapters if probably going to changing (it will no longer be the perfect number) as

I want to include some elements of S5 in what may be a sequel? I don't know, I should probably finish this fic first.

Alright, enough of my rambling, I hope you enjoy the chapter!

Chapter Title: Rock Mountain High, John Denver

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Today is the day. Shire had cleared Catra and she could finally leave Half Moon. Good riddance, is what Catra has to say (she does her best to not think about Shire or Busto or N'yan, even C'yra and Ri'ta. Catra had a job to do).

Shire had brought her a bag with some necessities, including a first aid kit and a lunch from Jen'dots. Shire then left for her lesson with Ri'ta, leaving Catra alone to look over her bag and wonder what else she could possibly need.

"So, you're really leaving."

C'yra's standing in the doorway of the infirmary, a green bundle tucked under her arm, covering something on the end of a long pole.

"Yeah, sad to see me go?" Catra says with a roll of her eyes.

"Yes," Queen C'yra replies. "Half Moon will be missing out on having a great Magicat in its midst."

"Yeah right," Catra scoffs. "Don't waste my time with that bullshit. If you've come to say goodbye, just say it, so I can get out of your hair."

Catra looks up at C'yra, and she seems . . . sad, somehow. Her mouth is a straight line and her ears are laxed, so it must be something in that one eye of hers. Catra stops paying

attention as C'yra speaks again, imparting yet another piece of that good old Magicat wisdom.

"Magicats rarely say goodbye," C'yra begins. "We know, that for the most part, we'll see each other someday, somehow. Even if we die, we could enter Lyses' realm and be back out here soon enough. It's only after the death of a great warrior or someone's ninth death that we really care to say goodbye. So this, is not a goodbye."

"I think it is," Catra counters. To avoid any more lessons or sad looks, Catra distracts, "So, what's in the bindle? Sending me off in style?"

"Yes," C'yra unwraps it to reveal the sharp end of a spear. She sets the green fabric to the side and holds the spear up straight, "The island is very dangerous, but I think you know that. I want to make sure you're armed, so you have a fighting chance."

Catra wants to refuse the weapon out of stubbornness, but knows that she'll need it. She takes it from C'yra's hands and feels it for herself. The spearhead is made out of a dark stone and comes to a perfect point. The pole is of a light wood, with subtle but intricate carvings along it. Catra runs her hands along it just to feel them.

"And," C'yra grabs the green cloth, unfurling it fully to reveal a hood and cloak. "Our hunters and scouts wear these to disguise themselves while in the woods. I feel as though you could do with some camouflage as well."

Catra holds onto the spear and takes the cloak with her free hand. The fabric is light enough to not get hot during the day, but it is enough to keep her warm at night. It's surprisingly soft on the inside, with rougher material on the outside.

These two gifts are actually quite useful . . . but gifts always come with a price. Catra studies C'yra, trying to find her

angle, but she's still closed off. Catra asks, "Why are you giving me these?"

"Usually we say 'thank-you' after receiving a gift," C'yra says, the corner of her lips twitching upwards. "But I gave you these because you need them more than I do, and though you may not think so, I don't want you to die out there."

Catra squints her eyes. C'yra may actually be genuine with that sentiment, but Catra knows better than to believe her, "Well, you won't be able to cash in whatever favors you want from me, because I'll be gone."

"The only favor I want is for you to take care of yourself and do your best to not die out there," C'yra reiterates. She places a hand on Catra's shoulder, "Good luck out there, Catra."

Catra stares at C'yra's hand until she removes it. Catra figures that if C'yra is giving her the spear and the cloak with no strings attached, she may as well be kind back because that's the thing you're supposed to do when sucking up to someone, "Yeah. Thanks."

C'yra gives Catra another one of those sad looks before leaving the room.

Catra looks at the gifts and tries to figure out if anything C'yra had said was true, or if she was lying just like Shadow Weaver. Either way, Catra didn't want to stay to find out. If she was lying, then Catra would have to face the punishments she always had to, but now's the chance to get out. If C'yra isn't . . . then Catra's not quite sure what that means for the both of them.

Catra puts on the hood and shifts into planning mode. Get out into the island, find where she was cast away, and wait for the Horde to return.

Catra leaves through the gates of Half Moon, hidden in the trees and rocky outcropping of the cave. Guards dressed in

red stand at the gates, and watch her as she leaves. They don’t stop her, even though she has C’yra’s gifts. They just close the gate with a thud once she’s through.

She steps into the forest again, keeping the hood and cloak close around her with a silver brooch C'yra must've left behind. Catra's not sure if she meant to, but Catra needs it more right now just to keep the cloak closed.

The forest is just like before: dense and dark, even in the day sun. As Catra slowly stalks through the under-brush she realizes one key fact: she actually has no idea where Half Moon is in comparison to where she was attacked by a beast. She has no bearing on the island, whatsoever.

Catra grits her teeth, blames the queens in her head, and decides to explore around. Beast Island is an island, it's not endless. She should be able to find the shore and make her way around to the spot she was dropped off. She's sure that she'll be able to recognize the exact spot, because the beaches on this Saz-forsaken island couldn't all look the same.

Shit. She's using Magicat speak. She has to get far away from Half Moon and fast.

She decides to travel in one straight line towards the setting sun, and figures that she'll run into a beach eventually. She travels for about half a day with no sign of any beaches or beasts. It's probably an couple hours into the afternoon, with the sun starting to tilt down towards the water, when she spots a break in the forests. But it's not a beach . . . .

It's a village.

Catra first finds a broken path, slabs of flat rock that has been conquered by moss and grass to be reclaimed by nature. She follows it into a clearing, the trees slowing disappearing as she spots the outlines of houses. Of course, they aren't houses anymore.

Everything in the village is wrecked, completely ruined. The walls caved in, thatch roofs burned off, homes knocked over, supplies scattered and trampled over. It was a Horde job. Something too familiar to her.

She slowly walks through, observing the total damage. The village is unlivable, and it shouldn't surprise her when all of the Magicats are living underground. She walks through some of the houses, seeing broken plates and decorations left behind in a hurry when the Horde invaded. She can't stop herself from wondering if Shire's family lived here, or Busto's. Catra has to step out of the house after that.

She follows the path, wandering between houses and peering inside at the ruin. She feels sick to her stomach, but she doesn't know why. She's never felt like this before, when she was ordered to ransack a village in Alliance territory (though it was filled with normal people who had never done anything but fear the Horde) she did it without second thought. Now, she just wants to throw up.

Catra almost trips on a stuffed doll as she meanders about, and picks it up to observe the dirty clothes and torn up face. It was pretty once, but dropped in the haste to evacuate. The child probably cried all the way to Half Moon, more concerned about the fate of its lost toy than the invading Horde forces.

Catra can see a younger Shire, dropping the toy, like kids do. She can see N'yan, not even born at the time, crying as she's dragged away from the only home she ever knew. She can see a lot of faces she’s seen in Half Moon.

Catra drops the doll and the thought.

She is Catra, former second in command to Hordak. She didn't think about those that the Horde hurt, but rather about who she hadn't hurt. Adora, the Princesses, Adora. She made plans, no matter how cruel, and followed them through. Why was she getting torn up about some stupid doll?!

Catra quickly leaves the village after that.

She finds the beach soon enough; her feet having carried her while her brain was a thousand miles away. Surprise surprise, the beach looks just like the one she landed on. All beaches look the same: covered in fucking sand.

She sits down on a log at the tree line and watches as the waves crash onto the shore. For as much as she hates water, it's kind of relaxing. She watches as the sun begins to descend towards the water and realizes something: she really doesn't want to sleep out here.

The first problem is that she didn't really bring any camping supplies. The second is that even if she covers herself in a makeshift tent, a beast still could find her and gobble her up in her sleep. Thirdly she has no idea when the next Horde transport will show up. It could be days, or weeks, and she might not even be in the right spot. Finally . . . the beds at Half Moon are *really* comfortable.

As much as Catra doesn't want to rely on Half Moon, it's probably better for her to take shelter in a safe place than out in the wilderness, especially after getting mauled by her beast on her first day out here. So, she makes her way back to Half Moon. She'll just have to explore more tomorrow.

Catra gets closer to the entrance to Half Moon where guards in red uniforms stand at attention. Catra narrows her eyes as she sees a Magicat dressed in purple addressing a woman wearing a uniform similar to Busto's. Catra scowls, of course C'yra is here.

Catra figures there's nothing she can do about it, and steps out of the tree line. As she gets closer, she can see C'yra and the captain look directly at her. Catra wants to run back into the woods.

"Back so soon?" C'yra asks Catra, sounding more curious than condescending.

"Uhg, yes," Catra groans. "Figured it'd be easier to sleep here than out in the fucking wilderness where a beast could get me. Can I come in?"

A small smile graces C'yra's face, "Of course. Cpt. Cr'shanks, please open the gates."

Cr'shanks doesn't look too pleased about it, but bows with a, "As you wish, my queen."

Cr'shanks signals some guard, and the gates slowly open. Catra darts inside and C'yra meets her on the ground level.

"How was it out there?" C'yra asks.

Catra decides not to mention the ruined village and stays aloof, "Boring. The beasts must've gouged themselves on some horses or something."

"Well, that's good then," C'yra insists. She looks down into the caves of Half Moon, "We should probably get you a room for the night, since there's no need for you to stay in the infirmary."

"Sounds good, as long as I can sleep," Catra says as she stretches and tries to suppress a yawn. She must be more tired than she thought, or the idea of a bed just sounds really nice.

"And, I believe the kitchens are still open if you're hungry."

"Okay, cool," Catra mumbles as her stomach grumbles. Apparently, she was also hungrier than she thought.

C'yra heard her stomach and softly chuckles, "So, what is it first? Food or sleep?"

"Just, show me where I'll sleep and I'll get food on my own," Catra growls.

"Alright," C'yra says putting her hands up, and together they enter Half Moon.

Getting a bed to sleep on is more convoluted than Catra thought. They head to a part of Half Moon filled with offices, but at this late hour most of them are empty. C'yra quickly explains that this is where most government functions take place and where her own office is. She has to find what apartment is empty and fill out a sheet saying that it's taken. Catra almost falls asleep as she waits for C'yra to finish the paperwork.

But, Catra gets a bed soon enough. C'yra shows her to a small one-bedroom apartment that has a bathroom and a small living area. C'yra says, "It's not exactly the lap of luxury, but it's better than the infirmary."

Catra carefully looks around the room. It's honestly the nicest place she's been given to sleep in. It's bigger and homier than the room she got in the Horde from her Force Captain promotion. She shrugs, "It'll do."

C'yra hands her a key, "I'd head down to the kitchens before they close before taking a good look around but . . . I'm glad you're safe after your trip to the surface, Catra. I truly am."

"I'm going to head back up tomorrow," Catra makes it clear. This isn't her giving in to Half Moon and the Magicats. She just wants to survive another night (and on a decent bed), "I'm not done exploring."

C'yra nods, "Understood. Then . . . sleep well, kitten."

Catra watches C'yra leave, the door slowly closes behind her. Catra stands in the middle of the dark room, debating whether to go and get food or go sleep. C'yra's last words wash over her. She trudges over to the bed, flops onto it and falls asleep instantly.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all, I'll try to remember to update the next chapter next Friday. I appreciate all your comments and the validation for the amount of world-building I've done, so consider leaving another comment!

I guess, also, you can follow me on Twitter? I probably won't talk about this, I mainly just yell about Muppets and Ghost Adventures, so if you like either of those things, follow me @Sniperdoodle12

Finally, I hope you all have a good day and stay safe!

so she sighs and she burns with desperation learns to cry over love of constellations

Chapter Summary

Catra goes to the library.

Chapter Notes

Title: Cassiopeia, Sarah Barellis
Alt title: i'm the map, i'm the map, i'm the map, i'm the map!

Hey, I remembered to update this! I actually have enough written to update every Friday up to the first week of July for right now, so hopefully I remember to do that . . .

But, not much else is new on my end. I hope you enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Alright, done," Shire finishes setting Catra's ankle. "I don't think you learned your lesson from the first time you got your ass kicked by the island."

"At least I wasn't mauled this time," Catra huffs as she warily moves her ankle, stiff now because of the splint. At least it would help the sprain heal faster.

She had fallen on another root, again, while trying to regain her bearings. Every fucking tree or beach on this island looks the same. Thankfully, she was able to hobble back to Half Moon just in time for Shire to fix her up, though she was getting sick of this reliance on Half Moon.

Shire places a pair of crutches against the bed, "These are for you if you want to go anywhere."

"I'm not stuck in the infirmary?" Catra checks.

"Well, you're not on bed rest, so no," Shire explains. "But, I'm running late so I better-"

"Oh, that's why you haven't shown up," Ri'ta interrupts as she enters the infirmary.

"Yeah," Shire sighs. "Sorry I should've sent a message-"

"No need to apologize for doing your job," Ri'ta insists. She looks at Catra, "Are you alright? What happened?"

"Twisted my ankle on a root," Catra sighs as she lifts up her bad foot. "I keep on getting lost on this stupid island."

"Yes, the forests and beasts have always made the island difficult to navigate," Ri'ta agrees. "But, that's why the Magicats became brilliant map-makes, recording just about every corner of the island for ease of travel."

"Wait," Catra pauses. "You all have maps of this place and no one told me?"

"Well, you never asked," Ri'ta points out. "Come with Shire and I to the library, I'll pull some out for you to look over."

Catra grabs the crutches and gets up, finally excited for some progress, "Alright, take me to them."

The library is pretty much the same as the last time Catra was here. Old scholars muddling about and reading dusty old books, while sending Catra concerned glances every so often. Ri'ta led her to the center of the library, where the raised floor designating the 'magic area' is.

"You can take a seat Catra, I'll be right back," Ri'ta says, before she heads off for another part of the library.

Catra falls down into a chair and waits. Shire is preparing her own books for her lesson, so Catra is stuck looking at the magic set-up.

There are multiple podiums for books around a central rune, which has nine, empty white marble pedestals, equidistant from each other. The tables are on the outer edge of the raised floor, some covered with books that have been left behind by some other mage, and others filled with stacks of paper notes. One table is filled with random objects, and another is filled with vials of glowing liquids.

Catra didn't get a chance to look around or ask questions the last time she was here, and she's not sure if she wants to bother Ri'ta or Shire about the random shit.

Ri'ta returns with an armful of tubes. She sets them on the table, doing her best to be quiet, "So, there's a map in each tube, from various time periods. I believed I grabbed the most recent one, but the Hunters might have the ones made since the Horde Invasion. Let me know if you need anymore, alright?"

"Yeah, thanks," Catra mumbles and just grabs the first tube she can reach. It opens up with a pop, and the map slowly slides out.

While Ri'ta begins her lesson with Shire, Catra begins to pour over the map. It's in very good condition, and Catra thinks that it's recent, but when she checks that date it was actually made one hundred years ago. And then, she realizes, that Purrsia is really fucking big.



The part that she's been exploring? It's just a peninsula on the island. There are smaller islands surrounding the island. Catra's not even sure she should bother calling it an island, it feels more like its own continent.

There were at least thirty different villages, two temples, and three big docks on the island. The temples are dedicated to Lyses and Saz, while the two biggest villages appear to be Full Moon and New Moon. There's no marking to Half Moon as a city, instead there are the Half Moon Caves.

Catra figures that for the Magicats to find her after being attacked by a beast, she must've been thrown onto this peninsula, since she doubts the Magicats travel far from the safety of Half Moon. That at least narrows down the beaches she could have been tossed on but, the Horde has a lot of area to dock. The next time they come back, it might not be in the same spot.

She wishes that she had attended Force Captain Orientation, or that Shadow Weaver told her about it so she could attend it. She's not sure that they would have mentioned Beast Island, but maybe there would be something about the protocol for getting rid of prisoners here.

The next map seems to be more about the topography of the island rather than locations of villages. There's a large lake at the center of Purrsia, and when she consults the map, she sees that New Moon is settled on the shores of this lake. Streams flow out from there to the sea, and it's on the highest part of the island.

Smaller islands around Purrsia have names, the one that interests Catra the most is the Isle of Ilir. A note on the side mentions that the Isle is off-limits and condemned. She wonders if it's because of the Magicat's stupid religion, or if there's actually something dangerous there.

Before she can move onto the next map, Catra looks up and sees Gus glaring at her from between the shelves. Catra glances at Ri'ta, focused on her lesson with Shire, and turns back to Gus. She sticks her tongue out at him, catches his scandalized gasps, and gets back to work.

It takes a while for Catra to figure out what this was a map of. The paper was dark blue, and it's covered in white dots with faint lines connecting them. The lines appear to make images, and each has a name. She suddenly remembers stars, the images they made and the stories they told. None of the books Shire gave her features a full map, so this must be a map of the stars that were once in the night sky. Of course, since stars aren't around anymore, this is entirely useless. Ri'ta must've grabbed it by accident.

However, Catra can't help but stare at the map in wonder, tracing over some of the pictures and imaging what they must've looked like in the sky. A brave warrior challenging a beast in combat, a sea monster bursting out of the water and attacking a

ship of sailors, two lovers holding hands . . . all stories immortalized in the stars.

They must have been pretty to look at.

Catra realizes that what she's thinking is ridiculous. When has she cared about if things are "pretty" or not? "Pretty" is not a necessity. If anything, it gets in the way. Why does she care about stars so much?

She rolls up the star map and shoves it back into the case that it came from. She sees Gus still glaring at her from across the library. It's either that he doesn't like her or how she's treating the map, or both. Catra doesn't really care.

She's about to move onto the next map when Ri'ta interrupts, "So, are you able to find what you're looking for?"

Catra glares up at her, "Aren't you supposed to be having your lesson with Shire?"

Ri'ta glances behind her, and Shire is studying a book on a lectern, "She's looking over a spell right now. I just wanted to check in with you. So, how's it going?"

"Fine," Catra mumbles. "The island's really big."

"That it is," Ri'ta chuckles. "It takes three days by foot to travel from the tip of the Claw Mark Peninsula to the northmost part of the island. I don't think the hunting patrols ever go beyond the ruins of Waning Moon, and that's a half day from the entrances to the caves."

"Did you have to walk everywhere by foot before the Invasion too?" Catra asks.

"No, but most of the vehicles got wrecked during the Invasion. We have some of the leftover ones in the Caves for an emergency," Ri'ta explains. "But, before the Invasion we didn't necessarily mind the walk. Lyses taught us to enjoy nature,

appreciate it, and take our time. The beasts were not as manic before the Invasion and we were able to walk through the forest without fear."

"Wait so the beasts weren't as dangerous?" Catra questions.

"They were dangerous, but they were more manageable," Ri'ta sighs. "Something the Horde did made them ten times worse. But, don't worry about why too much. It's more important to focus on just keeping yourself safe."

"Hey Ri'ta," Shire calls out, but quiet enough for the library. "I think I'm ready to try this spell."

"Aw well, back to work," Ri'ta says, and she joins Shire on the raised floor once again.

Catra turns back to the maps, particularly the one that marked all of the Magicat settlements. She looks at the different docks, one position on the east, south and west side of the island. All the beaches may be the same, but maybe there's something at the docks that could help her get off the island.

Hopefully, they're not too far away.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading. The next few chapters are going to be considerably longer so you all have that to look forward to. Leave a comment to let me know your thoughts about the story or the world-building! I hope you all have a good day and stay safe out there!

each day i learn just a little bit more i don't know why but i do know what for if we're all going somewhere let's get there soon

Chapter Summary

Catra spends a day in Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

It's been . . . a week. For my personal life and the real world. I hope you all are staying safe and taking care of yourselves during this time.

However, I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra has spent the last week spending equal time exploring the island and resting at Half Moon.

Her original plan to scout out the docks didn't work. She spent a day traveling to a village once known as Blue Moon in the Claw Mark Peninsula, but the dock was destroyed and there was no boat in sight. Since, she has spent every day traveling to different beaches to see if she could find a Horde vessel. Not even a blip on the horizon.

Of course, today was different.

While traveling to a small beach, Catra was so absorbed in her shitty hand-drawn map that she almost ran into a beast.

Well, correction. She did run into a beast. At least it was just a baby.

The beast is a quarter of the size she had gotten wrecked by. Its fur is pink, but it has a large mane that covers its eyes. Now that she knows what she's up against, Catra was able to

dispose of the beast by stabbing her spear in between its ribs . . . but it put up a fight.

Catra stumbles into the infirmary, clutching the side of her stomach. It's early enough in the day that Shire isn't at her lesson with Ri'ta. She gasps as Catra hobbles in, "A little help here?"

"Get on the bed," Shire instructs as she grabs a healing kit and her spell book. Catra flops down on a bed and she asks, "What happened?"

"Baby beast got my side before I could kill it," Catra grunts. She removes her arm, and it's covered her own blood.

Shire helps Catra get her shirt off so she can look at the scratches better. With just a quick look, Shire observes, "Thankfully, they're not that deep. I just have to clean them and bandage them, but . . . I could heal this up faster. I've finally mastered a spell that coul-"

"NO!" Catra pushes away from Shire as soon as magic is mentioned, scrambling up the bed so her back is against the headboard. Shire raises both of her hands in the air, shocked at Catra's reaction. She realizes she must look feral, and scoots back down the bed, "I've . . . I've had some bad experiences with magic."

"I see," Shire comments. "Then, it'll just take time and medicine. It'll scar over in the next couple days."

Shire gets to work, cleaning off Catra's wounds and bandaging them up. Once done, she moves onto something else, managing to read a book as she sorts through the medicine bottles. Catra knows that this is usually her "good to go", but she has lingering questions in her brain.

"When I first arrived . . ." Catra begins. Shire looks up from her book and she continues, "Did you use magic on me?"

"Well, I tried some minor healing spells while you were still unconscious," Shire admits. "But you had a bad reaction to them, subconsciously. Ri'ta suggested that I don't use magic on you. Makes sense now, I suppose."

"Sure you didn't just screw up a spell?" Catra checks, embarrassed to find that she showed weakness while she was out cold.

"Ri'ta was with me at the time, and I have those spells perfected," Shire explains. "I don't use any spells on patients that I don't completely understand and have practiced. I don't want to accidentally hurt them. I'm supposed to be a healer, y'know?"

Catra nods, but she doesn't really know. All the magic she knew growing up was only meant to hurt. Meant to terrify. Meant to torture. Meant to kill. It was almost heretical to think that magic could be used for good, and for someone to take enough care about the application of their magic is almost as absurd.

"Can I ask a question now?" Shire asks.

"That was one," Catra says with a smirk, the snarkiness giving her some vigor.

"You know that's not what I meant."

"Yeah, I know. Go ahead, I guess."

"So . . . what happened?" Shire begins. "With your 'bad experience' with magic."

Okay, back to square one. Catra pulls her knees up to her chest in a hug, despite the bandages pulling at her fur, "My childhood fucking sucked because the woman who looked after me was a fucking bitch."

"Oh, that's . . . pretty bad," Shire admits.

"Yeah," Catra huffs.

"Sorry," Shire adds.

Catra grumbles against her knees, "Nothing you can do about it, other than the fact that the bitch is still alive."

"I can't do anything about that, I took an oath to do no harm," Shire insists. "I'm sorry that I brought it up. I should've left it alone, you looked rattled enough."

"Nah, it's not really a secret that the Horde's fucked up," Catra relaxes. She stretches her legs out and stands up, putting her shirt on. She glances over at Shire before leaving, "Thanks for uh . . . healing me and uh . . . not using magic."

Shire stares at her, "Are you feeling alright? You actually thanked me."

"I thought that was the nice thing to do," Catra hisses.

"It is. I just didn't expect it from you."

"Fuck off."

"That's better," Shire laughs. "Also, you're not on bed rest, but as your cleric I'd suggest not trying to go back out onto the surface today."

"Wasn't going too," Catra huffs. "I'll see you around."

"Hopefully not in here!"

Catra rolls her eyes as she exits the infirmary. Her stomach grumbles, which means it's probably close to lunchtime. She hates being in the cafeteria, with everyone's eyes on her making her feel like a monster, so Jen'dots gives her a packed lunch to eat in her small room.

She begins to make her way to the cafeteria when she hears a strange buzzing sound.

"Tally ho, Catra! I thought I saw you enter Half Moon!" Busto says as he quickly walks up to her. "Your day of adventure seems to have been cut short."

"Yeah, a tiny beast scratched me," Catra rubbed at her side.

Over the weeks she's been at Half Moon, Catra has decided that Busto is tolerable, but only just. She tends to just let him fill the air, and she'll throw in a few barbs when needed.

"Are you headed to the cafeteria?"

"Yeah."

"Perfect! We can have lunch together!"

Catra stares at him for a second, "What do you mean?"

"I am headed to the cafeteria as well," Busto says slowly. "We will be eating lunch at the same time. Therefore, we should sit together. Y'know, I've never seen you in there before. You do eat, right?"

"Of course I do!" Catra says. "I just . . . usually eat in my room."

"That sounds lonely."

It is, but it's better than being gawked or glared at.

Why does Busto have this ability to be annoying 90% of the time, but thoughtfully observant the other 10%?

"So, you should eat with me!" Busto loudly proclaims.

"What if I say no?"

"I'll annoy you until you say yes."

"Uhg, fuh-ine."

"Wonderful! Let's go!" Busto picks up the pace, but Catra sulks a few steps behind him to prove a point.

As soon as she enters the cafeteria, she feels all eyes on her. She's not wearing her Horde clothes anymore, they got ruined in the beast attack, but the Magicats apparently just know that she's not one of them.

People watch her as she and Busto get in line, but Busto takes it in stride. He says hello to everyone they pass, and they seem to light up a bit.

Once in line, over the noise in the cafeteria, Catra mumbles, "Y'know they're staring at me, right? You don't have to make a fool of yourself."

Busto looks at her thoughtfully, "I'm just being friendly. Half Moon is quite a close-knit community. That happens when you've all been through a traumatic event. We all know each other. You're the first new face in years that's not a kit. They're just curious."

"Not because I was with the Horde?" Catra checks.

"Maybe you just need to open yourself up a bit," Busto suggests, ignoring the question. "You always seem wound up. If you start to say hello or wave to people, they'll start to warm up to it."

"They don't want to show kindness to a Horde soldier," Catra says.

"I thought you weren't a Horde soldier anymore. Small acts will prove that," Busto insists. "A smile, a wave, holding the door open for someone else, helping someone pick up something when they drop it. Seriously, would it kill you to lighten up every once and awhile?"

Catra glares at him, "Yes."

Busto rolls his eyes. He doesn't get to retort because they reach the service area and are given their food.

He leads Catra to the back of the cafeteria, to an empty table where they won't draw much attention. He could have stopped at any of the tables filled with soldiers in red uniforms, so Catra appreciates the small gesture.

Huh. So that's what he's talking about.

"Catra, you seem to be spending more and more time in Half Moon," Busto begins as Catra digs into her food.

"No, I'm not," Catra says, despite her mouth being full of food.

"Keep telling yourself that," Busto rolls his eyes again. "But the proof is in the catnip. If you're spending more time here, you may as well act like it."

"But I'm not staying here."

"Alright, whatever," Busto waves her off. He begins to eat his own lunch before asking, "So, did I ever tell you about the time that I fished up a giant sea serpent from the watering hole?"

Catra hadn't, and she's sure it wasn't true, but she'd rather talk about bullshit than try to confront her own feelings. She shakes her head, and Busto launches in a passionate retelling of these events.

Busto's story time goes on until they're finished with lunch, though he's too busy talking to actually eat (or notice Catra stealing his fries). It gets to the point where he realizes he's late from training, shoves the rest of the food in his mouth, and runs out of the cafeteria with a quick goodbye.

Catra looks around and notices that the cafeteria is mostly empty. Everyone must be back at work after the lunch

break. Catra returns her tray so the staff can clear off the table and then she's off to stalk the caves of Half Moon once again.

She tries to stay in the back hallways, but today she's accidentally walked into the market. The voices to vendors and shoppers alike echo off the ceiling of the large cave.

Catra almost turns back around, but she realizes she didn't get a chance to explore the market the last time she was here, stuck in a wheelchair in all. But the crowds here might stare at her like in the cafeteria. Or . . . maybe she could try what-fucking-ever Busto was talking about.

She descends into the thick of the market, and surprisingly most Magicats don't pay attention to her. They're too busy hocking their wares, browsing items, or talking to each other. To the few that she meets gazes with she doesn't smile or wave, she just nods. They nod back and go about their day.

Well, almost all of them.

In an alleyway between two stalls, Thom is lurking. Catra freezes when she locks eyes with Thom's glare. He huffs, "What're ya lookin' at, Horde scum?"

"Nothin'," Catra hisses. She looks Thom over, "At least, nothing important."

Thom stands up straight. He's taller than Catra when he isn't slouching, but he's thin as a twig. If he tried to fight her, Catra could probably snap him in half like one. He stalks over and looks down at her, "What's that supposed to mean?"

"It doesn't mean anything," Catra feigns innocence, shrugging her shoulders. "So, don't hurt yourself thinking about it."

Thom scowls, but it quickly turns into a smirk, "You can pull my tail all you want, but what's that gonna prove? I'm a

Magicat born an' raised, and you? You're just a runt from tha Horde. I'll always be better than you."

Catra growls, and feels her claws extend from her fingertips. However, she balls her fists and stands up straight, "Well, according to the Queens I'm a Magicat, just like everyone else. If anything, they're more annoyed by you than me."

"You can't hide behind the Queens forever," Thom sneers. "They're gonna realize the mistake they made, but I won't hang around for that."

Thom turns around and slinks back into the shadows, disappearing from sight.

Catra stares down the alley for a moment, and decides to leave the market. She tries to not think about Thom's words as she walks down the winding hallways of Half Moon. Suddenly, she finds herself at the foot of the metal doors of the library, her feet having subconsciously carried her there.

She's visited the Library every day this week and she can't say she knows why. If anyone asks, she says it's for research. She pours over the many maps of Purrsia while trying to make her own copy better, but that's not quite why. No matter what she's doing, Ri'ta will make time to talk to her about what Purrsia was like before the Invasion. It's . . . nice.

Catra kinda hates that she thinks it's nice.

She pushes the heavy metal doors and walks straight to the center of the Library. The scholars have begrudgingly become used to her presence (excluding Gus) and keep their noses stuck in their books as she passes.

At the center of the room is the raised floor. Catra usually finds Ri'ta reading old books (supposedly about magic), but today she's sitting at a table with C'yra.

C’yra notices her first, “Catra, I’m surprised to see you here.”

“Actually dear, Catra’s been my companion this week,” Ri’ta reveals. “She’s been studying the maps to help her explore.”

Catra pauses by her assigned table, where all of the maps are spread out haphazardly. She scowls, “I’m not in here that much.”

“True, but I do appreciate your visits,” Ri’ta says. “Why don’t you join us for a moment? C’yra’s just avoiding paperwork.”

“She doesn’t need to know that,” C’yra sighs.

“To be fair,” Catra steps up onto the raised floor. “I hate paperwork too.”

C’yra quirks an eyebrow, “When did you have to do paperwork?”

“Back in . . . y’know,” Catra waves a hand. She doesn’t want to say it.

“Ah, I understand,” C’yra nods. “My apologizes for bringing it up. But please, pull up a chair and join us.”

Catra grabs the nearest chair and drags it across the floor. It makes a screeching sound, and there’s a chorus of “shush”. Catra grins at the queens, causing C’yra to sigh and Rita to chuckle. Catra sits down and looks at the table, there’s a few empty plates, so the two of them must have just finished lunch.

“So, how has exploring the surface been going?” C’yra begins.

“Alright,” Catra shrugs. “I ran into a beast today.”

The two queens instantly become concerned. Ri’ta asks, “Are you alright?”

"It was a baby, I only got a scratch," Catra insists. "C'yra, the spear you gave me came in handy in taking it down."

"Good" C'yra smiles. "I'm glad it's doing its job. Have you been staying safe otherwise?"

"Yeah, as long as I don't trip on any more roots," Catra says.

C'yra and Ri'ta laugh, but Ri'ta pauses to turn to her wife, "Y'know, love, that reminds me of the time we were visiting Harvest Moon and you tried to prove to me you could climb that old tree-"

"Well," C'yra stands up. "Look at the time, I should get back to paperwork. Goodbye love, and please don't repeat any embarrassing stories about me."

Ri'ta grins devilishly, "I'll try not to, love."

C'yra turns to Catra, "I'll see you around."

The Queen of the Magicats walks out of the Library with a small flourish of her cape. Catra watches Ri'ta watches her wife go, a small smile on her face. She says, "She needed to finish her paperwork. There's no better motivator than the threat of an embarrassing story."

"So," Catra faces Ri'ta and smirks, "You gonna tell me the story?"

"Not today, kitten," Ri'ta smiles as she stands up. "I have to get back to work as well. Are you going to continue working on your map?"

"I will, but I want to hear that story eventually," Catra insists.

"And you will. Just not today."

She moves to her own table but she can’t focus on work. She thinks about the people at Half Moon, and how they’ve grown on her. It’s the last thing she needs, but she may be getting attached. She’ll need to find a way off of Purrisa soon, or else she’ll never want to leave.

Or maybe that’s not a bad thing.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading! Please, if you have the time leave a comment and let me know what you think!

the boys and girls in the clique the awful names that the stick you're never gonna fit in much kid

Chapter Summary

Catra and Busto spar.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I don't have much to say on this end other than, enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Come ooooooon Catra!"

"No!"

"Come oooooooooooooooooon!"

"No!"

"Come ooooooooooooooooooooooooooooonn!"

"No!" Catra stops and turns around to glare at Busto "Now stop bothering me!"

This morning Catra awoke to Busto almost breaking her door down and he has not left her alone since.

"But you said you'd spar with me!" Busto insists.

"When have I ever said that I would spar with you?" Catra questions.

Busto grins, "Why you just said so, right now."

Catra hisses, “Fuck you.” She tries to stomp away, but Busto is just a step behind her. She growls, “Why does this matter so much?”

“I just think it would be fun,” Busto shrugs. When Catra continues to glare at him, he adds, “Listen, if you spar with me, I’ll doing anything you want.”

“Anything?”

“Anything.”

“That’s a dangerous thing to offer.”

“Well, I’m a bit of a gambler, you see.”

“If I accept,” Catra begins. “You will . . . have to come camping with me.”

Busto blinks, “That’s it?”

“Yes, because you will be coming with me to scout out Wolf Moon,” Catra says. Wolf Moon is the farthest village from Half Moon, located on the western side of Purrisa, where another major port was located. She hasn’t forgotten about leaving, she’s just gotten . . . a little distracted.

Apparently, Busto sees right through her, “You’re still trying to leave?”

Catra’s shoulders hunch up, “Maybe! But I’ll fight you if you come with me, alright!?”

“Alright, I’ll come with you!” Busto throws his hands up in the air. “We’ll need to plan a bit . . . it’s quite a journey from here to Wolf Moon, but for now . . . shall we head to the training grounds?”

“Sure.”

Busto sweeps his arm out and half-bows, letting her take the lead. She does so with her head high, marching down to the training area of Half Moon.

It's emptier than when she was here last, but it's getting closer to lunch so the soldiers must be eating instead of training. This is the first time she's actually on the floor of the training area, even when it's empty it feels warm, unlike the hollowness of the Horde simulators. She looks up at the rows of seating surrounding the area while Busto draws his saber.

"So, there will be rules so neither one of us are grievously injured," Busto says.

"That's fair," Catra shrugs as she pulls her spear off of her back. "I think Shire is getting sick of me and I don't want to test my luck."

"Smart, you don't want to get on the bad side of the only healer in Half Moon," Busto agrees. "But rules! No drawn blood, we stop at a touch. First to five wins. Understood?"

"Yeah sounds easy enough," Catra shrugs.

"Then, let's begin!" Busto announces.

The two begin to circle each other, weapons at the ready. Catra attacks first, using the reach on her spear to avoid getting hit by Busto's rapier to tap him on the ribs. Busto chuckles as he shrugs, "Alright, you're fast. One point to Catra!"

They begin to stalk each other again, and when Busto tries to attack Catra jabs him in the ribs underneath his arm. She hasn't had much practice with the spear, but she was already enjoying its reach.

"Aren't you supposed to be like, one of the best soldiers here?" Catra teases. "A Horde cadet could knock you down."

"I've just begun," Busto insists. "Let's continue, shall we?"

Before Catra even readies herself, Busto surges forward. He wraps his rapier around the end of the spear, knocking it out of Catra's hands. Disarmed, he taps her chest with the rapier in the blink of an eye. He smirks, "As you can see, I was just getting warmed up. One point to Busto."

Catra growls, "That's the only point you're going to make."

"Go ahead and pick up your weapon so we can continue," Busto says.

She looks at her hands, flexes her fingers so her claws pop out then retract, "I'm more used to using these, if you don't mind."

Busto looks at her hands, "Sure, just don't claw my eye out."

"No promises."

Catra runs up and swings at Busto, but her fingers just graze the air as he dodges. He quickly stabs with his rapier and she tries to avoid it, but it sticks to her arm. He's certainly faster than he first appeared to be. It was a good strategy, getting her to underestimate him. She wouldn't underestimate him anymore.

Busto smirks, raising his free hand and beckoning her forward. He was going to regret it.

Now that they both know what the other is capable of, this match is more drawn out. Busto avoids every single one of Catra's swipes, while she dodges his rapier strikes. Catra's about to get the upper hand when-

"What's the Horde scum doin' here?"

Catra falters just in time for Busto to touch the tip of his rapier to her shoulder, "Point three to Busto. Never let your guard down in battle, Catra."

She doesn't even have a witty response to him, she's more focused on the three red-clad Magicats that have entered the arena. She carefully backs up and grabs her spear as the three Magicats stand next to Busto.

"More like you should be payin' attention Busto," a Magicat with brown fur, the apparent ringleader, says. She ends it with shooting a glare to Catra.

"I was, in fact," Busto says. "D'nah, Catra is not with the Horde and she is welcome here in Half Moon by the *Queen's* decree. Catra and I were just sparing, and I'd like to continue you that."

D'nah looks between Catra and Busto, "You don't actually think she's all *innocent* do ya? She's been spending all her time out of Half Moon, probably trying to find a way to contact the Horde so they can finish us off."

"That's ridiculous," Catra points. "You really think that after what the Horde did to me, I'd want to go back to them?"

"You could be a spy," D'nah narrows her eyes. "That could have been a cover. Even if I believed you, why do you even want to leave?"

Catra scowls, "I've got some unfinished business starting with 'She' and ending with 'Ra'."

"What a great, convenient, bullshit excuse," D'nah says. She looks to Busto, "After all the Horde did to us, *all of us*, you're going to try and be friends with a beast?"

Catra stiffens up at the accusation.

"She's not a beast," Busto says. "She's a Magicat, just like the rest of us."

"If she's with the Horde, she's a beast," D'nah says.

"I'm *not* with the Horde," Catra repeats. "How many times do I have to say it to get it to stick? Or is it just going in one ear and out the other?"

D'nah takes a few steps forward, glaring at Catra, "Oh I'm hearin' it. I still think you're a spy, but maybe the Horde did just get rid of you. What did you do to get cast out to Beast Island? Did you betray them? Were you just too useless?"

Catra feels the anger boiling up in her, and she moves before she can even think. She lunges at D'nah, claws extended. She feels fur and skin catch in her claws as she scratches across D'nah's cheek. The Magicat soldier jumps back before Catra can attack her again, and even if she did, Busto has pulled her back and is keeping a firm hand on her shoulder.

"What the fuck!?" D'nah exclaims, touching her cheek. Catra sees the faint claw marks, but blood drips down D'nahs face and on her fingertips. D'nah growls, pulling out two daggers from her side, "You really are a rabid beast, aren't you?!"

The two other soldiers rally behind D'nah, but Catra tries to attack again. Busto puts his arm across her chest, keeping her back, "Catra, D'nah! Both of you, stand down! Catra, *please* don't attack D'nah, and D'nah you have said some-"

"What is going on here?"

Everyone freezes as General Az'al walks into the training grounds. She seems to be the only one with a level head right, walking calmly, but she has a steely gaze leveled at Catra.

Catra suddenly deflates. This reminds her too much of her days as a Horde cadet, lashing out at everyone. Catra knows what comes next for a useless Horde soldier like her: punishment.

D'nah flashes a sly grin, and puts her daggers away, "The Horde soldier attacked me."

Az’al looks at D’nah, sees the scratches, and shoots a glare at Catra. Catra feels frozen on the spot, she swears she sees inky black tentacles at the corner of her vision, can feel them wrapping around her feet and keeping her in one spot.

“General Az’al,” Busto swallows and begins, trying to talk as fast as he can. “I was just sparing with Catra when D’nah came in and began to provoke her and while I don’t agree with Catra’s response it’s obvious that neither party is solely responsible-”

“Captain Bo’ots,” Az’al says, shutting him up. “You can leave that all to the report I’d like on my desk later. You,” Az’al turns to Catra, “Come with me.”

She can’t move.

Busto looks at her with concern, but she barely registers him, “Catra? Are you alright?”

She can’t answer.

Az’al huffs, walks over and grabs her by the scruff of her neck. She starts to drag her out of the training ground, which snaps Catra back to reality. She pushes away from Az’al, “I can walk by myself!!”

As D’nah laughs in the background, Az’al motions forward, “Then walk.”

Catra begins to walk, with Az’al close at her side. They wind their way through the long tunnel caves with an unbearable silence. Her anxieties cast their long shadow again, she barely even recognizes that she’s moving forward until they end up at C’yra’s office.

Fuck, C’yra is the last person she wants to know about her actions.

Az’al has opened the door before Catra can run away, and all but pushes her into the office. C’yra is sitting down at her desk,

in the middle of working. She looks up with a confused expression as the two enter her office and asks with concern, "General Az'al. Catra. What's going on?"

"She attacked one of my soldiers," Az'al simply says, gesturing to Catra.

C'yra's eyes go wide as she turns to Catra. However, she pauses to study Catra for a second and softly asks, "Is this true?"

Catra forces herself to nod.

"I don't want you smother her," Az'al snarls, crossing her arms. "I want there to be repercussions to her actions."

"General Az'al," C'yra stands up, keeping her voice calm. "I'd like you to leave while I talk to Catra."

"C'yra, she *attacked* one of my-!" Az'al raises her voice.

"General Az'al," C'yra repeats. "Your *Queen* is asking you to leave. That's an order, not a suggestion."

Az'al stares at C'yra before spitting, "Yes, *your highness*," before leaving.

C'yra sighs and returns to her seat, "Catra, please, sit down. Let's talk."

Trembling, Catra moves to the seat across from C'yra's as she mentally prepares herself for the worse. She doesn't know what punishments are like in Half Moon, but hopefully they're nothing like the ones in the Horde. The worst part though, is she feels as if she's disappointed C'yra somehow, one of the only people here who believed in her.

"Catra," C'yra pauses to study her once again. She's brought her knees up to her chest, hugging them as she grips her arms. "Please breath. You don't have to worry. I just want to talk about what happened."

“Are, are you,” Catra takes a deep breath. “Mad at me?”

“No,” C’yra says. “I’m not mad at you.”

“O-okay,” Catra shakily says. She slowly loosens her grip on her arms. “Okay.”

“Good, let’s start from the beginning, alright?” C’yra begins. “Tell me what happened.”

Catra relays the events that just transpired: her spar with Busto and D’nahs’ arrival. She can’t look at C’yra as she concludes, “And then I attacked her.”

“Why?”

She tucks her chin behind her knees as she mumbles “She called me useless.”

D’nah had, of course, called her many other things in their short conversation, but that was really the breaking point. She’s not *useless*. She’s spent her whole life trying to prove that she’s not that.

“Ah,” C’yra begins. She remains silent for a moment, tapping her fingers on the table, “Y’know Catra, when I was your age, I would have probably responded in the same way.”

Catra looks up, “What?”

C’yra smiles, “I had quite the temper when I was younger. I blew up at lesser insults than that. I got in trouble for it, it wasn’t quite befitting a princess to be attacking her subjects for minor things.”

“Really?” Catra checks.

“Really,” C’yra confirms. “As I matured, I realized that I had to take better control of my emotions, especially when you’re

a leader. However . . . it seems that for you, it's more than just a short temper."

"I mean," Catra sighs. "I do have a temper . . . I suppose you could call it a problem but . . ." Catra suddenly feels very small. "I got . . . called useless, a lot, in the Horde."

C'yra's eyes go wide once again and she reaches across the table to put a hand on one of Catra's knees. Catra instinctively flinches away, so C'yra leans back and clears her throat, "I'm sorry. I knew the Horde was bad but . . . I guess I had no way of knowing how bad."

"Yeah well . . . it really fucking sucks," Catra mutters.

"Catra, you didn't deserve to go through all of that, but you are very strong for moving forward despite of it," C'yra says. "And if you ever need someone to talk to, I want you to know that I'll always lend an ear."

Catra studies C'yra for a second. Despite just attacking one of her subjects, C'yra was calling Cata strong and even offering her support. Catra doesn't really know what's going on.

"So," Catra glances down again. "Am I in trouble? For attacking D'nah?"

"No," C'yra simply says. Catra looks at her in shock, "I suggest that you stay away from the training ground for a while, but I'm just going to give you a warning."

"Really? Just a warning?" Catra checks.

C'yra nods, "Yes. Considering how many warnings I've given Thom for worse; I feel that your first incident only deserves a warning. Now, I understand that sometimes our emotions are so powerful we need to find an outlet for them, but please don't lash out at others, alright? If anything, you can talk to me, or your friends."

"I don't have friends," Catra points out.

"Are you sure? Because you seem to have been spending quite some time talking with Busto and Shire," C'yra points out. Catra just stares at her for a second, her brain breaking. C'yra continues, "And just so you know, I will be having a similar conversation with D'nah about bullying, she should know better. Is there anything else you'd like to talk about?"

"Uh . . . no," Catra says.

"Alright, thank-you for your time Catra," C'yra says with a smile. "Now if you'll excuse me, I must talk with General Az'al and her soldiers."

Catra and C'yra exit the office, but Catra stands in the hallway while C'yra heads back to the training grounds.

It seems like once a week she has to have some kind of eye-opening experience. Last time, it was with Busto. Before that, it was Duet'ron. Now, it's C'yra.

The Queen doesn't mean all of that, right? C'yra thinks that she's strong, that she can rely on her, that she has friends. It's not true, is it? Catra desperately wants to believe it, she never really had any support like this before, aside from Scorpia and . . . well, she's not going to think about that.

She has other things to think about.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading! If you're enjoying the story (and also constant updates) please consider leaving a comment! I really appreciate each one and I thrive on the positive feedback. Have a good day and stay safe, I'll see y'all next week!

let it go let it roll right off your shoulders don't you know the hardest part is over let it in let your clarity define you in the end we will only just remember how it feels

Chapter Summary

Catra and Busto go camping.

Chapter Notes

Title: Little Wonders, Rob Thomas

Hello! Another week, another chapter!

Uh, a couple notes. I guess? I dunno I had an 8:30 AM meeting and I am still tired.

There is a minor spoiler for S5 at the end of this chapter, I wasn't expecting to put it in there but I did. It's a very minor reference to something that's revealed so . . . just be aware if you haven't seen S5 yet.

So, just for future reference, I have chapters planned up through the beginning of August now! And I will probably continue to write, but I am transferring to a university in the fall so I will most likely, fall off the face of the Earth again. Just fyi.

Also, this used to be a weed chapter! But then I realized, that after 21 years of life, I've never done a weed! I think this turned out a lot better.

Finally, all Meet the Robinsons references are intentional. It's also the best Disney movie behind Lilo and Stitch.

Alright, enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sun filters through the leaves above Catra, speckling the overgrown, dirt path she's following. It's been years since anyone has bothered to use this path, according to Busto, which means they're outside of the hunter's usual patrol routes.

She glances up from the map, watching Busto take the lead. He sought her out shortly after yesterday's incident, saying he got the next few days off so they could travel to Wolf Moon. He was uncharacteristically cold, like his thoughts were a million miles away. He's been like that since, staying oddly quiet during their current journey.

It's fine with her. His jabbering usually annoys her but it's . . . a bit unsettling to see Busto be so quiet.

He'll talk when he wants to talk.

Right?

Catra stares at Busto's back. C'yra said that the two of them are, quite possibly, maybe, *potentially* . . . friends. And, from Catra's understanding, friends are supposed to "care" and "look out for each other". Maybe she should check in on him.

It takes her a few more minutes to work up the courage to say, "You've been quiet."

That knocks Busto out of his stupor. He stops and stands up a bit straighter, "I'm sorry, I suppose I've just been thinking."

"You didn't get . . . in trouble for defending me or anything, right?" Catra asks. She knows C'yra went to go talk to Az'al afterwards, but Catra doesn't trust the General.

"No, no," Busto waves his hands. "Not at all. General Az'al actually appreciated that I . . . didn't let the situation escalate further, as you could say. Also, Queen C'yra agreed with the report I gave General Az'al, and that was that."

“She seemed pretty pissed with C’yra when we went to talk to her, though,” Catra points out.

“Well, it's kinda hard to disagree with the Queen,” Busto suggests. “But, that’s not what’s on my mind. I’d like to say I’m sorry for yesterday.”

“What do you have to be sorry for?” Catra grumbles. “I’m the one who attacked D’nah.”

“I’m sorry because I didn’t stop it earlier, I didn’t think about the repercussions against you if someone misunderstood the nature of our spar or if someone tried to antagonize you, like what happened yesterday,” Busto says. “I tend to try and see the best in people, and I forgot that everyone else doesn’t see things as I do.”

“It’s alright,” Catra deeply sighs. “It’s good that you see the world that way. Saz knows I don’t.”

“How do you see the world?” Busto asks.

Catra takes a deep breath, “I-I don’t know. I’ve never thought about it. I guess . . . Saz, you’re really going to make me have an introspective right now, on our nice camping trip?”

Busto laughs. “It’s just you, me, the beasts, and Lyses’ beautiful nature all around us. No better time.”

“Uhg fine I guess . . . everyone has ulterior motives,” Catra says, and she doesn’t feel bad for being honest with Busto. “So, you have to protect yourself and look out for every angle.”

Busto stops to look at her, “That’s dark.”

“That’s life in the Horde,” Catra says with a shrug.

“What’s my angle?”

“You don’t have one. You’re too nice and just a weirdo.”

"Well, I'll wear that badge with pride."

"Saz, you are a weirdo."

The conversation flows like it usually does, trading barbs and playfully teasing each other. It feels . . . nice, to be able to talk with Busto like this. They continue to talk through the rest of the afternoon, up until they camp at night.

Catra knows survival techniques, it's covered in basic cadet training, but she never had to apply it. Usually she had a transport to hunker down in or a skiff to run back to the Fright Zone with. Busto makes up where she lacks, getting the two tents up quickly and starting a fire with only a few flint strikes.

"You're good at this," Catra mentions as she sits down next to the fire. As the sun starts to go down, the island is getting colder. She wraps her cloak around her as she tries to get warm.

"It's been years since I've been camping, but I try to keep my skills sharp in case I need to," Busto shrugs. "I actually really like this, facing nature on your own. My family were devout followers of Lyses, my father enjoyed camping more than I did."

Catra pulls her legs up to her chest. With the way Busto is using past tense, it's clear that his family were felled during the Horde Invasion. Even though she feels uncomfortable and the topic is macabre, Busto has a small, nostalgic, smile on his face and looks like he wants to talk about it more.

"What was your life like," Catra begins. "Before the Horde Invasion."

Busto perks up, he wasn't expecting that question from her. He clears his throat, "Well, I actually lived in Wolf Moon, with my family! I would have come camping with you even if that weren't our destination, but it makes it better.

"Wolf Moon was very nice. My mother was the manager of the docks, while my father was a gardener. I had a younger

sister who couldn't say my name, Bust'fer, so she called me Busto instead. It stuck. My father took me camping every weekend, and during the week, sometimes my mother would let me come to work with her to watch the ships leave the harbor."

Busto's eyes light up as he recalls his childhood, something that must have seemed like it was a lifetime ago. However, he stares in the fire as he concludes, "And then . . . the Horde attacked. My mother was at the docks when the Horde closed in, while my father made sure my sister and I made it to safety."

Catra watches Busto, "I've never seen your sister."

"She died of a sickness in the caves."

"Oh," Catra squeezes her legs. "I'm sorry."

"You didn't know," Busto says. "She . . . died soon after we made it to the Caves. I don't think the stress of everything helped. I didn't have anyone but . . . General Az'al was actually the one to take me in. I'm pretty sure it was because she recently lost her own son but it was nice to have someone look out for me. Make sure that I was eating right. That I didn't fall in with the wrong crowd. Believe it or not, I almost became like Thom."

"You?" Catra looks Busto over. "Despite being annoying, you're a goody two-shoes."

"Well, I do have nice shoes," Busto gestures to his signature thigh-high boots. "But yes, Thom and I were actually good friends and we started to fall together. I was lashing out at the world for being cruel. I got into fights; I stole from the market. Az'al took me aside one day and she told me that I could do better. Channel my energy into something productive. She knew I was a decent fighter and persuaded me to give the soldiers a try. She tried to do the same thing for Thom but . . . it didn't work out."

Catra watches her tail flick against the ground, “That sounds like a completely different person than the one that interacts with me.”

“Yeah,” Busto sighs. “She’s a bit protective of the soldiers, she sees us all as her family. She lost her husband and son in the Invasion; I think she just doesn’t want to lose anyone else. That’s why she doesn't trust you.”

“But . . .” Catra looks up at Busto. “Do you trust me?”

He doesn’t hesitate, “Of course!”

“Why?” Catra says. “After everything the Horde did to you, your family, your friends, why bother? Why bother trusting me? Or-or trying to stand up for me? Why bother?”

Busto looks at her thoughtfully, “When we first met, it looked like you needed a friend. Besides, I see the good in everyone. I think there’s something good in you, beneath all those walls you built up.”

Is there really any good in here? Behind the Horde soldier? Behind the person that can attack the person that for a long time was her only friend? Behind the scared little girl who has been hurt too many times?

“That’s debatable,” Catra says. “But . . . we’re friends?”

“That sounded like a question, not a statement.”

“That’s because it is.”

“Well, I already consider us friends, but if you’d like to be friends that I am more than fine with that.”

Catra studies Busto. His eyes are wide but he seems relaxed. He may actually genuinely mean that.

She tries to play it off, casually saying, “Yeah. I’d like to be friends.”

Wolf Moon is exactly like every other village on the island: completely decimated.

It took them most of the day to get to the seaside city, and it’s bigger than any other village Catra has explored.

She watches Busto take the first step into the ruins. He takes a deep breath before walking onto the broken cobbled roads, the rocks are cracked and weeds grow between them. He stops, takes a sad look around, and pushes forward.

He doesn’t talk. Catra understands why, he probably hasn’t seen most of the destruction until now. She follows him, letting him decide where to go. He walks down the paths to what must have been the housing part of the village, where husks of homes are lined up neatly in rows.

Near the back of the district is a house that is partially collapsed. It was once painted baby blue but has chipped and faded over time. To the right of the house, a garden has taken over the remaining part of the house, vines and flowers wrapping up and around the walls. Busto stops in front of it, and just stares.

“Was this your house?” Catra asks.

Busto nods.

Catra’s not used to all this friendship stuff, as she never really acknowledged that she considered Scorpia a friend and . . . she doesn’t need to think about the other person. Maybe she should try to take a page out of Scorpia’s book and try to be supportive.

She kicks a rock on the ground and asks, “Is . . . there anything you want to do?”

"No," Busto says. "I . . . kinda just wanted to see it. My father would be happy to see his garden doing so well. But . . . since I'm here."

He walks down the path and pushes the door, but it falls down off the hinges, kicking up dust. Busto manages a laugh at that, and he enters his old home. Catra waits outside, since this seems to be a bit too . . . personal than what she's comfortable with.

A few minutes later, Busto leaves with a picture frame in his hands. The glass appears to be broken, but inside the frame is a black-and-white photo of four Magicats, two adults and two kids. Busto smiles as he shows it to Catra, "Those are my parents, and my little sister, Purr'li."

Catra feels like she's staring at ghosts. The photograph is faded and the three deceased Magicats inside it are happily frozen in time. Catra looks at a young Busto, a wide smile on his face as his father lifts him onto his shoulders.

Busto looks at the photo again smiling sadly at it. She looks at him and asks, "Do you miss them?"

"Every day," Busto admits. "But, worrying about the past gets me nowhere. The best thing to do is to keep moving forward, as my father would always say. I think he would be proud of how I've done my best to not just drift through life in grief, but thrive in happiness."

She looks at the photo again. She can barely make out the face of Busto's father, but he's smiling as well. There are wrinkles around his eyes, but they have a wise look around them. Busto must get his sense of wisdom from him.

"Your dad sounds like a good guy," Catra says.

"He was," Busto confirms. He takes the blanket out of his backpack to wrap the picture in before putting it away. He takes a deep breath and shakes his head a little, giving Catra his usual

smile, “So, shall we continue? You said you wanted to see the docks?”

“Yep,” Catra nods.

“Then I’ll lead the way.”

They only take a step or two in silence before Busto asks his characteristic unexpected deep question, “Catra, do you ever wonder about what happened to your parents?”

Catra stares at him for a moment, “You know, when I asked you to come camping with me, I didn’t think I’d have to answer so many deep questions.”

Busto turns around and begins to walk backwards, so he can face her, “But, have you thought about it? You’re a Magicat, obviously, so you had to have come from two Magicat parents.”

“Not really?” Catra shrugs. “When I learned about the Horde Invasion, I figured that they just died. Or gave me away to spare their own asses. No one in Half Moon looks like me, which just confirms it.”

“Hhm,” Busto pensively rubs his chin. “But you must want to know where you came from, right?”

“If they’re dead, it doesn’t matter,” Catra says. “It’s kinda just nice to know that there’s other Magicats. There wasn’t anyone in the Horde that looked like me, I thought I was alone. Also, be careful or else you’re going to trip and fall on your ass.”

“I’m very careful. I won’t-” Busto says, but then his foot catches on an upturned stone, causing him to fall flat on his ass. Catra laughs at him as he picks himself up and dusts off, “Alright, you got me there. But there really weren’t any other Magicats in the Horde?”

“Nope,” Catra says. “At least, not that I know of. Anyways, it doesn’t matter. Let’s keep moving.”

The port is the worst part of the city. The few buildings lining the edges of the docks have been ripped apart to their foundation, and the docks are half sunk into the sea. A few ships are sticking out of the sandbar, and surprisingly, an old Horde ship as well.

If Catra really wanted to, she could probably figure out a way to get that Horde skiff out of the water and powered on. It would be smooth cruising back to the mainland. That is . . . if she wanted to.

Busto whistles at the damage, "So, anything look usable?"

"No," Catra decides. "Nothing good here."

He studies the ships out in the ocean, and then Catra. He asks, "Do you still want to leave Purrsia?"

The waves crash up against the shore, spitting up seaweed before pulling it back into the wake. She watches this repetition a couple times before saying, "I . . . honestly don't know."

"What about your unfinished business?" Busto continues. "Back at the training grounds, you mentioned a She-Ra? Who is she?"

"She . . ." Catra watches the water. "Used to be a friend. But she doesn't matter anymore. I . . . don't think she ever thought of me the same way as I thought of her, so I may as well move the fuck on."

"A crush!" Busto teases. "Were you going to confess to her?"

"No actually, I wanted to punch her in the face."

"Oh. Hhm, not as romantic."

"But I think I need to start moving on," Catra declares. "Like you said, I can't drift in my grief and anger. I have to move on. But . . . I don't know if I belong in Half Moon, just yet."

"I think you already do belong in Half Moon," Busto says. "But it takes a lot of strength to accept the past and move forward. Take all the time you need."

That's the second time she's been called strong. She thought she was strong when she had the whole Horde at her beck and call. She thought strength was having enough physical might so that no one could hurt you anymore. She was proved wrong when Hordak choked her and sent her to the island.

She had a lot of preconceived notions, learned in the Horde, that have been shattered once she was brought to Half Moon.

Maybe once she figures out what real strength is, she'll be ready to be a part of Half Moon. Maybe once she finds something to believe in, to have faith in, she'll be ready. Maybe she has to figure out why C'yra and Busto think that she's strong when deep down inside, she's just a scared kid.

All she knows is that she has to start moving forward.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed this chapter! Leave a comment if you liked the chapter, validation it the best way to keep me writing. Have a good day and stay safe!

are you going to scarborough fair? parsley, sage, rosemary, and thyme

Chapter Summary

Catra goes shopping.

Chapter Notes

Hello everyone! I hope you're having a good day!

Some notes: I cut down on chapters again. i'm still kinda . . . working out that last half of the fic so that's why the chapter number is in flux. But, with the current number and with what I have written (not published) I'm 1/3 done with the fic!!!!! My goal is to finish this and make this my longest fic in terms of word count and chapters!

Also, I have been replying to comments, but I want to say thank-you to everyone who comments one every chapter or just leave a comment in general your support is what pushes me forward! As much as I love writing these characters, you responses give me that extra boost to push forward! So from the bottom of my heart, thank-you!

Now, this chapter is a bit of a filler, but I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Ow ow ow ow ow ow ow-"

"This would hurt less if you stopped moving!"

"No, that isn't helping!"

"Who's the healer here? You!?"

"No, but I know that fucking hurts, so it can't be helping!"

"It should hurt because I'm trying to clean your wound! How'd you get this anyway!?"

"Uh . . . tussled with a small beast. Another one. Must've been a baby."

Catra squints her eyes as she glares at Shire, who's giving her an exasperated look. She really doesn't want to admit that she tripped on a root and threw her spear as she fell. She then promptly landed on her spear, which slashed open her side. It cut her day short (as she had continued to explore the surface instead of spending more time under the judgmental gazes of other Magicats) and had to return to Half Moon immediately to get it looked at.

Thankfully, Shire was just sitting around the infirmary with nothing better to do.

Shire sighs as she places her hand on her forehead, "Of course you had to hurt yourself on the day I'm reorganizing the infirmary. I don't know where anything is now!"

"That sounds like a ‘you’ problem," Catra drawls as she waits for Shire to come back with a roll of bandages. Shire eventually does and when she starts to wrap it around Catra's stomach, it's tighter than it needs to be. Catra hisses, "And it's gonna be a ‘you’ problem if I can't breathe!"

"Then please, be a good patient and shut the fuck up," Shire counters.

"Oo! Shire said a bad word!" N'yan marks her arrival as she strolls into the infirmary, another Magicat kit following behind them.

"I always say bad words," Shire rolls her eyes. She looks Catra over, "Alright, you should be good to go. Clean your wound and rebandage it, you know the drill. Now, onto the two gremlins that have invaded."

"We're not gremlins!" N'yan insists. "And you promised that you'd take us to the market today!"

Shire stares at N'yan before letting out a delayed, "Shit."

N'yan's arms drop, "You forgot!?"

"I've been busy!" Shire insists. She looks around the mess of the infirmary until she settles on Catra, "*You*."

"Uh, yeah?" Catra quirks an eyebrow.

"I need you to take N'yan and Lily to the market."

"What."

"Hey, I nursed you back to health and have fixed all of your wounds with minimal complaint, I think you owe me!" Shire claims. "I have to clean all this up and I have an important lesson with Ri'ta today, so I really need you to do this favor for me. Please?"

Shire pouts and clasps her hands together, trying to pull at Catra's heartstrings. Catra likes to think that she can't be swayed so easily by such things, but for some reason N'yan and her friend, Lily, both join in on the pouty face session. Catra glares at all three of them before throwing her hands up in the air, "Fuh-ine! But not because that stupid pouty face worked. It's because I kinda like you. Now let's go to this stupid market."

"Yay!" N'yan and Lily exclaim at the same time and begin to run around the room, jumping over the boxes of medical supplies. "MARKET! MARKET! MARKET!"

"If you two keep on chanting I am not taking you!" Catra interrupts. The two stop suddenly and mime zipping their mouths shut.

"Thank-you, so much," Shire sighs, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder. "I owe you one."

"Better keep good on that," Catra mumbles as she trudges out of the infirmary, the two kits right on her heels.

She thought that the two would just keep the talking to themselves, but as soon as they leave infirmary they try to pull Catra into the conversation.

“Catra, why're you in the infirmary this time?” N’yan begins.

“What do you mean ‘this time’?” Catra asks.

“You’re always in there, whenever I come to visit,” N’yan says. “Shire says it’s cuz you go on the surface and the surface is dangerous, so what’d ya do?”

Lily gasps, “*You* get to go on the surface!?”

“Yeah,” Catra huffs. “Is it that big of a deal?”

“Yes!” Lily exclaims. “I thought only the hunters could go on the surface. Y’know my big brother Gr’wliger is in charge of the hunters. He’s so cool! I’m gonna be just like him one day! I want to go on a hunting mission but he says I’m too little. I’m too little, right?”

“No, you are,” Catra says, causing N’yan to laugh.

“Hey!”

“Listen, the surface is actually pretty dangerous,” Catra continues. She probably shouldn’t encourage one of the kits to try to explore on their own in any way, “Wait until you grow up a little bit more and you actually have some training in how to fight, alright?”

“Alright,” Lily huffs. “But *I* think I’m big enough.”

“But you’re not,” Catra says as they step out of the tunnel and into the market cavern.

The market is the same as last, but now she's at the whim of two excitable kits. They started to drag her around to each stall, 'oo'-ing and 'ah'-ing over everything that was slightly sparkly.

Catra doesn't care as much. She lets herself get dragged around while keeping an eye out over her shoulder. Her reception in Half Moon hasn't exactly gotten better since she attacked D'nah, and everyone (aside from Busto, Shire, the Queens, Jen'dots, and the kits) have kept their distance from her. The stall keepers eye her warily as the kits rummage through their wares. She tries not to mind it, and instead just gives the stall keepers a polite nod.

As the kits are at a stall full of hand-made stuffed animals, Catra notices movement out of the corner of her eyes. Slinking out of the shadows is Thom, and he looks like he's up to no good.

However, that is not her problem.

She turns back to the kits as N'yan shoves two colorful stuffed animals into Catra's face, "Which one should I get? The pink one or the red one?"

"How should I know?" Catra counters.

"Well what color do you like better?" N'yan continues. "C'mooooooon!"

"I don't know red?" Catra says with a shrug.

"Hhm . . ." N'yan studies the two and decides, "Nah, I'm going to go with the pink."

"Glad I could help."

The two end up *not even buying one of the stuffed animals* and moving onto a stall that's selling wooden toys. Lily almost takes Catra's eye out with a toy bow before she drags

them out of there because she's not going to get smacked around by toy weapons.

The next stall is selling jewelry. As the two look at the various bracelets and necklaces, Catra has to ask, "You two do have money right? To buy this stuff? Don't you have to trade metal coins to get goods and services, or whatever?"

"Yeah, my mom gave me some money," N'yan says. Lily nods in confirmation at the same time. "Do you have money?"

"No," Catra says, and suddenly her tail becomes very interesting. "It's not like I really do anything to earn it. Besides, all I need is food and a place to sleep, which are apparently free around here."

"But what if you get bored?" N'yan says. "Don't you want toys to play with or books to read?"

"I'm too old for wooden toys like that," Catra gestures to the previous stall. "And all the books here are free too, just have to go to the library."

"What if you want new clothes?"

"I was given a couple sets for free."

"Or a snack from one of the bakers?"

"I'm fine with just eating from the cafeteria," Catra eyes a food vendor. Hhm, that actually smelled pretty good . . . .

N'yan shoves a gold bracelet with blue jewels into her face, snapping her out of her food thoughts, "How about jewelry?"

"I don't get the purpose of jewelry, it seems like a waste of resources," Catra says. "Or it could get caught on something when you're trying to fight."

"It's to look pretty!" N'yan insists. "Have you even ever *tried* to wear jewelry?"

Scorpia may have tried to make her a "friendship bracelet" before, but with her claws she wasn't able to get very far. She supposes that there's the silver brooch C'yra left with her green cloak, but that was practical: it kept the cloak closed. Besides, such frivolous things weren't accepted in the Horde, but she's not going to try and explain why to the two kits staring at her with wide eyes.

"No."

"That's it!" N'yan declares, raising the golden bracelet in the air. "I'm gonna get you this bracelet-it goes with your eyes, by the way-and you're gonna have some jewelry and you're gonna look pretty!"

Catra's eyes go wide, "You *really* don't have to do that, I-I'm probably not gonna wear it anyway."

"You're gonna wear it because I'm gonna give it to you as a gift, and my mom says that even if you don't like a gift sometimes you have to pretend to like it anyway so you don't hurt the feelings of the person that gave you the gift!"

"What kind of logic is that?!"

Apparently, the might of a former Force Captain is nothing against the determination of a child. N'yan buys the bracelet, grabs Catra's hand and refuses to let go. It's only once Catra stops squirming that N'yan is able to clamp the bracelet around Catra's wrist, and she finally lets go. Lily watches and laughs at the whole ordeal.

"So, do you like-no, do you *love* it?" N'yan asks with wide eyes.

Catra shakes her wrist, and it feels odd having the weight on the end of it. She sighs, "I don't *hate* it."

"Yes!" N'yan shouts. "Next time we'll take you to get your ears pierced."

"My ears *what now*?"

She doesn't get an answer. The kits are dragging her back into the crowds of the market, from stall to stall. She's still trying to get used to the bracelet, shaking her hand every once in a while. At least it wasn't one of the ones with bangles . . .

As they move to another stall, Catra sees Thom again, walking their way. He's slouched over with his hands in his pockets, a half-full sack tied to the belt of his pants. Catra tries to not look him in the eye, so he doesn't get any ideas. He doesn't get out of the way when they pass, and he bumps into her shoulder.

"Hey!" Catra hisses. "Watch where you're going!"

Thom just snickers, continuing to walk. He turns around to shrug, and as he does so, Catra catches the glimpse of something sparkling in his closed hand. As he turns around, she realizes that the weight on her wrist is gone. Looking down confirms it: her newly gifted bracelet is gone.

Catra stops in the middle of the aisle, as Thom has somehow disappeared into the crowds. N'yan notices that she's lagging behind first, "Hey Catra, keep up!"

"Do you two still have . . . whatever you keep your money in?" Catra asks.

"That's an odd question," N'yan points out. "Also, it's called a *coin purse*."

"Just answers the question!"

N'yan and Lily pat their sides. N'yan produces a small purple sack, while Lily becomes frantic. He sighs, "Uh . . . I swear I just had it. Did I drop it?"

Catra looks back down the aisle, though Thom has disappeared he couldn't have gone far. She growls, "No. I think I know where to look. Stay behind me."

She moves through the crowds, weaving in and out of Magicats passing by while trying to catch a glimpse of Thom again. She checks every alleyway or dark shadow in the market. Seeing as how she's never seen him outside the market, Catra has the feeling that he's still around.

After her second time around the market, she sees Thom leaning against a stall selling rocks (Catra doesn't understand why anyone would buy a rock, even if they're shiny. You can just pick one off of the ground). While the stall keeper is distracted with a customer, Thom snakes his hand onto the edge of the stall and knocks one of the rocks over. It doesn't hit the ground, and as Thom walks away he's fastening the bag on his hip.

While his back is turned, Catra rushes forward. She runs up to him, making sure he doesn't slip away into the shadows, and taps on his shoulder.

"What the-" Thom turns around and scowls at her. "Why are you botherin' me, Horde scum?"

"I'd like my bracelet back," Catra says. "And Lily would like his . . . coin bag back."

"Coin purse!" Lily whispers. Both of the kits were cowering behind her knees, peaking out to glare at Thom.

"What makes you think that I have them?" Thom asks. "And how'd you even get a bracelet anyway?"

"I bought it for her!" N'yan says. "And you should give it back! Stealing's bad, y'know!"

"Oh, it is?" Thom feigns innocence. "I didn't know. But I don't have it."

Catra eyes the bag on his hip, and Thom takes a step back, “So you won’t mind me taking a look in that bag then, if you haven’t stolen anything.”

“That’s my private property,” Thom says. “You don’t have any right to look in there, even less so because you don’t even belong here.”

Catra growls, “Give. Me. My. Stuff. Back.”

“No,” Thom simply says. “What’re ya gonna do anyway? Attack me? I heard whatcha did to D’nah, snap like that again and they’ll be a mob callin’ for ya head. You can’t do shit.”

Catra’s sick of his voice. In a swift motion, she grabs Thom’s arm and shoulder. She twists his arm behind him, causing him to bend backwards awkwardly. It doesn’t cost her much effort despite him straining to break free.

“Ow ow ow ow!” Thom hisses. His eyes dart around at the Magicats standing by, who have started to stare. “Y’all just gonna let the Horde soldier *attack* me?!”

“It’s not like you don’t deserve it,” Catra says. “Now, drop everything you stole.”

“What?”

“Drop. The. Stolen. Items. *Now*.”

Thom growls, but he relents and uses his free hand to unhook the bag from his belt. It drops to the ground and with her foot, Catra pushes it over towards N’yan and Lily to pick it. With that done, Catra releases Thom and he lurches forward, trying to put distance between himself and Catra.

“You’re gonna pay for that,” Thom turns around and spits. “You’ll rue the day you crossed me!”

Catra crosses her arms and laughs, “Sure I will. Now scurry on out of here back to your hole, or whatever cesspit you crawled out of.”

“Fuck you,” Thom finishes before running off. Catra smirks, he just couldn’t come up with anything wittier in the end.

She turns to the kits, who are looking at her with starry eyes. N’yan exclaims, “That, was, so, cool!”

“It’s not really,” Catra says. She has a feeling that because it’s *Thom* she’s not going to face any repercussion, but she’s not too sure. She looks at the bag in Lily’s hands and says, “Open it.”

Inside is Lily’s coin purse and Catra’s bracelet, as well as many other presumably stolen items.

“So, what’re we gonna do with everything else?” Lily asks.

“Return them, duh,” Catra says. “They weren’t Thom’s and they’re not ours. What am I gonna do with a shiny rock, anyway?”

“Look at it,” N’yan suggests. “Put it on your nightstand. Or a pile of papers so they don’t blow away when you turn the fan on.”

“You have an answer for everything, don’t you?” Catra sighs.

“Well,” N’yan puffs her chest out. “I am very knowledgeable.”

Catra rolls her eyes, “C’mon, there’s a lot of shit in here. Let’s return it.”

The rest of their time at the market is spent trying to figure out where all of Thom’s stolen items came from. However,

as soon as the stall keepers realized that she was bringing back their stolen goods, they would light up and try to direct her to the next merchant. All thanked her for standing up to Thom, and for once, Catra didn’t feel like she stood out.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank-you all for reading, and leave a comment if you enjoyed! Once again, I really appreciate every single comment and it means a lot to me!
>
> Finally, one more chapter before we reach the climax of the first arc of this story. I'm really excited!!!!! Have a good day and stay safe!

sweet dreams till sunbeams find you, sweet dreams that leave all worries behind you

Chapter Summary

Catra has another nightmare.

Chapter Notes

Hey y'all! I . . . don't have much to say. This is a shorter chapter, but I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra wakes up covered in sweat, and in the darkness of her room she swears she can see the shadows, curling, coalescing on the floor to take the shape of inky, black tentacles. She dives for a light, pressing the button on the lamp and the room illuminates. The shadows are banished, but her chest heaves as the nightmare still lingers in her mind.

Another nightmare. Another dream about Shadow Weaver. Even a million miles away hidden in the Half Moon Caves, the woman's presence hangs in the back of her mind, waiting for when she's unconscious to strike.

She's been having nightmares like this every day this week. She didn't have one while she was camping with Busto, probably too exhausted from the long trek to Wolf Moon and back to dream. However, they've been plaguing her when she's alone in her room and she doesn't think she's been getting enough sleep. Perhaps that's why she slipped up and tripped on another root today.

After every nightmare she feels too wired up to go back to sleep. Her body's on the defense, waiting for that horrid woman to slink out of the shadows. She needs to calm down.

To do so, she leaves her room and begins to walk through the halls of Half Moon. It's somehow cooler at night, and at the foot of the hallways there are lights that illuminate the winding paths. She just begins to walk, try not to think about Shadow Weaver, and see where her feet take her.

She ends up walking down the corridor of offices, and most are empty right now . . . except for one.

There's a faint light coming from C'yra's office. Catra softly pads over and peaks her head into the doorway. C'yra is hard at work, hand in her hair as she goes through paperwork. The only light is coming from a small crystal, it's glow flickering like a candle.

With a smirk, Catra knocks on the door. She laughs as C'yra jumps up in her seat and stares at Catra, "By Saz! You almost gave me a heart attack! What are you doing up at this hour, Catra?"

Catra saunters into the room, "I could ask you the same."

She sits down, and even in the dimly lit room she notices bags under C'yra's eyes. With a small smirk, C'yra says, "I asked you first."

"I asked second."

"Catra."

"C'yra."

They stare at each other before both of them break down laughing. C'yra rubs her eyes, "Huh. The sleep deprivation is really getting to me. I just couldn't sleep, so I decided to get some work done. Now you."

Catra shrugs, "I couldn't sleep either. I . . . decided to go on a walk to wind down."

"I understand," C'yra nods. "I used to do the same, but I would pace the bedroom. That would eventually wake Ri'ta up, and I love my wife but she *hates* being woken up. She's not a morning person."

"Me too," Catra admits. "But I had to get up early a lot back in . . ."

The shadows return in her mind, and she can't bring herself to finish the sentence. Anytime she tried to sleep in and shrink off her duties as a cadet, Shadow Weaver made sure she regretted it.

"Understood," C'yra says. She looks Catra over and asks, "Have you been getting enough sleep?"

"Does that matter?"

"I want you to take care of yourself. Have you been sleeping well?" C'yra continues. When Catra doesn't answer, she sighs, "You can tell me anything, you know. I won't judge."

Catra crosses her arms and huffs, "You won't?"

"I promise."

She squirms in her seat before mumbling, "I've . . . been having nightmares."

"Ah," C'yra leans back in her chair. "Well, if it helps you to know, I'm actually up because of a nightmare too. You're not alone in that regard."

"So . . . do you always come and work on paperwork when you have a nightmare?" Catra asks.

"No, usually I wake Ri'ta up to talk about it. It's one of the only times she's fine with me disturbing her sleep," C'yra says. "But . . . tonight I decided to let her sleep. I had things I didn't

get done today, so I came here to work on it and get my mind off my dreams."

"What are they about?" Catra continues, her voice getting small. "If . . . you're comfortable talking about it. I didn't mean to pry or anything."

"Don't worry, it usually helps for me to talk about them anyway," C'yra says as she rubs her eyes. "I usually dream of the Horde Invasion, about the mistakes I made and the people I lost."

"Like your daughter?" Catra says. C'yra stares at her with a wide eye and eyebrows raised. She quickly adds, "Shire told me about her. Only once. I was asking about the Horde Invasion."

"No, it's fine," C'yra insists. "It's not quite . . . a secret. A lot of us don't talk about the people we lost. We've tried to move forward because there's not much else we can do but grieve but . . . yes, it was about my daughter. She was a ball of energy, a bit of a troublemaker, but so sweet. She was only four years old when she di-. . . went missing, and . . ."

C'yra had been staring at her desk, tapping her fingers, but she looks up and stares at Catra with a deep sadness in her eye, "I have made many, many mistakes. My biggest regret will be that I didn't hold her close enough, that I didn't protect her, that I didn't spend enough time with her. I . . . I worry that in the time I had with her, I spent so much time in war rooms, council meetings, and in battle that she didn't know how much I loved her."

C'yra goes silent, and remains looking at Catra. It gets awkward, especially because the queen has started to cry, but she suddenly blinks away the tears and asks, "Catra, this may seem like an odd question but . . . do you have any memory of your life in Purrsia before you were taken by the Horde?"

"Uhm . . ." the question is very off topic, but Catra still answers it, "No? I think I was pretty young during the Invasion, I

just figured I just forgot."

That or . . . Catra had a theory about a particularly shadowy bitch that she doesn't want to spend much brain power thinking about.

"Oh," C'yra sounds disappointed somehow, but she covers it up quickly. "I'm sorry, that's enough about me. Would you like to talk about your dreams?"

"Not really," Catra mumbles.

"Talking about my dreams helps me," C'yra says. "Though I didn't mean to get . . . that intense, I have a feeling that I'll sleep a bit better after this. The floor is yours, if you wish. Like I said, I won't judge you."

Catra hugs herself and looks to the ground. She's . . . never gone into details about her dreams, even with Adora, but with C'yra she feels . . .safe. She takes a deep breath, "My, my dreams are about my caretaker in the Horde. She was a bitch and is the one that called me 'useless'. A lot. She used magic to punish me or throw me into dark, small spaces and . . . yeah, that's what I usually dream about."

"I'm sorry that happened to you," C'yra says. "You didn't deserve to be abused like that. I know that anything I say will not make those dreams suddenly go away, but if you need someone to talk to about it, I'll be here for you."

"Will these nightmares ever go away?" Catra says in a hushed tone. She's had these nightmares for years now, ever since Shadow Weaver started to hurt her. It sounds like C'yra's been battling her nightmares since the Invasion.

"I . . . I don't know," C'yra admits. "My dreams of the Invasion have become less frequent, but every so often they'll rear their ugly head and I'll relive my loss all over again. I have to believe that our wounds will heal over time, but we don't have to try and get through them alone."

“Alright,” Catra sighs. “Thank-you.”

C’yra gives her a small smile, “Do you feel a bit better?”

She has to think about that for a minute. The oppressive cloud of darkness that bears down on her doesn’t feel as heavy at the moment. Maybe talking about her nightmares did help, “Uh . . . yeah. I do.”

“Good,” C’yra stands up and stretches with a yawn. “I think it’s time for both of us to try and face sleep again, if you feel like it.”

“I . . . think I am,” Catra says. The two leave the office, but before C’yra can actually disappear, Catra has one last request. She feels a blush rising up on her cheeks, like she’s a small child, as she hurriedly asks, “Can you say that thing you and Ri’ta always say to me that I’m like, 70% sure is magic because I always fall asleep afterwards?”

C’yra stares at her for a moment but then smiles, “It's not magic, it’s just a genuine sentiment.”

“Whatever,” Catra huffs.”

“Sleep well, kitten,” C’yra says with a soft smile.

“Thank-you,” Catra mumbles.

The two go in their separate directions, and when Catra climbs back into bed, she’s able to slip into sweet, dreamless sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you for reading! Leave a comment if you liked it! Next chapter . . . everything changes for Catra. I
'm super excited for you all to read it, and I hope you are too, but we just have to wait one more week. Have a good weekend and stay safe!

loneliness has always been with me, but maybe we don’t have to be all alone

Chapter Summary

Catra discovers a temple.

Chapter Notes

I'm not going to say much, but I hope you enjoy the chapter!

Song: The Fighter, the Fray

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra doesn't need to look at the map anymore. She knows the forests of Beast Island like the back of her hand.

Or it at least feels like it.

She runs across the ground, green hunting cloak drawn close around her as she jumps across logs and rocks to wherever her next destination may be. It’s still early in the day and the cold air chills her as she runs.

Her excursions to the surface are not about finding a way off the island, not much anymore. She’s spending more and more time in Half Moon, but she’s not ready to fully commit to Magicat society yet. She knows that she has some deep-seated shit to work through, along with the fact that she’s not entirely welcomed there by everyone just yet.

So, she goes to the surface to run, be free, and to explore.

Catra lands on a large rock and crouches on the top. It's easier to find markers in the forests, unlike the Whispering Woods which seem to cause those who enter to go around in loops. Beast Island's dangers are equally sinister, but at least they're

obvious. She looks for a mark in a tree, an odd-looking rock, or a clearing leading to a village.

After a moment of study, Catra realizes that she's on a part of the island she actually hasn't been to yet. It is a big island, after all. If her shitty hand-drawn map is correct, she’s near the ruins of Waning Moon. She takes a moment to quickly look it over before deciding on a direction, heading further into the unknown.

Catra takes it slower, paying attention to the trail she's blazing and looking for obvious markers, ones she’ll be able to pick up easily the next time she ventures out this direction. However, she’s quickly distracted by a break in the tree line.

Her breath is taken away by the large, stone monument before her. It’s geometric in shape, and the sides of the pyramid step up to an entrance at the top, with six levels in total. There are faded and ruined carvings on each step, hidden by an overgrowth of vines and bushes. There’s a set of normal-sized stairs on each side trailing up to the top.

She’s never seen anything like this before. The architecture is nothing like the brutalism of the Fright Zone or the sleek designs of the First One’s temples. She feels drawn to it, and before she realizes it, she’s walking up the steps.

The ruins are falling apart, chips of stone are flicked away as she walks up. There’s some major battle damage on one side of the pyramid, leaving a large stone crater crumbling into darkness. This must have been abandoned during the war, but she doesn’t quite understand its purpose just yet.

At the top of the pyramid is a small landing that lords well above the trees. She’s never been up this high before on the island, but she’s reminded of her days in the Fright Zone, trying to climb up higher and higher to get away from her troubles below and break through the smog above. There’s no smog here, the sun is shining, and the sky is blue. There’s no machines, just a sea

of green treetops and just beyond that, the shimmering blue waves of the ocean.

The center of the landing gives away to more stairs, because whoever designed this really likes stairs. She ventures down inside, the cool breeze disappears and instead she breaths in cold, stale air.

The room beneath the pyramid is almost completely empty, and if she couldn't see in the dark, she would be completely blind. She almost heads back out before she notices the carvings on the wall. They may have been painted once, but in the years it's been abandoned, it has faded away.

The first mural is of three, humanoid figures descending from the sky. They're surrounded by Magicats; on the right they appear to be fighting the figures, while on the left they're now bowing to them.

Pieces start falling into place for Catra. She recalls the textbook she read about the Three Stars: Saz, Lyses, and Ilir coming down from the sky to teach the Magicats. If this mural is of that . . . she must be in one of the Temples.

It doesn't take her long to figure out that this Temple is the one that belongs to Saz. The next mural is of Saz teaching Magicats how to fight. They hold a spear, and the Magicats mimic their movements. The tip of the spear points to the next mural: a clash between Saz and Ilir. Saz has rallied the Magicats to their side, battalions' line up behind him prepared to take on the Wretched Star. Ilir has no warriors, just an army of beasts and lightning bursting out of the sky.

The final mural shows Saz stabbing Ilir with their spear, the beasts running away while broken Magicats lie down bleeding. Ilir cries out in pain, while Saz cries for their fallen comrades. Catra knows what happens next, Saz and Lyses take Ilir away so that they can never harm the Magicats again.

The book she read never mentioned how many Magicats were lost during the battle against Ilir, or mentioned that Saz actually cared for them. The Magicats were not just fodder to the deity, to be thrown at the problem until it went away, they actually cared for all of their subjects.

This Temple must've been built by the Magicats to honor Saz and those that fell to Ilir's hand. Of course, that's if any of this happened at all. She still thinks that the Magicat's gods are completely bullshit.

Catra turns around to leave, when she falls through the floor with a yelp.

She manages to twist around in the air and fall on her feet, tucking her head in as she lands on all fours so none of the debris scattering around her hits her face. She didn't realize that the wooden floor was rotted, too busy looking at the murals on the wall.

Once it goes quiet, she stands up and brushes the dust off. There's so much of it, she gets into a sneezing fit. Thankfully, no one is around to hear her.

She's not sure where she has ended up, maybe she went into a secret basement underneath the pyramid. As she scans the room, it looks more like one of the caves rather than a built room. She looks up at the hole, she's fallen quite a distance. It'll be a bitch to try and climb back up.

She tries to think through her options. She holds her hand out, leaning on a stalagmite she narrowly avoided getting impaled on. As soon as her hand touches it, it flares up with orange light, filling the cave with brightness. A surge of energy goes through her arm and it feels like her entire body is on fire. It shocks her enough to make her jump back, and she watches the stone slowly lose its glow until it fades to darkness.

“What the fuck just happened,” Catra says to no one. She carefully approaches the rock again, not sure what to do. Holding her hand out, she barely has to touch the stone for it to light up like the sun once again. She quickly removes her hand and tries to figure out what happened.

Her mind runs through things she knows: this Temple is dedicated to Saz, as evident by the murals. Temples usually belong to the First Ones, though this doesn’t seem to have any of the advanced technology or bullshit magic ladies she’s used to. Hidden at the bottom of this Temple is a rock that glows. Rocks that glow like that are usually Runestones.

But if this is a Runestone . . . why did she make it glow?

"Catra?" the old voice echoes through the chamber, and Catra jumps away from the stone. She didn’t even notice a faint light slowly approaching through a darkened cave entrance on the other side of the room.

Catra tries to find a place to hide, but Duet'ron hobbles into the chamber, his cane in one hand and a ball of light in the other. He tilts his head, "Catra, what are you doing here?"

And she starts to panic. He's going to think that she was looking for the Runestone (if this *is* a Runestone) for the Horde, and he'll tell C'yra and Ri'ta and they'll hate her and throw her in jail or give her to the beasts she's disappointed them like she always does or Hordak always wanted her to find the Runestone and he's using her and Shadow Weaver's mind games like always and she's a danger to everyone-

"Catra," Deut'ron places a hand on her shoulder, forcing her from her thoughts. "It looks like you fell through the ceiling. Are you alright?"

"I didn't mean to!" Catra begins, every excuse spilling out, but this time it’s the truth. "I just found this place and, and I

was exploring, and I, I fell through her and found this weird stone that’s probably a Runestone, but I, I swear I wasn't looking for it!"

Even though Catra's falling apart, Deut'ron is composed, "I believe you."

"You . . . you do?" Catra chokes.

"Of course," Deut'ron insists. "You couldn't have known that we had a Stone, of course, it's a well-kept secret.

"I, I won't get in trouble?" Catra asks.

"No, of course, if anything I'm the only who'll be in trouble. I'm in charge of guarding the Temple and it's clear I've been neglecting it," Deut'ron says as he glances up at the hole Catra accidentally made. "Did you fall through the ceiling?"

Catra is only able to nod her head.

"See? A completely accidental discovery," Deut'ron continues. "Now, were you hurt?"

"Landed . . . on my feet," Catra manages to grin.

Deut'ron smiles as well, "That's good. And did you touch the Stone? Did it do anything?"

Catra gives Deut'ron a pensive look, trying to understand what he's trying to find out. He just said that she wouldn't get in trouble, so why is he asking more questions?

"I promise, you will not get in trouble," Deut'ron insists. "I only want to know if you have a connection to the Stone, of course."

"I . . ." Catra glances back at the stone and swallows. "It glowed. I touched it and it glowed and it felt weird. Are you sure I won't get in trouble?"

"Of course," Deut'ron squeezes her shoulder, not very hard since he's a very old man.

"Okay, so why did the Runestone glow when I touched it? Only Runestones glow like that. It is a Runestone, right?" Catra asks, recovering from her break-down. "Aren't only like, Princesses supposed to do that? Make Runestones glow and do magic?"

Or be Shadow Weaver, Catra glumly thought.

Deut'ron removes his hand and moves back towards the tunnel he came out of, "We have much to talk about, Catra. Come with me please, back to Half Moon. I promise you will not get in trouble."

One part of Catra wants to trust Deut'ron, and maybe it's a childish side that hopes that nothing changes and she just goes back to Half Moon, to explore and be free. Another part of her doesn't trust Deut'ron, a very broken part, that fears punishment and knows not to trust anyone who holds themselves above her. But then, the quietest part is curious about why the Runestone glowed when she touched it, who she was before Half Moon was attacked, where she came from.

Curiosity killed the cat.

But satisfaction brought it back.

She tries to reach down into the whisper of a voice, and takes a step forward.

Deut'ron nods and leads the way. Catra quickly follows, having to slow down her usual pace to stay in time with him.

Deut'ron begins, "So, I know you know of Saz and Lyses."

"And Ilir," Catra points out.

"Yes, but the Magicats only have Temples of Saz and Lyses, of course," Deut'ron continues. "You found the Temple of

Saz."

“Magicats built it, right?” Catch checks.

“With aid from Saz,” Deut’ron explains. “But, as I know you’re curious, when we would have dignitaries from Bright Moon or Salineas, they would, of course, say that those Temples belonged to the First One's and the Stone was a Runestone."

“They don’t exactly look like First One’s Temples,” Catra points out. The old stone reclaimed by nature was a far cry from the sleek and dangerous Temples she saw on the mainland.

“Of course, that’s what they would say as well,” Deut’ron agrees. “But as soon as they saw the Stone of Saz and how it reacted to Queen Bett’i, they called it a Runestone.”

Catra huffs, “Of course you have a different name for Runestones.”

"The Stone of Saz," Deut'ron continues. "As a Cleric of Saz, I do my best to take care of it even in its ruined state. It was discovered by C'yra the First, of course, and as the Chosen of Saz, she was able to use its power to unite the tribes into the Queendom of Purrsia. All of C'yra's descendants have been able to draw on its power, to varying degrees of course."

"Like a Princess," Catra points out. "So, it's a Runestone."

"It may be," Deut'ron says. "But even if it is, we'll still call it the Stone of Saz."

"Okay, if the Stone of Saz only works from Magicats descended from the original C'yra, why did it react to me?" Catra asks. She's getting a bit tired of this story, and wants to get to the point.

"That's something only the Queens will be able to answer. It's not my story to tell," Deut'ron insists. “But, we’re almost to Half Moon. You won’t have to wait much longer now.”

Catra crosses her arms and huffs, but continues to follow the Cleric.

He takes her to a large room with a big, circular table at the center. All of the chairs surrounding it are the same, except for two with tall, pointed backs. A purple banner hangs over the table with gold fringes, a golden spear surrounded by branches embroidered into it.

"This is the Council Room," Duet'ron answers before Catra can ask. "Please, wait here while I go get the Queens."

"Why don't I go get them?" Catra suggests. She doesn't say it out loud (with Shire mentally jabbing her in the stomach), but she knows that she'll be a faster messenger than Deut'ron.

"I must talk with both of them first," Deut'ron says.

"I thought you said I'm not in trouble."

"Of course, you are not in trouble. There are a few things I'd like to clear up with them first," Deut'ron insists. "Please, take a seat. I won't be long."

Catra doubts that, but she crosses her arms and watches Deut'ron leave.

Instead of sitting in one of the chairs, Catra hops onto the table. She begins to kick her feet in the air, trying to get her mind off of the growing dread in her stomach. As curious as she is to know why the Runestone glowed when she touched it, she's more worried about how C'yra and Ri'ta will react to her discovering it.

She stews in her dark thoughts, and jumps when the door to the Council room opens. She lands on her feet again, and watches as Deut'ron leads C'yra and Ri'ta into the room.

Catra wants the two Queens to instantly tell her that everything's alright. They understand that it was a mistake and then they can all laugh about it. However, C'yra is holding Ri'ta's

hand and the two Queens seem . . . nervous for some reason. Not angry, at least, but she doesn't know *why* they're nervous.

Deut'ron looks at Catra, his expression unreliable, before turning to the Queens and saying, "It's time."

Catra looks between the three, "Time for what?"

Ri'ta squeezes C'yra's hand. C'yra takes a deep breath, "Catra, would you come with us? There's something we need to talk about."

"Is . . . is it about me finding the Runestone?" Catra asks.

"Yes and no," C'yra says. "You're not in trouble for finding the Runestone, but . . . it's something we need to talk about. Just, let us show you something first. And, and please, keep an open mind."

Catra flicks her tail, "Why are you all acting so weird?! If I'm not in trouble, then I can just go, right?"

"Catra," C'yra looks at her with that sad look she saw the night before. "Please. Hear us out."

She doesn't like what's going on. She doesn't like how C'yra and Ri'ta are acting. But she feels like she has no choice. She spits, "Fine. Let's get this over with so everything can go back to normal."

C'yra takes the lead, guiding Catra over to a door near the back of the room. Catra marches over, Ri'ta and Deut'ron following closely behind. Inside the room are rows of portraits, each painting is in a gilded frame with a small plaque on it.

Before Catra can walk further into the room, Ri'ta places her hand on her shoulder. As usual, she has to provide some kind of history lesson, "All of these are portraits of the Royal Family, every Queen that has ever ruled Purrsia has been immortalized in

these pieces of art. They’re here because a few brave workers saved them from the destruction of the Castle stronghold.”

“That’s neat,” Catra huffs. “Why are you showing me these?”

“Take a look for yourself,” Ri’ta says.

Catra brushes off Ri’ta’s hand and stalks into the room, stopping at the first painting.

It is a portrait of C'yra the First, in some purple ceremonial garb. She's standing in front of the Runestone, head held high, and hand on the hilt of her sword, looking regal. Her other hand holds a spear. Catra's drawn to her eyes, hard and commanding, but the colors are mismatched:

One yellow, one blue.

She's followed by more portraits, generations of Queens who ruled over Purrsia and the Magicats. They are all different shapes and sizes; some are scholars while others are warriors or mages. But they all share one feature in common, their eyes:

One yellow, one blue.

The last one in the hall is a family portrait, unlike every other solitary queen. Sitting in a chair, with a golden circlet in her hair, is an older Magicat with a slightly crooked smile. She's wearing a purple uniform similar to C'yra's and holds a familiar looking spear next to her. Her eyes aren't serious like every other queen, but similarly colored.

One yellow, one blue.

Next to her is clearly C'yra and Ri'ta. They both look so happy. Ri'ta's wearing a more formal version of her blue robes, but what's noticeable is that she still has her hand. C'yra's still in purple, but her scarred eye is open, revealing its true color:

One yellow, one blue.

And in their arms is a child, but she’s very young, maybe only two. She has wild hair, barely tamed. She appears to be quite happy being in her mother's arms, or maybe it's because of the doll in her arms. She stared out with wide, curious eyes:

One yellow, one blue.

She stares at this last portrait. The baby is clearly her, though she has no memories from that age. Now that she sees what C’yra looked like with both eyes, she can clearly connect features that are similar between the two of them: the same of their face, the color of their fur and hair, and most obviously, their eyes.

One yellow, one blue.

When she finally rips her eyes away, C’yra and Ri’ta are standing behind her. They’re holding onto each other and looking at her nervously. Her emotions are a storm; confusion, anger, relief, and sadness all mix in, but only one thought manages to rise above it all: C’yra and Ri’ta are her mothers. Even as she tries to wrap her head around this world-shattering revelation, her temper breaks through.

“You . . .” Catra tries to say something, but all the words seem to die in her throat. C’yra and Ri’ta just stare at her, waiting for her to speak. “You knew.”

C’yra takes a shaky breath, “We did.”

Catra wants to ask them why they didn’t tell her sooner, but the answer is clear to her: they don’t want her. They wanted to wait and see if she was a rabid Horde soldier before welcoming her back into their lives. They wanted to see if she had any worth before accepting her. However, she’s been at Half Moon for some time now and they haven’t made this fact clear to her, so they must not want her. She’s proven useless, like always.

"Catra," C'yra begins, but Catra doesn't want to hear anything she has to say.

She turns around and runs. It is what she always does, she runs and runs and runs. The Queens don't want her. They may have acted like it but they never did.

Even as they cry out for her, she doesn't look back.

Chapter End Notes

Now I can finally make that joke: gee author, why do you let Catra have two moms?

Alright, anyways, I hope you all enjoyed that! I certainly did. Leave a comment to let me know your thoughts, and have a good day!

sometimes it may seem dark but the absence of light is a necessary part, just know you're never alone, you can always comes back home

Chapter Summary

Catra runs.

Chapter Notes

I don't really have much to say, other than enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra runs through the Caves. She runs through the gates and out into the forest. She runs through the trees and underbrush. She runs and runs and runs and runs.

She hasn’t been paying attention to where she’s going, not like she can really see with the tears stinging her eyes. Pressing her body flush against a tree, she begins to catch her breath and tries to not let any sobs break through. Any noise will be enough to alert a near-by beast that she’s not prepared to take one on.

Many thoughts course through her head, so fast it’s overwhelming. She just wants to scream. She can't believe she let herself get tricked again, into thinking that she’d be wanted. But no one wants a useless Horde soldier like her.

Eventually, she stops shaking and her eyes dry. She may have just run out of energy to be upset and tears to cry. She tries to resolve herself, will herself to move forward. She can get off of the island. Get far away from Half Moon. Get back to something that matters: taking down She-Ra.

However, she can't muster the resolve. She's just tired. Tried to running. Tired of fighting to prove herself. Tired of getting attached. Tired of being cast aside. Tired of getting hurt. So, so tired.

One thing's for sure: she can't return to Half Moon. She won't be able to face the Queens again, even if they're her mot-

She feels the tears threaten to spill again. She's not going to think about them. She's not going to think about it. She's not going to think about Half Moon.

Of course, to truly get her thoughts off of Half Moon, she'll have to get off the island. She'll go to Wolf Moon and try to fix that old Horde transport carrier. Now that she can't rely on Half Moon, she'll be able to move forward with her original goal.

It's hard to steel herself and her decision, but she forces herself to open her eyes and take the first step forward-

"Hey, you hear that?"

Catra immediately presses back against the tree, trying to sink down into the growth as silently as possible. The Queens wouldn't really send out a search party for her when she clearly does not want to be found?

Passing by the near-by trail is a group of four Magicats, wearing green cloaks (similar to her own, gifted by C'y-nope. Not gonna think about that. She absolutely refuses to) and carrying bows. Most are average height, but one with dark brown fur and darker stripes towers over the others.

They must be hunters. Busto explained to her once that the different factions have different colors assigned to them: red for the soldiers, green for the hunters, blue for mages and scholars, and purple for royalty. The green cloaks are a dead give-away. They probably have been hunting for most of the afternoon, and don't know about her . . . encounter with the Queens.

"I don't hear anything," the tallest speaks with a deep, yet soft voice. "Let's continue on. We haven't met today's quota yet."

The three other Magicats follow his lead, heading further into the forests.

As Catra watches them go, she realizes that she may not be as far from Half Moon as she thought. She recalls Ri'ta mentioning that the Hunter's don't travel beyond Waning Moon . . .

Catra hits herself in the head. She's not going to think about her. She's not going to think about them. She's not going to think about Half Moon. She repeats that like a mantra, waiting until she feels that the hunters are far enough that she can move. Until she's forced back into her hiding spot once again.

Beasts tend to have a calling card. If you can't hear the heavy breathing, branches snapping underneath their heavy paws, or the rustling of the branches as they lumber past, then you're fucked. Thankfully, Catra hears all three well before she sees the beast.

The beast, another neon monstrosity, passes by her without noticing. She doesn't want to have a repeat of her first day here, especially when she promised herself that she would stop relying on Half Moon. However, something gives her pause. The beast seems to be moving with a purpose, and suddenly she hears a scream.

She stands and watches as the beast runs towards a Magicat kit. Catra recognizes him, Lily, N'yan's friend. He had mentioned he wanted to go to the surface, to be a hunter like his brother. The little idiot must've actually gone through with it (despite Catra not recommending it). He's frozen in fear as the beast charges at him. She can't just leave him there.

Catra's good at moving without thinking. This time, she moves on instinct.

Before she realizes it, she's running after the beast. She runs and jumps onto its back right before it reaches Lily, digging her claws into its hide. It rears back, yowling and kicking its legs up in the air, but she manages to hold on for dear life. This is probably one of the stupidest things she's ever done, but she feels no regret.

"RUN!" Catra shouts over the howling. This is enough to shock Lily from his stupor and he runs for the underbrush.

The beast bucks and shakes, trying to knock Catra off of its back. She quickly loses her grip, and she's tossed onto the ground. She gets to her feet as fast as possible and draws the spear from her back, readying for the next attack.

However, the beast isn't interested in her. It has some sense in it and turns towards the easier catch: Lily. He didn't make it that far, tripping over a root (she understands) and is now trying to crawl into the brush. The beast spins around and tries to attack the kit again.

Catra run forward and stabs her spear into its side, and piercing the beast's hide. As it cries out again, she dashes for Lily, scooping him up in her arms and tumbling into the brush. They roll down a small hill, Catra tucking her body around Lily's so she takes the brunt of the damage. When they reach the bottom, she rolls onto her feet, still desperately clinging onto Lily. She begins to run, not quite sure of her current bearings.

She can hear the beast thundering after her, knocking down trees as it tries to get to its prey. The chase doesn't last for long, as she runs straight into a ten-foot-tall cliff, something she won't even dream of climbing while carrying and protecting Lily. There's only one thing to do, she ducks down and shields Lily with her body. Maybe she'll be able to at least do this to protect him.

The beast gets closer and louder, it's roar deafening. Before the end hits, she hears one last thing: "FIRE!"

Okay, maybe it's not the last thing she hears.

She hears the taunt snaps of bow strings as they release their missiles and the crackle of fire. She dares to turn and watches as a volley of arrows, all lit aflame, hit the beast. It cries out in agony as the flames consume it, and soon it's nothing but a smoldering pile of flesh.

Catra looks up, and at the top of the ridge are the four hunters from before. The tallest one gracefully slides down the ridge. Lily climbs out of her arm, crying as he runs at the tall figure, "GR'WLIGER!"

The tall Magicat, Gr'wliger, removes his hood as Lily runs up to him. His face looks serious, but it seems to lighten as he catches Lily in his arms, "Lily? What were you doing out here?!"

"I-I-I-" Lily sobs. "I wan-wanted to be a hunter l-like, like you! So I came o-out here to, to follow you an-and help you! Buh, but then the beast came, and I, and Catra, and I'm so sorry!"

"Shush," Gr'wliger says. He rubs Lily's head as the kit cries into his shoulder, "I'm just glad you're safe."

Gr'wliger turns to Catra, and she realizes she's still crouched on the ground. She stands up as the taller Magicat approaches her. She can predict the next words on his lips: he's going to ask her to come back to Half Moon. She can't go back. She can't.

She runs.

She leaves the hunters in the dust, running past the carcass of the beast and back into the forest. This time, she's paying more attention to where she's going, not that she really cares.

As she slows down, she notices that the sun has begun to set. She doesn’t quite know how long she has been running, but she knows she doesn’t want to be on the forest floor when darkness hits.

After a bit of deliberation, she finds a good tree and climbs.

She’s good at climbing. One of the only things she’s good at. She goes up as high as the tree branches will hold her, but she picked a tall one. Once again, she’s above the treetops, and is able to watch the sun slowly dive into the ocean. It casts brilliant colors into the sky, shifting from oranges and pinks to purples until everything fades into darkness.

The sky is pitch black, with no light except from the moons. She wishes that there were still stars, then she imagines she wouldn’t feel as alone. She’d be surrounded by the figures from myth, heroes and villains stuck in an internal battle on the night sky. But up here, with just her and the moon, she feels lonely.

She’s tired of being alone.

The tree besides her begins to shake. Catra wonders if a beast is trying to claw their way, but to her surprise, it’s just Gr’wliger.

"This is a strange spot," he says as he lifts himself onto a branch that'll hold his weight. It's lower than Catra's, but because of his height he comes up to her shoulder.

"What are you doing here?" Catra hisses. "How did you find me?"

"I don’t mean to brag, but I am the best tracker in all of Half Moon" Gr'wliger points out, his deep voice low in the night. "And I came to thank-you, for saving Lily."

Catra curls up and looks away, "It's not that big of a deal."

"Well, to me and my family it is," Gr'wliger insists. "And it was my fault for not noticing that he had snuck out sooner. He's alive right now because of you."

Catra doesn't really know how to process that comment without snarking, so she just stays quiet. Thankfully, Gr'wliger stays quiet as well.

They stay like that for a while, letting the cool night air ruffle their fur. Eventually, Gr'wliger says, "I will admit, I had another reason for being here. The Queens asked me to come and find you."

Catra huffs, pulling her knees up to her chin. She scowls as she says, "They don't care about me."

Gr'wliger looks at her, but his face is unreadable, keeping a stony facade, "Are you sure about that?"

"I'm pretty fucking sure," Catra insists.

"Because they are worrying themselves sick looking for you," Gr'wliger reveals. "They were so relieved when I said that I saw you, but were still afraid that you would be out here on your own, in the dark."

"I can take care of myself just fine," Catra hisses. "I've been doing so for years. They don't need to suddenly just start caring about me."

Gr'wliger looks back out at the sea of green, "Catra, may I tell you a story?"

"No."

"Okay."

If she were with Busto, he would have just started telling her the story, whether she said yes or no. Gr’wliger respects her answer and remains silent. Somehow, that’s worse than Busto’s ignorance (or maybe she’s just used to it) and she quickly caves, “Alright fine. Tell me your stupid story.”

Gr’wliger seems surprised by her quick change of tune, but takes it in stride. He slowly breaths in, “I am the oldest in my family, and I remember the transition to Half Moon Caves very well.

“When Queen C'yra moved the Magicats to the caverns, we barely had anything. We had only what we could carry since the Horde were still patrolling the island, destroying our homes and any sense of structure we had. Food was scarce, those who were brave enough went to hunt and try to gather supplies from the villages, but only half of them ever came back. My parents went without food so me and my siblings could eat. So did the Queens, they made sure that everyone else ate before them. More often than not, they did not eat."

Catra looks down at the trees. She had heard clues about the transition to the caves, but many seemed to focus on the tragedies that lead up to the migration.

Gr'wliger continues, "We all learned a lesson from the Horde Invasion, just different ones. I watched my parents starve, and I knew that we needed to have a better system. That's why I became a hunter in the first place. I’m the Head Hunter now, so no one else would go hungry. My parents learned about the importance of family, almost everyone lost someone, but they got out with each other and all their kids.

"General Az'al learned to protect what's important to her. She was much more reckless before the Invasion, but then she lost her husband and son . . . you should have seen her when her daughter, Demeter, became a hunter. She was afraid of losing her daughter the foot she stepped onto the surface. Others learned fear and hatred and . . . I think you know who I'm talking about."

Images of Thom insulting, Gus sneering at, and D'nah looking down at her all flash in her mind. She pushes out that and asks, "What about my mo-the Queens. What lesson did they learn?"

Catra looks down, and he's looking right at her, "Fear, of losing the ones they love. Losing anyone else."

Catra quickly glances back up at the sky so as to not burn under Gr'wliger's gaze.

He had said that they worried about her. Were they really? She thinks about every interaction she's had with the Queens, how much they seemed to care about her and believe in her. They gave her many chances, taught her about Half Moon, and called her strong. Maybe they didn't think she was useless. Maybe they just thought they would lose her.

And she proved them right. As soon as she learned the truth, that C'yra and Ri'ta are her mothers, she ran.

"Why don't you come back down with me?" Gr'wliger suggests. "It'll be safer to travel together, rather than alone. And if not that, I think the Queens are worried about you."

Catra doesn't look down but squeezes her eyes shut. She finally spits, "Fine. Race you back to Half Moon."

"Whu-what?" Gr'wliger sputters as Catra darts down the tree. She can feel the branches of his tree brush against hers as he tries to rush down, trailing after her.

Somehow, she feels lighter. She doesn't look back as she runs, she keeps her eyes forward, trained towards Half Moon.

Catra makes it back to Half Moon before Gr'wliger. He may know the forests of Purrsia better than her, but she's lean and able to get through the underbrush easier. She's out of breath, but laughing as she enters the clearing where the gates of

Half Moon are. Gr'wliger is close behind her, breathing heavy but still standing tall.

"Well, you may be fast but now I know why you're a constant infirmary case," Gr'wliger jokes with a deadpan expression.

Catra has to stare at him in surprise for a moment before she bothers trying to retort, "Hey! I only twisted my ankle twice! And not including the time I got mauled by a beast! Or the second time I got in a fight with a baby beast! And they were different ankles!"

"Thank Saz, or else Shire would have to amputate," Gr'wliger continues as he strolls over to the gates.

"You're just being a sore loser!" Catra claims and Gr'wliger laughs, deep and heartily.

The gates open and they pass through. Gr'wliger calms down and suggests, "I think you should let the Queens know that you're back in Half Moon. I have a feeling that you may need to have a deeper conversation with them, but it doesn't have to be serious tonight. At least let them know that you're safe."

Catra pouts at him, but Gr'wliger retains a neutral look. She eventually sighs, "Alright . . . thanks . . . for the talk, I guess."

Gr'wliger softly smiles, "Anytime, Catra."

He heads off to his own abode, and Catra figures she may as well face the Queens . . . her mothers.

Gr'wliger's words are a bit of comfort to her as she makes her way through Half Moon, she doesn't have to have a serious talk tonight. She still needs time to think, as her entire life has changed.

She has a family history that goes back hundreds of years. She has loving mothers who dreamed of holding her in

their arms again.

She always thought she had nothing. She was nothing. She was just some random runt Shadow Weaver took in because she had to. She was just some troublesome no-name. A disgrace and a pain.

She had nothing. And now she has everything.

It's almost too much.

She needed at least another night to think about all this. Maybe more.

She wants to just go and curl up and go to sleep so she could leave this problem to future Catra. Sadly, future Catra is waiting for her the next morning, so she may as well take Gr'wliger's advice and just start the process.

Catra doesn't really know where to look for the Queens. Ri'ta's usually in the library, and C'yra has her own office. She assumes that they have personal quarters, and considering the hour of night, they're probably there. However, she has no idea where it is. So, she tries C'yra's office first.

She's a bit surprised to hear the hushed and worried voices of the two Queens echo down the empty hallways of Half Moon. Late at night, most of the Magicats whose offices are here have gone home for the night, but Catra wonders why C'yra is still here, and with Ri'ta no less. Or maybe, for once, she's just lucky and doesn't have to search the entirety of Half Moon for them.

Catra slinks up to the door, not really sure how to approach this situation or even what's going on inside the office. She's right outside, but doesn't want to enter or let them see her yet.

"Do you think Gr'wliger and the others have found her yet?" Ri'ta asks, her voice is small but in the quiet Catra can hear her just fine.

"I hope so," C'yra sighs, sounding tired. Not exasperated, but a deep sadness that just makes you tired. Catra figures she's the cause, but it sounds like C'yra been tired for much longer than today, "But, she can handle herself. We've both seen her in action. And she'll come back to Half Moon when she's ready."

There's a beat of silence, when Ri'ta says, "I can't tell if we told her too soon or too late."

Catra hears the scrape of the chair against the floor as it is pushed back, followed by the soft padding of feet on the rock. A couch squeaks in protests as C'yra begins, ". . . I don't know either. Either way, we did it wrong."

"Oh, by Saz, of course we did," Ri'ta agrees with a sour laugh. "I just hope she can forgive us."

C'yra sighs, "Me too, dear."

The conversation stalls and Catra squeezes her eyes shut. She figures that this is as good a time as ever to barge in and ruin a moment.

She steps into the doorway and before she can even knock on the frame, C'yra and Ri'ta are both staring at her with surprise. The two of them are nestled together on the small couch, holding each other. It's sweet, but Catra feels even more intrusive than she did before.

"Uhm," Catra quickly looks around, her brain trying to figure out what she was even planning on saying. "I . . . didn't die out there so . . . that's good. And . . . I just wanted to let you know that."

C'yra composes herself first and she sits up straight, "Thank-you. We really do appreciate it. We were worried."

"Yeah, uh . . . no problem?" Catra says. By Saz, this was fucking awkward.

“Would you like to come in and have some tea?” Ri’ta offers, she’s about to get up and get some tea out of Catra’s vision.

“No! Uh . . .” Catra barks, and realizes she needs to pull her shit together. “Can we talk tomorrow? I’m still . . .”

“Processing everything? Ri’ta guesses.

Catra just nods her head.

“Then that’s fine with us,” C’yra insists. “We just want you to know is that . . . all we want for you is to be happy.”

“Yes,” Ri’ta agrees. “So, take all the time you need and if you want to talk tomorrow, then we’ll be ready to talk. There’s . . . quite a bit to talk about, whenever you’re ready.”

“Okay,” Catra nods again. It’s a bit comforting to hear those words, to know she’s not expected to have an answer to everything tomorrow morning as soon as the sun rises . . . but another part of her doesn’t want her to take forever. Maybe it’s curiosity, maybe it’s longing. Catra doesn’t know, she needs to sleep.

“Have a good night, Catra,” C’yra finishes up.

Ri’ta adds, “And sleep well, kitten.”

“Good night to you too,” Catra says and walks away.

She can feel some of the weight leave her shoulders, now knowing that C’yra and Ri’ta . . . her moms . . . aren’t angry with her for running and she has time to think about everything that’s happened the past day.

But maybe she’ll sleep first.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading, and I'm really glad that you're all enjoying it! I really do appreciate every single comment I get and I thrive off of positive feedback. Have a good day and stay safe!

oh how could i dream of such a selfless and true love? could i wash my hands of just looking out for me?

Chapter Summary

Catra eats breakfast. And gets some closure.

Chapter Notes

I don't have much to say on this end, other than hey, enjoy the chapter!

Title: Montezuma, Fleet Foxes

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Dawn comes peacefully. Usually, Catra is awoken by some nightmare, but her body must have been exhausted from the emotional rollercoaster that was yesterday.

Catra decides to not head to breakfast just yet. She didn't give herself enough time to think over everything yesterday, she just flopped on her bed and fell asleep. She has a clearer mind this morning, but things are still a mess.

There are many truths Catra knows now, but there are two that are the biggest: she has a family . . . and she's a Princess.

The realization that she's a Princess hits her like a freight train.

The thought of being a Princess honestly, freaks her out a bit. She's hated Princesses for so long, yet she was one. She was fine being the Horde Commander and ordering soldiers around, but being the leader of a country as a Princess seemed like a whole different beast. Maybe it's because she's given up on that dream, at least returning to the Horde, and she didn't see it ever

coming back. To boot, she was Princess to the Magicats, and she’s pretty sure that half of them hate her guts. Being a Princess seemed . . . terrifying.

But having a family? Not being alone in this world? Knowing that she came from somewhere, and there were people in this world that would love her unconditionally? Catra has always longed for that feeling, to not be alone and to always have someone who would be there for her. Once upon a time, that person was Adora. Scorpia was slowly becoming that person for her. And now . . .

Catra doesn't hate C’yra or Ri’ta, she really likes them if she’s being honest with herself. They were the first to accept her in Half Moon for who she is, though as to why is now apparent . . . but it never seemed like a mind game. They were always genuine in wanting to spend more time with her, getting to know her, and offering their help to her.

Catra honestly believes it when they say they just want her to be happy and . . . she tends to feel . . . nice around them. She's not quite sure what that feeling is-safety, comfort, maybe even love-but it's a good feeling.

Catra gets sick of her thoughts at the same time her stomach grumbles, and figures she should eat something. She didn't have dinner last night.

She heads down to the cafeteria and gets breakfast before she finds her usual spot across from Shire. She doesn't say much, just starts shoveling food into her mouth.

Shire watches her for a second before saying, "So . . . "

Catra swallows a mouthful before she responds, "So what?"

"You know, don't you?" Shire says carefully, like she's about to break something.

"Know what?" Catra raises an eyebrow. There's been a weird tenseness since she sat down and now that Shire's dancing around a topic, it's only gotten weirder.

Shire sighs, "You and C'yra and Ri'ta."

Catra drops her fork and her jaw as she stares at Shire, "You KNEW!?"

"Shh!" Shire hisses. "And everyone else will too if you don't shut up!"

She glares at Shire as she hisses, "You knew and you didn't think to tell me!?"

"Well first off, it wasn't exactly my secret to tell!" Shire argues. "Secondly, I was actually ordered not to so don't blame me."

"You could've broken a rule," Catra huffs.

"No, I don't live that kind of life," Shire insists. "Also, how would you even react if I told you? On the first night you had woken up, after the Queens had left and I was just like 'oh and by the way those are your moms'. If I was in a strange place and a stranger had told me that I was their daughter, I would've told them they were crazy, my parents are dead, and ran away."

Catra hates to admit it, but Shire does have a point. She always had thought that her parents were dead, had just abandoned her for the Horde, or maybe both. It had never crossed her mind that maybe her parents loved her and she was just taken from them as a cruel joke.

She probably wouldn't have believed anyone, if on that first night, they had told her that she had parents. Actually, that would just have made her want to get out of Half Moon even more desperately.

And Gr'wliger's words from last night come to her. The Queens are afraid of losing the ones they love. They love Catra, and were afraid that if they told her that she was their daughter, they'd lose her again. They'd rather have her in Half Moon blissfully unaware, rather than desperate to leave.

"So . . . are we okay?" Shire checks with Catra.

"Yeah," Catra sighs. "We're okay. Just . . . how long have you known?"

"Oh, the moment you opened your eyes," Shire confirms. "The Queens had their suspicions when you were brought in, but the blue and yellow eyes really confirmed it."

"So, does everyone else know?" Catra checks. If the eyes were a symbol of royalty, then everyone must have their own ideas about her.

"I don't know," Shire shrugs. "I know that the Council members, like Gr'wliger and Az'al, knew because there was that whole debate about having you in Half Moon, and I think Busto too because he was there? But overall, I wouldn't know."

That's . . . not as much of a comfort to Catra as she would have hoped, but at least no one has acknowledged that it's kind of weird that this former Horde soldier has a royal trait.

Catra looks up from her breakfast and sees C'yra receiving a basket of food from Jen'dots. Catra quickly stands up and says, "I gotta go. See you later."

"Uh, sure? Bye?" Shire calls out as Catra rushes over to C'yra, hoping to catch the Queen before she leaves.

Thankfully, C'yra stops as soon as she sees Catra running to her, "Uh, good morning, Catra. How are you today?"

"Good," Catra says. "I, uh . . . think I'm ready to talk."

"So soon?" C'yra checks. Catra figures that C'yra wasn't expecting her to speak to her so soon, especially with how she reacted to the new yesterday, but Catra had just had a series of epiphanies that made this possible.

"Yeah," Catra nods her head.

"Then, why don't you come and join Ri'ta and I for breakfast in our quarters?" C'yra suggests. "I'm sure that there's more than enough for the three of us in here. It certainly feels like it."

"Sure," Catra agrees.

Catra follows C'yra through Half Moon to the Queens' quarters, somewhere she hasn't been before. The walk there is quiet and awkward, because Catra's not sure what to say and C'yra probably feels the same. Everything is too tense between them, and Catra hates it.

The Queens' quarters are closer to the offices rather than the other abodes. C'yra opens the door with a, "Ri'ta, dear? We have a guest!"

She follows C'yra inside to a small living area. It's quaint, with a small table and chairs set to one side of the room, while the other has a large couch and fireplace. The walls are lined with bookshelves, filled with books. Considering that Ri'ta lives here, Catra shouldn't be surprised.

C'yra sets the basket on the table, next to a small vase with flowers in it as she sighs, "She's probably still asleep. She's not a morning person."

"Neither am I so, understandable," Catra agrees, starting to go through some of the titles of the book on the nearest bookshelf.

C'yra opens the basket and pulls out a pot of coffee and pours a cup, "Let me go and wake her up. Make yourself

comfortable, please."

Catra nods and C'yra disappears down a hallway next to the fireplace. Catra can hear muffled talk as C'yra tries to wake Ri'ta, and protests from Ri'ta about being woken at such an ungodly hour. Catra smiles, it's nice to be reminded that the Queens here are people too.

That's another thing about them, they don't seem like some god-like, unquestionable leaders like Hordak. They're kind, make mistakes, and listen to their people. Catra figures she should be lucky that they're her moms, even though that thought is still a bit weird to Catra.

Catra continues to browse the books on the shelves until C'yra manages to drag Ri'ta out of the bedroom. The minutes Ri'ta steps out-coffee cup in hand, bedhead, and wearing a robe over pajamas-she stares at Catra and hisses, "Fuck, Catra's here. You didn't tell me Catra's here."

"I did," C'yra rolls her eyes but she has a soft smile on her face. "You just ignored me in favor of sleep."

"And good morning to you too," Catra interjects, and she can't help but smile.

"That's because it's too early," Ri'ta insists. She softens up as she turns to Catra, "But yes, good morning to you, Catra. I'm glad you're joining us."

"Uh, yeah," Catra's not quite sure to respond, so she just eyes the basket and questions, "So, are we gonna eat or what?"

"Of course," C'yra says and they all sit down at the table.

It's a bit cramped, Catra assumes that even with the extra chair this table is meant for two people. But, C'yra divvies up the food while Ri'ta pours herself another cup of coffee, and Catra realizes that this isn't too bad. It's quaint and nice. Everything about Ri'ta and C'yra is nice.

"Alright," Ri'ta starts sipping her second cup. "I'd say I'm awake now. Catra, you'd like to talk?"

"Yeh uhm," Catra mumbles, her mouth already full of food. She should've brought the food she got when she ran off to C'yra, by Saz she was so hungry. She quickly finishes chewing and tries to get her thoughts together, but being put on the spot doesn't help.

She gathers herself and begins, "So uhm, I . . . think I get why you two didn't tell me I was your daughter right away and I'm sorry for running off yesterday. Uh, don't worry about that and I'm not good with this feelings shit but, I . . . don't hate you two and I actually kinda like you two. It's nice being around both of you."

Catra feels like that's a shitty explanation, but C'yra and Ri'ta both look relieved and quite happy with it.

"That's good to hear," C'yra says.

"Very good," Ri'ta agrees. "And we like being around you, as well."

"So, I'm not . . . opposed," Catra tries to choose her words carefully. "To the idea of being your daughter, not just because I am, but I don't think it would be terrible, it would actually be pretty nice. But . . ."

C'yra and Ri'ta have both been looking pretty happy with all this news, but their smiles falter for a second as Catra brings in a 'but'.

"I . . . don't think I want to be a Princess," Catra admits. "At least not now. I don't know if I'll ever want it, and I know that you don't really choose to be a Princess but . . . that's not me. I don't know if me being your daughter and being the Princess is mutually exclusive or-"

“Don’t worry,” C’yra insists. “I can speak for both of us when we say, you being the Princess is the last thing on our minds. I’m surprised you even thought of that.”

“I have a . . . *thing* about Princesses,” Catra tries to explain, but she doesn’t want to delve into more detail. Thankfully, they don’t press her for details.

"Like we said yesterday, all we want is for you to be happy,” C’yra says. “If you want to just be our daughter . . . then that's perfectly okay."

"And it would make us pretty happy too," Ri'ta continues. "Thank-you for talking with us. I think . . . we owe you an explanation and an apology. We should have told you sooner. You deserved to know, especially after everything you’ve gone through.”

“We were just . . . nervous,” C’yra admits.

“D-don’t worry,” Catra says. “I think I understand why. I probably shouldn’t have run off yesterday before you had the chance to explain yourselves, I probably just confirmed all of your worries.”

“Then let’s agree we all fucked up,” Ri’ta suggests.

“Agreed,” Catra says. “So, what did you two want to say?”

“You . . . and I have talked about Fel’cty, *you*, before,” C’yra begins, tapping her fingers on the table. “And it sounds like you’ve heard stories of the Horde Invasion from those around Half Moon. I suppose . . . just so we don’t have to repeat anything, what do you know?”

“All I know is that Fel’cty-wait, I guess I should say I because I’m here-went missing and no one could find me,” Catra says. “I guess, now you have closure. I ended up in the Horde but now I'm here. How . . . how did that happen?”

"It was during the siege of the old Conservatory," Ri'ta says. "That's where the mages of Purrsia would train. I was there, trying to protect it. However, our efforts were not enough. The Conservatory fell and I lost my hand."

"I was in the capital in the Castle Stronghold, with you," C'yra continues, looking at her hands. She can't look Catra in the eye, her old regrets bubbling up, "We were trying to move troops out to support the assault on the Conservatory, but we didn't know it was too late. However, in the middle of meetings I got word that an assassin had struck while we were all distracted. While we were in meetings or in battle, you were left in the care of a nanny and had your own guard. The assassin slaughtered them all, and you were gone."

"There was so much blood," Ri'ta's voice hitches. As she tries to hold back tears, C'yra reaches across the table to squeeze her hand. "W-we, we did our best to search for you. But we feared for the worst."

"And the Invasion was only getting worse," C'yra says. "I had to make a hard decision. I'm sorry that I didn't look harder for you. There was never a day that you weren't in our thoughts."

"We were very happy when you returned," Ri'ta says. "I hate that we had to be wary, because you were returned to us wearing the Horde's colors. I wish we could have told you sooner. But, the longer we put off telling you . . . the harder it got. We didn't want to . . . scare you away."

"I understand," Catra says.

C'yra lets out a deep breath. "Thank-you. I'm glad we're able to get this off of our chests."

"We really appreciate it," Ri'ta adds.

"Now that we're all caught up," C'yra says. "Can I ask you a question?"

"I thought we had just gotten caught up, why do you need to ask questions?" Catra teases with a smirk.

Ri'ta begins to laugh and C'yra shoots her a glare, "She gets that from you, you know."

"I know and I'm very proud," Ri'ta says through her laughter.

Catra doesn't know why, but those words make her feel warm. She now feels connected to Ri'ta and C'yra, not just through facial features, the yellow and blue eyes of royalty, but there are pieces of her that came from them. She has Ri'ta's sarcasm, and probably C'yra's temper.

"Shoot," Catra says as Ri'ta finally stops laughing.

"Who in the Horde named you Catra?" C'yra asks. "I think I can understand that they wouldn't want you to know that you're a Princess, but why name you something so . . . on the nose?"

She honestly doesn't know. She clearly remembers her and Adora coming up with last names for each other, but she doesn't want to tell the Queens that technically her fully name is "Catra Meowmeow". There's only one person that could have, "I don't know. Probably Shadow Weaver."

Suddenly, Ri'ta spits out her coffee. Before Catra can poke fun at her, she slams her hand on the table and asks, "*Shadow Weaver!?*"

"Uh . . . yeah," Catra says. She doesn't know what's going on anymore, but she adds, "Do-do you know her?"

"Yes, I . . ." Ri'ta's eyes go wide, she puts her hands over her mouth as she stares down at the table, deep in thought.

Catra pulls her legs up to her chest. She doesn't want to know how Ri'ta knows Shadow Weaver, that there might be some

unfortunate connection between the woman that has shown her nothing but kindness and the woman that made her life hell.

C'yra notices how Catra begins to fold in on herself, "Catra, are you alright?"

"How do you know Shadow Weaver?" Catra simply asks Ri'ta in a small voice.

This snaps Ri'ta out of her stupor. She reaches out to squeeze Catra's shoulder, "I don't know her well, only in glancing association. I . . . I suppose that if you know her, I should explain myself."

"Wait," C'yra says as she turns to Catra. When Catra looks into her eyes, it looks like C'yra has suddenly realized something. She must know about Shadow Weaver too, "Is it alright if we continue? Is . . . she the one that-"

Taking in a shaky breath, Catra says, "Yeah. She's the bitch that raised me in the Horde."

Ri'ta's eyes turn steely, "What did she do to you?"

"Nothing good," Catra admits. She watches Ri'ta's hand curls into a fist, and repeats, "How do you know her?"

"It has more to do with my mother-*your* grandmother-than myself," Ri'ta begins. "But the story goes back a bit further to when Purrsia first connected with the outside world, when the M'stoff'lls Tribe became allies with a hidden city known as Mystacor. On mainland Etheria, Mystacor is home to great and powerful mages. I won't bore you with the facts of that story, you just need to know that since then, the M'stoff'lls would train in Mystacor for at least some part of their life. I myself grew up there, I didn't live on Purrsia until I was fourteen.

"The reason why is that my mother had been living on Mystacor for quite some time. She trained there and became one of their great mages, but my mother has been described as . . .

hard to get along with. She referred to herself as 'feisty'. While she knew how to show love to her family, she was ornery with others. One of those people was a mage named Light Spinner.

"Apparently, my mother and Light Spinner had been rivals for years. When my mother began to train me, Light Spinner began to teach my best friend, Micah. However, Light Spinner tried to use him for her own gain to get more power, messing with dark magics. After that, she was cast out of Mystacor and to protect me, my mother moved us back to Purrsia.

"Years later, I faced Light Spinner again, during the Invasion. She led the attack on the Conservatory, but she was twisted into something . . . darker. She called herself Shadow Weaver. I lost that fight, and I lost my hand," Ri'ta puts her hand on her chin. "I don't know if this is certain . . . but I'm wondering if Shadow Weaver took you for a reason."

"So what? She kidnapped me, took away my memories, and abused me for years because she hated your mom?" Catra asks.

"It would be very sad if it is true," Ri'ta sighs as she rubs her temples. "When you came back, we simply theorized that the Horde took you because you were the Princess. But I had forgotten to add Shadow Weaver into that equation . . . I should have fought harder all those years ago. I should have killed her."

"We cannot change the past," C'yra says sagely. "If it's alright, let's move onto another topic. I doubt any of us want to talk about Shadow Weaver further."

"Agreed," Catra sighs. She wants to banish that evil woman from her mind.

Ri'ta seems to still be stewing, so C'yra starts, "But speaking about Ri'ta's mother, we actually named you after her."

"Really?"

"Yes," Ri'ta starts to light up. "My mother passed away from sickness a few years before you were born, but we couldn't come up with a better name. I know that she would have loved you."

It's strange to think that someone who is long dead would have bothered to care about her, but Catra doesn't bring it up.

"As I said, she was hard to get along with," Ri'ta continues. "It took C'yra a couple years to get on her good side."

C'yra chuckles, "That was an uphill battle."

The two begin to weave tales of Fel'cty of M'stoff'lls, about how she eventually started to like C'yra and of her time in Mystacor. Sadly, the morning has to end and the Queens . . . her mothers, have to get to work. But, as they all depart Catra feels a warmth inside her, one she's felt when she was around C'yra or Ri'ta before, now growing into a strong flame.

She found her family. She found a place to belong.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, I hope you all enjoyed that! We have officially finished the first arc of the story! I added on a bit of lore with Shadow Weaver and the M'stoff'lls, and I hope that worked out okay. Leave a comment to let me know how you're enjoying the story so far!

Next time, we finally get to see what the fuck Adora's been up to.

Interlude II: Adora

Chapter Summary

Hey, what has Adora and Scorpia been doing this whole time?

Chapter Notes

So, this is kinda the beginning of the next arc of this story. I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora sighs as she spots Brightmoon in the distance. After weeks in the desert, they finally made it back.

The Best Friend Trio returned having accomplished their goals for the Crimson Waste, having learned more about Mara and the portal, but as usual, things didn't go as planned.

First, there was Huntara, who came to their side after she and Adora bonded over leaving the Horde. Then, Octavia showed up with a platoon of Horde soldiers, almost kidnapping her, before Glimmer, Bow and Huntara were able to free her. Finally, a wastelander named Tung Lashor attacked them because of a bounty the Horde put on Adora's head. (She's not including when they got lost, and she and Bow drank some cactus juice, mainly because she doesn't really remember that). But, despite making out of all of that alive, Adora still felt that there was something off.

After weeks and weeks and weeks in the Crimson Waste, Adora had not seen hide nor hair of Catra.

Catra was always the first to catch onto Adora's plan and the first there to try and ruin them. For her to not show up *once* in their entire Crimson Waste adventure put Adora on edge. If she wasn't in the Crimson Wastes, then she *must* be planning

something big. Adora was expecting Brightmoon to be a soldering pile of ruins when they returned.

"See, Adora!" Bow says as they enter the castle's golden gates. "Everything's not on fire!"

"That doesn't mean that Catra's *not* planning something," Adora stresses.

"Adora, you need to calm down," Glimmer sighs. "We found Mara's ship! We defeated Tung Lashor and made a new friend! Can't we just celebrate this little victory without worrying about Catra?"

"She's planning something," Adora insists, narrowing her eyes. "I know it."

Bow and Glimmer share a worried look. Adora may have been getting a bit . . . anxious about this fact ever since they departed the Crimson Waste. She'd been having trouble falling asleep expecting a surprise attack from her former best friend.

She gets distracted as they enter the throne room, where Angella is waiting for them, "Welcome back."

"It's good to be back!" Glimmer says. "Especially because it's much cooler here than the desert."

"So, what did you find?"

Bow and Glimmer relay to Angella the information about Mara, the portal and She-Ra's sword, while Adora stays lost in thought. She's sure Catra is planning something, she knows it.

"We can't let the Horde know about the secret of the sword," Angella says. "But speaking of the Horde, we received a new . . . guest, while you were gone."

This catches Adora's attention. She snaps her head up and asks, "Who is it? Is it Catra?"

". . . No, but it is about her," Angella says. "The Horde commander Scorpia is currently in ou-"

Adora runs off before Angella can even finish. She heads straight to the dungeons, ready to interrogate Scorpia about Catra's latest scheme. However, the only person in the cells is . . . Shadow Weaver.

She runs past her cell before Shadow Weaver can even regard her.

Before she can start tearing the castle apart looking for Scorpia, Glimmer teleports right in front of her. She crashes into the shorter princess and they fall onto the floor in a pile of limbs, with Adora on top of Glimmer. She rolls off before Glimmer can complain too much, "Oops, sorry Glimmer."

"Adora," Glimmer just sighs. "Scorpia isn't in the cells, she's been moved to one of the rooms."

"Why?"

"She defected from the Horde."

"*Why?*"

"I don't know, but my mom says that she wants to talk to you."

"Can you teleport us there?"

"Sure."

One explosion of sparkles later and Adora's been delivered to Scorpia's door. Two guards stand at attention, and bow as Adora and Glimmer enter the room.

Scorpia is sitting by the waterfall, but she jumps up as soon as the two enter, "Uh, hey! Usually I'd say something about how it's a bit rude to enter when not knocking but it is so good to

see you two. I've been waiting for a while for you to return, where were you-"

"Enough with the chit-chat!" Adora says, pointing a finger in Scorpia's face. "Where is Catra? What is she planning?"

"Catra's been sent to Beast Island."

"What?"

All the animosity that has been building up, anticipating another attack, another stab in the heart, breaks away into concern for her former best friend. She can barely comprehend Scorpia's words. Catra has been sent to Beast Island. Her former best friend has been sent to Beast Island.

"Beast Island?" Glimmer echoes, bringing Adora back, "What's Beast Island?"

"It's . . . the worst punishment you can face in the Horde," Adora whispers. Could Catra really have been sent there? Could she be out of Adora's reach? Could Adora even save her?

"You have to help me," Scorpia begins to beg. "You're the only one who still cares for her, even if you've been on opposite sides of the war. I know she's still alive, so you gotta help me save her."

"Hold on!" Glimmer interrupts. "After everything you and Catra have done, why should we trust you?"

"I know I don't have much going for me," Scorpia says. "But Catra's my friend, and I would do anything for her. Even come over to the enemy side."

Adora studies Scorpia. She didn't know much about her. She heard very little about her while she was with the Horde and their interactions while fighting on opposite sides were fleeting. With Scorpia, where she lacks in street smarts, she makes up for in strength . . . and loyalty to Catra.

She might just be telling the truth.

And if she's not? What would Adora be losing? She would be falling for another one of Catra's traps.

If Scorpia is telling the truth . . . then Adora could be losing Catra. Forever.

"I believe you," Adora says.

"WHAT," Glimmer yells. She grabs Adora's arm and says, "Please excuse us for a second."

Glimmer teleports the two out of Scorpia's room and into her own, where Bow is waiting for the two of them. She doesn't stop to explain to him what is going on, just exclaims, "Adora, what the fuck?!"

"Language!" Bow scolds. "And what is going on?"

"Scorpia's here because Catra got sent to this 'Beast Island'," Glimmer quickly explains. "Which sounds like something Catra would come up with to trick us, but Adora-after spending our entire trip back from the Crimson Waste worrying about Catra-agreed to help Scorpia!"

"I think she's telling the truth!" Adora insists.

"How can you tell?!" Glimmer demands.

Adora takes a deep breath, "Maybe it is a trap. Maybe Catra is planning something. But if Scorpia is telling the truth? Catra's stuck on the most hellish place on Etheria, the stuff of nightmares, and she could even di-" Adora stops herself from even saying it, she's not going to think about it, "-And if I didn't do something to at least try and save her, I . . . I don't know if I'd be able to live with myself. So, even if you agree or not, I'm going to help Scorpia save Catra."

Bow and Glimmer share a look. The later sighs, “Well, if this ends up being a trap, we obviously can’t let you go alone. Let’s . . . go rescue Catra, I guess.”

“Thank-you,” Adora lets out a deep breath.

Glimmer teleports all three of them back to Scorpia’s room, who lights up on their return, “Oh! You’re back. So . . . will you help me?”

“We will,” Adora agrees. “How do we get to Beast Island?”

“I uh . . . don’t know,” Scorpia admits. “I haven’t exactly been let out of this room to go and research it. The Horde keeps its location a secret.”

“Okay then, let’s get researching!” Bow says. “It can’t be too hard to find, right?”

Hopefully not, Adora wishes. And hopefully Catra will be able to wait for them, for just a little bit longer.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading. I know a lot of people have been looking forward to this so even though it's a bit short I hope y'all enjoyed it. Leave a comment to let me know what you think!

Also: let Glimmer swear 2k20

Next week: Catra gets a job.

nine to five yeah they got you where they want you there's a better life and you dream about it don't you

Chapter Summary

Catra gets a job.

Chapter Notes

I don't have much say, other than enjoy the chapter!

Song title: 9 to 5, Dolly Patron

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Things were going pretty great for Catra.

For starters, she found out that she has a living family. The Queens that have been nothing but kind to her since she came to Half Moon are her mothers. Not only that, but the people of Half Moon have started to accept her. It's not because she's the Princess (she hasn't exactly advertised that), but because she saved Lily from a beast.

More Magicats smiled and waved at her as she walked down the hallways. No one glared at her, or made her feel like she didn't belong. It was finally starting to feel like Half Moon is where she is supposed to be.

Because of that, the past couple days have felt like a dream. She floats around Half Moon, talking with Shire, Busto, C'yra or Ri'ta, and hasn't returned to the surface just yet. Actually, without her excursions she's starting to get a bit bored.

It's four days after saving Lily, and three after talking with the Queens, when C'yra approaches her shortly after breakfast.

“Catra!” C’yra calls out, a soft smile on her face. Shire and Busto had already departed for their daily tasks, leaving Catra alone to finish off her food.

She can’t help but smile back, “Hey C’yra. What’s up?” (She’s not ready to call C’yra mom. Not yet.)

“I wished to talk with you, for a moment,” C’yra says as she sits down. “I’ve noticed you haven’t returned to the surface recently. Does this mean your intentions to leave Half Moon are . . .?”

C’yra looks so hopeful. Catra reveals, “I decided that I wasn’t going to leave Purrsia for a while now. I just . . . wasn’t ready to be a part of,” she waves her hand in the air, “Everything yet.”

“I understand,” C’yra nods. “And now?”

“I . . . think I’m ready,” Catra admits. She hadn’t said it out loud yet, not to anyone, but it feels good to say it.

“I’m glad to hear it,” C’yra says with a grin. It’s probably the first time she’s ever seen C’yra smile like that, “Very glad.” She clears her throat, the smile fading, “But there are a few . . . responsibilities that come along with that.”

“Not any . . .” Catra lowers her voice to a whisper. “*Princess* things, right?”

“No, no, like I said, that’s not a problem,” C’yra insists. “However, you . . . do need to get a job.”

Catra stares at C’yra, “I’ve known that I’m your daughter for four days and you’re already kicking me out and making me get a job?”

“You have your own roo-” C’yra begins before deadpanning. “You really do have your mother’s sarcasm.”

She grins. It's not just C'yra's reaction, but being reminded that she's connected to C'yra and Ri'ta. It makes her feel warm.

"So, what about a job?" Catra continues.

"It's not a personal thing," C'yra clears up. "But every Magicat at a certain age has to join one of the factions. You know, soldiers, hunters, chefs, mages, scholars, merchants . . . it is a recent tradition, implemented because of the move to Half Moon and the Invasion. So, now that you are deciding to stay in Half Moon you must join a faction.

"Of course, you will get paid for your work and you get to choose what faction you'd like to join. I also think that I will help the other Magicats accept you, seeing you participate in our society, beyond throwing yourself in front of a beast to protect a kit."

"I can't really argue with that," Catra admits. "I've also been pretty bored."

C'yra chuckles, "Then, do you have an idea of what you'd like to join? Or would you like me to give you a tour of each? You can always switch factions if things don't work out, but you should make an informed decision."

"Do you have the time?" Catra checks.

"I wouldn't be offering if I didn't."

Catra has had a general idea of what each faction is, but no one has gone into an explanation with each. Plus, she doesn't mind the idea of spending the day with C'yra.

"Sure," she says with a shrug.

"Where would you like to start?"

"Soldiers."

The soldiers seem like a good first option, seeing as how she spent most of her life training to be one and the fact that one of her only two friends in Half Moon is a member. However, she begins to regret the decision as she and C'yra enter the training area.

She hasn't been back here since the incident with D'nah. With C'yra standing next to her, she feels as though she has a bit of protection. The soldiers pause as the two enter and stare at her.

While the rest of Half Moon may have warmed up to her since saving Lily, the soldiers seem to have not forgiven her from attacking D'nah.

Except for Busto, of course.

"Catra! Queen C'yra!" Busto calls out cheerily. (Catra and Busto had a long conversation after she found out the Queens were her mothers, because he knew it as well. He let her hit him and then everything was fine between the two of them.) He steps away from the soldiers he's training with and walks towards them, "It's good to see the two of you! What brings you to this corner of Half Moon?"

"Catra is going to join a faction," C'yra answers first. "It's been many years since I was a part of the soldiers, so maybe you would provide better insight."

"Ah, finally going to become a contributing member of society, eh Catra?" Busto teases.

"Shut the fuck up, Busto," Catra sighs.

"No I won't because I'm proud of you," Busto continues before she can snark at him again, "The soldiers are Half Moon's primary offensive force. We're responsible for protecting Half Moon in the case of danger, though there hasn't been much of that aside from the occasional beast and Horde drone. So, we spend most of our days keeping our skills sharp and training, or

taking turns at guard or patrol duty. If you choose us, I know that the soldiers will be gaining a great warrior!”

“Thank-you, Busto,” C’yra says. “What do you think? Or would like a dry-run with the other soldiers first?”

Catra scans the arena and most of the soldiers look away. With their frosty reception of her, it’s clear that she’s not wanted here. Things only get colder when General Az’al enters the training area.

Despite what Busto said, she has still not seen Az’al’s good side. While she looks calm and collected as she strides up to them, it’s clear there’s anger boiling inside her, kept back by her own walls. She simply says, “Queen C’yra, what are you doing here?”

C’yra doesn’t seem notice Az’al’s mood, and says with a smile, “I’m just introducing Catra to some of the factions, Az’al.”

“I thought it was *General* Az’al,” she counters. “Your Majesty.”

The smile falls from C’yra’s face, replaced with confusion. She awkwardly coughs, “Yes, well, uhm, Catra, what do you think? About the soldiers?”

Catra doesn’t want to get stuck between whatever’s going on between C’yra and Az’al, and she certainly wants to get out of this hostile environment. She shares a look with Busto and bluffs, “I wanna see the other factions before I make a decision.”

“That’s a fair choice,” Busto hops on, joining her in attempting to diffuse the situation. “I hope you have a good day and I’ll see you at lunch, Catra. General Az’al, there was something I wanted to talk to you about with the patrol schedules.”

Busto leads Az’al away, letting C’yra and Catra leave. C’yra seems to be lost in thought about . . . whatever just

happened, so she attempts to jolt the Queen out of her thoughts, “So, what’s next?”

C’yra blinks and comes back to reality, “Yes, sorry about that. Well, how about we do the Mage’s faction next? Ri’ta heads it.”

The thought of magic sends a shiver down Catra's spine, "No. I don't want to get anywhere near magic."

“I understand,” C’yra says. “Then what about the Scholar’s faction?”

“What do they even do?” Catra asks. “It seems like they just sit around the library all day and read books.”

“They run the Library, translating ancient manuscripts and keeping the books in their proper condition,” C’yra explains. “They also help other Magicats do research, they teach classes on their specified subject in our schools. But yes, they do spend a lot of time in the Library.”

“Sounds boring.”

C’yra laughs, "I have to agree. Next is the Chef's Faction."

"Jen'dots runs it, right?" Catra checks. She remembers when she and Adora got stuck kitchen duty as cadets, it actually wasn't the worst thing in the world. They wouldn't have to cook anything, just set-up meals and if they were sneaky enough, they could steal some extra food and hide in the fridge to eat.

"Yes, would you like to talk to her about it?" C'yra questions.

Jen'dots is very nice-even to Catra-and would probably be a nice boss. Plus, she does have fond memories of kitchen duty . . . or at least as fond as she could get in the Fright Zone. With a shrug, she answers, "Sure, why not?"

When they get to the kitchen the chefs are working hard on preparing for the lunch rush. The two of them squeeze past the chef's, who politely nod to the queen but are too busy to say hello. As they pass through, Catra can't help but snag some small portions of food, getting a taste test for what lunch was going to be today.

"Catra! Queen C'yra!" Jen'dots shouts over the bustle of the kitchen. She's at a desk in the back, consulting a hand-written book filled with bright tabs. "What brings you here today?"

"She's forcing me to get a job," Catra says, motioning to C'yra with a nod.

"Ah well, we all have to eventually," Jen'dots sighs.

"We were hoping to talk to you about the Chef's Faction," C'yra continues. "If you have the time."

Jen'dots closes the book in front of her, "Well, for once you aren't disturbing me during the rush so I think I can eek out a minute or two. Catra, I think you can tell what we do here, we make food, breakfast, lunch, dinner and the occasional midnight snack. Plain and simple. Any questions?"

Catra's eyeing a delicious smelling vat of some brown gooey substance, "What's that?"

"Cake batter."

"Can I have some?"

"That's not quite the question I was expecting."

"No, you could get salmonella," C'yra interrupts.

"What's that?" Catra asks.

"Ri'ta can tell you later, maybe you have some questions about the chefs rather than the food," C'yra suggests.

"Uh, so like," Catra tries to get her mind off her stomach. "I guess you're always pretty busy, right?"

"Yep, it's hard work being a chef, but rewarding," Jen'dots comments. "We take shifts. There's morning mid, and night shift, so you wouldn't be stuck here all day. Well, except for me but the kitchen's a second home to me. Catra, have you ever cooked before?"

"No," Catra admits. "But I had to prepare food back in the Fright Zone while I was a cadet. Like, put it out and stuff like you guys do. It was the only job I actually liked."

"That's a good sign," Jen'dots says. "If you're willing to work for it, I'm sure I could teach you to cook. You may be stuck on dish duty for a while, everyone has to start somewhere."

"Do I still get food?" Catra checks.

"Of course," Jen'dots says. She seems to realize something as she says that, but a flash of green through the white and silver of the kitchen catches Catra's eyes. Jen'dots comments, "Ah, the hunters must be bringing this morning's kills."

"Looks like Gr'wliger went out this morning," C'yra comments. "We should go and talk to him as well, Catra. He is in charge of the hunter's faction after all."

"Yeah, definitely," Catra agrees. She hasn't seen Gr'wliger since they first met. He honestly seems like a decent guy.

"Thank-you for your time, Jen'dots," C'yra says as the two leave.

"It's no problem," Jen'dots insists.

"Gr'wliger," C'yra says as she and Catra catch up to him outside the kitchen.

"Queen C'yra," Gr'wliger says with a small bow. He thankfully doesn't do it and greets Catra with a smile, "Catra. It's good to see both of you again."

"Thank-you," C'yra continues. "Catra's going to join a faction, and I was hoping you could tell her about what the hunter's do."

"I'm heading back to the hunter's quarters right now, if you two would like to join me, I can talk as well as show you around," Gr'wliger offers.

"Yeah, sure," Catra says. "I've never seen the hunter's quarters."

"It's closer to the entrance of the caves," Gr'wliger explains. "Easier to get in and out. Follow me."

Catra steps in stride next to Gr'wliger, leaving C'yra following the two of them as a third wheel, "So, I'm guessing you guys hunt and stuff? I saw you all out in the forest when . . . a few days ago."

"To put it simply, yes," Gr'wliger answers. "But, it's a bit more intricate than that. As hunters, we provide food for at least half of the meals. The other half comes from the farms."

"There's farms in Half Moon?" Catra questions, and turns to C'yra.

C'yra clears her throat, "Uhm, yes. We have chicken, pig, and vegetable farms run by the Clerics of Lyses. They're kept far away from the main caves because of the smell." She awkwardly rubs the back of her head, "We haven't told you about it for . . . security reasons. My apologies."

"Y'know, that's fair," Catra says. "I'm not mad. How do you even grow stuff underground?"

“Nonetheless,” Gr’wliger continues. “There isn’t enough space or skilled clerics to have a farm big enough to support everyone, so we still must rely on a decent amount of hunting and gathering.”

“Alright,” Catra folds her arms. “What else about the hunters can you tell me?”

“We're the only faction to go out onto the surface,” Gr’wliger reveals. “Which puts us in danger of the beasts or, Saz forbid, probes from the Horde. We have to be excellent hunters, experts in stealth, and great warriors too."

Catra's hadn't even thought about the hunters when C'yra told her about the factions, but Gr'wliger was managing to win her over. It didn't take much, he's not an ass plus the hunters are the usually the only people allowed out of Half Moon Caves. Catra got a pass for the longest time since she technically didn't live at Half Moon, but now that she's allied herself with the Magicats, would that change? She hasn't bothered to ask C'yra yet because it hasn't come up.

"I don't see a lot of you around the training ground if you're all great warriors," Catra points out. The surface thing may have sold her, but if the hunters are in a jerk league of their own (with Gr'wliger being the current exception) she may have to bow out.

"Yes, we have our own small, training area, but we actually do some training and drills on the surface, not too often," Gr'wliger explains. "Especially since our job is one that has to be done every day. Even though the stakes are more dire, I consider the hunters to be . . . a bit more relaxed than the soldiers."

Catra almost wants to ask Gr'wliger to let her join right there and then, but they've made it to the actual hunter's quarters.

It's a smaller cave, at least in the first room, and it's pretty . . . homey. There's a small reception desk near the doorway where a smaller black-furred Magicat is sitting with his feet up on the tabletop. Behind him in a fireplace with a small set of couches, and a Magicat has their green cloak pulled over their face as they nap. Off to the right is a large desk, very clean and organized, with a drawn-on map of Purrsia tacked up on the wall. Left to that is a doorway leading further into a new trail of caves,

"Welcome back boss," the black-furred Magicat greats Gr'wliger with a grin.

"Feet off the table, Sh'dowell," Gr'wliger sighs as he ducks through the doorway. "We have guests."

Catra enters second, with C'yra close behind. Sh'dowell almost falls off of the chair when he sees C'yra, "Queen C'yra! I-uh, ah-hem . . . hi?"

"Hello to you too, Sh'dowell," C'yra says, a smirk pulling at her lips.

"Sh'dowell, this is Catra, a potential recruit. Catra, this Sh'dowell, we became hunters together," Gr'wliger continues.

"Yeah, but he got the promotion faster," Sh'dowell jokes. He stands up (he's shorter than Catra, but next to Gr'wliger he looks like a kit) and holds out his hand, "Nice ta meet ya."

Catra gingerly shakes his hand as well, "Yeah uhm, same here."

"Gar'ett is sleeping on the couch over there, but we just got back from a morning hunt so let's not disturb her," Gr'wliger leads the group towards the doorway, Sh'dowell now tagging along.

"This is where I usually work, as Head Hunter I have to schedule hunting parties and shifts, as well as approve of hunting

routes, making sure we avoid beast dens while we're out on the surface," Gr'wliger explains.

He leads them to the next room, which appears to be a locker room of sorts. There are large cubbies built into the rock, each cubby having a few pegs to hang a cloak or a weapon. In front of them are long benches to sit on. At the other end of the room is another doorway.

"This is the locker room," Gr'wliger says.

"Though it lacks actual lockers," Sh'dowell points out. "It's a kit's coat room at school! Just like the one back at the Conservatory, you remember that?"

C'yra chuckles, "My, you're right. I had forgotten about the Conservatory rooms."

"You are, but I won't give you the satisfaction of laughing," Gr'wliger says. "There's not much to see here unless you'd like to rifle through someone's personal things. The break room and shooting range are this way."

The doorway leads to a small hallway that opens up in a large cavern. There seems to be two levels, with the entrance on the lower one. A thick, white line had been painted on the ground just before a field of targets at various distances.

A couple Magicats were standing around, all wearing green cloaks, watching a Magicat with slate fur knock an arrow and take aim. She doesn’t release it until one of the Magicats, holding a timer, shouts, “GO!”

She releases the arrow, loading the next one without seeing if the first had made its mark. By the time the first one hits-at the center of the bullseye-she’s already notching a third arrow. She continues the rapid-fire barrage of arrows and each missile hits the bullseye. Catra is almost impressed.

The very last arrows hit the ring just outside of the bullseye, but the archer's shoulders relax and she lowers her bow. The Magicat holding the timer shouts, "NEW RECORD!" The other hunters quickly rush the archer, all celebrating and jostling her shoulders. Her hood falls as they do so, and Catra catches her steely blue eyes. It hits her: the archer looks a lot like Az'al.

"Congratulations Demeter," Gr'wliger says over the shouting. "That was very impressive indeed."

"Yeah, and no better time to do it," Sh'dowell adds, pointing to C'yra. "You got a royal audience."

The other hunters stop and stare, before jumping to attention. Demeter remains relaxed, "Hi C'yra. Whatcha think?"

"Demeter, good job," C'yra says with a nod. "It's good to see how your aim has improved in the short time you've been with the hunters. I expect we will be seeing great things from you in the future."

Demeter beams at the praise, but her smile falters as her eyes wander to Catra, "What are you doing here?"

Okay, so that's how it's going to be. Catra saw how she reacted to C'yra's praise so she says, "C'yra brought me here, to see if I wanted to join the hunters."

"We're giving her the tour of our quarters, currently," Gr'wliger explains. "And while Demeter, it seems you have heard of Catra, Catra, this is Demeter of Bom'luri."

"She's Az'al's daughter," C'yra adds. "And also, my goddaughter."

"Yeah, C'yra convinced my mom to let me join the hunters when she had her freak-out about it," Demeter continues, but she gives Catra a steely glare as she does so.

“I’m glad she did,” Gr’wliger says. “You’re the best shot in Purrsia to my knowledge.”

“I just do my best,” Demeter insists. “But than-”

BOOM!

The explosion reverberates through the cavern, shaking the floor. Catra jumps up high in the air in shock and gets caught by C’yra as she comes back down. Her mind races with all the possibilities of what that could be, but all of them connect back to the Horde attacking Half Moon and-

None of the hunters seem perturbed.

Catra jumps out of C’yra’s arms before any comment can be made, and demands, “What was that?!”

“That . . . would be our inventor,” Gr’wliger sighs.

“Has Lionel’o been experimenting with explosives again?” C’yra asks.

“They’re not supposed to be. Queen C’yra, would you mind helping me remind them of this fact?”

“Of course,” C’yra looks to Catra. “Would you like to come with us, or get to know some of the Hunters?”

Catra glances at Demeter, “I . . . think I’ll come along. Why do the Hunters need an inventor anyways?”

She follows Gr’wliger and C’yra back into the small hallway. As he leads them through the winding corridor, he explains, “Lionel’o works for us . . . mainly because we let them do whatever they want. The soldiers want them to just make weapons, while we like to see what they come up with.”

“They’re a very talent engineer,” C’yra says. “And currently the only engineer in Half Moon.”

The three enter a small workshop filled with strange mechanical parts and broken inventions. Currently, everything is covered in a fine layer of soot. It reminds Catra of Entrapta's lair back in the Fright Zone.

A frazzled Magicat wearing a pair of goggles pops up from behind a table with a giant dent in it. Their fur is gray as well as the coat they're wearing (but that just might be the soot). They remove their goggles, revealing two perfect circles of white fur, "Uh . . . I didn't do it!"

"Lionel'o, you obvious did it because you're the only one who could possibly make an explosion that big," Gr'wliger points out.

"That's," Lionel'o waves a finger around in the air for a second before giving up. "Fair. I won't do it again!"

"You won't?"

"Alright that's a lie as well. I will definitely be doing that in the future, seeing as how I obtained the desired effect from my experiment."

"What even caused that?" C'yra asks.

Lionel'o lights up and wave their hands in the air for dramatic effect, "*Beast fur*."

"Beast fur?" C'yra echoes.

Lionel'o begins to scramble around their lab, before grabbing a jar filled with neon fur, "As we all should know, beasts are highly flammable-"

"Wait no, I didn't know that," Catra says.

"Don't interrupt me."

She continues to interrupt, “Beasts are flammable? Why did no one tell me this?”

“While they are flammable,” C’yra begins. “The forests of Purrsia are sacred to Lyses. A beast on fire in a forest full of trees is a recipe for disaster, so we usually use it as a last resort.”

Catra doesn’t want to get into a religious argument, so she just lets Lionel’o continues.

“Anyways, beasts are highly flammable because of the material their fur is made of,” Lionel’o continues. “So, I’ve been experimenting with ways to implement this trait in our everyday lives.”

“And what were you just trying to make out of . . . beast fur?” C’yra asks.

“A lamp.”

The three of them stare at Lionel’o and at the disaster in the lab around them. Catra speaks up first, “You can never meet Entrapta.”

“Who?”

“Anyways,” C’yra clears her throat. “Please do not do that again. We don’t want your explosions to endanger the structural integrity of the caves.”

“You know, you got a point there,” Lionel’o says. “So, I will not do that again in the future.”

“You won’t?” Gr’wliger checks again.

“That was another lie.”

“Please don’t,” C’yra repeats. “Otherwise, have a good day Lionel’o.”

With that, Gr’wliger takes Catra and C’yra back out to the reception area of the hunter’s quarters, “I hope I was able to provide a satisfactory tour.”

“It was,” Catra answers.

“Thank-you for your time, Gr’wliger,” C’yra says.

He politely bows as the two leave the Hunter’s quarters, and Catra has something to ask before C’yra can say anything, “What’s a goddaughter?”

“Oh, hhm, I forgot that you probably wouldn’t be familiar with the term,” C’yra says. “Well, basically, it basically just means that if anything happens to Demeter’s parent-meaning Az’al-I’d step in and care for her as I promised to Az’al.”

“Why? You and Az’al don’t seem to get along” Catra points out.

“We used to, I’m . . . not quite sure what is going on right now,” C’yra sighs. “But we were very close when you two were born. You both were born around the same time, you're about three months older, though. Az'al and I would talk about how you two would grow up to best friends like us."

Which didn't seem to work out great, in many cases, but Catra doesn't snark since the wistful look of nostalgia on C’yra’s face is tainted by sadness.

She continues. "I'd appreciate it if you could make an effort to being cordial with her. You don't have to be friends, and you've only known that I'm your mother for a few days now and I don't want to make you do anything you don't want to. But . . . it would be nice to see one thing work out."

"Yeah, sure," Catra agrees. She doesn't mind too much, since it shouldn't be hard to at least pretend to be nice to someone, especially someone she's known for less than a day.

"Thank-you," C'yra smiles again. "Well, I believe we've visited most of the factions . . . aside from the Clerics and the merchants but I have a feeling that either of those aren't your speed. What did you like the most?"

It's an easy answer. The soldiers were all insufferable, asides from Busto (which turns out to be quite surprising). She doesn't want to deal with any magic, so the Mages' and Cleric's guild are right out. Working with food might be nice . . . but it also might just make her hungrier. The Hunter's guild is really her only choice, but it's the best choice as well.

"Hunters," Catra says with no hesitation.

"From what I've seen, that sounds like a good choice," C'yra says. "Though, you'll have to get used to Lionel'o's explosions. I won't be there to catch you every time, kitten."

Catra's face burns up in embarrassment, "Uhg, shut up. It was and will be a one-time thing, alright?"

C'yra laughs, "Alright. I'll talk to Gr'wliger later about you joining them, but now . . . I think it's time for lunch. Would you like to join Ri'ta and I today?"

"Uh . . . sorry I was already going to eat with Busto and Shire," Catra says as she rubs the back of her head.

"That's alright, I'm glad you've made friends," C'yra says with a smile. "But, it seems like we'll be headed in the same direction."

As she and C'yra begin to head towards the cafeteria, for the first time in her life, Catra finds herself contemplating how far she'd come. She started off as a disgraced Horde soldier, but now she feels better than she ever has in her life. She feels like she belongs.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading! Leave a comment to let me know what you think?

our house it has a crowd there's always something happening and its usually quite loud

Chapter Summary

Catra gets roped into Gr'wliger's family dinner.

Chapter Notes

I hope you all enjoy the chapter!

Title: Our House, Madness

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's first day with the Hunters is made up of training.

It's nothing like the rigorous and sometimes cruel training Horde cadets went through, but that's probably because there was no real competition beyond friendly in the Hunters. No one vying for a spot at Force Captain, trying to prove their worth to a higher-up that sees them as just another body.

Also, to her surprise, just about everyone there is kind towards her. Sh'dowell tries to teach her how to play knife monopoly during their break (Gr'wliger prevents him from doing so), Gar'ett teaches her the basics of wielding a bow and how to hunt with her spear, and even Lionel'o comes out of their lab to pester her with questions (she almost makes the mistake of telling Lionel'o about the blasters the Horde uses). Everyone seems pretty nice . . . except for Demeter.

Demeter is giving her the cold shoulder, for one reason or another. Even after her talk with C'yra, Catra can't bring herself to be nice to someone who isn't putting in the effort for her.

But, overall, her first day went *really* well, to her surprise.

As the other Magicats pack up to leave for dinner, Gr'wliger approaches her, "Catra, how was your first day?"

"Good," Catra answers. "When do I get to go out on a hunt?"

Gr'wliger chuckles, "Patience, it's only your first day. But, seeing how adept you are already, most likely by the end of the week. However, I wanted to ask a favor of you."

"What's up?" Catra usually doesn't like the 'favor' game, but she figures that it's different from the 'give a little and get a lot taken' state of things in the Horde. Never in a million years would Catra be able to guess what Gr'wliger is going to say next.

"My parents have invited you to dinner," he says. "They want to thank-you personally for saving Lily."

"Oh," Catra stares at him for a minute, trying to comprehend the question. "Uh . . . I guess?"

"Thank-you. They were ecstatic to learn that you were joining the Hunters, and have wanted to express their thanks since you saved Lily," Gr'wliger says. "I'm heading home right now, if you'd like to accompany me."

"Why? We aren't eating in the dining hall?"

"No. Sadly, my father likes to cook for himself."

"Sadly?"

"While he may enjoy cooking . . . he is not good at it. At least he has the heart for it."

Well, if dinner turns out inedible, the dining hall is open late. With a shrug, she stands up and says, "Let's get going."

Gr'wliger leads her to the residential area of Half Moon. Her own room is located here, but near the entrance of the

expansive network of caves the Magicats live in. His own domicile is farther in, and he explains that the bigger ones are back there.

He stops her steps in front of his home. It looks rather inviting, with a sign that says 'The Pangur'ban's' on the door and a mat that reads 'Welcome' at the entrance. He says, "I must warn you before you enter. My family can be a bit . . . rowdy."

Though she had only met two members of the Pangur'ban Family-being Gr'wliger and Lily-it's hard for her to imagine it considering the kind and soft-spoken man before her. Lily can be high-energy, but she figures that all kids are like that (Saz knows *she* was like that).

With a shrug, she insists, "I can handle it."

"I just wanted to warn you," Gr'wliger says.

He opens the door and Catra is greeted with pure, unadulterated, chaos.

There's at least nine Magicats running around, all getting into each other's spaces. It instantly makes Catra claustrophobic.

Gr'wliger seems to notice this, and over the general cacophony, he whispers, "You can still back out."

"No. No. It's fine," Catra steels herself. "I can do it."

"Alright."

"Gr'wliger? Welcome back!" an older Magicat woman walks through the chaos to the door. The sea of siblings seems to part for her, so she must be the matriarch. She has the same dark brown fur as Gr'wliger, but her hair is starting to gray. Her eyes widen as she spots Catra, "Oh, and you must be Catra!" she clasps Catra's hands and vigorously shakes them, she's stronger than she looks, "My, I am very glad you were able to come and join us tonight, I can't even begin to express how thankful we are that you saved Lily!"

“It’s,” Catra gulps. “It’s not a big deal.”

“It is to us,” she continues.

“Ahem,” Gr’wliger clears his throat. “Mom, please don’t overwhelm Catra.”

“It’s fine,” Catra repeats. “It’s fine.”

“Also,” Gr’wliger continues. “Catra, this is my mother, Dee’cee.”

“Saz, I seem to have forgotten my manners,” Dee’cee sighs. “Like Gr’wliger says, I’m Dee’cee and I work as a blacksmith. But please, come in Catra! My husband, B’nks, is just finishing up dinner,” Dee’cee pauses and leans in to whisper, “Steel your stomach.”

Catra wades into the torrent of the Pangur’ban clan, with Gr’wliger guiding her through each of his siblings. In order, from oldest to youngest, there’s B’gheer, Cleo, Leo’na, H’bbes, Tawn’ee, Snaggl’th, and last but not least, Lily.

“CATRA!” Lily runs out of the crowds and latches himself onto her. “Hi.”

“Hi,” Catra laughs. She ruffles the hair on his head, “You doin’ alright?”

“No, I got grounded,” Lily pouts.

“For good reason!” Dee’cee interjects. “You scared all of us by running off on your own!”

Lily pouts, “I’m sorry.”

Dee’cee sighs and rubs his head, “I know. We’re all glad you’re safe now.”

He nods and watches as Dee'cee walks away. He looks up at Catra with wide eyes, "Thanks for savin' me."

"No problem," Catra says. She has the feeling that she's going to be repeating that a lot tonight.

"ALRIGHT KIDS!" a shorter man with tan fur steps out of the kitchen. He's wearing an apron that says 'kiss the cook' and Catra makes a mental note not too. He pushes glasses back up the bridge of his nose as he announces, "DINNER'S READY!"

She almost gets trampled on as everyone runs into the next room, but Gr'wliger stands beside her and shields her from the mad rush. Dee'cee laughs as Gr'wliger says, "You get used to that after a while."

"Yeah, but you're too big to be trampled on," Catra grumbles.

"That's fair," Gr'wliger sighs. "Also, that was my father B'nks. He's a tailor."

"Let's go eat, kids," Dee'cee says, leading Catra and Gr'wliger into the kitchen and dining room.

Catra is guided to sit down between Lily and Gr'wliger, thankfully, but she still gets instantly lost in the ten different conversations flying around the dinner table as everyone waits for food to be brought out. She thinks that it might quiet down once everyone's eating, but she's proven wrong. Even with food being shoveled into people's mouths, the conversation continues.

She takes her first few bites of food as she tries to drown out everyone else. B'nks' home-cooked meal is not as good as Jen'dots', but it beats anything she ever had in the Horde. It's . . . perfectly edible. She just focuses on eating.

So far, Gr'wliger has been politely talking with his siblings, but he stops to ask her, "Are you doing alright?"

"Yeah, yeah," Catra insists. "The food's good."

"Why, thank-you!" B'nks interrupts. "I try my best."

Catra simply hums when Dee'cee asks, "So Catra, are you excited to join the hunters?"

"I guess," Catra says. "Everyone there seems cool."

"Good," Dee'cee smiles. "I know you'll fit right in. Gr'wliger does a good job in making everyone feel welcome."

Catra looks at Gr'wliger, who is awkwardly rubbing the back of his neck. So, he doesn't like being the center of attention. She grins, "He certainly has."

"Y'know, we never thought he was going to become a hunter," B'nks says. He places a hand on the table, "When he was a kit, all he wanted to do was go out on adventures. He would run off on his own just like Lily did, to go exploring."

"You did?!" Lily exclaims, starry-eyed.

"Just because I did something doesn't mean that you should do it," Gr'wliger points out. "It was also much less dangerous then."

"That's no excuse for giving us a heart attack," Dee'cee says. "Well, multiple heart attacks. Remember the time we took a boat tour around Purrsia and you tried to overthrow the captain?"

"Ah yes," B'nks chuckles. "You convinced B'gheer to help you with your little mutiny."

Gr'wliger buries his face in his hands, while Catra just laughs. He looks at her and sighs, "It's not that funny."

"It is!" Catra cackles. "Do you have any more stories about Gr'wliger? I, for one, would *love* to hear them."

"No, no," Gr'wliger says. "We don't need more stories. I grew up. I'm an adult now."

"Yes," B'nks says with a cheeky grin. "You grew up into the bureaucratic wunderkind."

Catra almost spits out her drink, "What? What's a 'bureaucratic wunderkind'?"

"Oh, it's just a nickname we came up with when Gr'wliger started to get really interested in government," Dee'cee says. "It's a term of endearment. Our bureaucratic wunderkind."

Gr'wliger pouts, "Please stop embarrassing me."

"Isn't that our job as parents?" B'nks ask. "To embarrass you?"

"Oh, let's leave him alone for now, we've done enough," Dee'cee says, putting a hand on her husband's shoulder. "We didn't invite Catra here to tease Gr'wliger in front of her."

"That is true," B'nks sighs. "Sorry, son."

"It's fine," Gr'wliger insists.

'I mean, I'm fine with you teasing Gr'wliger," Catra says. "So, if you wanted to continue . . ."

"Maybe later," B'nks says. "But Catra, we really just wanted to let you know how much we appreciated your actions in saving Lily."

"I already said it's no problem," Catra tries to dodge the praises, but Gr'wliger's parents are not relenting. It's her turn to be embarrassed.

"I know, but it's a big deal to us," Dee'cee continues. "Our family has been very fortunate, as it was one of the only families that survived the Invasion completely intact."

"That's why family is very important to us," B'nks says. "We've done our best to keep everyone together, but we failed at that when we lost track of Lily."

"If we lost Lily . . . or anyone of our children," Dee'cee takes in a very shaky breath. "Well, we'd be devastated."

"And that's why we wanted to thank-you," B'nks concludes. "You have kept us whole."

Catra stares at Dee'cee and B'nks, not quite sure what to say about that. She murmurs, "No problem."

Dee'cee looks like she's about to say something else when Tawn'ee flings a spoonful of food across the table at their twin. She bolts up and shouts, "Hey! No playing with your food!"

"That sounds like our cue to leave," Gr'wliger says, pulling Catra out before a food fight starts.

He takes her outside to the hallway and lets out a deep sigh. Catra kicks the ground and mumbles, "You have a real nice family, Gr'wliger."

Gr'wliger smiles, "They can be a bit rambunctious, but I wouldn't have it any other way. And Catra," she looks up. "Thank-you. Not just for indulging my parents, but for everything else as well."

"Saz, not you too!" Catra groans. "Really, it's no problem! How many times do I have to say that!?"

"Hhm . . . at least four more," Gr'wliger says, completely straight-faced.

Catra stares at him, "I kinda hate you right now."

Gr'wliger lets out a hearty laugh, "If you say so. You can sneak away now, if you wish. I'll just let my parents know that you said goodbye."

“I’ll take you up on that offer,” Catra says.

“Then, have a goodnight,” Gr’wliger says as he opens the door. It’s still very noisy inside, “And I’ll see you tomorrow, bright and early.”

“See you,” Catra waves at him as he retreats into his abode.

She begins to walk along the corridors of Half Moon, not really knowing where she’s going. She just walks.

Dee’cee was right, the Pangur’bans have been very lucky. To survive the war with no losses. They might just be the only complete family in Half Moon . . . or they were. Now that Catra knows that C’yra and Ri’ta are her mothers, her own little family is whole.

Catra finds herself near the Queen’s quarters. At this time in the evening, they’re sure to be home. She may as well drop by . . . just because.

Chapter End Notes

BDG voice: "Hi I'm Gr'wliger of Pangur'ban, Safety Fan and Bureaucratic Wunderkind. Please address me as such."

So, I hope you all enjoyed the chapter! I . . . don't have the next one finished yet and we'll see if I get around to it within the next week. If not . . then we're getting dangerously close to the start of the school year and I may go on hiatus.

Anyways! Let me know what you think by leaving a comment and have a good day!

i know you are a cynic but i think i can convince you, yeah, cause broken people can get better if they really want to or at least thats all i have to tell myself if i am hoping to survive

Chapter Summary

Catra and C'yra train together.

Chapter Notes

I'M NOT DEAD YET

I swore to myself that I would publish this chapter over Thanksgiving break because I had like, 90% of it done but I ended up dragging my feet until the very last day. Uh, anyways. I'm back for a hot second. I've been busy with school and I'm not sorry that I haven't posted anything. Zoom university isn't fun.

But, on another note, this is one of those chapters that I've had parts done since like, the very beginning. So, please enjoy!

Chapter Title: Recovery, Frank Turner

See the end of the chapter for more notes

While the hunter’s quarters have plenty in the way of area to hone their skill, there’s no better place to train in combat than, well, the training grounds.

Gr’wliger reserved the space for the hunters for the entire morning, and Catra felt a bit odd being there without the harsh stares of the soldiers. They were all there for a drill Gr’wliger and Lionel’o organized, as somehow the latter had built a robotic beast

for the hunters to train with. Sadly, it was just as flammable as every other beast.

By the time the hunters had managed to put out the flames it was time for lunch. Catra has elected to stay behind and take advantage of the empty training area. While she is getting used to training with the hunters, she still prefers to train alone. A part of her thinks that they'll just see her as a Horde soldier and is wary of exuding too much of the Horde's ruthless fighting style. Alone, she's able to let loose.

Also, it's not like she has anything better to do. She'd be alone at lunch today anyways, with Gr'wliger on a hunt, Busto in a meeting, and Shire at a lesson. Better here with no one rather in the cafeteria with everyone yet feeling alone.

She starts with her usual warm-up before moving onto the training dummies. As she stares down one of the dummies, she hears someone entering the arena. Catra laments not being alone anymore and debates leaving, but she gets over it quickly when she sees it's just C'yra.

"Ah, fancy meeting you here," C'yra says with a smile. She's not wearing her cloak, but still has her sword at her side, so Catra thinks she may have come to train as well.

"Well, it is an open arena, C'yra," Catra points out. She's still not quite ready to call her or Ri'ta mom just yet, and maybe she never will. She's still trying to get used to the idea of even having parents, "What are you doing here?"

"Just to train, like most others who come here," C'yra says. "I was expecting to be alone but . . . if you're here, would you like to spar with me?

"I haven't seen you fight before," Catra points out. "Think you're up for it?"

"Catra, I've been fighting since I could walk," C'yra says. ". . . My mother insisted that it was more of 'me crawling around

the palace and smacking the guards in the knees with a wooden sword', but nonetheless, I was a warrior before I was a Queen. The real question is, are you sure you can handle me?"

"One way to find out."

She doesn't give C'yra a chance to prepare. If C'yra is really a warrior, she could handle a surprise attack. She claws at C'yra, but the Queen jumps back and taps her wrist. A shield made of light appears and her claws bounce off of them.

"Really?" C'yra peaks above the edge of the light shield.

"You dodged it," Catra shrugs.

C'yra draws her sword, gleaming gold, and says, "One moment, kitten. Some ground rules-"

"Don't draw blood, blah blah blah I got it," Catra rolls her eyes. "No come on, let's go." She attacks again. C'yra dodges the first two jabs, but the third one strikes her side. C'yra doesn't seem to even notice it.

Like lightning, C'yra attacks. Every time Catra tries to dodge the swing of her sword, she ends up feeling the blunt side of the blade smack her. It hurts, but somehow Catra has the feeling that C'yra's holding back. That just makes Catra want to fight more.

One strike of her claws bounces off of the shield again, however she scratches C'yra's arm with both hands. But once again, Catra is on the receiving end of C'yra sword. She wonders how the Queen can be so fast.

The two of them continue to trade blows, Catra receiving more hits than she manages to land, but after a while she starts to get a feel for the Queen's fighting style. C'yra manages to combine brute force and speed, a deadly combination for anyone unfortunate enough to end up against her on the battlefield. Catra

feels a bit of relief knowing that she'll never have to face C'yra in battle for real.

"We should take a break," C'yra insists after a while, but it looks like she's not even breaking a sweat.

"No, I can keep going," Catra argues. She thinks she's reached a breakthrough: using her claws forces her to get in close quarters with C'yra. That usually works with She-Ra, since that damn sword is too big to be used in tight space. However, C'yra is adept enough with her longsword that tight spaces aren't a problem. Maybe a longer weapon would help, and it's worth a try. She grabs the spear from her back and points it at C'yra, "I could go all day."

C'yra doesn't respond, just stares at the spear.

"What?" Catra arches a brow, waiting for C'yra to drop down into a fighting stance.

Instead she breaks from her stupor, smiles and reveals, "That spear was my mother's, you know. It was given to her when she ascended the throne, a gift from the Clerics of Saz."

Catra looks at the spear in her hands, "That sounds important. Why give it to me?"

"She wanted you to have it," C'yra insists. "She always talked about giving it to you herself, I'm just fulfilling one of her final wishes."

Catra gazes over the carvings in the staff, somehow it now feels heavier in her hands. It wasn't just a random spear anymore, it was C'yra's mother's spear . . . her grandmother's spear. That thought hits her like punch in the face from She-Ra. This was her grandmother's spear.

It was a strange connection to make. Her grandmother, who Catra must have met yet was too young to remember her,

cared about her enough to give her a prize possession like the spear.

And Catra doesn't know anything about her.

"What was your mom like?" Catra asks, a bit afraid to refer to a woman she barely knows as her grandmother.

C'yra smiles, "She was always a bit eccentric, but truly cared for her people so she was well endeared. She always made time for me; she once stopped a council meeting when I scrapped a knee. She loved being a mother, and a grandmother."

"So . . . she liked me?" Catra questions.

"She loved you, always insisting that Ri'ta and I bring you by for a visit," C'yra insists. "She very much wanted to see you grow up. She always talked like she was going to live forever."

"And she still gave herself to the Horde?" Catra says before her brain could think it over, and she realizes how insensitive that must be.

The reminiscing smile fades from C'yra's face as she solemnly nods, "Its a decision that I have still yet to come to terms with. I so desperately wished she didn't, she could possibly still be around today and . . . the years after her death was when I needed her most.

"But what you need to know is that she did what she thought was best for everyone, including you and I. The Magicats didn't know how cruel the Horde was, and we had been at peace with ourselves and the world for hundreds of years. She wanted to sustain the peace, because we were thriving but . . . years without war meant that we weren't at our best. She gave herself to the Horde hoping to keep peace on Purrisa . . . but she didn't know that the Horde would not keep their promise and kill her."

Catra knows the true nature of the Horde first hand and her first response is some snark. Of course, the Horde did that,

they're the *evil* Horde. But like C'yra said, the Magicats didn't know how evil the Horde truly was.

"The Invasion would have happened whether or not my mother became a martyr," C'yra continues. "And I believe we would have had to retreat to Half Moon anyways. But, would my mother still be here, or would she die to the Horde eventually? What could change and what was always meant to be?"

"Would I have been taken by the Horde?" Catra plainly asks. All this talk about what could be and could not be. Catra wants to avoid mind games and get to the bottom of the cryptic statement.

"Don't blame your grandmother for that, if anything blame me," C'yra says with a heavy sighs. "I was overwhelmed after becoming Queen, right at the beginning of a war. I tried to be a ruler, a warrior, a mother, and a grieving daughter all at once. Something had to give, and it was the most important thing of all."

Catra could very easily play the blame game. It’s easy to blame. Blame Adora for how Shadow Weaver treated her, blame Adora’s friends for stealing her away, blame Entrapta for winning Hordak’s favor, oh so easy to blame everyone. But it’s just another mind game from the Horde, keep you paranoid and unquestioning. It was never the Horde’s fault, it was yours. But it was the Horde’s fault. Everything bad that has ever happened to her, at its core it's the Horde's fault.

“I don’t blame you,” Catra spits out, and C’yra’s eye is wide as Catra confesses. “It’s not your fault, it’s not your mom’s fault, we all just got put into a shitty situation because of the fucking Horde. They ruined our lives.”

Catra wants to look away but C'yra's faster, as she steps forward and gives Catra a hug. It's not as bad as Scorpia's, and the urgency makes it seem desperate. Catra considers hugging

her back, but she steps away as she realizes, "Oh scat, I'm so sorry I should've asked you-"

"Yeah, but uh," Catra interrupts the rushed apology. "It wasn't a . . . bad hug. I know someone who can do a lot worse."

C'yra raises a brow, "Is that permission for me to hug you again?"

"Uh . . ." Catra looks everywhere else as she rubs the back of her head. "May . . . be?"

"You don't sound too sure of it."

"Yeah sure. Fuckin' hug me. Go ham."

C'yra steps forward slower this time and wraps her arms around Catra in a light hug. Catra even decides to hug her back, because this feels . . . really nice, surprisingly. Even though Scorpia's hugs were painful, they had grown on her in an annoying way, so a normal hug from someone who cared for her was something . . . different, yet nice.

C'yra lets go of her and Catra almost protests, but C'yra keeps a hand on her shoulder, "I . . . I know a lot of people blame me or my mother for a lot of things surrounding the Horde Invasion, myself included. It's going to take me a while to see it your way . . . but thank-you."

"I'm still working on the whole blame thing myself," Catra admits.

"Ah-hem."

Catra and C'yra whip their heads to the entrance of the arena, where Az'al is standing with a few soldiers behind her.

"Sorry to interrupt this . . ." Az'al waves her hand, trying to remember a word. "Moment, your Majesty, but the arena is for fighting."

Catra wants to snap back, a jab already on her tongue, but with furrowed brows C'yra says, "Fair enough, General Az'al. Catra and I were just leaving, we wouldn't want to distract your soldiers from their training."

C'yra starts to leave, and Catra considers staying back and making a scene because it's not fair but the air in the arena has suddenly become thick with an unknown tension. It's so stretched that it Catra was to stress it, it would snap. So instead, she follows C'yra and glares at Az'al as she leaves.

Outside the arena, C'yra lets out a deep sigh. Catra sulks behind her and huffs, "What's her fuckin' problem?"

"As I said, many people blame me for some of the events surrounding the Horde Invasion," C'yra begins, sounding tired. "Losing the surface, the death of loved ones . . . Az'al is one of them."

"Aren't you two like, friends?" Catra checks.

"Before the Invasion? Very good friends," C'yra answers. "Afterwards . . . well, I can't say I'm sure."

Catra can't help but think of Adora, who was her best friend. Now that Catra's been separated from the Horde, it's easier to admit that she misses her, misses being able to talk to her and play games with her. Catra can only imagine that it's worse to miss someone who's right there.

"But, that's my issue," C'yra gathers herself. She looks around, "If you're still up for training, I know of another place."

"Yeah, let's go," Catra agrees.

C’yra leads Catra to a part of Half Moon Cave she’s never been to before. Through winding tunnel halls, they finally enter an open cavern with glowing mushrooms cascading from smaller alcoves at the top. The mushrooms illuminate the interior and give the whole room an ethereal glow.

Catra gasps when they enter, but C'yra just smirks, "I had the same reaction. I was wandering around one day and found this place . . . it might be a bit selfish of me for having kept it a secret, but I come here when I want to be alone."

She's surprised that C'yra is sharing such a special place with her, so she mutters, "Thanks for showing me this."

"Of course, kitten," C'yra ruffles her hair. "Now, want to get back to it?"

Catra mirrors her smirk, "Let's."

They take their places across from each other, and only wait a beat before they begin sparring again. This time, Catra knows that C'yra's faster and stronger, so she spends more of her energy on trying to outsmart her rather than overpower her. It's how she prefers fighting anyways.

Trading blows back and forth and dodging most of them, Catra and C'yra fall into a comfortable pattern. Attack, dodge, attack, dodge. For the first time in a long time, Catra's having fun while training. She figures that they'll just go until one of them is utterly exhausted, until something strange happens.

As Catra arcs her claws down, she feels a strange warmth course through her body. The burning feeling ends at her fingers as flames lick at her claws and trail in the air as she attacks. C'yra dodges, but both of them stop and stare at each other in shock. The fire has faded, but Catra can still feel the warmth between her fingers. She manages to stammer, "What . . . what was that?"

C'yra threads her fingers through her hair and laughs, "I . . . I think you just used the Stone of Saz."

Catra looks at her hand and wonders if she can summon the fire again at will. She doesn't know exactly what triggered it. As she flexes her fingers she asks, "How do I do it again?"

“To be honest, I don’t know,” C’yra says with a shrug. “I can't use it.”

“What do you mean you can’t use it?” Catra asks. “I thought every Princess could access their Runestone?”

“First off, I’m not a Princess.”

“Yeah,” Catra rolls her eyes. “But you should still be able to access its power, no matter your title.”

“I just can’t,” C’yra insists. “Never have. Deut’ron said I was always thinking too hard, or something. It’s not like it would make a difference for me.”

So far, Catra has seen that C’yra doesn’t need to use a Runestone to fight. She’s been able to keep up with Princesses, and the Magicat Queen was giving her a run for her money. C’yra might even be able to take on Adora in She-Ra mode without breaking a sweat.

“But,” C’yra continues. “If you’re able to access the power of the Stone of Saz, you’re going to have to learn how to use it. I don’t want you accidentally setting things on fire.”

“That sounds fun, though.”

“Kitten, no,” C’yra sighs as Catra laugh.

“Are you gonna teach me how to use it then?” Catra asks.

“I mean, I can try to remember what my mother taught me, but like I said I never used any of it,” C’yra scratches her chin. “But Deut’ron can do it. He’s the only cleric of Saz we have now, after all.”

Catra hasn’t seen Deut’ron since she first found the Temple of Saz. He’s probably just been chilling at Saz’s Shrine since.

"So, do I just go and ask him to train me?" Catra asks.

"I can ask," C'yra offers. "I'd love to come along and help where I can, if you'd like."

"Yeah, sure," Catra readily agrees. Deut'ron is nice and all, but she'd feel better if C'yra was there.

"Good," C'yra smiles. "I'll ask and we can do it next time we're all free. But as for now, I think it's almost time for dinner."

"Oh shit," Catra hadn't even noticed. She may have missed lunch to spar with C'yra, but it was worth it. Without thinking she asks, "Can we do this again?"

"You mean, us training together?" C'yra checks. Catra feels embarrassed, for whatever reason, but even with the blush rising to her cheeks she fervently nods. C'yra beams, "Of course. I'd like that very much. But, c'mon kitten, let's go eat."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Leave a comment if you want to help me survive finals so that I can try to continue this in December! But for now, I'm going to go back onto hiatus and if you don't hear from me, just assume that I'm drowning in school work.

If you'd like to occasionally hear from me, you can follow me on Twitter at shutupimshakira. I . . . don't talk about this fic often, but I have other inane ramblings that you may be interested in. Otherwise, I hope you all are staying safe!

life is old there older than the trees younger than the mountain blowing like the breeze

Chapter Summary

Catra goes on a hunt.

Chapter Notes

So uh . . . I know I said that I was going to go back on hiatus because of school but them we hit 900 kudos and 400 comments on this fic and I figured I would celebrate with the next chapter! Thank-you all so much for liking this fic and commenting it, even with how busy I've been recently. Let's see if we can get this baby over the 1k kudos mark!

After this, I probably will disappear for a while because I really need to focus on school. But once again, thank-you all and enjoy the chapter.

Title: Country Roads, John Denver

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra joined the hunters because it would give her a chance to continue to explore Purrsia while also getting shit done. She quickly found out that it was not all fun and games.

Gr'wliger has hunting paths planned out that avoid areas with high beast populations. It seems like too much work, but Catra can see why he went through the effort knowing how many people were lost after the Invasion just due to the heightened beast activity. Catra does her best to follow the trails but . . . she's never been that good at following rules.

Today, she's out with Gr'wliger, Gar'ett and Demeter. Gr'wliger, she doesn't mind, and the two have been talking more ever since she had dinner with his family. He's even been sitting with her, Shire and Busto at lunch more. Gar'ett is cool too, and

has been Catra’s primary teacher when it comes to hunting. Demeter however . . . the two of them do not get along, at all. Maybe it's because she's Az'al's daughter, no longer has the favor of C’yra, or maybe she hates Catra because of the whole Horde thing.

That's probably why Gr'wliger came along in the first place, to make sure that Demeter and Catra don't rip each other's throats out. (Gar’ett tends to be pretty passive, noted when she did not to try and stop Sh’dowell from helping Lionel’o with a new project involving explosions and knives. Thankfully, no one died.)

The quartet stalks along the paths carefully, watching out for movement in the underbrush signaling the presence of game . . . or a beast. Hopefully it's not the latter.

It's a new trail for Catra. She is usually assigned to one that keeps the hunters closer to Half Moon, most likely since she’s new. Even in her prior adventures on the surface, she hasn’t gone this way. It just makes her more excited and she tries to spot new landmarks she hasn't seen on the island before.

"Are you even looking for prey?" Demeter hisses as she stops at a bush of berries Catra walked straight past.

"I haven't done this trail before," Catra argues and comes up with an excuse. "I'm just getting my bearings."

"Yeah, well you should be getting these berries," Demeter argues.

"Hush," Gr'wliger commands and the two instantly fall silent as his ears flicker, Catra wonders if he's heard anything.

Gar’ett takes the initiative, walking forward and drawing her bow. She releases it, and the arrow flies through the air into the underbrush.

As Gar’ett goes to get her kill, Gr’wliger turns to Catra and Demeter to say, “Please, remember we are on a hunt. But

Catra's right, it's better that she gets her bearings for the next time she has to come down this path. That's why there's four of us here today."

"Right," Catra sighs with a smirk, glancing at Demeter. She pointedly ignores Catra and doesn't say anything, just pushes past her to grab the berries she missed.

Catra does her best to avoid Demeter for the rest of the hunt, as much as she can. About an hour later they reach the end of the trail and catch enough to head back. But, through the trees, Catra notices something strange.

She takes a few steps off the path and brushes away a few branches to get a better view. At the bottom of a valley, surrounded by greenery, is another temple. Most of it has been reclaimed by the Earth, swallowed by vines and moss, but the very top of it can still bath in the sun's rays. The peak of it is level with Catra's sight, and a giant emerald gleams in the sunlight. The decorative topper is what caught her eye.

"Catra?" Gr'wliger calls out. He steps behind her and pauses as he sees the Temple, "Ah, the Temple of Lyses. We usually don't come out this far."

"Another temple," Catra mutters. "How long has it been abandoned?"

"Probably since the fall of Purrsia," Gr'wliger says. "But it's always been . . . integrated with nature. I only came here once or twice as a child, so I can't say how different it looks on the outside." Gr'wliger glances to Catra and states, "You want to explore it."

"A little bit," Catra says. She glances at the kills Gr'wliger is carrying, "But we've got to get back to Half Moon."

Gr'wliger continues to study Catra, "You're going to come back here later."

Catra stares at him, “Are you a mind reader or something?”

“No,” Gr’wliger chuckles. “But I know you were wanderlust before joining the hunters, it only makes sense.”

“Are you going to stop me?” Catra asks.

“I don’t think I could if I tried,” Gr’wliger admits. “But . . . exploring the Temple sounds fun. I’d appreciate it if you’d let me come with you.”

“Really?” Catra quirks an eyebrow.

“Yes,” Gr’wliger says. “It’d be safer that way, too.”

She remembers falling through the floor at the Temple of Saz, so Gr’wliger may have a point. Plus, there’s a strange, excited gleam in his eyes about the prospect of an adventure like this.

“I’m in too.”

Catra jumps and turns around to find Gar’ett standing there, “How long have you been there?”

“Since Gr’wliger came over,” Gar’ett says. “It’s not like I’m going to go anywhere without you two. It’s dangerous.”

“Do you really want to come along?” Catra asks.

“Yeah. One of my moms was a Cleric of Lyses, and we used to visit the Temple all the time. I was pretty young since I’ve been here last, but I’d like to see it again.”

“The more the better, I guess?” Catra shrugs. Once again, she doesn’t mind Gar’ett and it might be fun to explore with her . . . acquaintances. Co-workers? Can she say friends yet?

“Hey,” Demeter pokes her head into the small clearing. “Are you three coming or not?”

"We are," Gr'wliger says. He pats Catra's shoulder, "Let's go."

They travel back to Half Moon, and make it there just before lunch. Catra ends up eating with Gr'wliger and Gar'ett since Busto and Shire are both busy. Afterwards, the three of them return to the hunter's HQ to prepare for their little adventure.

They take weapons, obviously. Gar'ett manages to sneak some snacks away from the kitchen and Gr'wliger grabs a backpack with rope, a grappling hook, first aid kit, torches, and more supplies inside. It's so practical that Catra wonders why she never thought of that between her many infirmary visits.

"Are we all ready?" Gr'wliger asks.

"Wait!" Demeter runs in. "I want to come too."

"What?" Catra asks. She was looking forward to this, but Demeter coming along would just kill her good mood. "Why?"

Demeter smirks, "Someone's got to keep you out of trouble."

"I don't go out looking for trouble," Catra argues. Trouble finds her, whether she wants it or not.

"If we are to do this," Gr'wliger interjects, stopping their bickering. "Both of you must agree to get along."

Catra and Demeter glare at each other, and turn away with crossed arms, "Fine."

Gar'ett sighs, "I should have packed more snacks."

"I have rations in the backpack," Gr'wliger reveals. "So, let's go, if we are to get to the Temple of Lyses and back before nightfall."

The quartet leave Half Moon, and now that they aren't hunting, they can engage in some quiet conversation.

"So, do the clerics of Lyses use the Temple at all? Or is it completely abandoned?" Catra asks Gr'wliger, hoping to keep her mind off of her unwanted travel companion.

"I believe it is completely abandoned," Gr'wliger says. "The Clerics usually keep to the Shrine and Lyses' temple is not connected to any underground tunnels, like the Temple of Saz."

"Gr'wliger," Demeter hisses. "Shouldn't we be keeping that a-"

"I know where the Temple of Saz is," Catra cuts Demeter off. "And that it's connected to Half Moon."

Demeter narrows her eyes suspiciously, "How?"

Catra doesn't want to tell her that she fell through the floor like a chump, so she lies, "I talked with Deut'ron, since, y'know, I respect my elders and care about what they have to say."

"Really?" Demeter questions.

"I do," Catra insists.

"Then name five other elders in Half Moon," Demeter challenges.

She stops and stares at Demeter, "Ah uhm, well . . . Deut'ron is one of them . . ."

"I said *other*. Like other than Deut'ron."

"Ah hhm . . ."

"If you two won't get along, I am heading back to Half Moon right this instance," Gr'wliger sighs.

Catra and Demeter share another glare, but they both drop the subject. The only one who talks is Gar'ett, who pulls a bag of granola out of her backpack, "Either of you want some granola?"

It remains tense until they make it back to the ridge that overlooks the Temple of Lyses. Slowly, they climb down into the valley and find the open entrance to the Temple. A curtain of vines obscures it, blocking off the darkness inside.

"Be careful," Gr'wliger reminds everyone as he passes out torches. Gar'ett pulls out a small lighter to aid in lighting them as he continues his speech, "Never go anywhere on your own and watch out for warped floors. Those could give out underneath us."

Catra grimaces as she remembers falling in the Temple of Saz, "Got it."

Gr'wliger leads the group into the Temple, torch raised high and lighting their path forward. As soon as Catra steps inside, it immediately feels different from the Temple of Saz. The Temple of Saz was all stone and carvings, but here . . . the gleaming crystal has faded over time due to the harsh elements. This is more like the Beacon in the Whispering Woods.

This realization must've slipped past her walls somehow, as Demeter turns to her and asks, "What are you doing? Are you scared? You're the one that wanted to come here."

"I'm not scared!" Catra loudly proclaims. She immediately calms herself down, because who knows what could be in here-beasts or maybe even worse, a homicidal light projection with a penchant for displaying the past. With a deep breath, she reiterates, "I think we should just be careful, like Gr'wliger said."

Demeter doesn't look convinced, but continues forward. Catra picks up the pace to keep in time with the others, and eventually they reach the end of the long hallway.

Unlike the Beacon, the central room doesn't look like a command hub, rather it's similar to the shrine. There's a pedestal at the other end of the room where it looks like a statue used to sit upon, but now it's empty. Other than that, there's nothing, not even doors. Though it all seems so plain, Catra can't help but feel anxious.

"Huh, I guess there's nothing here," Catra says.

"No," Gar'ett argues. She looks rather confused, "There used to be a statue here, and hallways."

"I remember that too," Gr'wliger agrees.

"Did they take the statue when they moved to Half Moon?" Demeter asks.

"No, the statue in the Shrine of Lyses looks nothing like the one that was here," Gar'ett insists. She walks up to the pedestal, "I wonder . . ."

Catra wants to yell out, to stop her from touching the pedestal, but as soon as she does the room lights up in shades of pink, purple and blue. Two hallways open up, revealing long, dark passageways. A humanoid figure flickers to life above the pedestal, wearing a light cloak with hood and holding a branch in its hands. It raises the branch but then freezes . . . until it starts to flicker and the room begins to shake.

"Oh no," Catra groans.

"What's going on?" Demeter asks.

"We need to leave," Catra says. "Now."

Gr'wliger and Gar'ett don't need to hear anything else, and begin to make their way towards the exit. Catra would follow them, if Demeter didn't stop her.

"Did you know this was going to happen?" she demands.

“What?” Catra asks. But shakes her head as she realizes what’s happening around them, “Doesn’t matter, let’s get out.”

But it’s already too late. As soon as Gr’wliger and Gar’ett step over the threshold to the room, a wall closes behind them and blocks Catra and Demeter inside. Everything stops shaking . . . but they are now trapped.

“Fuuuuuck,” Catra hisses. She runs up to the door and bangs on it, “Gr’wliger! Gar’ett! Are you okay!?”

“We are!” Gr’wliger shouts through. “Is everything alright in there?!”

Catra glances around, “It doesn’t look like anything wants to kill us . . . yet.”

“Yet?” Demeter questions. “You know something.”

“Maybe I do!” Catra says. “And what I know is that we need to *get out of here*.”

“Are the hallways inside still open?” Gar’ett asks.

Demeter glares at Catra but answers, “Yes, they are!”

“There should be an exit around the back, if I remember correctly,” Gar’ett says. “If you two head that way through the Temple, me and Gr’wliger can try to meet you around back.”

“That’s as good of a plan as we’ve got,” Catra sighs. “Alright, we’ll meet you back there.”

“And remember,” Gr’wliger adds. “Work together and don’t leave each other alone.”

Catra and Demeter share an uncertain glance. Catra knows that it would be safer to stay with Demeter . . . but it wouldn’t be fun.

“See you soon,” Gr’wliger concludes, and as she hears his and Gar’ett soft footsteps echo down the hallway and through the door, Catra knows she is alone with Demeter.

“Well,” Demeter steps back. “Let’s go.”

This was going to be difficult.

Without another word, Demeter chooses one of the two hallways and begins to walk. While Catra would normally bitch about her doing this without consulting her, she glances at the projection on the pedestal and decides to keep her mouth shut.

She has to run to catch up with Demeter, who is briskly walking through the Temple. Catra huffs, “We have to be careful.”

Demeter doesn’t look at her or answer her question. Instead, she asks, “How do you know about the Temple?”

Catra frowns, “Doesn’t matter.”

“Doesn’t it?” Demeter says. “We’re trapped here now. What do you know about this place and why?”

“What I know about it is that it’s dangerous,” Catra says with a scowl. “It will play mind games with you, so stay sharp.”

“You answered the what but not the why.”

“There’s one on mainland Etheria.”

“And you were there because?”

“What do you want?” Catra sighs, running a hand through her hair. “Can’t we just drop this and focus on getting out?”

“Hhm . . . no.”

“Fine. Whatever. You know why I was there? I was on a mission for the Horde. But I’m not with the Horde anymore. I’m trying to change.”

Once she had said the truth, Demeter stops asking questions. But the silence quickly became unbearable.

"Is that why you don't like me?" Catra asks as she glares at the back of Demeter's head.

Demeter turns around, holding the torch high, "Why do you care? You don't seem like the type of person to give a shit about what others think."

She usually tries to live that way, but with Demeter, there's something else going on, "I don't. But C'yra wants us to get along, or whatever. So, is that why don't you like me? Because I was with the Horde?"

"Why don't you like me?" Demeter tries to counter.

"Because it's clear you don't like me," Catra says. *And I can't figure out why you don't like me,* but that goes unsaid, "But really. Is it because I used to be a Horde soldier?"

"You just said, you aren't one anymore."

"Because your mom doesn't like me?"

"No," Demeter scowls. "My mom and I don't get along all that great right now either."

If Demeter isn't getting along well with her mom, then maybe it has something to do with her godmother, "So it's because I'm spending a lot of time with C'yra and you aren't?"

"I wasn't hanging around C'yra lot before you showed up," Demeter insists. "She pays attention, but she only steps in when my mom gets too over-protective."

"You seemed to be very receptive from her praise."

"Who doesn't like getting recognized by the Queen?" Demeter stops and stares at Catra again.

"Ah, so that's it. It's because I'm getting C'yra's praise and you aren't."

"No, it's not!" Demeter shouts.

"Then what is it!?"

Catra's words echo off through the walls of the Temple. The darkness is replaced by a harsh red light, and she immediately knows that somehow, she fucked up.

"We need to move," Catra says. She grabs Demeter's hand and tries to run.

"Wait, why?" Demeter demands.

"I forgot about the killer robots."

"You FORGOT about the KILLER ROBOTS?!"

"Listen, at the other Temple I was dealing with the fallout of turning against my childhood friend and having my shitty memories play out again in real time so sorry if I forgot about the spiders!"

Demeter blinks, "That's a lot to unpack but let's move."

The two begin to run in one direction, hoping that they can avoid whatever dangers have just been activated. They turn the corner and find their path blocked up a horde of tiny, robotic creatures with red evil eyes. This temple didn't have robotic spiders . . . they had robotic squirrels.

"I thought you said they were spiders," Demeter whispers as she slowly backs away.

Catra follows suit, tip-toeing in the reverse direction and hisses, "In the other place they were these big-ass spiders. But I guess squirrels are more manageable."

Until the horde of squirrels lunged at them.

"Never mind!" Catra yelps and starts to run.

She and Demeter go back and take a different route, the tiny, mechanical squirrels following and nipping at their heels. Catra has to brush a few off before they bite her with their sharp teeth, and Demeter draws two swords to slice a couple squirrels in half.

Eventually, their longer legs allow them to gain ground against the scurrying of the squirrels. After crossing the threshold into another room, the door closes behind them. The squirrels run into the door and the sound of them knocking into it echoes through the room. Catra would be worried that they might break down the door . . . if they weren't so small.

Scanning the room, Catra finds that it's identical to the first one, except this one doesn't have a pedestal. A long hallway leads into the darkness, so she hopes that this is the exit. First thing's first, her legs give out and she slumps on the floor.

Demeter does the same, sliding down against the wall and staring at Catra. With a sigh, she says, "Look, there's nothing wrong with mutual animosity as long as neither of us ever act on it, alright?"

Catra doesn't know why Demeter's not liking her is getting under her skin, but it's probably because (for once) she didn't do anything. Still, she promised C'yra she would get along with her. The Queen will have to live with a little mutual animosity. She sighs, "I can live with that. But I'm going to find out why you don't like me."

"Good fucking luck," Demeter stands up and holds out her hand to Catra, "Let's get out of here."

As soon as she helps Catra stand up, a deep voice echoes down the hallway, "Demeter? Catra?" Gr'wliger runs into the room, Gar'ett right behind him. He lets out a loud sigh when he

sees that the two of them are fine, “I am very glad to see the two of you. Did you have any trouble getting out?”

“There were squirrels,” Catra says.

“Evil robot squirrels,” Demeter adds.

Gr’wliger and Gar’ett stare at the two, but eventually the latter shrugs and pulls out a bag of granola, “That sounds fair. You two must be hungry.”

“I am, thank-you Gar’ett,” Catra grabs the bag of granola. Gr’wliger is still staring at her, so with a mouthful of granola she mumbles, “Wha?”

“Nothing,” Gr’wliger closes his eyes and pinches his nose. “Well, it’s good to see that you two are getting along.”

Demeter and Catra share a glance and laugh.

“No, we’re not,” Demeter says.

“Yeah,” Catra grabs more granola. “Far from it.”

“Save some granola for me.”

“No.”

“Then give me some now before you hog it all.”

“No!”

“Okay,” Gr’wliger shakes his head, looking more confused than before as he watched Demeter try to swipe the bag to granola from Catra. “Anyways, if there really are . . . evil robot squirrels here, we should leave.”

No one can argue with that. What Catra and Demeter do argue about is granola, and eventually Gar’ett revokes their granola privileges. Catra wasn’t expecting to go exploring with her friends and . . . target of mutual animosity?

Of course, as she leaves the Temple, one thought still remains in her mind. She had hypothesized about the First One's connection to the deities of Purrsia, but the Temple of Lyses only confirmed it. She wonders how deep this connection runs . . .

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading, please leave a comment and kudos if you have enjoyed it! If you'd like to hear more from me and about other projects I work on or watch me talk about Christmas specials, you should follow me on Twitter at Sniperdoodle12. I'll see you all (hopefully) after I survive finals (hopefully)!

ive seen fire and ive seen rain ive seen sunny days that i thought would never end

Chapter Summary

Catra trains with C'yra and Deut'ron to learn how to use the Stone of Saz.

Chapter Notes

Happy holidays! I hope you all are enjoying the time off, I know I'm trying to after surviving finals. But, here's the newest chapter! My goal for winter break is try to get to the half-way point of this fic, but we'll see.

Another note, Lara_84 made some really cool fanart for this fic, so you should go check it out here !

Chapter Title: Fire and Rain, James Taylor

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Unlike yesterday when it was warm and sunny and the perfect day to explore, today is overcast and rainy. As someone who likes to avoid water or getting wet in any capacity, having to go out and hunt in the rain wasn't fun for Catra. She's glad she let Gar'ett convince her to wear boots, because as she returns to the hunter's HQ, utterly drenched, she kicks off the mud-caked boots and slumps on the bench.

"You look miserable," Sh'dowell says.

"I don't like water," Catra grumbles, pulling off her cloak and wring it out. Water drips and pools onto the ground at her feet.

"We have like, a heater around here," Sh'dowell says. "I can drag it into the main room if you just want to curl up on the couch. I've done that a couple times after a rainy-day hunt."

She sighs, “As nice as that sounds, I’ve got to go and do something.”

“What something?”

Catra’s not sure how much she should reveal, so she simply says, “I wanted to talk with C’yra.”

Today is the day she’s going to start training with Deut’ron to learn how to use the Runestone. Since being able to use it is a surefire sign of being a princess, she wants to keep it on the down-low. Once she gets dried off, she’s going to go meet up with C’yra to head to the Temple of Saz.

“Ah, cool,” Sh’dowell says. “Well, let me grab you some towels because uh . . . you look pretty moist.”

“Don’t say moist.”

“I will say moist all I want!” Sh’dowell insists. She tosses a muddy boot at him but he just laughs and still gets her towels.

After using way too many towels to try and dry off her clothes and fur, Catra has to run through the caves of Half Moon to get to the meeting spot on time. She runs into the Shrine of Saz, “Sorry I’m late! It’s gross outside.”

C’yra and Deut’ron are the only people in the Shrine right now, and turn to look at her while she enters. The former smiles and says, “You don’t like the rain?”

“Not at all,” Catra grumbles.

“Your mother doesn’t like the rain either,” C’yra continues. “Something about the feel of it on her fur?”

“Exactly that!” Catra agrees. “Outside of a shower, getting covered in water *sucks*.”

"Good thing we'll be staying inside, of course," Deut'ron chuckles. "Shall we get going?"

Catra and C'yra nod at the same time, and follow the elderly cleric through the dark caves of Half Moon. He has to use magic to summon a light to guide their way. Despite being underground, Catra swears she can hear the rain pound on the ground above their heads.

Since Catra knows this will be a long walk (especially at the pace Deut'ron is going), she walks alongside him and asks, "Deut'ron, what do you know about the Temple of Lyses?"

"Not much, I must admit," Deut'ron answers. "Even before the war, I tended to stick to the Temple of Saz, being his cleric, of course. What about you, C'yra?"

"Same here," C'yra admits. "Because of the royal family's connection to Saz, I would have to visit the Temple of Saz more than the Temple of Lyses, religious ceremonies aside."

"You never saw any . . . evil robot squirrels while you were there?" Catra checks.

C'yra's eyes go wide, ". . . No? Where did you get that idea?"

"Well . . . yesterday I ended up exploring the Temple of Lyses," Catra admits. C'yra looks like she's about to open her mouth, so she quickly adds, "But I wasn't alone! I was with Gr'wliger, Gar'ett and Demeter, but I think we accidentally activated the security protocol. Hence the evil robot squirrels."

"Security protocol?" C'yra mumbles. "Why does an ancient building have a *security protocol*?"

"There have been legends that the Temples have ancient guardians placed by the Stars to protect them when the Magicats could not," Deut'ron admits. "Of course, I never thought that these guardians would be squirrels."

"I suppose that makes sense? Lyses is all about nature," C'yra says as she scratches her chin. "I still feel like security protocol is a strange choice of words, kitten."

Catra blushes at the nickname and glances at Deut'ron as she hisses, "*Don't say that in front of other people*."

"Alright, alright," C'yra puts her hands up as Deut'ron just chuckles.

"Don't worry, C'yra had a much more embarrassing nickname from her mother when she was a child," Deut'ron reveals.

Before Catra can ask about it, C'yra changes the subject, "So Catra, about the Temple of Lyses?"

Catra would certainly remember to ask Ri'ta about C'yra's old nickname, but she'll drop it for now, "It's just that . . . the Temple of Lyses is more like a First One's Temple on mainland Etheria than the Temple of Saz . . . actually it's eerily close, from the architecture to the security protocols. That plus the existence of a Runestone . . . are you all sure that the Three Stars aren't just First Ones?"

Deut'ron and C'yra share a look. Eventually, the former is the first one to shrug, "No one has ever bothered to look into it."

"Oh."

"Scholars from outside Purrsia have relentlessly implied the very same since they first saw our Temples," Deut'ron continues. "But we, of course, did not believe them nor did we wish to listen to them. In those days, Magicats were very devout and took their claims as heretical. Nowadays, it might be a more welcomed idea since faith in Saz has waned."

"It might be interesting to look into," C'yra admits.

Though the two clearly aren't saying it out loud, Catra has the feeling that they're encouraging her to research this herself. She may be the only person in Half Moon right now that doesn't believe in the Three Stars.

Catra ponders this as they enter the lowest level of the Temple of Saz, the Runestone faintly glowing in the dim light. Water pours into the room from the hole Catra made when she first fell in, pooling onto the ground, as thunder crackles in the sky far above.

"Ah, I knew I was forgetting about something," Deut'ron strokes his beard as he hobbles over to the pool of water. He stares up at the hole and sighs, "I forgot to fix the hole."

C'yra stares at him before pointing out, "The ceiling is sixty feet above our heads. You would have had to go through the jungles to get to it."

"Oh well," Deut'ron shrugs. "That's not important right now, of course. Catra, let's begin your training."

As Catra steps up to the Runestone, C'yra settles back against a wall, keeping an eye on things.

"Alright," Catra rubs her hands together. "So, I just touch this thing, right?"

"Not yet," he insists. "First off, you understand what power the Stone of Saz has, correct?"

"A Runestone, like the Stone of Saz, is a highly advanced piece of First One's technology ingrained into the environment of Etheria that when connected to a person grants them magical and or elemental powers," Catra says. She's glad that she listened to Entrapta . . . sometimes.

Deut'ron blinks, "Exactly. And as you must know, the only people connected to the Runestones, like the Stone of Saz, are Princesses, of course. You know about Princesses, correct?"

Catra frowns, “Sadly, I’m well-acquainted with them. Can we get to the part where I get to do sick shit with the Runestone?”

“Patience, Catra,” Deut’ron insists. “The Stone of Saz and other Runestones all can only be used by Princesses because they are a great power. Princesses, whether on Purrsia or Etheria, train for years to use its power for good.”

All of this Princess talk is starting to dissuade her from using the Runestone. She knows that *technically* as the daughter of C’yra and Ri’ta, she’s the princess of the Magicats. But they said that she doesn’t have to be the Princess if she doesn’t want to. That plus, the Runestone’s powers are supposed to be used *for good*. After all she’s done, can she really use this power for better purposes?

“Deut’ron,” C’yra clears her throat, interrupting his speech after Catra had zoned out. “All of this Princess talk is . . . a *little* dense. Why don’t we skip ahead a little bit, talk about the actual Stone?”

“Of course,” Deut’ron agrees.

Before turning back around, Catra mouths ‘thank-you’ to C’yra, who winks in reply.

“I, of course, have never been able to access the power of the Stone of Saz,” Deut’ron continues.

“No shit,” Catra sighs.

“But I remember when Queen Bett’i was being mentored by her mother in how to use it, and when Bett’i passed down that knowledge to C’yra.”

“It never really got me anywhere,” C’yra admits.

“It was said that though Queen Bett’i was a scholar and not a warrior, she had the strongest connection to the Runestone

in seven generations of the D'riluth Tribe, comparable to the power C'yra the First held," Deut'ron says. "Queen Bett'i said once that the power the Stone of Saz has is like trying to control a wildfire-powerful but it can burn you if you aren't careful."

"I mean, it is fire," Catra mutters. "But like, actual burns?" None of the other Princesses had to deal with stupid side-effects to the powers, aside from Princess Sparkles and her idiotic recharge.

"No, the user of the Stone of Saz is immune to its fire. But, of course, everything else is still the same amount of flammable."

"Ah, okay."

"When you start to wield the Fire of Saz, you must do your best to control and shape it," Deut'ron says. "But to start, of course, let's see if you can summon it on command. I suppose we're a bit lucky that everything is damp today."

"So, can I touch the Runestone now?" Catra asks.

"Yes, you may touch the Stone of Saz."

Eagerly, Catra touches the Runestone and its glow fills the room. She stares into the crystal as she does so, realizing how much it resembles a blazing inferno. Like before, the transfer of power is a bit of a shock, it courses through her body and makes her skin feel like it's on fire. When she can't handle it anymore, she wrenches her hand away from the cold surface, and the glow slowly fades.

"Do I have to do that all the time?" Catra asks, recalling Shimmer's recharge once again. "Like, recharge and shit?"

"No, this is to just establish connection between you and the Stone," Deut'ron reveals. "You may have to do it a few more times to solidify it, but then you should be able to draw on its power from anywhere."

She glances back at C'yra and asks, "Even though she's also connected to it? Aren't we technically sharing it's power?"

"Probably not," C'yra shrugs. "Like I said, I can't use it. It's all yours, kitten."

"You managed to touch it for quite some time," Deut'ron continues. "How do you feel?"

Unlike before, when she just barely touched it and felt nothing afterwards, she can still feel some of the power humming under her skin. It doesn't burn, but feels comfortably warm, "Good. Warm."

"Perfect," Deut'ron nods. "Now, you have to find a way to let that power out in the form of a flame. Try to see if you can summon one in the palm of your hand."

Catra holds out her hands and stares at them, "How?"

"Will the power there."

"That . . . doesn't help."

"Give it a try."

With a sigh, Catra stares at her palms. She tries to imagine a flame in her hands, but nothing appears. She tries to see if she can move the energy in her body to her fingers, like before. Nothing. She even just stops thinking about it, like it'll appear when she's not looking. Nadda.

"This is stupid," Catra drops her hands and sighs.

"The first step in controlling the Fire of Saz is to channel is," Deut'ron insists. "How you do it is something that you must find yourself."

"Still not helpful," Catra sighs.

"Why don't we try to replicate how you first managed to summon the Fire?" C'yra suggests, stepping forward and drawing her sword. "Maybe you're falling into the trap that I was, thinking too hard. If you focus on something more natural it might come back to you naturally?"

C'yra and Catra look to Deut'ron, who shrugs and hobbles off to the side, "Worth a try. Please try to not slip on the puddle or hit me."

"Of course," C'yra agrees. She turns to Catra, "Are you up for it?"

Catra nods and grins, "Of course."

Combat comes to her naturally. She and C'yra drop into a stance before charging. Unlike before, Catra is able to dodge C'yra's attack easier as she starts to learn her mother's fighting style. For the first time in a long time, training like this is . . . fun. C'yra is a difficult opponent, which makes the fight more engaging. Catra almost forgets where they are, too focused on the fight to pay attention to anything else. She doesn't even notice it when the Runestone starts to glow.

Like before, the warmth under her skin starts to move. It goes up her arm, through her hand to her finger tips, where a fire starts to burn. Catra doesn't stop this time, just continues to attack C'yra as if her hands being on fire is the most natural thing in the world. The power of the Runestone has become a part of her.

C'yra takes a second to notice too, also lost in combat. When she does, she blinks and laughs, "You did it, kitten!" Without missing a beat, she continues her attack.

"Wait, hold on!" Deut'ron interrupts. C'yra and Catra freeze as he walks back into the center of the room, watching as the fire in Catra's hand fades into dying embers until it's all gone. The Runestone does the same, its glow dimming to blackness.

“Oh, come on!” Catra growls, kicking the floor. “I had it!”

“Yes, you did. I wanted to see if you could hold it outside of battle, of course,” Deut’ron points out. “But, while in combat you were able to sustain it.”

“That was amazing, Catra!” C’yra adds, eyes wide with wonder. “That’s much longer than I ever could summon it.”

“It . . . it just felt natural,” Catra says, looking away to hide the blush on her face. She’s not used to praise, and from C’yra it feels . . . different.

“That was a good start,” Deut’ron says. “And I believe it was enough for today. Next time, we can focus on sustaining it once it’s activated, or how to summon the flames without the use of violence. But, of course, good job Catra.”

Okay, this was getting to be too much, “I just, let it happen,” Catra insists. “No big deal.”

“Well, I must head back to the Shrine,” Deut’ron says. “If you two wish to stay and I don’t know, patch up a hole, be my guest.”

“It’s my hole,” Catra sighs. “I’ll come back and fix it when it’s not raining.”

Deut’ron smiles, “Thank-you, Catra.”

He starts to hobble away, leaving Catra alone with C’yra.

“You did good today Catra,” C’yra says, still grinning despite the fact that the fire died out a while ago. “I only managed to summon the fire in my pinky finger, but that was something else. I swear, your grandmother would be impressed.”

“Are you sure? Deut’ron said that she had power comparable to C’yra the First,” Catra points out. “I can only summon the fire while fighting.”

"You've just started training," C'yra points out. "And you have a great start. You accomplished more than I ever could do with five years of training in one day."

Catra's eyes go wide, "You really trained with the Runestone for *five years*? You didn't figure out that after a while, maybe this isn't for me?"

"Oh, I did," C'yra says. "Around year two. But the Queen of Purrsia is supposed to be able to connect with the Stone of Saz, it was very important. My mother did her best trying to train me, but she was a natural at it. It didn't really translate well to someone who didn't understand at all. It looks like you're like her, a natural."

"And you aren't . . ." Catra looks at her feet and kicks a rock. "Mad?"

"Mad?" C'yra repeats. "Why would I be mad?"

"Because I'm a natural and you aren't?" Catra checks. When she was better at something, faster, stronger, she was always punished. Adora *had* to be the golden child, and Catra had to be the blemish. That's what Shadow Weaver wanted.

"No! I'm not mad, I'm impressed!" C'yra insists. "You being able to use the Stone like that is spectacular, and what mother would be upset to see her child be good at something?"

The answer is Shadow Weaver, but Catra doesn't say that. She jumps topics, and asks, "So, were you always training here at the Temple as a kid? Because you were the uh, princess?"

"No, I only had to train here like, once a week?" C'yra says. "It seems so long ago. No, I spent most of my time at combat training and figuring out how to get out of my other lessons. My mother wanted me to focus more on the scholarly aspects of being Queen, I just wanted to be a warrior. I got in a lot of trouble, either for skipping lessons or picking fights."

“Really?” Catra checks.

“Oh yeah,” C’yra laughs as she nods. “I loved getting into scraps. In the end, I realized my mother was preparing me to be a peacetime Queen, not one suited for war. While sometimes I wished I paid attention to my lessons more-mostly the ones about tax codes I’m still not great at math-I’m glad I spent a lot of time training. I really needed it.” C’yra frowns for a moment, her thoughts probably returning to the war. She shakes her head and says, “But, otherwise, being a princess wasn’t all that bad.”

“Do . . . do you want me to be the next Magicat Queen?” Catra asks nervously. She’s starting to train with the Stone of Saz, a requirement for the Queen. But of course, to become the Queen she has to be a . . . princess first. She hates the thought.

“I want you to be my daughter,” C’yra says. “The monarchy can end with me for all I care if you don’t want it.”

“You really mean that?” Catra asks with a small voice.

“I do,” C’yra says. “Now, let’s get back to Half Moon.”

Catra leaves the Temple of Saz feeling a little bit lighter, and even the dreary rain can’t chase that feeling away.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading and leave a comment! If you'd like to hear more from me and my thoughts as I work on fanfic, check me out Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle . I'm trying to get better at social media. Anyways, have a good day!

Next time: how are Scorpia and Adora going to find Beast Island?

Interlude III: Bow

Chapter Summary

> Adora, Scorpia and Bow try to figure out where Beast Island is.

Chapter Notes

> Hey, I'm back with a short and sweet update! After this chapter, there's only two more until we get to half-way through the fic. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora and Scorpia have been tirelessly working in the library for the past week and a half, going through just about each and every book Bright Moon owns in search for what Beast Island is and where it's located. Adora stepped away for missions, as both former Horde soldiers are dedicated to finding Catra. In all honesty, Bow's a bit worried about them, as they seem to be reaching the end of their rope.

"Nothing, nowhere, in this entire stinkin' library does anywhere say anything about Beast Island!" Adora exclaims one day as she slams a book shut. Bow had offered to join the two of them, as they seemed more exhausted than usual, and he's close enough to hear that outburst.

Adora's exclamation is echoed with a chorus of 'shushes' from near-by scholars.

"Sorry," Adora winces as she falls over, face-planting into a book.

"Well, there can't just be no information about it, right? Everyone in the Horde has known about the island for like, ever," Scorpia points out.

"But, it's a Horde thing?" Bow climbs down from a ladder with a prospective pile of books. "The Horde tends to twist things for its own gain, like Princesses, right?"

Adora and Scorpia look at him, waiting for a bit more explanation.

"What if we can't find anything about it because we call it by a different name than the Horde," Bow explains. He figures that the two are probably too tired to make that connection.

"Ohhhh," Adora and Scorpia realize together.

"But," Adora continues. "That just makes it harder for us, because we have no idea what else it could be called. All we know is that it's called Beast Island and has monsters on it."

"Hhm, maybe we just need a push in the right direction," Bow rubs his chin. "And I think I know just who to ask."

Adora and Scorpia share a curious look, but four hours later (after he forces the two of them to have a nap, they look really bad), the trio are making their way to his dad's house.

"Uh . . . are you sure I should be coming with you?" Scorpia checks. They had gotten her out of the Horde clothes and given her some civilian ones, but it's clear she still felt out of place as they traveled through the Whispering Woods.

"Yeah! I'm sure my dads will love you!" Bow insists. Scorpia's friendly enough, he can see her getting along with Lance, but he's not sure about George if he learns that she's a former Horde soldier . . . but once they get the two of them to talk history, everything should be fine.

When they reach the house, Bow pushes open the doors and calls out, "Dads? I'm home!"

"Bow?" Lance pokes his head into the room before running out to hug his son. "It's so good to see you again! And

Adora, welcome back!”

“Hello to you too, sir,” Adora says with a small smile.

“And who is your new friend?” Lance asks as he turns to Scorpia.

“This is Scorpia,” Bow begins.

“I, uh, nice to meet you,” Scorpia begins. She raises a claw, “I’d shake your hand, but uh, I’m more of a hugger.”

“That’s fine with me,” Lance steps up and gives her a hug. “Welcome to our home, any friend of Bow’s is a friend to us.”

Scorpia smiles and hugs back, lifting Lance off the ground. When he’s back on his feet, Adora asks, “Lance, we were hoping you and George could help us with something we’re researching.”

“Of course,” Lance says. “What are you looking into?”

“A place called Beast Island,” Bow reveals. “Or, at least that’s what the Horde calls it.”

“Hhm,” Lance rubs his chin. “Let’s go get George, he’s in the other room. Oh, and I’ll get us snacks before we get started!”

Once they get George (and Lance gets snacks) they all sit down and get to work.

“So, Beast Island?” George repeats as he strokes his mustache. “What else do you know about this place?”

“Well, it’s an island,” Scorpia says.

“It’s supposed to be filled with dangerous monsters,” Adora adds. “If you get sent there, it’s basically a death sentence.”

“So why are you trying to find this place?” George questions.

"Our friend is there," Scorpia admits. "She's strong, so I believe she's alright. But . . . even if this is all futile, we have to try."

"Alright," George nods. "I understand, but you all have to promise to stay safe and careful."

"Of course," Bow promises.

"Now, an island filled with dangerous animals and unheard of by many?" Lance begins. "I . . . think I may know what you're talking about."

"Really?" Adora questions.

"Yes," Lance nods. "I think you're looking for Purrsia."

"Purrsia?" Bow repeats.

George's eyes go wide, "Of course. Purrsia is a large island far east of Salineas. When we were younger, we wanted to go there."

"You wanted to go to *Beast Island*?" Adora checks.

"It wasn't always like that!" Lance insists. "Well, there were always monsters there, but there were rumors of First Ones Temples hidden in Purrsia's jungles. That's why we wanted to go."

"And people once lived on that island," George continues. "The Purrsians were reclusive, they rarely interacted with the outside world beyond an alliance with Bright Moon."

"Why . . . why are you using past tense?" Bow asks. "What happened to them?"

George and Lance share a somber look and the former reveals, "The Horde invaded and wiped them out."

Bow and Adora look at his fathers in shock, while Scorpia stares at the floor.

"I was no longer a soldier when it happened, but old friends of mine relayed the story. Traders from Bright Moon found the ruins of their ports," George continues. "When they tried to enter the forests, they were attacked by the local fauna, frenzied to the point of no return. They left immediately. I believe no one has tried to return since."

"But if they were allies with Bright Moon," Adora questions. "Why didn't they do anything?"

"The Princess Alliance couldn't do anything at the time, they were already stretched too thin," George sighs. "Purrsia was always secluded and independent, they weren't even members of the Princess Alliance. So, when they found out, it was too late."

"Did they not have a Princess?" Scorpia asks.

"They did. I was deployed elsewhere when she visited Bright Moon, but when I came back, I heard that she was only a couple years younger than me, closer to the age of the late King Micah at the time. She decided to not join the Alliance."

The room is silent after that, and Bow wonders that if the Purrsian princess did join the Alliance . . . maybe Purrsia would still be around. He clears his throat and asks his fathers, "do you have a map of when Purrsia is?"

Lance nods, "Most likely. George, come help me look for it."

When his fathers leave, Adora mutters, "I wonder why they didn't want to join the Princess Alliance . . ."

"So," Scorpia looks up from the ground. "How are we getting to Beast Island?"

"Are we still sure we want to go?" Bow checks.

"Yes," Adora and Scorpia say at the same time with the same glare.

"Okay," Bow nods. "So, my dads said it was east of Salineas, which means . . ."

Adora grins, "We probably need to ask Sea Hawk for help."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading, if you liked it leave a comment! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me @Sniperdoodle12 on Twitter or at sniperdoodle on tumblr . I'm trying to be more active, posting WIPs, and also putting my 11th grade graphic design class to use. Thank-you all and have a good day!

i never did believe in the ways of magic and i'm beginning to wonder why

Chapter Summary

Catra goes to the library to research, but ends up learning a little more about herself.

Chapter Notes

Yo, I'm back once again and I . . . don't have much to say here at the beginning. I hope ya'll enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After the morning's hunt, Catra is bored. All of her friends/acquaintances are busy, so she's left alone. Well, the only thing to do when you're bored is to read.

She heads to the Library, and realizes that she hasn't been there in a while. The last time she was there, she was determined to get off of the island and spent her time pouring over maps. But since she realized she wanted to stay in Half Moon . . . she hasn't been back. It's a bit of a shame, really, since she knows that Ri'ta spends most of her time there.

But today she's not going to go and look at old maps. She wants to look at old books, about Temples, the Three Stars, and anything that could help her draw a connection to the First Ones.

She passes through the steel doors of the Library into the familiar silence. The only sounds are the flipping of pages, and the quiet voices of Ri'ta and Shire as they continue their lessons. Catra tries to not disturb them as she walks up to the table Ri'ta reserved for her, still covered with maps she hasn't touched in weeks.

Well, she can't work like this. Catra starts by cleaning up her old mess, trying to put the maps back in the right tubes and

not crumple them as she rolls them up. That task alone takes her an hour, and she finishes about the same time Shire and Ri'ta finish their lesson.

"Hey Catra," Shire says as she passes by.

"Hey," Catra looks up. "Are you heading back to the infirmary?"

"Yeah, someone actually scheduled a check-up," Shire says. "So, I've got to go. Will I see you at dinner?"

"See you then," Catra nods.

"You've finally decided to tidy up your table," Ri'ta says as she approaches. "What brought you to the Library today?"

"I wanted to research something," Catra starts. "Then I realized I left a fucking mess."

"Research what?" Ri'ta asks.

Catra glances around first, she doesn't want the near-by scholars to listen in, "I'm looking into the connection between the First Ones and the Three Stars."

"Ah," Ri'ta nods. "C'yra did say you made a visit to the Temple of Lyses. Something about robot squirrels?"

"*Evil* robot squirrels," Catra corrects. "Yeah, it was similar to something I've seen on mainland Etheria, and I'm bored, so I figured I might look into it. But uh . . . you aren't against it?"

"Why would I be? The pursuit of knowledge is always worth it," Ri'ta says.

"But like, don't you all think that the Three Stars are gods?" Catra checks.

"Most do," Ri'ta says. "Those that were raised traditionally, here on Purrsia. But you forget that I wasn't raised here."

"You were raised on Mystacor," Catra recalls.

"Yep," Ri'ta nods. "My upbringing was far from traditional. My mother was more focused on teaching me magic and how it's a part of nature than the history of a country we weren't even living in. I had heard and read about the Three Stars a little, but after coming here when I was a teen I do have to admit," she lowers her voice, "I did think it was a little ridiculous."

"Really?" Catra checks.

"Really. You've seen what mainland Etheria is like, their beliefs differ greatly from the Magicats," Ri'ta says. She pauses, "Actually now that I think of it, you and I might be the only people in Half Moon that don't believe in the Three Stars."

"Even though faith in Saz has waned?" Catra asks.

"Even if their belief in them has waned, they still believe they exist," Ri'ta says. "And there's Lyses."

"And Ilir," Catra adds.

"But no one wants to think about Ilir," Ri'ta sighs. "Well, I have some time right now, would you like a hand in researching? I've only got one to give, though."

Catra sighs, "Do you ever get tired of telling one hand jokes?"

"No."

"Alright, yeah I guess. I don't even know where to start."

"The beginning tends to be a good place to start," Ri'ta advises with a smirk. She steps off of the raised platform, heading

into the library. It takes Catra a second to realize that she's supposed to follow. Ri'ta continues in a whisper, "You probably want a more detailed account of the legends of the Three Stars and their Temples, as well as what we have about First Ones which I must admit, is not a lot."

"I already know a lot about the First Ones," Catra says. Entrapta talked about their technology a lot, and she did have two first-hand encounters with First Ones' temples. "But more about the Temples would be nice. Who built them?"

"According to the myths, the Three Stars built them, but the Temple of Saz was built with the Magicat's help," Ri'ta answers.

"Makes sense," Catra nods. The Temple of Saz had a man-made feeling to it, made of rough stone rather than sleek metal.

Ri'ta leads her through the winding shelves of the library, and Catra feels like she's in a maze. Occasionally, they'd stop and Ri'ta would hand her a book and explain what it was about and why it would be useful. There are so many books that the stack blocks Catra's view and she does her best to follow Ri'ta.

"This might be enough for now," Catra grunts. She tries to lower her arms so she can peek over the top book and look at Ri'ta.

"You might be right," Ri'ta agrees with a chuckle. "Sorry kitten, it seems that I got a bit carried away."

Catra would make a comment about Ri'ta calling her 'kitten' in public, but she remembers something more pressing, "Oh hey! Before I forget, what was C'yra's childhood nickname? Duet'ron said it was embarrassing."

"Oh Saz, it was bad," Ri'ta agrees. "Her mother called her-"

"*A-hem*."

Standing behind Ri'ta is Gus, who looks very unhappy, as usual. Ri'ta turns around and says, "Ah, hello Gus. Were we being too loud?"

"No, for once the *Horde soldier* has managed to keep a respectable volume," Gus says, spitting when he says 'Horde soldier'.

"I'm not a Horde soldier anymore," Catra sighs.

"So, you say," Gus narrows his eyes. He limps forward, until he's below Catra's line of sight, blocked by the pile of books. "I just wanted to remind you that you should treat the Queens with more respect. It's because of them you're even allowed to stay here."

"Gus," Ri'ta rubs her eyes with her hand as she sighs. "The *Council* voted and decided that Catra could stay here. And in the months following that decision, she has done nothing to earn your ire. In fact, she's become one of us. Now, please leave us be."

"Queen Ri'ta," Gus hisses. "Just because you have let your guard down doesn't mean that I should."

"Hey," Catra interrupts. "Maybe you should listen to your own advice and *respect* the *Queen's* decision, right Gus?"

Though she can't see him, she imagines that he's looking pretty pissed off. He growls, "Fine. I shall be taking my leave."

As he hobbles away, Ri'ta smiles and nudges her in the side, "That was pretty good."

"C'yra keeps saying I get my sarcasm from you," Catra says.

"Damn straight. But that's a part of our charm," Ri'ta laughs. "Now, your arms must be getting tired. Let's get back to our work area."

They return to the center of the library and Catra drops the books on the table without a care for the noise it makes. She was starting to lose the feeling in her arms and shakes her hands before sitting down.

"I'll be working over here," Ri'ta tells Catra. "Let me know if you need any more books."

"I . . . I think this'll be enough for now," Catra says, eyeing the large stack. She grabs a book in the middle, one Ri'ta says was about the creation of the Temples. She knows about the Three Stars, so the history of the Temples seems like a good place to start.

As she starts reading, she finds herself getting distracted. It's partly because the text is thick, dense and old, but also she's trying to figure out what the fuck Ri'ta is doing.

Usually, Catra tries to avoid magic at all costs. She learned that lesson long ago from Shadow Weaver. But she keeps on glancing up, and watches Ri'ta cast spells and becomes entranced. Unlike the dark, milky shadows she's used too, Ri'ta's magic is colorful and bright. She mutters something as she traces her finger in the air, leaving behind a trail of light.

Catra must've said something without realizing it, because Ri'ta turns to her and asks, "Catra, what was that?"

"Oh, uhm," Catra considers saying that it's nothing, but she finds that curious part of herself she's been listening to lately pipe up. "I was wondering uh, what you're doing. With the lights and stuff?"

"Ah," Ri'ta walks over. "I have a lesson with the kits tomorrow, and I was just practicing some basic spells. It's good to

go back to basics sometimes, because it’s the foundation for everything else.”

“That was basic magic?” Catra asks, eyes wide. “You were making shapes in the air and everything!”

“Well, if this was normal Etherian magic then yes, that would be more complex,” Ri’ta explains. “But light magic and being able to manipulate it is very simple in Magicat magic.”

“Huh,” Catra recalls Shadow Weaver’s dark magic and wonders if the bitch could even conjure light. “I guess that would be useful, even though we can see in the dark pretty well already.”

“Would you like to learn how to conjure light?” Ri’ta offers.

“What!?” the sudden proposition surprised Catra so much, she says it out loud and gets a few ‘shushes’ from near-by scholars. She leans forward and hisses, “I can’t do magic!”

Ri’ta stares at her with a raised brow before revealing, "Catra, you have the ability to do magic.”

"No, I don't," Catra insists. She's pretty sure that if she could do magic like Ri'ta or Shire, Shadow Weaver would have treated her better . . . or worse.

"Catra, magic is an innate ability that yes, does need to be refined and practiced to make the use of it fluid, but you've been able to do magic since you were three. Your mother and I would have playful arguments about whether you'd be a great mage or a great warrior," Ri'ta says with a smile. "But, magic is not an ability you lose just because you haven't done it in a while. It's still with you."

Catra feels weird about this. She generally distrusts magic (*thanks Shadow Weaver*) and to know that she can do it herself? It kinda scares her.

Ri'ta notices that Catra's been silent, so she sits down in front of her, "I know magic has been used to hurt you in the past, but I believe that magic is inherently good. The simplest spell you can do is to conjure a ball of light, showing that magic is a light in a dark world. Shadow Weaver perverted that light and turned it dark, but not all magic is like that."

Catra nods her head, still mulling over Ri'ta's words. It honestly makes sense, as all of the mages she's met in Half Moon have been nothing but nice. Shire wants to use magic to heal. Deut'ron uses magic for his faith. Ri'ta uses magic to teach. Not to harm. Not to wound. Not to main. Not to punish. Not to torture.

Inherently good. Just twisted to be evil.

Catra looks up, "I guess . . . you can show me. How to . . . conjure light, right?"

Ri'ta lights up, "Yes! Hold out your hands like you're cupping up water."

Catra follows Ri'ta's instructions and holds out her hands.

"Now, start to clear your mind. Think of the sun, its rays warming your fur. Imagine a light, banishing the darkness. Now visualize that light in the palms of your hands."

Catra closes her eyes and thinks of the sun, filtering through the trees of the forest. She remembers Deut'ron's light, revealing her in the Temple of Saz. She sees N'yan doing the same spell in the infirmary, easily conjuring light and it flickering away as easily as it came.

Catra feels a warmth in her palms as Ri'ta says, "There. That was easy, wasn't it?"

Catra opens her eyes and marvels at the bright orb in her hands. She can't help but gasp, "Holy shit."

Catra looks up at Ri'ta who is smiling, yet tears are starting to form in her eyes.

Catra doesn't know what caused the change, what made her sad. The light flickers and grows smaller as she asks, "Did I do something wrong?"

"Kitten, you didn't do anything wrong, it's perfect," Ri'ta insists, laughing even though she looks like she's about to cry. "Just … the look on your face, it's the same look of wonder you had when you first did it, when you were three. My, how some things never change."

"Oh," Catra looks down at the ball, it was starting to regain some of its vibrancy.

"Now," Ri'ta starts to compose herself. "Let's see how long you can keep that lit. All spells require a component of visualization, you need to see it in your mind before you can reproduce a result. Some need physical components, which includes energy, and others need verbal components. Actually, most of them need verbal, this spell and a few others are the only ones that don't need the verbal component, and fewer more need only the visualization component. Catra, you're doing really good. I'm surprised you haven't lost concentration by now . . . unless you're not paying attention."

"I am!" Catra insists, the light bouncing in her hands as she jolts up. "It's not that hard."

Ri'ta smiles, "See? You're a natural at magic."

"Huh," Catra looks back down at the light. "So, how do I turn it off?"

As soon as she questions it, the light flickers and diminishes until it's gone. Catra stares at her hands in surprise, but Ri'ta smiles, "Just like that."

Out of curiosity, Catra wills the ball and it appears in her hands. She wishes it away and it disappears again. She does it a couple times, just to get a feel for the warm magic in her palms.

"Usually," Ri'ta says as Catra goes through the motions. "It takes some time to get a handle on the simple spells, but I'd say you're ready for the next lesson."

"Already?" Catra questions, flicking the ball of light into and out of existence once again.

"Oh yes," Ri'ta stands up and retrieves a book off of the podium. "I'm thinking that this is more of a muscle memory for you, something that can't be unlearned. You could do it just as easily when you were young as you are now."

Catra stares at the ball of light in her hand again. Something that can't be unlearned. Something that can't be taken away, no matter how much Shadow Weaver tried. It's a small comfort to know that maybe during all those years in the Horde, she hadn't completely lost every semblance of what she knew as home. It was still with her; she just didn't know it was there.

"So, there's a couple spells we can try next," Ri'ta sets the book down in her lap as she starts to flick through the pages. "This is a beginner's spell book; I use it with the kits during the lessons I give."

"What about that spell you were doing earlier?" Catra suggests. "You were making shapes out of light."

"That would be a good spell," Ri'ta nods. "It is just a modified form of the light spell. Instead of focusing it in your hand you have to narrow your focus to your finger. Then, you have to speak the command word to allow it to leave a trail."

"Command word? So that's a verbal component?" Catra questions.

"Yes, magic is written in an ancient language known as Starscript, but no one can read or speak it fluently anymore," Ri'ta explains. "Most magic books tell you how to pronounce it anyways. So, the command word for this spell is *pictor*."

"Pictor?" Catra repeats. When Ri'ta nods, she double-checks, "So, summon light to my finger and say the word?"

"That's a bit simplified, but yes," Ri'ta says. "Go ahead and try."

Catra steps back and takes a deep breath. Summoning the ball of light was easy enough, so this should be too. Instead of visualizing the light in her hands, she imagines seeing it at the tip of her finger. She imagines the warmth of the light, like the fire burning in a hearth.

"Catra," Ri'ta pipes in. "I hate in interrupt, but your hand's on fire."

She opens her eyes and stares at the dancing flames in her hands. At first, she's confused, how did she manage to summon the Fire of Saz when she was trying to conjure light? Then, she's ecstatic, because she summoned the Fire of Saz without violence, but it quickly turns into panic because *she doesn't want people to know she's the Princess-*

Ri'ta calmly grabs a blanket off of a side table and covers Catra's hand, snuffing out the flame. Catra stares at her, "When you've been teaching magic as long as I have, you know to be prepared in case things get set on fire, but that's the first time a light spell has turned into that."

"Uhm," Catra glances away as Ri'ta removes the blanket. "That, uh, might have been . . ." She tries to draw out the shape of the Runestone in the air, vaguely gesturing to get her point across.

"Ah," Ri'ta eyes go wide with realization. "Right. C'yra said you two were working on that. Well, from my understanding,

using . . . that is similar to using magic.”

“Really?” Catra questions.

“Yes, both are a natural talent that require concentration and visualization,” Ri’ta says. “To put it simply.”

“So, I’m guessing C’yra isn’t good at magic either?” Catra asks.

“She has the magical talent of a chicken bone, to put it kindly,” Ri’ta laughs. “That type of concentration has never been her strong suit. But it seems that you can extend these magic lessons to your other training.”

“Right,” Catra agrees.

“So, would you like to try that again without setting yourself on fire?” Ri’ta asks. “You were thinking about fire, weren’t you?”

“Uh . . . yeah.”

“Just focus on the warmth and glow, not the actual fire. Then you should be able to summon the light.”

Catra’s research lays abandoned, as she spends the rest of her day practicing light spells with Ri’ta. She never thought she would enjoy learning magic like this, but maybe for once, the light has managed to banish the shadows from her mind.

Chapter End Notes

So, I wrote part of this chapter probably over a year ago, before I started to write for Catra being able to use the Runestone. I had always planned on Catra learning some magic, as Ri'ta being a mage was a part of the plan to help Catra move on from Shadow Weaver and claim magic for herself. Hopefully I'm not making Catra seem too op because

she already is able to hold her own against She-Ra without a Runestone or magic.

Anyways, I still plan on trying to get to the half-way point but I've . . . hit a writing road block. I'm trying to recharge so I can blast through a shorter chapter, but your comments really do help motivate me to write.

Finally, if you want to hear more from me, story updates and WIPs, or just general ramblings follow me @Sniperdoodle12 on Twitter or sniperdodle on Tumblr . Well, that's it from me. Hopefully I'll see y'all next week.

take a moment to think of just flexibility love and trust

Chapter Summary

Catra has another nightmare. This time, it's about Adora.

Chapter Notes

WA-HOO! We've made it boys, half-way through this fic! Thank-you all for your comments and support, it really means a lot to me. I love you all.

I'll admit, this chapter was a bit of a roadblock to me. So, I handled it as you should any roadblock: speeding up and crashing through it. I don't think it's my best work and it's a bit short, but all that matters is it's done.

So, I hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

With all the magic she was doing earlier that day, Catra thought her dreams would have been invaded by Shadow Weaver.

Instead, she sees Adora.

She stands above Adora in the Beacon, sees her cling to the ledge and dangle above the darkness below. Instead of helping her up, Catra lets her fall.

Then, she’s facing Adora in battle, surrounded by gold as the form of She-Ra has taken over. She remembers raking her claws down Adora’s back, the feel of them cutting flesh and warm blood dripping down her hands.

Catra wakes and her first instinct is to go wash her hands, to try and get rid of her friend’s blood. She looks down at

them and is relieved to see them clean and that it was all a dream . . . but she still has the urge to wash them. With all the blood she's spilt . . . they'll never be clean. There will always be a red spot, a damned spot, that she can never wash away no matter what she does.

Instead, she decides to go and try to walk the dream off. It's too quiet, and Catra's thoughts keep on bouncing around and coming back to her dreams.

She doesn't have dreams about Adora often. Usually, her nightmares are filled with shadows and Adora's only there if it's related to the particular memory. But as she's started to step out of the darkness, her other regrets are filling in the spaces . . . namely, Adora.

After wandering around aimlessly, Catra finds that her feet have carried her to C'yra's office. Unlike the last time she came this way in the middle of the night, it's dark and locked shut. A small part of her was hoping that C'yra would be awake and she could talk to her. It helped last time a nightmare shook her like this.

If C'yra isn't her office, then maybe . . .

No, Catra doesn't want to intrude. C'yra's probably asleep and she doesn't want to wake her moms up with her personal problems. She can handle the nightmare herself.

Except she heads to the queens' personal quarters anyways.

"This is a bad idea," Catra hisses to herself as she stares at the door. There doesn't seem to be any light inside, so the Queens must be asleep. "They aren't gonna be happy that you woke them up."

Yet, she steps forward and knocks on the door anyways.

She steps back and waits a few moments. When she doesn't hear anything from inside, she turns to walk away. Then, the door flies open.

Ri'ta is standing there, wearing a nightgown and looking vaguely annoyed. "Who the-" she stops when she sees Catra, her expression morphing into something softer, "Oh, hey Catra. Come on in."

"Sorry for waking you up," Catra mumbles as she dashes into the room, head held low, like it's a limited time offer.

"S'alright," Ri'ta insists as she lets the door close. She pauses to yawn and asks, "Is everything okay?"

"Yeah," Catra nods. "Well, no."

"So," Ri'ta smirks, slowly starting to wake. "Which is it?"

"I uh," Catra glances at the ground. "Had a nightmare."

"Oh," the smirk fades. She sits down and pats the couch, "Wanna talk about it?"

Catra joins her the same time C'yra stumbles into the room, wearing a robe over pajamas and eyes barely open, asking, "Who'sit?" She pauses and stares at Catra, "Hi kitten. Nightmare?"

"Yeah," Catra admits. She shifts in her seat, feeling nervous with both of her moms' eyes on her.

"Ah," C'yra falls into a chair. She waves her hand to Catra, giving her the floor.

Catra shifts in her seat, feeling nervous with both of her mothers' eyes on her. She stares at her hands as she begins, "I was in the Temple, on mainland Etheria, with . . ." she's never mentioned Adora to C'yra and Ri'ta yet, as the ruins of what used to be their friendship is still too fresh in her mind, but maybe it's time. "Adora. We were . . . best friends back in the Horde."

"You haven't talked about her much," Ri'ta points out.

"We used to be friends," Catra grumbles. "Not . . . not anymore."

"Do you mind if we ask what happened?" C'yra says. "If you don't want to, you don't have to answer."

She doesn't really want to, but how else will they have the context for her dream? She sighs, "Adora joined the Rebellion. Left me behind. Was Shadow Weaver's favorite." That seems to be enough to paint the picture for the Queens. "In the dream, it was after she joined the Rebellion. We were trapped in the Beacon. And . . ." Does she mention the mind games? How the Beacon made them relive the past? Remind them of what they once had? "We fought evil spider robots."

"Not squirrels?" C'yra checks.

"Definitely had eight legs," Catra nods. "And . . . we were working together to get out. But then Adora fell off a ledge and I . . ." she stares at her hands. She doesn't want to say what happens next. She doesn't want them to lose faith in her. There's too much blood on her hands.

"Catra?" Ri'ta puts a hand on her shoulder, grounding her. "Are you alright?"

". . . This isn't just a dream," Catra admits as she wraps her arms around herself and turns away. "It actually happened. It's a memory."

"You can tell us anything," Ri'ta insists. "Take your time."

"I let her fall," Catra admits. "I walked away." She can't look C'yra or Ri'ta in the eye. "And when I led the Horde to invade Bright Moon, I fought Adora. I wanted to kill her." She doesn't notice that she is crying until she feels the drops on her fur. She rubs her eyes as she sobs, "I tried to kill my best friend."

Catra can imagine C'yra's and Ri'ta's disgusted faces, so she's shocked when she feels a hand rubbing her back. She looks up at Ri'ta, who looks concerned rather than abhorred, "That's a lot to carry around, kitten. But you're not that person anymore."

"What?" Catra gasps.

"The fact that you're feeling remorse and regret right now means that you've grown," Ri'ta continues. "You're not the person who would do such a thing anymore. And now, you can work towards making it right."

"We've all done things we regret, there are things that we aren't proud of," C'yra adds. "All we can do is move forward."

"But . . . how do I make this right?" Catra questions.

"I don't know," Ri'ta admits. "Right now, all you can do is keep on improving in your own ways. You have changed since you've come to Half Moon, and maybe one day you'll find an answer."

Ri'ta is right, she has changed. She is not the Horde soldier she was when she arrived, desperate for revenge. Now, she's a member of Half Moon. She's a Magicat. She just has to see where this path takes her.

For now, she doubts she'll be seeing Adora anytime soon. She can focus on that problem later.

"Feeling better?" Ri'ta asks.

"A bit," Catra admits. "But . . ." If she's putting off her Adora problems, she certainly doesn't want to face her in her dreams.

"Don't want to fall asleep?" C'yra guesses.

Catra nods.

"Why don't you stay here?" C'yra suggests. "We have a spare room. That way, if you have another nightmare, we're close by."

"I don't want to intrude . . ." Catra mumbles.

"You're our daughter, you're not intruding," Ri'ta insists.

"Okay," Catra agrees. The thought of being near to C'yra and Ri'ta in case she has another nightmare is . . . comforting to her.

"Anything you need from your room?" Ri'ta asks, and Catra shakes her head. Ri'ta leads her to a room down the hallway. There are only three doors: C'yra and Ri'ta's room, the bathroom, and a spare room. Ri'ta explains, "We didn't know what to do with it, since we both have our own offices. We just threw some furniture in there and called it a day."

The room is similar to her own in Half Moon, with only a bed, desk, lamp, nightstand, and dresser. But, Catra's only spending the night here. She doesn't need much else.

"It'll work," Catra insists.

"Alright," Ri'ta smiles. "Good night, kitten."

"Good night," Catra responds. She lays down on the bed and closes her eyes. Her worries don't plague her as she drifts off into unconsciousness, sleeping well knowing that her mothers are near-by.

Chapter End Notes

I'm never writing another nightmare chapter.

Anyways, the winter semester has started which means that I might not update regularly! I have the next five chapters in various states of completion and I might just eat my words and get them all ready, but I also may just drop off the face

of the Earth for a while. However, if I don't update for a while, that does not mean I have abandoned this fic. I am a college student. I have a life outside of writing. I understand that a lot of you are passionate about this fic and want to see it through to the end (me too) but just . . . don't assume that it's dead.

If you want to make sure that I'm alive and hear about my progress or other projects I'm working on, you should follow me @Sniperdoodle12 on Twitter or sniperdoodle on tumblr.

Once again, thank-you all for your support and (maybe?) I'll see you next week!

how do i feel by the end of the day (are you sad because you're on your own) no i get by with a little help from my friends

Chapter Summary

Catra has an emotionally freeing moment.

Chapter Notes

Okay here I am, eating my words . . . but to be fair I was really excited for this chapter. Anyways, I hope you all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Okay, wait," Catra puts her hands together and stares at Sh'dowell. "Where do the knives come in?"

"That's the beauty of knife monopoly," Sh'dowell insists. "The knife is always a surprise."

"What," Gr'wliger walks up to their lunch table with Gar'ett, both carrying their own trays. He stares at the plethora of knives left out on the table, then to Catra, then back to Sh'dowell, "I thought I told you that you couldn't teach Catra knife monopoly."

"I don't think I want to learn now," Catra admits.

"But it's the most dangerous-and funnest-game!" Sh'dowell insists.

"Funnest isn't a word," Gar'ett is quick to point out. "Put away your knives, I wanna sit down and eat."

Sh'dowell pouts, but collects all of their knives and puts them away so there's space to eat.

If someone had told Catra that one day she would be sitting in Half Moon, surrounded by friends, she wouldn't have believed them. But now . . . honestly, she still can't believe it. Just about every day, she eats lunch with Gr'wliger, Sh'dowell, Gar'ett, Busto and Shire . . . her friends. Ri'ta was right, she has changed.

"No need to fear, Captain Busto is here!" Busto arrives with his usual loud greeting, Shire following close behind him. That's probably because Busto has a bandage wrapped around his eye.

"What happened to you?" Catra asks as the two sit down.

"I was training a new set of soldiers today and one of them poked me in the eye with a training sword," Busto admits.

"Usually you're faster than that," Catra points out.

"Did you get distracted?" Gr'wliger guesses.

"Yes, with the soldier that tried to tackle me but was just clinging to my back," Busto sighs. "I've got a long way to go with the new recruits."

"Well, tell them not to aim for the eyes next time," Shire advises.

"Actually, you tend to want to aim for the eyes if you want to blind your opponent," Sh'dowell argues. "Puts them at a disadvantage."

"Yeah," Catra jumps on with a smirk. "If anything, Busto, your students are ahead of the game."

"This isn't about tactics," Shire says, "It's about me having to treat injuries that can be easily avoided."

"But now you're getting experience treating those injuries," Sh'dowell says. "So, it's actually a win-win situation."

Shire glares at them as Busto points out, “I got poked in the eye. *I* don’t win.”

“Well, what do we have here?” Thom saunters up to the table, butting into the conversation and ruining the mood. Catra’s done her best to avoid Thom after getting on his bad side, but she can’t avoid him in a public area like this, “Looks like the loser table to me.”

“Uh . . . what the fuck?” Gar’ett begins.

“I mean, I guess if you want to call the head of the hunters, the second-in-command of the army, and the only capable healer we have in Half Moon *losers*,” Sh’dowell mumbles. “Be my guest.”

“Thom,” Busto begins. He sounds more serious than Catra has ever heard him, “What are you doing?”

“I just wanted to know why you’re all associating with the Horde soldier,” Thom says, snatching a biscuit off of Catra’s plate and eating it. “After all,” he glares at Busto, “You’ve just traded one problem for a worse one.”

Well, Busto did say that he once was friends with Thom . . . so he’s got a point there. Why befriend a Horde soldier over a street rat?

“Hey, it’s *much* better than hanging out with you,” Shire scowls.

“Catra’s our friend,” Gr’wliger says. “She saved my brother, you know.”

“Oh, so you’re friends with her out of obligation, then?” Thom snarls.

They had only met once she saved Lily, but the afterwards that’s the only reason she met his family. Then they started to hang out more . . .

"Catra's cool," Sh'dowell says. "You're a dick, Thom. That's why no one wants to hang out with you."

Isn't that why no one liked her in the Horde? She pushed away and acted like a jerk to her squad mates, and even did that to the only two people that saw her as a friend.

Catra tries to push away the voices of doubt. These were her friends. They never did anything to show that they were only hanging out with her out of obligation, or that she was ever a burden to them. Why else would they stand up for her?

"Hey Thom," Catra speaks up and glares at him. "Fuck off."

Thom frowns, his tail lashing out behind him, "I'll see you losers later."

As he stalks away, Gar'ett repeats, "What the fuck was that about?"

"He's just lashing out," Busto says solemnly, staring into his food.

"I did catch him stealing a while back," Catra mutters. "But . . . he may have a point."

"That we're losers?" Sh'dowell questions.

"No just uh . . ." Catra picks at her food. "I don't know. I wasn't . . . just a Horde soldier guys, I was a *force captain*. I did bad shit."

"You *were* a force captain," Gr'wliger corrects. "Now, you're a hunter of Purrsia."

He says it so simply, yet it has such a strong impact.

"Yeah, you're with us now!" Busto says with a little bit of gusto returning to him. "You're a Magicat! One of us!"

"One of us! One of us!" Sh'dowell chants.

"Don't let Thom get to you," Shire adds, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder. "He's just trying to rile you up, to start a fight and get you in trouble. Don't fall for his mind games."

Shire has a point, Catra should have known better. If there's one thing she knows, it's mind games. Thom wasn't at the level of Shadow Weaver, but he let her own brain do the heavy lifting.

"Thanks guys," Catra says with a small smile. "I'm glad we're friends."

"Oo!" Busto jumps up. "You called us all your friends!"

"No shit dipshit, or did the trainees fuck up your ears too?" Catra bites back.

"Congratulations on your emotionally freeing moment," Gare'tt chimes in.

"Wait!" Busto loudly proclaims. "I had an idea!"

"No need to yell in my ear," Gr'wliger sighs as he rubs his ear.

Busto ignores him and continues, "Catra, you had a . . . badge of some kind when you arrived, right?"

"You mean the uh, force captains' badge?" Catra says in a quiet tone. She supposes Busto saw it because he was one of the people to find her after she got attacked by a beast.

"Yes," he nods. "We should throw it in the ocean."

Everyone stares at him, and Shire is the first to ask, "*Why* the ocean?"

"Imagine how cathartic it will feel," Busto says dramatically, clenching his hands together. "To throw the last dredges of your past into the sea and let it wash it all away."

Catra rubs her chin, "Honestly, that sounds fun."

"Oo! I wanna come!" Sh'dowell declares.

Gar'ett nods, with a mouth full of food, "Meh too."

"I suppose we'll all come along," Gr'wliger adds.

"Wait, even me?" Shire checks. "I'm . . . just a Cleric. I'm not used to going on the surface with *beasts*."

"You'll be with four hunters and a soldier," Catra points out. "Plus, if something terrible happens, you'll be able to administer immediate first aid."

Shire purses her lips in thoughts, "Fine, but if I die, I'm going to haunt you all."

"You're not going to die," Busto insists. "Now Catra . . . where is this badge?"

"I . . . think C'yra has it?" Catra guesses. She hasn't seen it since that first night she woke up in Half Moon. It wouldn't be a problem to ask her, she's sure the Queen will give it back, she just doesn't want her to get suspicious when there's no reason to be. Especially after what she told C'yra and Ri'ta last night about her past . . .

"Let's go get it!" Busto immediately stands up, yet Gr'wliger puts a hand on his shoulder and pushes him back down.

"Let's finish eating first," Gr'wliger insists.

Busto sheepishly shrugs, "Ah. Yes. Can't go adventuring on an empty stomach."

After they all finish eating, it's decided that Gr'wliger will go to his office to determine the shortest path to the ocean, while everyone else joins Catra in going to get her force badge back. She would have preferred to go alone, but they all insisted, something about them being 'emotional support'. She doesn't need emotional support to talk to her mother.

C'yra's office door is open and the inside is lit, so she must be working on paperwork.

"Alright," Catra turns to her friends. "You idiots stay back here. We don't all need to crowd in her office."

"Aw," Sh'dowell sighs.

"Then we shall wait out here," Busto declares and salutes.

Catra nods and walks over to the office, knocking on the doorframe. C'yra looks up and smiles, "Hello Catra. What are you doing in this corner of Half Moon?"

"Not much," Catra admits. "I was just wondering . . . do you still have my force captain badge?"

C'yra's smile falters for a second as she raises an eyebrow, "Yes . . . why?"

"I'm going to throw it into the ocean."

"Okay now I have more questions."

"She's going to have an emotionally freeing moment!" Busto calls from down the hallway.

"I don't know," Catra shrugs, ignoring him. "It's just . . . time to move on. By throwing the badge into the ocean."

"Well, I'm glad you're taking this step, even if I don't completely understand," C'yra admits. She opens up a drawer and

pulls out the badge, “It’s useless to me anyway. We had Lionel’o take a look at it when you were unconscious . . . that seems like so long ago.”

“I know, I feel the same,” Catra agrees. She’s not the person she was when she arrived on Purrsia.

Handing the badge to Catra, C’yra adds, “Be careful. If you’re heading to the ocean-”

“Gr’wliger’s picking out a path right now,” Catra reveals. “And I won’t be going alone. My friends are coming along too.”

C’yra smiles, “Good. Have fun with your . . . emotionally freeing moment.”

Catra waves her mother goodbye and rejoins her friends. Sh’dowell runs up to her, “I wanna see it!”

She flashes the badge to him, “It’s nothing big.”

“Huh. Yeah. It’s just wings,” they sigh. “I was expecting something more . . .”

“Evil?” she guesses.

“Flashy.”

“Oh.”

She glances at the badge. This useless piece of metal once meant so much to her. Now, it’s heavy in her hands, reminding her of her past.

They make their way to the hunter’s headquarters, joining up with Gr’wliger. He leads their expedition to the ocean, taking the shortest route possible. It only takes about a half an hour to make it to the edge of a cliff (with absolutely no beast sightings, helping Shire relax a bit), over-looking the ocean. The

sun shines in the waves, turning white as they crash against the bluffs.

"Alright," Busto rubs his hands together. "Time for you emotionally freeing moment."

Catra takes a deep breath and steps forward, clutching the badge in her hands. She glances back at her friends, "So . . . do I say anything? Or just throw it in?"

"You should yell something," Sh'dowell suggests.

"No yelling," Gare'tt reminds them. "That'll alert the beasts."

"Oh right."

"*Please* don't yell," Shire begs. For most of the trip, she's stuck close to Busto and is still hiding behind his back. "Maybe . . . you should say something about the Horde?"

"Say whatever feels natural," Gr'wliger says.

"Right, this is *your* emotionally freeing moment," Busto reminds everyone. "Now, go ahead."

She nods and turns back to the sea. After everything the Horde has done to her, what does she say? They took her away from her family, let Shadow Weaver torture her for most of her childhood, let her hurt her best friend. Can she really leave this all in the past and live a new life in Half Moon?

Well, only one way to find out.

"*Fuck the Horde*," Catra whispers as she rears her arm back and tosses the badge into the sea. It flies through the clear, blue sky and lands in the water, barely making a splash in the waves. Now, it's gone forever.

"Couldn't have said it better myself," Gar'ett agrees, politely clapping.

"So, feel any different?" Shire asks.

The badge was the last physical thing tethering Catra to the Horde. She still has a lot to deal with, but somehow, getting rid of it did make her feel . . . lighter. Turning to Shire, she nods, "Yeah. I feel . . . better."

"Great!" Busto exclaims. "That was a wonderful emotionally freeing moment!" he runs up to Catra and wraps his arms around her, picking her up in a hug.

"Put me the fuck down Busto we are right next to a fucking cliff!" Catra panics.

"Oh right, sorry," Busto apologizes and safely puts her down away from the cliff.

"I'm glad you feel better Catra," Gr'wliger agrees. "But let's get back to Half Moon before it gets dark."

Shire grabs Busto's arm and fervently nods, "Please."

As they return to Half Moon, Catra smiles. *This* is where she belongs.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading and please consider reading a comment! I suck at replying but I really do appreciate you all.

If you wish to hear more from me, whether it be story WIPs of my inane ramblings, consider following me @Sniperdoodle12 on Twitter or at sniperdoodle on Tumblr. I hope you all have a good week!

ill prove to the crowd that ill come out stronger, but i think i might lie here for a little longer

Chapter Summary

Catra and Ri'ta discuss magic and the past.

Chapter Notes

I don't have much to say at the top other than welcome back and thank-you for reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day after throwing her Force Captain badge into the ocean, Catra has another lesson with Ri'ta. The mage smiles as Catra enters the library, "Hey, I like the new haircut."

Catra's hair has changed, she cut it shorter and now has it in a ponytail high on her head. She's been playing with the ponytail all day, not used to the weight of it, and reaches up to touch it as she mutters, "Oh, uh, thanks."

"What inspired the change?" Ri'ta asks.

"Busto said that I should get an 'emotionally freeing haircut' to go with my 'emotionally freeing moment'," Catra explains. When Ri'ta gives her a curious look, she adds, "I threw my old force captain badge into the ocean."

"Ah," Ri'ta nods. "How'd you feel after your 'emotionally freeing moment'?"

"Good. Real good," Catra admits.

"I'm glad," Ri'ta smiles. "Are you ready for today's lesson?"

She nods. Despite this only being their second lesson, Catra was getting a good grip on magic. The basics came to her easily, like a muscle memory. So, it's time for the next step.

"Now that you've mastered the basics, let's talk about the different types of magic," Ri'ta begins. "Magic can be organized two ways: by deity or by function. If you go by deity, there are three or six types. If you go by function, there's five. Some insist that there's six but divination is unproven to work and entirely baseless in my own opinion."

"Divination?" Catra questions.

"Supposedly being able to see into the future," Ri'ta sighs. "However, half of divination spells require components that are proven hallucinogens so that's where the 'seeing the future' part comes in. The other half are just stupid."

"Do you have some kind a beef with divination?" Catra checks.

"I had a . . . *small* rivalry with a girl who insisted she was a diviner at the old Conservatory, probably because I went out of my way to disprove all of her 'prophecies'," Ri'ta taps her chin. "But that's a story for another day. Back on track, the three divine magics are healing, war and elemental magic, associated with Lyses, Saz and Ilir respectively. They all have an advanced form which is why I said that there could also be six divine magics. However, we'll be focusing on sorting magic by function. The five types of magic are enchantment, healing, illusion, thaumaturgy, and war.

"Enchantment is about manipulating thoughts, entrancing others," Ri'ta sees the frown on Catra's face and ensures, "Don't worry, it was banned by the Council about a hundred years ago since it was often used for naught. All of our enchantment books are in the restricted sections and protected by my own charms."

Catra lets out a deep breath, “Okay. So, next is healing? That’s just curing wounds, right?”

“When you say it, it sounds simple,” Ri’ta says. “But in reality, you have to have a very strong knowledge of the body. You don’t want to try and heal a broken leg with a spell meant to cure a cold, right?”

“I guess?” Catra shrugs. She that’s probably why Shire is very careful with her spells.

“Illusion is about deceiving senses, making people see something that’s there but is not really,” Ri’ta continues. “It’s similar to a trick of the light. Recently, I worked with Lionel’o to use illusion magic to develop fake fire traps for beasts.”

Catra vaguely remembers Lionel’o talking about something like that, but Gr’wliger wanted to test it a bit more before using it out in the field. She feels a bit better now knowing that Ri’ta had a hand in it.

“Thaumaturgy is all about the manipulation of inanimate objects,” Ri’ta says. “It could be taking multiple items and combining them to make something new, or make something animated. Finally, war magic is the primary weapon of war mages,” she pauses and smiles. “Which is what I am.”

“Really?” Catra raises an eyebrow. “You don’t seem like a warrior to me.”

“I suppose I am more of a teacher these days,” Ri’ta sighs. “But I do still consider myself a war mage.”

“Sure, you’re ferocious,” Catra rolls her eyes at the kindly mage. “But what the fuck is a war mage?”

“A war mage . . . doesn’t focus on one discipline of magic, like illusion or thaumaturgy. They instead cover a broad subject of spells that can aid them and their allies, ranging from

offensive, defensive, and augmentation, while keeping in peak physical form as a warrior," Ri'ta explains.

"Why did you become one?" Catra asks. It's hard for her to see Ri'ta as anything other than a teacher and her mother. She would almost say that she doesn't have the snuff to be a warrior, seeing as how much she cares for the well-being of everyone around her. Or maybe that's just a Horde mindset she needs to lose.

"Some become war mages to try and impress Saz, others have had the title of 'war mage' passed down in their clan for centuries. I, however," Ri'ta pauses dramatically. "Became a war mage because I thought that it would impress pretty girls."

"Really?" Catra laughs, and when a chorus of 'shushes' come from the scholars she covers her mouth to stifle her laughter.

"Yes, and for the record, it worked," Ri'ta insists. "I bested C'yra in combat and she was quite smitten with me."

"I need to hear this story," Catra demands.

Ri'ta smiles and begins, "It was shortly after my mother, Fel'cty, and I moved back from Mystacor to New Moon. I first saw C'yra while I was training with my mother in the old Conservatory. She was running around for some reason, but I was so caught up in the vision of her that I dropped a spell on my mother. It took her days to get the residual gunk out of her fur, but at least she wasn't too mad at me.

"After that, I tried to get C'yra's attention for a week, but she practically lived in the Grand Arena at that time, always training and fighting. I figured that if I wanted to talk to C'yra face-to-face . . . I'd have to face her in combat.

"I found her training with Az'al that day, and it was stupidly hot outside, I certainly remember that. It almost dissuaded me, the idea of fighting in the heat, but thankfully I

pushed on. I marched into the arena, straight up to C'yra, and challenged her.

"She was quite confused; she had never seen me before in her life. She was reluctant at first, but thankfully Az'al goaded her into a battle. C'yra tried to go easy on me at first, until I hit her with a spell that shocked her and caused her to drop her weapon. Then she knew she had a real challenge on her hands.

"I was put on the defensive for a while-I had to waste quite a bit of energy creating shields in odd spots-but I spent enough time observing her to find a blind spot. To make sure I was able to hit it, I cast three augmentation on myself-speed, strength, and aim-so that next time when she tried to strike, I twisted around her and jabbed the butt of my weapon into her back. She fell on the ground and I with her, pinning her to the ground. As I caught my breath and the spells wore off, she just looked at me in shock. I think that was the first time she got pinned since she was a kit. I figured that was a good time to finally introduce myself to her, then I got off of her and left.

"The next day, C'yra knocked on my door with a handful of flowers she picked from the Royal Gardens to ask me out on a date. She was incredibly flustered and it probably didn't help that Az'al was laughing her ass off behind a bush in the background. But I said yes."

Ri'ta finishes the story with a soft smile on her face, her eyes staring off into the distance as she reminisces. Catra lets her have a moment, and she turns to her, placing a hand on her shoulder and saying, "And I guess you can figure out the rest of that tale."

"Alright, it sounds like you were a pretty cool war mage," Catra admits.

"Present tense, dear," Ri'ta corrects.

"You *are* a pretty cool war mage," Catra repeats. "I'm surprised that C'yra got all embarrassed like that. She doesn't seem like the type."

"Oh Catra, C'yra has always been quite the romantic mess," Ri'ta laughs. "But, that's why I love her. And love to tease her. But we've got quite off track. Where did we start?"

"War magic," Catra says, not going back quite far enough to the start, but that's what she's curious about. "I get needing offensive and defensive spells, but what's augmentation?"

"Augmentation spells are usually spells cast on yourself or others to improve your physical form in battle," Ri'ta explains. "You have to be careful though, too many augmentation spells cast on one person can exhaust them. The recommended amount is one augmentation spell at a time."

"So, what happened after you cast three on yourself when you fought C'yra?" Catra questions.

"Oh, I went home and slept for a whole day. I was only up for an hour before C'yra came to visit," Ri'ta chuckles. "It took me a couple more times of doing something foolish like that to learn my lesson. But I can save those stories for later, if you want to learn some actual magic."

"Yeah sure, we were working on more advanced light spells, right?" Catra says.

"Why don't we take a detour today?" Ri'ta grins. "Why don't I teach you a few augmentation spells?" She walks over to one of the shelves and pulls out another book, "You're adept enough now to branch off into other subjects, besides it's a way to get a good foundation in spellcasting, to try different subjects. So, are you up for it?"

War magic seems like it would be useful if Catra ever had to go back to the Fight Zone and give Hordak and Shadow Weaver a piece of her mind. Besides, maybe she could one-up C'yra like

her mother once did, one of these days. Catra nods and Ri'ta begins the lesson anew.

They talk about some of the rules of augmentation magic and how it works. Most spells don't just make you stronger, instead they react with the body to release more adrenaline or whatever hormone makes you better at that one thing for a short time. Then, they get to the practice.

"So, the easiest augmentation spell to cast is speed," Ri'ta explains. "And it's easier to cast it on someone else first. If you want me to show you how it's done, I can cast it on you first before you try."

All functions in Catra's brain stops as the sirens blare. An old fear, one she had learned quickly in her early days of the Horde springs to the surface and she doesn't want to do anything other than run.

Ri'ta places her hand on Catra's shoulder and squeezes, "Catra, are you-" she cuts herself off, "Oh scat, I'm so sorry Catra, I can't believe I forgot. I'm not going to do any magic to you, alright? I promise."

Ri'ta sounds like she's telling the truth, but her brain doesn't want to let her believe it. She manages to mumble, "C- . . . can we not do augmentation?"

"Yes, of course," Ri'ta says, closing the book as a finality to her statement. "Why don't we take a break? It might be too early to get dinner, but we could see what C'yra is up to? Just to get out of the library."

Catra nods, and Ri'ta keeps a hand on her shoulder as the two of them leave. Catra finds herself able to breathe easy again as they pass through the heavy iron doors of the library.

"I'm very sorry Catra, I didn't mean to be so careless and frighten you like that," Ri'ta apologizes as they enter the caverns.

New anxieties replace the old ones, and Catra takes a deep breath before she checks, "Are . . . are you mad that I didn't want to do the spell? That our lesson ended early today?"

"No, not at all!" Ri'ta insists. "If you aren't comfortable with a type of magic, that's fine. I want you to be happy, and if doing a certain subject of magic upsets you, we won't touch it. And there's always tomorrow. Now, where do you think your mother might be at this time of day?"

"Doing paperwork?" Catra guesses.

"Worth a check," Ri'ta agrees.

They stop by the Queen's office, but C'yra's nowhere to be found.

"She must be at the training grounds then," Ri'ta guesses. "The paperwork probably got to her."

"Or . . . she could be training somewhere else," Catra suggests.

Ri'ta quirks an eyebrow, and Catra wonders if she's spilled a secret she wasn't supposed to tell. But, Ri'ta's eyes light up and she says, "Ah, so she's showed you her secret spot. It's been a while since I've been there, if you want to lead the way."

Catra lets out a breath she was holding, and the two make their way to the small cavern with glowing mushrooms. Catra was right on the money, C'yra's training, going through drills silently, not knowing that her wife and daughter have snuck up on her.

"How long do you think it'll take her to notice us?" Catra whispers to Ri'ta.

"It depends on how badly paperwork pissed her off," Ri'ta says out loud. This causes C'yra to jump, dropping her sword.

Glaring at Ri'ta, C'yra sighs, "You two could have given me some type of warning!"

"We weren't exactly subtle in coming here, dear," Ri'ta reveals. "So, was I right? Paperwork?"

"Not quite," C'yra grunts. She sheathes her sword and checks her light watch, "I thought you two would still be having your lessons."

"Decided to cut it early today," Ri'ta reveals. "It was getting a bit . . . heavy. We figured that you would be doing something interesting."

"Hhm, just trying to destress," C'yra shrugs. "But, since we're both here Catra, we could spar if you wanted to."

"Why not?" Catra shrugs. She joins C'yra in the center, pausing to ask Ri'ta, "You wanna join us? You were bragging about how great of a war mage you are earlier."

"And embarrass C'yra? I could never," Ri'ta teases.

"I'm not embarrassed easily," C'yra tries to insist.

"She already told me about how she kicked your ass when you two first met," Catra chimes in.

A blush creeps up on C'yra's face, and she manages to keep her voice even, "Is that so?"

"I did," Ri'ta says. "But I'm still going to sit this one out. I'd rather watch today."

"Might be for the best," C'yra mutters. "You and I can . . . get caught up when we spar."

"Aw, gross!" Catra chimes.

“Not like that!” C’yra claims, the blush blooming on her face.

“Don’t break your mother, dear, only I can do that,” Ri’ta says as she finds a rock on the side to sit on.

C’yra tries to get her head straight, clearing her throat when she turns to Catra, “You should use your spear today.”

Catra pulls the spear off her back. Since finding out it belonged to her grandmother it felt heavier in her hands, but she has decided that it’s easier to hunt with it than fight. She raises an eyebrow, “Why?”

“I was reading through my mother’s old journal the other day,” C’yra says. “And I discovered that the spear was made to channel the Fire of Saz.”

“Really?” Catra checks.

“That’s what she said,” C’yra nods. “Her powerful connection to the Stone was one of the reasons why she was given this spear in the first place. Might help with channeling the power of the Stone.”

“Oh, Catra!” Ri’ta suddenly calls out. “Did you ever tell C’yra about how your hand caught on fire during our first lesson?”

“You don’t need to tell her that,” Catra grumbles.

“Hey, I’m your mother. It's my job to embarrass you.”

“I knew you two started magic lessons, but what happened?” C’yra questions.

“I tried to make light but accidentally summoned the Fire,” Catra admits. “I haven’t tried it since.”

“Well, now’s a good of time as any,” C’yra says. “Are you ready?”

Catra nods, “Ready.”

The two fall into a familiar pattern, of baiting and trading blows and waiting for an opening. Catra waits to get into the rhythm of the fight before trying to channel the Fire of Saz through the spear. Like the other day in the library, she images a warm hearth with a roaring flame. Instead of appearing at the tips of her fingers, she feels the fire move into the spear. The spear lights up with an orange glow, and fire trails from the tip as she swings it around. C’yra doesn’t stop to congratulate her (because Catra would just use that as an opening) but the smile on her face is enough to know that she’s done a good job. She thinks she might even hear Ri’ta cheering from the sidelines, but she’s too engrossed in the fight to really pay attention.

After an indefinite amount of time lost to the rush of adrenaline, Catra and C’yra stop at the same time, staring from each other across the room.

“Good fight,” C’yra says with a smile.

“You too,” Catra replies.

“Man, you two make me want to get in there,” Ri’ta says as she joins them, arms crossed and a smirk on her face. “Catra, I bet I could give you a run for your money.”

“I’d like to see you try,” Catra challenges.

“She would,” C’yra backs Ri’ta up.

“I could take both of you on,” Ri’ta boasts. “Not right now though, it wouldn’t be fair. You two stopped at the perfect time, it’s almost dinner.”

“Good, I’m starving,” Catra admits, the adrenaline fading away to reveal her growing hunger.

“Oh uh, before we leave,” C’yra begins. “Catra, I wanted to talk to you but I got distracted by the fight. I hope this doesn't

seem odd, but I have something to request of you," C'yra's taking her time to talk carefully, which is already odd.

"That doesn't sound ominous," Catra huffs, trying to deflect the dread growing inside her.

"It's nothing bad, just . . . important, I suppose," C'yra continues. Catra glances over Ri'ta, who isn't interjecting but seems curious as well. This must be about something C'yra hasn't told her. "And I would never force you to do anything, so you can certainly decline, but . . . I would appreciate it and I think you will too."

"Then just spit it out," Catra says, getting sick of C'yra beating around the bush.

C'yra finally concedes, "I'd like you to compete in the Jellicle Ball."

"The what now?"

"It's an old Magicat tradition," Ri'ta chimes in. "Once a year, we hold a tournament, consisting of our finest warriors, and usually the ones on the youthful side too. It's dedicated to Saz, and was originally meant to show off our best soldiers to him, but now it's for fun and a little bit of glory."

"If it's a fighting tournament then why is it called a ball?" Catra questions.

Ri'ta shrugs, and C'yra adds, "We do hold more festivities afterwards. There's a feast and a dance."

"But wouldn't like . . ." Catra bites her lip, a dark feeling settling in the pit of her stomach, "Wouldn't going out and beating up other Magicats make people think I'm a Horde soldier even more?"

"No, I hope that it will do the exact opposite," C'yra says, squeezing Catra's shoulder. "The Jellicle Ball is a Magicat tradition.

If you join in, its showing that you're a part of our culture and one of us. And there are rules in place to make sure that no one's maimed, so there's that as well."

"It's a far cry from the gladiatorial bloodshed is was long ago," Ri'ta adds.

"Plus, you were an exceptional warrior when you came to Half Moon, and you've only gotten better," C'yra says with a twinkle in her eye that Catra can't identify (maybe it was just a trick of the lack of light? or dust?). "I believe that you would do very well if you competed. So, will you?"

Catra's still worried about her . . . dissenters being able to find some offense in her willingness to compete, but the pros C'yra laid out seem to outweigh the cons . . . Catra takes a deep breath and says, "Yeahokayilldoitwhatever."

C'yra smiles, "Thank-you. You're going to do great."

"So, when is this thing?" Catra questions.

"It's in a few weeks, but sign-ups are earlier and there's time to focus on training," C'yra explains. "We can continue spar, if you want, but many Magicats find it fun to train with their friends. Busto and Gr'wliger have competed in the past and will both probably sign-up as well."

Catra's already having doubts it both Gr'wliger and Busto are competing. They're both amazing fighters . . . but she supposes that if she trains with them, she'll have a leg-up on how they'll do in the competition.

"And I can help as well," Ri'ta adds. "We can start focusing on war magic in our lesson, if you wish, ignoring the more . . . personal spells."

Catra knows that Ri'ta wouldn't force her to do something she was uncomfortable with, so she isn't afraid to answer when she says, "Yeah, of course!"

C'yra stands up, checking her watch as she does, "Well, we should get to the dining hall or else we'll miss dinner."

"Like Jen'dots would let us starve," Catra rolls her eyes.

"Yes, but I'd still like to stay on her good side," C'yra admits. "And, I'm hungry."

"All that watching made me hungry as well," Ri'ta jokes. "Are you going to eat with tonight, Catra?"

"Yeah sure," Catra says. "Maybe you can tell me some more embarrassing stories about C'yra."

"There's not many," C'yra claims.

"There are so many, I don't know if I could pick just one," Ri'ta jokes. C'yra glares at her, but she starts making her way towards the exit, "But really, let's talk over food."

They make their way back to the main caverns, Catra can't help but feel comfortable. Sure, she has the Jellicle Ball now to worry about, but that's a problem for future Catra. Tonight, she was going to spend time with her moms.

Chapter End Notes

So . . . we've reached the end of all the chapters I have written right now so I'd have to consider this hiatus officially a go (watch me eat my words once again). This does not mean that the fic is dead, it just means that I have school to deal with.

If you'd like to know what I'm doing in the meantime, you should follow me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or tumblr at sniperdoodle. I'm trying to get better at posting about writing updates so we'll see what happens.

In the meantime, I appreciate all your comments and I'll see you all at the end of the semester!

Interlude IV: Adora

Chapter Summary

Adora sails to Beast Island.

Chapter Notes

I'm back! Uh, sorry about the long wait? This interlude is pretty short but then I got stuck with the next chapter and had to rewrite it twice, so please enjoy this two'fer!

In other news, Lara_84 has made some really cool fanart that you can find here!.

Other than that, I hope y'all enjoy the chapters!

Bow once told Adora that listening to waves crashing upon a shore is supposed to be calming. However, as she watches the water splash against the hull of Sea Hawk's boat, Adora does not feel calm. She is very much on edge and cannot ignore the dread growing inside her. Even Sea Hawk, Bow and Scorpia singing sea shanties can't distract her.

"*Hey, ho, we'll go anywhere the wind is blowing! Friendly friends are weeeeee! Sailing for adventure on the deep blue sea!*"

Okay, it was a little distracting.

But for the most part, Adora can't stop thinking about Catra. Beast Island is an unknown, even after all the research Bow's dads gave them, so her imagination runs wild going through every single possibility. Most of these elaborate thoughts end with Catra dead, which is the last thing she wants.

Has Catra been able to survive on Beast Island all this time? Back in the Horde, Shadow Weaver and other Captains told stories about Beast Island to keep the cadets in line-each story ending with the line "and they were never seen again". If the tales

are true, then will she never see Catra again? With everything that happened between them left unresolved?

"Hey," Glimmer puts a hand on Adora's shoulder, spooking her out of her thoughts. Adora actually almost jumps off the side of the ship, but Glimmer's hand keeps her centered, "Oh jeez, are you okay, Adora?"

"Yeah! Why wouldn't I be okay?" Adora lies.

Glimmer gives her a pointed look, clearly seeing through her. She begins, "We're headed to a dangerous, beast-covered island that belonged to an extinct civilization to try and find your friend turned enemy. You have a *lot* you can be worried about."

Adora sighs, "Okay fine. I might be . . . a bit worried."

"A bit?" Glimmer asks.

"Okay a lot worried," Adora finally admits. "It's been a couple months. Catra's been alone, on *Beast Island*, for months. And I didn't know about it. If something happened to her . . . I don't think I could ever forgive myself."

In part of her mind, Catra is still her best friend-despite their recent . . . differences. They may be on opposite sides of a war, but Adora's never *really* wanted to hurt Catra, or wanted her gone. She always thought that despite how stubborn Catra is, one day she could convince her over to the side of the Princess Alliance, to leave the Horde behind. But now, she may never get the chance.

"Adora, it wouldn't be your fault-"

"But it would!" Adora insists. "I should've known something bad would've happened if Shadow Weaver left the Horde, or, or done more to try and get Catra to join the Princess Alliance, or-"

"It was out of your hands, Adora," Glimmer insists, placing her hands on both of Adora's shoulders, trying to center her. "We had no way of knowing what was happening in the Horde until Scorpia came to us. Besides, Catra's strong. She's stubborn. If there's anyone who could take on an island full of beasts and survive, it's her-even if she's powered only by spite. Think of it, she's probably *super* angry at Hordak now, right?"

". . . Right," Adora agrees.

"So, wouldn't she want revenge against Hordak now too?"

". . . Probably."

"And that'll be enough to drive her to survive, right? Along with her beef with you?"

". . . Yeah," Adora agrees.

"So, when we get to Beast Island, we're going to find her," Glimmer insists. "And she'll probably attack us. But, repeat after me: we're going to find Catra."

"We're going to find Catra," Adora repeats.

"Say it louder!"

"We're going to find Catra!"

"Louder!"

"WE'RE GOING TO FIND CATRA!"

"Yeah!"

"Hey guys, why are we shouting?" Scorpia asks as she comes over.

"We're going to find Catra!" Adora shouts once again.

"Uh, yeah!" Scorpia enthusiastically agrees, though she looks slightly confused. "Oh, and Glimmer, Bow says he needs your help because Sea Hawk keeps on talking about setting the boat on fire? He's not going to do that, right? Because we still need to get back?"

"Oh no," Glimmer groans. "Scorpia, I'm going to need your help restraining Sea Hawk until his pyromaniac urges have subsided," she grabs Scorpia's hand and begins to drag her over to the other side of the ship, "And Adora, everything's going to be okay!"

Adora turns back to the sea, and tunes out . . . whatever's going on behind her. She repeats the mantra in her head: we're going to find Catra, we're going to find Catra, we're going to find Catra, we're going to find Catra . . .

On the endless, blue horizon, a distinct shape appears. Lush green covers the island, but Adora knows what dangers lie beneath. Straight ahead, is Beast Island.

And hopefully, Catra will be alright.

should old acquaintance be forgot and never brought to mind? should old acquaintance be forgot and auld lang syne?

Chapter Summary

Interlopers are found on Beast Island.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With the Jellicle Ball coming up, Catra is doing her best to prepare. Most Magicats competing will be soldiers who train every day. She needs an advantage against them, and one is clear: magic.

She's determined to learn as many war spells as she can before the Ball-as Ri'ta later explained some of the rules to her and only war magic spells are allowed. That's why she's in the library with Ri'ta early in the morning, on a day she doesn't have to go on a hunt.

"So," Ri'ta glances up from the spell book. "Think you're ready to try it?"

"Yeah," Catra nods determinedly. They've been talking about theory and form and all that jazz for about a half an hour, it's gotten to the point where Catra just wants to try the spell.

Ri'ta steps back, giving Catra space. The spell in question is a shield spell-one that can temporarily block attacks without the need for components. Components will make it stronger, but Catra can't bring spell components into the tournament-only weapons.

Taking a deep breath, Catra crosses her arms at the wrist in front of her face. She closes her eyes, imagining a shield in her mind. However, the only one that comes to mind is the one she

saw on the arm of She-Ra . . . she chases that thought out of her mind with a small shake of her head and a scowl. She instead tries to think of the shield C'yra wears when they spar, and speaks the command word, "*Scutum*."

Catra opens her eyes, but keeps her arms up. Ri'ta walks over and flicks the air where the shield should form, but her finger passes through, "Good first try, kitten."

"Nothing happened," Catra grumbles as her arms drop. "How's that good?"

"You had good form and pronounced the command word correctly," Ri'ta insists. "Mages usually don't get this spell on their first try, so don't worry."

Other spells just click with Catra and so far, she's gotten most of them on the first try, and a part of her feels like she's letting Ri'ta down every time she doesn't perform it perfectly on the first try. But, Ri'ta's never disappointed with her, always encouraging, so she tries again.

Arms crossed. Eyes closed. Shield imagine-no not She-Ra's shield! The soldiers have shields, right? They're probably made of wood or metal. And not gold and glowing. That'll do. Another deep breath, "*Scutum*."

Once again, Ri'ta tries to tap the shield, but there's nothing there.

"Saz dammit it!" Catra hisses.

"Hey, it's alright," Ri'ta places her hand on Catra's shoulder. "Every mage has spells they struggle with-and this is only your second try."

"Right," Catra takes a deep breath. "I'll get it on the third."

"You don't even have to get it right on the third try," Ri'ta insists. "Or the fourth, fifth, sixth, and so on. With magic, sometimes you just have to keep on trying. No mage is perfect."

Catra tries to believe Ri'ta's words, and takes a step back to try again. Arms crossed. Eyes closed. Imagine a shield (please not She-Ra's shield). Another deep breath, "*Scutum*."

Nothing.

"It's alright," Ri'ta preemptively insists.

"Are you sure I'm not doing anything wrong?" Catra quickly asks.

"Everything seems fine to me," Ri'ta says. "Are you visualizing a shield? If a generic shield isn't working, maybe think of a particular person's shield-like C'yra's."

That's what she *has* been doing. She tries to think of C'yra's shield, but only She-Ra's shield is coming into her brain. Maybe she just has to think *harder*, "Let's try again-"

"Catra!" Sh'dowell hisses loudly as they run into the library. They seem to be doing their best to stay quiet, but still gets 'shushed' by the few scholars in the library.

She lets the spell fizzle out in her hand and turns to the hunter. They're out of breath, and must've run here from their hunt, but why? She asks, "Sh'dowell, aren't you supposed to be out with Gr'wliger and Demeter?"

"Yeah, yeah," they nod, gasping for breath. "But we. . . found . . . a boat."

"A Horde ship?" Catra asks. This gets Ri'ta's attention, and she walks over to listen in.

"No," Sh'dowell insists. "Just like . . . a normal-ass ship. Dunno why they're here."

"Why are you telling me?" Catra questions them. "Shouldn't you tell C'yra?"

"Went there first," Sh'dowell says. "She's alerting the guard. But Gr'wliger wants you to come out. You know mainland Etheria best."

Catra frowns. She may be able to identify the ship, or maybe not. The former scares her more-since who knows who could be on the ship. She would like to stay in the library and train, but knows she has to go in case this ship spells trouble for Half Moon.

"Okay," Catra grabs her cloak from the chair she threw it on. "Let's go."

"Catra," Ri'ta stops her by placing a hand on her shoulder and squeezing it. "Be careful."

"I will," Catra promises. "Can we continue the lesson when I get back?"

"Of course," Ri'ta nods. "I'll be helping C'yra, so just come find me."

With that, Catra and Sh'dowell leave the Caves of Half Moon. Rain pours from the sky, making the ground muddy and damp. Catra pulls her cloak tighter around her, silently cursing the weather as she follows Sh'dowell. They're usually talkative-eager to make jokes and get others to laugh-but now, they're silent as they rush through the forests.

"Are you nervous?" Catra asks as the two get closer to the edge of the island.

"Yeah," Sh'dowell admits with a gasp. "The Horde dropping prisoners off is one thing. Someone deliberately coming to the island is another."

Catra nods, sharing the sentiment. Who would willingly come to Beast Island?

Gr'wliger and Demeter are waiting at the tree line, tucked underneath the canopy and staring at the beached ship. It's smaller than a Horde transport carrier, and flashier too. It's an Etherian-made boat.

"Catra," Gr'wliger turns to her. "Thank-you for coming."

"Yeah. No problem," Catra mutters. "So. That's the boat."

"No shit," Demeter rolls her eyes.

"What are your thoughts on it," Gr'wliger asks.

As she stares at the ship, Catra can't help but get a nagging feeling that it's familiar. She ignores it and answers, "It looks like it's from Salineas."

"Salineas?" Sh'dowell asks.

"It's a sea kingdom," Catra says. "So, this could be a merchant ship, scouting for materials, maybe."

"I remember some of the merchant vessels when I was young," Gr'wliger points out. "I wouldn't be able to name a kingdom, but this looks more like a sailing ship, merchant vessels are much bigger."

"Then why are they here?" Demeter asks.

"Stupidity?" Catra suggests.

"Could it be the Horde?" Gr'wliger says.

"Unlikely," Catra argues. "Beast Island is a capital punishment and in their territory. Why go to the lengths of disguising yourself when it's *your* death island?"

"To draw us out and finish us off?" Demeter points out with crossed arms.

"The majority of the Horde doesn't know about the Magicats," Catra insists. "As far as I know, only Hordak does-and he has his hands full with Princesses." There was also Shadow Weaver, but she disappeared from the Horde. Catra's sure that the bitch has no idea she has returned to Beast Island and reunited with her parents.

"So . . . we're back at square one not knowing who it is," Sh'dowell shakily sighs.

"Now what?" Catra questions. "Let the beasts kill those idiots?" For some reason, that thought makes her stomach feel sick. If she was still a Horde soldier-she wouldn't hesitate. But . . . she also shouldn't hesitate to protect Half Moon. She knows there is another option to who could be on Beast Island-she just doesn't want to accept it.

"The rain has washed away their tracks," Gr'wliger says with a frown. "The path that leads here splits-so we'll have to split up into pairs to follow each path."

"Why?" Sh'dowell asks. "Are . . . we *trying* to find them?"

"We need to make sure that they stay away from Half Moon," Gr'wliger says. "And to try to discern their intentions-but do not interact with them. Understood?"

The hunters nod and follow Gr'wliger into the forests. He's the best tracker in Half Moon-but the rain has covered the interloper's trail.

At the fork in the path, Gr'wliger turns to the hunters, "Sh'dowell, with me. We'll take the left path. Demeter and Catra, you two will go down the right path."

"Wait, what?!" Catra and Demeter exclaim at the same time. He knows that they *don't* get along and usually he doesn't

pair them together.

"Demeter and I are better trackers while Catra and Sh'dowell are better combatants," Gr'wliger justifies. "Just trust me and *don't* fight."

"Fine," Demeter huffs.

"You owe me," Catra hisses, pointing a finger at Gr'wliger. "For making me do this."

The Magicats split up and stick to the shadows and underbrush, hoping to remain hidden when they find the newcomers.

Catra and Demeter follow the path and the rain follows suit as the drizzle disappears. Though Demeter is a better tracker, there's not much to track-until they find the large beast paw sunken into the mud of the path.

Demeter doesn't say anything, just crouches down next to the track for a moment and says, "I think this beast is following something-it usually doesn't stray onto hunter paths."

"So, it's following our interlopers," Catra says.

"Oh well, we don't need to worry now," Demeter sighs. "They're probably dead."

For some reason, that doesn't sit well with Catra, and she insists, "We should still follow-just to make sure."

"Fine," Demeter sighs.

It doesn't take them long to catch-up to the beast especially because it seems that it has found the interlopers. The beast- an older one, evident by the scarring on its hind and the haziness of one eye-chased them into a small ravine (Catra knows the feeling) and cornered them. Catra has learned that the older a

beast gets, the more dangerous it is. Afterall, it was smart enough to trap the interlopers.

As for the interlopers . . . Catra recognizes them. Oh, she recognizes them very well.

The Princess Alliance has found their way to Beast Island, and is meeting its namesake head on. Bow is firing arrows while Glimmer teleports around and throws sparkles at the beast. A pirate-Catra thinks Scorpia mentioned his name is Sea Hawk-is trying to poke the beast with a sword, but gets knocked back with a swipe of its paw. The only people doing any damage are Scorpia . . . and She-Ra.

Catra didn't expect the *Princess Alliance* of all people to be here. She thought that maybe, one day, a Princess would be captured by the Horde and sentenced to Beast Island, causing them to go on a rescue mission. If that day ever came, Catra would have done her best to avoid them. But . . . why is Scorpia with them? Did they make Scorpia direct them to Beast Island-though she, like every other member of the Horde, probably did not know where the island is located-or . . . or did they come for Catra?

Why? Why would they *bother* coming to look for her? After everything she did to them and Adora? Why would *Adora* come to look for her?!

As Catra watches the beast approach her friends? Enemies? Rivals? Whatever they are, the beast approaches them and Catra's mind starts to churn out a plan. She could leave them and let nature take care of this problem-survival of the fittest and all-but Catra's sure that even She-Ra won't be able to take down an old beast . . . at least not alone. One thing is clear in her mind: she doesn't want Scorpia . . . or Adora . . . to die.

"Demeter, I need you to trust me," Catra begins. "We need to rescue them."

"Even though one of them is clearly a Horde soldier?" Demeter checks.

"Yes," Catra says. “Well, that sparkly one, hard to look at, is a Princess.”

“Which sparkly one? The tall, hot one or the short one?”

Catra can’t help but scowl as Demeter calls She-Ra ‘hot’, for some reason. Whatever, she can unpack that later, “The one wasting all her teleports.”

“And how do you know that?” Demeter continues, raising a brow in suspicion.

“I’m a *former* Horde soldier, remember? The Princesses were my enemy,” Catra snaps. It’s not the full truth-but it should be enough to temper Demeter’s curiosity. “Let’s get a move on before they die.”

"Alright," Demeter shrugs. "We gonna kill the beast or scare it away?"

Catra's surprised that Demeter is on-board for this, that Catra has to pause. She shakes her head as she gets back in the game, "A beast that old? It’ll be stubborn. Even if we try to coordinate with, She-Ra, it'll be hard to chase it away."

"Who's She-Ra?"

"The eight-foot glowing one with the sword."

"Oh. The hot one"

Catra glares at Demeter, trying to ignore the feeling of heat rushing up to her cheeks, "Shut up and stay on track. What should we do?"

Demeter digs into her bag and pulls out a flint and steel, “I can light my arrows on fire to kill it, but it won’t be enough

since you don't have a bow with you." She may not have a bow, but Catra has something else-the Fire of Saz.

"I have magic," Catra lies. "Go to the other side of the ravine. We'll corner it in and kill it with fire."

With that, the two separate to circle around and get on either side of the beast. The Rebellion seems to be doing their best to hold the beast back; She-Ra has changed the sword into a shield to block the beast's long claws, Glimmer is throwing sparkle bombs at its eyes to try and blind it while Bow shoots arrows into its thick hide. Scorpia is grappling one paw with her own claws, and Sea Hawk is hiding behind her.

When Catra gets into position, she is able to spot Demeter across the way. They share a nod before Demeter lights her arrows and Catra summons the Fire of Saz in her hands. She's only ever channeled it into her spear or claws, maybe she can just . . . throw it like a snowball?

A second later, Demeter releases her arrow and Catra pitches a ball of fire, bursting as it hits the beast's side. The beast dies quickly, succumbing to the flames, and letting out one last cry before it collapses. The flames quickly ravage it, fur turning to ash and flesh burning.

The Princess Alliance members stare at the dead beast in shock. Adora freaks out first, "Where'd all that fire come from!?"

"Those were arrows," Bow points out. He steps forward, straightening his back and notching an arrow, "Who goes there?!"

"*Now what?*" Demeter mouths as she glares at Catra.

Good question. Catra holds up a finger and asks Demeter to wait, before moving forward and revealing herself to the Princesses, "Wow. Great job taking out that beast guys. Glad to see the Princess Alliance still has it."

Everyone looks up at her with mixed variations of surprise. Glimmer and Bow are both shocked and horrified. Adora is flabbergasted and Scorpia looks elated. Their reactions make her feel warm inside, dramatics were always her things.

She flicks off her hood as she stares right at Adora and grins, "Hey Adora."

"Catra," Adora almost whispers, filled with hope and surprise, which sends a spark down her spine.

Catra ignores it as she hops down from the ledge. "So, what brings you all-"

Before she can say anything, Scorpia sprints over and wraps her arms around her, lifting her off of the ground. Catra would protest, but she actually missed the bone-breaking hugs Scorpia would give her. Scorpia cries, "Oh my gosh, Wildcat, I'm so glad you're okay! You gave me such a scare; I was so worried!"

"Yeah, good to see you too," Catra chokes out. "Now, can you put me down, please?"

"Oh yeah sure," Scorpia sets Catra down and brushes the dust off her shoulder. She pauses, "Did you just say please?"

"Uh . . . yeah?" Catra says.

Scorpia raises an eyebrow, "Are you the real Catra?"

"I better fuckin' be," Catra huffs.

Scorpia grins, "There's the Wildcat I know and love!"

"Catra," Adora says as she changes back from She-Ra, stepping forward like she might step on a mine if she's not careful enough. She continues, "What happened to you? You . . . look different."

Catra's about to retort something about the cloak and emotionally-freeing haircut, but Demeter interrupts, "Aw, the hot one's a Horde soldier too?"

Everyone turns to Demeter, who is now lazing besides a tree, messing with the string on her bow. She has her hood down as well, and everyone gasps when they see that she's a Magicat like Catra.

"Former Horde," Catra interrupts before any questions can be asked, because she has some of her own. She turns to Scorpia, "If you're with the Rebellion then did you . . ."

"Yeah, I left the Horde," Scorpia awkwardly rubs the back of her head. "I couldn't just stay there, not when they sent you here to die. I went to the Rebellion to try to get you back. Sorry it took so long, I guess you really didn't need saving."

Catra looks at Scorpia with wide eyes. She gave up everything she's known-the Horde, her family-just for a chance to save Catra. Catra sighs, "No, Scorpia, that's . . . got to be the, the nicest thing anyone's done for me. And, it's clear that the Horde doesn't want me but . . . I don't want to try to go back either. And I'm glad to see you again."

Tears start to appear at the corner of Scorpia's eyes, "You really mean that?"

Catra nods and begins to brace herself, "Yeah."

Scorpia tackles Catra as she hugs her, squeezing the breath out of her as she smiles and cries, "I'm glad to see you too, Wildcat."

"Uh, as touching and, quite frankly weird, reunion this is and all, but WHAT IS GOING ON!?" Glimmer shouts.

Scorpia puts Catra down, and Catra has enough energy to shush Glimmer at the same time as Demeter. Demeter continues, "You want another beast to show up?”

"Yeah, shut up," Catra adds. "So, you all came to rescue me?"

"Yes, but, it's clear you're doing fine," Bow says.

"Nah," Demeter interjects. "She got mauled by a beast and our healer had to fix her."

"Thanks," Catra sighs. "They really needed to know that."

Bow looks back at Demeter, "Who is that?"

"Demeter of Bom'luri, pleased to make your acquaintance," Demeter says.

“Why does she look like you?” Adora asks.

“She’s a Magicat,” Catra says. “Like me.”

“Wait, the Magicats survived?” Adora gasps. “Wait, *you’re* a Magicat?!”

“You’ve . . . heard of them?” Catra asks. She had never known that there was anyone that looks like her-how does Adora know?

“We learned about them from my dads,” Bow clears up. “We thought the Horde wiped you out.”

“They certainly tried,” Demeter huffs. “But also, hey Catra-what the fuck do we do now?”

"Ahg, right, how am I supposed to get all of you into Half Moon?" Catra switches gears. Adora and Scorpia are wearing their Horde uniforms still, so they'll instantly be accused of being Horde soldiers. As a consequence of that, Catra will be accused as well by her critics, like Gus. Catra needs to get them in Half Moon, has to get some disguises, and talk to her moms before anyone else can get to them. Then no one has to get in trouble.

"Can you please explain what's going on first?!" Glimmer requests.

At the same time, Demeter exclaims, "*That's* the first thing you want to do?! After we were told to a, not interact with them-which, by the way, I'm putting all the blame on you if we get in trouble-and b, to keep them away from Half Moon!"

Catra ignores Glimmer and walks over to the foot of the ledge where Demeter is still resting, "Look, I know we don't like each other, but I need you to trust me. They aren't going to do anything bad to Half Moon or the Magicats. I know that some people are going to think that I'm still a Horde soldier and this was all some grand scheme of mine-but it's not. Please trust me on this."

Demeter sits up and sighs, "You have that little faith in me, do you?"

"I just said, we don't like each other," Catra repeats.

"Okay, that's fair," Demeter blinks. "But I don't like you because I think you're annoying, over-confident, and reckless, not because you're a former Horde soldier. But you're a Magicat, like the rest of us."

"Huh," Catra feels a weight come off her shoulders. At least Demeter doesn't hate her because of the Horde, just because of who she is. That's kinda progress, "Thanks? I guess?"

Demeter shrugs, "I suggest you take what you can get."

"Okay, let's get you all to Half Moon," Catra says, and tries to get back to planning.

"Hold on!" Glimmer interrupts. "We're not going anywhere with you! This could be a trap!"

"If this was some scheme of Catra's, I wouldn't be working with her," Demeter interjects. "Last time I did I almost

got killed by robot squirrels.”

“Wait, what?” Scorpia questions, but the robot squirrels get glossed over.

"This could all be an act!" Glimmer points to Demeter. "So, I won't go anywhere until I'm sure of what's going on because, no offense Catra, I don't trust you!"

"S'fair," Catra agrees. She knows exactly what she's done to Glimmer and all of Bright Moon. "But here's two things. One, if we stay out here any longer, the beast might come back, and maybe he'll come back with some friends. Two, I hate mind games."

Adora steps besides Glimmer and puts a hand on her shoulder, "I trust her."

"Yeah, me too," Scorpia agrees.

"It might be a good idea to get out of the forest filled with beasts," Bow agrees.

"Yes, even though I wouldn't mind going hand-to-hand with another beast for the adventure . . . I think we all could use a rest," Sea Hawk adds.

Glimmer pouts but eventually spits, "Fuh-ine. But I don't like it one bit."

"Noted," Catra says. She rubs her chin, they have to get started soon, "We need to get going. But I think the easiest way is to enter through the hunter’s quarters and stash you somewhere so I can go and talk to the Queens about you all staying in Half Moon."

"Sounds like a plan," Demeter agrees. She hops down from the ledge to join everyone, "I'll take point. You keep your group quiet and out of sight."

Catra nods and turns back to the Rebellion, "Be as quiet as you can. Try not to step on any twigs or fall on your face."

The Princesses and company nod in agreement, and begin to follow Catra. Demeter carefully moves through the brush, trying to spot any lurking beasts.

Catra should be paying attention too, but her mind wanders. When they get to Half Moon, she needs to find the Queens to explain everything to them. While there's the fact that the Princess Alliance came looking for *her* she also needs to talk to them about her own princess shit. And the fact that Adora and Glimmer *cannot* find out that she's a Princess. At all.

"Uh, hey Catra!" Scorpia pulls Catra out of her thoughts, just in time for her to catch Adora looking back at her, but glances away and starts walking as soon as Catra catches her eye. Scorpia is doing her best to be quiet, but that was never her strong suit, "Whatcha thinkin' about?"

"What I have to do once we get back to Half Moon," Catra whispers back.

"Oh! Okay," Scorpia nods. "So . . . have you been living there this whole time?"

"Pretty much," Catra says.

"And . . . do you like it here?" Scorpia clicks her claws together while she asks this, clearly nervous.

"I do," Catra admits. "I didn't know there was anyone else like me, so that's been nice . . . but I did miss you, Scorpia."

"Aw," tears well up in the corners of Scorpia's eyes, and she raises her voice, "I missed you too-"

"You can cry on me and hug me later," Catra quickly hisses. "Remember, beasts?"

“Ah right, sorry.”

Scorpia sticks close to Catra for the rest of the walk back, thankfully remaining quiet. The other stayed ahead, and every so often Catra caught Adora glancing back at her, but she would quickly look away whenever she did, trying to act like she’s looking out for beasts (which to be fair, she is-Adora’s just distracting her by being . . . Adora. As usual).

They make it back to Half Moon without any incidents-asides from Sea Hawk tripping on a root and falling on his face but Catra can’t criticize him. When they reach the hunter’s entrance, Catra steps to the front of the crowd to guide them to the Council Room.

There are many secret passageways, leading from the Temple of Saz to just about everywhere in Half Moon. The best spot for the Alliance members right now would be the Council Room, since it seems to be rarely used. The last time Catra was in the Council Room was when she learned that Ri’ta and C’yra are her moms. Like last time, it’s empty and she glances to the room that holds the portraits of past Purrsian Queens. Just one thing to make sure . . .

"Demeter," Catra whispers, staying quiet and pulling Demeter aside, “Can you make sure no one goes into that back room?”

“Why?” Demeter asks.

“If you do this for me-I’ll owe you a favor,” Catra offers.

“I’ll do it if you also give me ten gold coins.”

“What! Fine.”

"Deal.”

“So, where are the Queens?” Bow asks, glancing around the table. “Shouldn’t they be here . . . holding court?”

“. . . No?” Demeter says.

“They have better things to do than sit around on a throne all day,” Catra says with crossed arms. “So, I’m gonna go and get them.”

“You?” Glimmer questions.

“Do you have a problem with that?” Catra asks.

Before Glimmer can open her mouth, Demeter surprises Catra and says, “Catra understands your situation better, and will explain it better. Plus, you shouldn’t be seen in Half Moon without warning.”

“But . . . we’re not Horde,” Bow says.

“You’re outsiders,” Demeter says. “It’s like I said earlier- the last time we had outsiders here it went pretty bad for us.”

Catra sighs. "The Queens need to know what's going on so like, a riot doesn't start up. Trust me, Magicats hate the Horde way more than you do."

"The Horde killed my dad!" Glimmer bursts.

"And the Magicats literally lost half of their entire population!" Catra argues. "Everyone here lost someone, not just you! So, sit back and chill the fuck out until I get back."

Glimmer glares at Catra, but everyone seems content with that plan. Catra nods to everyone before she renters the passageways. She doesn’t know what Glimmer’s problem is when she came along on the little adventure the Princesses took to get here. But, Catra shoves it out of her mind. She has two missions: tell her moms to not tell the Princesses about her being a princess . . . and also get Scorpia and Adora non-Horde clothes.

Chapter End Notes

Well, I hoped you liked the double update! I won't make any promises about being consistent just . . . because. But, if you want any update about this fic or see me talk about important things like the Muppets and ABBA, you should be following my Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or my tumblr at sniperdoodle.

Also, if you follow me on Twitter, you will get updates on the DND show me and my friends are going to eventually get to! If you like my world-building here, you're going to love the world and the game I'm running for my friends (which is also where the majority of my creative energy has gone to recently). So, keep an eye out for news about Bungeons & Bagons and the Wonderful World of Faetan!

Other than that, thank-you all for sticking with me while I've been dealing with schools and such, leave a comment if you enjoyed the chapters!

Interlude V: Glimmer

Chapter Summary

Glimmer doesn't trust Catra.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I am back for the second week in a row! Yay me!

Anyway, this is probably my favorite interlude to write (you can tell by its length) and I figure that's just because I get to write for some of the Magicats. Thank-you all for your kind comments and please enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer doesn't like any of this, one bit.

She doesn't trust Catra as far as she could teleport her, and now they're knee-deep in her new turf.

Yes, she *did* willingly agree to come along, mostly because Adora needed this. She still has a strong bond with Catra despite being on opposite sides of the wars, and if worse came to worse she needed her best friends by her side. And now . . . they're in Half Moon. Surrounded by Magicats.

Her father told her about the Magicats when she was very young-and though she can't remember his voice she remembers the gist of the stories: the Magicats were a nation of warriors who lived and breathed battle. They also had powerful mages and clerics, and he seemed to know a Magicat personally.

To her, the Magicats seemed more like a legend than something real-especially when she learned of their demise. But now that she's on Purrsia, in their Council Room, it's . . . different. Especially now that she knows that Catra is one of them. She thought that Catra would just be surviving in the cruel forests of

Beast Island-not *thriving* among the Magicats. Catra's the type of person who would have a hay-day amongst the gangs in the Crimson Wastes and was one of the biggest threats in the Horde aside from Hordak and Shadow Weaver-so who knows what she's done while in Half Moon. Glimmer knows Catra, and knows that she can't be up to anything good. But right now, she should be concerned with the Magicat Catra left behind . . . .

Demeter is standing back in the corner near a door, keeping a hand on her bow. She's clearly on edge with all of the non-Magicats, but she remained behind. Bow, ever friendly, tries to make small-talk and approaches her, "So, you're a master of archery too! I'm Bow, the Tech Master of the Rebellion!"

Bow holds out his hand to shake, but Demeter only raises an eyebrow suspiciously and crosses her arms, "I suppose you could call me that. I'm the best shot in Half Moon. And . . . Bow? Isn't that a bit on the nose?"

"So is '*Cat*-ra' and she's a 'Magi-*cat*'," Bow points out.

Demeter snorts, "No sane person named her that."

"Aw, so all your names don't have cat puns in them?" Bow asks.

She dead-pans and glares at him, "*No*."

It's silent for a beat as Demeter stares at Bow, but suddenly it's broken by a new arrival.

"Catra, what did you want to talk about?" a voice echoes from an ante-chamber and an older Magicat enters the Council Room. She's orange-furred and is missing one eye, the other one being a familiar blue. Her mane is shaved and ears nicked. She's wearing a purple uniform with white cape and golden honor, but most notable is the hand on the sword hilt at her side. She takes a few steps out of the antechamber before she stops and stares at the assembled Rebellion members and says, "Well, now I understand what Catra was talking about."

Glimmer wants to immediately launch into questioning this new figure, but a second Magicat walks in and joins the fun. This one is a shorter, blonde-furred woman wearing blue robes with golden trim and one hand is tucked into a pocket. She looks at everyone with curiosity until she settles her gaze on the orange-furred Magicat and trades it for a small smile.

"Well," the blonde Magicat smiles. "Fancy meeting you here."

"I know, it's been far too long," the orange Magicat says, reaching out to take the blonde's hand.

Catra said that she was going to get the Queens of Half Moon, but neither of these Magicats look like royalty. Glimmer's own mother has a diadem she wears, but these two don't even have crowns! The orange-furred one looks more like a General than anything else. Are these two allies of Catra's somehow?

"Are you two really making eyes at each other, right now?!" Catra bursts into the room with her usual grace. "You two saw each other this morning!"

"What, are you embarrassed that we're in love?" the blonde Magicat teases.

"Catra," the orange-furred Magicat gets to the point. "Can you give us a better explanation of what's going on," she punctuates it by sending a wary look to Adora and Scorpia-who are still in their Horde uniforms.

"Yeah!" Glimmer hops in, pointing fingers at Catra. "You haven't explained anything since we found you! Who are those two!? What are you planning!?"

"I'm *planning* on keeping a mob off your asses!" Catra argues. "As for those two . . . I thought I already told you but," she glances at them and smirks, "I think you should introduce yourselves."

The orange Magicat stands up a bit straighter and instantly appears more regal, “I am Queen C’yra of D’riluth the Third, Queen of Purrsia and the United Magicat Tribes.”

“Ri’ta of M’stoff’lls,” the blonde Magicat continues. “Head Mage and Queen.”

Catra shoots Glimmer a self-righteous glare as she blanches. Bow quickly steps forward, “Your majesties, Glimmer didn’t mean any offense, we’re new here and didn’t know that-”

“Oh, it’s fine,” Ri’ta insists, hooking an arm around C’yra’s. “We tend to be pretty casual around here anyways.”

“I’m more worried about . . . whatever’s going on here,” C’yra says.

“I already explained everything,” Catra insists.

“You were talking kinda fast,” C’yra counters. “So, you brought the outsiders back to Half Moon because you believe they mean no harm, but you never explained *why* they’re even here.”

“Oh, well, they’re here for . . . me,” Catra says. “To rescue me. And Half Moon is much safer than camping out in the forests.”

“And what about the two that are wearing Horde clothes but aren’t Horde soldiers?” C’yra continues.

“They both left the Horde,” Catra confirms. “Scorpia’s my friend and Adora is . . . well, Adora’s She-Ra so there’s that.”

The Queen seems curious about She-Ra, and Glimmer spares a glance to Adora who look . . . hurt, by Catra’s words.

“Alright,” C’yra is quick to trust Catra, which makes Glimmer suspicious but at least it’s in their favor. She scans the group one more time, “Let’s finish up introductions and talk about what’s next.”

There's a beat of silence, then Scorpia takes the initiative, "I'm Scorpia, Catra's best friend and I'm a hugger!"

"Adora," Adora picks up. She hoists up the Sword of Power, "Also She-Ra."

"Sea Hawk!" the pirate shouts. "Explorer of the seas, fighter of monsters, and burner of boats!"

"Bow, master archer and the Rebellion's tech master," Bow finishes and its Glimmer's turn.

She stares right at the Queens, "Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon and General of the Princess Alliance."

"Glimmer?" Ri'ta echoes before she smiles in realization. "You're Micah's daughter, aren't you?"

Glimmer freezes, "Did you know my dad?" She remembers that her father seemed sad whenever he talked about the Magicats, though he was smiling it didn't reach his eyes. It makes sense that he must have known one-he was grieving for a friend.

"Yes," Ri'ta smiles as she reminisces. "I was actually born and raised in Mystacor, didn't live here until I was 14. My, the two of us got into so much trouble together."

Glimmer has rarely heard about this side of her father, generally just that he was a kind and brave man. She's ready to ask questions, but then reality comes crashing down.

"How is he?" Ri'ta asks so innocently.

"My dad . . ." Glimmer doesn't want to be the one to break the news. "Died in battle with the Horde. When I was little."

Ri'ta covers her mouth as C'yra puts an arm around her shoulders. C'yra continues, "We know loss quite well here, so you have our condolences."

"Thank-you," Glimmer cordially responds. It's weird talking to strangers about her father's death.

"Catra!" the somber moment is shattered as brown-furred Magicat wearing white robes enters the Council Room, kicking open the door because there are piles of clothes in her arms, "Why the fuck do you need clothes brought to the Council Room?! Would it kill you to explain it a bit bet-" the Magicat pauses as she looks at the Etherians in the room, then turning to Catra, "Everything makes perfect sense now."

"Thank-you Shire," Catra quickly says as she takes the clothes from Shire and gives them to Scorpia and Adora, "I think these should fit you two."

"Huh, you really thought of everything," Ri'ta comments. "But won't it be odd that Etherians are wearing Magicat robes?"

"It was just raining," Demeter suggests. "And they fought a beast. We can just say that they were ruined and needed replacements."

The Queens stare at Demeter and C'yra asks, "Demeter, have you been here the whole time?"

"Yeah," Demeter nods.

"Well," Ri'ta clears her throat. "It's a good idea. But, what should we tell the populace? That the Princess Alliance came to Purrsia looking for Catra?"

"That makes me feel like I was being hunted down like a criminal," Catra grumbles.

Glimmer wants to point out that she *is* a criminal, but a pointed glare from Bow shuts her up.

"Well, we came for her because is, was, our friend," Adora stutters out. "If we hide the fact that Scorpia and I are defected Horde soldiers, that should be fine, right?"

"People *know* that I came from the Horde," Catra argues, not looking at Adora. "That'll cast suspicions on you all. It might be better to say that the Princess Alliance decided to look for any remaining Magicats as allies and I happened to recognize you."

"I don't know if that would make sense," C'yra says with a small frown, but she seems more upset underneath the surface. "Because I never joined the Princess Alliance when I was Princess. And others aren't fond of it either."

"Better than being associated with the Horde," Catra points out.

"Wait," Adora interrupts, innocently asking. "Why didn't you join the Princess Alliance?"

C'yra glances away, "It doesn't matter. The past is the past. I made my decision and I can't change it if I wanted to."

"But, Queen Ri'ta was friends with my dad," Glimmer points out, wheels churning in her head. "The Magicats are legendary warriors! If we took a stance together against the Horde, we could have made a dent in their forces! We could have helped!"

"Could you?!" C'yra's head snaps up, her eye fiery with rage. She clenches her fists, "The Princess Alliance was thousands of miles away and you could barely hold your own against the Horde. At that time, we had never seen them on our shores and for once, we wanted peace-not war. Obviously, that didn't work out in the end, but," C'yra closes her eye and sighs, pausing before opening it to ask, "How would *you* have saved my people? Would *you* be able to do it better?"

There's that Magicat ferocity Glimmer has heard about, but she won't back down, "Even if we couldn't fix everything, you wouldn't be alone now."

"That didn't answer my question," C'yra points out with a growl. "And we're doing fine on our own. Purrsia is *surviving*.

That's all that matters."

"I still don't understand why you wouldn't take a stand against the Horde!" Glimmer says.

"We were at *peace*," C'yra stresses.

"Oh come on, there's got to be more there!" Glimmer pushes. Apparently, that was the snapping point.

"I was *pregnant*! Okay?!" C'yra reveals. "For once, all I wanted was peace after years of chasing after a fight. Maybe I was delusional to think that the Horde would never touch Purrsia. But . . . no, I *was* delusional to think that. But I've paid the greatest price for it."

"Is . . . is there a princess here?" Adora asks.

C'yra lowers her head, glaring at the floor, "No. She was killed by the Horde."

Ri'ta places a hand on C'yra's shoulder, who covers it with her own. The Head Mage turns to the Princess Alliance members, "Thanks for bringing up those memories. We *really* appreciate it."

Glimmer is about to apologize, because okay, she obviously shouldn't have pushed so much when it was obvious the Horde has affected Purrsia more than other countries, but C'yra continues.

"Princess Glimmer," C'yra looks up. "As a gesture of goodwill to our former ally, you and your friends can stay in Half Moon as long as you wish. We shall tell everyone that your party is from the Princess Alliance, nothing more and nothing less. However, do not involve us in your affairs. Our goal is survival, not retribution." She turns to Catra, "Catra, I hope I can leave them in your capable hands."

"Sure," Catra agrees.

"We shall be taking our leave. Please let us know if you need anything," C'yra says, straining to remain cordial. "On behalf of the the Council of the United Purrsian Tribes, I welcome you to Half Moon. Do not make me regret it."

The Queens leave, and Catra immediately turns to Glimmer, "*How* the fuck did you manage to piss them off?"

"What?" Glimmer echoes.

"C'yra and Ri'ta are some of the most understanding people I know," Catra says. "You've been here for twenty minutes and pissed them off."

Glimmer opens up her mouth, but Shire jumps in, "She's right. I've *never* seen Queen C'yra or Ri'ta that angry. I heard that C'yra used to have a temper when she was young but . . ."

"I have," Demeter chimes in, surprising everyone with her presence once again. "C'yra got pissed off at my mom and they were shouting for like twenty minutes before going to the training ground to beat the shit out of each other. Queen Ri'ta basically had to pull them off each other. But, as much as I hate to admit it, Catra is right-it does take a lot to set Queen C'yra off."

"You know that now that you've said it once I am going to lord that over you, right?" Catra says with a grin.

"Whatever," Demeter rolls her eyes. "Now that we're done here . . . you owe me ten gold."

"Uhg. Right," Catra pulls out a small coin purse and fishes out a handful of gold coins. Glimmer doesn't know how Catra got money and figures she doesn't want to ask. When she hands the money over, she says, "Hey, if you spot Gr'wliger, can you fill him in on everything? Y'know, discretely?"

"If I see him," Demeter shrugs. "I'm heading to the training grounds right now."

"Why would you go there?" Catra questions.

"Why do you think?" Demeter counters, and she leaves the room.

Catra watches Demeter with suspicion as she leaves, waiting to turn towards the Etherians and saying, "So, do you losers-and Scorpia-want a tour?"

"Oo!" Scorpia cheers up. "A tour sounds lovely!"

"Lead the way," Bow says.

"You wanna join us Shire?" Catra asks.

"Uh, why not?" Shire shrugs.

Catra leads them out of the Council room for a tour, but Glimmer's mind is elsewhere. For starters, she needs to keep an eye on Catra, as she still doesn't trust her. But also, the Magicats of Purrsia are legendary warriors. If the Princess Alliance had that kind of might, the Horde wouldn't see it coming. She just has to convince C'yra . . . after she apologizes.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Leave a comment to let me know what you think! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. And I hope you all have a good day!

ch-ch-changes there's gonna have to be a different man, times may change me but you can't trace time

Chapter Summary

Catra gives the Princess Alliance losers (and Scorpia) a tour of Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

I'm back again! I just wanna say-there's parts of this chapter that I really like and parts of this chapter that I'm not a fan of, but it's done, so enjoy! And also thank-you for commenting and reading, I appreciate all of you!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was in a bit of a hurry when she went to go and get the Queens (*"hey so y'know how Gr'wliger and Demeter found a boat on the shore and thought that they might have intruders on it? Well it turns out that they're from the Princess Alliance and they came looking for me to try and rescue me for some reason and I brought them back to Half Moon so they wouldn't die but two of them still look like Horde soldiers even though they're not anymore and I don't want a mob to come after them so I hid them in the Council Room and we should really talk about it. Also* ***please do not mention that I'm a Princess****. Okay, thanks, I'll meet you there!"*) but she made one thing clear: don't let the Princess Alliance know that she's their daughter.

Since finding out that C'yra and Ri'ta are her mothers, she's been avoiding coming out to the general public as their daughter because of the whole princess thing. Gr'wliger, Busto and Shire all know, but don't seem to care about that. She has a feeling that the rest of Half Moon has their suspicions because of the whole blue and yellow eyes thing, but no one has bothered to mention it.

But if Shimmer and the others learn she's technically a princess . . . she doesn't want to think about it.

And she doesn't have to, since she's too busy giving these losers (and Scorpia) a tour.

From the Council Room, she leads them to the most interesting place in Half Moon: the market. As they walk through the crowds, Magicats give the Bright Moon crew strange looks. It's probably been years since anyone has seen any Etherians.

"So, this is the market," Catra explains as they enter the crowds. "Don't get lost."

"It's so busy," Scorpia says, eyes wide as she looks over the colorful wares shop-keepers are selling. If she went straight to Bright Moon, she probably hasn't seen a place like this before.

"People are probably stopping by on their way to lunch," Shire explains (Catra is very thankful that her friend has decided to join her on the tour, so she won't be alone-especially after how she asked her to help get Scorpia and Adora clothes (*"hey Shire you're the first person I've found that I trust and I need you to not ask any questions but can you find me some clothes that would fit like, Gr'wliger and Busto and take them to the Council Room okay thanks byeeeee!"*)). "This and the cafeteria are the only real social places we have in Half Moon."

"It's . . . quaint," Glimmer says as she looks at a shop that sells rocks.

"Aw!" Bow coos over a toy shop, pulling out a miniature weapon. "Look! Tiny bow!"

"If you all want anything, let me know," Catra offers with a sigh. "I don't really need things from here so I guess I can buy y'all stuff. Better to recirculate my cash into the local economy than have it burn a hole in my pocket."

"How do you have money?" Adora questions.

"I have a job," Catra rolls her eyes.

"What is your job?" Scorpia asks.

"Hunters."

"What do you do?" Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

"Hunt things."

Shire sighs, "They go out onto the surface to hunt and scavenge for food we can use to supplement the farms we already have. There's multiple job factions you can join, mine are the healers."

"So there isn't a soldier faction?" Glimmer continues her scrutiny.

"Most of those guys are jerks, aside from Busto," Catra says. "And the General hates me for some reason. Anyways-"

"CATRA!" N'yan bursts through the crowds and flings herself onto Catra's leg, clutching onto it. She looks up with a smile, "Hi."

Catra rubs Nyan's head, ignoring the curious and slightly suspicious looks from the Etherians, "Hey, long time no see."

"What am I to you, chopped liver?" Shire grumbles.

"I see you every day!" N'yan insists. "It's been so loooong since I saw Catra!"

"I saw you last week," Catra points out.

"Exactly! It's been ages!" N'yan pauses when she notices the Etherians and steps behind Catra's legs. She clings to her pant leg and whispers loudly, "Who are those people and why do they look weird?"

"Now come on," Catra tsks. "Just because they don't have fur, doesn't mean you can call them weird. Even if Shimmer sparkles too much."

"Hey!"

"But it's *weird* that they don't have fur," N'yan insists.

"They're Etherians, N'yan," Shire says. "They aren't supposed to have fur."

"Why?"

"I don't know."

"Why?"

"Okay, we're not doing this," Shire sighs as she turns to the Bright Moon Crew. "Anyways, this is my cousin, N'yan. N'yan, this is Adora, Bow, Scorpia, Sea Hawk, and Princess Glimmer."

"Hi there," Bow waves. "It's nice to meet you."

N'yan hides her face in Catra's leg. She sighs, "Don't worry, they're alright . . . for the most part . . ."

"You promise?" N'yan asks.

"I do," Catra nods.

Trusting Catra's word, she steps back in front of Catra, putting on a brave face, "Uh . . . hi."

"Hello," Bow gives N'yan a tiny wave.

"So why're you all here?" N'yan asks, gaining strength in her voice.

"We're with the Princess Alliance," Adora says.

N'yan's face screws in confusion, "What's that?"

Catra jumps in, “They're . . . the good guys. They fight the Horde.”

“Ohhhhh,” N’yan nods, turning back to the Etherians. “But isn’t that scary? Aren’t you afraid that the Horde’s gonna hurt everyone?”

“That’s why we have to fight them,” Glimmer says. “So, they don’t hurt anyone else.”

N’yan nods, and knowing her she probably has a billion other questions and Catra doesn’t want to sit through the Princess Alliance Q&A. She shoots Shire a pleading look, who takes pity on Catra and points out, “N’yan, shouldn’t you be in school rather than wandering around the market?”

“I was taking a shortcut!” N’yan insists. “Class doesn’t start again until noon!”

Shire glances at a near-by clock, hanging from one of the stalls, “You have four minutes to get to class.”

“Oh Saz,” N’yan sighs, taking off and ducking underneath Scorpia’s legs. “Bye!!!”

“Bye N’yan,” Catra says, waving despite the fact that the kit isn’t looking back. “Alright, so let’s continue-” She turns around and immediately runs into the last person she wants to see.

“Watch where you’re going!” Thom hisses as he stumbles back.

“Well don’t go sneaking around like that!” Catra growls back.

“I wasn’t sneaking around.”

“You’re always sneaking around!”

“That’s just how I walk!”

Catra scowls, crossing her arms and studies Thom for a moment. She eyes the bag on his hip and notices that it's empty, so he hasn't tried to steal anything yet. But she recalls the last time she crosses paths with him and says, "If you took my wallet, I'm going to drag you to C'yra myself."

Thom scoffs and places a hand on his chest, "Are you accusing *me* of stealing?"

"Yeah, it's your whole schtick," Catra sighs.

"Catra," Adora steps forward, her voice quiet and nervous. "Should you really be trying to pick a fight here?"

"I'm not trying to pick a fight!" Catra raises her voice, glancing between her and Thom to make sure he doesn't move an inch. "I'm trying to stop *him* from doing something illegal."

"Once again, you're accusing *me* of doing something-" Thom scoffs again, but this time he can't hide the self-assured smile on his face.

"No, Catra's right," Shire interjects, also keeping her eyes on Thom. "He's a ne'er do well."

"Ne'er do well?" Thom echoes. "Well usually people just call me a criminal so thank-you."

"It's the same thing," Shire says.

"Why don't you go away, Thom?" Catra growls, getting more and more pissed off. But, she is going to keep a level head. Just to prove Adora and the other Etherians wrong.

"Why should I?" Thom question. "It's fun talking like this. It'll be even more fun to watch you snap . . . again."

He must be talking about the one time she did let her temper get the better of her with D'nah. But not here. Not now. *Not in front of the Princesses.*

Suddenly, a dark shadow falls over Thom as Gr'wliger looms above him. Despite being over six feet tall, Gr'wliger is rather stealthy and has managed to sneak up on the troublemaker-who jumps in the air when Gr'wliger speaks, "Thom of M'cavity, don't you have something better you could be doing?"

"Gah!" Thom turns around, looking like he's about to argue, but it dies on his lips when he sees who it is, "What do you want?"

"I want you to go about your business," Gr'wliger says. "And not get in trouble."

"Or what?" Thom sneers as he shoves his hands in his pockets, trying to look defiant.

"Well if you don't leave now," Gr'wliger stoops down to get into Thom's face. "You'll find out."

Thom pauses, considering his chances, before backing down and slinking away. Catra doesn't take her eyes off of him until he's disappeared into the shadows of the alleyway.

"I apologize for intruding-" Gr'wliger says as he straightens up.

"Nah, I'm glad you did," Catra smirks. "Thom was getting on my nerves and wouldn't scram."

"Then you're welcome," Gr'wliger says. "But we should talk about," he pauses to glance at the Etherians, "Them."

"I already talked to the Queens about them! They're from the Princess Alliance and y'know, they're the 'good guys'," Catra quickly insists. She leans in, having to stand her tip-toes to try and whisper in his ear, "I'll tell you about it later when we're not in public."

Gr'wliger raises an eyebrow, but nods, "Okay. So, who are your new companions?"

"Scorpia, Bow, Shimmer-"

"GLIMMER!"

"-Adora, and Sea Hawk," Catra sighs and turns around. "This is Gr'wliger, head of the hunters."

"Welcome to Half Moon," Gr'wliger says with a small bow.

"You don't need to bow," Catra grumbles. "They're just from the Princess Alliance."

"If they're from the *Princess* Alliance then shouldn't at least *one* of them be a Princess? And it is customary to greet visiting dignitaries with a bow."

"Alright, yeah Shimmer's-"

"GLIMMER."

"-A princess but it's weird when you do it for her. You're such a . . . *bureaucratic wunderkind*."

The Princess Alliance were clearly expecting something more fowl to come out of Catra's mouth and look confused, but Gr'wliger stiffens as Shire tries to hide a laugh behind her hands. He clears his throat and immediately diverts the subject, "Now, I was just making my way to the cafeteria, if you're heading there as well."

"I'm getting hungry," Catra admits. "Y'all good with lunch?"

"Yeah, we haven't eaten since we stepped ashore," Scorpia says.

“Almost getting eaten by a beast makes you surprisingly hungry,” Bow jokes.

“Then let’s go,” Shire says. “The more we talk about eating the hungrier I’m getting.”

At this hour, the cafeteria is busy, so they have to wait in line. When they get their food, Jen’dots only stares at the Etherians for a moment before claiming that, “Everyone gets to eat-whether they have fur or not.”

Sh’dowell and Gar’ett are already sitting at their usual table. The former turns around and says, “Catra! There you are! Where did you go-OH SAZ WHY DO YOU HAVE ETHERIANS WITH YOU?!”

“Calm down!” Catra hisses. “They’re with the Princess Alliance! They’re okay.”

“Right,” Gr’wliger agrees. “Everything is fine, Sh’dowell. Take a deep breath.”

They suck in air, but when they let it out, it comes out as a high-pitched whine. But, they claim, “Okay. Okay. I’m okay.”

“Good,” Gr’wliger nods. He sits next to them, and Shire next to him, so Catra sits next to Gar’ett. Then Princess Alliance fills in the rest of the seats, and Scorpia thankfully takes the seat next to Catra. Catra makes quick introductions before she begins to eat.

“Looks like you had an eventful morning,” Gar’ett says.

“No shit,” Catra sighs.

An awkward silence settles until Sh’dowell-apparently getting over their initial panic-says, “So? Anyone wants to learn knife monopoly?”

"No!" Shire quickly interjects before anyone can ask just what knife monopoly is. "We're not playing knife monopoly especially after the last incident and I had to heal you!"

"I never heard about this incident," Catra says with a small smile.

"Well, I was playing knife monopoly, as I do," Sh'dowell begins. "And to make a long story short, the knife went clean through my hand."

"Gross," Catra chuckles. "Did you get a scar from it?"

"No," Sh'dowell sighs. "Sadly."

"That's because I healed it before it could!" Shire says.

"And that's why knife monopoly is banned," Gr'wliger adds.

"Oh. Yeah, that makes sense," Catra says. "I always wondered why but no one gave me an explanation and you could have just said that."

"It was funnier not to tell you," Gar'ett says. "But we do that with all new recruits."

"I don't think we've told Demeter yet, to be honest," Sh'dowell says with they scratch their chin. They turn to Gr'wliger, "Have we?"

"No," Gr'wliger admits. "Lionel'o doesn't know either."

"Huh," Sh'dowell says. "At least it's better than the hazing the soldiers aren't supposed to do but do anyways."

Catra is equally glad she didn't join the soldiers and extremely curious about what the soldiers even do to haze new recruits, but she doesn't get to say anything.

"So the rumors are true, in Half Moon we have a human crew!"

Catra groans, but Shire gives Busto a pity-clap as he saunters over. Butso's been trying to find a new greeting rhyme and it's been getting on her nerves. Shire sighs, "Okay, that one was decent, you have to admit."

"Thank-you," Busto says as he puts his leg up on the bench, right at the end next to Sh'dowell.

"I don't have to admit anything," Catra says. She turns to the others and makes a quick introduction, "Everyone, this is Busto. Busto, this is Adora, Scorpia, Shimmer, Bow, and Sea Hawk."

"Actually, it's Princess Glimmer," Glimmer says while glaring at Catra, clearly getting tired of her shit, but Catra's having a lot of fun with it.

"Well I am pleased to make all of your acquaintances," Busto dramatically bows. "As Catra said, I am Captain Bust'fer of Bo'ots, second-in-command to General Az'al. But everyone calls me Busto."

"Nice to meet you as well!" Sea Hawk stands up. "I am the one and only Sea Hawk!"

Glimmer glances between Sea Hawk and Busto as they begin to animatedly talk to each other before she whispers, "There's two of them now."

Gr'wliger asks, "Since when did Busto have a human twin?"

Shire snorts as she drinks, causing her to go into a coughing fit. Gr'wliger slaps her on the back as Busto retorts, "We just happen to be of like minds, Gr'wliger. But now that I'm here, we can get down to business."

"What business?" Catra scoffs.

"Training," Busto reminds her. "As long as you're not busy."

"Ah shit," Catra hisses as she buries her face in her hands. "Of course that was today."

"Don't worry if you can't, there's always tomorrow," Gr'wliger insists.

"No, no, I need to train," Catra insists. C'yra herself asked Catra to compete in the Ball, so she has to do good, which means she needs to train. There's no way she's going to be able to continue her lesson with Ri'ta, at least for today, now that she has the Etherians to trail around, so she may as well get combat training in.

"Training for what?" Bow questions.

"The Jellicle Ball!" Busto shouts. He gets a few looks from the surrounding Magicats, who wave it off as usual Busto shenanigans.

"Oo, a ball!" Scorpia gets excited.

"It's not really a ball," Catra points out. "It's a fighting tournament."

"Then why is it called a ball?" Adora questions.

Catra shrugs, but then Busto stands on the table. She sighs as she removes her plate and waits to see what he's planning on doing.

"A dance is very much like a fight," Busto draws his saber and gets in a fencing position. "It's a conversation between you and your partner. It's about opposite reactions. You take a step forward-" Busto lunges forward, poking the air with his sword, before drawing back, "-and your partner steps back. You go left-"

Busto starts to sashay across the table, carefully avoiding everyone's food, "-Your partner moves right. It's a delicate balance, until one person takes control and starts to lead, winning the fight."

"Ah, makes sense," Scorpia says.

Catra rolls her eyes as Busto hops down, "Why are we friends again?"

“Because we have genuinely bonded over multiple experiences,” Busto says. “Like that time we went camping!”

“Okay, that’s fair,” Catra sighs.

“Wh-where did you go camping?” Scorpia asks.

“Here on Beast Island, where else-” Catra turns to face the Etherians and is surprised to find a look of shock on most of their faces. Her Magicat friends are equally confused.

Sh’dowell speaks up first, “Uh . . . you guys okay?”

“Did you just use the word ‘friend’?” Bow asks. “In relation to Catra?”

“. . . Yeah?” Busto says. “Because she’s my friend?”

“You all are sitting at a table with my friends,” Catra points out. “Why else would they choose to sit here?”

Bow and Glimmer still seem genuinely surprised, but Adora is looking away, so Catra can’t discern her emotions. Scorpia however, seems very nervous as she asks, “We’re . . . we’re friends too, right Catra?”

“Of course,” Catra doesn’t hesitate. And then Scorpia crushes her in another hug.

“Aw, thank-you, Wildcat!”

"Ahg! Scorpia!"

"Wildcat?" Sh'dowell echoes.

"It's my nickname for Catra," Scorpia explains, finally letting Catra go. Catra drops down into her seat and covers her head to hide. She kinda wants to die from embarrassment-she almost had forgotten about Scorpia's nickname for her.

Sh'dowell grins, "I like it! It's feisty, perfect for Catra!"

"I know, right?"

Catra turns to Gar'ett, "Can you kill me?"

"Not yet."

"Darn."

After that, Sh'dowell and Scorpia seem to hit it off-while Bow, Glimmer and Adora all talk to themselves. Catra tries to focus on talking with her friends, but her mind keeps on drifting off. Now that the Etherians are here, they'll probably be sitting at her lunch table and it's going to stay crowded like this. What else will change with the Etherians around? Things have been going so good for her lately-Catra doesn't want it to change.

As lunch winds down, the conversation shifts to what they'll do next.

"So, I did reserve the training grounds for the spot after lunch," Busto says. "Because it was open. No one should disturb us."

"Sounds good," Catra agrees, recalling the last time she was in the soldier's training grounds. "Gr'wliger, Sh'dowell, you two said you were going to join us, right?"

"Of course!" Sh'dowell says, while Gr'wliger just nods.

"Then let's go!" Busto declares, dramatically standing up and pointing towards the training grounds.

"Actually, I'll meet you guys there," Catra says as she stands. "I left my spear in my quarters."

"Alright," Gr'wliger nods.

"And you all . . ." Catra turns to the Etherians. "Do whatever. I guess I'll see you all back here for dinner."

Catra starts to walk away before anyone can ask her anything. She's eager to go and train and pretend that nothing changed for a while. But, as soon as she leaves the cafeteria, she hears a voice call out after her, "Catra!"

Cursing inwardly, Catra turns around and faces Adora, "What?"

"I just . . ." Adora begins. "I'm glad you're okay."

"Really?" Catra questions. "After everything I did to you?"

"Yeah."

"Oh."

When she doesn't say anything else, Adora starts to turn around, "Well, I guess I'll get back to Glimmer and Bow-"

"Wait!" Catra says. As much as she wants to pretend that nothing will change with the Etherians here, she also knows she needs to start facing her past outside of her dreams-especially when it's standing right in front of her. She's still hurt by the fact that Adora left her, but she hurt Adora too, "I'm sorry."

Adora stares at her with wide eyes and gasps, "What?"

"Don't make me say it again."

"No, no, I won't!" Adora quickly says. "I was just . . . surprised."

Catra crosses her arms and her tail lashes out, but she doesn't say anything-lest she have to apologize again.

"You've . . . really changed here, haven't you?" Adora says.

"I . . . I hope so," Catra says.

"Well," Adora sucks in a breath. "I . . . I won't hold you up. Have fun training, Catra."

"Thanks," Catra says. She watches Adora leave as a strange feeling settles in her stomach. Is this . . . relief? She certainly feels like she owes Adora more than just a two-word apology, but . . . it's the first step. She doesn't know if they'll ever be able to go back to the way they used to be, when they were best friends in the Horde but . . . she's not sure if she wants that anymore.

"There was a distinct lack of punching in that encounter."

"Fuck!" Catra jumps out of her skin as she whirls around and faces Busto, a shit-eating grin plastered on his face. "*Were you listening in on that?! How'd you even get behind me?!*"

"I only heard the end, I was looking for you," Busto claims, throwing his hands up into the air. "But that was her right? Adora's the girl you had a crush-"

Catra lunges forward and plasters her hand over his mouth, "No! No she's not!" Though she hasn't removed her hand, Busto raises an eyebrow and gives her a pointed look like he was saying, '*really?*'. She glares at him and sighs, "Uhg! Whatever, let's go train."

She finally removes her hands and he jumps up, "Certainly. But I'm not forgetting this. Busto *will* remember this."

"Maybe if I hit you in the head hard enough while we train you *will* forget."

"Hey! Friends don't hit friends in the head, right *friend*?"

". . . Fine. I won't hit you in the head because you're my friend . . . however I will try to hit you everywhere else."

"That's acceptable. Thanks friend."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Leave a comment if you wish, and if you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle.

lead you to the supermarket checkout some specials and rat food get lost in the crowd

Chapter Summary

Catra and Scorpia spend a day at the market.

Chapter Notes

Hello y'all! Sorry about last week, I got caught up in binging a TV show and lot track of time and suddenly I had a homework assignment due. I'm going to do my best on updates, but I'm balancing this story between my summer class and my Genshin Impact brainrot.

Anyways, this is a shorter chapter and a bit of filler, but I hope you enjoy!

Chapter title from "One Way or Another" by Blondie

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As always, the market is busy. Since arriving in Half Moon, Catra has become able to blend in with the crowds. She doesn't stick out like a sore thumb, people seeing the Horde soldier rather than the person, anymore. But now, with Scorpia walking alongside her, people are staring, not out of disgust but out of curiosity.

"Wow, this is . . . a lot," Scorpia gasps as she looks around with wide eyes.

"Yeah, it took me a while to get used to all the noise," Catra admits. "But, the vendors here sell real good food, so it's worth it."

The Princess Alliance has been on Purrsia for a day so far, and Catra hasn't gotten a real chance to talk with Scorpia. After lunch yesterday, she trained, went on her evening patrol, had

dinner, and went to bed thoroughly exhausted. She had another hunt this morning, and as soon as she came back Scorpia asked if she wanted to hang-out. There's only one place to 'hang-out' in Half Moon, and that's at the market.

"Oh, hhm, is there anything you would suggest?" Scorpia asks, appearing a bit unsure of everything.

"There's kabobs," Catra starts. "And there's a guy that fries bugs? Which sounds gross but the crunch is good-"

"I'll have to skip on that," Scorpia quickly says.

Catra glances around the food area of the market, finally settling on a certain stall, "Maybe you'd like this." She grabs Scorpia's claw and drags her over to a Magicat selling fried dough called 'beast ears'. It tends to be too sweet for her tastes, but maybe Scorpia would like it, "It's just fried dough with like, cinnamon on it."

"Fried . . . dough?" Scorpia repeats.

"Want some 'beast ears'?" the Magicat vendor asks.

"Yeah, I'll take two," Catra says.

"Why're they called beast ears if it's dough?" Scorpia questions.

"I think it's supposed to be in the shape of a beast ear? I don't know, it doesn't really look like it. Kinda just looks like a blob to me," Catra admits as she pays. The vendor hands over two beast ears, wrapped in paper. They walk over to a small sitting area off in the corner, and begin to eat.

Catra watches Scorpia hesitantly take the first bite of hers, and her eyes light up, "Oh wow . . . this is . . . *good*." Scorpia basically inhales the rest of the beast's ear and looks sad when it's done. Catra hasn't touched hers, so she hands it over, "Wildcat . . . are you sure?"

"Yeah," Catra insists. "I can always get another. Just don't choke on it, okay?"

"Oh . . . thank-you," Scorpia says, and this time she takes her time eating it. In between bites she asks, "So . . . how's life in Half Moon been like?"

"What?" Catra echoes. She doesn't know why she wasn't expecting that question.

"I haven't been up too much," Scorpia says. "I sat in a jail cell in Bright Moon for a while before spending weeks trying to research Beast Island. It must have been more exciting here. I want to know what happened to you. I want to know *everything*."

Catra can't tell Scorpia everything (*cough* being a princess *cough*) but she can try, "Well . . . I got attacked by a beast when I first came on the island, and the Magicats rescued me, so I spent a while recovering. That's how I became friends with Shire. And then I spent time trying to get off the island but Half Moon grew on me. And then I had to get a job which is why I joined the Hunters."

"So, you've kept busy," Scorpia says.

"Yeah," Catra nods.

"And how'd you meet your other friends?"

"Well, I told you about Shire," Catra says. "Gr'wliger, Sh'dowell and Gar'ett are all hunters. Busto . . . Busto kinda annoyed me into being his friend."

When she looks at Scorpia, she's stopped eating her beast ear for the moment. She's staring at the table, looking slightly somber, "Wildcat, I'm glad you're doing good here. You're a lot happier than you were in the Horde."

"I . . . I am," Catra nods.

"And you've made a lot of friends."

"And you're my friend too," Catra reminds her.

Scorpia looks up and smiles, "Right."

She quickly finishes the beast ear and then they're moving through the market again. They mostly window-shop and talk, and Catra tells Scorpia more about what life in Half Moon is like. Of course, if you walk around the market for a while, you're just bound to end up running into Thom.

"Oh," Catra scowls when she sees him in front of them. "We should go a different way-"

"Why? I thought you said that there was another food stall ahead that you like?" Scorpia asks.

"Yeah, but-" Catra turns around and tries to direct Scorpia the same way. However, she feels someone push her into Scorpia and she nearly falls on her friend, but she catches herself. When she stands up straight, she sees Thom passing her by, glancing at her with a smirk.

"You okay, Wildcat?" Scorpia asks. "Did you trip?"

"No, I was pushed," Catra growls and immediately glances at her wrist. She's been wearing the bracelet N'yan gave her because it makes the kit happy, and of course it's gone, "C'mon Scorpia, we gotta find Thom."

Catra starts to move as quickly as she can through the crowds of Magicats, and it takes Scorpia a moment to follow, asking, "Wait? The guy that tried to pick a fight with you the other day? Why?"

"He stole something from me," Catra growls. Thankfully, Thom's tall enough that he sticks over the heads of other Magicats-even when he's trying to stoop over. She's catching up to him when he ducks into an alleyway. Good, she can trap him. But

when she turns the corner, she finds a dead-end . . . with no Thom, “What! Where did he go?”

Scorpia catches up, staring down the street, “Wait, isn’t that him down there?”

Catra glances in that direction, and catches Thom stepping out of a different alley with a self-assured smirk on his face. But he hasn’t gotten away with anything and she makes a beeline towards him, “Get him!”

As soon as Thom sees Catra sprinting towards him (with Scorpia on her tail) he takes off. Thankfully, the Magicats see her on a warpath and part for her, while Thom is slowed down by people not getting out of his way. She almost catches up to him, but he pops into another alleyway again.

“Oh no, not this time!” Catra shouts, but when she gets to the alley, he’s gone. “How does he keep doing that?! Scorpia, do you see him?”

“Uh, no,” Scorpia says as she scans the room. “Is there like a trap door?”

“No!” Catra kicks the cave floor. There’s a fence that he couldn’t have climbed over that fast, and stalls on either side that he couldn’t hide in. “Let’s head to one of the exits and cut him off.”

One exit leads to the dining hall, and another leads to other caves in Half Moon. Catra figures that the latter is more likely, so she starts to run in that direction. On the way, she spots Thom’s head down another street, so she changes direction and runs straight to him. At this point, he’s evaded her grasp twice, and figures that the best course of action is to tackle the motherfucker-her image with the Magicats be damned.

Before he can see her, she jumps and knocks him over onto the ground, shouting, “Give me my bracelet back you piece of shit!”

"What the fuck!" Thom hisses and tries to punch her. "I don't have it!"

She grabs his wrist and looks at his closed fist, which is wrapped around her bracelet, "Really?!"

"Found that on the ground!" he argues as he squirms. He uses his other hand to try and push her off, since both of her hands are busy trying to uncurl his fingers. However, she's wrapped her legs around him and is not getting off until she gets her bracelet back.

Of course, unless someone grabs her by the back of her shirt and pulls her off of him.

Catra feels herself airborne for a second and is quickly placed back on her feet. Thom is dragged up too by the other hand, and both of them are now looking at General Az'al, who doesn't look happy. The last time she got into a fight with someone, Az'al was the one to break it apart too, and the memory of nearly being dragged to C'yra's office makes her sick. She closes her eyes and tries to breath in as she waits for it to happen again.

"Now," Az'al begins. "What did you steal from Catra?"

Wait, what?"

She opens her eyes as Thom crosses his arms, "I didn't steal nothin'! She attacked me outta tha blue!"

"Now I don't believe that," Az'al says, taking her hand off of Catra and holding it out before Thom. "Give it to me, *now*. Or else you're finally going to find out what it's like to spend a night in the brig." Thom glares at Catra but finally drops the bracelet into Az'al's hand. With that, she lets him go but gives him another warning, "If me or any of my soldiers catch you again, we will arrest you. This has gone on long enough. Now get out of here."

With that, he shoots a final glare at Catra before slinking away. Part of her wants to watch him, to make sure he actually leaves, but she's too concerned with Az'al.

"Here you go," Az'al hands Catra her bracelet.

"Sorry," Catra quickly says, on instinct.

"No need to be sorry," Az'al insists. "Thom's the one who should be apologizing." Her eyes widen for a moment and says to herself, "Oh crap, I should have made him apologize to you too."

"But I tackled-" Catra tries to get out.

"No blood was drawn," Az'al says as if that explains it. "Now, you'll have to excuse me, I'm about to be late to an emergency Council Meeting."

Catra hasn't heard about an emergency meeting since she showed up, so she suddenly asks, "Is it about the Etherians?"

Az'al pauses, "Yes, it is. Now, excuse me."

Catra watches the General leave, and realizes that's the nicest Az'al has ever been to her. Then, she wonders why the Council needs to meet about the Etherians. She has a feeling that Gr'wliger, C'yra and Rita will all speak up on their behalf, and she'll annoy the hunter later to get the details about it. For now, she doesn't have to worry.

"So, is that what Thom stole from you?" Scorpia brings Catra back to reality. "A bracelet?"

"Yeah," Catra nods. "I usually don't wear jewelry but N'yan bought it for me and since it's a gift I *have* to like it but it's nice," an idea dawns on her as she rambles, and she looks up at Scorpia, "Do you want one too?"

Scorpia's eyes sparkle, "Can they match? Like *friendship bracelets*?"

Catra sighs, “Sure Scorpia, they can match. Let’s go get you a bracelet.”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Once again, sorry about the delay, but if you wanted updates on this story or you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. If you like the story, please leave a comment! I know I suck at responding to them but I swear I read and appreciate every one.

like someone who found a small town to escape to, keeps one eye on their abandoned former self

Chapter Summary

Catra trains for the Ball with C'yra and her friends.

Chapter Notes

Hello! So, sorry about the delay but I think I'm going to be moving to updating this fic once every two weeks. I think it just makes more sense with all of the projects I'm working on right now plus school, and uh, let's be real once Genshin Impact 2.0 drops next week I am going to be spending way to much time scrambling around Inazuma. But, that's kinda why I'm writing like crazy right now to get the next chapters ready. So for now, please enjoy this chapter!

Chapter title come from Spent Gladiator 2, by the Mountain Goats

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"*Scutum!*"

BANG!

"Fuck!"

C'yra launches Catra on her ass again, after the shield spell fails *again*. She finally got a chance to sneak away to train with C'yra and practice the spell, but it hasn't worked *once*.

"You alright, kitten?" C'yra asks as she holds out a hand, but Catra doesn't accept it just yet. "That was a hard fall."

"Yeah," Catra sighs dejectedly. "Just . . . why isn't the stupid fucking spell working!?"

All C'yra can do is shrug, "I'm sorry. I wish I could help but you know I'm no good with magic. You sure you're not missing anything?"

Catra's form is good. Her pronunciation is perfect. She even gave up and is envisioning She-Ra's shield in her mind. It just doesn't work for her.

"No, I'm doing everything right," Catra groans and buries her face in her hands.

C'yra sits down on the ground across from Catra, "Maybe there's something else going on. How have you been feeling since the Princesses showed up?"

"It's been nice talking to Scorpia," Catra says.

"And the others?" C'yra asks.

Catra frowns and looks away, remaining silent.

"I won't judge you, Catra," C'yra reminds her. "If it's because of something you did before coming to Purrsia, I know you've changed."

She knows that-C'yra and Ri'ta have been nothing but caring and understanding-but it doesn't make it any easier. She takes a deep breath and says, "I've been trying to avoid Adora, Glimmer and Bow. I hurt all three of them and so far, I've only apologized to Adora. And all I said was 'sorry'. I should say more but . . . it's hard."

"Apologizing always is," C'yra says. "Especially for stubborn people like us."

"But also . . . she never apologized to me," Catra continues. "What I did to her was fucked up and maybe I don't deserve an apology, but I'm still hurt."

"What did she do?"

"She left me in the Horde," Catra growls. "Breaking her promises to stay by my side. But that . . . that's why I did everything I did. I was just . . . so angry and hurt."

"It's okay to feel hurt, especially over a promise as big as that," C'yra says. "And while I can't agree with how you reacted in the past; you've changed. You deserve as much of an apology as she does now that you've taken responsibility for your actions, but you may have to give it more time. At least she came all the way here to 'save' you."

"But I didn't need saving. I don't need her, here," Catra crosses her arms and grumbles. "I just . . . feel like I can't trust her anymore."

"Both of you will just have to rebuild that trust," C'yra says.

She may be right, but Catra's getting sick of talking about Adora and changes topic, "So, Gr'wliger told me you called the Council meeting yesterday."

"Yes, I just wanted to make sure that the Council was on the same page about the Princess Alliance," C'yra says. "Did Gr'wliger tell you about it?"

"No, Az'al did," Catra says. "Well, I asked her after she pulled me off of Thom cuz I tackled him because he stole something from me, but, uh, I was kinda surprised she wasn't pissed off at me. I thought she didn't like me."

"Az'al has no real reason to not like you," C'yra says. "And if she does-it's because of something that has nothing to do with you."

"I attacked one of her soldiers."

"Well, I suppose there's that, but," C'yra sighs and rests her chin in her hand. "It's a bit more complicated than that."

Catra waits for C'yra to continue, but the Queen has zoned out and is now staring out into space. She snaps her fingers and says, "I'm nosey. Tell me why Az'al doesn't like me."

"Once again, nothing to do with you," C'yra insists. "Remember how I told you that Az'al's daughter, Demeter, was born shortly after you?"

"Yeah."

"Well, Demeter wasn't an only child. She had a twin brother. But he and Az'al's husband were lost in the Fall of Purrsia," C'yra lets out a heavy sigh. "During the war, many people went missing, and between the Horde and the beasts we had to assume they were dead. But when Az'al lost her son, she was convinced he was still alive and never gave up hope that one day, he would come home. So, when we found you, she got her hopes up once again. If she didn't like you, it's because you weren't her son."

"Oh," Catra blinks.

"And you said that there were no other Magicats in the Horde, right?" C'yra checks.

"As far as I know," Catra mumbles. "I never saw anyone that looked like me."

"Okay," C'yra sighs.

Silence falls over them like a thick, wooly blanket. Catra breaks it to ask, "Is that why you and Az'al don't get along anymore? Because your daughter came back and not her son?"

"I don't think it's helped," C'yra sighs. "But things between us were already pretty bad, so don't blame yourself."

"So what happened?" Catra asks.

"You don't need to worry yourself with it-"

"Hey. I vented to you about my ex-best friend. It's only fair you tell me about yours," Catra says as she crosses her arms.

C'yra sighs, "There's . . . many things. After her husband and son died, she threw herself into the war. She didn't want to retreat-she wanted to fight until we won, or she died a glorious death and the former wasn't going to happen. But I wasn't going to let her kill herself for a lost cause, so I forced her to retreat, and I needed her. Her daughter needed her. I think she always resented that."

"So, she doesn't like you because you wouldn't let her die in battle?" Catra asks.

"That may be part of it," C'yra says. "But, after the retreat into Half Moon we didn't talk about it. We were too busy trying to survive. It didn't boil over until years later when we got into the worst fight we've ever had."

"The one where Ri'ta had to pull you two apart?" Catra asks. When C'yra raises a brow, she adds, "Demeter mentioned it when you got pissed at Glimmer."

"We always did prefer to solve things with our fists," C'yra says. "But yes, Demeter overheard that whole conversation and it may have driven a rift between her and her mom. Az'al blamed me for that, which may be rightfully placed. After the fight we left things unsaid, so we weren't bad, but we weren't good. We were just okay. I suppose I was misinterpreting it and things were worse than they seemed. And here we are now," C'yra sighs again and closes her eyes for a moment. When she opens them, she says, "But I have hope that we'll both fix things with our friends, in due time."

"Really?" Catra asks. It feels like she burned all her bridges with Adora, and her band-aid apology is barely enough for building a new foundation.

"Really. You're stubborn like me, kitten. Stubborn enough to persevere through this very rough patch," C'yra says with a small smile. "Well, thanks for listening to me. Do you feel better?"

"Yeah," Catra says. C'yra's right-she's stubborn. Slowly but surely, she can fix things with Adora . . . once she gets an apology from her.

"Now I'd offer another round, but I think we're running out of time," C'yra says as she stands up, and gives her hand to Catra to help her too. "Didn't you say you were going to train with Busto, Gr'wliger and Sh'dowell at three?"

"Oh Saz, you're right," Catra groans. "Well, I'll see you later and . . . thanks for letting me vent."

"Anytime, kitten."

To her surprise, Catra's the first of her friends to show up at the training ground. But she's not alone.

At the center of the arena, Demeter and Az'al are fighting. Well, not *fighting* fighting, it looks like they're training. Demeter doesn't have her longbow, rather she's in close quarters with twin blades. She pauses and steps back from Az'al when she spots Catra, "Hey. What's up?"

"I didn't mean to intrude," Catra instinctively says. "It's just, I'm supposed to meet Busto here. I think he said he reserved the next spot for training."

"Ah right, looks like we're out of time," Az'al sighs, turning to Demeter. "We can continue tomorrow, and don't overwork yourself if you decide to train more."

"I know, Mom," Demeter rolls her eyes, but she has a small smile on her face.

"I'll see you around," Az'al says as she takes her leave. Once the General's gone, Demeter and Catra stare at each other in silence.

"So," Catra says.

"So," Demeter says.

"What're you doing here?"

"Training for the Jellicle Ball, duh."

"You're competing?"

"Of course," Demeter nods. "But Gr'wliger was right in that I'm a better hunter than I am a fighter."

"So, you asked your mom to train you?"

"Yep. She can go toe-to-toe with C'yra, so I'm learning from one of the best," Demeter nods.

That's fair, especially because Catra's been training with both of her mothers. She crosses her arms and says, "Well. I look forward to competing against you."

"Good," Demeter smirks as she leaves. "Just don't underestimate me!"

Catra thought that her main competition for the Ball would be Busto and Gr'wliger, but she'll have to watch out for people like Demeter.

Once Demeter leaves, she's not alone for long. Busto arrives with his usual flair, shouting, "Tally ho, Catra! Looks like you beat me!"

"Yeah, you're late," she turns around and freezes as she notices that he's carrying a jug of water and is trailing Adora, Bow and Glimmer behind him. While the three of them are taking in the sight of the arena, she says, "Hey, Busto?"

"Yeah?"

"Whatcha got there?"

"A jug of water! In case we get parched."

Catra sighs and pinches the bridge of her nose, "Busto?"

"Yeah?"

"Come here." He walks over and Catra grabs his shoulder, wrenching him down so she can hiss in his ear, "Do you really think it's a good idea to bring them here to practice fighting after everything that happened between us?"

"Well, I think they're getting stir-crazy, Catra," Busto says. "And to move on, you'll have to face the past eventually. May as well get over this hurdle."

"Couldn't you have also grabbed Scorpia?!"

"She's hanging out with Sea Hawk, right now."

She sighs, but as Sh'dowell and Gr'wliger arrive, she figures that there's no way out of this.

"So, are we all training together?" Sh'dowell asks.

"I guess?" Catra shrugs.

"Well, we thought we'd help you guys prepare for this Ball however we can," Bow says.

"Plus, we need to stay on top of our game," Adora adds.

"We'll take any help that we can get!" Busto says. "Practicing against a variety of foes will help keep our senses sharp for the Ball!"

"So how does the Ball work? Is it just a fighting tournament?" Glimmer asks.

"Yes and no," Busto jumps to answer. "There are three brackets where people fight to make it to the final challenge: a free-for-all battle between the three best warriors in the United Clans."

"So . . . how is that not a fighting tournament?" Bow asks.

"The entire Ball and festival afterwards is dedicated to Saz-we fight not for the glory . . . well, maybe a little bit, but we fight to show our battle prowess to Saz!" Busto says as he strikes a dramatic pose, but it falls flat with the Best Friend Trio.

"Who's Saz?" Glimmer asks.

"Have . . . have we met them yet?" Adora asks.

"You . . . you don't meet Saz," Sh'dowell says, slightly concerned. "Well, unless you die."

The Best Friend Trio stare at Sh'dowell in horror, so Catra pinches the bridge of her nose and steps forward, "Okay. Quick rundown of Magicat religion: there's three gods. Saz is the god of war and death, Lyses is the god of nature and life, and Ilir is the god of storms & beasts."

"I have questions," Bow begins.

"I'm not answering them," Catra sighs. "Besides, we should be busy *practicing for the Ball*."

"Right!" Busto agrees. "But . . . there are a few more things you all should know about the Ball."

"Uhg!" Catra groans.

"The rules are," Busto continues. "You can only bring three weapons with no major modifications, ammunition does not count as a weapon, you must wear armor, no death blows, and only battle magic is allowed."

"That's . . . not a lot of rules," Bow says.

"Next! The Jellicle Ball takes place here, in the arena, but during it a special mechanism design by our own Lionel'o will be activated that makes the arena move and change shape, providing another level of difficulty!"

"This is the second year we have the moving arena," Gr'wliger says. "The old Grand Arena had this ability as well."

"It won't move . . . now, right?" Adora checks.

"No. It can only be activated by Queen C'yra during the opening ceremonies," Busto says. "So, we're fine! Now, any other questions?" he only pauses for a moment and ignores the multiple Etherians opening their mouths to speak. "None! Good! Because we only have the arena reserved for two hours so let's get started!"

"It's your fault that you talk too much," Catra grumbles.

"So, I guess we should pair up? One Magicat and one member of the Princess Alliance?" Bow says. "But, we have an odd number."

"Don't worry," Catra says. "I'm not sparing with any of you guys."

"Why not?" Adora asks. Catra simply raises an eyebrow and gives her a 'really' look. To her surprise, Adora can still read her, "Oh right. Well . . . if that's what you want then, okay."

"Then, I'll spar with you Adora!" Busto offers.

"You sure?" Adora checks, revealing the (very stupid and not at all impressive) sword of Power.

While Busto, Gr'wliger and Sh'dowell gasp at the Sword, Catra crosses her arms and says, "I'm pretty sure 'magic girl transformations' don't count as war magic. Actually, same thing with Shimmer's useless teleports."

"They're not useless!" Glimmer insists.

"Then why do you always run out of them?"

"Okay!" Busto interjects to break up a potential fight. "Only war magic is allowed at the Ball! I'll have to fight your magic girl form another day."

"Oh," Adora deflates, turning the sword back into a gauntlet. "I"ll uh, need to borrow a sword then."

"We have spares in the armory," Busto says. "We don't draw blood during training as a rule, so you can use a real one. However, we have to use felt-tipped arrows to determine a 'hit', so Bow, Gr'wliger can share some of his with you."

"And you don't draw blood during the Ball too?" Bow asks, becoming slightly nervous.

Busto stares at him.

"And you won't draw blood during the Ball too, right?!"

"Well . . ." Busto begins.

"The Jellicle Ball used to be gladiatorial combat between the best warriors in rival tribes to try and become the Champion," Gr'wliger quickly steps in. "We have scaled back the stakes and the danger of competing, but competitors fight until they can fight no more. Though no major wounds are allowed, we have a healer on stand-by."

"No one has died during the Jellicle Ball since they stopped the gladiatorial combat thing," Sh'dowell points out. "Trust us, it'll be fine."

Glimmer side-eyes Catra, "You sure?"

"Yes," Catra growls. "Now, you all can continue chatting, I'm going to go beat the shit out of a training dummy because at least that doesn't talk."

"There you are!"

Catra groans, as she hasn't moved an inch before someone is barging into the conversation. Thom enters the arena with a shit-eating grin on his face, and she sighs, "Saz dammit. What the fuck do you want Thom?"

"I wanted to tell you something," Thom says as he stops between Gr'wliger and Sh'dowell, who are both tense and have a hand on their weapons. He rolls back and forth on his feet as he announces, "I'm competing in the Ball!"

"But, why?" Busto quickly interjects, looking concerned. "You hated to fight when we were kids."

"Things change!" Thom sneers. "*Obviously*. But, I'm competing so me and Catra can finally fight, for real!"

"For real?" Catra repeats, raising an eyebrow skeptically. "What makes you think that this will be an even fight?"

"I've got tricks up my sleeve!" Thom says. "Many, *many* tricks."

"Sure you do," Catra rolls her eyes. "Get the fuck out of here Thom. We have the arena reserved."

"Why? You don't want a warm-up fight to get a taste of what you should expect?" Thom taunts. "Or are you scared?"

“Of you? An overgrown weed? No,” Catra scoffs. “Now, I have some real training to do. At the Ball, you can hit me with your best shot.”

Thom scowls as he starts to back away, “Oh I will. You better watch out for me Catra.”

He leaves, blending into the shadows at the entrance of the arena, and Adora asks, “Uh . . . what was that all about?”

“Don’t worry,” Catra sighs. “Now, can we train, or what?”

“Yes, we can train,” Busto says. “Especially because we have only like an hour and a half left!”

Catra trains alone for the remaining hour and a half, while the Best Friend Squad spars with her friends. She doesn’t mind. Really, she doesn’t. But Busto still comes up to her after they’re done to say, “Sorry about that. I guess you’re not ready for a push yet.”

“You think?” Catra growls.

“You want to go and run around outside for a bit?” Busto says. “Gr’wliger says it should be fine if we stick to Hunter trails, and you should know them by now.”

“Yes, get me out of here!” Catra groans.

They both don green cloaks and hoods before passing through the gates of Half Moon, and Catra takes the lead. She doesn’t really think as they quietly travel together, but her feet lead her to the ledge where she threw her Force Captain’s badge into the ocean.

"Ah, remember your emotionally freeing moment?" Busto asks nostalgically as they approach the cliff.

"Of course I do. It wasn't that long ago," Catra rolls her eyes. "So . . ." she starts to trace the bark on the tree she leans against with one of her claws, "What are your thoughts on Adora?"

"She's a good fighter," Busto says. "Though she could just fight with brute force, she still fights smartly. But, I was still able to get multiple hits on her since she fights like she should be eight foot tall."

"I think she underestimated you," Catra says, and then crosses her arms and scowls. "And she's also probably used to fighting as She-Ra."

Busto studies her for a moment, "You *really* don't like She-Ra."

"No shit," Catra huffs. "But enough about her."

"You started."

"Shut up."

"You want to stand around in awkward silence?"

"Fine. Talk about something that's not Adora."

"Okay. The Jellicle Ball."

"What about the Jellicle Ball?"

He doesn't speak for a moment, decides to climb up onto the tree Catra's leaning on and sits on the lowest branch. He begins to kick his feet out like a child as he asks, "Do you think you're going to make it into the top three?"

"Yeah," Catra snorts. She has to, so she doesn't disappoint C'yra and Ri'ta. She has to win. "What about you?"

"Of course! I placed in the top three the last two years!" Busto says, suddenly standing up on the branch. He almost falls off, but quickly stabilizes himself against the trunk. "But, do you know why the Ball is split into three brackets rather than two?"

"No."

"Well, it was because back in the old days, they believed that if you were really the best fighter in all the tribes, you should be able to fight off two enemies at once," Busto says. "It was a test of strength, and we've kept it since then. Sometimes, it'd be equal between the three competitors, like back when Az'al, C'yra and Ri'ta used to all compete. But really, it's made it harder for some of the best warriors to win."

Catra looks up at him for a moment, but he isn't looking at her, "Because the other two team-up to take them out?"

Busto finally glances down and nods, "Yes. I've had a target on my back since I became Az'al's second-in-command. But this year, there's someone else."

"It's me, isn't it?" Catra guesses.

"You're on equal footing with me, if not better since you're the only person in Half Moon who can use war magic beside Ri'ta," Busto continues. Catra opens her mouth, she hasn't been keeping it a secret that she's training with Ri'ta, but also hasn't been going around shouting about it. He holds up his hand, "I know, but as soon as you start using it during the Ball the target on your back will grow bigger. I know you'll make it to the top three, but once there you're going to have a hard time making it to the top spot."

"I've had the whole world against me for all my life," Catra says. "I think I can handle this."

"Catra," Busto sighs. "I want that top spot also. I hope you don't hold it against me, but if I end up in the final three with you, I'm going to give it all that I've got."

"You're gonna gang up on me with whoever else is with us?" Catra asks.

"I'll try not to," Busto says. "But as my main competition, I will try to take you out first. I'm sorry."

Catra stares at him and sighs, "Don't be. I think I'd be angrier if you were underestimating me or weren't trying. But I won't let you take me out. I'm going to win!"

Busto claps his hands and laughs, "There's that fire! I have a feeling that this is going to be the best Jellicle Ball we've had in a long time. Let's hope that we don't end up in the same bracket so we can make it to the final round!"

"Yeah," Catra agrees. "You better be looking forward to me kicking your ass."

The Jellicle Ball is in three days. Catra knows that if she wants to win it all, she's going to have to train harder than ever.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! Please consider leaving a comment (I know I suck at responding to them but I do really read all of them) and following me on social media, at Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. And I hope you all have a good day!

i've been working on a unified theory if i make it through tonight everybody's gonna hear me out

Chapter Summary

With the Jellicle Ball on the horizon, Catra tries to learn a few more spells from Ri'ta. However, she's interupted by Bow & Adora.

Chapter Notes

Hello! I guess I don't have much on the top other than that I made a map of Purrsia! You can see it in Chap 10, or find it here on my twitter.

Also, thank-you all for the comments, I do read and appreciate them all! I just suck at responding to them. But with that out of the way, please enjoy the chapter!

Chapter title: Touch Tone Telephone, Lemon Demon

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Over the past two days, Catra has been training day and night to prepare for the Ball. She sparred with Busto and got tips from C'yra. Now, she has the chance to learn some more spells from Ri'ta.

"Alright, so," Ri'ta looks to Catra, up from the book they're going over together. They're shoulder-to-shoulder, and Catra's doesn't mind the closeness. "Think you're ready?"

"Yeah, sure," Catra agrees. This spell is probably the most difficult one she's done yet (excluding the shield spell). It pushes opponents back with a wall of force and requires great concentration-especially because the library is filled with easily toppled bookshelves. Catra can't wait to try it.

"Then tell me what you have to do, one more time," Ri'ta says.

"I put my hands together like this," Catra says, holding out her hands and placing her palm on the back of the other. "Say the control word, `*Vela*', and push my arms forward."

"Good," Ri'ta nods. She walks over and drags a chair to an open spot. "I want you to push this chair, but as soon as you move it a little-drop the spell. I don't want the chair to go flying and hit someone or a bookcase to fall over."

"Separating my hands should stop the spell, right?" Catra checks.

"Correct," Ri'ta nods. She steps back, out of the spell's range, and says, "Go ahead, whenever you're ready."

Catra takes a deep breath, raises her hands to cross them, and says, "*Vela*." The air begins to solidify and shimmer in front of her as the wall forms and-

"Hey Catra, Busto said-" Adora steps out from behind a bookshelf, with Bow following close behind her. She stops immediately, causing Bow to slam into her as she exclaims, "Whoa, are you doing magic!?"

Catra's concentration snaps in half and the spell fizzles out. She angrily turns around and hisses, "Well, not anymore!"

"Oh, sorry," Adora awkwardly rubs the back of her head.

"It's alright," Ri'ta says as she steps forward and places her hand on Catra's shoulder, "The spell can be done again. If not, we wouldn't be doing magic in the first place."

Ri'ta's presence is enough to calm her, but her words are comforting as well. Adora notices this and steps further into the center, Bow carefully following.

"So, what's up?" Catra asks as she crosses her arms.

"Well, we can come back later, you look busy," Adora says, glancing between Catra and Ri'ta. Adora's nervous around the Queens, probably because of the whole horde connection and Glimmer pissed them off.

"Don't worry, it's about time we take a break anyways," Ri'ta says. "I'm going to run to the kitchen for a snack, would any of you like anything?"

"Whatever Jen'dots is making," Catra shrugs.

"Oh, we just had lunch, but thank-you, Your Majesty," Bow says. Catra wants to roll her eyes at how formal he's being, she knows that Ri'ta isn't a fan of that type of shit.

"No need for formalities, Bow," Ri'ta insists. "I'll be right back."

Once she's gone, Bow sighs, "She's so nice."

"Yeah, she's cool," Catra agrees. "So really, what's up?"

"Can we talk about you doing magic first? Because I think we need to talk about you doing magic first," Adora asks.

"Okay, so what about it?" Catra begins.

Adora breaths in, "You can do magic?!"

Her outburst earns a few shushes from the surrounding scholars, hidden by the bookshelves. Adora winces, but Catra continues on, not giving them much attention, "Yes. Is that all?"

"How can you do magic?" Bow asks.

"I dunno, according Ri'ta it's just something you're born with, and I guess I have 'it'," Catra saunters over to the table where she had her books spread out. She doesn't mention that

she’s pretty much guaranteed at least some magical ability because, well the M’stoff’lls tribe are the most clever and magical of any Magicats, and she’s Ri’ta’s daughter.

“So, you’ve been practicing. Why?” Adora asks as she stands besides Catra. There’s something unspoken about that statement, leaving off anything about Shadow Weaver and how her magic has hurt Catra in so many ways.

“Because it’s, y’know, good magic,” Catra tries to explain, but she doesn’t really like that Bow is behind them and there’s a bunch of nosey scholars about. If the two were having this conversation alone, Catra might consider spilling something. Maybe. Things are still so very awkward between them. She does her best, “It kinda makes it mine. Being taught by Ri’ta, getting good at magic, it’s making a point. Proving something.”

Adora nods, and Catra knows that she’s gotten it. No need to name-drop Shadow Weaver in this situation.

Catra nods back, “So, did you two come just to interrupt my magic lesson or what?”

“Oh, right!” Bow steps in, and Catra supposes she should be thankful he knows when to mind his own business. “So, we were talking to Busto, who mentioned something about Ruins and that you knew something about them. We were wondering if-”

“They’re First Ones’ ruins? Well, good news for you, they totally are,” Catra steps over to another table, the one that’s usually reserved for her-away from all the scholars and close enough to Ri’ta-where she has her usual research laid out. There’s a combination of old books with crumbling covers, ancient maps bound by twine, and fresh parchment with her near-indecipherable scribbles on them. She’s been so busy with the Ball and learning magic and working with the hunters, it’s been a while since she got to do any research.

"Oh wow," Adora gasps as she and Bow look over her work.

"You've done a lot," Bow adds.

"It actually isn't that much," Catra says. "I've been busy lately."

"So, what's up with these Temples? They don't have any hologram ladies in them, do they?" Adora checks.

Catra raises an eyebrow as she starts to unfurl one of the maps, "No . . . well, there were robot squirrels in one-"

"What?"

"-But, the two temples are called the Temple of Saz and the Temple of Lyses, dedicated to two of the three Magicat deities."

"The Jellicle Ball is for Saz, right?" Bow checks.

"Yes, because they're the deity of War, and is the primary deity of the Magicats," Catra continues.

"Didn't you say they were also the god of death? The primary god is a god of death?" Bow checks.

"All three deities are associated with death," Catra says. She can't believe how much of this stuff is sticking in her head, she used to hate the Horde history class. Well, most of that was probably propaganda made up to make the Horde look good. Anyways, "Saz is known for glorious death-usually in battle-while Lyses is known for rebirth after death, you get nine times before you get to chill in their realm forever."

"Who's the third?" Adora asks.

"Ilir, deity of storms and beasts," Catra explains. "They're evil. Those wicked in life go to their realm to suffer for eternity

when they die. They don't have a temple."

Ri'ta returns at that moment, carrying one of Jen'adots perfectly packed baskets. She sets it down on the table as she joins in the conversation, "Actual, some clerics believe that Ilir does have a Temple, it just hasn't been seen yet. When it rises, it will mark the end of times."

Catra looks at Ri'ta with surprise, "I haven't seen that anywhere."

"It's probably in the more religious texts, you should ask Deut'ron about it," Ri'ta suggest as she joins them. "I know a little bit about it, a famous cleric who Lyses blessed with foresight predicted the end of times and how it could be stopped. It included the rise of the Temple of Ilir. Of course, foresight is bullshit, so."

"I'm . . . I'm sorry?" Bow says, shocked that the Queen swore. "But what do you mean?"

Ri'ta sighs, "Don't get me started on divination magic."

"How can one stop the 'end of times'?" Adora asks, looking a bit worried. Catra figures that she's placing that burden on herself, but Ri'ta's right. This cleric probably got high on Nip and had a fucking awful trip.

"According to the cleric-but once again, this is probably bullshit-the Champion of Saz will have to go into the Temple of Ilir and destroy the Stone of Ilir, causing the Temple to crumble and banishing Ilir's influence from our world," Ri'ta explains.

"So, who's the Champion of Saz? Whoever will win the Jellicle Ball?" Bow asks.

"No, then it would change from year to year," Catra says. "If I had my guess, it's whoever's connected to the Stone of Saz."

Ri'ta smiles, "Exactly right."

“And the Stone of Saz is just a Runestone, so the current champion is C’yra,” Catra concludes. She realizes that all of that technically makes her the Champion of Saz as well-even more so than C’yra because of her stronger connection to the Stone-but she doesn’t try to think about that right now.

“Also right,” Ri’ta says.

“Wait, you guys have a Runestone?” Adora says with a hushed voice.

“Underneath the Temple of Saz,” Catra drops, not trying to keep it a secret.

Bow narrows his eyes, “How do you know that?”

Catra sighs, sensing his distrust, “I stumbled upon the Temple of Saz while exploring Purrsia, and fell through the floor onto the Runestone.”

“Yes, and thankfully you weren’t hurt,” Ri’ta tries to diffuse the tension. “But I suppose technically, the Stone is a Runestone. We’ve been calling it the Stone of Saz long before anyone told our people it was a ‘Runestone’.”

“So, why’s it called the Stone of Saz?” Adora asks.

Ri’ta quickly relays the story of C’yra the First and how she united Purrsia with its power, and how her connection to it has been passed through her bloodline.

“So, the First Ones Temples are also Temples to the Magicat deities?” Adora questions once Ri'ta is done. “But, how?”

“Well, the Magicats usually just insist that it’s different without giving much explanation,” Ri’ta admits. “But Catra has a very good theory about that.”

Everyone looks at Catra, and she shrugs as she explains, “Yeah, they’re just the same.”

“What?” Bow says.

“The First Ones and the Magicat deities, they’re just the same people,” Catra continues. “I think Saz, Ilir, and Lyses were all just First Ones who landed on Purrsia and ran into the Magicats. The Magicats decided they were deities and aided them in building Temples and such. So . . . yeah. I'm still doing research on all of this, but haven’t had time to work on it, so I'm not done with the full theory, yet."

"It is technically, a heretical theory," Ri'ta picks up. "But I’m interested in seeing where it goes."

“Well I could help,” Adora says. “If the Temples really are First One Temples, I could read the writing in there and it would probably react to me because of the whole, y’know, She-Ra thing.”

“Maybe,” Catra tries to deflect. Going to the Temple of Lyses should be okay, since the only thing in it are evil robot squirrels, but if they go to the Temple of Saz . . . Catra would have to stay away from the Runestone to avoid revealing that she’s a Princess. “We’d have to wait until after the Ball.”

“Ah, right,” Adora nods, her shoulders slightly dropping. “I guess we should let you get back to your training then, but . . . can I talk to you later? If you’re not busy?”

Catra blinks, caught off-guard by the earnest request. She’s still doing her best to avoid Adora but it’s hard to dodge out of a straight-forward request like this, “If I’m not busy.”

“Okay! Good! Just come find me!” Adora says, a smile returning to her face. “See you later!”

“Good luck with your training!” Bow adds as the two leave.

“So,” Ri’ta says as she turns to Catra. “Anything you want to talk about or . . .”

"I think I'm going to choose 'or' here," Catra says. She exhausted her emotional talk on C'yra the other day, she can catch-up Ri'ta after the Ball. "Can I just try the spell now?"

"Of course," Ri'ta nods and steps aside.

As Catra tries to focus on the spell, she finds her mind wandering as she wonders what Adora wants with her. Whatever it is, it may have to wait until after the Ball. But that doesn't mean that Catra can avoid Adora forever-especially because the Ball is tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

Next time: the Jellicle Ball starts, I swear. I'm sorry if the build-up has been a bit too long, but I realized that for this chapter to make sense I needed to move it up.

If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. I definitely give more updates on this story on twitter rather than tumblr.

Finally, if you like this story, consider leaving a comment! And thanks for reading!

i've had my fair share of sand kicked in my face but i've come through

Chapter Summary

The Jellicle Ball beings.

Chapter Notes

Welcome back! First off, thank-you all for your comments, I do read them all I just suck at replying and I appreciate them all. Secondly, I got obsessed with Hero Forge and made C'yra, Ri'ta, Busto and Gr'wliger in it, so you can look at them here. Finally, enjoy the chapter!

chap title: we are the champions, queen

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"But, c'mon!" Catra begs as she trails Ri'ta out of the library at the end of the day. "The Ball is tomorrow and I still haven't mastered that stupid shield spell! Just one more lesson, please!"

Ri'ta turns to her as the heavy metal doors close behind them, "No."

"Fine then. How about you teach me one more offensive spell? I only know like, five."

"Still no."

"But why?" Catra pleads.

"Because working yourself to the point of exhaustion the night before the Ball isn't going to help you. Trust me, been there, done that," Ri'ta says. "You've done all you can to prepare. The best thing you can do now is get a good night of sleep before you have to get up early tomorrow."

"But-" Catra tries to argue, but Ri'ta's right. Better to have enough energy to make it through the Ball tomorrow. But that doesn't make her feel better, she feels useless just sitting around waiting for the start. It feels like there is so much riding on her success tomorrow. She balls her fists and closes her eyes, "I don't know if I can sleep. I just feel so . . ."

"Wired up?" Ri'ta guesses, and Catra opens her eyes. "Like your stomach is filled with butterflies and you could run a marathon?"

Catra nods.

"Don't worry. It's natural to feel excited and nervous about your first Ball. I was like that too," Ri'ta says. She pauses, "But I think I have something that can help you. Do you have anywhere you need to be?"

Well, Adora said that she wanted to talk to Catra if she was free but . . . now Catra isn't free and she can avoid Adora for another day. She says, "No. Why?"

Ri'ta grins, "It'll be a surprise."

She follows Ri'ta to her and C'yra's quarters, but really Catra usually sleeps here too because she doesn't have bad nightmares while in their proximity. Catra ends up waiting in the living room as Ri'ta goes into her room, and returns with a tall, thin bottle filled with a dark liquid.

"What's that?" Catra asks as Ri'ta grabs two glasses and places them on the table.

"Wine," Ri'ta says. "Vintage from Plumeria. They stopped making it years ago when they thought it was cruel to stomp on grapes to make the wine or something like that. This was a gift from Queen Angella when me and your mother visited Bright Moon years ago."

Catra scrunches her nose, “Then shouldn’t it be bad by now?”

“Wine only gets better with age,” Ri’ta insists. “Now where did I put the bottle opener . . . and how the fuck am I going to open this up with one hand?”

“I can do it,” Catra offers.

“Do you know how to open a wine bottle?” Ri’ta says as she pulls a screw-like tool out of a drawer.

“. . . No.”

“Damn.”

The door opens and C’yra enters, pausing as both Catra’s and Ri’ta’s eyes fall on her, “Oh. Hello.”

“You’re back late,” Ri’ta says as she returns to the wine bottle and tries to screw the cork into the stopper with one hand.

“Finishing up all of the prep work for the Ball tomorrow,” C’yra says as she walks over. “Here, let me open it. Why are you even opening wine anyway?”

“Catra’s nervous about the Ball,” Ri’ta says as C’yra begins to screw the opener into the tool.

C’yra pauses, “You can’t get Catra *drunk* before the Ball-”

“Just one drink, dear,” Ri’ta says, placing a hand on her shoulder. “Remember when we used to do this before the Ball? Of course, it was with cheaper wine, but.”

“Ah. Right. It was a bit of a ‘good luck’ ritual, wasn’t it?” C’yra says with a small smile. She pulls out the cork in the bottle with a pop, and the sweet smell of the wine hits Catra. “Get another glass for me then, I’ll have a drink too.”

"What do you mean, 'good luck ritual'?" Catra asks as C'yra starts to pour and Ri'ta fetches another glass.

"Well, once we were old enough to drink but still young enough to compete, we'd spend the night before the Ball uh," C'yra pauses.

"Partying," Ri'ta finishes. "But, at the end of the night, we'd all toast to each other's victory in the spirit of sportsmanship."

"So," C'yra raises her filled glass. "I propose a toast to your victory in the Jellicle Ball, Catra."

"Here, here!" Ri'ta adds, raising her glass. "I know that you're going to do great tomorrow Catra."

C'yra and Ri'ta look at Catra expectantly, and she nervously raises her glass as well. She feels so much riding on her victory at the Ball-she won't only be letting herself down but C'yra and Ri'ta as well. She will live up to their expectations and win. She *has* to.

"Catra!" Busto shouts as he knocks on her door. "Are you ready?!"

"Hold your fucking beasts!" Catra shouts back. Okay, she might be a bit on edge because of the Ball and doesn't deserve to be that rude to Busto, but her hands are shaking as she finishes fastening the armor she got from the armory. She swears under her breath as she finally gets the last strap done, and grabs the spear and knife Sh'dowell gifted her before opening the door, "Here I am."

She ended up moving into her original room this morning to grab her weapons and armor, so Busto's standing in the hallway rather than in the Queen's quarters. He smiles as he says, "You ready?"

"As ready as I'll ever be," Catra says as she sucks in a breath.

"Nervous?"

"No."

"You're lying."

"Are you nervous?"

"Of course."

"Fine. Then I'm nervous too."

"You should be honest with your feelings.

"I'm not talking about my feelings right now," Catra crosses her arms. "Shouldn't we go to the arena and check in?"

"Yes! We don't want to be late!" Busto exclaims.

The two walk down the winding halls of Half Moon, and she spots other Magicats getting ready for the Ball. Most of them are soldiers, wearing their red uniforms under their armor, and nervously chatting as they finish getting ready. Those that aren't competing seem to be excited, carrying around red banners that have the emblem of Saz and chatting animatedly about the Ball. Throughout their walk, Busto is uncharacteristically quiet, so he must've not been lying when he said he was nervous.

There's a crowd at the entrance of the arena watching as the fighters enter and check-in. At the edge of the crowd, Gar'ett is standing with the Etherians since she isn't competing, and waves her and Busto over. Catra would like to avoid talking to

Adora right now, especially because she kinda blew her off last night to hang with her moms, but Busto's already walking over so she has no choice.

"Hey!" Scorpia greets Catra first. "Are you ready for the Ball?"

"As ready as I'll ever be," Catra sighs.

"Don't worry Wildcat!" Scorpia says as she pulls Catra into a hug that lifts her off of her feet. Catra didn't brace herself for it so she has the wind knocked out of her, "I know that you're going to do great!"

"Thanks," Catra grunts as Scorpia sets her down.

Adora steps forward next, wringing her hands, "Hey Catra."

Catra sighs, "Hey Adora."

"Sorry I didn't get a chance to talk to you last night-I couldn't find you," Adora says.

"Yeah, sorry. I was . . ." Catra wonders how she should lie, but finds that she's too nervous to even try. "Talking with the Queens."

"The Queens?" Adora echoes, and concern shines clear on her face. "Are you in trouble?"

"No, they just wanted to wish me luck," Catra says. C'yra and Ri'ta are the last people Adora should be concerned about, but she doesn't tell her that.

"Oh. Anyway," Adora continues, checking Catra over. "Shouldn't you have three weapons? You only have a spear and a dagger."

"Well, I also have, y'know," Catra says.

"Ah, right!" Adora insists. "Well, good luck."

"Thanks," Catra nods.

"Yeah," Bow chimes in. "Good luck to both you and Busto!"

"You both have a good chance of making it to the final three," Gar'ett says. "As long as you don't end up in the same bracket."

"We should go in there and find out which bracket we're in," Catra says.

"We should," Busto agrees. "But . . . do you all know where the best seats are?"

"Right side of the arena, third row," Gar'ett says. "Don't worry, we'll all be sitting together. Well, most of us will."

"Most?" Catra questions.

"Queen C'yra asked me to sit in their box with them," Glimmer says. "As a 'diplomatic gesture' or something. I thought she didn't want to do anything with the Princess Alliance."

"They don't," Catra insists, crossing her arms. "But wasn't Queen Ri'ta friends with your dad? It's probably more for him than anything else." She looks at Glimmer and realizes that she is actually concerned about sitting with the Queens, so she drops her arms and sighs, "They're actually nicer than you think. Just don't talk about the Horde or the Princess Alliance with them, alright?"

Glimmer looks up and manages a small smile, "Right."

With that, Busto and Catra enter the arena. Competitors are lined up in front of a table, where General Az'al and another soldier are signing people in. It moves quickly, and soon she and

Busto are at the front. Busto goes first, animatedly talking to Az'al as her assistant looks over his weapons. Then, it's Catra's turn.

"Hello Catra," Az'al greets her with a curt nod. Overall, the General does seem to be treating her better and even has a small smile on her face. "Please present us the weapons you'll be using in the Jellicle Ball."

Catra lays the spear and dagger out on the table. The spear isn't the one C'yra gave her since that one is technically modified, so Catra's using a regular one. Az'al looks at Catra, waiting for the third one, and she says, "I'll also be using War magic."

Whispers spark down the line behind her, but Az'al just nods, "Alright. Please collect your weapons. You're in bracket number one. A list with the bracket is in the barracks, please go ahead inside."

Catra nods, grabbing her spear and knife. Busto is waiting for her outside the barrack doors and quickly asks, "What bracket are you?"

"One," Catra says.

"Whew," Busto sighs. "I'm in two. Let's go find Gr'wliger and Sh'dowell and see what one they're in."

"We'll have to face one of them before the final round," Catra says.

"Right," Busto frowns.

It's easy to spot Gr'wliger's tall head in the sea of soldiers in the barracks. He, Sh'dowell, and a few other hunters are standing in the corner, naturally separating from the soldiers. It takes Catra a moment to realize that Demeter's with them too, talking while they wait.

"Hey!" Sh'dowell says. "You two see the brackets yet?"

"No," Catra says as Gr'wliger passes a sheet of paper over to her. The three brackets are hand-written and the paper is crinkled at the corners as it's already been passed between hands many times.



Busto looks over her shoulder, "Looks like we might be facing off before the final, Gr'wliger."

Gr'wliger simply nods, while Catra says, "So I guess Thom's getting what he wanted, a direct fight with me. How are these brackets even decided?"

"They're pulled at random," Busto says. "It looks like you might fight D'nah too."

Catra frowns. She hasn't seen D'nah since she scratched her early in her time at Half Moon. She seems like the type of person who would still be angry at Catra, so she'll have to deal with two people who have grudges against her.

"Uhg, I'm probably going to have to fight Jerry," Sh'dowell complains.

"What's the matter with Jerry?" Catra asks.

"He's super strong!" Sh'dowell complains. "He'll squash me like a watermelon between his meaty thighs!"

"You'll do fine," Demeter insists. "And then I'll squash you like a watermelon."

"Thanks for the encouragement," Sh'dowell grumbles.

"Who are you fighting against?" Catra asks, noticing the blank spot.

"I'm fighting Griza. We got an incomplete one, for some reason," Demeter says. "But I'm not worried. I'm sure I can make it to the final three."

"You're gonna have to fight Jerry for the spot," Sh'dowell says.

"Stop moping, you'll do fine."

"No I won't!"

Catra knows that just standing around and listening to Sh'dowell complain about Jerry won't help her nerves. She's already feeling restless just doing nothing, so she taps Busto's shoulder and asks, "Is there like, anywhere I can get water in here?"

"There's a refreshment table over there," Busto says.

"Thanks," Catra nods and begins to wade through the crowds of soldiers. At the other end of the room is a table run by one of Jen'dots' chefs. They hand her a cup of water, but before she can take a sip of it, someone knocks into her arm and she spills it on the floor. Catra whirls around and hisses, "Hey, watch where you're-"

Her fight dies out when she finds herself face-to-face with D'nah, who has a shit-eating grin on her face. She chuckles, "What was that, Horde soldier?"

Catra pauses and realizes that her fight with D'nah isn't going to start during the Ball-it started months ago when Catra

scratched her. Though Catra's changed, she's not backing down, "First off, I'm not a Horde soldier anymore. Secondly, watch where you're fucking going."

D'nah blinks, clearly not expecting Catra to fight back in the soldier's territory. A few of the soldiers look over at the noise, so Catra crosses her arms and tries to stand a bit straighter.

"Well," D'nah sneers. "What are you gonna do about it? Scratch me again?"

She was right-D'nah is the type of person who holds a grudge. Catra was like that too, but isn't anymore and it's time to prove that. She presses her hands together and leans forward, "Actually, I want to apologize for that. I let my anger get the better of me. I'm sorry."

It's clear D'nah wasn't expecting that, as she backs off as a look of confusion dawns on her face, "Uh . . . okay?"

"But," Catra continues. "You also shouldn't have called me useless. So maybe you deserved it. Just a little."

D'nah scowls and steps back into Catra's space, "You may think you're hot shit, but I'm going to kick your ass during the Ball."

"You can fucking try," Catra hisses.

"Hey wait!" D'nah and Catra turn at the same time toward the poor, idiotic soul who decided to disturb them. She shouldn't be surprised that said idiot is Thom, who marches over to her, "I'm the person you're supposed to be picking a fight with-" and then turns to D'nah, "And you won't have a chance to kick her ass because I'm going to kick her ass!"

Catra pinches the bridge of her nose as D'nah raises an eyebrow and scoffs, "You? Catra's gonna snap you in half like a fuckin' twig. And *I'm* gonna be the one to knock her out."

"You don't know what I'm capable of!" Thom claims. "I've got tricks up my sleeve!"

As D'nah and Thom stare each other down, Catra decides to leave. This won't end well for her so she may as well slip away while their attention is off of her.

She returns to her friend group without incident, and Sh'dowell is still nervously complaining about Jerry. Busto asks, "Did you find it?"

"Yeah," Catra grumbles. "But I don't want to talk about it."

". . . Okay?"

"Atten-tion!" Az'al suddenly shouts as she enters the barracks, and all the soldiers freeze up and salute the General- even Busto. Catra wants to laugh at him, but Az'al continues, "The opening ceremonies are about to start!

"Most of you know the drill, but for the first timers: I want you all to line up in three lines, in the order of your matches. You'll march out to the arena, Queen C'yra will give her speech, and then each bracket will head to their respective barracks to wait for your match. Got it?"

"Sir, yes sir!" the soldiers bark. Catra just gives a thumbs up.

"Well," Busto sighs as everyone moves. "Showtime. Good luck, Catra."

"Good luck to you too," Catra says. "See you in the top three."

And so, the Ball begins.

All 24 competitors are lined up in the arena, Catra standing between two Magicats she barely knows, and turned towards C'yra. C'yra is wearing a fancier version of her usual uniform, and is standing in the box, addressing the crowd.

"Magicats, of the United Tribes of Purrsia," C'yra begins. "It is time once again for the Jellicle Ball!"

The crowds erupt in cheers and Catra can feel her anxiety rise. She's here to prove to everyone that she's not just a Horde soldier. She's here to make C'yra and Ri'ta proud. She can't let them down.

"We gather here to prove our worth to Saz," Cy'ra continues. "Allowing our best warriors the chance to compete for glorious victory! One of these 24 competitors will be the next Champion!"

As the crowd cheers, Deut'ron hobbles forward and hands C'yra a gilded dagger. Catra was warned about this part.

"And so, in the name of Saz," C'yra says as she cuts across her palm with the dagger, drawing a line of blood. "And with the blood they blessed-" C'yra places her hand down on the edge of the box, where Lionel'o's mechanism is activated. The arena lights up as C'yra finishes, "I declare the start of the Jellicle Ball!"

Chapter End Notes

Alright so, I have some bad news: its hiatus time. Tomorrow, a doctor's gonna play Tetris with my jaw to try and get it to line up so I can eat mozzarella sticks. So, I'll be out of it for a while. Then, once I'm recovered, it's gonna be time for school. But please know, I have no intention of stopping this fic and I will be slowly working on it over the break. The next

chapter is going to be pretty long and pretty hard for me to write, but I've come this far with this fic and I'm determined to finish it. So, if you want to hear more from me in the meantime, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Thank-you all for reading and leaving comments, and have a good da

make up magic spells; wear them like protective shells, landmines on the battlesfield; find the one safe way and stay alive, just stay alive

Chapter Summary

The Jellicle Ball begins.

Chapter Notes

Hello, I'm back! For those wondering, jaw surgery went good and I got good grades last semester! I appreciate everyone's support and comments over the past few months as I slowly but surely worked on this fic. But now, let's get to what you are all waiting for: this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's match is first, so as soon as she enters the barracks she's back in the arena. She stands ten paces away from a large Magicat, who's taller and thicker than her. But, the bigger they are, the harder they fall.

"For our first fight," C'yra begins, hand now bandaged. "Garf of F'ld versus Catra! Let the fight . . . begin!"

As soon as the Queen is done speaking, the arena begins to shift and change. Catra pays no mind to it as she runs at her opponent.

She uses her spear to vault over a ledge that rises from the ground and kicks Garf in the chest, causing him to stumble back. Landing on her feet, she quickly points her spear at his neck, but he knocks it back to roll out of the way and onto his hands and knees. She doesn't let him get up, as she quickly kicks him in the side to knock him back down. When she tries to jab her spear down, he rolls out of the way again. Clearly, he's not going

out without a fight, so she'll just have to knock some sense into him.

Catra jumps back as Garf draws his sword and swings it, trying to take out her ankles. She draws her dagger as he stands up, and it's clear to her he's not light on his feet when he slightly stumbles. So, she rushes forward, dodging his sword as she drags her dagger blade across his side. He swings around, all brute force with no elegance, while she stabs him on his other side. She easily dodges his wide strikes, and sneaks in jabs with her dagger when she sees openings.

Even if he wasn't slowly bleeding out, it's clear that Garf is getting tired from putting all his strength into his swings. He's also getting frustrated, since he hasn't hit Catra once. It's just what she wants.

After one of his wild swings, she sees her opening. The arena floor begins to lift up behind him to make a ledge, so she swipes with her dagger-not trying to maim him, just trying to get him to back up. He does so to avoid getting eviscerated, and trips on the step to land hard on his back. His sword falls from his grip and Catra jumps forward, jabbing her spear through his hand and putting her dagger at his throat.

He's breathing heavily, but Catra hasn't broken a sweat at all. When he doesn't move or try to fight back, C'yra calls, "The winner of the fight is Catra!"

Catra stands up, pulling her spear out of his hand. Garf is quickly ushered off towards the infirmary for Shire to take care of his wounds, while she returns to the barracks.

To her surprise, the crowds are cheering as she leaves the arena. Maybe they're going to accept her, like C'yra hoped for. Or maybe they're just consumed with bloodlust and want to see people beat the shit out of each other. Either way, she pays them no mind.

One fight down, another one to go.

"Do you mind if I sit here?"

Bow tears his attention away from the gladiatorial combat below to glance at an older, slate gray furred Magicat who has squeezed her way through the crowds. She's wearing the red uniform of the soldiers, but it only looks more official since she has golden honors on her lapel.

"Yeah, sure!" Bow says, scooching closer to Adora to make room. This gets her attention, and she glances over curiously.

"Thank-you," the Magicat sighs as she sits down. "It took me much longer than I thought to leave. I haven't missed much, have I?"

"We're into the second bracket," Bow says. "This is the second to last fight in it."

"Shit," the Magicat hisses. "I wasted too much time."

A beat silence follows as the Magicat continues to watch the current fight, but Bow can't help but be friendly and holds out his hand, "I'm Bow by the way."

The Magicat raises a brow but shakes his hand, "Az'al of Bom'luri."

Bom'luri . . . that seems familiar . . . but, Bow ignores that nagging feeling and drags Adora into the conversation, "Oh, and also this is my friend Adora."

"Uh, hi," Adora gives a small wave.

"So, who won in the first bracket?" Az'al asks, but she currently more focused on the fight.

"Catra, Thom, Heath, and D'nah," Bow lists off.

Az'al stares at him, "*Thom* won his fight?"

"Uh, yes?"

". . . *How*?"

"He was . . . fast and hid a lot," Bow tries to explain. He actually didn't really follow the fight, but Thom seemed to prefer to hide and quickly pop out to attack.

"Huh," Az'al huffs. "Well, he's facing Catra next, so I doubt he's going to get any farther. She's going to do a clean sweep of her bracket."

"You really think so?" Adora asks.

"She's a natural fighter. Gifted, almost," Az'al says, and Bow almost thinks he sees a fond smile on her face, but she's turned away from him. "She'll do fine in her bracket."

"And do you think she'll win it all?" Bow asks.

"Don't know. She's going to get dog-piled on in the final round," Az'al says.

"What do you mean?" Adora says as a look of concern grows on her face.

"In the final round, the weaker two of the three competitors usually team up to take out the best," Az'al says with a shrug. "Or at least, that's how it's been recently. Back in my day, it was a true free-for-all. C'yra, Ri'ta and I would just wail on each other until we couldn't fight anymore."

"O-oh," Bow mutters. He glances at Adora, who has become concerned. She doesn't pay attention to the next battle, which Gr'wliger wins easily. The next battle is Demeter versus

Griza, and Bow's curious to see how a fellow bow master does. However, he doesn't anticipate Az'al's excitement.

Az'al stands up in her seat and shouts, "KICK HER ASS, DEMETER!"

Adora jolts in her seat, pulled out of her thoughts as Az'al shouts. Demeter runs a hand down her face and glances away, trying to ignore Az'al. Griza looks like she's snickering but is trying to hide it behind her hand.

"Now, we move onto the first fight of the third bracket!" C'yra announces. "Demeter of Bom'luri versus Griza of B'elle! Begin!"

Oh, *that's* where he's heard Bom'luri before! Az'al must be Demeter's mother, if how enthusiastically she's cheering for her if anything to go by. Adora must have never seen a 'sports mom' before with how she's watching Az'al with a mixture of curiosity and terror.

Bow tries to pay attention to the match-Demeter's very good with a bow and every one of her shots hit Griza-but it's a bit hard when Az'al is enthusiastically cheering right next to him and damaging his ear drums. When Demeter wins her match, Az'al finally sits down and takes a deep breath, but she has a happy smile on her face.

"So . . . Demeter's your daughter?" Bow checks as the next match starts.

"Yeah," Az'al says, her smile not fading. "I've been trying to get her to compete for the past couple years and this year she finally did. Though, I think that has less to do with me and more with the competition she might face . . . but, I think she's got a good chance at winning!"

"She's certainly a good marksman," Bow nods, recalling how fast she was able to fire arrows and with scary accuracy. He might even have a hard time keeping up with her. "Most of the

fighters seem to use to close-range combat, aside from maybe Gr’wliger. She certainly has a clear advantage.”

Az’al raises an eyebrow, “Are you a strategist?”

“Well, I’m familiar with battle tactics, but I actually use a bow too!” Bow says.

“Didn’t you say your name was Bow? Isn’t that a bit on that nose?” Az’al checks.

Bow sighs, “Yes, yes it is.”

ROUND ONE RESULTS

Winners of Bracket One: Catra, Thom, Heath, D'nah

Winners of Bracket Two: Busto, Brutus, Coric'pat, Gr'wliger

Winners of Bracket Three: Demeter, Munk'strap, Sh'dowell, Jerry

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So, it appears Thom is going to get the fight he wanted. He somehow managed to make it past the first round, and he returned to the barracks with an annoying smirk on his face. She’ll have to wipe it off.

“Catra and Thom! You’re up next!” one of the soldiers shouts. Catra stands up and walks to the entrance, where Thom is already waiting. She crosses her arms and turns to the door, not acknowledging him.

“Ready to get your ass kicked?” Thom taunts, leaning against the door frame. The smirk still hasn’t left his face.

“I should really be asking you that,” Catra growls. She refuses to look at him or give him any satisfaction.

“I told you, I’ve got-”

"-Tricks up your sleeves, yeah yeah," Catra waves a hand. "You keep saying that, but the shirt you're wearing doesn't even have sleeves on it."

"That's-that's not the point!" Thom sputters. "The point is-"

"And now our next competitors," C'yra's voice echoes across the arena, cutting Thom off. "Catra and Thom of M'Cavity!"

Catra steps into the arena first, leaving Thom to jog to catch up to her quick strides. She takes her place across the arena from him, brandishing her spear.

"One last chance to give up!" Thom shouts across the arena with a smirk on his face. "Wouldn't want you to get embarrassed in front of the Queens!"

"Shut up," Catra growls.

"Let the fight," C'yra says, pausing to glance at Catra and give her a small nod. "Begin!"

The first thing Thom does is run and hide. Catra shouldn't be surprised, considering that he's a coward. He jumps behind a pillar that rises from the ground, and Catra's already running after him. However, when she gets to the pillar, he's nowhere in sight. She hears the ring of a knife being pulled from a sheath and turns around just in time to block the blade with her spear. How did Thom get behind her?

"See?" Thom snarls, mouth pulled into a grin and eyes wide. "I told you, I got tricks up my sle-whoa!"

She doesn't let him finish the thought and pushes him back. He stumbles and she bears her spear down on him. He rolls out of the way at the last second, scrambling to his feet. She tries to kick him before he can stand, but he gets up and she misses.

"Rude," Thom huffs, pulling out a second knife. He leans forward, like he's about to attack, so Catra braces herself, but instead he runs off again.

"I'm not playing a game of cat and fucking mouse, Thom!" Catra shouts, running after him. He ducks behind a wall that's retreating into the ground, and she launches herself over it to land on top of Thom. However, she hits the ground as the wall disappears into the dirt. Thom's gone, "What the fuck?"

She scans the arena and spots him jump up from behind another wall half-way across the arena. As she runs at him, he tries to throw a knife at her, and she easily dodges. She jumps over the small wall again, before he can mysteriously disappear, and tackles him. She uses one hand to pin him down and the other to keep her spear at his throat.

"Give up Thom," Catra growls. "I've got you trapped."

"You just think you do," Thom grins. "*Corvus*."

Suddenly the shadows come up from the ground and wrap around Thom's form. Catra jumps off of him before the inky blackness can even touch her-too much like Shadow Weaver's cursed magic-but he fades into the shadows. She tries to chase away the panic of seeing magic that's all too familiar to her and come to terms with one fact: somehow, Thom knows magic.

Thom reappears, stepping out of the shadows of a moving pillar. He grins and says, "*Chamaeleon,*" before disappearing again. However, this time the shadows haven't swallowed him whole.

"He's gone invisible!" Ri'ta shouts from the box, jumping up from her seat to stand at the edge with C'yra.

"Thom is using illegal magic and therefore disqualified," C'yra announces. "This fight is over, and Catra will move on."

The fact that she's winning on a technicality doesn't sit well with Catra, but apparently Thom agrees. From somewhere in the arena, he calls out, "What are you talking about, I'm just getting started!"

"You heard her Thom," Catra growls. "It's over."

Suddenly, she feels the cold metal of a knife at her throat. She couldn't hear his footsteps on the dirt floor of the arena over the annoyed cries of the crowd. She stiffens as Thom leans down and whispers in her ear, "Come on now, you know you don't want to be over. She's just giving you a free pass into the next round because she *likes* you, for some reason."

Though Catra can't see him, she reaches back and grabs his shoulders, sinking her claws into flesh. The pain makes him drop the knife and he loses his concentration, causing him turn visible again. She turns around and pounces on him, scratching him across the face once before holding his shoulders down.

"Now it's over," Catra says, holding him still despite his struggling.

"I've got one last trick up my sleeve!" Thom claims.

"Is that the only thing you know how to say?!" Catra counters.

He unsheathes out his own claws and digs them into her forearm, saying, "*Canes Venatici!*"

Pain suddenly courses through her body, like the red lightning Shadow Weaver channeled, forcing her to let go of Thom. He crawls out from underneath her as the pain wrecks her body, not letting her stand up.

Thom draws his last knife and points it at her, "I've won. You won't be getting up after that."

"Please," Catra growls, grabbing her spear to stand upright. "I've felt worse. *Sagitta*."

She was hoping to save that spell for later in the Games, not wanting to reveal her trump card so soon, but she can't move. She raises her hand as three magical darts extend from her palm and hit Thom. He's knocked back to his feet just as Ri'ta makes her way onto the arena.

"That's enough!" she shouts and launches a spell at Thom. "*Reticulum!*"

His hands fly together and are bound by a glowing circle with a diamond shape centered at the diameter. No matter how he tugs on it, it doesn't break. As soon as they appear, the pain disappears and Catra can finally stand.

"As Queen C'yra said Thom, you are disqualified," Ri'ta says, turning to Thom. "Furthermore, you are under arrest for violating the sacred rules of the Jellicle Ball."

"Fuck," Thom whispers as soldiers come and grab his arms, dragging him away. The crowds cheer at that-as most of them have probably been at the receiving end of Thom's kleptomania-and Ri'ta puts a hand on Catra's shoulder, guiding her back to the barracks.

"Are you okay?" Ri'ta asks once they're away from the crowds.

"Yeah," Catra gulps. Seeing Thom do shadow magic, or whatever that was, shook her more than the pain spell. But she can shake it off. Afterall, like she said, she's felt worse. "Did you know Thom could do magic?"

"No, I didn't. I didn't know that there was anyone left who *knew* any blood magic," Ri'ta says with wide eyes. "If I had known . . . obviously I wouldn't have let him do that to you. I'm sorry that we let that happen. I should have done something

sooner when Thom first disappeared like that, I should have known he was using magic . . . Are you sure you're alright?"

"I am," Catra lies. "I can still fight."

"You're too much like your mother," Ri'ta shakes her head. She squeezes her shoulder, "But, you're doing great. You've made it to the third round."

"Because Thom cheated," Catra mutters.

"After that fight, I don't think anyone's going to think that you don't deserve to move on. Even if Thom wasn't cheating, you would have won," Ri'ta insists. "I've got to get back, but . . . you're going to make it to the end. I know it."

Catra sucks in a shaky breath, the weight of Ri'ta's and C'yra's expectations replacing the heavy shadows, "I will."

When Ri'ta leaves, Catra moves to the back of the barrack and sits down, trying to chase away the remaining shadows in her mind so she can focus on her next fight.

The Ball has begun in earnest.

For the most part, Glimmer isn't too interested in the battles. She would spend most of this time chatting with Bow and Adora . . . but she wasn't with them. She's stuck with the Queens of the Magicats.

C'yra invited her up to the Queen's box, explaining that back before the Invasion, foreign dignitaries would be invited to come observe the Ball. That would lead to diplomatic discussions and the like, but for now it just seems to be for tradition.

It's not that she doesn't like the Queens, she just thought that they didn't like her, and she would rather be with her friends.

C’yra stands up to introduce each fighter but has mostly been talking with Ri’ta. The two politely talk about the competitors, techniques, and prospects, which Glimmer isn’t really interested in. The only fight they both seemed to be very invested in is Catra’s fight with Garf, but it’s no surprise to Glimmer that she won easily.

As the last fight of the third bracket starts, Ri’ta leans over and asks, “How are you enjoying the fights so far?”

“They’re . . . interesting,” Glimmer lies.

Ri’ta smiles knowingly, “Not your cup of tea?”

“No,” Glimmer admits with a sigh. “It’s not like we have anything too diplomatic to discuss-” since she doubts she could convince the Queens to join the Princess Alliance here, especially with no Magicat Princess, “-and I still don’t fully understand this all.”

“It’s all about tradition,” Ri’ta shrugs. “The Ball, diplomatic guests, honoring Saz. I can’t say I’m tradition’s biggest advocate, but this is one I can’t help but enjoy. I suppose you’d have to be a Magicat to truly understand it.”

“Hhm,” Glimmer pauses, “But you said you grew up in Mystacor, right? So, you didn’t grow up with the Ball?”

“I didn’t,” Ri’ta says. “But we moved back to Purrsia when I was old enough to compete. I even won a couple times.”

“Those were the days,” C’yra leans back to join in, a nostalgic smile on her face. “It was you, me and Az’al at the end, every time. It’s been a long time since we had quite a competition like that.”

“Are you tooting your own horn?” Ri’ta teases, lightly slapping her arm.

"No!" C'yra insists. "But I included you in that sentiment if I was, so don't complain."

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asks.

"It's been a while since we've had at least three competitors who are equally matched in strength," C'yra says. "And the last time was when myself, Ri'ta and Az'al would compete, like I said. The past few years, there's always been one very strong competitor, but they would get over-powered by the other two in the finals. This year, however, I have a good feeling that the final fight will be on more equal footing. After all, we have competitors like Catra, Busto, Jerry, and even Demeter."

"Speaking of Jerry," Ri'ta taps C'yra's shoulder, "He won his fight."

"Ah right," C'yra stands up. "The winner of this fight is Jerry of Tom'an! And now our next competitors, Catra and Thom of M'Cavity!"

As Catra and Thom enter the arena, Ri'ta leans forward in her chair. She seems to be more interested in this fight than any of the others, including Jerry's.

"Let the fight begin!" C'yra announces. She quickly sits back down, observing the fight as intently as Ri'ta. They didn't seem to care during Thom's first fight, and Catra's fight was first so short she didn't notice, but they must have a deeper interest in Catra than Glimmer realized.

As soon as the fight begins, Thom runs away. Glimmer keeps her eyes on him, and watches as he steps behind a column. Her view of him is obstructed, but somehow, he ends up behind a wall a few feet behind the column.

"How did he do that?" Glimmer murmurs to herself.

"Do what?" Ri'ta questions, not taking her eyes off the fight.

"Nothing," Glimmer pushes it aside.

Thom tries to attack Catra, but she blocks it and quickly goes on the offensive. Thom doesn't seem to have a strategy other than hide and sneak attack. He ducks behind another wall and when it disappears, he's gone. Glimmer is already scanning across the arena and sees him on the other side.

"He's teleporting," Glimmer says, aloud this time.

"What?" C'yra asks, turning to her.

"Thom's teleporting," Glimmer says. "He just teleported across the arena."

"That's not possible," Ri'ta insists. "He doesn't know magic."

"How else could he get halfway across the arena without anyone seeing him?" Glimmer counters.

"He's good at sneaking around," C'yra says as she turns back to the fight. Her eyes go wide, "Oh shit he just used magic."

"What?!" Ri'ta stands up as Thom reappears from the shadows and casts another spell that causes him to go invisible. "He's gone invisible!"

"Thom is using illegal magic and therefore disqualified," C'yra announces. "This fight is over, and Catra will move on."

Apparently, Thom's not too happy about that, as he declares, "What are you talking about, I'm just getting started!"

He attacks Catra while invisible, and C'yra turns to Ri'ta, "Get down there and stop him!"

"Got it," Ri'ta gone in a flash, running out of the box and down to the arena.

C’yra grips the railings of the box, watching the fight with a scowl, “Fuck.”

“Catra will be alright,” Glimmer insists. She doesn’t understand why C’yra’s so worried. “She can handle some thug’s magic.”

“*Canes Venatici*!”

Oh, that looks painful.

Despite the pain, Catra manages to fire off a spell just as Ri’ta enters the arena. She casts a spell on him that blocks his magic, and the fight is over.

As Thom’s dragged away in handcuffs and Ri’ta guides Catra to the barracks. C’yra sits down from a moment, hand on her chin as she stares off into space.

“Uh, Queen C’yra?” Glimmer asks. “Don’t you need to announce the next fight?”

“Right,” C’yra sighs and stands to face the crowds. Her voice booms over the excited chatter, “Thom of M’Cavity will be facing judgement for his transgressions in this competition held in Saz’s honor. But we must continue as always. Our next competitors are Heath of Cl’ff and D’nah of Cori’pat!”

Ri’ta returns to the box and sits down next to C’yra, “Catra says that she’ll be fine to continue.”

“You’re sure?” C’yra checks, leaning in close to whisper. “I know she has an aversion to magic . . .”

Catra having an aversion to magic? Since when? Didn’t she just use a spell in her fight against Thom, and Adora said that she was learning magic with Ri’ta . . .

“She insists. She’s stubborn,” Ri’ta whispers, but then smirks. “Wonder where she gets that from?”

C’yra rolls her eyes and leans back, “If she insists on continuing, but she doesn’t have to. We’d be proud of her for trying either way.”

“Of course,” Ri’ta agrees.

Huh, maybe Catra’s closer to the Queens than Glimmer thought. But the Queens focus back on the fight again, and Glimmer decides to not pry for now.

ROUND TWO RESULTS

Winners of Bracket One: Catra, D'nah

Winners of Bracket Two: Busto, Gr'wliger

Winners of Bracket Three: Demeter, Jerry

“I knew it. I knew Jerry would kick my ass,” Sh’dowell bemoans as they lay down onto the bench next to Catra.

“There’s always next year,” Busto says, patting Sh’dowell’s back.

“I’ll be honest, it was kinda hot.”

Busto rolls his eyes and ignores them, “Well, Catra, it looks like you’re up next. You ready?”

“Of course,” Catra says. She’s been shrugging off her friend’s concerns, trying to focus on the next fight. Garf was easy to beat, Thom had his tricks up his sleeve, but D’nah . . . may be more of a challenge, especially since she’s feeling slightly fatigued from Thom’s last spell.

“One more fight to the finals,” Busto reminds her.

"I'll see you then," Catra says, as she moves towards the door. D'nah is already stepping out into the arena without, so she picks up her pace to catch up. "Hey! Aren't we supposed to walk in together, or whatever?"

"I'll choose whatever," Dn'ah huffs.

Ah, so they're picking up their bickering right where they left off. Catra would expect nothing less.

"Unless you're just eager to get out here to get your ass kicked," Catra shoots back.

"Please," D'nah scoffs. "You may have gotten by on a technicality last round, but not this time. You're not going any further."

"Hey, it's not my fault Thom decided to cheat," Catra argues. The fact that she got by on a technicality is bothering her too, but she's not going to let D'nah know that. "Now, are we going to fight or not?"

As soon as C'yra gives the word, D'nah is running at Catra with her broadsword raised. It almost reminds her of how She-Ra charges into battle with that gaudy Sword of Power. A sword as heavy as that takes effort and time to swing, and D'nah lacks She-Ra's pure strength to just wave it around. But she must be skilled with it to have made it this far so Catra doesn't underestimate her.

D'nah tries to bring the broadsword over her head, using its weight and gravity to her advantage, but Catra dodges it easily. She tries to strike her left side, but D'nah blocks it with the buckler strapped to her arm. D'nah sweeps low with her broadsword, but Catra flips back and decides to bring out the big guns.

"*Sagitta!*" Catra casts, and three darts shoot out of her hand. D'nah manages to block one with her shield, but the other two fly around and hit her in the sides. Catra uses her distraction

to run forward and uses the length of her spear to her advantage, avoiding the broadsword and striking her side. D'nah growls and grabs the spear, trying to pull Catra in closer while hitting her with her broadsword.

Instead of falling, Catra lets go of the spear and casts, "*Lepus!*" and leaps high above D'nah's head. She lands behind her and tries to claw her back, but she's wearing armor. D'nah twirls around, using the momentum to swing her sword. Catra ducks under it and dives to grab her spear out of D'nah's hands. She rolls out of the way before D'nah can hit her again, and the broadsword sinks into the dirt. Catra goes to attack again, but a wall quickly rises out of the ground and cuts the two off. She scales it instead, just as D'nah runs around.

"Where'd you go!?" D'nah hisses. She glances up just as Catra jumps down, trying to knock D'nah to her feet. Sadly, D'nah is much more muscular than her and only stumbles. Catra puts the tip of her spear to her neck as she regains her footing. D'nah knocks the spear away from her face with her buckler and steps back before jabbing her broadsword forward.

As Catra dodges, she realizes that she isn't going to get very far as long as D'nah is still well-armored. She-Ra only ever has the shield, leaving her toned arms and back vulnerable for attack. So, she puts her spear on her back and changes her tactics.

The next time D'nah tries to strike with her broadsword, Catra ducks underneath it and grabs onto D'nah's shield. She rips it off and tosses it across the arena like a frisbee. D'nah tries to punch her, but Catra dodges it.

"*Lepus!*" Catra jumps back up into the air to avoid D'nah's grasp, and lands squarely on her back. She only manages to undo one buckle on her armor before she's knocked off. Catra rolls onto her feet, prepared to launch into an attack.

"What do you think you're doing?" D'nah growls.

Catra jumps forward and scratches D'nah's unshielded arm, she bites down a yelp and tries to hit Catra with her broadsword, but Catra steps behind her to sink her claws into her right shoulder. D'nah elbows Catra hard in the stomach, causing her to stumble back. She turns and hisses, "Do you have to use your claws like some animal?!"

"Do you have to fight like a bitch?" Catra retorts. It's a low blow, but she's too focused on the battle to come up with a good one. She's now starting to do damage but would like to finish the fight. She lunges forward to scratch D'nah's face, but she stumbles back just in time.

Realizing that her broadsword isn't working in the tighter quarters Catra's forcing her in, D'nah drops her sword and tries to punch her. This, Catra can work with. She dodges D'nah's fist while deeply scratching the back of her hand, drawing lines of blood. D'nah then tries to tackle her, to wrap her arms around her waist to bring her down, but Catra's too fast for that and ducks down out of her grasp. Crouched on the ground, Catra kicks out one of D'nah's legs, causing her to fall. Catra rolls out of the way and jumps on her, wrapping a clawed hand around her throat, nails pressing into the skin with just enough pressure to not draw blood. The other hand pins D'nah's above her head so she can't move.

"Do you give up?" Catra growls.

"No," D'nah spits back. She tries to sit up, but Catra's claws press into her neck.

"Do you have a choice?" Catra counters with a grin.

D'nah glares at her, but it's clear what the outcome of this battle is, as the countdown passes and C'yra announces, "Catra is the winner of this battle!"

Catra quickly jumps off, letting D'nah sit up and cough. She looks despondent for a moment. Catra could rub it in, how

the Horde soldier has defeated her, but instead holds out her hand. D'nah scowls and stares at it, before finally accepting it. As Catra helps her up, she grumbles, "Next year, you won't be so lucky."

"It had nothing to do with luck," Catra insists. "But I look forward to our rematch."

As Catra comes out for her third match, Scorpio cheers. Of course she's going to cheer for her best friend, even if she's gotten to know Busto and Sh'dowell better.

"So, what do you think about this match?" Sea Hawk asks Gar'ett, who has been sitting with them. Adora and Bow are with them too, but they've been talking to the gray furred Magicat that sat in their row. "Her opponent looks tough."

"Catra can handle any opponent!" Scorpia argues. "She's bested She-Ra multiple times!"

"Wait, what?" this grabs Adora's attention, but Scorpia ignores her.

"And She-Ra's much bigger than that Magicat," Scorpia concludes.

"D'nah's one of the soldiers," Gar'ett says with a mouth full of popcorn. She keeps on disappearing between rounds, but Scorpia hasn't seen her leave. Whenever she looks back to her, she has a new food and will share it with her and the others. "I think she's supposed to be getting a promotion? I've heard them say she's going to be a lieutenant soon."

"She is!" the gray furred Magicat calls from the other end. Scorpia may have heard Bow call her Az'al? "She's one of my best soldiers, even if she has a bit of a temper. She'll give Catra a good challenge."

"Hhm," Adora studies D'nah as the fight starts. "She looks like a good soldier. But Scorpia's right, I think Catra's got this in the bag."

And that's what Adora said about Catra's last fight. And then Thom started using magic. Hopefully D'nah doesn't have any 'tricks up her sleeve', like the shadowy spells Thom wielded. But Scorpia shouldn't worry. Her wildcat is strong and can overcome anything thrown at her.

She watches the fight intently. Catra is faster than D'nah, but D'nah is stronger than her with the way she swings the broadsword around like it weighs nothing. They trade and dodge blows until Catra takes away D'nah's shield and unlatches her armor. It's at that moment that Scorpia knows Catra is going to win, since she's proved she's smarter than D'nah too.

When D'nah drops her broadsword to fight Catra with her fists, it's as good as over for her. Catra has D'nah pinned to the floor shortly with claws at her neck, and C'yra declares Catra the victor.

And Scorpia cheers, she probably cheers louder than anyone else in the arena for Catra. There's just one more around to go, and Scorpia knows that Catra's going to win.

ROUND THREE RESULTS

Winners of Bracket One: Catra

Winners of Bracket Two: Busto

Winners of Bracket Three: Demeter

"This is it," Busto sighs. "Good luck Catra."

"Good luck, Busto," Catra replies.

Demeter stares at the two of them, “What? Am I not going to get a ‘good luck’ too?”

“Why?” Catra snorts. “You think you’re gonna need it?”

“No,” Demeter huffs.

Busto puts a hand on Demeter’s shoulder, “Well, I don’t want you to feel left out, so good luck Demeter.” He turns to Catra, “Now you say it.”

“No,” Catra crosses her arms. “She said she didn’t want me to say.”

“Actually,” Demeter grins. “Now I kinda want to hear you say it.”

“You’re just being contrary!”

“Me? Contrary? Never. Or maybe I am.”

“Catra,” Busto gives her a stern look. She glares back at him, waiting for him to break, but he doesn’t.

“Fine,” Catra sighs. “Good luck Demeter.”

Demeter smiles victoriously, but says, “Good luck to you too, Catra.”

“Alright!” Az’al walks up to the three of them, the rest of the barracks have been cleared out as others were eliminated. They’ve probably gone up to sit in the arena to watch the final fight. “Are you all ready?”

“As ready as we’ll be,” Catra says with a shrug.

“Yes, let’s go!” Busto shouts and raises a fist in the air, but he’s clearly nervous.

“I’m good,” Demeter says.

"Then you can go ahead into the arena," Az'al says. "But first," she quickly hugs Demeter and lifts her off of her feet, "I'm so proud of you! You've made it so far!"

"MOM," Demeter says, trying to get out of Az'al's grasp, but the general is stronger than her. "THIS IS EMBARRASSING."

Az'al drops Demeter and she lands on her feet, "I'm not sorry. And Busto, you're the best second in command I've ever had and Catra you are an amazing fighter, but Demeter . . . kick their asses."

Demeter runs a hand down her face, "You are the absolute worst." She quickly runs ahead of Busto and Catra to get out of the barracks.

The three enter the arena to raucous applause. This is the moment that everyone has been waiting for.

"We arrive at the final fight of the Jellicle Ball," C'yra begins, as Catra, Busto and Demeter take their places across from each other in the arena, in the formation of a triangle. "Saz looks down favorably at the final three contestants that stand before you all. The winner of the first bracket, Catra! The winner of the second bracket, Captain Busto'fer of Bo'ots! And the winner of the third bracket, Demeter of Bom'luri! However, only one can be the Champion, the winter of the Jellicle Ball! Let the battle, begin!"

As soon as C'yra gives the word, Catra is sprinting towards Busto, and he's drawing his rapier and running at her as well. Demeter doesn't seem to be eager to join them, drawing her bow first and stepping behind a wall.

Catra and Busto meet with a clash of blades, his rapier pressing against her spear, He immediately pulls back and tries to slice her side, but she dodges. She's about to return to the attack, when she spots Demeter stepping out and releasing an arrow. She only has a second to dodge, and narrowly misses having the arrow lodge itself in her shoulder. Busto takes the advantage and

scratches her arm with the rapier, but she won't let him stay on the offensive for very long.

"*Lepus!*" she casts, and as she's lifted in the air, she slams her knee into Busto's jaw. She hears the clacking of teeth and him swearing under his breath. Demeter takes another shot at her while she's in the air, but she's falling before it can hit her. She tries to land on Busto, but he rolls out of the way.

Busto is instantly on his feet and unsheathes his second rapier. He ducks under one of Demeter's arrows before continuing his quick and brutal assault on Catra. She's forced to dodge both of his blades without time to get in an attack for herself. She finally spots her opening and causes him to trip, but he rolls onto his back and catches her spear by catching it between his crossed rapiers.

"This is fun," Busto grunts and somehow manages to smile as Catra bears her full weight down on him.

"Sure is," Catra growls back, but she's telling the truth. The only other person who is on her level is Adora and her annoying alter ego, it sure is nice to fight with who is her equal.

It would be nicer if Demeter stopped trying to turn her into a pin cushion.

One of Demeter's arrows grazing her nose causes her to back off Busto, who jumps to his feet and starts to attack. But Catra won't let him get the advantage again. She jabs her spear at one of his hands and knocks one of the swords out of his grip. Of course, he has a *third* rapier strapped to his back and he simply replaces it, and he won't be falling for that again.

As she rushes forward to strike Busto, she feints and casts, "*Sagitta*." Three magic darts fly towards Busto. He manages to dodge one, but the other two strike him on the back. He fumbles forward and Catra smacks him in the chin with the dull end of her spear.

"Can you please stop trying to ruin my beautiful smile!" Busto bickers, blood trickling down his lip from where he bit it, but Catra doesn't reply. She's about to put her spear through his shoulder, finally gaining the advantage against him-

When an arrow rips through her knee.

She gasps as she lands roughly on the wounded knee, arrow still stuck in it. She only has enough time to glance over her shoulder and see Demeter drawing her twin blades before she has to bring her spear up to block Busto's next attack. She forces herself to roll back, narrowly avoiding Busto nicking her, ignoring the pain shooting up her leg. She tries to stand up but finds herself leaning heavily on her good leg.

Demeter attacks her first, and Catra barely knocks away both blades with her spear. Then comes Busto, forcing her to jump back and put more pressure on her bad leg. She bites on her lip to avoid crying out in pain, not wanting to show any weakness. If she can't get in a physical attack, she can try to get in another magical one, "*Sagitta!*"

Two darts target Demeter, while the third flies towards Busto. Both hit Demeter, but Busto dodges his to attack Catra. She knocks away the first strike, but the second slashes across her chest.

Demeter moves to her other side, and they've both got her surrounded. She's getting tired, the three battles that preceded this are weighing on her. She must come up with a strategy, and fast since she can't face both on her own. Maybe she can buy herself some time with the shield spell . . . despite it never working for her before . . . .

As Demeter moves forward for another attack, Catra doesn't spare a another thought and crosses her arms to cast, "*Scutum!*"

She tastes steel and blood as the spell fails and Demeter knock her with the blunt end of her sword before slashing her arm. The wound is deep and causes her to drop her spear. Catra is knocked back, and she manages to roll into a crouching position despite the pain shooting through her knee.

In a last-ditch effort, Catra unsheathes her claws and launches at Demeter, despite the protesting pain in her leg. If she's going out, she's going out swinging. She rakes her claws across Demeter's chest, cutting through the leather armor. When Busto tries to attack, she kicks him in the stomach with her good leg, her bad leg nearly buckling at her full body weight. Demeter counters with a jab in her stomach, and then Busto tackles her.

She feels the wind knocked out of her as she lands hard on her back, Busto's full weight on her (damn, why is he heavy). Busto only manages to keep a rapier at her throat for a second, since Demeter dropped her swords to pull out her bow. She has an arrow drawn and pointed at his head, forcing him to roll off Catra to dodge.

Without Busto's weight on her, Catra tries to force herself to stand again. Demeter knocks an arrow and shoots it at Catra. The arrow pierces her shoulder and forces her down, a warning to stop now. Demeter walks away from Catra as she starts to rapidly fire arrows at Busto, who is running and hiding behind the moving walls and column to avoid getting hit.

Catra doesn't want to go out. Not like this. Even though she's being turned into a pin cushion by Demeter. Even though Busto may have broken a rib by sitting on her chest. It's starting to hurt to breathe, but Catra's not out yet. She has felt worse. That's the mantra she replays in her head as she continues to fight.

She rips the arrow out of her shoulder and rolls over, trying to push herself off the ground. As she stands, she watches Busto throw his second rapier, it clatters against the ground elsewhere. Demeter's distracted by it, and Catra takes the

opportunity to toss herself and wrap her arms around Demeter's leg, causing her to lose balance and fall. Of course, she falls *on* Catra, and that hurts. Maybe another rib got cracked. Who knows. She pushes Demeter off her and scrambles to get on top to put her claws at her throat. Demeter has the same idea, pulls out a sharp arrowhead and pokes it into her chin, nearly piercing the skin.

The two are stuck breathing heavily, at a stalemate. But they're not alone. Busto runs out from his hiding space, and he has a choice. He can attack Demeter, or he can attack Catra. And he wants to win.

So Catra's not surprised when Busto pressed the cold steel of his rapier against her throat. She closes her eyes and counts to ten. Before C'yra can announce it, Catra says it, "I surrender."

Busto and Demeter pull away their weapons, letting her step away before resuming the fight against each other. She trudges back to the barrack, dragging her bad leg as the adrenaline retreats and the pain starts to get to her.

She lost.

Adora watches as Catra surrenders in shock. She's never known Catra to surrender to anyone or anything, no matter the stakes. But the Ball is more brutal than the Rebellion ever could be, the Magicat ferocity and tenacity coming through. Busto and Demeter continue the fight, but it's clear who the winner will be.

"I'm going to find Catra," Adora says, and gets up before Bow or anyone else can say anything.

The caves of Half Moon are still confusing to Adora, but she finds the entrance to the barracks outside the arena with ease. Standing outside the closed doors are two soldiers, and she quickly approaches them, "Hey, I need to get in and see Catra."

The two soldiers share a look, and the first says, "Only soldiers and competitors are allowed in the barracks. No outsiders allowed."

"I really need to see her," Adora stresses. She can only guess what Catra's feeling right now, probably something like how she would react after Adora would beat her in training exercises back in the Horde. She wants to be there for her.

"General's orders," the second soldier says, and that seems to be that.

Adora briefly considers just beating them up, but the doors push open and a brown-haired Magicat leaves the barracks, dressed in the soldier's garb. Adora recognizes her as D'nah, the Magicat she beat to make it into the finals.

"D'nah," the first soldier asks. "How's the fight going?"

"Catra got knocked out, Busto's about to kick Demeter's ass," D'nah says as she pulls out a small box from her pocket and grabs a small cylindrical stick from it. "It's about time Busto won. Now, either of you got a light?"

The second soldier pulls out a match, strikes it against the wall, and lights the strange stick on fire. D'nah puts it to her mouth, breathes in, and breathes smoke out as the second soldier sighs, "Wish we could have seen it."

"Then you two should stop being late to training," D'nah argues. She glances at Adora and scowls, "What are you doin' here?"

"I need to see Catra," Adora tries with D'nah.

"She's in the infirmary with Shire," D'nah says. "And no outsider is gonna enter the barracks."

"Please," Adora begs. "I . . . just need to know if she's alright. Well, obviously she's not alright physically but-"

D’nah stops her by blowing a puff of foul-smelling smoke in her face. As Adora coughs, D’nah says, “She’ll just have to deal with defeat like the rest of us. But she should be proud, she put up a good fight. That’s probably been the best fight I’ve seen in years. Now, don’t worry your pretty little furless head off.”

Adora frowns, but realizes she isn’t getting by without some help from She-Ra. So, she finally steps back.

“Alright,” D’nah turns to the soldiers. “I’ve got to get going before Cr’sanks finds me.”

The first soldier grins, “She’s trying to get you in a dress again for the dance, isn’t she?”

D’nah scowls, “Yeah. And she’ll then get on my case about smoking. She’s just my damn cousin, and I’m a fucking adult.”

“Well, at least you know she cares,” the second one teases. “See you later, D’nah.”

As D’nah walks away, Adora makes herself comfortable by leaning against the wall across from the door. She waits and hears the echoing roar of the crowds as the fight finishes. Magicats pour out of the arena after that, and as they pass by Adora can hear them talk about the fights and how they’re looking forward to the Ball. Still no sign of Catra.

Her friends find her, Bow, Glimmer, and Scorpia are accompanied by Sh’dowell, who joined them after their fight.

“Any sign of Catra?” Bow asks.

“No,” Adora shakes her head. As she says that, the doors to the barracks open and Catra walks out. She looks good despite all her injuries and walks without limping, but her head hangs low. Adora steps forward, “Catra!”

“Oh,” Catra looks up. She grabs her own arm and rubs it awkwardly, “Why were you guys waiting for me?”

“We wanted to make sure you were okay,” Adora says.

“Yeah. Well. Shire healed my wounds,” Catra says.

“I mean like, are you really okay?” Adora repeats. Catra should know what she means.

Catra only glances away, as Sh’dowell and Scorpia come up to her side. The latter says, “You did really great wildcat! Can I hug you, or will that hurt?”

“Shire said my ribs will still be a bit bruised,” Catra says with a shrug. “Maybe later.”

“Your fight with Busto and Demeter was really cool!” Sh’dowell says. Out of all of them, they’re the only one that seem to be in good spirits. “Next year, I hope we get a chance to fight! I mean, you’ll probably kick my ass, but at least it’ll be fun!”

Catra doesn’t reply, just grips her arm and glances at the ground.

“Catra,” an ancient looking Magicat hobbles up to them, but he barely leans on his cane. He looks over the rims of his small glasses and says, "You did very well today, congratulations."

Catra looks at her feet, "Yeah well, thanks Deut’ron, but I only got third place."

"You made it within the top three, that's very good," Deut’ron insists. "But, enough from me. The Queens wish to speak with you."

"What do they want from Catra?" Adora questions, standing up straighter. Why would the Queens want to speak with Catra after she lost? The only reason Adora can think is shrouded with shadows.

"I believe they just want to congratulate her as well," Deut’ron says. Adora doesn’t believe this old fool for a second.

"I'll catch up with you guys at the dance," Catra says, before Adora can stop her, and walks away. Adora watches her go, though she wants to run after her.

“Ah, and you must be the Etherians,” Deut’ron holds out his hand. “I don’t believe we’ve met, I am Deut’ron of Salem, Cleric to Saz and advisor to the Queens.”

“It’s . . . a pleasure to meet you,” Glimmer steps around Adora to shake his hand. “I’m Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon.”

“Deut’ron,” Adora interrupts. “Why do the Queens want to talk with Catra? Tell me the truth.”

“I did not lie,” Deut’ron shrugs. “They just wish to congratulate her. This was her first time competing and, of course, she did very well.”

“But she lost,” Adora stresses.

“Third place isn’t losing,” Deut’ron argues. “Do not worry. The Queens are kinder than you think. Now, you young’uns should get ready for the dance.”

Deut’ron walks away, but his words have done nothing to temper Adora’s nerves. She looks back down the hallway Catra walked down. For the first time in a long time, Adora feels powerless.

Chapter End Notes

Alright, first thing's first: I want to talk about power-leveling. I play a lot of DND, so I want to frame this in terms of classes. Busto's a fighter, Gr'wliger's a ranger, Sh'dowell's a rogue, Thom's a bastard, so on and so forth. Catra, however,

is a monk with multi-classes in ranger and wizard. At this time, she only has one level of wizard, which is why she doesn't know a lot of spells. I just wanted to share my thought process about that with you all.

Next, I felt that it was important for Catra to lose during the Ball, for the progression of her character arc in this fic. You'll see more of it in the next chapter (*cough when i write it cough*), but I hope I made it worked. Combat's not my forte, but I definitely got practice in with this chapter.

As for the *next* chapter, I can't promise any consistent release schedule. The winter semester starts tomorrow, but at least I'm done with jaw shenanigans. All I can promise is that I'll do my best to write a little every day. Thank-you all for your patience and support, and if you'd like to help me you can leave a comment! Your support does wonders for my inspiration and I appreciate every one!

Finally, if you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. I post most of my fic updates on Twitter, but you'll then have the unfortunate side effect of hearing me talk about the Muppets.

I hope you all have a good day and I'll see you next time!

when i was a child i stayed wide awake climbed to the highest place of every firescape restless to climb

Chapter Summary

Catra faces C'yra and Ri'ta after the Ball.

Chapter Notes

HAHAHA I'm back already!!! Who would have guessed it? Not me. But, I think you can tell how much I struggled with the combat in the last chapter by how much I've written for this fic since then. So, for now, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s silent in the infirmary, the only sound being the faded noise of the crowds from the arena. Slowly, Shire is cleaning and patching Catra’s wounds. Usually, Shire would be complaining about how Catra should be more careful. Usually, Catra would bicker back and tell her that it’s her job to care for injuries. Neither of them talks.

“I was able to catch a little of your fights,” Shire finally says. “You were really good.”

Catra sighs and stares at the wall.

“And I bet you did really well in the final round too. I was still patching Jerry up and wasn’t able to catch it.”

“. . .”

“I’ll have to tell Demeter to stop aiming for the knees. They’re a pain in the ass to clean up and we have to make sure that it heals right. I don’t want it hindering you in the future.”

“. . .”

“But I’ll get to that next though. I can’t say it was the smartest decision to rip the arrow out of your shoulder, I’m surprised that it’s so clean though.”

“. . .”

“Let me know if anything I’m doing hurts.”

“. . . Shire?”

“Yeah?” Shire pauses her work to look up at Catra. “Is it the alcohol? I know the it stings but I need to clean the wound.”

“No,” Catra shakes her head. “. . . You can use magic.”

Shire stares at her, “Oh Saz, you have a concussion. You must have hit your head on the ground at some point-”

“No, I’m serious,” Catra grabs her hand before she can get up. “I figure I’ve just experienced the worst spell a Magicat can do . . . your healing spells can’t be any worse.”

She studies Catra, trying to make sure she’s being serious (and doesn’t actually have a concussion), “If you’re sure . . . I’ll only use magic on your shoulder and knee, those are the worst injuries. Everything else can be healed with medicine and time. And if at any point you want me to stop, just say it, alright?”

Catra nods and closes her eyes, bracing herself. Shire lays a hand on her shoulder, over the arrow wound, and mutters a spell under her breath. Catra tenses up instinctually, but a warm, pleasant feeling spreads through her shoulder. It lingers even after Shire removes her hand.

“Huh,” Catra opens her eyes and rolls her shoulder. There’s no pain, “That’s not as bad as I thought it would be.”

“Good,” Shire sighs. “Now, I’ll get your leg.”

She starts by removing the arrow, the pain of the removal quickly replaced by the warmth of the healing spell. There's no trace of a wound ever being there, and Catra's able to stand up without stumbling.

"Hold on," Shire pushes Catra back down into her seat. "I'm not done."

"I feel fine now," Catra insists.

"I still think you have a concussion."

Catra sighs but remains still as Shire bandages her remaining wounds and checks her ribs. She winces as the healer's hands run over her stomach.

"Alright, your ribs are probably fractured too, not broken. I can heal them with magic, if you want, but you still should be careful and avoid combat for at least a week," Shire says.

"I can do that," Catra says. "Go ahead and heal them."

As the warmth of the healing spell spreads over her chest, a soldier knocks on the door and pokes their head in, "Sorry to interrupt, Ms. Shire, but the Ball is over, and Demeter and Busto will be in soon."

Catra stiffens, thoughts trailing back to her failure again.

"Who won?" Shire asks as she stands up

"Busto," the soldier says. "But both are looking pretty bad."

Ah, at least he won. She can feel relief from that, since he's her friend and now she doesn't have to deal with Demeter gloating for weeks about her win.

"You're free to go Catra, I have to clean up," Shire says. "Unless you want to stick around to see Busto."

"I'm good," Catra says. She's happy for Busto, she's truly surprised that she's happy for him, but she doesn't want to have her loss rubbed into her face. "But . . . tell Busto that I said, 'good job'."

"Got it," Shire nods.

Catra quickly makes her way out of the infirmary, her defeat returning to the forefront of her mind. If she didn't get hit with Demeter's arrow, she probably could have won. She should have paid more attention; she should have been faster. And now . . . and now the Queens will be disappointed in her. Catra doesn't know how she can face them . . .

"Catra!"

She was so lost in her thoughts, that she didn't even notice that she had wandered out of the barracks. Sh'dowell, Scorpia and the Princess Alliance are all there, Adora at the forefront.

"Oh," Catra grabs her own arm and rubs it awkwardly, "Why were you guys waiting for me?"

"We wanted to make sure you were okay," Adora says.

"Yeah. Well. Shire healed my wounds," Catra says.

"I mean like, are you really okay?" Adora repeats.

Catra glances away. Does she think she's going to lash out like she did in the Horde? Stuck in the shadow of the golden child?

Thankfully, Sh'dowell and Scorpia are there to distract her from that thought. The latter says, "You did really great wildcat! Can I hug you, or will that hurt?"

"Shire said my ribs will still be a bit bruised," Catra says with a shrug. "Maybe later."

“Your fight with Busto and Demeter was really cool!” Sh’dowell says, happier than Catra would expect from someone who was bemoaning about their loss an hour earlier. “Next year, I hope we get a chance to fight! I mean, you’ll probably kick my ass, but at least it’ll be fun!”

Catra doesn’t reply, just grips her arm and glances at the ground. She supposes there’s always a chance to try and win next year . . . but she lost this time. When the Queens specifically asked her to compete, to prove herself this year.

"Catra," she turns around just in time to see Deut’ron walk up to her. "You did very well today, congratulations."

Catra looks at her feet, "Yeah well, thanks Deut’ron, but I only got third place."

"You made it within the top three, that's very good," Deut’ron insists. "But, enough from me. The Queens wish to speak with you."

"What do they want from Catra?" Adora questions. There's an edge in her voice, Catra’s heard it before when they were kids and Adora would try to protect her from Shadow Weaver. It never worked then and it won't work now.

"I believe they just want to congratulate her as well," Deut’ron says. Catra knows that's a lie. She got third place. She lost. She disappointed her moms. May as well face this with her head held high.

"I'll catch up with you guys at the dance," Catra says, before making her way to the Queens' box, overlooking the arena.

Catra takes her time going there, trying to mentally prepare herself on the way. She gets to the door, takes a deep breath, and opens it up.

And Catra is suddenly attacked. With a hug.

C'yra wraps her arms around Catra's waist and lifts her off the floor. Catra's brain does not compute, and she goes slightly limp as C'yra squeezes her, giving her a hug that rivals Scorpia's, and says, "Catra, you were amazing! I'm so proud of you!"

Catra gets set down and her brain is running a marathon just trying to catch-up, "Wa-"

Ri'ta steps in as soon as C'yra's done and gives her a hug that's not as tight but just as satisfying, "You did such a good job, Catra!"

Ri'ta lets go and her moms stand in front of her with huge grins on their faces. Catra wonders if this is some cruel joke. She manages to stutter, "Bu-but I came in third place. I lost."

"You may have lost a battle, but you still came within the top three. You got all the way to the final fight!" C'yra points out, her eye twinkling with something. Catra can't tell if it's because of this cruel joke . . . or something Catra's never seen before. C'yra places a hand on Catra's shoulder, "First years rarely ever make it that far. During my first Jellicle Ball, I got my ass kicked by a soldier five years my senior in the first round. You were very impressive!"

"But it's not good enough!" Catra insists. She's so confused. She's so sick of this mind game. "I know that! You two know that! Third place is a far cry from first! I'm just a failure, like everyone has been telling me my whole life!"

Catra closes her eyes, ready for the floodgate to break open and the words of disappointment to wash through. However, it doesn't come. Catra peaks an eye open and sees her moms looking at her with wide and shocked eyes.

Ri'ta steps forward reaching out to Catra, but pauses, "Catra, we . . . we don't think that. We'll never think that you're a disappointment. We'll always be proud of you, we already are so proud of you, no matter what you do."

Catra looks between her moms, mouth gaping as she tries to form her disbelief into words, "Why?"

"You've been through so much, yet you're so strong," C'yra says.

"I know you don't talk much about the Horde, but . . . I know it was the worst and yet you survived," Ri'ta says. "And you've flourished in Half Moon, even though everyone isn't your . . . biggest fan. You've survived so much, what is there not to be proud of?"

"You've made much growth in Half Moon, we have been keeping a close eye on you, being your mothers and all," C'yra continues. "You've become a better person. Wanting to make a change in yourself and actually making that change are two different things and vary in difficulty, but you're accomplishing the latter. And there's so many more reasons why we're proud of you."

"And always will be," Ri'ta adds with a small smile.

Catra stares at her moms and tries to will the tears that have started to form away. She lunches forward, throwing an arm around each of her mother's necks and bringing them close. They hug again, this time softer and drawing her close.

Catra's tears turn into sobs, as relief washes over her. Her moms are proud of her. That's probably the first time . . . anyone has said that to her.

Ri'ta pats her head while C'yra rubs small circles into her back. Catra doesn't quite want to let go just yet, wanting to stay in her mothers's embraces and feel accepted and loved.

Catra manages to pry herself and chokes down her tears for a second to mumble, "I love you two."

“We love you too, Catra,” Ri’ta says, and she hears C’yra starting to sniffle. “C’yra, are you okay?”

"Yeah," C'yra says, starting to cry as much as Catra. "Just . . . got something in my eye."

"You two are going to make me cry now," Ri'ta says, her voice starting to break up.

Catra laughs, "Yeah Mom, don't make Mom cry."

C'yra and Ri'ta both stare at her for a moment. This must have been the first time she called them 'mom' out loud, despite thinking it in her head for a long time. Then, they both start to cry and hug her again.

"It's not that big of a deal!" Catra complains, her own tears starting to dry.

"Yes, it is, this is the first time you called us 'mom'!" C'yra insists.

"But I'm still not going to say it in public, yet," Catra reminds them. "Because the whole . . . princess thing."

"That's fair," Ri'ta says.

Once they all calm down, her moms have one more surprise left for her.

"We also got you a gift," Ri'ta says, pulling a small box out of her pocket.

"You didn't have to," Catra says as Ri'ta shoves the box into her hands.

"It's tradition to give a Magicat a gift the first time they compete in the Jellicle Ball," C'yra insists. "Whether they make it all the way to the end or get knocked on their ass in the first round."

Catra finally opens in it, and inside is a small golden brooch shaped like a flame with an orange gemstone that has a

kaleidoscope of red, green, and yellow when shined in the light.

"We tried to think of something practical," Ri'ta continues. "So, you can use that to hold your hunter's cloak together. It should also go with that tuxedo you were telling us about."

"I love it," Catra insists. "What's the gem inside?"

"It's called a fire opal," C'yra says. ". . . It's also the royal gemstone of Purrsia."

"Subtle, guys," Catra rolls her eyes. "But I'll still wear it. Thank-you."

"We're glad you liked it," Ri'ta smiles. "You don't know how long we spent trying to come up with something. Now, we should all get ready for the party."

Catra nods, and her eyes go wide as she suddenly remembers, "Shit, I forgot to pick up my tux from Gr'wliger's dad."

"Don't worry," C'yra laughs. "A lot of the competitors forget. You should go now."

"Right!" Catra closes the box, shoves in into her pocket, and runs out of the room. She almost crashes into Gr'wliger and Adora, who are right outside the door. "Shit! What are you two doing here?"

"Someone was worried," Gr'wliger says, nodding to Adora. He holds out a box and says, "And my father is having me and my siblings' running deliveries. Here is your tuxedo."

"Thank Saz, I was just on my way to get it," Catra sighs. "Thanks Gr'wliger, but is your dad *really* making you run deliveries right after you competed?"

"He said that if I could walk, I could do deliveries," he sighs. "But, Shire healed most of my wounds so I'm not

complaining."

"Catra," Adora cuts in. "What happened with the Queens? Is everything alright?"

As Catra opens her mouth to answer, C'yra and Ri'ta leave the room, arm-in-arm and both smiling. The latter says, "I see you didn't have to go far to get your tuxedo. Gr'wliger, is B'nks forcing you to run deliveries?"

"If you want to get out of it, you can tell him that the Queens said to give the competitors a break," C'yra offers.

"I don't mind helping out the family business," Gr'wliger insists. "So I must get back."

"You're a good kid, Gr'wliger," C'yra says. As he leaves, C'yra turns to Adora, "Hello Adora, what are you doing here?"

"I . . . was looking for Catra," Adora says, shocked by the good mood of the Queens.

"Hope we didn't keep you from her for too long," Ri'ta says. She nudges Catra's back with her free elbow, and Catra has to hold back a warning growl. For this, she doesn't want a push. "But, you two better get ready. The dance is going to start soon."

"We'll see you there, Catra," C'yra adds, and the Queens depart. Catra has a half a mind to run after them, to avoid this confrontation with Adora.

"So . . . what did they want?" Adora asks.

"Just what Deut'ron said. They wanted to congratulate me," Catra insists. She sighs and runs a hand down her face, "You don't have to worry about them, Adora."

"But . . . you look like you didn't want to see them," Adora says. "Like . . . you were afraid."

"I shouldn't have been. They were proud of me," Catra says. She almost feels like she's boasting. Adora was once in the favor of Shadow Weaver, but now she has *two* people who care about her and are *proud* of her, who love her unconditionally. Shadow Weaver could never do that, for either of them.

"Oh. That's good," Adora says, starting to cheer up. There's something that twists inside Catra when she sees Adora smile, something ugly. Something that makes her want to draw her claws.

"I don't know why you care," Catra continues. "You don't need to try and be a hero here, in all places. When I don't need you to try and protect me. But where was that gusto back in the Horde? With Shadow Weaver?"

"Catra . . ." Adora says, trying to reach out for her. Catra steps back.

She wants to twist her claws into the wound, to make it hurt. But, this isn't who she wants to be. She doesn't want to make others hurt just because she hurt anymore. So, Catra walks away and leaves Adora in the hallway. Here, in Half Moon, she's a different person. A better person. And she doesn't need Adora anymore, no matter what her heart is telling her.

Chapter End Notes

So, the plan right now is to stagger chapters of fic with my other new one, 'Sad Song' (which you should go and read if you like genshin impact or old musicals) until I run out of backlog to give myself time to write new chapters while school starts to pick up. In the meantime, if you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Finally, I appreciate every

comment you guys leave me even if I suck at replying to them, so consider leaving a comment! Have a good day!

i’ve been afraid of changin’ ‘cause i’ve built my life around you but time makes you bolder even children get older and i’m getting older too

Chapter Summary

It's time for the dance after the Jellicle Ball! Will Catra finally talk to Adora? Does Carta *actually* know how to dance?

Chapter Notes

Not much to say up at the top other than thank-you all for your support and comments as I continue to write this fic, and I hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

All of the stalls in the market have been taken away, leaving an open dance floor for the finale of the Jellicle Ball. Along the sides of the room are tables of food, Jen’dots in the thick of it, bossing the chefs around. Floating above all their heads are glowing lanterns, warmly lighting the whole room.

By the time Catra walks in, there are Magicats already dancing. When she first heard there was going to be a dance, she imagined the slow dances of Princess Prom accompanied by light, poppy music. However, the music here is high energy, the drums set a fast beat while horns blare the tune. The music lends itself to the high-energy dancing with twisting feet and swinging bodies.

Gr’wliger arrives at the same time as her, dressed in a sharp dark-green suit and hair pulled back into a short ponytail, “Hello Catra. You look good.”

“Well, it's thanks to your dad,” Catra’s tuxedo is white with a red shirt and embroidery. She didn’t bother with the tie but

is wearing the brooch her mothers gave her on the lapel her jacket. “You look good too. Anyways, no one told me Magicat dancing was like *this*.”

“What do you mean?” Gr’wliger asks.

Before the Ball, multiple people asked her if she knew how to dance. She got to roll her eyes and say ‘of *course* I know how to dance’ because Scorpia taught her before Princess Prom. But she didn’t expect this, “Fast. Fun.”

“How . . . else would you dance?” Gr’wliger says.

“Slow. Fancy. *Boring*,” Catra sighs. “That’s how they danced at Princess Prom.”

“Well, this style of dancing is called ‘swing’,” Gr’wliger explains. “And I believe you’ll catch on quickly. But that reminds me, Lily said that he wanted to-”

“Caatraaaaa!” Lily shouts as he runs into the room. He’s wearing a suit identical to Gr’wliger’s and holds out his hand. “-May I have this dance?”

Gr’wliger sighs, “-Dance with you.” He leans over Lily’s head and whispers, “You can say no.”

“I heard that!”

“It’s fine,” Catra laughs. She takes his hand, “You’ll have to teach me how to dance, though.”

Lily puffs his chest out, “I’ll be the best teacher!”

As Catra finds out, Lily doesn’t know how to dance either. He does his best to mimic other dancers, but just ends up wiggling. Somehow though, she thinks she starts to get the hang of it.

The song ends and the music stills as Az'al steps onto the stage. Everyone quiets and turns to her, "Presenting the Queens of the United Tribes of Purrsia, their Majesties, C'yra of D'riluth the Third and Ri'ta of M'stoff'lls!"

C'yra and Ri'ta enter together, hand in hand. C'yra is wearing a fancier version of her purple uniform along with a white cape hanging from one shoulder. It's strange to see Ri'ta in a color other than blue, but she looks beautiful in a purple evening gown that matches C'yra.

"Now that we are done celebrating Saz," C'yra says. "Let us revel in Lyses' life!"

The crowds cheer and Catra can't help but join in. She still finds the three deities ridiculous, but the joy is infectious.

Catra excuses herself for the next dance, and Lily wanders off to find his friends. She just wants to say hello to her moms but approaches the Queens at the same time as Glimmer and Bow. Glimmer bows to them and says, "Queen C'yra. Queen Ri'ta, it is an honor to be here."

"Stand up Glimmer," C'yra says with a laugh. "This isn't Princess Prom."

"Oh," Glimmer blinks.

"Yeah, Princess Prom sucks," Catra says, gesturing to the dancing behind her. "This is already much more fun."

"Catra," Ri'ta says. "How do you know about Princess Prom?"

"I was Scorpia's date," Catra says.

"And you kidnapped me," Glimmer growls.

"Let's not worry about that," Catra tries to push it aside. Her moms just said that they were proud of her, she doesn't want

to ruin that already. “Anyways, you two didn’t tell me that Magicat dancing was like this.”

“Saz, were you only taught stuffy Etherian dances?” C’yra asks.

“They’re traditional dances,” Glimmer says.

“It is kinda stuffy,” Bow argues.

“I showed up to my first Princess Prom not knowing how to do it and was so confused,” C’yra sighs. “And the music sucked.”

Catra laughs as Glimmer frowns. Ri’ta rolls her eyes, “But we had fun at your second Princess Prom.”

“That’s because we spent most of our time making out in the supply closet of Salineas-” C’yra says.

“Alright!” Catra interrupts. “I’ve heard enough!”

“Sorry Catra,” Ri’ta laughs as C’yra goes red. “Oh, you’re wearing the brooch.”

“Of course,” Catra stands up straighter. “It was a gift, and I’ve been told I have to like gifts,” Catra pauses, “But I really do like it.”

“Good,” Ri’ta smiles.

“Oh hey,” C’yra taps Ri’ta’s shoulder. “This is our song.”

“You’ll have to excuse us,” Ri’ta says, sharing C’yra’s smile as she nods to Catra, as well as Bow and Glimmer. Catra honestly forget that they were there.

“See you around,” Catra says as the two depart to the dance floor.

"What was that all about?" Glimmer asks, staring at Catra with narrowed eyes.

"They like me," Catra shrugs, trying to play it off. "And . . . about that whole kidnapping thing . . ."

"Yes?" Glimmer raises an eyebrow.

"I'm . . ." this is more painful than Catra realized, but she has to do it. She has to take another step forward. "I'm sorry. For all the stuff . . . that I did to you two."

"Oh," Glimmer's eyes go wide. She really wasn't expecting that.

"Apology accepted, Catra," Bow says. "Aw, you're really growing!"

"But," Catra continues. "I still don't like you, Shimmer."

"That's expected," Glimmer sighs.

"Now that I got that over with," Catra sighs. "Have you two seen Busto?"

"No," Bow shakes his head. "And we were just going to ask you if you had seen Adora. We haven't seen her since she went with Gr'wliger to deliver your suit."

Oh, that's not good. But, it's not Catra's problem, "Yeah, but I left when I got my suit. How about I look for Busto and you two go look for Adora?"

They split up then, and Catra focuses on her goal. She scans the crowds not dancing and spots Busto near one of the tables of food and surrounded by Magicats she doesn't recognize

"Excuse me!" Catra forces herself through the group and grabs Busto's arm. "I've got to borrow him for a while."

"Catra!" Busto says as she pulls him away. He's his official soldier uniform, with a red sash around his chest to denote his victory in the Jellicle Ball. "I was looking for you!"

"Didn't look like you were looking too hard," Catra teases.

"I got . . . held up," Busto admits. "I went to grab a bite to eat and suddenly I was surrounded. I didn't know that so many people were attracted to sashes. But anyways . . . you did a good job at the Ball. You were a tough opponent."

"Thanks," Catra says. "Congratulations on winning, by the way. You deserve it."

Busto blinks, "You aren't . . . mad?"

"Why would I be?" Catra counters. "I was more disappointed in myself, than anything else and you did what you had to do to win."

"I know that feeling well," Busto sighs. "But you'll find that the only people who care about placement are those competing in the Ball themselves. Everyone else just cares if you put up a good fight or not. And our fight," he pauses to raise his fist in the air and strike a pose, "Was amazing!"

"Right," Catra laughs. "And next year, I'm going to get you."

"I'd like to see you try!" Busto laughs.

"Anyways, I've got to be honest with you: I don't know how to swing dance," Catra says as she watches the dancers. "My first dance partner was a little short so I was wondering if you could . . ." she glances at the entrance and catches Adora entering the room, wearing a red dress similar to the one she wore at Princess Prom. Their eyes meet, and for some reason, Catra doesn't look away.

"Uh . . . Etheria to Catra?" Busto snaps his fingers in front of her face. "Were you going to ask me to teach you how to dance? Because if so, I would love to! I am as well trained in dance as I am in combat, so you have come to the right person!"

Catra turns away from Adora, who has started to approach her. Time to get on the floor before another painful conversation can happen, "Good. Then let's get start-"

"Catra," Adora says. Too late. "You look . . . amazing."

She face face Adora, and she must admit: Adora looks beautiful as well. Catra doesn't know where she got this dress, since the only person she told about the dance's dress requirements to was Scorpia, but it looks amazing on her.

"Hey Adora," Catra says.

"I . . . I was thinking about what you said early," Adora begins.

"Earlier?" Busto asks, peeking around Catra's shoulder.

Catra pushes him back and sighs, "Yeah . . . sorry for snapping at you." Wow, two apologies in one day. She better not be making a habit of it.

"Actually . . ." Adora glances away, wringing her hands. "You may be right-"

Oh shit, is it finally happening. Is Adora, the golden child, going to admit she was wrong? Is she going to fucking apologize?

"What's going on here?" Demeter approaches the three of them, she's wearing an elegant green dress tonight, and Catra wants to punch her in the face. "Oh, hey Catra, you put up a good fight."

"So did you," Catra crosses her arms and glares at Demeter. "But next year, if we fight, the first thing I'm doing is

snapping your bow in half."

"You'll have to catch me first," Demeter shrugs. "But I didn't come here to talk about that."

"So what? You're just butting in for fun?" Catra counters.

"Actually," Demeter turns to Adora and holds out her hand. "Adora, would you like to dance with me?"

"I . . ." Adora looks at the other Magicat dancers. "Don't know how."

"I'll teach you," Demeter insists. "It would be my honor."

Adora glances at Catra, as if asking for permission, but she turns away. Adora can do what she wants. And if she really wants to apologize right now, she'll apologize right now. But, Adora accepts Demeter's hand and is guided off to the dance floor.

Catra scowls as she feels anger stir in the pit of her stomach, starting to bubble up. She watches as Demeter guides Adora where to put her hands, but it's clear they're closer than they need to be when compared to the other dancers. For whatever reason, it makes her feel sick.

"Uh," Busto brings her back to reality once again. "What just happened?"

"Nothing," Catra growls.

"Doesn't look like nothing," Busto says, a shit-eating grin sliding onto his face. "Oh, you're jealous."

"I'm not jealous!" Catra hisses. "Besides, weren't you going to teach me how to dance?"

"Why, yes!" Busto dramatically bows and holds out his hand, "Catra, would you do me the honor of accompanying me to

the dance floor?”

Catra grins and snorts, “Only if you stop making a fool of yourself.”

He stands up straight, “Ah, but it got you to smile.

She rolls her eyes and takes his hands, “Just teach me how to dance Mr. Jellicle Ball Champion.”

Busto is a good teacher, and Catra quickly masters the basic moves of swing dancing. They even attempt a move where Catra slides under his legs and she pops up on the other side. She ends up pulling him onto the ground and he topples over her, but both of them are laughing too hard to care if they look like fools.

Once they’re done, Busto gets grabbed by another suitor, and Catra lets him go so she can take a break. She goes to sit down and catch her breath, but only once she’s sitting does she realize who she’s next to, “Hey D’nah.”

D’nah looks like she’s trying to blend into the background, sitting with her arms crossed and smoking a cigarette. She’s wearing a red dress that seems out of place on her frame. She pulls the cigarette from her mouth and growls, “I don’t want to hear a single word from you.”

Catra smirks, “You look good.”

“I said not a single fucking word.”

She’s tempted to continue teasing, even though it looks like D’nah’s contemplating scratching her eyes out, when she hears her name called, “Catra!”

Scorpia comes bounding up, wearing a figure-hugging black dress that was designed by Gr’wliger’s father as well. Her hair is slicked back like at Princess Prom and she’s smiling, so she must be having fun.

Catra abandons D'nah and approaches Scorpia, "Hey. You enjoying yourself?"

"Yeah!" Scorpia says. "It's so different from Princess Prom . . . and I don't think that's a bad thing. You look like you're having fun too."

"Somehow, I am," Catra admits. She smirks, "Say, you want to dance?"

"Oh, well," Scorpia clicks her claws together. "I don't even know how to with this fast music . . ."

"Busto taught me the basics, and I can teach you," Catra says. "C'mon Scorpia, I know you want to."

"Well . . ." Scorpia holds out a claw. "If you insist."

She starts off dancing with Scorpia, but somehow, she doesn't stop dancing for the next hour. Catra dances with nearly all her friends, Gr'wliger, Sh'dowell, Gar'ett, Shire, and even Busto again, and each teaches her a new dance move. By the end of the night, she'll be an expert.

But, even she has to take a break and retreats to the snack table to grab something to drink. As she hydrates, her eyes are drawn back to the dance floor.

Scorpia and Sea Hawk are dancing, but Sea Hawk is fumbling over his feet while trying to figure out how to hold Scorpia's claws. Sh'dowell is dancing with Jerry, despite being two heads shorter than him, and Catra looks away when Jerry leans down to kiss them, feeling like she's intruding on a personal moment. Busto is now dancing with Shire, who has stepped up to save Busto from dancing with another person he doesn't know, but it looks like Busto's trying to get her to laugh with his bad jokes. Gr'wliger is now dancing with Demeter, but Adora is vacant from the dance floor, meaning that Bow and Glimmer must have found her.

At the center of the dance floor are C'yra and Ri'ta, and Catra wonders if her mothers have taken a break since she last saw them. They're both laughing as they twirl each other around, wholly focused on each other without a care for anything around them. The two are looking at each other like the other is the sun, and it's no wonder that they surround Catra with so much love when they love each other like that. She's quite lucky to have them as her mothers.

"Catra?" Ok, maybe Adora isn't talking with Glimmer and Bow, since she's snuck up on her. She opens her mouth to say her usual 'Hey Adora', when she notices Adora is holding her hand out, "May I have this dance?"

She stares at Adora's hand for a moment. There's no way to avoid this, but Catra doesn't have to go without a fight, "Depends. Did Demeter manage to get anything through your thick skull?"

"I . . . may have stepped on her foot a few times," Adora admits.

"Well, you've never been light on your feet," Catra laughs.

"At least that hasn't changed," Adora agrees, a small smile appearing on her face.

Catra finally takes Adora's hand, "Let's dance."

Adora looks at her hand in surprise but squeezes it as they return to the dance floor. They start slow, since Adora has two left feet and hasn't really learned how to swing dance. That gives them time to talk.

"So," Adora begins. "You and Busto?"

Catra snorts, "What about me and Busto?"

"It looked like you two were having fun dancing," Adora continues. "And you two are close."

"Wait, are you insinuating that I *like* Busto?" Catra has to laugh at that.

"Uh . . . maybe?" Adora counters.

"Listen, he's just a friend who's easy to talk to and doesn't take my snark lying down," Catra says. "But, if we should be talking about anyone we should talk about you and Demeter."

Adora quirks an eyebrow, "What do you mean?"

Catra rolls her eyes, "Adora, she has a crush on you. And it's disgusting."

"She-" Adora gasps and lowers her voice. "She does?!"

"It's obvious," Catra says.

"Oh," Adora says and glances away. "Well . . . she's nice but I can't say that I'm interested . . ."

Catra tries to ignore the way that makes her feelings swell in her chest, "You sure? She came in second place in the Jellicle Ball, after all."

"I think I'd much rather dance with the second runner-up," Adora insists and sighs, "Wow. We're gossiping like we're cadets instead of fighting. So much has changed, hasn't it?"

Though she's not fond of where this conversation is turning, Catra sighs, "Yeah. I've . . . been trying to make a change. To be better. Despite everything I've done."

"And I'm proud of you, for that," Adora says. Her words don't hit as hard as her mothers', but the warm feeling doesn't fade from her chest. "And it's nice to be able to just talk with you."

Despite all of the anger that threatens to spill over due to broken promises, Catra can't help but agree. She finds that *missed* talking to Adora, without ulterior motives and hurt feelings. But she also can't ignore the pain Adora caused.

"Hey Adora," Catra begins, and she hums in response. "Earlier, before Demeter interrupted us, you were going to say something."

"Oh, it . . . doesn't matter," Adora insists.

Catra freezes in her tracks, and they stop dancing, "Actually, it does matter. I know I did a lot of shitty stuff, stuff that I'm going to have to work hard to make up for, but would it kill you to acknowledge that you hurt me too. You're not perfect, either."

"I-I know I'm not perfect," Adora argues.

"Fuck, no you don't. You're the golden child. Shadow Weaver's favorite. *She-Ra*," Catra says it like it's poison on her tongue. She runs a hand down her face, "Of course *you* haven't changed. Would it kill you to apologize to me?!"

Catra's outburst grabs the attention of the Magicats near-by, and she realizes that she may need to go cool off. As she steps back, Adora reaches out to grab her hand, but Catra pulls it away.

"Just, leave it alone," Catra growls. She walks away and exits the room, catching her breath as she leans against the cave walls of the hallway. She rubs her forehead as a headache starts, probably caused by the disagreement between her head and her heart.

Adora hasn't apologized yet. Maybe she never will. And logically, Catra knows she should move on. She has a life here in Half Moon that doesn't involve Adora. But it was so easy to fall back into their old banter. And it felt so nice to be held in Adora's arms. After all this time, she still wants Adora.

For anything to happen, Adora has to apologize first, and Catra doesn’t know if that’s ever going to happen.

Chapter End Notes

How long can I drag out Catra & Adora not talking? Don't worry, they'll start to resolve things soon. But, this is the end of the Jellicle Ball arc! I don't know whether to call the last part of this fic one arc or two, but fourteen chapters left to go!

Thank-you all for leaving comments, I appreciate each and every one though I suck at responding, you all are wonderful. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. I'm more active on Twitter, so I'd suggesting going there. Finally, I hope you all have a wonderful day and thank-you for reading!

all will be well, even after all the promises you've broken to yourself, all will be well, you can ask me how but only time will tell

Chapter Summary

Maybe Catra and Adora will finally talk this time . . .

Chapter Notes

Chapter title from All Will Be Well, by the Gade Dixon Band

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Now that the Jellicle Ball is over, things start to go back to normal. Catra goes on hunts, trains with C'yra, does magic with Ri'ta, and hangs with her friends. However, there's one thing that's bothering her . . .

The Princess Alliance is still here.

She doesn't even know why they've hung around for so long. They wanted to see if she was still alive, and she's still breathing. The Jellicle Ball happened, and they saw that. But why else could they be hanging around?

(Of course, Scorpia is not included in this sentiment and Catra doesn't mind having her around. In fact, Scorpia can stay in Half Moon as long as she likes as long as Catra has a say in it. It's the other Etherians that are getting on her nerves.)

"Do you know why the Etherians are still here?" Catra asks Ri'ta one day in hushed tones as they look over old tomes. She's supposed to be learning the Reticulum spell Ri'ta used on Thom, but Catra can't get her mind off of them.

"I feel like I should be asking you that," Ri'ta says with a smirk. "The diplomatic reason for them being here ended with the

Jellicle Ball, though C'yra said that Princess Glimmer talked to her about meeting with the Magicat Council."

"Really?" Catra asks. She thought that they may be hanging around because of her, for Adora, but maybe there is a political reason. "Can she do that? Why?"

"I really don't like to worry about politics, but if I had to guess, maybe she would like to try to reestablish relationships between us and Bright Moon," Ri'ta says. "But, I can't see the Council agreeing to that."

"You sure she isn't going to ask about the Princess Alliance and the Rebellion?" Catra counters.

"Well, the Magicats don't have a Princess," Ri'ta counters, raising a pointed eyebrow at Catra. "So that's a nonstarter."

That's a bit comforting, but before she can refocus and continue the lesson, Adora enters the library.

"Catra?" Adora says, trying to keep her voice low. She pauses before the center dais and says, "I'm not interrupting, am I?"

"Hey Adora," Catra says. "And, you are."

"Actually," Ri'ta smirks, and Catra doesn't think that means anything good for her. She puts her hand on her back and says, "I have to step away for a moment, but I'll be right back."

Ri'ta disappears between the shelves of the library, and Catra feels like cursing. But, Adora is staring at her, so she sighs, "We should step out of the library."

As the heavy doors of the library close behind them, Catra turns towards Adora and crosses her arms, "So?"

"You've been avoiding me," Adora starts off, and that's the wrong thing to say.

"No scat," Catra replies. She's starting to get sick of running around, but if that's the only way to protect her heart, she'll do it.

"You said you wanted me to apologize to you, but how am I supposed to apologize to you if you won't even let me talk to you!" Adora shouts.

"Well, I'm here," Catra says. "Are you going to apologize, or what?"

Adora takes a deep breath in and says, "I'm sorry."

"For what?"

"What?"

"Tell me why you're sorry."

"You only said 'I'm sorry' to me too without having to list off everything!" Adora argues.

"Do you want me to?" Catra counters. "I'm sorry for hurting you, I'm sorry for attacking Bright Moon, I'm sorry for leaving you behind in the Beacon, I'm sorry for tricking Entrapta, I'm sorry for kidnapping Glimmer, and I'm sorry for a *lot* of other things." Catra has to catch her breath and stares at Adora, "Now you."

"I'm . . . sorry for hurting you too," Adora says, more quietly this time.

"But why did you hurt me?" Catra stresses. "Do you even know why I did everything I did? Why I was lashing out?!"

"Because I joined the Princess Alliance, our enemy? Because of She-Ra?" Adora says. "Stop making me try and guess!"

"You shouldn't have to guess, you should just know!" Catra shouts. "And if you don't know then . . . then I don't know if

I can trust you! Because you might just do it *again!*"

"Just tell me what it is!" Adora yells.

"*Ah-hem*." The two turn to Gus with scowls on their faces, but the old scholar doesn't flinch at their anger. In fact, he appears to be just as angry, "This door is *fire-proof*, not *sound-proof*."

"Sorry," Catra hisses. "Adora was just leaving, right Adora?"

"Right," Adora says, glaring at Catra. "I'm sorry for disturbing the peace."

Adora marches away, and Catra brushes past Gus as she heads back into the library. Ri'ta is waiting for her at the center, and Catra sits down and crosses her arms, anger still boiling inside.

Ri'ta sighs. "That didn't go well."

"You heard?" Catra grumbles.

"Oh kitten," Ri'ta places her hand on her shoulder and squeezes, "Everyone heard."

". . . Fuck."

Instead of having dinner with her friends, Catra decides to eat with C'yra and Ri'ta. The two usually have a calming effect on her, but she can't let go of her anger. She doesn't have her usual appetite and is laying on the couch instead of with them, arm slung over her eyes as her conversation with Adora replays in her head.

"You're sure you're not hungry, Catra?" Ri'ta asks for the umpteenth time.

"Yeah, Mom," Catra insists. "I'm fine." She hears Ri'ta go into a coughing fit, and sits up for a moment, "You gotta get used to that so I don't accidentally kill either of you."

"Listen," Ri'ta tries to argue, though she's still choking. "We both love hearing you call us 'mom' but it's going to take a while for us to get used to it."

"Why don't you join us Catra?" C'yra asks. "So you can at least make sure that neither of us choke?"

"I'm good," Catra says and she flops back down onto the couch. She puts her arm over her eyes again when she hears a chair scrap against the floor. A weight settles on the other side of the couch and a reassuring hand lands on one of her legs.

"You know, for a while I was worried I was going to miss out on getting to experience teenage brooding," C'yra says.

Catra removes her arm and scowls, "It's not brooding."

C'yra gives her a pointed look, and she responds by rolling over on her side and facing the back of the couch. But, Ri'ta joins them and she leans against the couch, "You must admit Catra, this appears to be a little brooding. You won't even eat."

"Are you two just going to make fun of me?" Catra growls, turning her face into the couch pillow.

"I'm sorry, we don't mean to trivialize your feelings," Ri'ta says. "In fact, we want you to talk to us. You can tell us anything, Catra."

She wants to just be angry a little longer, but finds herself giving in too easily. She slowly sits up and pulls her knees up to her chest, hugging her legs, "I'm mad at Adora."

C'yra and Ri'ta don't say anything, they just listen to her.

"It feels like I've been mad at her for so long, since she left me and broke her promise," Catra says. "Then she showed up here, thinking that I needed her to save me from Beast Island- which she doesn't! She keeps on trying to act like a hero when I don't need her to. But, it almost felt like we were getting to some type of reconciliation, but then she doesn't know why I'm angry at her. She apologized, but not for the right thing. Which is why we were yelling at each other. And . . . and I want to trust her again. I want to trust her again so bad. I haven't even spent that much time with her but I missed her. But if she doesn't even realize what she did . . . how can I trust her again?"

"You're right, it will be hard to trust someone again after they broke a major promise to you," C'yra begins. "But also, you are very much like me, meaning that you're stubborn as hell. There have been times when Ri'ta and I would fight, I would hold my ground as long as possible. But I think you're beginning to realize just how exhausting being stubborn is."

"I'm stubborn, so what?" Catra grumbles.

"You say you want to trust Adora again, but I think you also still want to be angry at her," C'yra counters. "Because she hurt you and doesn't seem to realize how much she hurt you."

Catra buries her face into her legs, because C'yra's right. She thought she got over lashing out in response to being hurt . . . but she seems to still be doing it. Because she's stubborn.

"And maybe it's time you tell her that," Ri'ta picks up. "Be honest with her. If you two are going to rebuild the relationship you once had, you're both going to have to be honest if you want to trust each other again. And that trust is going to have to be rebuilt, one piece at a time."

This is the next step forward Catra has to take, reconciling with Adora. It won't be easy to rebuild that trust. They aren't the naïve children who have barely faced the horrors of the

Horde they once were. If only it could be as easy as locking eyes with someone and deciding that you would be friends forever.

Catra takes a deep breath in and lets it out, “Okay. I can do that.”

“Good,” C’yra smiles. “But, I know that this is difficult considering everything that happened between the two of you, so you don’t need to rush yourself.”

“No,” Catra shakes her head. “I’m ready.”

She has half a mind to go and find Adora now while she has the boosted confidence, but her stomach rumbles and distracts her.

“Now are you hungry, kitten?” Ri’ta asks.

“Yeah, you two didn’t eat everything, did you?” Catra asks.

“Of course not,” C’yra insists. “Your meal is still waiting for you, though it might be a little cold.”

The three return to the table, Catra sitting in between C’yra and Ri’ta. As she begins to dig in, she notices C’yra take a sip of her water and hits her with, “Thanks for the advice, Mom.”

Predictably, C’yra spits it across the table. As Ri’ta and Catra laugh, she gasps, “That time you did it on purpose!”

“No I didn’t,” Catra insists, but her grin gives her away.

Ri’ta leans across the table and wipes away the liquid dripping down C’yra’s chin, “You’ve got to admit dear, that time it was a little funny. At least no one is choking.”

“Fine, but I think that this just means we need to get used to Catra calling us ‘mom’ sooner,” C’yra points out. “Because she’s figured out how to weaponize it.”

"Hey Adora. Why'd I know I'd find you here?"

The next day, Catra saunters into the arena during lunch time. As usual, it's empty, aside from a blonde beating training dummies into submission with her stupid glowing sword.

"What are you doing here?" Adora asks. She doesn't pause as she slices another training dummy in half, the fluff spilling out.

"Hey, you know those are handmade, right?" Catra avoids the question as she leans against another dummy. "And made of like, leather. You're really supposed to be using training weapons on them."

"Oh," Adora finally stops and looks at the trail of carnage and fluff she's left. "I'll fix it."

"Do you know how to work with leather?" Catra counters.

"It can't be that hard, right?" Adora says. Catra holds back her laugh, she's seen the hunter's armorer create leather armor for them, and it's clear Adora doesn't know one thing about leatherworking. Adora changes the sword into a golden gauntlet and stares at Catra, "Really, Catra. Why are you here? I said I was sorry and, I'm sorry I don't know what you want me to apologize for."

"I'm here to take another step forward," Catra says. "I was angry when you left the Horde. You could figure out that much, but I guess you really don't know why. It wasn't just because Shadow Weaver was threatening me. And it's not as simple as just you leaving. It's why you left."

"Because of the sword," Adora says, reaching for the gauntlet on her hand. "And the Princess Alliance?"

Catra nods, "And not because of me."

"But . . . you never wanted to leave the Horde," Adora says.

"Who wouldn't want to leave the Horde after all the *horrible shit* Shadow Weaver did to me? To us? But I had you, and you wanted to stay, so I never suggested it," Catra says. She tries to keep her voice level, though the anger threatens to bubble up again. Adora needs to hear this. "I was angry that *I* wasn't the reason you decided to leave and break our promise. To me, it looked like you broke the promise we made over a stupid sword and a stupid sparkling Princess. For that, I wanted to hurt you. And I did. And I'm sorry about that."

"Catra I . . ." Adora shakes her head. "I must have been pretty stupid to not realize that."

"Yeah," Catra nods. "You are. Glad we can agree on that."

"I'm sorry," Adora says. "I know that Shadow Weaver was terrible and I failed to protect you-"

"You don't have to protect me!" Catra quickly interrupts. "I don't need it. Especially not now. I just . . . need you," she replays her impulsive words over in her head and quickly adds, "To apologize. And to . . . stop trying to act like a hero for me. All I wanted was for you to stay."

"And I'm sorry for leaving when I promised to stay," Adora revises. "I hope now you can see why I left but . . . I was blindsided and didn't see how much I hurt you."

"There," Catra says. "That wasn't so hard, wasn't it?"

"It was easier once I knew what you were feeling," Adora says. "I used to be able to read your emotions so easily, I understood you so well, and now-"

"We've changed, but more importantly, we hurt each other," Catra cuts her off. "I want to be friends with you again,

Adora. But . . . I don’t think either of us fully trust each other yet, not like we used to.”

“So what do we do?”

“We start over. Let’s not start with any promises, though. I don’t think I can handle it yet.”

“I understand,” Adora nods, “So, Catra Applesauce Meowmeow-”

“Don’t let anyone else hear you call me that,” Catra growls.

“-Would you like to be friends?” Adora says.

Catra smiles, “I’d love that.”

She finally feels a weight lifted off her heart when Adora returns her smile. They have a long way to go, but for now this fresh start is enough.

“*Awwwwwwwwww.*”

“Adora, how long has Bow been here?”

“Uh . . . the whole time.”

". . . Fuck."

Chapter End Notes

It finally happened! They finally talked! It only took 40 chapters! They definitely still have more to talk about but . . . it's a start.

Thank-you all for reading and leaving comments! Though I'm not great at responding to them, everyone helps inspire me to write more! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. And finally, I hope you all have a good day!

i need another story, something to get off my chest, my life gets kinda boring need something that i can confess

Chapter Summary

Catra tells Scorpia a secret.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Oh my gosh is this your room!? It's so . . . you!"

Catra is starting to regret letting Scorpia into her room, but she needed a place to talk to her friend alone. She actually hasn’t been in her room in the heart of Half Moon since the Jellicle Ball, preferring to stay in C’yra and Ri’ta quarters, so there’s a fine layer of dust covering everything. Her other room is cleaner, but she can’t take Scorpia there . . . yet.

Scorpia began to flit about her room, cooing over her messy bed, over-flowing desk, closet filled with random clothes, chair where she perches her extra weapons, and floor where she leaves everything else.

"Man, you've got a lot of books," Scorpia tries to pick one up with her claws, and it's thick enough she's able to get a good grip. "'The Three Deities and Their Influence'. I wouldn't take you to be the person into that religious stuff, Wildcat."

"I'm not," Catra says. "It’s for research.”

"About what?" Scorpia starts to flip through Catra's notes and some of the other books on her desk, careful to not punch any holes into them (Catra feels like Gus would kill her if he found a hole through one of his dusty old books).

"The relationship between the First Ones and the Three Stars," Catra reveals as she brushes through some of the pages in the book. This one actually had some decent information about the Temples and the Runestone, along with a bunch of cultural shit that helped things click for Catra about the Magicats. She forgot she dumped these books in here a while back, and this will be useful now that she's picking her research back up to fill in what little free time she has left.

"Oo!" Scorpia sits down in the desk chair. "Is that what you wanted to talk about?"

"Not really, but I don't mind talking about it," Catra walks over to her bed and flops onto the edge.

"So what did you want to talk about?" Scorpia quirks an eyebrow.

"It's kinda of a secret so I need to you be quiet about this, alright?" Catra begins.

Scorpia's eyes go wide, "Wildcat, you can tell me anything."

"I know," Catra says. "But . . . I just don't know how the others will react. I'm pretty sure that everyone in Half Moon knows, they just don't talk about it so . . ."

"Well, what is it?"

"You have to promise to not tell anyone though."

"I promise," Scorpia says, placing a claw across her chest. "Cross my heart."

Catra takes a deep breath and decides to keep it simple, "You know that C'yra and Ri'ta have . . . *had* a daughter. She was taken by the Horde during the Invasion, presumed to be dead. As it turns out, she's not dead because she's . . . me."

Scorpia goes slack-jaw, "What."

"Yeah," Catra awkwardly rubs the back of her head.

"YOU'RE a Princess too!?" Scorpia freaks.

"Yeah."

"Oh my gosh we're both Princesses! Who were in the Horde!" Scorpia continues, and she adds in a hushed tone, "Our connection grows stronger."

Catra has to smile at that, "Yeah, it's kinda strange. All my friends in the Horde were Princesses, and as it turns out I'm a princess."

"So, wait wait," Scorpia settles down. "How were the Queens sure that you're their daughter?"

"Well, I was the only Magicat in the Horde," Catra begins. "Plus, the blue and yellow eyes are a sign of royalty. There's a hall full of portraits where you can see that literally every other queen has one blue, and one yellow eye. C'yra too, before she lost her eye."

"Oh wow, so it's like how everyone in my family is part-scorpion," Scorpia nods her head. "But if you're a Princess . . . do you have a Runestone? Like the Black Garnet?"

Catra nods her head, "The Stone of Saz. That's actually another reason why they know I'm their daughter, I can use the Runestone."

"Saz that's . . . one of the deities?" Scorpia checks.

"Yeah, according to Magicat Legend the Stone was a gift from Saz to C'yra the First, and she used its powers to unite the Magicat tribes into the Queendom of Purrsia, so on and so forth," Catra quickly explains. "But it's definitely a Runestone. And the Temple of Lyses is a First One's Temple, but I'm not too sure

about the Temple of Saz yet. That's why I started doing this research, to find the connection. But, I didn't really want to talk to you about the Runestone and First Ones. I wanted to talk to you about being a Princess."

"Oh," Scorpia says. "Well, I can't say I know much about being a Princess . . . considering that I was pretty much raised in the Horde. The only real 'Princess-y' things I got to do were go to Princess Prom. Why not talk to Glimmer or Adora?"

Catra scowls, "Glimmer's the last person I want to find out about this. And Adora's not really a princess, *She-Ra* is. It's just . . . I thought I didn't want to be a Princess. I still don't, in the way the Princess Alliance is. I knew that what the Horde taught us about them was bullshit, but after everything that happened with the Princess Alliance . . . I didn't want to be associated with that. And my moms . . . C'yra and Ri'ta said that it's fine if I never want to be a Princess, I can just be their daughter."

"That's sweet," Scorpia says, and she almost sounds forlorn. "They sound so nice."

"They really are," Catra nods. "I think that's part of the reason I've come so far . . . even before I knew that they were my mothers they did their best to support me. And now . . . now I don't know about being a princess."

"Really?" Scorpia asks.

"It's not for any reason associated with the Princess Alliance or diplomacy," Catra says. "It's mostly because I just want to be C'yra and Ri'ta's daughter. So we can be a family without having to hide it, even though I think most of the people in Half Moon know. But then, there's a small part of me that sees C'yra lead the Magicats and . . . I want to do that too. Not for power, but for the Magicats . . . is this making sense, I don't think it's making sense."

"I think you're seeing another side to it," Scorpia says. "You and I have only ever seen the Princess Alliance as they're fighting us, so that's all we know about that. But now you're getting a more intimate look at what it's really about. Maybe you should talk to C'yra about the Princess stuff, because she used to be one."

"That's . . . actually a pretty good idea," Catra says. It's hard to see C'yra as anything other than a Queen and it seemed to have slipped her mind. However, it was time to tell Scorpia, "Thanks Scorpia."

"Well, I'm full of good ideas," Scorpia says.

"I'll have to talk to her later, she's busy with military inspections right now, or something," Catra says as she stands up. "So for now . . . do you want to see the Runestone?"

Runestone training had been pushed aside with the Jellicle Ball, because it wasn't like Catra could use the Fire of Saz without revealing herself as the Princess. This is her first lesson back, but C'yra can't make it today. It was going to just be her and Deut'ron, but she figured there was no trouble in inviting Scorpia to come along.

"How did you beat us?" Catra asks as she enters the basement of the Temple of Saz, Scorpia following close behind her. Deut'ron is sitting on a rock, eyes closed and his cane held in front of his hands.

"I fixed the hole," Deut'ron says, pointing to the ceiling.

Catra stares at the patch for a moment, "*How* did you get up there?!"

"A cleric never reveals his secrets, of course," Deut'ron says as he stands. He hobbles over to study Scorpia, "And I see you brought a friend today."

"I told Scorpia and figured she could stand in for C'yra since she can't be here," Catra says with a shrug. Hopefully, Deut'ron won't question that choice.

"I uh, don't have a connection to the Runestone, though," Scorpia points out. "I don't even have a connection to my own."

"You don't need to, I just need someone to spar with," Catra says.

"You do not need to spar with someone to summon the Fire of Saz, of course," Deut'ron points out. "But, if that is how you wish to get back into the swing of things, go ahead."

"Scorpia, you alright with that?" Catra double checks. She probably should have mentioned that earlier, but at least she's checking now.

"Oh sure! I'll just have to be careful to not sting you," Scorpia says.

"And I'll make sure to not set you on fire," Catra grins as she sets her hand against the Stone of Saz, and the room illuminates.

"Wait, what?"

When Catra retracts her hand, she summons the fire and grabs her grandmother's spear, the fire then following through it. Catra grins and says, "You ready?"

Scorpia drops into a fighting stance and mimics Catra's smile, "I'm always ready."

The two begin, and Catra realizes she's never actually sparred with Scorpia before. She knows the other is a bit self conscious about accidentally hurting Catra, but at least things are leveled with Catra using the Stone of Saz. Scorpia is made of pure strength, and Catra has to dodge her powerful claws. It's a bit like

fighting C'yra, but the style is different since Scorpia's primary weapon is her claws.

They dance around each other, occasionally surprising the other one, but they're equal and don't make a real headway. Catra finally thinks she's found and opening and-

"Sorry I'm late," Catra and Scorpia freeze as C'yra runs into the room. "Military inspections ended earlier than I expected-" she stops when she spots Scorpia. Scorpia immediately drops out of her fighting stance and steps back, as if she was caught doing something bad.

"Uhhhh," Catra lets the Fire of Saz die down and begins, "I told Scorpia I was a Princess and invited her to train with me because I didn't think you were coming."

"Oh," C'yra says. "Okay."

"You're . . . okay with that?" Scorpia checks. "Even though I was with the Horde?"

"If Catra trusts you, I trust you," C'yra says. "Honestly, I'm a bit more surprised that Catra told you about the Princess thing. I thought she wanted to keep it on the downlow."

"Well, Scorpia's a princess too," Catra says. "But like . . . not a part of the Princess Alliance, so I figured it'd be alright."

"And that just makes our bond grow stronger!" Scorpia adds, grabbing Catra in another hug. She yelps in surprise, and Scorpia drops her.

"Wait," C'yra stares at Scorpia. Scorpia shuffles nervously under her gaze until C'yra smiles, "How did I not see it sooner? You're Red and Aranea's daughter, aren't you?"

Scorpia lights up and quietly says, "You knew my moms?"

"Yes," C'yra nods with a smile. "They were probably the only princesses I got along with, since most were too involved in diplomacy shit and I just wanted to fight. But, the Magicats and the Tlincalli always respected each other as warriors."

"Wait, you *know* the Scorpoini's original name?" Scorpia continues.

"The Etherians give everything stupid names," C'yra rolls her eyes. "The Magicats used to be known as the Sehrah before the Etherians started calling us 'Magicats' because we were 'magical' and 'catlike'."

"Wait," Catra says. "Why don't I know that? Why do we call ourselves Magicats then?"

"It caught on," Deut'ron says.

"So . . . the Magicats, or the Sehrah, weren't afraid of the Tlincalli?" Scorpia asks.

"No, we got along, usually," C'yra says. "I believe there was some friction when leaders didn't get along, but the respect was always there. No one else on mainland Etheria took combat as seriously as us. However, my mother got along well with your grandfather, King Tityus." The smile fades from C'yra's and she sighs, "It was a shame what happened to him."

"What do you mean?" Scorpia asks. "My . . . my grandfather made an alliance with the Horde and . . ."

The look on C'yra's face is enough for Catra to understand, who says, "The Horde lied about that too, didn't they?"

Scorpia glances back at Catra, looking utterly devastated. She turns back to C'yra, "What happened?"

"From what I understand," C'yra begins. "It's similar to what happened to us. A full-fledged assault and a slaughter. The

Tlincalli have always been polarizing, so no one on mainland Etheria would help. I wanted to fight, but my mother wished to remain neutral against the Horde. Didn't work out well for us but . . . I heard that in a last ditch effort to spare his people, King Tityus surrendered the runestone and the princess . . . and the Horde repaid him with betrayal. The Scorpion Kingdom was leveled and the Fright Zone was built on top of it."

Scorpia's shoulders sag as the story goes on and stares at C'yra. Catra steps forward and hugs Scorpia, doing her best to comfort her. Her strong arms wrap around Catra, but they don't squeeze her with her usual fervor. Catra hears Scorpia sniffling above her.

"I'm sorry you have to find out like this," C'yra says.

"No, I'm . . . I finally know the truth," Scorpia insists. "Thank-you." She lets go of Catra and steps back, and taps her claws together, ". . . You said you knew my moms, right?"

"I did. They were the closest thing I had to friends among the Princesses," C'yra says.

Quietly, Scorpia asks, "Could you . . . tell me more about them?"

"I can. We can head to my office and have tea," C'yra nods, and turns to Deut'ron, "I hope you don't mind if we end this lesson early?"

"Of course not," Deut'ron insists. "It is important for them to be remembered, and who better to carry that memory than their daughter?"

As they begin to leave the Temple, Catra isn't sure she should come along. This is an intimate topic for Scorpia, it's her moms. But, Scorpia turns to Catra and holds out her claw, "You'll come with me, right Catra?"

Catra nods and takes her claw, "Of course I will."

C’yra and Scorpia spent most of the afternoon talking, and Catra just listened. This was for Scorpia and she’s there to support her friend. Around dinner, Ri’ta finds them and offers to help Scorpia find books about the history of the Tlincalli in the library, leaving C’yra and Catra alone.

“You look like you want to ask me something, kitten,” C’yra points out once the door is closed.

“Yeah, actually,” Catra shifts forward in her seat. “I wanted to talk about . . . being a Princess.”

C’yra’s eyes go wide, “Catra, if you don’t want to be a princess, you don’t have to. I stand by my original statement, if you don’t want to be a princess then the monarchy can end with me.”

“I know,” Catra nods. “I think . . . I just want to know more about what being a princess is like. At least for the Magicats. Because my only real exposure to princesses is the Princess Alliance and . . . most of them annoy me. Sounds like they annoyed you too.”

“Magicats and most of mainland Etheria have different standards,” C’yra says with a laugh. “But, I was also pretty scrappy and preferred to solve things with my fists rather than through words. The first time I met Queen Angella I got pissed off and kicked her. I was pretty young, though.”

“Really?” Catra laughs. “I can top that, the first time I met her . . . I tried to invade her kingdom.”

Thankfully, C’yra manages to take that as joke, “You know, Ri’ta also blew up the Bright Moon kitchen with Micah, so I think I’m starting to sense a trend.”

“Can I get that story?” Catra eagerly asks.

"Ri'ta tells it better," C'yra insists. "Besides, I haven't even answered your question yet."

"Yeah but that sounds much more interesting."

C'yra laughs and shakes her head, "Now let's see . . . when I was a Princess, I had a lot of classes. Combat, history, law, training with the Stone of Saz, and such. I didn't really pay attention to any history and law lessons, but if you decide to be a princess those are things you need to know."

"I think I'm caught up on Magicat history," Catra says.

"Oh, trust me, whatever you've done is only brushing the surface," C'yra laughs. "And then, there was diplomacy, which as you can tell, I wasn't really big on. However, we currently aren't allies with anyone so you'd be spared that. The biggest thing would be preparing you to take the throne."

Catra nods. It's not as bad as she thought it would be . . . the fact that she doesn't have to care about diplomacy helps. She has more questions though, "And what if . . . I never wanted to be Princess, but I didn't want to hide the fact that you're my mom anymore. What would happen then?"

"I . . . I believe you'd have to abdicate," C'yra says. "You'd have to renounce the throne. Which isn't the first time it has happened. My great-grandmother became the Queen because her older sister abdicated. However, that is not a decision you'd have to make right away. You can take however long you'd like to decide what you'd like to do."

"Any decision would have to wait until after the Princess Alliance leaves, though," Catra adds. "If any of them found out I'm a princess . . . they'd become insufferable." At least, Shimmer would. Catra isn't sure how Adora would react.

"And that's okay," C'yra says with a smile.

"How much longer do you think they're going to be around?" Catra asks. "Mom said that Shimmer wants to talk with the Council."

"That meeting is in four days," C'yra says. "She didn't tell me what she wished to talk with the Council about, though. I know you don't talk with Princess Glimmer, but do you have any idea?"

"There's only one thing she'd want from the Council," Catra snorts. "And that's for the Magicats to join the Princess Alliance, princess or not. They need bodies to throw at the Horde."

C'yra frowns and leans back, "Well, that'll be an interesting meeting. She's going to be disappointed."

"She could use a little disappointment," Catra argues. "But . . . thank-you for telling me about being a princess and all that scat."

"It's no problem, Catra," C'yra reaches across the desk and squeezes Catra's hand. "And no matter what you choose, Ri'ta and I will always be here for you."

Chapter End Notes

Once again, thank-you all for reading and consider leaving a comment! I suck at responding, but I do read all of them and appreciate every one. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle

those kids were as fast as lightning, in fact it was a little bit frightening, but they fought with expert timing

Chapter Summary

The Magicats get a chance to spar with She-Ra.

Chapter Notes

Chapter title from Kung-Fu Fighting by Carl Douglas.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So," Bow sighs. "Lionel'o can never meet Entrapta, right?"

"Yes," Glimmer and Adora reply.

Catra can't help but laugh. The hunters were trying out another one of Lionel'o's new inventions, and the Best Friend Gang, or whatever stupid name they came up for themselves, got to witness the fiery explosion.

"Glad we can all agree on that," Catra says as the other hunters pour water on the smoldering pile of ash where an invention once stood.

"Lionel'o," Gr'wliger sighs as he pinches his nose. "What did I say about using beast hair in your inventions?"

"I don't remember," Lionel'o says.

"You have a perfect memory; I know you remember."

"You said that I can't use them because I'd eventually set the entire cave system on fire."

"Yes, and please do not use any beast hair in the future."

"I promise to not use beast hair in the future!"

"You have your fingers crossed behind your back."

"That I do!" Lionel'o says and begins to walk away. "Well, see you later Gr'wliger!"

Gr'wliger puts his head in his hands, and Catra walks up and pats him on the back, "Listen, it'll be alright."

"How?"

"We get rid of all the beast hair while he's sleeping and tell the soldiers at the gate that he can't leave the caves unaccompanied by a hunter."

"That's a start," Gr'wliger sighs. He turns to Adora, Bow and Glimmer, "I am sorry you had to see that reckless display of engineering."

"Don't worry that . . . actually reminded us of a friend," Bow says, his sentence ending in a frown. Catra grimaces as well, Entrapta's still back in the Horde. She is probably having the time of her life, actually, but Catra would like to apologize to her and get her out of there.

"Hey, Gr'wliger," Demeter interrupts. "Since this ended how we all knew it would end, can we go early?"

"I suppose," Gr'wliger sighs. "You are all free to go."

Most of the hunters leave the room, and Adora asks, "Does that mean we can use the training arena?"

"As long as the soldiers do not need it," Gr'wliger says. "But, we had it reserved for another hour and a half, so you should be fine until then."

"So Catra," Adora turns to her. "Would you like to join us?"

Catra still feels apprehensive about training with the Princess Alliance, as the times where she tried to hurt them are still fresh in her mind. Thankfully, Busto comes in to save the day.

"Well, I thought I smelled smoke!" Busto laughs as he enters the arena. "I assume the hunters are done for the day, then?"

"Sadly," Gr'wliger sighs.

"Great!" Busto says and he turns to Adora, "That means that I can do this. Adora!" Busto draws his rapier and strikes a dramatic pose, "I challenge you, and your giant alter ego She-Ra, to a duel!"

"Uh . . . okay?" Adora agrees.

"Wonderful!" Busto stands up. "Then, once the arena's cleared out, we can begin!"

While Catra usually doesn't like She-Ra, she is curious to see how Busto fares against her. She nudges Gr'wliger in the side, "You going to stick around to watch?"

"No, I think I'm going to talk to Sea Hawk," Gr'wliger says. "If I can find him."

Catra doesn't know what Gr'wliger would want with the eccentric boat captain, but can point him in the right direction, "I think Scorpia dragged him to the library."

"Thank-you," Gr'wliger says. He departs as Catra, Bow and Glimmer head up to the arena seats. Catra isn't sure if she wants to be left alone with them, but as long as she can watch the fight she'll be fine. It's bound to be entertaining, to see the Champion of the Jellicle Ball fight She-Ra.

"So, Catra."

Saz dammit.

Glimmer sits next to her as soon as Busto and Adora drop into fighting stances and continues, “What do you know about the Magicat Council?”

Catra growls, “The fight’s about to start.”

“So!” Busto shouts, brandishing his sword. “We’ve fought before, but I am eager to fight with She-Ra!”

“I can make that happen,” Adora says. She transforms the bracer on her arm into the Sword of Protection, and raises it above her head, “For the honor of Grayskull!”

In a burst of light and sparkles that Catra has to turn away from lest she be blinded, Adora transforms into She-Ra. She-Ra grins as she brandishes the sword, but Busto remarks, “You know, I thought you’d be taller.”

She-Ra rushes forward to attack. Busto jumps and flips backwards out of the way, and Catra knows he’s just showing off. He steps forward to strike and-

“I’m serious, Catra,” Glimmer says, shaking her arm. “I need to know about the Magicat Council.”

“Why?” Catra scowls, ripping her attention away from the fight. She gets the feeling Glimmer isn’t going to leave her alone until she gets her answers.

“Because I’m going to be meeting with them in three days,” Glimmer says. “And I’m unfamiliar with how it functions.”

“So why’d you agree to meet with them if you don’t know what you’re doing?” Catra hisses.

“I’m asking you so I know what I’m doing!” Glimmer argues.

“Fine,” Catra runs a hand down her face. She doesn’t know everything about the Council, but has managed to collect

information on it. “The Council used to be made up of the heads of the tribes of Purrsia, but it’s now the heads of the factions that make Half Moon run. The Queens, General Az’al, Jen’dots, Gr’wliger, Gus, and Deut’ron are all on it. There’s also a Cleric of Lyses, a farmer, a merchant, and a citizen’s representative that I haven’t met. Does that answer your question?”

“What are all the factions?” Glimmer continues.

“Soldiers, hunters, chefs, scholars, mages, clergy, agricultural, merchants, and healers,” Catra says. She tries to pay attention to the fight again, and somehow Busto is holding on against-

“Who is the head mage?”

“Ri’ta.”

“Isn’t she also the Queen?”

“She does both.”

“What does Deut’ron do?”

“He’s the Queens’ advisor.”

“What is Gus like?”

“He has a fucking stick up his ass.”

“Do you have any idea how I can meet the other faction heads?”

“No. Stop asking me questions.”

“I have more.”

“I don’t care.”

Catra turns back to the fight, and She-Ra has just knocked Busto onto his ass. He rolls over onto his feet and wipes

the blood from his lips as he begins his next assault. He ducks under She-Ra's sword only for her to drop it into her other hand and hit him in the stomach with the blunt end. Catra can't help but wince.

She was secretly hoping that maybe Busto could find a way to sneak a victory over She-Ra, but it doesn't look like that's going to happen. Despite patching things over with Adora, Catra can't help but feel contempt for her fancy princess persona.

"What's going on here?"

Glimmer and Bow gasp as C'yra joins them sitting on the sidelines, watching Busto and She-Ra spar. Catra smirks at their reactions, she heard C'yra enter the arena a few seconds before she joined them.

"Busto's getting his ass kicked," Catra bluntly answers, and Glimmer shoots her a glare like that was the wrong thing to say to a Queen. But, Catra knows a bit more about C'yra than Glimmer does.

C'yra snorts, "Well, it had to be done. After winning the Jellicle Ball I feared he was getting too far up on his high horse."

Now, Bow and Glimmer are staring at C'yra in shock and curiosity but, C'yra ignores them as she asks, "So that's She-Ra, correct?"

Catra glances at She-Ra, who has knocked Busto onto the ground once again, "Yeah, what about it?"

"I thought she'd be taller," C'yra says. She scratches her chin as Busto yields, the Sword of Power pointed at his chest. Catra's never seen such a scheming look on her face, and before she can ask a question C'yra hops down into the arena.

"What is she doing?" Bow checks.

"No fucking clue," Catra admits as she leans over the side of the railing. She grins, "All I know is that I wanna watch."

C'yra walks over to She-Ra and Busto, "Well Busto, that was a spectacular defeat."

"I fear I deserved it, my Queen," Busto laughs as he stands up and brushes himself off. "After all, the higher up on the horse, the harder they fall."

"Or something like that," C'yra says and she transfers her look to She-Ra. "Are you up for another round?"

"I'm out!" Busto quickly exclaims and he makes a fast exit. Catra laughs, Busto's good but he wasn't prepared for She-Ra. However, Catra doesn't think She-Ra is prepared for C'yra.

"With who?" She-Ra questions.

C'yra draws her sword-her constant companion, always at her hip-and touches the gauntlet on her left arm, bringing up the light shield. C'yra grins, "With me, of course."

She-Ra blanches as Bow exclaims, "The Queen wants to fight with Adora?"

"With She-Ra," Catra corrects Bow. "But yeah. She's the best warrior out of all the Magicats."

Catra has learned of a Magicat saying when it comes to combat, 'float like a butterfly, sting like a bee' and C'yra perfectly encapsulates that. She's strong and can hit hard, but somehow manages to be extremely dexterous at the same time. In addition, she's smart and can think fast when it comes to combat. She is truly the best the Magicats have to offer.

"I thought Busto was," Bow says. "Considering he won the Jellicle Ball."

"Well," Busto joins everyone, sitting behind Catra and still out of breath. "I appreciate the sentiment, but that's not true. C'yra is the superior warrior here, and Az'al and Ri'ta are up with her."

The fight below begins, as She-Ra hesitantly accepts the offer. They begin circling each other, waiting for the other to make the first move.

"Well, that makes sense," Bow says. "Considering that C'yra is connected to the Runestone-"

"She doesn't use the Stone of Saz," Catra cuts Bow off.

Bow blinks, "Wait, what?"

"C'yra's connection to the Stone of Saz is piss poor," Catra explains. "She doesn't use any of the powers that it grants, she's just that good."

Bow doesn't know what to say to that, so he turns his attention back to the battle happening before them.

She-Ra decides to strike first, running forward and swinging her sword. C'yra ducks behind her shield and tackles She-Ra, digging the top of the shield into She-Ra's stomach and launching her over her back. She-Ra lands on her back, clearly surprised by C'yra's display of pure strength. Catra can only laugh at this.

C'yra spins around as She-Ra jumps up, and their swords clang together. However, the Queen quickly knocks She-Ra sword to the side and hits her arm with the blunt side of her sword. This was all for fun, after all. She-Ra tries to hit C'yra with her sword, but it bounces of C'yra's shield.

Their blades clash and bounce off of each other in a relentless attack. C'yra is grinning wildly, clearly having fun, while She-Ra is growing frustrated. She changes the Sword of Protection into a spear, but the change barely phases C'yra. When

She-Ra jabs with her spear, C'yra steps on the end and lodges it into the ground. She jumps off of it and kicks She-Ra in the chin before landing back on her feet. She-Ra stumbles back, pulling the spear out of the ground. C'yra doesn't relent and runs forward, tackling She-Ra to the ground. When She-Ra tries to throw C'yra off, she simply rolls onto her feet and launches at She-Ra again.

Catra can tell that C'yra's persistence and skill are starting to throw She-Ra off. The golden child has rarely faced a challenge she can't beat into submission, and all of She-Ra's skills can't compare to C'yra's pure talent.

Before C'yra can land what would be the finishing blow, Az'al's voice cuts through the arena, "Your Majesty, just what do you think you're doing?"

Catra holds her breath. Az'al has been strangely cordial with her lately, but she doesn't know if that holds the same for C'yra. The Queen steps back away from Adora and wipes away sweat from her brow, but the smile doesn't fade, "What does it look like I'm doing, General?"

"It looks like you're challenging the fancy Etherian princess to a battle," Az'al begins, her face schooled. It breaks into a grin similar to C'yra's, "Without *me*! Why do you get to have all the fun!"

C'yra laughs, and Catra lets out the breath she was holding, "Maybe you should have thought of it first, then!"

"Well, if you're done playing with your food," Az'al says as she marches over. "I want to spar with her next."

"What do you say, Adora?" C'yra asks She-Ra. "Think you can go for another round?"

"Uh . . ." with a burst of light Adora returns, "Sorry, I'm kinda winded. Maybe next time?"

Az'al nods, "Just remember that I'm first in line the next time you're training."

"I will," Adora sighs.

"I take it that means we're done here too," C'yra says. She places a heavy hand on Adora's shoulders, "You're good, kid, but I think you've still got aways to go."

Catra laughs when she sees the disbelieving look on Adora's face. For as powerful She-Ra is, she's never fought someone like C'yra.

"You still got energy after fighting that giant?" Az'al laughs. "Then why don't you and I have a go at it? Just like old times . . . unless your age is getting to you."

"You're the same age as me," C'yra counters, but she's smiling. She twirls the sword in her hand, "If your joints aren't aching, I'd love to fight you."

The two begin to spar, and Catra can't help but be happy for her mother. She must have taken her own advice and talked with Az'al, just like she told Catra to do with Adora. Hopefully, the two are repairing their friendship.

"Wow," Adora sits next to Catra, while Bow and Glimmer continue to watch the fight. "C'yra's really something."

"Oh yeah," Catra laughs. "I've sparred with her before, and it's something else."

"Was she using the Magicat Runestone?" Adora checks.

"Not at all," Catra says. "She's just that good."

"Wow," Adora repeats. "Say . . . maybe next time, would you like to train with me?"

"Az'al already called dibs," Catra points out. "Oh, and she's C'yra's equal when it comes to combat, so you have that to look forward to."

Adora blanches and Catra laughs. She recovers and says, "Well, after that, I suppose. We could train together, just like old times."

"I don't know, Adora," Catra admits. "I think . . . it's still too fresh."

"Oh," Adora nods, becoming downcast. "That's okay."

She must have just wanted to spend time with Catra, seeing that they haven't really done that since they made-up. It's not like Catra's trying to avoid her, she's just been busy. But, since she has the rest of the afternoon off, maybe it's about time.

"But, we haven't really had a chance to hang-out yet, have we?" Catra continues. "We can't climb up the rafters like we used to, but why don't I show you around Half Moon? I bet you haven't even seen half of the caves yet."

Adora lights up, "I would love that, Catra."

"Can we finish watching C'yra and Az'al fight first?"

"Sure, maybe studying the competition will help me the next time I have to spar with either of them."

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading and thank-you for all the comments! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle! I hope you all have a good day!

won't you help me sober up? growin' up it made me numb, and i wanna feel somethin' again

Chapter Summary

Catra has gotten so good at redemption that now she's offering it to other people.

Chapter Notes

Chapter title: Sober Up, AJR

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Catra," Busto says. "I have some bad news."

"It's too early for bad news," Catra groans as she gets in line for breakfast. She woke up, threw on some clothes, and trudged to the cafeteria after a night of little sleep. Stupid nightmares.

"Thom is getting released today."

Well, that's woken her up.

"He's getting released?" Catra asks. "But it's only been like a week."

"That's all they could do him in for violating the Jellicle Ball rules," Busto shrugs. "It's . . . more than he's ever gotten, at least."

"So, do you think he's going to be angry at me?" Catra asks. She could survive his shitty comments and snide remarks, but now she knows that he can do magic . . . and she would prefer to not be put under the *Canes Venatici* spell again.

"I think Az'al put the fear of Ilir into him," Busto says. "But . . . I've actually talked to him too."

She glances up and Busto looks ashamed. She nudges her shoulder, "It's okay. I know you two used to be friends. I've been reconnecting with old friends too."

Busto lets out a sigh, "Thank-you. I haven't been able to get much out of him, but . . . I think now that the anger has faded, he's disappointed in himself. He's not going to cause you any trouble, Catra."

"Okay," Catra nods. "If you think so . . . I trust you."

And hopefully, Catra wouldn't see Thom anytime soon.

Later that day, Catra sees Thom.

She's in a lesser used part of the Caves, leaving from sparring with C'yra in their spot to take a break before training with Ri'ta. She actually almost doesn't see him.

Thom is crouching in a corner, an old worn tome laid out in front of him. He holds out his hands, mumbles something, and magic begins to coalesce at his fingertips. The spell almost forms, but it fizzles out. Thom frowns, disappointment turning to anger, "Saz dammit!"

He hasn't noticed her yet, so she still has a chance to leave. All he's ever done to her is give her a hard time, whether using his thievery skills or blood magic. If he's reconnecting with Busto, that might mean he's changing through, and Catra wants to see if for herself. Curiosity killed the cat and only satisfaction will bring it back, "What are you trying to do?"

With a yelp, Thom grabs the tome as he jumps to his feet. He scrambles to hold it close to his chest, trying to hide the fact that he was doing magic, "WHAT THE FUCK?!"

"Dude, calm down," Catra's trying not to laugh at his extreme reaction. "I just wanted to know what you're doing."

Thom narrows his eyes, "Nothin'."

"I just saw you trying to do magic," Catra sighs.

"No I wasn't."

"Yes, you were."

"No, I wasn't."

Catra does not want to play this game. She frowns, "I can *make* you tell me. So do you want to do this the easy way, or the hard way?"

He frantically looks around, trying to find a way out of this situation. There's no one around and Catra has him trapped in a corner. Eventually, he chooses the easy way, "I may be . . . doin' magic."

"What spell?"

"Whoa!" Thom raises his hand. "I told you want ya wanted ta know!"

"Why are you being so stubborn about this?" Catra groans. She rubs a hand down her face and wonders why she's even bothering. They're practically enemies, but he looks so pitiful practicing magic in a forgotten corner of Half Moon. Maybe if she helps him, they won't be enemies, "Look, it's *obvious* you were having trouble with that spell. Maybe I can help you out."

Thom narrows his eyes, "Why do you want to help *me*?"

"I'm starting to ask myself that question too," Catra says. "Listen, will you let me help you before I change my mind?"

He purses his lips in a pout, but concedes, "Fuh-ine."

Thom opens the tome, flips it open to a certain page, and presents it to Catra by jabbing his finger at it. She quickly skims the page; it appears to be a spell that summons monsters made of shadows.

"What do you want to do with this spell?" Catra interrogates before she moves forward.

"It just looked cool," Thom shrugs. "Ta be able ta summon animals made a' shadows. I could have, like, a dog."

"Thom, it specially uses the words 'shadow beasts'."

"Yeah. That could be like a dog."

It's a very advanced spell, requiring multiple physical components and spell-casting techniques Ri'ta hasn't even taught her yet. She wonders how Thom thought he could attempt this spell.

Against her better judgment, she points to a paragraph, "You need these components."

"What?" Thom squints. "Why?"

". . . Have you not used any components in a spell before?"

"No."

"Wow you've . . ." Catra recalls the variety of spells he used during the Jellicle Ball, from blood magic to teleportation. "You've gotten pretty far without having to use spell components. I'm . . . actually kinda impressed."

Thom's eyes go wide, "You are?"

"Yeah," Catra says. "And if you really want help with this spell, you should go to Ri'ta."

She blinks and realizes, “Why haven’t you asked Ri’ta to give you lessons? You’re already decent at magic, you could get really good.”

He holds the tome tightly to his chest, “I can’t go to the library.”

“Why?”

“This is an overdue book.”

Catra stares at Thom, “Really?”

“Yeah!” Thom says. “I took it out of the library years ago! I didn’t want to get in trouble after missing the due date . . . and my whole life fell apart!”

“Wait wait wait,” Catra pauses Thom. She’s doing her best not to laugh, especially because he’s getting upset about this. “Are you saying . . . that the only reason you became a criminal . . . is of an overdue book?”

“Maybe . . . but I also dropped outta soldier training at the same time cuz my shitty ass father died,” Thom mutters. He seems to be realizing how ridiculous this all is, “But what am I gonna do now? This is my life!”

“You can come to the library with me,” Catra says.

“I just said-” Thom begins, but she grabs his wrist and drags him away, “Hey!”

“Listen, it’s been *years*,” Catra points out. “I doubt that anyone remembers or cares at this point.”

Despite Thom’s best efforts, he’s unable to overpower Catra and break free. He struggles all the way, but she pulls him to the library all the way to the center.

Ri’ta and Shire appear to be in the middle of a lesson, but they stop and watch Catra force Thom to sit down in one of the seats. She stands behind him, putting her hands on his shoulders so that as soon as he stands up, she can push him back down.

“Hello Catra . . . Thom,” Ri’ta’s a bit confused. “It’s good to see you . . . both, but is there anything I can help you with?”

“Thom wants to learn magic,” Catra announces. Ri’ta’s eyes go wide.

“Now wait a Saz damn second-!” Thom exclaims, jumping up, but Catra wrestles him back into his seat.

“Ahem.”

Catra was too busy wrangling Thom to notice Gus approach, “Sorry Gus. Thom’s being a little bitch.”

“Hey!”

“That is not the reason I came over,” Gus says. “Well, I suppose it is one of the reasons. But Thom of M’Cavity, you have an overdue book.”

Thom stares at Gus and turns to Catra to accuse, “You said no one would remember!”

“Shush!” Catra hisses. Thom’s volume level would not help him here. She grabs the book before he can react and hands it to Gus, “He’s not in trouble, is he?”

“Usually, there’s a monetary fine,” Gus says. “Nothing otherwise.”

“There’s no need,” Ri’ta walks over. “We’ll waive the fee for today. The book has been returned safe and sound, and I believe Thom has learned his lesson in other ways.”

"I suppose that's fair," Gus eyes Catra. She only shrugs in response as he hobbles away.

With Gus gone, Ri'ta turns to Thom, "So, you'd like to learn magic properly?"

Thom gulps, "Uh . . . yes?"

"Well, let me finish my lesson with Shire, and then we can get started," Ri'ta says.

He stares at her in shock, and barely even processes it when Catra waves her hand in front of his face, "Etheria to Thom?"

"Oh!" Thom jolts. "Uh . . . hi?"

"Are you doing alright?" Catra asks.

"Yeah," Thom nods. "I guess . . . I just never realized it would be this easy. I always wanted ta do magic, but my dad wanted ta be a soldier like him. And now he's probably rollin' in his grave but I don't fuckin' care." He sighs and stares up at Catra, "Oh . . . also, thanks? I guess?"

"You're welcome," Catra says. "And," she grabs his chin and digs her fingers into his skin as she growls, "And if you ever cast any spell on me again-especially Canes Venatici-I will make your life hell. Got it?"

Thom nervously swallows, "Good."

"Good," Catra smiles and let's go of him. "Glad we could come to this understanding."

"I'm sorry," Thom says, after a beat. "Ya didn't have ta help me get lessons with Ri'ta, but ya did."

"It's called being a good person," Catra says. "Maybe you should give it a try sometime"

"Maybe I will."

Catra hangs around for Thom's lesson with Ri'ta. It's similar to her first lesson, summoning a ball of light. It comes easily to Thom. He must be a natural. Once he's done, he looks lost, so Catra grabs him and drags him with her to the dining hall. When her friends ask her why Thom's here, she just shrugs. Busto has a different reaction, though.

Busto's face skews into a look of confusion as he walks up to the table, keeping his eyes on Thom, "Hello! Uhm . . . Thom, it's good to see you but . . . why are you here?"

Thom shrugs, focusing on eating his food.

Catra sighs, "I think we're friends now?"

"You *think?*"

"She got me lessons with Ri'ta," Thom says with a mouthful of food.

Busto stares at Thom, "You *finally* got magic lessons?"

"Yeah, why?"

Busto drops his tray on the table and wraps Thom in a hug that lifts him out of his seat, "I am so glad! I'm happy that you're back!"

("Where'd he go?" Sh'dowell jokes.)

"Put me down!" Thom hisses.

"Oh sorry," Busto drops Thom. "So . . . you and I should get caught up. Without cell bars between us. If you'd like."

Thom stares at Busto before turning back to his food, as if he's trying to hide his face, "Okay."

"Okay?" Busto repeats. "Okay! Great! I'm-"

"Going to sit down and eat now?" Catra interrupts.

"Yes," Busto says. "Okay," and he sits down.

"That was weird," Shire says.

"That was exactly what Catra did with Adora," Gar'ett says. "Just faster."

Catra stares at Gar'ett, "Stop."

"No."

Thom stares at Catra, "What do you mean-?"

"Hey guys!" Bow says as he tows along Glimmer and Adora. "What's up?"

"Thom's joined us," Sh'dowell says.

"Hey," Thom adds.

Adora eyes Thom warily, "Aren't you the one that cheated at the Ball? And used shadow magic?"

"Yeah," Thom says.

"It's fine," Catra says. "I've threatened him already."

"Is it?" Shire questions.

Catra shrugs, "I've done worse. But we're both changing."

When Catra looks at her friend group now, she doesn't know what's more surprising: that she's friends with Thom or that she's reconnected with Adora. Or maybe it's the fact that she has any friends at all. Her former self, the Horde commander, would scoff at her for being weak. However, Catra has never felt stronger.

Chapter End Notes

This is a shorter chapter, but I really like it! If you can't tell, this part of the arc is all about reconnection and I think this chapter exemplifies that as Catra's able to help Thom.

If you like the story, consider leaving a comment! I read and appreciate every one even if I'm not the best at responding to them. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle

friends who don't have a clue, well meaning teachers, but down in your arms, your arms, i am a wild creature

Chapter Summary

Catra has a nightmare and seeks out Adora to talk.

Chapter Notes

This fic hit 2k kudos!!! Thank-you all for your support, I really love this story and the fact that you all love it too means a lot to me. I wish I could say that I have something special planned, but I don't, so all I can really say is thank-you. Now, we just have to get this fic to 2.6k kudos so it can be my most popular fic. Now, enjoy the chapter!

(Also, I know I said that I would never write another nightmare chapter, but I somehow did. Whoops.)

Chapter title: Broom People, the Mountain Goats

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra's eyes fly open and she scrambles to summon a ball of light in her cupped hands. The light flickers as she breathes in and out, the shadows of her nightmare retreating. Once her breathing evens out, she growls and runs a hand down her face.

She's been having the same nightmare for the past week. It doesn't take place in the Fright Zone, or anywhere on mainland Etheria, but in the caves of Half Moon. Horde soldiers storm the caves, cutting down anyone in their path. Leading the dark assault is Shadow Weaver herself, and in the twisted logic of her dreams, her black lightning manages to cut down even C'yra and Ri'ta.

Her mothers' words haven't helped with these nightmares, when it usually does. They tell her that Half Moon is

safe, that the Horde is done with them and won't touch them again, that C'yra and Ri'ta would curb-stomp Shadow Weaver into the ground if she ever touched Catra again. None of it has helped.

After a week of waking her mothers up, Catra feels like letting them catch-up on their sleep, no matter how comforting their presences are. Maybe what she needs instead is to talk to someone who is more familiar with the Horde, someone who understands . . . maybe she can talk to Adora.

Catra slips out of the queen's apartment and walks through the winding caves of Half Moon, using the light spell to illuminate her path and chase away the shadows. As she walks, she realizes that she has no idea where Adora is staying. She knows she's rooming with Glimmer and Bow, but that's about it.

Lost in thought, Catra rounds the corner and almost gets skewered by the Sword of Protection, "Who goes there!?"

"Adora, what the fuck?" Catra says. She holds up the ball of light to illuminate both of their faces, "It's just me."

"Oh, sorry," Adora changes the sword into a bracer.

"You're lucky it was me and not some kit," Catra sighs. "What are you doing up?"

"I couldn't sleep," Adora shrugs. "And I didn't want to wake up Bow or Glimmer. What about you?"

"I was actually looking for you," Catra says. "I couldn't sleep either and I wanted to . . . talk."

"Did you have a nightmare?" Adora asks. "Do you need me to stroke your tail like I did back in the Horde?"

Catra is thankful that no one is around to hear that as her ears burn with embarrassment, "No, I do not need you to do that.

I just wanted to . . . talk about it. Nothing else. I think you're the only one who'd really understand . . ."

"Okay," Adora nods. "Should we . . . go somewhere else?"

"Yeah, I wouldn't want to wake anyone up," Catra says. "And I think I know just the place."

It's a bit of a walk, but Catra leads Adora to C'yra's secret place. The glowing mushrooms give off enough light Catra can finally dispel the glowing ball in her hand. She turns around to watch Adora's reaction as she walks in.

"Wow," Adora gasps. "How did you find this place?"

"C'yra showed me," Catra says. "But I don't think she'd mind me telling you."

"Really?" Adora checks. "I don't think I'd want to chance getting on her bad side after seeing how she fights . . ."

Catra laughs, "I'm sure. She's more relaxed than you think."

"So," Adora sits down on a nearby rock. "You wanted to talk about a nightmare?"

"Yeah," Catra sits next to her, their shoulders barely brushing. Now that they're here, she hesitates for some reason. It feels like it's been forever since she could confide in Adora like this . . .

Adora seems to understand her feelings, and says, "Remember when we were really young, and you'd have nightmares, but you could never remember what they were about? And when you woke up, you were nearly inconsolable. I had to calm you down before Shadow Weaver heard. Eventually, you stopped having those nightmares . . ."

Catra had nearly forgotten those dreams, filled with faceless figures and an unfamiliar warmth. It wasn't that the dreams themselves were scary, it was waking up in the Horde feeling like she had just lost something. She wonders if those dreams were the remnants of her memories of Purrsia, echoes of the life Shadow Weaver took from her.

"It's not like that," Catra says. "I've been having dreams of . . . of the Horde invading Half Moon. Capturing kits, killing my friends, burning down the forests. And I can't do anything."

"I have dreams like that too," Adora says. Catra looks at her in surprise, she just thought Adora would understand the overwhelming totality of the Horde, not the dream itself. "Except for me, it's Bright Moon."

"I'm sorry," Catra says. She's the one who did lead an assault on Bright Moon, and though it was foiled it was so close to being successful.

"You don't have to apologize again," Adora says, taking Catra's hand and squeezing it. "I know. And it's not you in those dreams, it's Hordak himself leading the assault."

"Ha! Like he ever leaves the Fright Zone," Catra tries to joke.

"I suppose," Adora shrugs. "But it's still frightening."

For Catra, it's Shadow Weaver as the ever-present boogeyman of her dreams, "I know the feeling . . . how do you deal with these dreams?"

"Well," Adora says. "It helps knowing that I'm not alone, once I'm awake." Catra can agree with that, she has her mothers and her friends now, but they're the people she's worried about protecting. "I'll have the Princess Alliance to back me up when things get rough."

Okay, Catra can't agree with *that*.

"You know, Catra," Adora continues. "You should come back to Etheria, and join the Princess Alliance-"

"Absolutely not," Catra says, standing up.

Adora stares at her, "Why not?"

"Because," Catra says. Why doesn't she want to join the Princess Alliance? Do her own apprehensions even matter anymore when she is a Princess? She grips her head as she says, "Because I can't!"

"That's not a real reason," Adora argues. "It doesn't matter that you were in the Horde, you've changed! You can be Half Moon's representative for the Princess Alliance, and we can work together to take the Horde down!"

"I can't leave Half Moon," Catra says. Her mothers are here. All her friends are here. And right now, Adora's here too. "What about my friends?" The nightmare must still be on her mind, as she continues, "Who would protect them if the Horde invaded?"

"That's why you should join the Princess Alliance," Adora says, standing up and taking her hands. Catra wants to rip them away, but Adora's stronger than her, "So we can stop the Horde before they even think about coming back here. Don't you want to stop the Horde too? After everything they've done?"

After all the people they've hurt, all the people they plan to hurt, all of the hurt they caused Catra and Adora, "Of course I do! Sometimes I wonder if the only way to stop these nightmares is to make sure the Horde can never hurt anyone again! Like they hurt me! And . . . and . . ." she must be sleep deprived as all these thoughts leave her, "I want revenge. Not just for what they did to me. For Half Moon too. For all the Magicats lost in the Invasion."

She hates how this makes her feel. She wants to give Hordak a taste of his own medicine and make him choke. She

wants to kill Shadow Weaver to make sure she can never hurt anyone again. She thought she was getting better, but now it just feels like her anger has shifted to a new target, one that may actually deserve her ire. Even then, what would happen once the Horde is gone?

"I feel the same way, and I won't rest until the Horde is defeated, so we can both have peace of mind," Adora says. She squeezes Catra's hands, "And if you join me in the Princess Alliance, I know that we can do it together."

"Adora," Catra sighs. "The Princess Alliance . . . it reminds me too much of what I was. How it represented everything I hated. I just . . . don't know. Would the others even accept me? I don't think I'm even on Shimmer's good side yet."

"I want you there," Adora says. "So they'll have to deal with it."

Adora is looking at her so hopefully, but Catra isn't ready. She feels stuck to Half Moon, not that she minds that, because all of her growth has been here. Her family is here. The world outside of Purrsia has been scarred by her own actions. Would they truly accept her as the Magicats have?

"If you're not ready, don't worry," Adora says, reading her mind. "But, will you think about it?"

"I guess," Catra says, not really feeling like promising this. However, it will probably be on her mind in the coming days. Adora and the others have got to be leaving soon, right?

"Good," Adora smiles. "Glimmer and I will be talking to the Magicat Council tomorrow about the Princess Alliance, and I couldn't think of anyone better to represent the Magicats on the Alliance."

Catra's eyes go wide. She has only told Scorpia that she's the Magicat Princess, so how did she end up in this position

anyways, “You sure you don’t want Busto? He’s the Jellicle Ball Champion after all.”

“Yeah, but he’s not you,” Adora insists.

“Of course,” Catra steps back. “This is only if the Council agrees to join.” Which, they most likely won’t. She knows at least half of the people on the Council, and they all would put the Magicat’s own secrecy and safety over the defeat of the Horde.

“Right,” Adora agrees. “So, do you feel better?”

The answer’s no, but Catra swallows and says, “Yeah. You should get to sleep if you’ve got an important meeting tomorrow.”

“Do you want me to walk you to your room?” Adora asks.

“I’ll be fine,” Catra waves her off. “However, you’re gonna need me to guide you to yours, or else you’re going to get lost.”

“That’s fair,” Adora chuckles.

Catra summons another ball of light as they leave the glowing mushroom cave, and they quietly make small talk as they walk. She can tell Adora’s getting tired, by how her words are slightly slurring.

“Well, good night,” Adora mutters at a fork in the road. C’yra and Rita’s quarters are one way, and Adora’s going the other. She takes Catra’s hand, “You promise you’ll think about the Princess Alliance?”

“I’ll think about it,” Catra says, avoiding the word promise. “Good night, Adora.”

Catra silently slips back into her room and slides into bed, but as she stares at the ceiling, sleep refuses to come to her. The offer to join the Princess Alliance, the fact that Adora could be

leaving soon though it feels like they've barely just begun again, and her own statement of revenge to the Horde play over and over again in her mind. Maybe she can finally sleep once the Horde is gone . . .

Chapter End Notes

Please consider leaving a comment, I know I'm not great at responding but I do read and appreciate every single one. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Thank-you for reading and I hope you all have a good day!

As for next time . . . we'll get to see my favorite interlude I've written so far.

Interlude VI: Glimmer

Chapter Summary

Glimmer approaches the Magicat Council to see if they will join the Rebellion.

Chapter Notes

I don't know what it is about Glimmer's perspective that just makes me write a whole bunch, but here we go! Also, sorry for the delay in the update, I was super tired yesterday. Anyways, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer takes a deep breath as she stares at the doors to the Magicat Council room. A week ago, she asked C'yra if she could meet with the Magicat Council. C'yra (who looked uncomfortable talking to her alone) agreed without asking any questions. And now . . . she's going to ask the Magicats to join the Rebellion.

"Okay, one last time," Bow says, glancing down at the notecard she made. "Who is the Cleric of Lyses on the Council?'

"Griz of Skim'shanks."

"Head Chef?"

"Jen'dots of Rum'tug."

"Head Merchant?"

"T'ggr of B'nce."

"The citizen's representative?"

"M'wth of Ter'ocket, she's a jeweler, but her term will be up in a month. Then the citizens will vote on a new

representative."

"I think you're good," Bow says, handing the notecard back to her. "Do you remember what you want to say?"

"I'm going talk about how I've always admired the Magicat's warriors and magical abilities-calling upon my relationship to my own father who was a mage and friends with Ri'ta, talk about the progress Bright Moon and more importantly the Rebellion has made since they last had contact with the mainland, and then ask them to join the Rebellion," Glimmer says.

"And if that doesn't work," Adora says, summoning the Sword of Protection. "We'll show them She-Ra. She-Ra always works."

"Uhm . . . technically didn't us helping the other Princesses with the Horde win them over, not just She-Ra?" Bow points out.

"The Magicats are warriors, Bow, they'll respect a warrior like She-Ra," Glimmer argues.

"C'yra fought Adora to a stand-still," Bow says. "And their General can go toe-to-toe with C'yra."

Adora's face falls at the memory, but Glimmer says, "Stop it! We don't need the negativity going in!"

"Right," Bow says, face set. "You two are going to kill it in there!"

"Yes, you'll do great!" Busto says. Glimmer nearly teleports away, surprised at his arrival. He said he was going to be attending the Council meeting, but he managed to sneak in, "By the way, the Council is waiting for you, Princess Glimmer"

Glimmer squares her shoulders and turns to the door Busto holds open. She marches in, head held high, Adora

following close behind with the Sword of Protection holstered at her side. Busto closes the door and follows them, announcing, "Presenting her highness, Princess Glimmer of Bright Moon and her companion, Adora of Bright Moon!"

All eyes are on her as she steps up to the Council table. There are eleven Magicats in total, including the Queens, the General of the Army, the heads of the factions, and a citizen's representative. There's a familiar face of Gr'wliger, Catra's friends, and the Queens. The two sit next to each other in high-backed chairs, directly across from the space Glimmer is standing. Ri'ta gives Glimmer an encouraging smile and nod, while C'yra gives her a cold stare.

"Princess Glimmer," C'yra begins, her voice steely. It reminds her of the voice her mother uses during Rebellion meetings and when conducting court. That must be a Queen thing. "On behalf of the Council, I welcome you. Allow me to introduce you to the other members of the Council."

Okay so, she memorized all that for nothing. C'yra goes through the members, starting with General Az'al on her right, following with Deut'ron the advisor and Cleric of Saz, Gr'wliger, Theo the Head Shepherd, Gus the Head Scholar, M'wth the citizen's representative, T'ggr the Head Merchant, Jen'dots the Head Chef, Griz the Cleric of Lyses, and ending with Ri'ta.

"It's an honor to stand before you all today," Glimmer begins. "I remember the stories my father, the late King Micah, told me of the Magicats, from their mighty warriors to their clever mages, and all of Bright Moon was disheartened when we heard of the Fall of Purrsia. However, I know that my mother, Queen Angella, will be delighted to hear of your survival-"

"You cannot tell anyone," Gus hisses, surprising Glimmer. "Letting you Etherians in here is already dangerous, and loose lips sink ships. The more people that know of us, the more likely the Horde can find out about us."

"Queen Angella can be trusted, Gus," Ri'ta says. "And so can her daughter. What I'd like to know is how Bright Moon has been faring in the years we've been in hiding."

This is a jump in her script, but Glimmer takes it in stride, "The years after the dissolution of the original Princess Alliance was rough, and our Rebellion barely held back the Horde. However recently, the tides seem to be turning in our favor, starting with the arrival of She-Ra. Princess Perfuma of Plumeria, Princess Mermista of Salineas, and Princess Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows have all joined the Princess Alliance. We're stronger than ever and making headway against the Horde along with deciphering First One's technology-"

"Bah, *First Ones*," Griz, the Cleric of Lyses, grumbles. Glimmer figures it would not be a good idea to go down that path, since the Magicats have a different view of the First Ones.

"-And together I believe we could take down the Evil Horde, once and for all," Glimmer concludes.

The Magicats of the Council seem surprised at her statement. Afterall, if the mighty Magicats of Purrsia couldn't defeat the Horde, what could a bunch of furless Etherians do against them? At least they're furless Etherians with magic powers.

"Well," C'yra says. "We will look forward to that day, if you are ever able to accomplish your goal."

"You don't have to just sit back and wait," Glimmer says. "The United Tribes could help us and join the Rebellion."

The mood of the room shifts, and tension fills the air. C'yra herself sits up straight and glares at Glimmer, shaking her head. It's a warning, to stop and recover before she causes more damage. However, Glimmer isn't going back.

"With your aid, combined with the current strength of the Rebellion and Princesses, we'd have an army that could rival that

of the Horde," Glimmer continues. "And-"

"Preposterous!" Gus exclaims. "All that would do is bring the Horde back to our doorstep!"

"And we don't have any extra soldiers to provide the Rebellion," General Az'al says as she quickly writes something down on a page before her. "All of our forces would need to be here in case of another Horde Invasion."

"But you would have back-up now!" Glimmer jumps in. "She-Ra and the Princesses would be able to come and aid you, to drive the Horde away. With the First One's technology, we can communicate at a moment's notice-"

"We don't need any 'First Ones Technology' here," Griz says. "The Three Stars are all we have ever needed."

"And would you really be able to arrive that quickly?" Gr'wliger asks softly, his low voice reverberating through the room. He's been kind to the Princess Alliance so far, Glimmer's a bit surprised he's speaking against them. "Sea Hawk's boat is an impressive vessel, but even that cannot travel leagues of ocean at a moment's notice. Besides, if the Horde were to attack us, we would have bigger problems. We would no longer be able to hunt on the surface to supplement our food supply and keep down the beast population. We would have to ration the food from the farms we have down here, and the beasts would have free reign of all the food they want, further spiraling out of control."

"I agree with Gr'wliger," Theo says. "Our farms would not be able to keep up with the population of Half Moon forever-and heaven forbid, if the Horde finds our food supplies . . . we'd starve."

"Just like last time," Jen'dots adds quietly. "We almost starved. How many of us went without food so our kits could eat?"

"Rationing would be bad for business too," T'ggr says. "Last time, we had to find ways to reduce the metal consumption, and we don't even have an active mine anymore. How much would we have to give up preparing for another war?"

"We also don't have a Princess," M'wth points out. Az'al, Gr'wliger, Duet'ron and Gus all spare a look at C'yra and Ri'ta, but both remain emotionless. "Don't you have to have a Princess to join the Princess Alliance?"

"No, we'll protect anyone-whether they have a Princess or not," Glimmer insists. "As long as they ask for our help."

"How successful have you truly been so far in repelling the Horde?" Az'al asks curiously.

"Very! When the Horde hijacked the Runestones and attempted to invaded Bright Moon, we were able to repel them with the combined forces of the Princesses and She-Ra," Glimmer explains. She's getting a few blank stares from the Council members, so she steps back to give Adora the floor. "And for those who have not seen She-Ra yet or doubt her strength, Adora."

Adora nods, drawing the Sword of Protection and raising it above her head, "FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

With a burst of color, Adora transforms into She-Ra. She stands with her hands on her hips in front of the Council, and Glimmer knows she's trying to show off her muscles with the way she's flexing her arms.

"That was . . ." M'wth begins. ". . . *Bright*."

Unlike what Glimmer was hoping for, the Magicats don't seem too impressed.

"This is a First One's thing, isn't it?" Griz growls.

“Didn’t C’yra fight ‘She-Ra’ to a draw the other day?” Az’al asks.

“Uh . . . we did spar-” Adora says. “. . . And we did tie.”

“If the best of what you have to offer matches the best of what we have to offer, and we weren’t able to defeat the Horde,” Gus says. “Then what hope do you have to defeat them?”

Glimmer is left, mouth hanging open. Adora has magic, and C’yra doesn’t, but Ri’ta has magic and is equal with C’yra. That would be a losing argument.

“Why are we wasting time talking in circles?” T’ggr says as Glimmer tries to come up with an argument. “I have a feeling we all agree on this subject.”

“I think the only people who would disagree are those dead set on entering Saz’s realm,” Griz continues. “We cannot let our children let themselves get killed for glory. What say you Deut’ron?”

“As a Cleric of Saz . . .” Duet’ron says. “I cannot in good faith agree with something that may lead to war. As much as Saz encourages our skills as warriors, I know they would not want us to throw ourselves into something so hopeless.”

“But it’s not hopeless!” Glimmer tries to argue, but she’s beginning to lose confidence in herself. She knew that the Magicats had lost a lot, but she didn’t know that people *starved*. “The Princess Alliance and the Rebellion are stronger than ever! She-Ra has been a source of hope for people all of Etheria, let us give you hope too!”

“I think we’ve all heard enough,” C’yra says, steel cut into her voice. Neither she nor Ri’ta have said a word since Glimmer made her proposition. “All for joining the Rebellion?”

No hands go up, and Glimmer’s stomach drops.

"All against joining the Rebellion?" C'yra asks. Everyone's hands go up, including C'yra's and Ri'ta's. C'yra turns to Glimmer, "It is unanimous. The United Tribes of Purrsia will not be joining the Rebellion."

"Understood," Glimmer says. "Thank-you all for your time, but I hope you all reconsider it."

C'yra stares hard at Glimmer, "I don't think we will be."

"Uhg!" Glimmer crashes on the bed in the room she's been sharing with Adora and Bow. "It was a massacre!"

"It couldn't have been that bad," Bow tries to comfort her.

"It was that bad," Adora counters. "They weren't even impressed by *She-Ra*."

"Oo, that is bad," Bow hisses. "But you'll always have another chance to convince them!"

"No I won't, when I asked them to reconsider it C'yra said '*I don't think we will be*'," Glimmer tries to impersonate the Queen, but that just earns her a snort from behind.

Scorpia and Catra have snuck in, the latter looking a bit sleep deprived if the dark bags underneath her eyes are anything to go by. Catra continues, "Is that your impression of C'yra? It's way off."

"I really don't need your sass right now, Catra," Glimmer growls. "And it's not like you can do any better."

Catra's smirk fades as her expression turns serious, mouth drawn together in a small frown, ears straight up, and brows furrowed slightly. When she speaks, she does it in a slightly deeper tone, "'*I am Queen C'yra of D'riluth the Third, Leader of*

the United Tribes of Purrsia, and I don't think we will be.'" Once done, the smirk returns, "How was that?"

"That was . . ." Adora says. Catra's impression was much more accurate than Glimmer was expecting, she wonders if Catra just has a gift or has been spending a lot of time around Queen C'yra, "Accurate."

"Yeah, you almost convinced me there too for a second, wildcat," Scorpia says.

"You almost even looked like C'yra then too!" Bow adds.

For some reason, Catra freezes at his statement, but Glimmer ignores it, "That's just because you're a Magicat, you have an advantage."

"I think I could do a pretty good Ri'ta too," Catra offers. "Or Duet'ron."

"Nope, I don't need to hear anything else from you," Glimmer groans and buries her head in the pillow. She can't handle the failure with the Magicat Council and Catra's shit in the same day.

"Well, we just wanted to see how the meeting with the Magicat Council went," Scorpia says, sitting on Bow's empty bed, while Catra moves to sit next to Adora. "But it doesn't look like it went great."

"No," Adora sighs. "They voted against joining the Rebellion. It was unanimous."

"Knew it," Catra says. Glimmer grabs a pillow and throws it at her, but Adora knocks it down. Catra probably would have dodged it anyways.

"Why are the Magicats like this!?" Glimmer groans, to no one in particular. "You'd think that after everything the Horde did

to them, they'd at least want some sort of revenge! Or to get out of these Caves and back onto the surface!"

Catra stares at her intently, the yellow and blue eyes unblinking as her tail lashes out behind her. She doesn't want to know what Catra is thinking, so she turns over and faces the wall. Maybe Catra will soon leave so she can wallow in peace.

"Glimmer."

She rolls over in an instant. Catra never says her name right.

"What?" Glimmer asks, but it's more of an accusation.

"I know you lost your father," Catra begins. "But everyone in Half Moon lost *something*. Parents, children, loved ones, limbs, sense of security, faith . . . and it's hard for someone like me who can't . . . may have been too young to remember, to explain it. You should talk to someone who did. It could give you perspective."

"Perspective," Glimmer repeats.

When she entered the Council Meeting, she was only looking at this from the standpoint of the Rebellion. She doesn't remember the failure of the First Princess Alliance like her mother did, which might make her more reckless. But the Princess Alliance is back together and the Rebellion recently has had multiple victories under their belt. She was looking at Purrsia joining the Rebellion like a Princess-not like a Magicat. And she doesn't know what that looks like. That's . . . actually good advice, and she's shocked it's coming from Catra.

Glimmer teleports across the room behind Catra and Adora, spooking the former. She grabs Catra's shoulder and demands, "Where can I get this perspective? Who can I talk to? Do I need to read some books from the library?"

Catra was not expecting this barrage of questions, and barely looks like she's comprehending what Glimmer's saying. She blinks once, then twice, and grins, "I think you may need to talk to a bureaucratic wunderkind."

"A what?"

Glimmer did not want to see any of the Council Members ever again after the embarrassment of the meeting, but she finds herself being dragged into Gr'wliger's office by Catra not hours afterwards, with Bow, Adora and Scorpia all following them. The head hunter is currently studying a map and occasionally drawing lines over it. He doesn't look up when they enter, he simply says, "Catra, I thought I gave you the day off."

"You did, but," Catra pushes Glimmer in front of her, so she's standing at the foot of his desk, "Glitter has a question for you."

"You said my name fine earlier," Glimmer growls under her breath.

Gr'wliger looks up at Glimmer, his yellow eyes emotionless, "Princess Glimmer, I am sorry we could not give you the response you were looking for at the Council meeting today, but the safety of the Magicats must come first. I hope you understand."

"That's actually why I'm here," Glimmer says. "I don't think I completely understand. I don't know what really happened to the Magicats during the Horde Invasion and afterwards, and Catra pointed out I could use a little perspective. She said you could give it to me."

He stares at her, and she feels his eyes piercing her soul. Softly, he asks, "You want perspective?"

"Yes," Glimmer nods enthusiastically. "Tell me everything about what happened with the Magicats and the Horde."

"Are you sure that you want to hear it from me? I wasn't that old when it happened. There are things that I remember clearly and things that had to be told to me," Gr'wliger warns.

"Catra said you'd be the best," Glimmer says. "Please, tell me."

He doesn't speak for a moment, giving her a chance to back out. But she doesn't, she wants to hear this story.

"It started when the Horde arrived at our shore. Queen Bett'i, C'yra's mother, tried to broker peace by giving herself up. They slaughtered her in front of everyone," Gr'wliger begins. Next to her, Catra's eyes go wide, as if she didn't know that fact. "Then, the war began. We thought that like the Whispering Woods, the beasts would help protect us. Instead, the Horde had technology that somehow scared the beasts away from them and frenzied them at us. We lost about a quarter of our soldiers to the beasts alone.

"We used to be great mages. Great inventors. Great healers. But there's a reason there's only Lionel'o, Ri'ta and Shire left. The Horde targeted the Conservatory and bombed it before going in slaughtering the rest so we couldn't protect ourselves, heal ourselves. The only survivor was Ri'ta, and she didn't make it out completely unscathed.

"Then it had been years since we had a true war. There were eager soldiers, talented but inexperienced, willing to die in the Saz's name, and die they did. Their reckless behavior against the ruthlessness of the Horde was not a good match. We were slaughtered. Eventually, when the losses grew too high, C'yra decided to retreat into the Caves. The Horde leveled our cities and left the frenzied beasts to take care of the rest."

Glimmer knew the Horde was bad . . . but how had she never heard of any of this before? Is the Whispering Woods really the only thing keeping Bright Moon safe from utter annihilation?

This is already so bad, and Gr'wliger hadn't even brought up the fact that people almost *starved* to death.

"Everyone lost someone. Something. You must have at least heard this phrase already," Gr'wliger continues. "Az'al lost her husband and son, who are also Gus's brother and nephew. Jen'dots lost her wife, sister, and brother-in-law, and she raised her daughter and niece on her own. T'ggr watched his employees die in his store when the Horde bombed it. M'wth is the last survivor of her village. Theo was a former soldier, but he was so badly injured during the Fall he had to retire and become a shepherd. Griz had to watch helplessly as the Horde burned the Forests he was supposed to protect. Deut'ron is the last surviving Cleric of Saz, but he's no warrior. He was a *mortician*. He saw everyone who died pass through the Temple, lit the pyres for everyone who died in the chase of the glory of Saz."

Gr'wliger, who is calm in the face of everything Glimmer's seen thrown at him so far, is getting worked up. He suddenly stands and towers over Glimmer, looking down at her, "My family was one of the lucky ones, but I watched my parents *starve* so I could eat. I saw others grow sick and *die* in the caves since we had no healers. I saw kits crying all day because their parents were *dead,* and they had no one to comfort them." Glimmer feels tears threaten to spill at the tragedy of it all, and Gr'wliger must have sensed the shift as he sits down, "But, we survived."

"You didn't mention C'yra and Ri'ta," Catra says quietly.

He stares at her, as if asking permission to continue. She nods, and he sighs, "What pain did they not face together? C'yra's mother died before her eyes, Ri'ta watched all her friends die, C'yra had to send soldiers to their deaths, when we had no food they were always the last to eat, and worst of all, they lost their daughter," Gr'wliger closes his eyes, "The Royal Guard protecting Princess Fel'cty were slaughtered. They say there was so much blood, it was hard to imagine a child surviving that massacre."

When he opens his eyes again, he stares right at Glimmer, as if challenging her. To say that joining the Princess Alliance is still a good idea.

"I didn't . . ." Adora gasps, and Glimmer finally turns away from the hunter. She looks sick, "I didn't know it was *that* bad."

"They did the same to the Tlincalli," Gr'wliger says. Scorpia, looking at the floor, nods at this. "I don't know what has changed since then, but I know the Horde would do it again in a heartbeat."

"Maybe someone got what they wanted," Catra says in a small voice.

"That's . . ." Glimmer tries to find words, but finds none. "That's horrible. I'm so sorry."

"It took years, but we've finally found some semblance of safety and normalcy in the Caves," Gr'wliger says, turning in his seat to a map of the caves of Half Moon, hanging on his office wall. "We have enough soldiers for a standing army again, the combined efforts for the hunters, shepherds and chefs have created a stable food supply, and we have the first healer in the United Tribes in over a decade. No one wants this peace to end."

Glimmer can understand that, after all of the hardship the Magicats faced they're finally at peace, but are they really safe if they feel the need to hide in the Caves? Are they safe if the Horde is still out there? She still wants the Magicats to join the Rebellion- not because it would make them stronger, but so they can get revenge against the Horde and to feel truly safe again.

Catra said she should get perspective. She doesn't just need perspective on the Magicat's past, but also on where they can go next.

"What would have to happen to make you feel safe enough for Purrsia to join the Rebellion?" Glimmer asks.

Gr'wliger and Catra both stare at her, the latter looking shocked that she has the gall to ask this after all the tragedies that happened to the Magicats have been laid bare for her. But, Glimmer needs to know if she even has a chance.

"There would need to be a plan for rapid deployment to Purrsia if the Horde discovers us and returns," Gr'wliger says slowly, thinking over his words carefully. "And how long it would take for you to deploy troops. Next, an alternative, back-up food supply that we could use, or the promise to bring enough rations for everyone."

Glimmer nods as Gr'wliger speaks, and half-way through she realizes she should be writing this down. She grabs a piece of paper and pen off of his desk, writing down everything. This was good shit. When he stops, she looks up, "You have anything else?"

"No," Gr'wliger says. "I believe that covers my basic concerns. And you're going to try and come up with a plan to accommodate all of the Council's concerns and repropose Purrsia entering the Rebellion."

"That obvious?" Glimmer sighs weakly.

He continues to stare before leaning forward, hands collapsed together on the table, "I hope you come up with a *very* good plan. I would like to see the United Tribes join the Rebellion."

"You do?" both Glimmer and Catra exclaims. Only the former continues, "But you voted-"

"Because I have the rest of Half Moon to think about, not just me," Gr'wliger admits. "I dream of the day when we are able to live on the surface again, to connect to the world, to not have to fear the Horde. If we can help you accomplish your goal . . . I would like that, just not at the detriment of Half Moon. There are

others who feel the same as I, but fear overpowers any dreams we may have."

"Then," Glimmer says, clutching the paper with both of her hands. "I'm going to do my best."

"Thank-you," Gr'wliger says, a small smile finally breaking out on his face. "Is there anything else I can help you with today?"

"No, but thank-you for your insight and perspective," Glimmer says. "We'll let you get back to work."

They all vacate out of Gr'wliger's office, and though Glimmer has found a positive in this-Adora and Scorpia are both looking pretty shaken up. Catra's staring at Glimmer with some unreadable expression, so she ignores her.

"So, I guess we're staying in Half Moon a little longer," Bow says. "I don't know how happy your mom will be about that."

"She'll be thrilled once I get an alliance with the United Tribes," Glimmer says. "Now, I've just got to talk to everyone on the Council."

Catra snorts, "I love your takeaway from being told about a massacre that has scared everyone is to try and recruit those traumatized people into your alliance."

"How else are they going to feel safe again, Catra?" Glimmer counters. "If we don't get rid of the Horde, the Magicats are going to be stuck in Half Moon, forever, living in fear. Though the Princess Alliance is strong, we're even stronger together."

She and Catra stare at each other, and Catra's the first to break. She pinches the bridge of her nose and sighs, "I don't know if it's because I'm sleep deprived, but I think I'm going to say something crazy, and you can expect me to never say this again."

"Just spit it out," Glimmer says.

"You're right. I want in," Catra says.

"Wait, hold on," Glimmer grins. "Can you say that first part again?"

"No, because I'm pretty sure I only said that because I'm exhausted and can't think properly," Catra says. "But I want in on your plan."

"Why?"

"I didn't know the full story, either," Catra admits, crossing her arms across her chest and looking away. "So, maybe I need a little more perspective too. Plus . . . I think this is just something I need to do for myself."

Glimmer doesn't entirely understand Catra's reasoning, but as much as she hates to admit it, Catra was a master strategist in the Horde. She's smart and she's cunning, plus she has more of an insight into Magicat culture than Glimmer. She's close to the Queens, who despite being silent the whole meeting may be her biggest opposition.

"Okay," Glimmer agrees, holding out her hand. "But, you better not be a piece of shit the entire time we work together."

Catra smirks as she takes Glimmer's hand, "No promises . . . and no take backs."

Well, this would be interesting. Despite the humiliation at the Council meeting, Glimmer feels a renewed determination is getting the Magicats to join the Rebellion. Hopefully, Catra actually wants to help with her plan, rather than deter it.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading and please consider leaving a comment! I'm not great at replying, but I read and appreciate all of them. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. I hope you all have a good day!

Interlude VII: Sea Hawk

Chapter Summary

Hey, what has Sea Hawk been doing this entire time?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You know," Sea Hawk says. "I'm beginning to think that they've forgotten about me."

Chapter End Notes

. . . that's it that's the update

nothing last forever, some things weren't meant to be, but you'll never find the answers, until you set your old heart free

Chapter Summary

Catra has an existential crisis and somehow gets the best advice from Demeter.

Chapter Notes

Regarding the last chapter: you all understood the assignment. good job.

Also, sorry about the delay in this chapter! Hopefully, we'll be back on track for the rest of the summer. If any other delays happen, I'll try to keep you all informed on my Twitter @Sniperdoodle12.

Otherwise, please enjoy this chapter!

Chapter title: Hello My Old Heart, the Oh Hellos

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra is starting to regret her sleep-deprived fueled decision.

During her break the next day, she's sitting with Glimmer, Bow and Adora in their room. Growing up with Adora, she was used to her over-the-top planning, obsessing over finding every angle and possibility in a battle to ensure success. The nerd does that with everything, even mundane things like chores. It's endearing. However, that doesn't prepare her for Glimmer's style of winging it.

"So I think we should talk to Gus first," Glimmer says, with no plans aside from the sheet of paper she scribbled while

talking to Gr'wliger yesterday. "As a scholar, he's probably super knowledgeable-"

"Don't talk with Gus first," Catra interrupts. "He has a vitriolic hatred of the Horde. Won't listen to reason until you have a better plan than the scraps Gr'wliger gave you."

"Then maybe General Az'al?" Glimmer suggests.

"Uhg, no," Catra groans. "If we're going to be collecting information, we should do it in a particular order so that we can build on what we have to convince the next. Gus is definitely one of the last ones, but Az'al should be towards the front half, just not first, so we can get insight on the current operations of the military and what supplies they have."

"Catra's right, we can't just wing this," Adora says. She looks eager to pull out paper, tacks, and string to form a plan. "We should know what we can and can't talk about with each Council member first, so we don't accidentally offend someone."

"Which we can get from either Busto or Gr'wliger," Catra says. "Busto is well-liked by everyone and Gr'wliger already has an idea about what we're doing."

Glimmer glares at Catra, "You better not be encouraging Adora's over-planning."

"We need to over-plan in this case," Catra argues. "If you truly want to get on the Council's good side."

"Fine," Glimmer huffs. "Can you at least tell me who you think we should talk to first?"

"Easy, Deut'ron," Catra says with crossed arms. "He's the oldest Magicat in Half Moon, very wise, and easy-going. He also acts as the advisor to the Queens. Perfect first target."

"Are you sure?" Bow asks. "Gr'wliger said that he worked as a mortician during the war. He might not be willing."

"Bow, I know him better than you do," Catra says. "If you want perspective, he's got loads, of course."

"I agree, he sounds like the kind of person we should be talking to first," Adora agrees.

"Okay, Duet'ron first," Glimmer agrees. "Then . . . Griz?"

Catra sighs, "Are you just listing them randomly?"

"Maybe?"

Oh, this was going to be a long day.

And even then, Catra wasn't too sure why she was helping Glimmer. She still isn't sold on the Princess Alliance, but their goals align.

When she dragged Sparkles to talk with Gr'wliger, she wasn't expecting to be getting a dose of perspective herself. Now that she knows how much the Magicats truly have hurt, she wants to help them. She wants them to maintain the safety they currently have while also trying to get back some hope . . . and maybe a little revenge.

Like her, it seems that the people of Half Moon will only breathe easy once the Horde is gone. Though they have settled, everyone is still watching their backs and waiting for the other shoe to drop. The Horde could in fact return at any time at Hordak's whim, and what will protect them if they do?

Glimmer thinks the answer is the Princess Alliance, but Catra isn't too sure. That's why she wants to help, to see what they can come up with.

At least she gets to spend time with Adora.

"Okay," Glimmer shouts after about an hour of planning. Bow stopped paying attention twenty minutes ago, tinkering with

his arrows, as Catra and Adora dominated the conversation. “This is too much, let’s just do it!”

“It’s not too much!” Adora argues. The floor is covered with paper, as she and Catra cover what they can and can’t mention with each member of the Council, as well as topics they may have to prepare for each (Catra also made sure that the ‘missing’ Princess was a big no-no, just so she didn’t have to deal with it).

“Yeah, do you want to fuck up like you did during the Council meeting again?” Catra tries to argue.

“At this point, I’m too bored to care,” Glimmer grabs Catra’s arm and hauls her to her feet.

“Hey! No touching!” Catra hisses.

“Take me to Deut’ron now before I fall asleep,” Glimmer demands.

“Fine,” Catra agrees. “But then we’re coming right back here.”

“Whatever,” Glimmer rolls her eyes.

Oh yeah, Catra was already regretting this.

Over the next few days, Catra continues to question her decisions. She and Glimmer talk with Deut’ron, Jen’dots, Theo and T’ggr. Most of their concerns revolved around food supply, and they were able to build off of each person they talked to. The conversations end well, but she hates how Glimmer handles them. Though she has gotten perspective on how the Magicats view the Rebellion, she still doesn’t fully understand them.

Their next target is General Az’al, and though the General has been kinder to her, Catra still feels slightly apprehensive. That’s why Catra came up with a plan: ambush Az’al while she’s

talking with Busto. He doesn't quite know what she's doing but he'll be a calming presence for both parties.

When Catra told Glimmer this, her response was, "That's stupid."

Catra frowns, "Why is that stupid?"

"Why are we waiting for a specific moment when we could just ask him to come with us?" Glimmer asks.

"It has to be natural," Catra insists. "And it's not like we would be waiting forever. Busto usually talks with General Az'al after training on Tuesday's and Thursday's, right before lunch. We just have to wait until tomorrow."

Glimmer stares at Catra, "I'm not doing that," and brushes past her.

"Saz dammit Glimmer," Catra hisses to herself, she wonders whether she should be glad Bow isn't here or not. If he was, he could reign Glimmer in, but he would take offense to the string of profanities Catra spews as she rushes after Glimmer.

At the training grounds, soldiers are running through drills. Off to the side, Busto and D'nah are talking, and Glimmer marches straight up to them and butts in before Catra can stop her.

"Tally ho, Princess Glimmer!" Busto greets her with a smile. D'nah just grunts her greeting. "What can we do for you today?"

"I was wondering where General Az'al was," Glimmer says. Catra finally catches up and tries to put a hand over her mouth, but Glimmer teleports three feet away. "I wanted to talk to her."

"But if she's busy I'm sure Princess Shimmer can come back another time," Catra adds, shooting a glare at Glimmer.

Busto stares at Catra and raises an eyebrow, looking for some explanation, "I believe General Az'al is in her office right now, but I must stay here. D'nah, would you show Princess Glimmer to the General's office?"

D'nah doesn't look happy about it but she shrugs and says, "This way."

Catra is about to follow, but Glimmer holds her arm out, "I think I've got this one handled, Catra."

"Oh come on," Catra growls, but Busto puts a hand on her shoulder.

"Why don't we step away as well?" he suggests before she can pick a fight. He looks curious and is probably wondering why she is willingly hanging out with Glimmer-even if they look like they're about to rip each other's throats out.

"Sure," Catra sighs. They ascend to the arena seats about the training area, sitting up at the very top so Busto can still keep an eye on his soldiers.

"So . . ." Busto leans forward, resting his elbows on his knees and head in his hands. "What are you doing?"

"I may be helping Glimmer talk to the Council members to see what would happen for them to agree to joining the Rebellion to see if we can get Purrsia to join the Princess Alliance," Catra explains.

"Oh . . . why?"

"I'm still wondering about that myself."

"Do you want the Magicats to join the Rebellion?" Busto asks.

"I don't know."

Busto presses his hands together in front of his lips, clearly trying to find something to say to help her.

"It's fine," Catra insists. "I guess a better answer to your question is . . . I'm trying to figure out if we should join the Rebellion. I don't want us to be afraid of the Horde forever, after everything they've done to us, and maybe the only way to get rid of that fear is to join the Rebellion. And it has to be the Rebellion because they're the only force on the face of Etheria with any resources to actually go against the Horde. But to join the Rebellion, we'll need a Princess. And I don't know if I'm ready for that yet, even though I feel ready to get rid of the Horde. Does that make any sense?"

Busto thoughtfully nods as she speaks, "It makes sense . . . I think."

"So, what should I do?" she asks.

He continues to nod, and it looks like he's deeply contemplating. There are a few false starts, opening his mouth to speak but he ends up closing it. With a sigh, he determines, "I don't know."

"Oh, thanks a lot," Catra grumbles.

"Catra, I admit that this is a bit outside my wheelhouse," Busto says. "I don't remember much of the Horde, I don't know much about the Rebellion, and I know nothing about being a Princess. But, whatever you do, I'll support your decision as your friend."

As unhelpful as that is, it does feel nice to have his support, "Thank-you, Busto. And I say that as unsarcastically as I can."

"You are welcome," Busto says. His ears perk up as he glances at the arena, where Az'al and Glimmer are entering. "Oh, it looks like the General is in a good mood."

Glimmer's talks with Az'al didn't end with disaster it appears, and Catra can let out the breath she was holding . . . only to suck it back in. If Az'al's on board, they're one step closer to their goal, and Catra's nowhere closer to knowing what she's doing.

Well, at least they have the other half of the Council to get through before any decision can be made.

Busto is right, he doesn't have the experience needed to help her with her problem. So, Catra should go to someone who can, and she knows just the bureaucratic wunderkind.

She plans to talk to Gr'wliger after her morning hunt the next day, but when she enters the common room, Glimmer and Sea Hawk are there, already cornering Gr'wliger.

"-And Sea Hawk knows a bit more about boats," Glimmer says. "Oh, Catra!" she teleports and grabs Catra's arm, dragging her over as Sea Hawk starts to talk about . . . boat speeds? Catra couldn't care less. "There you are! Where were you?"

"Uh . . . doing my job?" Catra counters. "I had the morning hunt. If you were awake when I stopped by this morning, you would have known. Anyways, why are we talking to Gr'wliger?"

"Last night I was talking with Sea Hawk about the Salineas navy, and he mentioned that their fastest boats could get to Beast Island in a week's time, and carry more soldier and supplies," Glimmer says, brimming with excitement. "So, I brought him to Gr'wliger to talk about implementing it as relief for Beast Island, should the need arise. Isn't this great!"

"Yeah," Catra says dryly. "It's super cool."

"I mean, it's not the most exciting thing in the world," Glimmer admits. "But you have to admit, this will be a major point for the Rebellion."

“Sure,” Catra directs her attention to Gr’wliger and Sea Hawk, the head hunter fully engaged in Sea Hawk’s dramatic drivel.

“This could work,” Gr’wliger eventually decides. “This also opens the door to the possibility of the Magicats having sailing vessels of their own again.”

“So?” Glimmer jumps in front of Gr’wliger. “Does the Rebellion have your support?”

“Yes,” Gr’wliger says. “This takes care of most of my concerns. When the Rebellion is brought back up in the Council, you have my vote.”

“Yes!” Glimmer shouts, taking Gr’wliger’s hand and shaking it vigorously. “Thank-you so much!” She spins around to Catra, “Now, we just have to talk to everyone else! I think we should meet with Theo again; he was also concerned with food.”

“You go on ahead,” Catra insists. “And take Sea Hawk with you.”

“Okay!” Glimmer grabs Sea Hawk and the two teleport out of the room.

“Catra,” Gr’wliger says like he’s seeing her for the first time. “Is there anything I can do for you?”

She stares at him, and sighs, “No, I’m good.”

“Are you just going to mope in the infirmary all day or are you actually going to tell me what’s wrong?” Shire asks after the tenth time in a row Catra dramatically sighs. “This is giving me flashbacks to when you broke your leg-and not the good kind.”

Catra rolls onto her back and lets her head hang off the side of the bed, “I have a problem.”

“A medical problem or a problem with your brain?” Shire asks. She walks over and stares down at her, so she appears upside down.

“Well, you see-”

“CATRA!”

“OOF!”

N’yan and Lily both launch themselves at Catra as soon as they come into the room, landing on her stomach and stabbing her with their knobby little elbows. The kits laugh at her pain, the bastards.

“Please, do not hurt Catra, I do not want her as my patient again,” Shire pleads.

“Wow,” Catra lets out a strained grunt. “So that’s how you really feel about me.”

“I adore you as a friend but as a patient you kinda sucked.”

“Caaaaaatra!” N’yan shouts, shaking her shoulder. “Did you know that your blonde hairless friend can turn into a giant woman!”

“It was so cool!” Lily adds.

“Can you also turn into a giant woman because you were from Etheria?” N’yan continues.

“No,” Catra shoves the two kits off of her and onto the bed. She sits up before either one can think of jumping on her again, “I cannot turn into a giant woman, and I do not want to. It’s not even that cool.”

“But, she turned into,” N’yan jumps up and down on the bed. “A! Giant! Woman!”

"Stop jumping on the bed," Shire scolds, but N'yan ignores her.

"How is that not cool?" Lily counters.

"Because," Catra shrugs. "I can take her-"

Shire sputters loudly and cuts Catra off, so N'yan curiously asks, "Like, in a fight?"

"Yeah," Catra turns to Shire, who looks like she just died. "What were you thinking I was gonna say?"

"Nothing, nothing," Shire insists, waving her hand. "I'm just gonna go into the corner and die."

"You really think you can defeat a giant woman in a fight?" N'yan asks, clearly unimpressed.

"I think Catra can do it!" Lily decides. "She saved me from the beast and did really well during the Jellicle Ball! She can do anything!"

"Well," N'yan hops off the bed and grabs Catra's hand. "If you think you can beat her in a fight, then prove it."

"What?" Catra asks as N'yan begins to drag her out of the infirmary, Lily following dutifully while Shire lets her be abducted.

"She's in the training arena as a giant woman right now!" N'yan says. "So you and Adora can fight! If she wins, then clearly a giant woman is better than you."

As much as Catra doesn't want to relive the memories of fighting Adora, desperately trying to *hurt* her . . . she does not want this kit to not think she's cool anymore. She at least spares one more glance to the infirmary, but Shire seems to have moved on to her tasks. She can talk about her princess problems another day.

"Fine," Catra says. "But I'm way cooler than a giant woman."

It's been nearly a week since Catra agreed to help Glimmer with her plans, and despite their progress, Catra is nowhere closer to answering her own question: what should she do?

She's tried to weigh pros and cons, but when they seemed to be equal, she ripped up the lists. Everything she could do would have its downsides and someone she's leaving behind. She's tried seeking advice from her friends, but those that know her secret don't know what to do either. The only resource she hasn't exhausted is her mothers but . . . they're afraid of losing her, she knows they'd want her to stay.

Could she really be a Princess? Being the Princess of the Magicats is nothing like the sparkly nightmare of the Etherian Princesses, and she's basically already started to train as one. But will the people of Purrsia ever see beyond the Horde soldier? A remnant of the forces that leveled their homes, killed their loved ones, and destroyed their way of life.

Could she really join the Rebellion? After everything she's done, all the people's she's hurt . . . would the other Princesses even accept her? And, she might even get arrested when she steps foot in Bright Moon for her Invasion. The Rebellion has done decently so far, they can take on the Horde easily now that Catra and Scorpia are no longer there, but . . . .

Could she really stand by and do nothing? Sit back and enjoy her comfy life in the Caves of Half Moon, blissfully ignorant of the world outside, while the Horde continues to ruin everything in their path? Let them continue to abuse their soldiers and plot to exterminate the Etherians just as they had done to the Sehrah and Tlincalli? Let the Magicats continue to live in fear?

Could she really let Adora go again? Adora's back in her life, and they're on good terms. Even their little play combat to appease Lily and N'yan yesterday brought none of the bad memories of the things they did to each other, they were able to enjoy themselves. If Adora left . . . no, Adora will leave because she has a savoir complex but at least she asked her to come with her this time. When Adora leaves, they'll be a hole left in Catra's life that only she can fill.

That's just the tip of the iceberg of Catra's thoughts.

Before she can dive deeper, something grabs onto her arm and tugs her back.

"Catra," Demeter hisses. "Can you fucking pay attention? You almost walked off a cliff."

"Sorry," Catra sighs, rolling her shoulder once Demeter lets go of her arm. She guesses the middle of a hunt isn't the best place to have an existential crisis. "Guess I have a lot on my mind."

"Well, think about it later," Demeter says. She huffs as she turns around, cloak fluttering in the breeze.

It's not like Catra has any choice. It's the only thing she can seem to think about.

Catra and Demeter return after the sun has passed its peak, though the former wasn't too successful today. It's just the two of them in the barracks, and since Demeter doesn't care, Catra's left with her thoughts.

Until Demeter decides to care.

"Okay, what's wrong?" Demeter sighs. "You look like you have to take a shit."

"I'm fine," Catra growls.

"No you're not," Demeter rolls her eyes.

"I am, and if I wasn't I wouldn't be coming to you for help," Catra insists. "Why do you even care?"

"I'm nosey," Demeter shrugs. "Now, tell me what's wrong or I will have to use my excellent powers of deduction against you."

Catra snorts, "I'd like to see you try."

Demeter smirks, "Well, it's got nothing to do with Adora, since you two made up and *for some reason* she's into you when I'm right here. Or maybe it does since she'll have to leave eventually. Seeing as you used to be in the Horde, I believe that this has to do with the Princess Alliance asking us to join in their war against the Horde. But, it's not because you still think of them as your enemy, or even because you lack a healthy fear of the Horde that every Magicat has, it's because you are the Magicat Princess and you're feeling conflicted."

"Wha-" Catra mouth hands open as she fishes for words. She crosses the room and whispers, "How do you know that?! Did your mom tell you?!"

"Please, Catra," Demeter rolls her eyes. "You follow the Queens around like a lost kit, you look just like C'yra, you have Ri'ta's magic and you have heterochromatic eyes meaning you're royalty. It's not hard."

Catra rests her head against the wall and mutters, "Is it really that obvious?"

"Only if you have eyes and can see," Demeter says.

". . . Fuck."

"So," Demeter says. "Let's see, and since you are obviously the Princess, I assume you're starting to feel some sense of responsibility when it comes to Half Moon-particularly

when it comes to the Horde, since you probably know them better than anyone else."

"How are you so good at this?" Catra groans.

"I read a lot of mystery novels," Demeter shrugs. "But back to you: so the question is really whether you should let Half Moon join the Princess Alliance or not, and because you're the Princess you think that means you have to join in Half Moon allies with them."

"Right," Catra groans and slams her face into her hands.

Demeter lets her sulk for a moment before she asks, "Do you want me to give you some advice?"

"I'm at the end of my rope," Catra mumbles into her hands. "So shoot."

"What do you want?" Demeter asks.

"What do I want?" Catra repeats.

"Yeah," Demeter says. "You can't make a decision unless you know exactly what you want. Two years ago, when I was trying to figure out what job I was going to take, I had to ask myself the same question. What I wanted was different than what my mom wanted: she wanted me to do something safe: like be a chef or something. However, I wanted to help Half Moon and explore. So I joined the hunters. My mom wasn't happy with it, but she came around to it eventually. You have to make a decision that will make you happy, no matter what anyone else wants. That'll be the best path forward. So, what do you want?"

"I want . . ." Catra begins. "I want to stop having nightmares. I want the Horde gone so the Magicats don't have to live in fear. I want to be able to live on Purrsia peacefully. I want Adora."

“Then,” Demeter says. “I think you know what you have to do.”

Catra nods, “I have to become the Princess.”

“Seems like it,” Demeter slaps Catra’s back, “So . . . good fucking luck.”

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading and if you like the story, leave a comment! I appreciate every comment even if I'm not great at responding to them. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Thank-you once again and have a good day!

when the working day is done oh girls they want to have fun

Chapter Summary

Catra wants to tell Adora she's the Princess but gets sidetracked.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra has a plan. She spent all night coming up with everything she needs to do in order to become the Princess of Half Moon. The first step is to tell Adora.

Now, in all honesty, she could do this at any time. She should really tell C'yra and Ri'ta that she actually wants to be the Princess now, but for some reason that thought scares her for the reasons she *wishes* to become the Princess. She knows they're afraid of losing her, and isn't quite sure how to handle it. This secret has been rattling around in her brain for so long, and she wants to tell her best friend first.

Of course, she doesn't want to tell her inside of Half Moon where anyone could hear-especially Glimmer-so she'll just have to get Adora away for a while.

"Hey Adora," Catra finds her outside the training arena, leaving for the day.

"Catra," Adora smiles when she sees her. "Have you had lunch yet? I'm about to head to the cafeteria."

"Not yet," Catra admits. "But I wanted to ask you something first. You know how I've been researching the Three Stars and the First Ones?"

"Yeah?"

"Well, I was wondering if you'd like to come with me to the Temple of Saz to try and read the stuff in there," Catra says. "I have the day off tomorrow and-"

"CATRA!" Sh'dowell shouts, running up to both of them. She glares at them, but they don't get the message, "I made a new game!"

"This better not be knife monopoly two," Catra sighs.

"Oh no, I already tried to make knife monopoly two, electric boogaloo, but it didn't catch on," Sh'dowell says. They basically are vibrating with excitement, bouncing on the balls of their feet. "This is better!"

"Is anyone liable to get hurt?" Catra continues.

"Most likely," Sh'dowell says. "But it has 100% less blades than knife monopoly one or two."

Catra sighs, "Okay, let's hear it."

Sh'dowell takes a deep breath, "So, this game takes two teams of two. Each team has to try and get both players over the other team's camp without getting tagged or touching the ground."

It sounds like an old Horde exercise-one of the more fun ones, and a glance from Adora let's Catra know she's thinking the same. But, knowing Sh'dowell, there's going to be some type of catch, "Okay, it's not bad so far."

"*But*," Sh'dowell raises a finger in Catra's face and smirks. "This game can be played anywhere, at any time. If anyone on either team says 'impossible', they have to get off of the floor and declare wherever they're standing as the camp. You get a point if you take the other's camp, or if the other players are all out. The first to ten points wins, and you have to wait at least five hours before you can declare another round."

“Couldn’t you get in trouble?” Adora asks. “If you were suddenly climbing on the furniture around you?”

“You just *don’t* get in trouble,” Sh’dowell says. “That’s part of the fun.”

“Hhm,” Catra taps her chin, thinking it over. “Could be interesting. I think it needs a trial run and some hard rules on where and where you cannot play the game.”

“So, that means you want to help me play test it?” Sh’dowell asks with a grin.

“I didn’t say that.”

“You basically said that,” Sh’dowell insists. “Come on Catra, it’ll be fun!”

With how stressed she’s been recently with helping Glimmer, having her own existential crisis, and committing to telling her secret to Adora, she could use a stress reliever. She sighs, “Fine. And-” Catra wraps her arm around Adora’s. “-You’ll help too, right Adora?”

“Wait, what?” Adora blinks. “But what if we get in trouble?”

“Just don’t,” Catra repeats, and flicks her forehead.

Sh’dowell rubs their hands together, “Alright, that’s three players-”

“-I didn’t say yes,” Adora argues.

“Who else?”

Catra glances around, and the perfect target sulks by. Thom still likes to stick to the shadows of Half Moon, despite turning over a new leaf. Not everyone is willing to trust him. She smirks and shouts, “Thom!”

“Huh, what!?” Thom jumps out of his skin. He must have been lost in his thoughts, worse than usual. “Oh, Catra. Whaddya want?”

“You want to play a game?” she asks.

“Uh, I guess?” Thom scratches his head as he comes over. “What type of game?”

“No takes backs,” Catra says first, and turns to Sh’dowell. “What is this game called anyways?”

“I call it,” Sh’dowell pauses for dramatic effect. “‘Impossible’.”

Thom scrunches his nose, “Why would I want to play a game called ‘Impossible’, it sounds like no one can win.”

“No take backs,” Catra reminds him.

“Wait, if you and him said it,” Adora says. “Does that mean we have to start?”

“What?” Thom says. “I don’t even know the rules and we’re starting?”

“I’ll explain it,” Sh’dowell says.

“No,” Catra grins. “I think we should begin. Thom, you’re with me, Adora you and Sh’dowell can be on a team.”

Adora pouts, “We don’t get to be on a team?”

“It’s balanced with way,” Catra says. “We’d cream Thom and Sh’dowell if we were together.”

“Hey!” Sh’dowell exclaims.

“True,” Thom shrugs. “So, what the fuck are we even doing-fuck!”

Catra slings Thom over her shoulder and jumps on a near-by table, “Can we move around before we claim our camp?”

“Our what?”

Sh’dowell clings to the wall, while Adora jumps up and grabs the doorway into the training arena, “Sure, five minute limit.”

“You just made that up.”

“Maybe.”

“Then let’s head to the training area,” Catra says. “And Thom?”

“Yeah?”

“Don’t touch the floor.”

“Wha-” Catra tosses him through the doorway, past Adora and onto a near-by banister. “FUCK STOP THROWING ME! YOU’RE NOT THAT BIGGER THAN ME!? HOW ARE YOU DOING THIS?!””

And so, the first game of Impossible has begun.

Sh’dowell has struck gold with ‘Impossible’ because it’s actually quite fun to play . . .

. . . If only they weren’t a hinderance on everyone else.

That’s the game’s biggest downfall, the variability of the setting and all of the unwitting participants. The training arena was fine because there wasn’t anyone in there at the time, and the equipment allowed them to hop around. The market caused a bit of disruption, and most vendors weren’t too happy about them trapezing over their stalls, but after the third time they seemed to give up. The library was the most unfortunate victim, as Sh’dowell

surprised Catra, Thom and Adora while they were working. While Ri'ta thought it was funny, Gus was not amused.

Then there was the fact it could be played at any time. It was funny when they accidentally said it in the cafeteria and immediately had to hop up onto the table, but Catra once said 'Impossible' on a hunt while complaining and Sh'dowell made her drop everything to play.

Otherwise, it's incredibly fun.

Despite how annoyed everyone else is.

"You guys are going to get hurt!" Bow argues with Sh'dowell as they walk through the market, though a game is not in progress. Somehow, Bow only found out about it yesterday since he's been busy helping Glimmer. "Or get in trouble!"

"Listen, Thom already fell from the highest shelf in the library and he's fine, so you don't have to worry," Catra waves her hand, trying to dissuade Bow.

"I landed on Gus," Thom explains.

Bow loudly sighs, "Adora, please tell me you can stop this madness."

She blinks at him, "But it's fun."

He gasps and turns back to Catra, "You've corrupted her."

"I've done nothing of the sort," Catra crosses her arms. "I've just reminded her that she can be fun."

"I have to agree with Bow," Busto interjects. "You are not only endangering yourselves, but you are endangering the people around you."

"General Az'al was fine with it," Sh'dowell argues.

"The General was too busy laughing her ass off at Thom falling to give a shit," Catra points out. "And Ri'ta also thought it was funny."

"Just because it's funny does not mean you should do it!" Bow shouts.

"And Thom," Busto sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. "I know you're just doing this to avoid me because I asked you-"

"Uh, no I'm not!" Thom interrupts, eyes blown wide in panic. He looks like he wants to run, but he's trapped by the group.

"Wait, what's going on between you two?" Catra thought that now that Thom had 'reformed', he was getting along with Busto. But, maybe she was wrong.

"I asked him on a da-" Busto begins, but Thom stops it.

"Impossible!" Thom shouts, causing Adora and Sh'dowell to jump onto a near-by table with a groan. Catra doesn't move, glancing between him and Busto. He grabs her arm and tries to tug her off of the ground, "C'mon Catra, we're ahead we don't want to lose our advantage! Shit, why are you heavy?"

Catra pushes Thom to the ground and stands on his back. In the most sarcastic tone she can muster, she mumbles, "Oh no . . . Thom fell on the ground . . . looks like he's out." She clears her throat and turns to Busto, "Anyway, what happened between you two?"

"I asked him on a date," Busto says, ignoring Thom's strangled protests.

"Oh, *oh*," Catra's eyes go wide. And then, she's suddenly staring at the ceiling. Thom had managed to knock her off onto her back. "Oh, fuck off Thom!"

"Fuck off of me first!" Thom shouts.

"I am off of you!"

"Ha, we win!" Sh'dowell shouts. "We're tied again!"

"Look at what you did!" Catra hisses at Thom as Adora hops down from the table to help her up.

"You started it!"

"Wait, if you're tied what's the score?" Bow asks.

"It's nine to nine," Adora explains. "So, the next team to score wins."

Bow stares at her, "You've played this game eighteen times already?!"

"Yeah."

"Well, may as well get this over with," Busto sighs. "Impossible."

Once again, everyone hops off of the ground, with Thom scrambling to get onto his feet. This was the deciding game.

"Is this a good idea?" Bow asks Busto.

Busto sighs, "The sooner this is over with, the better. Or better yet . . ."

"What?"

"Why don't we end it early?"

As it usually goes in 'Impossible' (and in battle), Adora and Catra head for each other first. But, at least this time, it's all in good fun.

Adora and Catra are on opposite ends of the roof of a large stall, ready to try and pounce on the other. However, before

they can even get in their usual quips, Catra hears the sound of an arrow being released and jumps out of the way. The arrow releases a rope with weights on the end that wraps around Adora's legs, pulling them together and causing her to lose balance. She topples off the roof with a, "GOSH DARNIT BOW!"

"Ha-ha!" Catra gloats. "I see you still suck at dodging."

"Oh don't rub it in," Adora huffs, as she tries to get free from Bow's trap. Of course, Catra isn't safe for long.

"Catra!" Busto calls out as he steps into her line of sight. "I'm gonna tell Adora-"

She lunges at him before he has the chance to finish his sentence or even get Adora's attention. Her hands slam over his mouth as they fall to the ground, Busto landing on his back and Catra landing on Busto. Before she can even hiss a threat, he grabs her arms and flips her over his head and onto the ground.

"There," Busto grins as he rolls over. "You're out."

"You're the worst."

"You love me."

As Catra bemoans her existence on the floor, Sh'dowell jumps overhead, narrowly dodging all of Busto's arrows. They cackle, "Ha! You think this is a challenge?! Demeter is a better shot on her worst days!"

They're too busy taunting Bow to see Thom stick his foot out and trip them. They fall off of the ledge onto their face on the ground. Thom looks up and says plainly, "I win."

"Fuck yeah Thom!" Catra celebrates. Even after everything . . . she still likes winning.

"So, are you guys done?" Bow asks. He walks over to help Adora get out of his trick arrow trap, as somehow, she's only

become more tangled.

"Yep!" Sh'dowell peels themselves off of the ground to rejoin everyone. "Catra and Thom win! Thank-you all for participating in the playtest of 'Impossible', please let me know if you have any feedback!"

"I have feedback," Thom grunts. "Can we never play this again?"

As Sh'dowell begins to argue with Thom, Catra taps Adora's shoulder once she gets free, "Hey Adora, can I talk with you for a moment?"

"Yeah, sure," Adora blinks. She waves goodbye to Bow as Catra pulls her away from the crowds. Now, she can do what she was planning all along. "What's up?"

"I know I mentioned it before, but I figured I'd make an official offer," Catra says. "Would you like to go to the Temple of Saz? Maybe you can learn a bit more about the First Ones. It would help with my own research too."

"Of course!" Adora lights up. "Will anyone be coming along?"

"I think the two of us can handle ourselves," Catra says. She really just doesn't want anyone to intrude on their conversation. "I can get the day off tomorrow, so why don't we meet at Half Moon's gates after breakfast?"

"Sounds like a plan," Adora says. "It feels like it's been a long time since we truly got to hang out by ourselves . . . nightmares notwithstanding. Here is Half Moon, it feels like we're always surrounded by others-which isn't a bad thing! It's just that . . . I think the last time we were truly alone . . . we when we were enemies."

Catra knows exactly what Adora is talking about. The Temple. What a strange coincidence that they're going to a

different Temple that may be connected to the First Ones to get a little peace and quiet.

"I know what you mean," Catra says softly. "But, at least we can put that behind us."

"Right," Adora agrees with a smile. For some reason, it feels like Catra's heart skips a beat when Adora looks at her like that. "So, I guess I'll see you tomorrow."

"See you," Catra nods.

Tomorrow, Catra will tell Adora she's a Princess, and hopefully that'll go well.

. . . It's going to be a rough night for Catra.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you for reading and please consider leaving a comment! I'm not the best at responding to them but I do read and appreciate all of them! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Have a good day!

Interlude VIII: Adora III

Chapter Summary

Adora learns Catra's secret.

Chapter Notes

I'm hungry so I didn't really proof read, sorry. But, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After being in the Caves of Half Moon for a few weeks, Adora is glad she has a chance to soak in the sun. It filters in through the trees, makes patterns on the forest floor below, and warms her skin. The climate of Purrsia is warmer than mainland Etheria, and today it’s welcomed.

She glances ahead at Catra, who is leading her through the jungles of Purrsia. She hasn’t said much this trip, under the guise of not wanting to attract beasts, but Adora gets the feeling there’s something else going on. She can’t put her finger on it yet, but she doesn’t think it’s something bad. Catra just seems . . . nervous, for whatever reason.

The trees break away and they finally arrive at their destination: the Temple of Saz. It’s so unlike the First One’s Temples Adora has seen before, none of the slick architecture and technology, but instead it is made of hand-carved stone.

“Is this-” Adora begins.

“The Temple of Saz,” Catra reveals. She grins and nudges Adora’s side, “C’mon, I’ll race you to the top.”

“Wait, don’t we have to be careful-” Adora begins, but Catra’s already taken off, sprinting on all fours as she runs to the base of the Temple. Adora growls, but knows that two can play at

that game. She transforms into She-Ra and catches up to Catra with a few long strides.

"Oh, come on!" Catra hisses. "That's cheating!"

"So is getting a head start!" Adora counters.

The two run up the stone steps, and by the time they make it to the top both of them are left panting.

"I got here first!" Adora claims, letting go of She-Ra's form in the burst of light.

"Uh, maybe your big toe did," Catra counters. "Let's just call it a tie."

A competitive side of Adora wants to press her victory, but decides that maybe it's be better if they kept it peaceful between them, "Okay, it's a tie."

Once Catra catches her breath, she steps forward and gestures around the stone room, "Go ahead and take a look, but be careful. I don't think the floor is super stable in some place."

Adora steps up to one of the walls and runs her hands over the stone carvings, "Sounds like you're speaking from experience."

"Yeah, but you won't have the safety of always being able to land on your feet," Catra teases.

"Are you saying you wouldn't try to grab me?" Adora asks, throwing a cheeky smile over her shoulder.

"I'd rather not be pulled down into a hole with your heavy ass," Catra teases.

"It's muscle!"

"It's still heavy."

Adora huffs and turns back to the temple walls. There are four murals, depicting what looks to the be the Magicat's "Three Stars" descending from the sky and aiding the Magicats, or fighting against them? She really should ask Catra to clear up the Magicat's mythology for her. There's actually very little writing, kept to the descriptions at the bottom of the mural.

"So?" Catra stands behind Adora, looking over her shoulder. "Find anything good?"

"Here, it just states that the Three Star's names are Saz, Lyses and Ilir," Adora says.

"Knew that," Catra mumbles.

She moves onto the mural of the Three Stars teaching the Magicats to fight. After a moment, Adora's says, "This one says 'Saz prepares the Sehrah to protect the artificial runestone'."

"Artificial?" Catra questions, but it sounds like it's directed towards herself. Adora turns and sees that Catra's brows are furrowed and hand at her chin. She's deep in thought.

"I wonder if that means the Magicat's runestone is a First One's creation," Adora suggests.

"Maybe," Catra mutters. She finally looks up at Adora, "What else does it say?"

The next mural shows Saz and Ilir fighting. Adora reads, "Ilir reminds Saz of the mission." Following it is the Three Stars leaving, "Saz and Lyses keep the Sehrah safe." Adora stands up straight and stares at the murals, "What could all of this means?"

"Saz and Lyses keeping the Magicats safe makes sense," Catra murmurs. "They supposedly left to take Ilir away from the Magicats after they attacked them with lightning and beasts. I'm more concerned about the fact that m-*our* Runestone is supposedly artificial."

"If only Entrapta were here," Adora sighs wistfully. She realizes what she says and stares at Catra, and apology on her lips for even bringing it up, but Catra raises a hand.

"I know," Catra sighs. "I . . . I need to apologize to her too. We need to get her away from the Horde."

Adora nods in agreement, "We'll save her."

"Oh, she doesn't need to be saved. I'm sure she's as happy as a clam with all of the Horde's technology," Catra points out. "It's just . . . I lied to her. I want to make that right too."

"You will," Adora insists. She places a hand on Catra's shoulder and squeezes it lightly, "You've grown so much, and the day will come when you see Entrapta again."

Catra stares at her hand, and Adora goes to remove it, but she places her clawed one over hers. She sighs, "Thanks Adora."

Adora stares at their touching hands and doesn't know why that makes her want to blush. She and Catra used to hold hands all the time in the Horde, as a comforting way to ground each other during rough times. Why is this different?

Catra removes her hand and sighs, "It's getting stuffy in here. Do you want to look around or get some fresh air?"

"Fresh air sounds good!" Adora exclaims. She turns on her heel and marches outside, ignoring the weird look Catra is getting her.

From the top of the Temple, the forests of Purrsia stretch out between them. The lush greenery is a sight she can get used to.

"So," Catra walks up next to Adora. "Race you back to Half Moon?"

“Does everything have to be a race?” Adora sighs.

“I know you want too,” Catra insists. “No She-Ra, though.”

“Then no head-starts,” Adora counters.

“Fine with me. On the count of three?”

“Sure.”

“One . . .”

“Two . . .”

“Three!”

Together, they bolt down the large stairs of the Temple, gravity helping them pick up speed. They remain neck-and-neck for the most part, barely squeezing ahead for only a moment, until they reach the bottom. Adora hesitates for a moment, because she realizes she actually doesn’t know the forests as well as Catra.

Catra turns around, “Are you already lost?”

“I don’t know the way back to Half Moon!” Adora admits, and she runs to catch up with Catra.

“Then follow me!”

“Doesn’t that defeat the point of a race?”

“Maybe. Just try to keep up,” Catra bolts, and Adora nearly stumbles over her feet as she starts running again.

Adora laughs as she chases after Catra through the forests of Purrsia. It reminds her of the few carefree moments they had during their childhood: climbing the rafters of the Fright Zone, always trying to get higher and be faster. But there’s no fear of falling or what waits for them below. It feels more freeing.

She finally manages to catch up to Catra, but that's only because she's stopped in a clearing.

"Hey, what's wrong?" Adora asks Catra as she stares out at the field, but Adora quickly realizes why she's stopped. It's a village, nearly completely leveled. The stone paths are overgrown with moss, and the foundations of the houses barely poke out of the tall grass and the vines. On the other end of the village is a destroyed Horde tank, rusting away and reclaimed by nature.

"I didn't get it at first," Catra says. "Why you wanted to protect Thaymor."

Thaymor seems like so long ago. Adora barely knew what she was doing with the Sword of Protection, and it was the beginning of their fractured friendship. But now, Adora's more confident in her abilities as She-Ra. Catra has defected from the Horde and found a home at Half Moon. They're friends once again.

"I didn't see what you saw in that place," Catra says as she walks forward and stands at the precipice of the broken path. "Couldn't understand it. Wouldn't. I knew that the Horde was hurting the people there, but I didn't care. That's just what the Horde did. But then I came here . . ."

"It took me experiencing a bit of life outside of the Horde to decide to fight against it," Adora says. She stands beside Catra and places a hand on her shoulder. "Maybe you had to see it too."

Catra shakes her head, "I was hell-bent on getting off of this island, even after experiencing life in Half Moon. I couldn't go back to the Horde, but I was just angry. Once I was able, I began to explore the island to figure out how to get off. Then, I stumbled upon a ruined village like this one. I could see the friends I had started to make and the people I had begun to care about be hurt at the Horde hands. I could see myself committing those atrocities once again."

"But you're not like that anymore," Adora insists. "You wouldn't let that happen if the Horde came to Half Moon again. And the Princess Alliance will make sure that never happens."

"Adora . . . are you sure that the Magicats should join the Princess Council?" Catra asks. "The Horde has hurt so many people here . . . everyone lost someone. Should we risk it happening again?"

"If you don't try," Adora argues. "It could happen again."

Catra steps back, turning away from her again, "Adora, have you ever heard the full story of what happened to Princess Fel'cty?"

"She was killed by the Horde, right?" Adora says. She doesn't know anything other than that and she doesn't know either of the Queens well enough to ask about something so personal.

"She was four," Catra begins. "She was a ball of energy, a bit of a troublemaker, and had signs of being a magical prodigy, but most of all she was beloved by her mothers. But then, the war began. Queen Bett'i was killed and C'yra had to become Queen before she was truly ready. Both were involved heavily in the war, protecting their home, and maybe they couldn't see their daughter enough.

"And then one day . . . tragedy struck. Ri'ta was stuck protecting the Conservatory from Horde attack, while C'yra worked on getting her back-up. Under both of their noses, assassins snuck into the Castle Stronghold and slaid all of the Princess' guards. There was no sign of the Princess, so the Queens had to assume the worst. They looked for her, but with the war reaching a tipping point, C'yra had to make a decision. The Magicats retreated into Half Moon, and C'yra and Ri'ta assumed their daughter was dead."

Part of Adora wonders how Catra knows all this, it's a bit more detailed than the account Gr'wliger gave them, unless she's closer to C'yra and Ri'ta than she realized.

"But . . . there's more to the story. There was also a woman, a mage in Mystacor, who fell from the light and into the shadows, carrying with her an old grudge. When the Horde planned to take control of Purrsia, she decided to make good on a promise in seeing the M'stoff'lls Clan die. So, she stole the Princess, erased her memories, and raised her in the Horde. No . . . raise isn't the right word. Abuse is more like it. And so, she grew up in the Horde, thinking that there was no one else like her. Until she got sentenced to Beast Island."

"Catra," Adora gasps.

Catra turns around and summons a flame in the palm of her hand. It dances between her fingers before she extinguishes it with a closed fist, "I am the daughter of C'yra and Ri'ta, Princess Fel'cty of D'riluth."

"You're a Princess too?" Adora asks quietly.

She nods, "C'yra and Ri'ta knew I was their daughter the moment I stepped into Half Moon, the eyes confirmed it, but they didn't tell me at first. I learned it slowly, just as I learned how to be a Magicat. If the Magicats are to join the Princess Alliance, they'll need a Princess. So, tell me Adora, should I join the Princess Alliance? Will that give the Magicats hope again?"

Adora wants to say yes just because she wants Catra by her side, for them to be close again like they once were. Together, they could take on anything. But, that's not what Catra's asking. She's carrying a weight Adora doesn't know intimately, she carries all of Etheria while Catra carries the responsibility for the safety of the Magicats.

"I think," Adora begins carefully. "That if there's anyone, out of all of the Magicats, who could face the Horde and give

them peace of mind, it's you. And if you do decide to join the Princess Alliance, you won't be alone. All of us want to protect all of Etheria, including Purrsia. If something were to happen, the Princesses would back you up. And even if you don't join . . . we'd still help anyway. We won't leave you all alone, like last time." Adora steps forward and takes Catra's hand, "I won't leave you behind again."

Catra glances away, "I . . . I still have to think about it."

"That's okay," Adora says. "We'll wait for you. But, I want you to know that . . . I also want you to join the Princess Alliance . . . just so we can be close again. Only if you want, of course."

"Wow," Catra chuckles. "Are you admitting that you, the powerful She-Ra and golden girl, have wants? How dare you."

"Catra," Adora whines.

"I know, if anyone deserves to be a little selfish, it's you," Catra says. "And since that selfishness is coming from you . . . it's a bit more convincing than any other argument you could make."

"Really?" Adora blinks.

"Yeah," Catra nods. "When was the last time you wanted anything, anyways?"

Adora tries very hard to think about that. Did she even really want to be a Horde Commander? Or did she want Shadow Weaver's twisted attention. Her silence is enough of an answer.

She coughs, "Anyway, what's it like being the Magicat Princess?"

"I'm not it officially," Catra admits, she turns away and scratches the back of her neck. "Not yet, anyways. I haven't even told my moms that I want to be the Princess."

It’s weird hearing Catra call the Queens her moms, but she says it with such fondness that Adora is glad that she found them, “Why not?”

“I think they’ll be afraid that they’re going to lose me again,” Catra says quietly.

“They clearly care a lot about you, and if I’ve learned anything from watching Glimmer and Queen Angella, it’s better that you tell them than go behind their backs,” Adora suggests.

Catra sighs and drops her arms, “I’ll think about it . . . thank-you Adora.”

“For what?”

“Just . . . for being here for me.”

“Of course, Catra.”

“. . . Can I ask you one more favor?”

“Sure.”

“Don’t tell Glimmer.”

“That . . . is going to be hard. You know how bad of a liar I am.”

“Yeah, but how is that going to come up into conversation? If she asks what happened, just tell her about what we found at the Temple. Simple as that. Even you can handle of a lie of omission, right?”

“. . . Probably not. But I’ll try for you.”

“Thanks.”

“Also . . .”

“Yeah?”

"Isn't it weird how there were three Princesses in the Horde when the Horde's whole thing is hating Princesses?"

". . . It's pretty weird."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading, consider leaving a comment if you enjoyed it! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Have a good day!

far too great a toll its played on me animal of destiny i have seen it from afar saw its teeth and felt its claws felt it ripping me apart to find my place among the stars

Chapter Notes

Chapter title: ok ok, half alive

also i didn't really proof read this again sorry but enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, I suppose you are all wondering why I have gathered you here today," Catra says as she paces in front of Busto, Demeter and Shire.

"Is it because you're finally going to become the Princess of Half Moon?" Demeter asks in a bored tone.

"You are?" Busto pipes up as Catra shoots a glare at Demeter. "This is a big step forward for you Catra, since I know you have a thing about Princesses-"

"I want to become Princess so I can officially join the Princess Alliance on behalf of Half Moon to help defeat the Horde," Catra says.

"Oh," Busto says. "Well, if that's what you wish to do then as your friend, I will gladly support you!"

"It better not get us all killed," Demeter leans back and crosses her arms. "Wait, why am I even here?"

"Forgive me for assuming, but I thought you didn't like Demeter," Shire adds. "Wouldn't Gr'wliger be a better choice for this?"

"I don't want the Council knowing yet," Catra says. "Especially because I don't think my moms are going to agree with what I want to do. When Shimmer talks to them about the Princess Alliance, I want to ambush it and give them my reasoning."

"That's because the Queens probably just don't want to lose you again," Busto says softly. "Going back and fighting the Horde . . . it's dangerous. You're sure this is what you want to do?"

"I don't think I'm going to know true peace until the Horde is gone," Catra admits, her voice slightly breaking. "And . . . I don't want to do this just for me. For all of Half Moon too. So, you all don't have to live in fear either."

Busto, Shire, and Demeter all share a look, the latter saying, "Then, let's do this."

"Thank-you," Catra sighs. "First thing's first, since I can't ask C'yra I need to figure out exactly what I need to do become a Princess."

"There's probably some old laws that pertain to that, it's been over hundreds of years since we had any claims to the throne," Busto says.

"Then," Shire begins. "It sounds like we need to go to the library."

It's late in the evening. At this point, there's barely anyone in the library, including Ri'ta who is relaxing with C'yra in their quarters. Catra quietly follows Shire as they weave through the rows and rows of massive bookshelves, looking for a specific book.

"So, laws are over here," Shire murmurs, running her finger along the shelves as she reads the spine of each book. "And down here . . . ah! 'Succession to the Throne of Purrsia'!"

"Will that have what we're looking for?" Catra asks as Shire pulls the book off the shelf.

"If it doesn't, hopefully it'll point us in the right direction," Shire says. The book is heavier than she expected, and it slips through her arms and falls on the floor with a thud, "Scat."

Catra leans down to pick it up, but freezes as the light of a lantern casts down the aisle and Gus calls, "Who goes there?"

"Uh . . ." Catra grabs the book and hugs it to her chest, making sure to hide the cover. "Nothing. We were just looking for a book and it slipped from our grasp."

"We're very sorry, Gus," Shire adds for good measure.

Gus hobbles over, lowering the lantern as he walks, "What are you two doing in the history of law section? Are you not both magic students?"

"Well, we're trying to settle an argument, you see," Catra lies. "I know I'm right, but Shire demands I have proof."

"And your proof is within the 'Succession to the Throne of Purrsia'?" Gus asks.

Catra glances down at the book, she's hiding the cover, how did he figure that out? She nods, "Yes, yes it is."

Gus stares at her, "The current laws of succession are not well-defined in that book. It simply goes over the history of changes to succession. You are looking for the Succession Declaration Act, which is defined in the 'Revised Accession and Coronation Acts'." Gus sets down the lantern to pull off a thicker book from the shelf, "Which is right here."

"Oh," Catra deposits 'Succession to the Throne of Purrsia' in Shire's arms, who stumbles slightly and takes the book from him. "Uh . . . thank-you?"

"But you do not have anything to worry about," Gus says. "There is no one on the Council who would deny you as C'yra's heir. You will do just fine, Fel'cty."

Catra stares at him. Out of everyone at Half Moon, she thought Gus hated her the most. Much quieter this time, but with more feeling she says, "Thank-you."

He nods as he picks up his lantern and hobbles away. As Catra stares in her hands, Shire chuckles, "I guess even old curmudgeons like Gus can change."

The next day, Catra finds herself sitting with Demeter in a quiet corner of the hunter's quarters with 'The Revised Accession and Coronation Acts', slowly flipping through the old tome. They're the only two not on a hunt, and it's the first chance Catra has had to read through the dense book.

"So, it looks like it's up to C'yra to name me as her heir once I claim it," Catra says. "And then the Council can vote on whether the claim is legitimate or not, if they so wish to."

"Then, you don't need to worry," Demeter says with a shrug. "Like I said, you look just like C'yra. You're obviously her daughter."

Catra glares at Demeter and growls, "Not helping."

"Then why are you talking to me?"

"Because you said you'd help."

"I now realize that is a mistake on my part."

Catra returns to the book and continues to read, "Oh, it looks like I need to prove I can use the Fire of Saz to show that I am the heir."

"Well, can you?"

“Yes, I can.”

“Prove right now.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“I’m holding a very flammable book right now.”

“Hhm . . . coward.”

Catra rises to retort, but footsteps echoing throughout the hunter’s quarters causes her to shut her mouth. It should be a while before any of the hunters are back from their rounds, but Catra’s still surprised when Az’al suddenly walks through the doorway.

“Demeter?” Az’al looks between her daughter and Catra. “Oh, am I interrupting something?”

“No,” Demeter stands up. “Catra’s just being a coward.”

“Shut up,” Catra growls.

“So, what did you want?” Demeter asks.

“I wanted to ask you . . .” Az’al begins, but trails off and blinks. “You know, I’ve already forgotten.”

This must be a come occurrence, as Demeter sighs, “Again? Mom, why didn’t you write it down?”

“You know that’s because I forgot,” Az’al laughs. “I guess let this be a reminder to both of you-avoid head injuries. Anyway, what are you two doing? Just hanging out?”

“I guess you could say that,” Demeter shrugs, glancing at Catra over her shoulder.

Az'al is nosier than Catra realized, because when she notices Catra's reading a book, she walks over and asks, "What's that?"

She shifts her body away, in hopes that Az'al won't see anything, "Nothing."

The general stares at her, which morphs into a full grin, "You're finally doing it, aren't you?"

"Doing what?" Catra tries to play dumb.

"You're going to claim your birthright!" Az'al says, much too loudly. Both Catra and Demeter shush her, but she just laughs, "About time if you ask me. C'yra said you didn't want to be a Princess, what made you change your mind?"

"I just thought it was time," Catra says with a shrug. She doesn't want to go into the real reasons, even though she knows Glimmer has already talked with Az'al.

"Well, you're gonna do great, kid," Az'al says.

". . . You really think so?" Catra asks.

"Yeah!" Az'al says. "You're a great warrior, but you've also earned the respect of a lot of people here in Half Moon."

"I have?" Catra says, genuinely surprised. She thought that people didn't trust her-still seeing her as a Horde soldier. But, somehow between saving Lily, joining the hunters, standing up to Thom, and competing in the Jellicle Ball, she must have done something to earn the Magicat's respect.

"I'm not included in that statement, by the way," Demeter points out.

"Oh come on Demeter, you two were supposed to be friends," Az'al throws an arm around Demeter's shoulder and pulls

her closer. “You were born around the same time, and C’yra and I always hoped you would be good friends like us.”

“Saz, don’t embarrass me,” Demeter groans. When Catra laughs, she shoots her a glare and says, “Oh just you wait. Once you’re publicly the Princess, that means that Queen C’yra can embarrass you in public too.”

“C’yra wouldn’t do that,” Az’al insists. “It’s Ri’ta you’ll have to watch out for.”

Catra gulps, “I’ll make sure to remember that.”

“Well, if that’s all you wanted from me-” Az’al begins.

Demeter deadpans, “You came in here looking for me.”

“Oh, right,” Az’al nods. “Either way, I have to get going. If I remember what I was going to tell you, I’ll make sure to write it down.”

“You won’t,” Demeter sighs.

“Wait, General Az’al?” Catra interrupts.

“You can just call me Az’al, Catra, you’re my best friend’s daughter,” Az’al insists.

“Then . . . Az’al,” Catra begins. “I . . . haven’t told C’yra or Ri’ta that I want to become the Princess yet. Could you keep it a secret?”

“Don’t worry, she’ll probably just forget it,” Demeter grumbles.

“I don’t forget anything important!” Az’al insists. “And Catra . . . sure, I can do that. Hopefully I get to see the look on C’yra’s face when you tell her, with there being another Council meeting at the end of the week and all.”

Catra grins, “I’ll make sure you do.”

Az’al begins to leave, not without kissing the top of Demeter’s head and saying, “I’ll see you later, Dee.”

Demeter lets out a frustrated groan once her mom is gone, and Catra asks, “Is she always that absent minded or have I just never noticed?”

“She’s usually better about hiding her bouts of short term memory loss,” Demeter says. “But, she really does remember the important stuff.”

“So,” Catra goes quiet. “C’yra mentioned something that you two . . . had a bit of a rift between you two. Are you two getting along better now?”

“You mean after the fight between my mom and C’yra?” Demeter asks. When Catra nods, she sighs, “Yeah, I heard some stuff I probably was never meant to hear . . . and in my teenage angst I started to fight with her more. But, I decided to ask her to train me for the Jellicle Ball and we actually talked about stuff. So yeah, things are better. Why do you care?”

“Well . . . I kinda went through something similar with Adora recently,” Catra says. “But . . . I guess I’m just glad that it seems like everyone is getting along better now. Wouldn't you agree?”

Demeter smiles, “Yeah, I guess I can agree with you on that.”

“If you want to be a Princess, you have to dress like it,” Busto says.

Catra grimaces, “You mean . . . like sparkles and dresses and flashy stuff?”

Busto gives her a strange look, “No I mean like . . . an official uniform, like C’yra’s. Wait, does every Princess in Etheria wear clothes like Glimmer’s?”

“Yes,” Catra sighs.

“. . . Even in battle?”

“Especially in battle.”

“That’s so impractical!”

“Agreed.”

She lets him drag her to the only tailor in Half Moon, Gr’wliger’s father B’nks.

“So,” B’nks says. “You need an official uniform in the royal style with royal colors . . . for what reason?”

“Because . . . I think it looks good?” Catra tries to lie. B’nks doesn’t look convinced, so she drops her shoulders and sighs, “Because I’m C’yra and Ri’ta’s daughter and I’m planning on becoming the Princess but can you keep that a secret for now?”

“Oh,” B’nks says. “It was a secret?”

Catra groans and puts her head in her hands, “Is it really that obvious?”

“A little,” B’nks admits. “But I didn’t know about the second part! Now, I’ll need to get your measurements again and if you don’t mind, I don’t want to copy Queen C’yra’s outfit exactly, I want to give you something that says *you*.”

“I’m fine with that,” Catra shrugs. B’nks made her suit for the Jellicle Ball, and she trusts him to do whatever.

“Good! I’ll get started on the design while Gr’wliger takes your measurements,” Catra’s eyes go wide as B’nks glances over

his shoulder and shouts, “Gr’wliger!”

As B’nks steps into the back room, Busto eagerly follows him with ‘design suggestions’. Gr’wliger steps past them and looks at Catra in surprise. It’s odd to see him out of his leather armor and green cloak, trading it for a button-up shirt and slacks. But if he was in the other room . . . it just meant that he heard her admit to wanting to become the Princess.

“Fancy see you here, Catra,” Gr’wliger says as he grabs a tape measure and steps up to Catra.

“Yeah. Also, do you spend all of your days off helping out your dad?” Catra asks.

“Only when he asks for assistance,” Gr’wliger says. He begins to get Catra’s measurements as he lowers his voice, “I think he just wants to spend time with me. I’m the busiest out of my siblings, so he sees me less.”

“I didn’t know you knew any of this tailor’s stuff.”

“My father wanted me to take over his business before I became a hunter,” Gr’wliger adds. “But my younger sister is poised to take over.”

“That’s good.”

Silence follows, as Catra’s not quite sure how to broach the Princess subject as Gr’wliger flits about her. Thankfully, he takes the initiative, “So, you do wish to become the Princess now?”

“Yeah,” Catra nods.

“Is it because you wish to join the Rebellion?” Gr’wliger asks, quieter now.

“That’s . . . part of it,” Catra says. “I’m sorry for not telling you, I just didn’t want C’yra or Ri’ta to know yet.”

"I would have kept it a secret," Gr'wliger says.

"I know," Catra sighs. "Sorry. I should have figured, since you've been helping Glimmer with her second Council proposal."

"It's alright," Gr'wliger insists. He goes quiet again, and when he speaks next his voice barely comes out in a whisper, "I was actually going to volunteer to join the Rebellion as the Magicat's representative."

"Really?" Catra asks. Gr'wliger was one of the most devoted people to Half Moon's safety and infrastructure, it's hard to imagine him leaving.

"It's for selfish reasons, I must admit," Gr'wliger says. "I want to see the world."

He says it so wistfully, like it's a dream just out of reach. She recalls the story his parents told her, about when he was young he wanted to be an adventurer to the point he tried to commit mutiny on a boat tour. But, like many of the Magicats, he had to grow up fast and aid Half Moon in any way he could. He must have never let go of that dream, kept it locked away in his heart. And now . . . he has his chance.

"You could come with me," Catra suggests. One of the reasons why she's the best candidate to join the Rebellion is that the Horde knows about her, and Hordak probably thinks she's the last living Magicat. If anyone else were to come along, it would hint at the Magicat's survival. But, Catra doesn't want to deny Gr'wliger his dream.

"That would be dangerous," Gr'wliger says.

"It would," Catra admits. "But, I couldn't imagine anyone better for the job. You're an adept fighter, a bureaucratic wunderkind-"

"-Will you ever let that go?" Gr'wliger sighs.

"No," Catra snorts. "But, you're also my friend. I *want* you to come with me."

Gr'wliger pauses, but finally says, "If I could, I would be honored to travel with you . . . Princess Fel'cty."

Catra groans, "Is that payback for the bureaucratic wunderkind thing?"

"Oh yes," Gr'wliger finally steps away. "I'm going to give these measurements to my father, but let's keep quiet on our . . . adventure plans for now."

Gr'wliger must be in a similar situation as her: he doesn't want to worry his parents, at least just yet. They made it out of the Invasion with their family intact, they'll probably won't be eager to let their eldest son travel to mainland Etheria to fight the Horde.

"Understood," Catra nods. She follows him into the cramped backroom, while Busto and B'nks are still talking.

"Oh, Catra!" B'nks stands up, a sheet of paper in his hands. "This is a very rough design, but I want your opinion on it."

He holds up the design for Catra to see, and she smiles, "It's perfect . . . and can I also get a second one in red?"

Catra takes a deep breath. Adora's words ring true to her, that going behind her mothers' backs would be more trouble than it's worth. It's already been exhausting keeping this secret and . . . considering that half of Half Moon seems to already know, she should tell them too.

"You okay, Catra?"

She nearly jumps out of her skin as C'yra sneaks up on her. Maybe she should have expected that *maybe* C'yra wasn't

home yet and may catch her trying to hype herself up outside.

"You've been staring at the door for a while," C'yra says with a concerned look on her face.

"Yeah! I'm fine!" Catra says, a little too forcefully. She sighs, "I just . . . wanted to talk to you and Ri'ta about something."

"Oh," C'yra nods. "Like a crush?"

"What? No," Catra scoffs. "I don't have a crush on anyone. Certainly not Adora."

C'yra raises an eyebrow, "I didn't mention Adora."

"Can we just go inside!?"

"After you."

Inside, Ri'ta is setting up the table for dinner, and greets both of them with a smile, "Welcome home. Dear, I see you've convinced Catra to come inside. I heard her pacing back and forth outside our door for so long."

"I was thinking," Catra growls.

"Then, penny for your thoughts?" Ri'ta leans up against the back of the couch. "Your mother only paces when something is deeply troubling her, and we're here to listen."

C'yra nods and settles next to Ri'ta, putting an arm around her shoulder. They wait for Catra to speak, but don't pressure her.

"What if . . ." Catra begins slowly. "I said that I do want to be the Princess? Like, seriously?"

"Is this a hypothetical?" C'yra asks.

"Doesn't sound like a hypothetical," Ri'ta says.

". . . No," Catra admits. "It's not a hypothetical."

C'yra pulls herself away from Ri'ta and walks forward, putting her hands on Catra's shoulders, "I know we've talked about this, but are you sure?"

"Yes," Catra nods. "I . . . want to do this, for the people of Purrsia."

Suddenly, she's crushed by a hug, "I'm so proud of you, Catra. You've grown so much."

"I can't breathe."

"Sorry," C'yra doesn't quite let go of her, but she isn't crushing her to death anymore. She kisses the crown of her head, "It's a long way off, but I know you'll be a great Queen one day."

"Yes," Ri'ta agrees as she joins them. "There's a bit more schooling in your future, though."

"I'm fine with that," Catra agrees with a laugh. She doesn't know why she was worried, of course C'yra and Ri'ta would be fine with it. Now all she has to do is tell them about how she wants to join the Alliance-

"We can announce it once the Rebellion is gone," C'yra says. "I don't want them to bother you. I've heard Princess Glimmer is trying to sway the other Council members to join the Alliance still despite our decision."

Catra knows that-she's helping her-but her gut reaction is to lie and sigh, "Of course she is."

She herself told C'yra that any of her decisions should happen after the Princess Alliance leaves, so her mother is only being considerate to her. All she can do now is nod and return to her original plan.

"How do I look?" Catra asks.

"You look regal," Shire says.

"You look great," Busto says, wiping a tear from his eye. "Like a real Princess."

"Can't say I feel like one," Catra says. B'nks uniform for her is purple double-breasted jacket with golden buttons. The cuffs are white, and a white stripe extends from her sides to the fitted purple pants that cut off just below her knee. There's also a white cape, with golden embroidery on the side. The fire opal brooch rests on her lapel, completing the look, "But I do think I look good."

"Then, if you're ready, we should get going," Shire says. "The Council meeting should be starting soon."

"It's already started," Demeter says, slipping into the room. "Gr'wliger went in there twenty minutes ago. I was waiting around for you losers when I figured I should just come get you."

"Then let's go," Catra says.

"Should we take the back route?" Busto asks.

Catra grins, "Well, since everyone already seems to know I'm the Princess, I don't see why we should bother trying to hide it."

She leaves her room, closely trailed by Busto, Shire and Demeter, and walks through the Caves of Half Moon with her head held high. The Magicats she passes by only look at her with confusion for a moment, but it quickly morphs to joy. They greet her as 'Princess', and for once the word doesn't cause her to recoil in disgust.

Waiting in the anteroom are Adora and Bow, lacking their sparkly friend which means that she's already in there. Catra

wanted to beat her to it, but she'll just have to crash the party instead.

"Catra?" Bow asks. "What are you doing here? And why are you wearing that?"

Adora just grins, "You're doing it, aren't you?"

"Yes, I am doing 'it'," Catra says.

"I'm so proud of you," Adora hugs her, lifting her feet off of the ground.

"Uh, what is 'it'?" Bow asks, voice increasing in pitch as he becomes more concerned.

"Thank-you," Catra sighs once Adora sets her down. She turns to the door and takes a deep breath. It's time, but she can't seem to move her feet forward.

Shire picks up on her apprehension and puts a hand on her shoulder, "You're going to do great, Catra. You have more fans than enemies in there."

("Uh, hey wait," Bow tries to interrupt. "Glimmer's in there right now-")

"And like C'yra and Ri'ta can say no to you," Demeter adds with a roll of her eyes.

Busto steps forward and grins as he dramatically bows, "I will see you on the other side, Princess Fel'cty."

("*What do you mean Princess!?*" Bow exclaims.

Adora puts an arm around his shoulders, "Don't worry about it.")

He opens the door for her and winks. His theatrics manage to calm her nerves just a bit, and she finds the courage

to enter the room. Time to claim her birthright.

The Council Room is quite aside from Glimmer's voice, and she stands at one end of the table giving the speech she rehearsed with Catra. As the doors close behind Catra, it catches the attention of a few Council members, who tear their gaze away from Glimmer and at her. Some don't look that surprised, like Az'al who just smiles and nods. Others are more shocked, including her own mothers that look at her with wide eyes but don't speak up.

Catra approaches the table and taps Glimmer's shoulder. She is quiet enough, and Sparkles is so enthralled in her speech, that she nearly jumps out of her skin, "Catra!" Glimmer growls, "What are you doing here?"

"I'm so sorry to interrupt, Princess Glimmer," Catra tries to be formal, but can't help but let a bit of passive aggressiveness seep into her tone. "But I have something I need to address with the Council."

"But-" Glimmer begins to protest.

"Princess Glimmer," C'yra interjects, her voice cold and informal. Her hands are clasped in front of her face as she leans forward with her elbow on her table. Though she keeps her face schooled, Catra can see that sparkle in her eye, something that she now knows is pride. "We shall resume this in a moment. Catra is a bit more impatient than I thought," C'yra pauses and a small smirk passes through her mask, only for a moment, "Please let her speak."

Glimmer glares at Catra but steps back.

Catra stands at the Council table, all eyes on her. She's dealt with the harsh glares of Shadow Weaver and cold stares of Hordak, but the curious look of the Magicats at the table is something she's not used to. She focuses on her mothers, C'yra remaining serious but Ri'ta smiles and nods, encouraging her to go forward.

"I, Catra, am here to claim my birthright as heir to the Throne of Purrsia and descendent of C'yra the Great Unifier," Catra begins, reciting the words she had read in 'Revised Accession and Coronation Acts'. She summons the Fire of Saz in her hand, allowing to dance along her fingers, "As proven by the Will of Saz manifesting itself in me." She extinguishes it by quickly closing her fist. That's all she needs to say, but she has something she wants to say, "As Princess of the United Tribes, I promise to do my best to protect the Magicats and help them thrive in the face of any adversity."

The room is silent as C'yra stands up, hands braced against the table. She knows C'yra will not reject her, but the little voice of doubt still worms its way into her head. After all, the shimmer of pride in her eye has not faded.

"Catra," C'yra says, her stern voice echoing in the room. "You have lived among us, learning our culture and truly becoming a Magicat. So, Fel'cty of D'riluth," C'yra smiles and holds out her hand, "My daughter, I am proud to say this to you: welcome home. I recognize you as a child of the D'riluth Tribe and heir to the throne of Purrsia."

Catra drops the act and runs around the table to hug C'yra. Her mother laughs as her strong arms wrap around her, holding her close, and Ri'ta stands up to join them. When they let go, C'yra puts her hands on Catra's shoulders, "I'm so proud of you, Catra."

"We both are," Ri'ta interjects, and kisses Catra's forehead. "You could have just told us you wanted to do this sooner rather than later, but you look very regal. Nearly the spitting image of your mother."

"Finally!" Az'al laughs, interrupting the moment. Catra had nearly forgotten she was in a room full of people.

"I'm glad you have joined us, Princess Fel'cty," Gr'wliger adds with a small smile.

"It seems it's time for Purrsia to have a Princess once again," Deut'ron says.

Most of the Council look pleased with this new development, and Catra lets out a breath she was holding. So she really wasn't seen as a Horde soldier, she was a Magicat. Across the table, Glimmer stands and stares at her with mouth gasping. Her chin moves up and down slightly, fishing for words. Finally, she finds one, "WHAT."

Catra smirks with fangs barred and crosses her arms, "Surprise."

"You . . ." Glimmer growls, fists clenching and unclenching. She finally shouts, "HOW MANY PRINCESSES WERE THERE IN THE HORDE?!"

"Hopefully only three," Catra shrugs. "Actually, four if we count Entrapta."

"Wait, who else was a Princess in the Horde?" Gus asks.

"Don't worry about it," Catra waves him off. "It's above your pay grade."

"I doubt we need to do it, of course, but as is tradition," Deut'ron says. "Does anyone not believe Fel'cty's claim to the throne is legitimate."

"We all remember the symbol of royalty, though Queen C'yra may not have her eye anymore," Gus says. "You will hear no objections to me."

"Yeah, and it helps that Catra's basically a mini C'yra with Ri'ta's magical ability," Az'al points out, crossing her arms as she leans back. "She's clearly their daughter."

"Then it is so," Deut'ron says when no one else voices any concerns. "Princess Fel'cty, we welcome you to the Council. The future of Purrsia is in your hands."

"Thank-you," Catra shakily sighs. "I . . . I actually want to talk to you all about Purrsia's future, if I can."

"Ambitious, are we?" M'wth chuckles.

"Go ahead," C'yra says.

She takes a deep breath and stares out at the Council, but her gaze settles on her mothers. C'yra gives her another small, encouraging nod, while Ri'ta smiles at her.

"I don't think there's anyone here who knows the Horde better than me," Catra begins. "Furthermore, I don't think there's anyone who fears them more. I've lost so much to them . . . my best friend, my family, my sense of safety, and now I am only getting them back. That only makes me fear the Horde more, and I understand that you all feel the same. The Horde took everything from us, and though we've rebuilt, their shadow lingers over us.

"Is this really living? Do we deserve to live in fear of the Horde? To let them invade our nightmares? To let them make us afraid of reforging connections with the outside world? I just want to not be afraid anymore, and I can tell the exhaustion of fear hangs from all of us. Aren't you all tired of being afraid?"

It's a hard thing to admit, being afraid, but it's clear that the threat of the Horde hangs over everyone in the room.

"And that's why," Catra takes a deep breath. "I think we should join the Rebellion and aid the Princess Alliance."

C'yra's and Ri'ta's eyes both widen at the same time, as they suddenly realize Catra's goals. The other Council members, who have talked with her and Glimmer, know what was coming.

"If you talked to me a year ago-or even a month ago-I would be the last person to endorse this," Catra continues. "But the more I've learned . . . the more I believe that they may be our only chance at having peace of mind. As much as it pains me to

say this, they are powerful enough to go toe-to-toe with the Horde when they work together. The Princesses are a force to be reckoned with, and they're not the type of people to leave us in the lurch. If we join the Princess Alliance, we'll be stronger than we are on our own, and that's why I think we should join them."

Catra steps back after her speech and look out over the Council. Most keep a school expression, but C'yra is staring down at the table, not meeting Catra's eyes. Her heart sinks.

Az'al is the first to speak, "It sounds like your offer correlates with Princess Glimmer's plans to provide aid to the Magicats if the Horde finds out about us, but if we join the Princess Alliance . . . how do we hide our existence if we're on the mainland aiding them?"

"There's a simple solution to that," Catra says. "We don't send entire squadrons, only a select few. In fact, the best person to go . . . is myself."

"Catra," Ri'ta says quietly. "You can't."

"The Horde already knows about me," Catra continues. "And they know I'm quite scrappy. It may not be hard to believe that I found a way to escape Beast Island, or the Princess Alliance specifically came to look for me. I would be the representative for the United Tribes in the Princess Alliance." Before anyone could speak up, Catra turns to Glimmer, "Unless you have any objections, Princess Glimmer?"

Glimmer looks incredibly frustrated, but she sighs and says, "I have no objections. I know the type of warrior you are, and even without knowing what powers you possess from the Runestone, I know that the Princess Alliance could use someone like you."

"Thank-you, Princess Glimmer," Catra bows slightly. "I apologize for the interruption, but I turn the floor back to you."

Catra steps back as Glimmer steps forward and begins to talk about the Alliance again, though her voice is not as strong as when she started. She must have thrown Shimmer off *hard*. But it's not like Catra's any better, no longer paying attention to her speech but instead focusing on her mothers.

C'yra's hands are folded in front of her, gripping each other until her knuckles turn white. She stares at them, not looking up at Glimmer, and Catra can't really see her face. Ri'ta however, is actively listening to Glimmer . . . or seems to be. She's looking at her, but her eyes seem distance. Catra didn't meant to do this to her mothers.

"I know that from the previous Council meeting, you all did not believe that the Rebellion can aid you and that together, we can defeat the Horde," Glimmer finishes. "However, I hope that now, both Princess Fel'cty and I were able to convince you otherwise."

"Thank-you," C'yra says, still not looking up. "The Council will take it's time to discuss this matter. Princess Glimmer and Princess Fel'cty, you are dismissed."

Catra nearly freezes at her mother's cold tone, but Glimmer places a hand on her shoulder and pulls her out of the room. They enter the antechamber, where everyone is still waiting for them.

"So, how'd it go?" Adora is the first up, running up to both of them.

"Well, they're talking about it right now," Glimmer says as Catra sits down. "But . . . DID YOU KNOW THAT CATRA WAS A PRINCESS!?"

"I only found out a couple days ago," Adora admits.

"I just found out!" Bow shouts. "And I am still freaking out about it!"

"Catra," Busto approaches her. "How do you feel about all of this?"

She hasn't said anything yet, but she sits down on one of the benches and finally sighs, "Do . . . do you think my moms are going to be mad at me for suggesting we join the Rebellion?"

Glimmer stares at Catra and sighs, "Lemme guess, you didn't tell them you wanted to do this?"

"I did tell them I wanted to become the Princess," Catra says. "But . . . not that I want to join the Alliance. There's a reason I didn't tell you I was the Princess before, y'know."

"I don't think they're mad," Glimmer says. "At least, not mad in the way my mom gets mad. But even they are, they still love you. They're your moms."

"You sure?" Catra softly asks.

"Oh yeah," Glimmer nods. "I've done *much* dumber stuff and I'll do stupid things in the future, but I know that my mom will always be there for me no matter what."

As Glimmer's words sink in, Catra realizes that for once she's been helpful. That manages to shock her out of her stupor for a little bit, "Thanks Glimmer."

"No problem," Glimmer grins. "Us *princesses* have got to stick together."

"You're never going to let me live that down, are you?"

"Absolutely not."

"So now what do we do?" Demeter asks.

Catra glances back at the closed doors to the Council, "Wait for them to make a decision."

It’s another hour and a half before there’s any sign of the Council meeting being done. Catra doesn’t know if the Council has ever gone on so long, because her mothers are usually home before dinner.

While they wait, Adora and Busto have sat down next to Catra on either side. Busto tries to distract her by coming up with increasingly stupid rhymes, while Adora simply holds her hand. Both are helpful.

Finally, the Council doors slowly creak open, and Deut’ron is the one to poke his head in. Catra jumps up immediately and nearly knocks him over, “Deut’ron! What happened? What did the Council decide?”

“Nothing, today,” Deut’ron shrugs. “Congratulations Princess Fel’cty, you have successfully caused the first overtime decision in three decades. It will be decided in an emergency meeting tomorrow.”

“Do you know what way they’re leaning?” Glimmer asks.

“No, it’s half-and-half, but of course, not everyone has voiced their opinions yet,” Deut’ron says. “Particularly the Queens.”

Catra’s heart falls at that and Adora squeezes her hand.

“But, speaking on that,” Deut’ron says. “Queen Ri’ta wishes to speak with you Catra inside. The other members have left.”

“Not C’yra?” Catra asks quietly.

“She must have some other business to attend to, of course,” Deut’ron insists.

Or she’s gone to take her emotions out on a training dummy, which is more likely. Still, Catra needs to know what her

mom thinks, so she squares her shoulders and walks into the empty Council room before she loses her nerve.

Ri'ta is the only one sitting in the Council room, staring off into the distance. Catra accidentally lets the door slam behind her and she doesn't move.

"Uh . . ." Catra walks forward, trying to not fidget too much. "Mom?"

"Sorry, Catra," Ri'ta jumps slightly, and stands up. "I was lost in my thoughts."

"Because of me?" Catra guesses.

"You certainly hit us with quite the surprise," Ri'ta insists and smiles, but it's not as wide as usual. She walks over to Catra and puts her hand on her shoulder, "Catra . . . is this something you really want?"

Catra blinks, she was expecting her mother to be angrier, but Ri'ta has always been level-headed, "What do you mean?"

"Do you really want to join the Princess Alliance?" Ri'ta repeats.

This feels like her last chance to back out if she wants, she could just stay here in Half Moon for the rest of her life, hiding from the Horde. As tempting as it is, it wouldn't really be peaceful, would it? To be afraid of what the Horde could do to them (could be doing to *Adora*) constantly?

"I do," Catra says. "I don't want to be afraid of the Horde forever, I want to do something about it for Half Moon. Are . . . are you mad?"

"No, no, I would never," Ri'ta says. "I hope I didn't look like it, I was just drawn into my own anxieties. I know C'yra is too."

"I guess that just my own worries," Catra nervously chuckles. "I don't want to disappoint you two . . ."

"And you haven't," Ri'ta insists. "Any mother would be proud to see that their daughter has become such a strong woman, someone who wants to help others. But, it should only be natural for a mother to worry as well. It feels like we just got you back Catra, we don't want to lose you again."

"You won't," Catra says. "It's just until the Horde is defeated, then I'll come home. And I'll have the other Princesses watching my back."

"That'll be a hard promise to keep," Ri'ta points out. "But I am sure your friends will help you keep it. I'll vote in your favor for Purrsia to join the Rebellion."

"You will?" Catra gasps.

"This is what you want," Ri'ta says, as if it is really that simple. "And if you really believe you will come home, then I see no reason to vote against it."

"Thank-you," Catra murmurs.

Ri'ta pulls her into a tight hug, nearly betraying her own wishes to not let Catra go, "You have to come back though. I don't know if I can bear losing your again."

"I will," Catra promises. "I will."

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you enjoyed this, please consider leaving a comment! I'm not the best at responding, but I do appreciate all of them. If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle.

say it loud say it clear you can listen as well as you hear its too late when we die to admit we dont see eye to eye

Chapter Summary

Catra and C'yra talk.

Chapter Notes

So, a slight chapter warning in the oddest sense but it may be more of a spoiler, but since this is rated T, there is some talks about the birds and the bees. Now you know the way this is going. Anyways, enjoy the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After the Council meeting, Catra and Ri’ta return to their home, but it’s empty. C’yra isn’t there.

“Ah, well,” Ri’ta sighs. “I didn’t think she would be here, if I’m being honest.”

“Is she,” Catra softly asks. “Mad at me?”

“At worse, she’s probably just a bit upset you didn’t tell her you wanted to join the Princess Alliance,” Ri’ta reassures Catra, turning around and placing her hand on her shoulder. “Speaking of that, you should talk to her.”

Catra blinks, “She’s not here.”

“You go look for her,” Ri’ta says. “While I get dinner, because I’m sure none of us have eaten since lunch.”

She feels so nervous, Catra doesn’t know if she can eat, “Are you sure . . . it’ll be okay? Me talking to C’yra?”

"I am, as at the end of the day we're your mothers and we love you. If her emotions get the better of her, I'll make sure to straighten her out," Ri'ta promises. "Just make sure you let her hear your thoughts, not as a Princess like in the Council meeting, but as Catra."

"Okay," Catra nods. Ri'ta always seems to know the right thing to say.

They split up, Ri'ta heading to the cafeteria and Catra off to find C'yra. As she walks through Half Moon, she realizes she hasn't yet changed out of her Princess attire and has people randomly bowing to her. She stops and tells them that they don't have to do that, so it takes a bit longer than normal to get around.

Catra checks the arena and C'yra's training spot, but she's in neither place. There's one last place to look: her office.

To Catra's surprise, C'yra's office door is slightly ajar. When she peaks in, she sees the room bathed in the soft glow of candlelight. Behind piles of paperwork, C'yra is sitting at her desk with her head in her hands as she glares at papers on her desk. She looks busy, Catra tells herself, so she tries to back away, but accidentally bumps into the door causing the hinges to squeak.

C'yra's head snaps up in attention, "Who's there?"

"Sorry," Catra pokes her head in. "I didn't mean to disturb you."

"It's alright," C'yra says, relaxing slightly, but she still looks agitated. "You're always welcome here, Catra."

"Always?" Catra checks.

"Always," C'yra nods.

If she's always welcome here, Catra steps further in and sits across from C'yra, who has returned to her paperwork. She

waits for her to speak, but it's clear that C'yra is fully involved in whatever she's reading.

When the silence becomes unbearable, Catra says, "I could help."

"What?" C'yra blinks.

"I could help with your paperwork," Catra repeats. "I used to do a bit of it in the Horde and . . . it looks like you have a lot."

C'yra stares at her, "Are you sure? This stuff is pretty boring."

"I'm going to have to get used to it," Catra argues. "I'll be doing a lot of it in the future."

"That's fair," C'yra softly chuckles. She glances around before grabbing a smaller stack and handing it over to Catra. "This is a proposal to restart mining operations, it's being passed around the Council to look over. Let me know if you see any of note."

"Like what?" Catra asks.

"Complete disregard for the miner's lives," C'yra says. "Unsafe working conditions. Or anything you think is fishy, I trust your judgement."

Catra wonders if she trusts her enough to judge whether or not they join the Princess Alliance but doesn't say anything. She begins to read through the heavy document, and feels her brain go numb with each page-long paragraph. About halfway through it, she's marked a few odd places, but can't bring herself to read anymore.

"This is so booooring," Catra complains, throwing her head back on the chair to stare at the ceiling.

C’yra chuckles, “You should get used to it. Every important document I’ve ever read looks and sounds just like that.”

“I forgot how much I hate paperwork,” Catra groans, tossing the document on the desk for the moment. She rubs her eyes, “How do you manage?”

“I complain about it as soon as anyone is willing to lend an ear,” C’yra says. “Or I take a break and punch things.”

“I like the latter.”

“Well currently you’re doing the former.”

The two laugh, and the silence settles once again. Catra stares at her mother and realizes how tired she looks. Was it her own decision weighting so heavily on her?

“Mom,” Catra finally speaks up. “Are you . . . upset that I want to join the Princess Alliance.”

C’yra freezes, then sets her pen down and leans back, “I was . . . surprised. I thought you didn’t like them.”

“I don’t like the Horde more than I don’t like them,” Catra argues.

“I suppose that’s fair,” C’yra nods.

Catra stares at her, “. . . Is that it? That you were surprised?”

“Saz no,” C’yra admits with a shaky breath. She runs a hand down her face as she shakes her head, “I don’t like admitting this, but I was scared.”

“Scared?” Catra repeats. “Of losing me again?”

"Yes," C'yra says. "If you're hundreds of miles away on the mainland, I can't protect you like I'm supposed to. Not that I ever seemed to be any good at it . . ."

"You didn't have any control over Shadow Weaver's shitty actions," Catra reminds her. "I . . . I'm just happy that you're here now. And it's not like I really need any protecting, I . . . I just want your support."

Catra glances away from her, until C'yra speaks again."

"You know I was asked to join the Princess Alliance," C'yra says. "While my mother was still alive. Purrsia was always secluded from the rest of the world, not isolated. Ri'ta and I were visiting Bright Moon on a diplomatic mission when Angella asked me."

"And you said no," Catra says.

"I did," C'yra sighs. "I was delusional and naive, thinking that the Horde would never come to Purrsia. More importantly, I was pregnant with you. And honestly, I can't say that decision is one of my regrets."

Many of their conversations have been about regrets. Their many, many regrets. Catra with the horrendous actions she did in the Horde, and C'yra with the mistakes she made during the war. She lets her mother talk.

"I would have been away from Purrsia if I joined," C'yra continues. "I was able to spend more time with you, be with my mother in her final moments. I can say for certain that allying with the Rebellion would not have saved Purrsia. But now . . . that may have changed."

"That sounds like you're warming up to the idea of the Princess Alliance," Catra says.

"I think . . . I think it's time," C'yra agrees. "But it's your choice in the end, and I will support whatever you chose."

“I want to join,” Catra says with finality.

“Then,” C’yra reaches across the table to squeeze one of Catra’s hands. “We shall join.”

“Thank-you,” Catra sighs. Her worries are lifted off of her shoulders, now that she knows that her mothers aren’t angry at her decision. “And I promise I’ll come back.”

“You and I both know that’s quite a heavy promise to keep,” C’yra says sadly. “But I will hold you to it.”

“This is a promise I want to keep,” Catra insists. “Now that’s settled, Mom said she was going to grab us food. Do you have more paperwork, or can we go eat?”

"Before we leave, I want to make sure you're fully prepared to face the world outside of Half Moon and the Horde, so," C'yra pauses, and Catra patiently waits for her to continue. However, she seems very embarrassed by whatever she is going to say next, "When two people love each other very much, they may want to make their relationship … *intimate.* So, they'll perform an act called … ah, *fornication*-"

"Wait," Catra interrupts as she recoils back. "Are you trying to give me the sex talk?!"

"Er… yes I am," C'yra admits. "I just assumed the Horde was lacking in that department."

"I got the sex talk," Catra says. It was from Shadow Weaver, and it was more of a threat than anything else really.

"What did they tell you?" C'yra asks curiously. "If you don't mind me asking."

"They told me what sex was, and if I did it I would get pregnant and kicked out of the Horde and die," Catra says. "Well, that last part isn't relevant anymore."

"That's not quite correct," C'yra says. "Depending on who you're with, you may not get pregnant if you wish to … do it, but if you are with someone who could get you pregnant there are ways to avoid it. Ri'ta knows some protection spells she could teach you."

Catra thinks of *Scutum* and wrinkles her nose, "I'm not good with protection spells."

"Not that kind of protection," C'yra says. "But … hopefully there's no crossover. It'd be good to learn so you can practice safe … sex."

"There's a difference between regular sex and safe sex?" Catra asks. "Is it safer because you're using a shield spell?"

"Oh Saz," C'yra puts her head in her hands as she mumbles to herself. "I should have asked Ri'ta for help."

"You started this," Catra snorts. "Why did you even want to talk about this?"

"Because you're young and if you chose to be intimate with someone I want to make sure you're being careful," C'yra says. Catra raises a brow, expecting more. Her mother's resolve cracks quickly as she leans forward, "And I've seen the way you look at that Adora girl, plus when you two went through a romp in the woods the other day-"

"Don't call it that," Catra groans. "That makes it sound worse."

"-But you came back looking like you were over the moon!" C'yra continues. "If you ever end up dating her and you two decide to get serious, I want to make sure you're prepared!"

"Uh … actually," Catra begins. "I think . . . I do want to kiss her."

C'yra pauses, her eyes going wide. Catra guesses she wasn't expecting that to happen so soon. Neither was Catra, to be honest.

"Do I have to be protected when kissing too?" Catra asks.

"No," C'yra says. "Kissing is fine. And I'm happy that you and Adora have resolved things enough that you feel comfortable enough to be with her. I can tell that she makes you happy."

"Thanks Mom," Catra mumbles. She knew her mother would never be disappointed with her, but she was still unused to kind words.

"But," C'yra growls, balling up the nearest document and sinking her claws into it. "If she ever hurts you again, I am going to hunt her down and make her regret being born."

"Uh … calm down, Mom," Catra says. She's never seen C'yra's protective side come out like this, and she never had anyone who would fiercely protect her like that. It's kinda nice … and also slightly scary.

"Sorry," C'yra sighs. "It's Ri'ta's turn to give Adora the shovel talk."

"What?"

"Anyways," C'yra sighs. "If you want, we could continue the … sex talk."

Catra has to think it over. The Horde was extremely limited in what information they gave her, so maybe it's better to take this opportunity right now, even though C'yra looks uncomfortable. She started it.

"I guess … better to be safe than sorry?" Catra says.

And then proceeds the most awkward conversation of Catra's life.

Catra and C'yra return to their home slightly traumatized, and with Ri'ta waiting for them. She instantly stands up and stares at the two of them, "Oh Saz, what happened?"

"I don't want to talk about it," Catra weakly says.

Ri'ta turns her angry glare to C'yra, who raises her hands in defense, "I *may* have given Catra the sex talk-"

"How did it go from talking about Catra's decision to join the Princess Alliance to the *birds and the bees!?*" Ri'ta exclaims, sounding astonished rather than angry.

"I want to make sure Catra's prepared for anything!"

That's all it takes for Ri'ta to burst out laughing.

"It's not that funny," C'yra huffs.

"I'm sorry," Ri'ta says, but she's still laughing. "But was everything else cleared up?"

"Yes," Catra answers. "We're good."

"Good," Ri'ta sighs and finally calms down. "Now, we can stop thinking about that for the moment and eat, though it's a bit cold by now."

"One more thing," C'yra says, turning to Catra. "Would you like to attend the Council Meeting tomorrow? You'll be able to sit with us as the Princess, but not make any votes, mostly be an observer. You can get a head start on getting used to how the Council works."

". . . I think I'd like that," Catra admits.

"I'll make sure Gr'wliger excuses you for the day then," C'yra says. Ri'ta is staring between her and the food, so she sighs, "Now we can eat. Ri'ta, you didn't have to wait for us."

"I didn't," Ri'ta says. "I just want seconds."

Catra and C'yra laugh as they sit down with Ri'ta. They don't talk about Catra's decision for the rest of the night, instead just enjoying being together as family. After all, who knows how long this will last.

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you all for reading! If you liked the chapter, consider leaving a comment! If you want to hear more from me, you can find me on Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 or on tumblr at sniperdoodle. Have a good day!

Interlude IX: Adora IV

Chapter Summary

The Council decides on whether or not to join the Princess Alliance . . . again. Adora is nervous the whole time.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Today, the Council decides on whether Purrsia will join the Alliance. Again.

Adora's nervous. No, not because she really wants the Magicats to join the Rebellion, though that would be good. She's worried about Catra. She was so worried about upsetting her mothers yesterday, but Adora hasn't seen her since she disappeared through the Council doors to talk to Ri'ta.

If Adora's being honest, she hasn't gotten a good read on the Queens of the Magicats yet. Catra and everyone else speaks so highly of them. From what she's seen, that's all true, despite not really talking with them. She just . . . doesn't want Catra to get hurt again.

It doesn't help that she's not at breakfast either.

"Wait," Thom yells. "CATRA'S THE PRINCESS?!"

"Was that not obvious?" Sh'dowell asks.

"Didn't you ever see C'yra before she lost her eye?" Gar'ett adds. "She has the same eye colors and looks just like her."

"If it was obvious," Thom grumbles. "Why didn't anyone talk about it?!"

Sh'dowell only shrugs at that, while Shire provides a better answer, "She wasn't ready. So, if she wasn't going to mention it, no one else would."

"Honestly, you're probably the only person in Half Moon who didn't figure it out," Sh'dowell says.

"Speak for yourself," Glimmer grumbles. "I can't *believe* Catra is a Princess! I'm on an equal authoritative level with Catra! We're even *both* going to become Queens!"

"And that's why she didn't want to mention it," Shire sighs.

"Is that even really all that important?" Bow questions as he pats Glimmer's back.

"I think its cool!" Scorpia argues. "Now, we're Princess buddies, and our friendship is even stronger!"

"Speaking of that," Bow says. "If Catra joins the Princess Alliance, are you going to join too Scorpia?"

"I've been thinking about that," Scorpia murmurs. "I can't go back to the Horde, not after what they've done to Catra and *especially* after all they've done to the Tlincalli. Even if Catra wasn't going to join . . . I was going to ask if I could."

"Of course you can join, Scorpia!" Bow says. He nudges Glimmer in the side, to try and get her out of the funk.

"Yeah!" Glimmer nods suddenly. "We could use someone like you in the Alliance, Scorpia."

"Good," Scorpia smiles.

"Though," Glimmer taps her chin as she smirks. "Imagine the look on my mom's face when I come back with two new Princesses recruited, and they're both former Horde soldiers."

Adora would like to imagine that. She's would like to imagine anything other than what Catra could be feeling now, but she's stuck sadly picking at her breakfast . . . until C'yra entering the cafeteria catches her eye. Slowly, she picks herself up as C'yra heads to kitchen and accepts a basket from Jen'dots, disappearing as quickly as she came.

"I'll be right back!" Adora shoots out an excuse as she quickly tries to catch up to C'yra, to not lose track of her.

C'yra briskly moves through the halls of Half Moon and morning crowds, but Adora is able to keep an eye on her purple cape from a reasonable distance. As far as she can tell, C'yra seems . . . unbothered, holding herself up high. Or, maybe that's just her natural state as Queen. Eventually, she enters the residential area and Adora has to make sure she stays out of sight. She only loses track after C'yra enters a room that must be hers and Ri'ta's home.

Her mind races, wondering how she can find out if the Queens are mad at Catra. Could she just knock on their door and ask if they've seen Catra? Or is that too obvious?"

Poof!

"What are you doing?"

"Ah!" Adora jumps around into a fighting stance and nearly connects a fist with Glimmer's face. She sputters, "W-why!?"

"Because I saw you sneaking off," Glimmer crosses her arms and gives Adora a pointedly look. "To follows Queen C'yra, of all people. I had to make sure you weren't going to do something stupid."

"I'm not!" Adora protests.

"Then what are you doing?" Glimmer asks.

"Looking for Catra!" Adora blurts out. It's a half-truth, but at least it's not a full lie.

Glimmer stares at her through squinted eyes, "You're lying."

Adora deflates, "Only kinda."

"You're getting better," Glimmer admits. "Which I will blame on Catra. So, what are you really doing?"

"I . . . I want to make sure C'yra and Ri'ta aren't upset at Catra," Adora says.

"And what would you do if they were?" Glimmer asks. "Try to convince them that it's all your fault?"

Adora honestly hasn't gotten that far, since this was a spur of the moment thing. All she can do is shrug.

"Listen, knowing my mom and how she reacted I first wanted to be involved in the Rebellion, they're probably just concerned for her safety," Glimmer says. "And, it doesn't help that she's been captured by the Horde once. They won't be mad at her."

"But how can I be sure?"

"Just ask herself yourself."

"Huh?"

"Hey Adora."

Glimmer disappears as Adora whirls around, and Catra is standing in the doorway or C'yra and Ri'ta's home. It never occurred to her that Catra may just be staying with her mothers.

"Everything okay?" Catra asks as she saunters over.

"Yeah!" Adora tries to insists, but her voice cracks, causing Catra to snicker.

"Cuz my mom said you were following her, and she thought it was weird you didn't talk to her," Catra saunters over with a smirk. "Everything alright?"

"I should be asking you that question," Adora says. Her voice goes quiet, as the door is still open, "Did everything go alright with the Queens?"

Catra nods, "Yeah, I talked with both of them. They don't want to lose me again, so they were worried. But they aren't mad."

"Oh," Adora sighs, her body sagging as the anxiety leaves her. "That's good."

"And actually," Catra continues. "They asked me to sit in on the Council meeting. I don't get to vote or anything, but it'll be cool. But, are you okay?"

Adora blinks, why was Catra asking if she's okay when she told her mothers she wanted to leave Half Moon to fight for a war they nearly lost everything in? "What do you mean?"

"You don't look any better than I did yesterday," Catra says, but concern only shows on her face for a moment before she masks it with a smirk, "What, do you care about me or something?"

"Of course, I do," Adora says, half-heartedly but playfully pushing Catra in the shoulder. Now is when Catra jokes back, but instead a blush rises through her fur. "Are you sure you're okay?"

"Catra!" Ri'ta calls out, stepping into the hallway. "Do you want to eat the rest of your breakfast or are you going to forfeit to C'yra?"

"I was going to wait!" C'yra shouts from inside.

Catra turns back to Adora, who sighs, "You should go. You need your energy for the Council meeting."

"Thanks," Catra nods. "And . . . do you want to talk afterwards? Like, just the two of us where-" she turns over her shoulder, "-Nosey parents can't eavesdrop!"

Ri'ta is still standing in the doorway. She crosses her arms and tilts her head back in faux astonishment, but the smirk on her face betrays her, "I don't know what you're talking about, kitten."

"That sounds perfect," Adora agrees. "I'll see you later."

"Later," Catra promises. She turns around and starts herding Ri'ta back inside, both of them smiling. Catra really has become closes to her mothers in the short time she's been in Half Moon. Despite her anxieties seeping through, she's comfortable enough around them for them to touch her and call her nicknames.

It makes Adora feel bad for asking her to leave.

The Council is once again in session to decide if Purrsia should join the Princess Alliance.

Adora's nervous. Again.

She still isn't too concerned about whether they join or not, but she is nervous about Catra. What does she want to talk about? Is Adora a bad person for asking her to leave her home? But will she have to leave Catra behind if she really does not want to go?

"How is she more anxious?" Bow asks Glimmer as they wait outside the Council doors. Adora paces while the rest of the

Princess Alliance-now including Scorpia-sit back and wait for their decision.

"I don't know," Glimmer shrugs. "She *talked* with Catra, who is perfectly fine by the way."

"I knew she'd be," Scorpia nods. "C'yra and Ri'ta are like, *really* nice. She's lucky to have them."

That only makes Adora feel worse.

The doors to the Council creak open, and Busto pokes his head in with a small smile, "The Council summons the Princess Alliance leaders."

Adora shares a nervous look with the others. Glimmer stands up straight, looking like a mini-Angella, and nods, "Let's do this."

The Council room looks the same as last time, but now Catra sits between C'yra and Ri'ta. The entire Council-including Catra-wears a schooled expression, so Adora can't even tell whether they joined or not. The Alliance stands at the open spot, Glimmer in the front as everyone else stands behind them.

"Princess Glimmer," C'yra addresses, pauses until a small smile sneaks onto her face. "After much reconsidering, Purrsia has agreed to join the Rebellion."

Adora meets Catra's eyes, and she smiles. It's a genuine smile, one she's started to see from her childhood friend more and more. It certainly helps calm some of her nerves.

"Thank-you so much, Queen C'yra," Glimmer manages to stay professional. "I am glad that you understand that we're stronger together, and we'll be able to defeat the Horde."

"Right now, all we can afford to send is our Princess and a small guard," C'yra continues. "The safety of the Magicats is our priority."

"I understand," Glimmer nods. "And I know that we are gaining a great warrior in the form of Princess Fel'cty."

"I've kicked your butt before so you're lucky to have me," Catra teases. Glimmer pouts, but it brings a smile to some of the members of the Council-including the Queens.

The rest of the meeting is mostly talking about logistics between Glimmer and the Council, Bow occasionally chiming in when it drifts into more technological topics. Adora's eyes constantly drift back to Catra, who meets her gaze with a small smile. It takes about another hour, but then the Council is dismissed.

Catra bids goodbye to her mothers and heads straight for Adora, who asks, "So, how was the Council meeting?"

"It wasn't as boring as I thought it would be," Catra shrugs. "I thought I would just be an observer, but the Council had a lot of questions for me about the Horde and mainland Etheria. Anyway, let's get out of here."

To Adora's surprise, Catra takes her hand and pulls her away, and she lets herself be pulled along as she blushes at their touch. They've held hands before, why is now anything different? They end up in a hallway leading out of the antechamber that doesn't seem to go anywhere, but it's quiet.

"So," Adora kicks a rock on the ground. "Are you excited about joining the Princess Alliance?"

"I think right now I'm a little more nervous, if I'm being honest," Catra says. "But I'm looking forward to the things we could accomplish together.

"Good, good," Adora nods.

Catra stares at her, "Were you worried?"

Adora doesn't want to worry Catra in return, but knows she can be honest with her, "I . . . I didn't want to drag you away from Half Moon if you really didn't want to go."

"I want to," Catra insists, reaching out to take Adora's hand again. "I really do."

"You're sure?" Adora checks.

"Yes," Catra nods. "Now, about what I wanted to talk about . . ."

"Right," Adora nods and leans back. "What's up?"

To her surprise, Catra doesn't speak right away, rather she seems nervous. Is this something really important then? Maybe it has to do with how they'll be leaving for Bright Moon soon. There's a lot of important details that will have to be hashed out-

"We've . . . we've known each other for a long time," Catra begins, rather quietly.

"We've been friends as long as I can remember," Adora says. Her earliest memory is finding Catra in the Horde. "Aside from the period of time where we weren't friends." She doesn't really want to think about that now that they're on good terms.

"Yeah," Catra nods, glancing to the side. "But I think . . . how I feel about you has changed . . . or had changed . . . before either of us left the Horde, into something more . . . serious."

Adora furrows her brows, "What do you mean?"

"I like you, a lot," Catra basically spits the words out. "Like, more than a friend. And, I don't know if you feel the same now that you're surrounded by Princesses but-"

"Wait," Adora blinks. "Are . . . are you saying you want to be my girlfriend?"

Before heading to Bright Moon, Adora wasn't familiar with the terms of romantical relationships. She's very thankful that Glimmer has given her rundown before this moment, when everything suddenly makes sense. Her own feelings about Catra always seemed more intense than how she felt about Glimmer or Bow, of course they're romantic.

"Yes," Catra nods. "But only if you want to! If you don't feel the same way . . . then, then we'll just forget this ever happened and go back to normal-"

"No, I-I like you too," Adora says. "I like you a lot."

Catra stares at her before sighing, "Oh thank Saz."

It feels right to think of Catra as her girlfriend-they've always been close, and this is the inevitable conclusion. Adora reaches out and carefully takes Catra's hand, who eagerly squeezes back.

"So we're girlfriends?" Catra checks.

"Yes," Adora says with a giggle. "If you want."

"Of course, I want to. I wouldn't have gone through that nerve-wracking confession if I didn't," Catra says with a slight scowl. "Does that mean I can kiss you?"

Adora's surprised her brain doesn't short-circuit right there. Kissing Catra, her best friend and now girlfriend? It had been a secret desire locked behind denial, fear and eventually a growing rift between them. As a blush grows on her face, Adora can only dumbly nod.

Catra smiles as she leans in, and all Adora can focus on is her lips. However, she pauses just before they meet, "I . . . I haven't done this before."

"Neither have I," Adora quietly admits. "But it doesn't have to be perfect."

"Says the perfectionist," Catra scoffs.

"Hey-!" Catra shuts her up with a kiss, crossing the gap to smash their lips together. It is rough, but it feels like they fit perfectly together.

"Guess you won that bet."

Adora and Catra jump apart and stare at C'yra and Ri'ta, who are standing at the end of the hallway with shit-eating grins.

"Haven't you learned by now to never bet against me?" Ri'ta asks, nudging C'yra in the side.

"CAN'T I GET ANY PRIVACY!?" Catra yells as Adora blushes and wonders how much the Queens heard.

"And miss our daughter's first kiss? Never," Ri'ta teases.

"What even was the bet?!" Catra says.

"Who would kiss who first," C'yra says with a shrug.

Catra stares at her mothers, "*Why*?"

"We have to have some fun," Ri'ta says. "But speaking of fun . . ."

She nudges C'yra forward, who rolls her eyes before she says, "I'm sorry to interrupt, but there's something I wished to speak about with you Catra."

". . . Can't it wait?" Catra sighs.

"Sadly, no," C'yra says.

Catra turns to Adora and sighs loudly, "We aren't done here."

"I hope not," Adora murmurs.

With another sigh, Catra follows C'yra out of the small hallway. To Adora's surprise, Ri'ta didn't follow. She turns to Adora with a sweet smile, "Now, we can talk."

"Oh," neither of the Queens have really talked to Adora, so she wonders what they want with her now. "How can I help you?"

Ri'ta walks over, and Adora can't help but feel like a deer in headlights. She places a hand on Adora's shoulder, "I know you and Catra grew up together-you were there for her when C'yra and I couldn't be. But . . . you still fell apart."

"Yes," Adora nods. "And . . . I wish she came with me, but now we're friends again. More than friends? I really wish we could have finished that conversation."

"Either way, Catra cares a lot about you," Ri'ta says, and the grip on her shoulder turns painful. "And if you ever hurt her again . . ."

Adora gulps, "I wont."

"But if you do," Ri'ta usually calm eyes becomes harsh. "Let me remind you that I come from one of the most clever and magical clans in all of Purrsia, and I'll find a way to make your life a living hell," Quickly, she flips and smiles warmly, "Okay?"

"Uh . . ." Adora stares at Ri'ta in fear just as C'yra and Catra return.

"I don't get why we even had to step away to talk about that," Catra pouts.

"Because we did," C'yra pats Catra's back as she turns to Ri'ta. "You done?"

"For now," Ri'ta says with a smile, scaring Adora further.

Catra stares at the Queens, "You two are acting weird."

"Don't worry," Ri'ta insists. "Adora and I just had a friendly talk . . . right Adora?"

"Yep!" Adora instantly straightens up and tries to smile. "Completely friendly!"

With a shake of her head, Catra turns to Ri'ta, "You didn't know that Adora is an absolutely terrible liar, did you?"

"I threatened her a little," Ri'ta says with a shrug.

"Mom!" Catra gasps.

"I also plan on threatening her a little," C'yra adds. "But Ri'ta has dibs."

"I can't believe you two," Catra groans into her hands.

"It just shows that they care for you?" Adora tries to help, though she's not quite sure who she's helping. The mood isn't helped by Glimmer teleporting in the middle.

"There you guys are!" Glimmer sighs, looking between Catra and Adora. "Bow and I have been looking everywhere for you! We have to talk."

"About what?" Catra scoffs.

"We need to get back to Bright Moon soon, I'm sure my mom is going crazy worrying about me," Glimmer admits with a nervous laugh. "So, we'll be leaving in four days."

"Four days?" Ri'ta says, the amusement gone of her voice. She and C'yra share a sad look, "That soon?"

Glimmer turns to them, surprised to see the Queens there, "We really need to rejoin the Rebellion sooner rather than later. Will that be enough time?"

C’yra sighs, “I suppose it will. Catra is that okay with you?”

Catra shares her mother’s sad look, but says, “If that’s how soon we need to leave, that’s when we’ll leave.”

“Okay, when you’re done here,” Glimmer waves her hand around. “Then come find Bow, Scorpia, Sea Hawk and I so we can all finalize everything.”

“Got it,” Catra sighs. Glimmer disappears as soon as she came with a sparkly poof, and instantly Catra’s is accosted with a hug from Ri’ta, “Ah Mom, what’s this for?”

“We have four more days together until you leave,” Ri’ta says, trapping Catra. “Let me have this.”

“You’re making me jealous,” C’yra says.

“Then come join us,” Ri’ta scoffs.

“As long as you don’t crush me,” Catra adds.

C’yra joins the hug, wrapping both Ri’ta and Catra in her arms. Adora feels like she’s intruding on what should be a personal moment, but she’s happy to know that Catra has a family that love her and look out for her. She can only hope she’ll be able to give Catra the same when they depart for Bright Moon.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you liked the chapter, please consider leaving a comment! I suck at responding but I treasure each one. And have a good day!

i'll make you proud of everything i know

Chapter Summary

Catra prepares to leave Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With a four-day time limit, there's a lot Catra has to do-starting with coming up with an actual plan.

The day after the Council meeting, she meets with C'yra and Ri'ta to talk about her leaving and Purrsia's interaction with the outside world. That means that Gr'wliger's here.

"Not that I don't like see you Gr'wliger," C'yra says, sitting forward in her desk. "But why are you here?"

"He's coming with me," Catra answers first as he opens his mouth. "Because he's my friend and he wants to see the outside world."

Gr'wliger nods, "That is true. It also means that Catra will have someone from Purrsia watching her back."

C'yra and Ri'ta share a look, the former asking, "But what about your position as head hunter?"

"I am in the process of picking someone to take over the role for me," Gr'wliger says. "Also, I am prepared for staying out of the public eye. My skills as a sniper will allow to me to engage in battle from a distance and while hidden."

"Well," C'yra shrugs. "I must admit I'm not opposed to you journeying with Catra. I can trust you to protect her."

Catra pouts, "I don't need protection."

"I know, but it helps put my own mind at ease," C'yra insists. "Permission granted, Gr'wliger."

Gr'wliger bows deeply, "Thank-you so much, Queen C'yra. I promise to do everything I can to protect Purrsia while on the mainland."

"Which means not talking about it," Ri'ta adds. "The less you both talk about Half Moon, the better. Only talk to trusted allies like Queen Angella and the Princesses can be let in about our existence."

"Of course," Catra nods.

They spend the rest of their meeting going over what should and should not be mentioned. Things like the Magicat's defenses and where exactly the caves should be kept close to their chest, while the general existence of them can be told to close allies. After an hour, Gr'wliger departs for his own duties, leaving Catra alone with her moms.

"Have you started packing?" Ri'ta checks.

"I have four days," Catra scoffs.

"That time will be gone before you know it," C'yra says. "Plus, it'll give you time to decide what you really need to bring."

"You have two rooms, technically," Ri'ta says. "And I already promised you could bring some magic books for the library. It's better to start sooner rather than later."

"Uhg, fine," Catra stands up. "Is there anything else we have to talk about, or can I go pack?"

"We can talk about your girlfriend!" C'yra says eagerly.

"Oo yes," Ri'ta nods. "Have you two decided on a first date yet?"

Catra stares at her moms and stands, “I’m leaving.”

Catra stares at the room she rarely stays in, far away from her mother’s quarters. It’s quite a mess, but she has to start somewhere. She decides to sort everything into three piles: things to take, things to leave, and things that need to be returned to the library.

However, she doesn’t seem to get very far in her clean-up process.

There’s a lot of library books, that should be easy enough to take back. However, once glance at the covers reminds her of the time she spent researching the Three Stars and learning more about them. She still doesn’t believe in them, but between the two Temples and incorporating swearing to Saz into her vocabulary, it seems they’ve been integrated into her life anyway.

Just like everything else in Half Moon.

She remains frozen until it’s time for lunch. It’s only then she’s able to move herself to the cafeteria, to join Adora and her friends to eat.

No packing gets done.

There’s one thing Catra *needs* to get done before she leaves, and it’s not packing.

She wants to learn a new spell.

It’s something she wants to surprise her mothers with, so she doesn’t want to ask Ri’ta. That leaves one person to help her: Thom.

“What about this one?” Thom asks as he lifts the book up for Catra to see.

She reads over his shoulder and shakes her head, “No, that’s in the right direction but not quite what I’m looking for. Keep looking.”

Catra returns to her own book as Thom groans, “Why don’t you just ask Ri’ta? She’ll know.”

“I don’t want to ask Ri’ta because I want to surprise her and C’yra when I leave,” Catra says. Thom stills when she mentions leaving, “Hey, you find something else?”

“No,” Thom mumbles and he shifts so his back is to her, shoulders curling further.

“Okay, something’s wrong,” Catra says. “Spill it.”

“Nothing’s wrong,” Thom insists. He only manages to hide it for another moment, when he turns around and says, “I want to come with you.”

“What?” Catra blinks. “Why the fuck would you want to come with me?”

“Well, everything’s been goin’ good for me recently, but I feel like I don’t deserve it. I was really shitty for a long time,” Thom mutters. “And you . . . I know you went through your own shit to get to where you are now. If I come with you . . . it might be a chance to redeem myself.”

“Thom, you don’t have to do that,” Catra insists. “You just have to keep on doing your best to do better every day. That’s what I did.”

“But that's not what happened! You dragged me to the library and turned my life around without me having to do scat!” Thom argues. “Let me come with you!”

“Are you sure this is really what you want to do and not some complex scheme to avoid Busto since he tried to ask you

out . . .” Catra watches as Thom curls in on himself, glancing at the ground as he scratches the back of his neck. “No, oh no.”

“I . . . I don’t deserve him,” Thom says. “Even after all the stuff I did, he still wants to be my friend-*more* than a friend-and I just don’t understand! I need to do something to make it feel like I’m worthy of him! And protecting his best friend seems like the best option!”

“Oh Saz,” Catra groans. “It’s like staring in a pathetic mirror.”

“What?”

“Listen, Busto likes you the way you are, no matter what you did, you don’t need to do anything to be with him,” Catra says.

“But!” Thom continues. “Won’t you need a magic buddy to do magic within Bright Moon?”

“You didn’t know what components were two weeks ago,” Catra points out.

“Catra, please!” Thom begs.

“Thom,” Catra puts her hands on his shoulders to force him to look in her eyes. “I’m going to war. The Rebellion is fighting against the Horde in a war. Do you even remember the Horde?”

“I remember my village being burned down,” Thom says quietly. “I know they’re bad, Catra. I wouldn’t be asking to join you if I didn’t realize what I was getting into.”

She has a feeling that Thom isn’t going to let this go.

“Uhg, fine!” Catra gives in. “Only if you find the spell I’m looking for *and* you talk to Busto before we go.”

"Deal," Thom nods eagerly. He glances down at the page and his smile widens, "Hey is this it?"

Catra leans over one more time, "That is exactly it. Let's practice it."

"But," Thom wags his finger at her. "That means I get to come along with you."

"No, you only accomplished the first part," Catra says as she stands up. "You still have to talk with Busto."

"Do I really?" Thom whines.

"*Yes*."

"Okay, fine."

With three days to go, it's time for Catra to pack.

This time, she's recruited Adora and Scorpia to help her.

Once again, they start in her rarely used room.

"Catra, this is a mess," Adora says.

"Well, I don't really sleep here," Catra kicks some clothes over. "I have a room in my moms' place."

"Wait, you have two rooms?" Scorpia asks.

"Yeah, but I kinda just dump dirty clothes in this one," Catra admits.

"I can tell," Adora sighs. She stands up straight and claps her hands together, "So, I think the best plan of attack will be to sort by type: books, clothes, weapons, notes, and miscellaneous. Then we can wash all the dirty clothes and decide what should stay and what you should take."

"Wouldn't it be easier to do stuff I'll take, stuff I'll leave here, and stuff that needs to go to library?" Catra counters. "AKA, nearly all of these books."

"We could get the books out of the way," Scorpia suggests. "Then we only have to deal with stuff that's actually yours."

The three stares at each other, but eventually Adora and Catra agree, "Scorpia's idea's the best."

Slowly, they begin to sort through the mess of the room, pulling out a variety of library books. Most are heavy old tomes, and some are rolled up maps. Eventually, Adora finds one of those maps-specifically the star map.

"What is this?" Adora gasps.

"Star map," Catra says.

Scorpia glances over Adora's shoulder, "What's a star?"

"A glowy thing that was in the sky," Catra haphazardly explains, as she's focused on carrying way too many books. "And there was a lot of them."

"I . . . I thought I was the only one who knew about stars," Adora says quietly.

"No, it's like . . . a thing with the Magicats, they used to use them for travel and stuff before they mysteriously disappeared," she stares at Adora who is still marveling at the map. "Do you want to see what else the library has on stars?"

Adora nods vigorously.

"Then grab some books to take back and let's go."

In the end, the three spend the rest of the day in the library learning about stars.

No packing gets done.

Catra taps her claws on the table, and the noise echoes through the Council Room. This is the last meeting they'll have before she leaves in two days. She, C'yra, Ri'ta, and Gr'wliger have been waiting for Az'al for nearly ten minutes.

"Can't we start without her?" Catra asks. "She's just the General, what does she have to do with me leaving?"

"Because this is a matter of national security, if you're *both* leaving," C'yra says.

"Maybe she forgot?" Gr'wliger suggests.

"She wouldn't," C'yra says. ". . . I wrote her a note."

The doors to the Council room burst open and Az'al arrives . . . followed by D'nah. The General looks annoyed while D'nah doesn't stop talking, "-And therefore I am perfect for the job!"

Az'al marches over to the table and grips the edge, "I apologize for being late," she glances over her shoulder and growls, "You are dismissed, soldier."

"With all due respect, General Az'al," D'nah stands straight as a board. "I will not leave until I get an answer, sir."

"What's going on here?" C'yra asks, curious rather than annoyed, like Az'al.

"It's nothing," Az'al says. "But . . . Sergeant D'nah, I'm not the person you should be asking this to." Az'al turns to Catra, "You should be asking her."

"Me?" Catra asks. What would D'nah want from her?

D’nah turns to her and stands at attention-even though it looks like it pains her to give any respect to Catra-to say, “Princess Fel’cty, I request to be made Captain of your Royal Guard.”

“My what now?” Catra asks. She looks to her mothers for an explanation.

“There used to be an established Royal Guard,” Ri’ta says. “But they were disbanded after your . . . disappearance.”

“And . . .” Catra faces D’nah again. “Why would you want to be a part of the Royal Guard for *me*?”

“I still don’t like you-” D’nah begins.

“You’re already winning me over,” Catra says sarcastically.

“But I want to fight the Horde,” D’nah says. “They killed my family. Destroyed our country. I want revenge.”

That’s the same reason Catra’s fighting. And there’s probably more like D’nah in Half Moon, who wants revenge against the Horde. Catra can’t bring them all with her to get their pound of flesh. With D’nah, however . . . despite everything Catra finds that she respects her. If she could bring any soldier with her, she’d obviously choose Busto first, but D’nah would be next on the list. And since Busto won’t be coming with her . . .

“Okay,” Catra agrees.

“I am perfect for the position, I’m already in line for a promotion and-” D’nah stops. “Wait, what?”

“Gr’wliger and Thom are coming with me,” Catra shrugs. “What’s one more?”

“Thom’s coming with you?” Ri’ta interrupts with wide eyes.

"He wants to redeem himself and avoid Busto or something," Catra tries to quickly explain. She doesn't quite understand it either, but she lost the argument against him.

"I'm losing *both* of my magic students?" Ri'ta exclaims, but from the grin on her face Catra knows she's only teasing.

"You're . . ." D'nah says. "Really fine with me becoming head of the Royal Guard?"

"You'd be my only Royal Guard," Catra points out. "But, that means that I get to boss you around. No take-backs, by the way."

D'nah's eyes go wide as she hisses, "Shit."

"I do get a say in this too," C'yra interrupts. "And, the more Magicats on the mainland means there's more chances for the Horde to discover us. But . . . it would mean extra protection for you, Catra."

"Uhg, mom," Catra groans.

"D'nah," C'yra continues. "You will have to pledge your loyalty to the Princess on Saz's name. Are you prepared for that?"

"I know," D'nah says. "And I am willing to make the pledge right here and now."

"Then, let's do it," C'yra steps forward to stand behind Catra and places a hand on Catra's shoulder. "This is a pledge between the two of you. Catra, hold out your hand."

"Uh, okay," Catra holds out her hand.

"And D'nah, take Catra's hand and kneel," C'yra continue.

D'nah does so, and Catra instantly feels odd, "This is weird."

"It's tradition," Ri'ta shrugs.

"Repeat after me, D'nah," C'yra says. "I, and then your name, pledge myself to the health and protection of Princess Fel'cty of D'riluth in Saz's name."

"I, D'nah of Cori'pat, pledge myself to the health and protection of Princess Fel'cty of D'riluth in Saz's name," D'nah says.

Catra glances back at C'yra, "Is that it?"

"Yes, that is it," C'yra says. "Now, D'nah is your guard and is in charge of your safety."

"Shouldn't I be in charge of that?" Catra checks.

"She'll keep you from being reckless," Ri'ta says with a small smile. "Now that we're all here, shall we start?"

"Should I stay?" D'nah checks as she stands up.

"Yeah," Catra says before anyone can respond. She's in charge of her now, after all. "You're coming with me, you should be here for this."

Now, Catra's leaving with Gr'wliger, Thom and D'nah. It could be dangerous, but Catra's glad she won't be the only Magicat out on the mainland.

"Remember, Catra!" Glimmer shouts as Catra tries to close the door. "We leave tomorrow! You have to be ready, or we'll leave without you!"

"You won't leave without me!" Catra argues.

"Do you want to risk it?" Glimmer counters.

"Fine! I'll be ready!" Catra groans. "Now leave me alone!"

With a slam of the door, Catra rests her back on it and turns toward C'yra and Ri'ta's apartment. She hasn't made any progress in packing despite the warnings and offers of help.

Currently, neither of her mothers are home. Catra felt overwhelmed by her little used room, and wondered if this one, that is more lived in and slightly more organized, would be easier. She trudges down the hallway and enters.

She starts with the most significant items: her two sets of fancy princess clothes, her grandmother's spear, a few spell books Ri'ta is letting her take, her hunter's cloak, the bracelet N'yan bought her . . . why does it feel like there should be more?

As she stares at the items she throws onto her bed, she feels . . . something. Something not good. She never really had anything she owned, especially in the Horde, where the only thing she considered 'hers' was Adora. Since coming to Half Moon, her life has been so full . . . by why does she feel empty now when she looks at the pittance worth of items she owns?

It's the people, Catra realizes as tears start to slowly fall down her face, the people of Half Moon have made her life rich. Shire, N'yan, Busto, Gr'wliger, Sh'dowell, Gar'ett, Demeter, Thom . . . her mothers. She's leaving most of them behind.

"Catra, are you finally packing?" Ri'ta knocks on the door and calls out, but the door squeaks wide open as she hurriedly enters. "Kitten, is everything alright?"

"I . . ." Catra doesn't quite understand why she's crying, but everything feels so much. When Ri'ta places a hand on her shoulder, she turns and sees C'yra standing in the doorway too, looking just as concerned as Ri'ta. "I'm gonna miss you two."

"Oh, we're going to miss you too," Ri'ta says, and she wipes away Catra's tears with her thumbs.

"T-this is something I-I have to do," Catra sniffles. "But . . . I . . . I . . ."

"It's always hard to say goodbye," C'yra says, joining them by sitting on the bed. "And it's okay to not like them. But, this isn't goodbye. We're going to see each other again."

"You did promise," Ri'ta reminds her with a soft smile.

"And we'll find a way to communicate," C'yra continues. "We'll let you know what's going on in Half Moon, and we'll want to know how you're doing."

"O-okay," Catra sighs. She wonders if that's why she hasn't been packing-it's one step closer to saying the dreaded goodbye.

"Are you feeling better?" Ri'ta asks.

Catra nods, "Can . . . can you two help me pack?"

C'yra smiles, "Of course."

"With minimal complaining over how you should have started days ago," Ri'ta adds.

On her final day in Half Moon, Catra spends it with her moms. Who knows when she'll get to do this again?

Chapter End Notes

Thank-you for reading and if you liked the chapter please leave a comment! I'm great at responding, but I appreciate everyone! Next time, it's the last chapter!

just a dream and the wind to carry me

Chapter Summary

Catra leaves Half Moon.

Chapter Notes

This is it. Enjoy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Today is the day, Catra thinks as she stares at the ceiling. She's leaving Half Moon.

She's been staring at the ceiling for what feels like hours, sleep not coming easy to her throughout the night. A knock on the door is what finally convinces her to move.

"Catra!" Adora calls through the door. "Are you up?"

Catra opens the door, "Adora, how the hell did you get in?"

Considering she spent the night with her mothers, Adora shouldn't be here. But, Adora just smiles and kisses her cheek, "Good morning to you too. Queen C'yra let me in. She also wants to let you know you're missing breakfast."

"You can just call her C'yra," Catra mumbles as she enters the main room.

"No," C'yra interjects. "She has to call me Queen C'yra."

It takes Catra a moment to notice the tense atmosphere between C'yra and Adora, while Ri'ta smirks in the background. She sighs, "Adora, did C'yra give you a shovel talk too?"

"Definitely not," Adora unconvincingly lies, nodding her head.

Catra glares at C'yra, who shrugs, "I know she's not a good liar. It was my turn though."

She shakes her head as she sits down, "Adora, are you joining us or are you just going to stand around awkwardly?"

"I promised to help Glimmer wrap things up," Adora says with a sigh. "I would if I could . . . and if your moms weren't glaring at me."

Catra turns around, but C'yra and Ri'ta appears absolutely pleasant. The latter says, "Is it so bad we want to spend time with our daughter before she leaves?"

"Yeah, we're going to have a lot of time to spend together soon," Adora agrees.

"Okay," Catra grabs Adora's hand to pull her in for a quick kiss. Adora looks stunned, and Catra smirks at the reaction she was able to pull from her girlfriend. "I'll see you later."

"Later," Adora agrees, blinking back to reality. She gives Catra one more kiss on the cheek before she leaves.

"So," Ri'ta starts as soon as the door closes, and Catra turns to find she's sporting a devious smirk, "Have you planned yours and Adora's first date yet?"

"No," Catra begins to dig into her breakfast but pauses, "Do I need to?"

"You have enough to worry about right now, don't worry about first dates," C'yra advises. "Is there anything else you have to do today before you . . . the Princess Alliance leaves?"

C'yra couldn't even bring herself to say that Catra's leaving. Honestly, Catra's going to have a hard time too. She shakes her head, "We packed everything yesterday, we just have to meet the others at the front gates this afternoon."

"Have you said your goodbyes?" Ri'ta says suddenly, but quickly changes, "No, it's not a goodbye. Have you talked to everyone you wanted to before you leave? I'm sure plenty of your friends want to send you off."

Catra blinks, "I haven't."

"That would be a good way to spend the day," C'yra agrees.

"Do . . . would you rather I spend time with you two?" Catra checks. She knows her mothers are going to be hit the hardest by her leaving.

"We don't deserve to monopolize your time when your friends are going to miss you too," Ri'ta insists.

"And we'll be coming with you all the way to the shore," C'yra reveals.

"Okay," Catra nods. "Then I'll do that."

She wants to take all of Half Moon in, just in case it may be the last time.

Life goes on in Half Moon despite how momentous today feels for Catra. She passes through the busy hallways, and its denizens are unburdened. They wave to her as she passes, calling her 'Princess'. What a dramatic shift from when she first arrived.

She heads to the Hunter's HQ first, since she knows that her friends should be back from their morning hunts. However, she was surprised to see Gr'wliger there, who has his own packing to do. He's standing in the middle of the room awkwardly while Sh'dowell cries while clinging to him, and Demeter and Gar'ett watch.

“What have I missed?” Catra asks, trying to comprehend the odd scene before her.

“Sh’dowell’s saying goodbye,” Gar’ett answers.

“Though they only got through one word before they burst into tears,” Demeter adds.

“Caaaaatraaa!” Sh’dowell whines, letting go of Gr’wliger and turning to her.

“Oh no,” Catra backs up. “You’re not crying on me!”

“Buh I’m gonna miss youuuuu!” Sh’dowell blubbers. They jump forward and she can’t even dodge before they crash into her, and they fall to floor. While they sob into her shoulder, she pats their back.

“There, there?” Catra says, though she’s not that great at comforting people. “We’ll be back, Sh’dowell.”

They just cry harder, “BUH I’LL STILL MISS YOU!”

Catra glances around, “Can someone help me?”

“No,” Demeter shakes her head.

Gr’wliger picks Sh’dowell up by the scruff of their neck and sets them back on their feet, “Sh’dowell, I have something I need to do. Can we continue this in five minutes?”

Sh’dowell nods and they do their best to not cry but continues to sniffle.

“What’s going on?” Catra tries again as she stands up.

Demeter and Gar’ett both shrug, but Gr’wliger continues, “I wanted to say farewell to all of you . . . except Catra . . . but I have something more important to do. I am stepping down as the head hunter.”

"Noooo!" Sh'dowell instantly begins to sob.

"Understandable," Gar'ett nods.

"And," Gr'wliger continues. "Demeter, I'd like you to be the next head hunter."

Demeter blinks, "What?"

"Congrats," Gar'ett pats Demeter's back.

"Deme'her," Sh'dowell cries and moves over to give her a hug, but she holds her arm out and puts her hand on their forehead to keep them away. "You're gonna do sooo good!"

"Oo," Catra's own surprise morphs into amusement. "Now you get to work closely with your mom."

"Shut up," Demeter hisses and tries to swat Catra with her free hand, but she jumps out of the way. She swallows and looks at Gr'wliger, "Thank-you, but . . . why me?"

"One, you're one of the best shots and trackers in Half Moon," Gr'wliger begins. "Two, I believe you have what it takes to be a leader. Finally . . . when Catra comes back she's going to need an ally on the Council."

"You think we're allies?" Catra scoffs.

"Yes," Gr'wliger says. "Though you may push back on her, I believe you share the same ideals."

"But," Demeter points out. "That means that you're not going to take the position back."

"You are correct," Gr'wliger says. "Hopefully, when I return the Horde will be gone. Then, I will be free to travel the world as I please."

Demeter stares at him, but she seems to stand slightly taller, “Then, I’ll do my best to do you proud.”

“You will,” Gr’wliger insists.

“Looks like we’ll be working together,” Catra says.

“Not until you come back,” Demeter scoffs. “So take your time.”

“Now, I must go say goodbye to my family,” Gr’wliger says, stepping around a still-crying Sh’dowell but pats their back. “And Catra, I believe you have to do the same.”

“Yeah,” Catra sighs. “There’s more people I want to see but . . . I do want to thank-you all for being my friend.”

“Why wouldn’t we?” Gar’ett says with a blank expression.

“I can think of a few reasons,” Demeter scoffs.

Catra punches her arm, causing Demeter’s other arm to finally bend and let Sh’dowell crash into her. They two fall on the ground and Catra can’t help but laugh.

“Don’t go Catra!” Sh’dowell cries from the ground as Demeter tries to push them off. “Who will play Impossible 2.0 with me?!”

“I’ll be back,” Catra promises. “And I’ll make Impossible legal.”

“Already trying to abuse your royal powers?” Demeter groans.

“Only for my friends.”

“That’s still illegal.”

"Before you two go," Gar'ett interrupts, and holds out two large bags of trail mix. "Some food for the road."

Catra stares at her, but finally accepts it, "Uh, thanks."

"Oh good," Gr'wliger eagerly grabs the trail mix. "I was going to miss your trail mix. I'll have to make it last."

"Uh, does anyone want to help me?" Demeter interrupts. She's still stuck on the floor.

"You're the head hunter now," Gr'wliger says with a small smirk. "They're your problem now."

Gr'wliger makes a quick exit, and Catra eagerly follows, "I'll see you guys later!"

Sh'dowell's sobs and Demeter's frustrated scream are muffled by the closing door, leaving Catra and Gr'wliger alone.

"So," Catra begins. "You aren't regretting your decision to leave?"

"No," Gr'wliger says with a shake of his head. "I'm following my dream. How about you?"

"No," Catra agrees. "This is something I have to do."

Catra passes through the cafeteria on the way to her next destination, not expecting to be stopped.

"Princess Fel'cty!" Jen'dots calls out from the kitchen, and Catra instantly walks over. She grins, "Or should I still call you Catra?"

"Just Catra, please," she sighs.

"Then Catra," Jen'dots corrects, and hands her a massive picnic basket. "This is for the road."

"Whoa," Catra nearly drops it once it's laid in her hands, much heavier than she expected. "Thanks Jen'dots . . . your food is probably going to be the thing I miss the most about Half Moon."

"Aw," Jen'dots pulls Catra into a hug, and she nearly loses balance and drops the picnic basket, "Take care, Catra. I can't imagine losing my child even once . . . I don't want the Queens to have to go through it a second time."

"I will," Catra promises.

Jen'dots lets her go and pats her shoulder, "I'm sure you're busy so I won't keep you long."

"Thanks for the food again," Catra says. "And . . . and everything else. You were one of the first to accept me. I appreciate that."

"I never saw you as a Horde soldier Catra," Jen'dots says. "I saw you as a girl who needed help, and who was I to keep that from you?"

"Please don't make me cry in the middle of the cafeteria," Catra grumbles.

"Then stop lolly-gagging around," Jen'dots jokes. "But when you come back, come here first. I'll serve a big feast for all four of you."

"I may have to go see my moms first but I will definitely come here second," Catra promises as she walks away. Jen'dots' food is as good an incentive to come back alive as anything.

Catra knew she wasn't going to see Ri'ta in the library. She also knew that Shire and Thom wouldn't be her either. However, she wanted to take it all in. The smell of the old books, the sounds of flipping pages. She'll miss it.

"Princess Fel'cty," Gus approaches her. "I am sorry, but Queen Ri'ta isn't here at the moment."

"I know," Catra nods. She decides it's okay is Gus refers to her officially. "I just wanted to see the library."

"Ah," Gus nods and turns away. "Then please, take your time. You are a Magicat, after all."

That causes her to pause, "Gus?"

He stops, "Yes?"

"Why did you vote to join the Princess Alliance?" she asks. That was a question that would nag her all the way to Bright Moon but not as important as everything else going on.

Gus lets out a long sigh, "As much as I fear for Half Moon's safety, your speech stuck with me. I'm tired of being afraid too, and I believe my fear has caused me to act unkindly towards you. I'm sorry."

"Thanks," Catra murmurs. "Well, I'll see you around Gus."

He bows, "Until next time, Catra."

Catra wants to find Busto next, so she tries the arena. However, she finds D'nah instead.

A group of soldiers have gathered around D'nah, who is wearing a uniform similar to Busto's but with different epaulets.

"Don't get a big head just cuz you're now the head of the royal guard," one soldiers says.

"Yeah, don't forget about the little guys like us!"

"You think you I can join the Royal Guard?"

"Hey, that's not important right now!"

"D'nah, you better come back safely, alright?"

"Guys, guys," D'nah calms the crowd. "It won't be forever. I'll be back before you know it," she grins. "Then I get to boss you all around for real."

"So, we *can* join the Royal Guard?" one soldiers reiterates.

"Well, do I have any say in it?" Catra makes her presence known. All the soldiers but D'nah snap to attention.

"No," D'nah scoffs. "I get to choose who joins the Royal Guard once we come back."

"But I'm your boss," Catra continues. "So I think I get the final say."

"Uh, D'nah?" one soldier coughs. "Should you be talking the Princess like that?"

"She doesn't care," D'nah shrugs.

"You don't know if I do care or don't," Catra says. The soldiers freeze, but she smiles, "But I would be pretty weirded out if you treated me like a Princess."

"See?" D'nah throws a smile to the soldiers behind her, but schools her face when she turns back to Catra. "Why are you even here? Just wanted to see me?"

"No, I'm gonna see enough of your face when we leave," Catra says. "I was looking for Busto."

"Oh," D'nah says. "Thom just grabbed him for some reason. At least it stopped him from making some big speech saying goodbye to me."

"Do you know what direction they went?" Catra asks.

"Nope," D'nah shakes her head and turns around, "So, bye!"

"Alright," Catra rolls her eyes, and decides to not bother her anymore. "Don't be late!"

"You wish I would!"

Catra ends up wandering for the caves, looking for Busto. At least she knew that Shire would be in the same place. Somehow, she's ended up in the Shrine to Saz. Deut'ron is reliably there, smoking from his pipe.

"Hello Catra," Deut'ron looks up with a smile. "I'm glad I could see you before you left."

"Hey," Catra responds. As she walks forward, her gaze is captured by the formless statue of Saz, still prepared for battle.

"Anything I can do for you?" he asks.

"I'm just . . . taking everything in," Catra says. "Before I go. Saying 'see you soon' to people."

"Hhm, yes, saying goodbye is one of the hardest thing, of course," Deut'ron nods. He brings his pipe to his mouth and slowly exhales smoke. "I have said goodbye many times."

Catra turns to him, clenching her fist, "I'm gonna make sure you don't have to say goodbye anymore, Deut'ron. There won't be any more funeral pyres for you to light."

"Death is a part of life, Catra," Deut'ron reminds her. "And I hope that when we truly do say goodbye, it's a happy one." He slowly stands, and Catra watches as he approaches her, "But, for my peace of mind . . . may I give you Saz's protection?"

She doesn’t believe in Saz or the Three Stars, not like everyone else does. She believes they existed as First Ones, but not that they have any powers beyond what they may have left behind. Yet, she still nods.

“Then,” Deut’ron raises his hand and places it on her head. “Saz the First Star, I beseech you to protect Fel’cty of D’riluth as she travels away from our land and lend her your strength as she strikes down our enemies.”

Catra doesn’t really feel any different, but when he removes his hand, she nods, “Thank-you, Deut’ron.”

He nods, “Until next time, Fel’cty.”

Catra feels like she’s been everywhere looking for Busto, and of course, he’s in the last place she looks. By that, she means that she just stumbled upon him locking lips with Thom in one of the back hallways.

“Do you have to do that out here?” Catra groans. The two hadn’t noticed her and jump apart.

“Ah! Catra!” Busto clears his throat and stands up, though his uniform is disheveled, and a few buttons have been undone. “I was just . . . saying goodbye to Thom.”

She stares at him, “You better not say goodbye to me like that.”

“I . . . won’t.”

“Good.”

“So,” Thom leans against the wall and crosses his arms. “Did you want something from us or can we get back to saying goodbye?”

"I wanted to talk to Busto but now I think I don't want to."

"I'll be with you . . . shortly," Busto says. He glances at Thom. "Or longer. Where can I find you?"

"I'm going to see Shire, and then I'll be getting ready to go," Catra says. "So, you better not be long."

"I'll try not to be."

Thom scoffs, "Not if I have anything to say about it."

"Okay, I think I'm going to need Shire to wipe my mind of this," Catra scowls and begins to walk away. "Remember Busto, don't take too long!"

She walks as fast as she can to the infirmary, and as she predicted Shire is there. But, she's not the first to greet her.

"Catra!" N'yan bolts from the bed she's sitting on and tackles Catra's legs, nearly knocking her over. "Don't go!"

Shire sighs as she walks over, "She's been moping all day."

N'yan turns around and hisses, "You have too!"

"Have not!"

"Hey, hey," Catra stops the fight before it can start. "I'll be back, I promise."

"B-buh, buh isn't the scary H-Horde out there?" N'yan begins to sob.

"Yes, and they are scary," Catra kneels down and pats N'yan's head. "But I have to go out there, so they don't scare anyone in Half Moon ever again."

"D-do you really have to?" N'yan mutters.

"I'm the Princess," Catra says with a wink. "Who else is going to join the Princess Alliance?"

"Oh right!" N'yan perks up and suddenly kicks Catra in the shin. "Why didn't you tell me you were the Princess!"

"Ow!" Catra hisses, despite the fact that it didn't hurt at all. "I didn't know it myself when we first met."

"Also, are you really going to kick the Princess?" Shire steps in, pulling Shire back.

"But Catra kept a secret and I thought secrets were bad!" N'yan protests.

"Sometimes . . . secrets are necessary," Catra says. "I'm sorry for keeping it a secret for you. It does feel better now that everyone knows. Also, Shire knew before me and didn't tell."

N'yan turns around with a gasp, and Shire sighs, "Thanks, Catra."

Catra grins, "No problem."

"YOU DIDN'T TELL ME OR CATRA!?" N'yan loudly exclaims.

"It was the Queens' secret, not mine!" Shire tries to protest.

"What is going on here?" Busto asks as he enters, still looking disheveled.

"Speaking of secrets," Catra grins, turning to Shire. "Busto was making out with Thom in the hallway."

"Catra!" Busto squeaks.

"Holy shit," Shire gasps.

"Don't swear!" a still furious N'yan shouts.

"That's not what I wanted to talk about though," Catra says.

"No, I want to know more about Busto and Thom," Shire insists.

"What does 'making out' even mean!?" N'yan says.

"Oh Saz," Busto puts his head in his hands. "Do I even want to know what is going on in here?"

"Probably not," Catra shrugs. "So just forget that because I want to talk with you and Shrie about something important."

"What about me?!" N'yan demands.

"I'm going to say what I want to say to you now," Catra says. She places her hand on her head once again, "Don't worry about me, kit. You've got more important things to do, like making sure Shire is happy while I'm gone. I'm sure she's going to miss one of her best friends."

"Not anymore," Shire huffs.

"But what if I miss you?" N'yan sniffles.

"Well," Catra tries to stall, not really sure how to answer that. She glances down at the friendship bracelet on her wrists that N'yan gave her months ago, "Just know that whenever I see this, I'm going to think of you, alright?"

"Ok," N'yan sniffles. Catra's glad that did the trick. The kit launches forward and hugs Catra, and though she's surprised at the touch she hugs her back.

"Now, do you mind giving me a moment alone with Busto and Shire?" Catra asks.

"I guess," N'yan huffs. "But . . . you're going to come back, right?"

"I'm going to do my best to," Catra says and pats N'yan's back. "And I'll see you then."

N'yan is finally satisfied, and she squeezes Catra one more time before running out of the room. Catra stands up with a heavy sigh. That's not going to be the last hard goodbye.

"You know, she never talks like that to me," Shire huffs. "And we're cousins."

"N'yan is probably just used to you, Shire," Busto suggests with a smile, but it doesn't reach his eyes. "Now, Catra, what did you wish to talk about with us?"

"First," Catra takes a deep breath. "I wanted to thank you both for being my friends. You two were some of the first people to accept me despite my past with the Horde, and I don't think I ever told you how much I appreciated that."

"It's not like we were looking for a thanks," Shire shrugs.

"Yes, we're your friends because I want to be!" Busto adds.

"I know. And . . . and . . ." Catra stumbles on her own words. "I actually don't know how to say this next part. I'm just . . . gonna really miss you two. Bright Moon . . . it's not gonna be fun without two of my best friends by my side."

"Aw, Catra," Busto sniffles, turning away as he hurriedly tries to wipe away tears with a handkerchief. "I'm going to miss you too, especially because . . . well, you were my first real friend in a long time. I got thrusted into leadership quickly, and I haven't had a chance to get close to anyone since Thom. So, thank-you.

"Damn, Busto, don't make me cry too," Catra grits her teeth.

"I get that too," Shire huffs, she isn't crying though there are tears in the corner of her eyes. "I'm the only person who can do healing magic in Half Moon, so I had a lot of pressure on my shoulder. Really, if you're the first person who saw us without all the responsibility, we carried it's only fair that we treat you the same about your pass."

Now Catra is fully crying, and Shire is too. The former manages to huff, "Wow. Look at us. A bunch of idiots crying in a room."

"Don't bottle this up, Catra," Busto insists. "Crying is healthy."

"I hate it."

"Me too," Shire adds.

"Then there is only one thing to do," Busto says as he holds his arms out. "Bring it in for a group hug."

"That's gross," Catra says, but still lets Busto pull her in. Shire doesn't put up a fight either and Busto hugs them both.

He holds the hug, until he mutters, "Stay safe out there, Catra," and lets them both go.

"Yeah," Shire nods, her own tears finally drying. "I won't be there to patch you up if you trip on another root."

"Shouldn't you be glad that I'm going to be a horror to other healers now instead of you?" Catra says.

"Just remember that I'm the best at it."

"Yeah, maybe."

"Hey!"

“I really don’t want to end this too soon,” Busto says. An uncharacteristic frown appears on his face, “But, I believe you have to leave soon, Catra.”

“Right,” Catra sighs. She looks at her two friends and take in a deep breath, “I’ll be back guys, I promise.”

“Don’t be a stranger,” Shire mumbles.

“And we’re going to hold you to your promise,” Busto adds.

Catra turns to leave but has to give Busto and Shire one last hug. Then, she’s out the door and towards the gates of Half Moon.

It’s been a long time since Catra has passed through the front gates of Half Moon. The hunters have their own exits and entrances to the caves, while the official entrance is heavily guarded. The last time she must have bothered using the main entrance is when she was still trying to get off of the island.

So much has changed since then. Purrsia and its people have become home to her, and now she’s almost loathed to leave. Catra has a job to do, not just for herself, but for the friends and family and people who look up to her. She’s going to do her best to protect her home and free it from fear.

“About time you showed up!” Glimmer complains as Catra appears. She had to quickly run to grab her bags-what a novel thing that it, that she has more possessions than the clothes on her back and a meaningless badge-before arriving at the gates.

“Sorry, I was just y’know,” Catra mumbles. “Saying goodbye.”

Glimmer’s expression softens for only a moment, “I suppose that’s fair.”

"Catra!" Adora happily bounds over from the main group, where Bow, Sea Hawk, and Scorpia are talking with Gr'wliger, Thom, and D'nah. She eagerly takes Catra's hand and squeezes it, her voice instantly dropping in volume, "Are you doing okay?"

"Yeah, I am," Catra insists.

"So, now that we're all here," Glimmer continues. "Shall we get going?"

"Not just yet," C'yra's voice booms through the opening cavern, and when Catra turns to her mother she's smirking at how she made Glimmer jump. She's accompanied by Ri'ta, Az'al, and Demeter, but the former two have traded any royal garb for traveling clothes. "We haven't had a chance to say goodbye to our daughter yet."

"Which we'll be delaying," Ri'ta shrugs. "Hope you don't mind us and a few hunters accompanying you through the forest."

"Not at all!" Glimmer says. "In fact, it'd be an honor."

"You don't have to," Catra mutters.

"Too bad," C'yra muses Catra's hair. "Let us eek out a little more time we get to have with you before you go."

"Alright," Catra sighs, but she really does appreciate it. She knows she's going to miss her mothers the most when she leaves.

"Oh! And before I forget," C'yra produces a letter from her jacket, folded and sealed with the royal symbol of the United Tribes, "Would you please give this letter to Angella?"

It's probably just some official Queens stuff, to let the ruler of Bright Moon know that the Magicats actually *aren't* dead. Catra nods and tucks it into her bag.

"We also haven't given you the official goodbye yet," Az'al adds. "So, on behalf of the Council, I and our new head hunter-" Az'al proudly grins, while Demeter buries her face in her hands, "-Wish you and your companions a safe journey outside Purrsia, and may Saz and Lyses protect you not matter how far you travel away from home."

"And you better come back," Demeter adds with crossed arms. "Purrsia needs its Princess."

"More than that," Az'al insists, and she glances at C'yra and Ri'ta, "A lot of people are going to miss you."

"I know," Catra sighs.

"A few hunters and soldiers are going to accompany you to the coast, to where Sea Hawk's ship is," Demeter chimes in. "I put Gar'ett in charge of our hunters, but the final word on anything of course goes to you, Your Majesties."

"Thank-you, Demeter," C'yra nods. "And, I haven't had a chance to say it yet, so congratulations on your promotion. I look forward to working together with you in the future."

Demeter actually blushes from C'yra's praise, "Ah, thank-you, Queen C'yra."

C'yra turns back to the party, made of Magicats and Princesses, and says, "Shall we get going?"

"Please," Gimmer sighs.

The gates of Half Moon are slowly opened up, natural sunlight entering the caves. With a nod, Gar'ett takes point and everyone follows, with the hunters and soldiers forming a perimeter around the main party.

Catra has traveled across the surface of Purrsia many times, whether just to explore or for a hunt. As they leave, they feel like they're seeing the beauty in the danger for the first time.

How many times will they be hit today with the little things they're going to miss? Not to mention the big ones.

C'yra and Ri'ta are both quiet as they travel. Everyone is, the beasts of the island are still a danger, but that doesn't mean that there can't be any small talk. Her mothers are silent as they walk behind Catra.

"Everything okay?" Catra turns around to ask at the half-way mark.

"Oh yes," Ri'ta insists. "It's been a while since I've traveled through Lyses' forests, if I'm being honest."

That is probably true, but it's not the reason why she's been quiet, Catra can tell. Especially because both Ri'ta's and C'yra's eyes are trained on her and not the surrounding forests.

"Alright," Catra says, and decides to not push at it further, especially when surrounded by dangerous forests. Adora sends her a look over her shoulder, and Catra shrugs slightly. They can talk once on shore.

The dense forest of the island breaks away to the sandy beach where Sea Hawk's boat resides. He rushes forward and jumps onto his ship, getting to work. Bow and Scorpia follow him, while Gr'wliger watches curiously as he starts rigging masts and other boat junk.

Catra turns to her mothers, who are both staring at the boat that's going to take their daughter away. She clears her throat to get their attention, "So . . ."

"So," C'yra repeats. All three of them don't want to say goodbye, but now's the time.

"I . . . before I say goodbye," Catra says, delaying the inevitable for only a moment. "I want to show you a spell I learned."

"Without me?" Ri'ta says with a teasing smile.

"I wanted it to be a surprise," Catra says. She pulls a piece of paper out of her pocket and holds it between her clasped hands. Holding her hands to her lips, she whispers the spell, "*Columbia*."

When she opens her hands, the paper transforms into a bird and flies over to Ri'ta, landing on her hand she quickly outstretches. The bird disappears in a puff of smoke, leaving the paper in her hands. She quickly unfolds it, and C'yra leans over to read it as well.

All it says is: *I'll miss you. I love you*.

Ri'ta reacts first, tears in the corners of her eyes as she holds the paper against her chest, "You know, I was cursing the fact that I wasn't able to teach you this spell since we were so busy, but you managed to get one step ahead of me."

"Now we can communicate across the ocean," Catra says. "Or, at least Ri'ta and I can."

"You'll be hearing from me too, kitten," C'yra says.

"I'll happily become the messengers between you and everyone here," Ri'ta insists. She holds her arms out, "Come here Catra, we love you too."

Catra rushes forward and is quickly enveloped by both C'yra and Ri'ta. She can't help but cry now, tears rushing freely as she holds onto her mothers. A small part of her, a voice that seems faintly familiar, but she hasn't heard since her early days in the Horde, never wants to let go and doesn't want to be apart from them.

When they finally all step back, there's no snarky remark from Ri'ta to try and make her feel better, just a sad smile on her mother's tear-streaked face. C'yra is having a hard time keeping it

together, as she cups Catra's face and weakly asks, "Come back, please."

"I-I promised," Catra manages to say. "I will."

"We love you so much," Ri'ta adds and kisses her forehead.

"I love you too," Catra murmurs.

They only manage to stay like that for a few moments more, as Sea Hawk gives the signal that he's ready to leave. When she turns around, everyone is waiting for her. Adora is wearing a guilty look, but Catra does her best to smile and reassure her.

C'yra steps back and clears her throat, "Gr'wliger, D'nah, Thom."

The three Magicats quickly stand to attention, but Gr'wliger is the one who bows, "Yes, your Majesty?"

"Please, I want all four of you to keep each other safe," C'yra says. "Purrsia will be eagerly awaiting your return."

"We shall," Gr'wliger insists. He turns to Catra, "Princess Fel'cty, are you ready to depart?"

"Just," Catra swallows. "One more moment."

He nods and walks to the ship, D'nah and Thom following him. Only Adora remains on the shore.

Catra hugs both of her mothers one more time, holding them as close as she can. Both of them kiss her head and she tries to memorize all of this. She never had this love in her life before, and she doesn't want to forget it if anything happens.

"You better not keep your friends waiting, kitten," Ri'ta says, but there's a sour tone to her voice. Catra knows she also

doesn’t want this moment to end.

“I’ll send a message as soon as we arrive in Bright Moon,” Catra insists.

“You better,” Ri’ta says. “It may seem like forever, but we will be together soon, kitten.”

“Give Hordak hell,” C’yra adds.

“You know I will,” Catra says. They’re delaying, she knows they are, so she says it one more time, “I love you.”

C’yra puts an arm around Ri’ta waists and speaks for both of them, “We love you too.”

It takes all of Catra’s will power to turn around and move her feet towards the boat, away from the place she finally knows she can call home. Away from her friends, her family, and towards making a better future for everyone here.

Adora meets her at the gangplank, “Are you alright?”

“I will be,” Catra insists. She takes her hand, and they step onto the boat together. Despite the rough patches, she knows that she and Adora can take on the Horde. Together, they can take on nearly everything.

The boat casts off from the shore, and despite the sea sickness threatening to set in, Catra keeps her eyes trained on Purrsia. Her mothers remain on the shore with their guard, waving as she leaves despite the tears in her eyes. She finds that she’s crying again. She watches up Purrsia is nothing but a dot on the horizon, and then it’s gone.

She turns around the ship and finds everything in chaos, from Sea Hawk singing with Bow and Scorpia while Gr’wliger tries to learn about sailing, D’nah threatening to throw Thom overboard, while Glimmer and Adora talk Princess Alliance

strategies. Despite the chaos, she knows that this is what she has to do.

Purrsia will wait for Catra, and she's going to do everything she can to protect it from the Horde.

Chapter End Notes

FUCK YEAH I FINALLY FINISHED A LONG FIC!

Seriously this was a problem.

Anyways, time for something more elegant: this fic has taken me over three years to complete and I'm slightly surprised at this myself. I've been writing on ao3 since 2013 and . . . I have left a slew of unfinished fics in my wake, but with this and sad song I think I may finally be in the business of finishing long fics.

However, this fic is really much more than a goalpost for me. During these three years I've always wondered why do I keep coming back to this? I have never been that big into She-Ra, unlike Fairy Tail or FE:3H or (sadly) Genshin Impact, but I had read other people's takes on Catra being a Princess mixed in with some mythology research I was doing at the time and I had come up with my own concept, and I think that concept kept on drawing me back. The culture of the Magicats and the Magicat OCs themselves pulled me back in every time I stopped writing for this fic. The fact that you all loved the original concepts I cooked up really means a lot to me too.

So, I'd like to thank everyone who has sat down to read this fic, kudos'd, left a comment, made fanart, recommended the fic, or anything else. I loved seeing all of the love for this, and you don't know how many times that loves has made my day or brought me out of a slump. Thank-you all so very, very much.

And now, what's next? Honestly . . . I don't know. I haven't started work on the next installment, and I am constantly going back and forth on what I want to do. What I do know, is that I am going to take a break on this series for now. I'm entering the final semester for my bachelor's degree and there's a lot of other stuff I want to work on. When I'll come back, who knows? Your best bet is to follow my twitter at Twitter @Sniperdoodle12 for updates (and muppet content). In the meantime, you can check out some of my other works (unless it's Demigod Izuku I hate that it's my top kudos'd fic and I'd rather that spot go to this one).

I hope to see you all soon, and thank-you once again.

End Notes

I hope you enjoyed the first chapter! More to come soon, so leave a comment if you want to vitalize the writing spirit within me!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!